Cost & Management Accounting

Concept-First Notes + Exam Q&A + MCQ Bank + Mock Test — CA Intermediate

One complete file: concepts, worked Q&A, revision cheat-sheet, MCQs & a full mock test

Contents

Cost & Management Accounting — Quick-Revision Cheat-Sheet

> CA Intermediate • last-mile scan • formulas + logic only, not teaching. Round per ICAI convention; quote figures in exam as `₹`.

---

1. Cost Sheet & Cost Concepts

Build-up (running total)	Formula
Prime Cost	Direct Material Consumed + Direct Labour + Direct Expenses
DM Consumed	Opening RM + Purchases + Carriage-in − Returns − Closing RM
Factory/Works Cost	Prime + Factory OH + Op. WIP − Cl. WIP
Cost of Production (COP)	Works Cost + Admin OH (production-related)
COP of goods sold	COP + Op. FG − Cl. FG
Cost of Sales	COGS + Selling & Distribution OH
Sales	Cost of Sales + Profit

- **Scrap/defective sale** of factory material → deduct from Factory OH. **Notional items** (own rent, interest on capital) excluded from cost.
- **Cost classification:** by *nature* (mat/lab/exp), *function* (prod/admin/S&D), *variability* (fixed/variable/semi), *controllability*, *normality*.
- **Cost centre** = location/person/equipment for cost gathering; **Cost unit** = unit of output for cost measurement (e.g. per tonne-km, per bed-day, per kWh).

---

2. Material Cost

EOQ (Economic Order Quantity) $$EOQ=\sqrt{\dfrac{2\,A\,O}{C}}$$ A = annual consumption (units), O = ordering cost/order, C = carrying cost per unit p.a. (= price × carrying %). - At EOQ: **Ordering cost = Carrying cost**; Total inventory cost minimised. No. of orders = A/EOQ. - Total cost = (A/Q)·O + (Q/2)·C + purchase cost.

Stock levels

Level	Formula
Reorder Level (ROL)	Max usage × Max lead time
Minimum Level	ROL − (Normal usage × Normal lead time)
Maximum Level	ROL + ROQ − (Min usage × Min lead time)
Danger Level	Normal usage × Emergency lead time
Average Stock	Min level + ½ ROQ (or (Max+Min)/2)

- **Inventory Turnover** = Material consumed ÷ Average stock; high = fast-moving.
- **Pricing issues:** FIFO (issues @ oldest), LIFO (@ newest — not allowed under AS/Ind AS for financials), Weighted Avg = Total value ÷ Total qty (recompute each receipt).
- **Losses:** *Normal* (unavoidable) → absorbed by good units (inflate rate); *Abnormal* → costed & written off to Costing P&L.
- **Perpetual** = continuous records + **continuous stocktaking** verification. **ABC**: A = high value/low qty tight control.

---

3. Labour Cost

Item	Formula
Labour Turnover — Separation	Separations ÷ Avg workers
— Replacement	Replacements ÷ Avg workers
— Flux	(Separations + Accessions) ÷ Avg workers
Efficiency %	Std time for actual output ÷ Actual time × 100
Idle time	Paid time − Worked time

Wage / Incentive systems

System	Earnings
Time rate	Hours × Rate
Piece rate	Units × Rate/unit
Halsey	Time wages + 50% × (Time saved × Rate)
Rowan	Time wages + (Time saved / Time allowed) × Time taken × Rate
Taylor differential	<100% eff → low piece rate; ≥100% → high piece rate
Merrick	<83%→ord; 83–100%→+10%; >100%→+20%
Gantt task	Below task: time rate; at task: +20% bonus; above: high piece rate

- **Rowan vs Halsey:** Rowan gives higher bonus until time saved < ½ time allowed; caps worker earning (protects employer from over-generous bonus). Rowan bonus max when saved = ½ allowed.

- **Idle time:** *Normal* (tea, setup) → part of cost (loaded on rate); *Abnormal* (strike, breakdown) → Costing P&L.
- **Overtime premium:** normal cause/ customer request → job/OH; abnormal → P&L. **Guaranteed wage** floor still applies.

4. Overheads — Absorption

Absorption rate = Budgeted OH ÷ Budgeted base.

Base	Rate
% of Direct Material	OH÷DM ×100
% of Direct Labour	OH÷DL ×100
% of Prime Cost	OH÷Prime ×100
Labour hour rate	OH÷Labour hrs
Machine hour rate	OH÷Machine hrs
Rate per unit	OH÷Units

- **Machine hour rate** preferred where machine-intensive; comprehensive MHR includes operator wages.
- **Primary distribution:** apportion on logical bases (rent→area, depreciation→asset value, power→HP×hrs, ESI/canteen→no. of employees, stores→material value).
- **Secondary distribution (service→production):** *Direct*, *Step-ladder* (one-way), *Reciprocal* — **Simultaneous equation / Repeated distribution / Trial & error**.

Over/Under absorption = Absorbed − Actual. - Absorbed > Actual → **over-absorbed** (credit). Actual > Absorbed → **under-absorbed**. - Treatment: (a) supplementary rate if large/normal, (b) Costing P&L if small/abnormal, (c) carry forward if seasonal. - **Blanket rate** = single factory-wide; **Departmental rate** = per dept (more accurate).

ABC (Activity-Based Costing): Cost pool → **Cost driver rate** = Pool cost ÷ Total driver units → apply to products. Removes volume-based distortion for low-volume/complex products.

5. Cost Accounting Systems

- **Non-integrated:** separate cost ledger; **Cost Ledger Control A/c (CLCA/General Ledger Adjustment A/c)** replaces financials. Reconcile Costing P&L with Financial P&L.
- **Reconciliation causes:** items only in financials (interest, dividend, donation, income-tax, profit/loss on asset sale, notional charges), over/under-absorption, different stock valuation & depreciation methods.
- **Reco rule:** Start with one profit → add incomes credited only there / OH over-absorbed / stock differences that raise profit, subtract the opposite → reach other profit.
- **Integrated (Integral) accounting:** one set of books, no reconciliation needed.

6. Job / Batch / Contract / Process / Operating

Batch — Economic Batch Quantity (EBQ) $$EBQ=\sqrt{\dfrac{2\,D\,S}{C}}$$ D = annual demand, S = setup cost/batch, C = carrying cost/unit p.a. (Same shape as EOQ; "setup" replaces "ordering".)

Contract costing

Work certified %	Profit to transfer to P&L
< 25%	Nil
25% – < 50%	⅓ × Notional Profit × (Cash received ÷ Work certified)
50% – < 90%	⅔ × Notional Profit × (Cash received ÷ Work certified)
≥ 90% (near complete)	Estimated total profit × (Work certified ÷ Contract price)

- Notional Profit = Value of work certified − (Cost of work certified). WIP in BS = Work certified + Uncertified − Reserve − Progress payments. **Loss → transfer full to P&L.**

Operating (service) costing — composite units: passenger-km, tonne-km, kWh, patient-day, room-day. Cost/unit = Total cost ÷ composite units. Split fixed (standing) vs variable (running) vs maintenance.

---

7. Process Costing & Equivalent Units

- **Normal loss:** expected; cost absorbed by good units; scrap value credited to process. **Abnormal loss/gain** valued at *normal cost per good unit* and taken to Costing P&L.
- **Cost per unit (normal loss)** = (Total cost − Scrap value of normal loss) ÷ (Input − Normal loss units).
- **Abnormal Gain** debited to Process A/c (raises output above expected); its scrap loss reduces the normal-loss scrap recovery.

Equivalent Units (EU) = Physical units × % completion (per element: material / labour / OH).

Method	Logic
FIFO	EU = complete Op. WIP (remaining %) + units started & finished + Cl. WIP %. Cost = current period cost only ÷ EU.
Weighted Avg	EU = units completed + Cl. WIP %. Cost = (Op. WIP cost + current cost) ÷ EU.

Steps: (1) physical flow, (2) EU per element, (3) cost per EU, (4) value Cl. WIP + transferred + abnormal.

Inter-process profit: unrealised profit in closing stock eliminated via **Stock Reserve**.

Joint & By-products — apportion joint cost at split-off:

Method	Basis
Physical units	Quantity
Net Realisable Value	(Sales − further processing − selling)
Constant gross-margin %	Equalise GP% across products
By-product	Credit NRV to main process (reverse-cost / other-income)

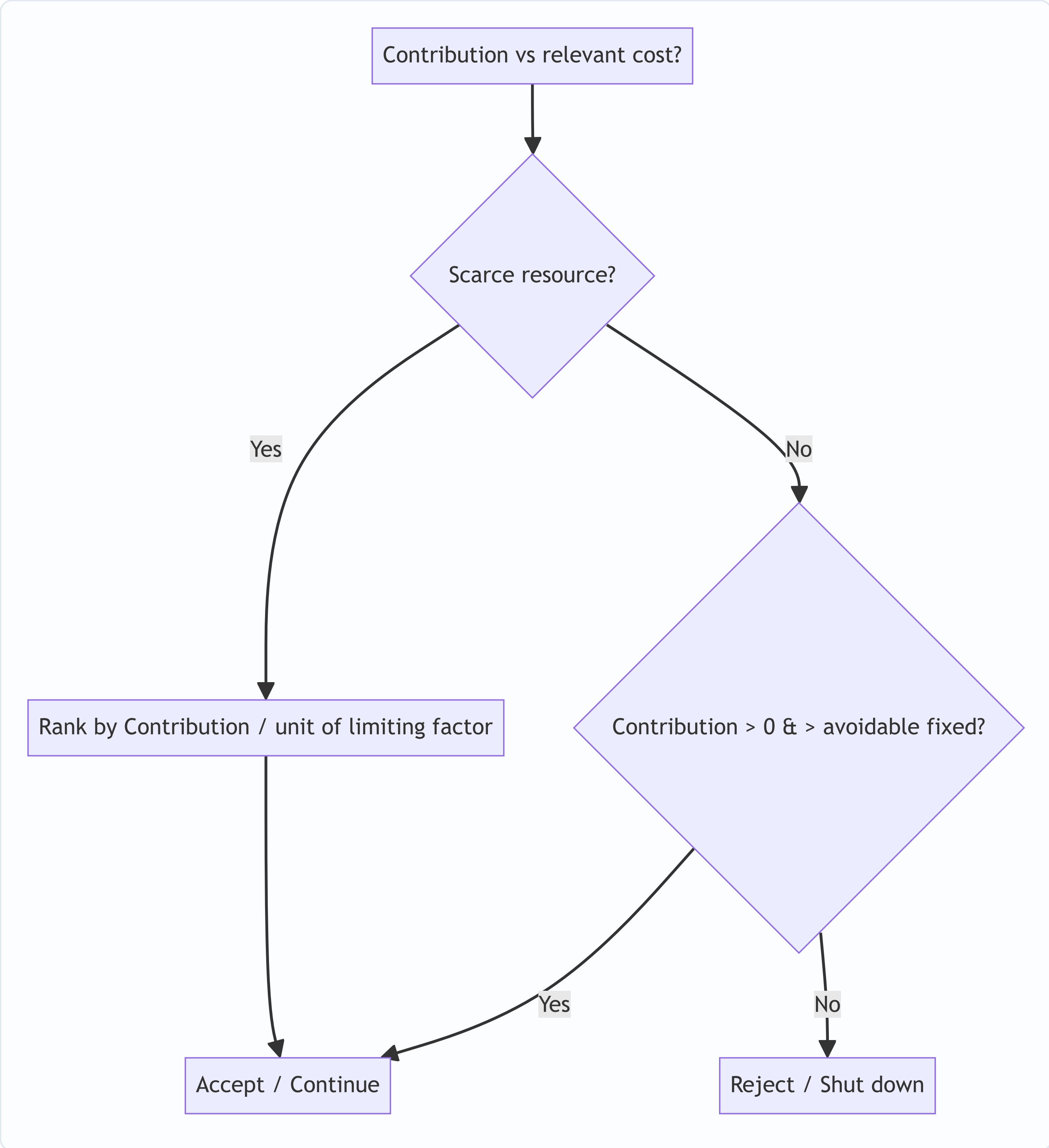
- **Further-process decision:** process if **Incremental revenue > Incremental cost** beyond split-off (ignore joint cost — sunk).

---

8. Marginal Costing & CVP

Metric	Formula
Contribution (C)	Sales − Variable Cost = Fixed + Profit
P/V Ratio	C/Sales = ΔC/ΔSales = ΔProfit/ΔSales
BEP (units)	Fixed ÷ Contribution per unit
BEP (₹)	Fixed ÷ P/V ratio
Margin of Safety (MoS)	Actual Sales − BEP Sales = Profit ÷ P/V ratio
MoS ratio	Profit ÷ Contribution
Required Sales (target profit)	(Fixed + Target Profit) ÷ P/V ratio
Sales for target profit after tax	(Fixed + TP/(1−t)) ÷ P/V ratio
Profit	(Sales × P/V) − Fixed

- **P/V improves by:** ↑price, ↓variable cost, richer sales mix. Fixed cost does **not** affect P/V ratio (only BEP & profit).
- **Absorption vs Marginal profit diff = Fixed OH in stock change.** Production > Sales → absorption profit higher (fixed cost deferred in closing stock).
- **Key/limiting factor:** rank products by **Contribution per unit of scarce resource** (per machine hr / per kg / per labour hr).
- **Make-or-buy:** make if buy price > relevant (marginal + avoidable fixed) make cost. **Shutdown point:** continue while contribution ≥ avoidable fixed cost; shutdown if avoidable fixed saved > contribution lost.



9. Standard Costing — Variances

Sign rule: Actual better than standard (lower cost / higher revenue) → **Favourable (F)**; else **Adverse (A)**. `SP=std price, AP=actual price, SQ=std qty for actual output, AQ=actual qty, RSQ=revised std qty (mix)`.

Material

Variance	Formula
Cost (MCV)	(SQ×SP) − (AQ×AP)
Price (MPV)	AQ × (SP − AP)
Usage (MUV)	SP × (SQ − AQ)
Mix (MMV)	SP × (RSQ − AQ)
Yield (MYV)	SP × (SQ − RSQ)

Check: MCV = MPV + MUV; MUV = MMV + MYV.

Labour

Variance	Formula
Cost (LCV)	(SH×SR) − (AH×AR)
Rate (LRV)	AH × (SR − AR)
Efficiency (LEV)	SR × (SH − AH_worked)
Idle Time (LITV)	SR × Idle hours (always Adverse)
Mix / Gang	SR × (RSH − AH)
Yield (Sub-eff.)	SR × (SH − RSH)

`AH` = hours paid; `AH_worked` = paid − idle. LCV = LRV + LEV + LITV.

Variable OH

Variance	Formula
Cost	(SH×SR) − Actual VOH
Expenditure	(AH×SR) − Actual VOH
Efficiency	SR × (SH − AH)

Fixed OH

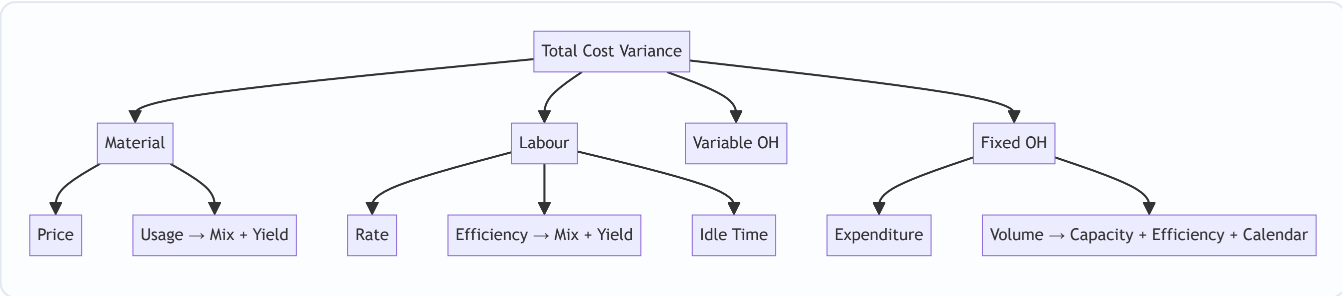
Variance	Formula
Cost (FOCV)	Absorbed − Actual = (SH×SR) − Actual FOH
Expenditure	Budgeted − Actual
Volume	Absorbed − Budgeted = SR × (Std hrs for actual output − Budgeted hrs)
Capacity	SR × (Actual hrs − Budgeted hrs)
Efficiency	SR × (Std hrs for actual output − Actual hrs)
Calendar	SR × (Actual days − Budgeted days) × hrs/day

Check: FOCV = Expenditure + Volume; Volume = Capacity + Efficiency + Calendar.

Sales (value-based)

Variance	Formula
Value	Actual Sales − Budgeted Sales
Price	AQ × (AP − SP)
Volume	SP × (AQ − BQ)
Mix	SP × (AQ − RBQ)
Quantity (Sub-vol)	SP × (RBQ − BQ)

Sales-margin (profit) variances: replace price with **margin per unit** (Std profit) throughout.



10. Budgets & Budgetary Control

Type	Note
Fixed budget	Single activity level, not adjusted.
Flexible budget	Recast for actual activity; separate fixed vs variable.
Zero-based (ZBB)	Every rupee justified afresh from zero.
Cash budget	Receipts − payments; excludes non-cash (depreciation). Methods: receipts-&-payments, adjusted P&L, balance-sheet.
Master budget	Consolidated summary of all functional budgets.
Principal/Key budget factor	Limiting factor (usually sales) — budgeted first.
Production budget	Sales + Cl. FG − Op. FG (units).
Material purchase budget	Consumption + Cl. RM − Op. RM.

Ratio	Formula
Capacity Ratio	Actual hrs worked ÷ Budgeted hrs × 100
Activity Ratio	Std hrs for actual output ÷ Budgeted hrs × 100
Efficiency Ratio	Std hrs for actual output ÷ Actual hrs worked × 100
Calendar Ratio	Actual days ÷ Budgeted days × 100

Relation: **Activity = Capacity × Efficiency** (÷100).

---

11. Quick Traps / Exam Discipline

- Abnormal loss/gain, abnormal idle time, notional & financial items → **Costing P&L, never product cost.**
- Normal loss/normal idle → **loaded on good output** (raise per-unit rate).
- Scrap of normal loss → **credit the process**; reduces cost per good unit.
- EOQ/EBQ: keep A vs O vs C units consistent (annual). C = price × carrying% if given as %.
- Rowan bonus caps earnings; Halsey is simpler flat 50%.
- Marginal vs Absorption difference = **fixed OH element in inventory change only.**
- Contract: `< 25% → nil profit`; loss always fully booked.
- Variance sign: check via total = sum of components; label **F/A** on every answer.
- Sales-mix & material-mix use **RSQ/RBQ** (actual total qty in standard proportion).

> **Taxation note:** This is Cost & Management Accounting — no tax rates apply. If cross-referencing any Taxation figures (rates, slabs, TDS limits, depreciation %, turnover thresholds), treat them as **Assessment-Year-specific — verify against the current ICAI study material / Finance Act for your attempt** before relying on them.

Chapter 01 — Introduction to Cost & Management Accounting

1. The Problem — A Decision Financial Accounting Refuses to Answer

Imagine you run **Deccan Cycles Ltd.**, a factory in Hyderabad making two models of bicycles: a *City* model and a *Racer* model. Your Chartered Accountant hands you the audited financial statements at year end. They are beautiful. They tell you the company earned a net profit of ₹42 lakh, that trade receivables stand at ₹1.8 crore, and that the balance sheet balances to the last rupee.

Now you sit across from that CA and ask five ordinary questions a manager must answer every single week:

1. A dealer will buy 500 City cycles but only if you drop the price to ₹4,200 each. Your "cost" per cycle in the accounts is ₹4,500. Do you refuse the order — or is ₹4,200 actually *profitable*?
2. The Racer line is "losing money." Should you shut it down? Will profit go *up* or *down* if you do?
3. Your foreman overspent on power this month. Was that his fault, or did the electricity board raise tariffs? Whom do you hold responsible?
4. You can either make brake-cables in-house or buy them from a vendor at ₹90. Which is cheaper — and cheaper by how much?
5. What price should you *quote* tomorrow for a custom order of 200 cycles that has never been made before?

The financial statements are **silent on every one of these.** They were never built to speak. Financial accounting (FA) looks *backward* at the business *as a whole*, aggregates everything into totals, and reports to *outsiders* (shareholders, tax authorities, lenders) under a legal framework (Companies Act, Accounting Standards). Its unit of analysis is the *entire entity over a past period*. That is exactly the wrong lens for the five questions above, because each question is about a **part** of the business (one product, one order, one department), looks *forward*, and is asked by an *insider* who can still change the outcome.

> **The problem cost accounting solves:** managers must make forward-looking decisions about *parts* of a business — pricing, product mix, make-or-buy, cost control, shutdown — and financial accounting, by design, delivers only backward-looking totals for the *whole*. We need a second accounting system whose entire purpose is to attach cost to the *right object* (a product, a job, a process, a department) at the *right time* and in the *right form* for the *specific decision at hand*.

This chapter builds the vocabulary and the classification logic of that second system. Every concept here exists because *some decision needs it*. If you ever catch yourself memorizing a classification without knowing which decision it serves, stop — you have missed the point.

1.1 Three accounting systems, not two — where each one lives

Students arrive thinking there are two systems (financial and cost). There are really **three overlapping information systems**, and the exam repeatedly tests the boundaries between them:

System	Primary audience	Time focus	Governed by	Core question
Financial accounting	External (shareholders, lenders, tax, regulators)	Past	Companies Act 2013, Accounting Standards / Ind AS	"What did the *whole entity* earn and own?"
Cost accounting	Internal + statutory cost records/audit where applicable	Past *and* future	ICAI Cost Accounting Standards (CAS); Sec. 148 cost records/audit for notified industries	"What did *this product/job/process* cost and why?"
Management accounting	Internal (managers) only	Overwhelmingly future	*No* external rulebook — whatever aids the decision	"What should we *do* next?"

The trap to internalise now: **cost accounting is partly regulated, management accounting is not.** Certain companies must maintain **cost records** and undergo a **cost audit** under Section 148 of the Companies Act 2013 (industries and turnover thresholds are notified by the government — *verify current notified list and thresholds against current ICAI material / relevant AY*). Management accounting has **no** statutory format, no compulsory audit, and no prescribed periodicity — precisely because a rulebook would blunt its usefulness.

1.2 Cost accounting vs. management accounting — the finer line

Because Section 2 folds them together conceptually, the exam likes a crisp distinction:

- **Cost accounting** *ascertains and controls cost*. It is quantitative, largely monetary, and can stand alone.
- **Management accounting** *uses cost data plus financial data plus non-financial and qualitative data* (market trends, staff morale, economic outlook) to *advise* management. It is broader, more subjective, forward-looking, and cannot function without the other two feeding it.

One clean line for the exam: *cost accounting is a subset of the raw material; management accounting is the finished advice.* Management accounting has **no fixed conventions or double-entry discipline** — it will happily present a one-page contribution statement that would never pass as a financial account.

---

2. The Core Idea — A Camera vs. an X-Ray, and a Wardrobe of Lenses

Financial accounting is a **group photograph** of the family taken once a year: everyone in one frame, smiling, verified, framed on the wall for visitors. It is truthful and complete — but you cannot use it to diagnose a broken bone.

Cost accounting is the **X-ray machine and the whole diagnostic lab.** It does not care about the pretty group photo. It cares about *this bone*, *this organ*, *this symptom*. It slices the business into thin cross-sections — this product, this batch, this hour of machine time — so a manager can *diagnose and act*.

But here is the deeper idea, the one that unlocks the whole subject:

> **Cost is not a single fixed number. It is a *number-for-a-purpose*. The same rupee of spending gets classified differently depending on the question you are asking.**

Think of cost data as raw light, and each *classification* as a different **lens** you snap onto the same camera:

- Want to trace cost to a product? Use the **direct / indirect** lens.
- Want to predict what happens if volume changes? Use the **fixed / variable** lens.
- Want to fix responsibility on a manager? Use the **controllable / uncontrollable** lens.
- Want to decide on a one-off order? Use the **relevant / sunk** lens.

There is no "true" classification of a factory rent or a foreman's salary in the abstract. There is only "how should I classify this *for the decision in front of me*." Master the wardrobe of lenses and *when to reach for each*, and cost accounting stops being a memory test and becomes a thinking tool.

2.1 The one rupee, five labels — a concrete demonstration

To feel the "number-for-a-purpose" idea in the bone, take a *single* item — the **₹2,00,000 monthly salary of the City-line foreman** — and watch it wear five different labels depending on the question:

The question a manager asks	Lens applied	Label the ₹2,00,000 wears
What did the City line cost to run?	Traceability (to the *line*)	**Direct** to the line, but **indirect** to a single cycle
What happens to cost if we make 10% more cycles?	Behaviour	**Fixed** (salary won't move within capacity)
Does it sit in closing stock or hit this month's P&L?	Period-attach	**Product cost** (part of factory overhead, inventoriable)
Is the works manager answerable for it?	Controllability	**Controllable** by the works manager, **uncontrollable** by the foreman himself
Should we accept a special order using idle time?	Relevance	**Irrelevant / sunk** for that order (already committed, doesn't change)

Same ₹2,00,000. Five questions. Five different — and all correct — classifications. This table is the entire philosophy of the subject compressed into one number; if a classification ever feels arbitrary, ask "for which of these questions?"

---

3. Why It's Built This Way — The Logic Behind a Separate System

Why not just make financial accounting more detailed and be done with it? Because the *constraints* on FA are incompatible with the *needs* of decision-making. Look at the tensions:

Constraint on FA	Why it blocks decisions	What cost accounting does instead
Must follow Accounting Standards / Companies Act	Rules optimize for comparability across firms, not usefulness to *this* manager	Free to use any method that aids the decision — no external rulebook
Reports the whole entity	Hides which product or department is the problem	Reports by cost centre / cost unit — the *part*
Historical, period-end	A decision is dead by the time year-end arrives	Continuous, real-time, and *future-oriented* (budgets, standards, estimates)
Records only actual transactions	A decision often hinges on cost *not* incurred (opportunity, notional)	Can bring in opportunity cost, notional rent/interest, imputed costs
Values inventory at total cost	Fine for the balance sheet, misleading for a shutdown or extra-order decision	Splits cost into fixed vs. variable so the *avoidable* part is visible

The design principle is: **an information system must be shaped by the decision it feeds, not by an external compliance rulebook.** Since managers face many *different* decisions, cost accounting cannot offer one number; it must offer a *classified* number and the discipline to pick the right classification. That is why the beating heart of this whole subject is **cost classification** — and why the CA syllabus makes you learn *many* ways to slice the same cost.

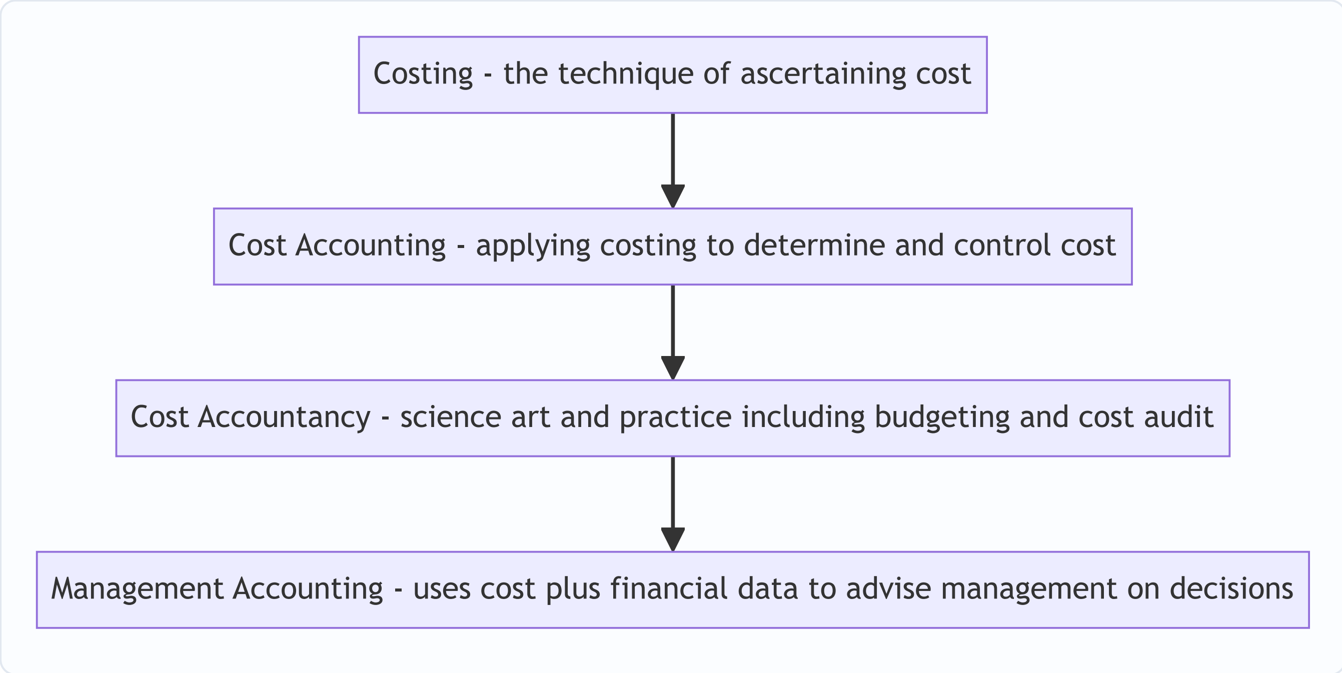
Two definitions to anchor the vocabulary (classic CIMA/ICMA terminology — exam-acceptable):

> **Caveat on sourcing:** the wordings below are the traditional CIMA/ICMA terminology definitions, *not* CAS-1. **CAS-1** ("Classification of Cost") defines cost as *"a measurement, in monetary terms, of the amount of resources used for the purpose of production of goods or rendering of services."* If a theory question asks for the **CAS-1** definition, quote that ICAI wording; verify against your current ICAI module.

- **Cost** — the amount of expenditure (actual or notional) incurred on, or attributable to, a specified thing or activity. Note "notional": cost accounting can count sacrifices FA never records.
- **Costing** — the *technique and process* of ascertaining cost.
- **Cost Accounting** — the *formal application* of costing principles, methods and techniques to the process of determining and controlling costs.
- **Cost Accountancy** — the *widest* term: the science, art and practice of a cost accountant, embracing costing, cost accounting, budgetary control, cost control, and cost audit for managerial decision-making.

Nest these like Russian dolls: **Costing** ⊂ **Cost Accounting** ⊂ **Cost Accountancy**, with **Management Accounting** as the outermost layer that *uses* all of them plus financial data to actually advise management.

Figure 3.1 — Cost concepts nest inside progressively wider disciplines; management accounting sits at the top and consumes the rest.



3.1 Objectives of cost accounting — what the system is actually *for*

The exam sometimes asks bluntly "state the objectives / functions of cost accounting." Do not list at random; every objective maps to one of *three verbs* — **ascertain, control, decide**:

Verb	Objectives it covers
Ascertain	Ascertain cost per unit; analyse cost by element, function and behaviour; ascertain profitability of each product/job/process
Control	Control cost through standards and budgets; disclose waste, idle time, spoilage; fix responsibility for variances
Decide	Provide data for pricing, make-or-buy, mix, shutdown; guide expansion, tenders and quotations; assist policy formulation

A fourth, quieter objective is **statutory** — to maintain cost records and enable cost audit where the law requires it. If you can group your answer under *ascertain / control / decide (+ comply)*, you will never blank on this question.

3.2 Cost control vs. cost reduction — a favourite two-marker

These sound identical and are relentlessly confused:

	Cost **control**	Cost **reduction**
Aim	Keep cost *within* a predetermined standard/budget	*Permanently* lower cost *below* the current standard
Assumes standard is	Correct and to be *achieved*	Itself *challengeable* — the standard can be beaten
Nature	Retains existing conditions; conservative	Questions everything; dynamic and continuous
Ends when	The target is met	Never — it is an ongoing programme
Example	Stopping power overspend against budget	Redesigning the frame to use less steel forever

Memory hook: *control fights to reach the line; reduction moves the line.*

3.3 Prerequisites of a good (ideal) costing system

An exam may ask "what makes a costing system good?" The answer is not "accuracy at any price." A good system is: **simple, tailored** to the business (not copied off the shelf), **cost-effective** (its benefit must exceed its cost — the *principle of the marginal utility of information*), **comparable** period to period, **flexible** to change, **accurate but timely** (a roughly-right number today beats a precisely-right one next month), and **reconcilable** with financial accounts. The single deepest principle: *a costing system is itself subject to a cost-benefit test.* Elaborate systems that cost more than the decisions they improve are bad systems, however precise.

---

4. Full Technical Content — Every Concept Wrapped in Its Decision

4.1 The Elements of Cost — the raw material of every classification

Before we can slice cost cleverly, we need the three natural building blocks. Every rupee a factory spends is one of three **elements**:

1. **Material** — physical inputs (steel tubes, tyres, paint).
2. **Labour** — human effort (welders, painters, supervisors).
3. **Expenses** — everything else (power, rent, depreciation, royalty).

Each element then splits by *traceability* into **Direct** and **Indirect** (we justify this split in 4.2). Stacking the elements gives the famous cost build-up:

Build-up stage	Formula	What it captures
Prime Cost	Direct Material + Direct Labour + Direct Expenses	The cost that *belongs* to the product directly
Works / Factory Cost	Prime Cost + Factory (Works) Overhead	Everything spent *inside* the factory
Cost of Production	Works Cost + Administration Overhead (production-related)	Cost of a finished, ready-to-sell unit
Cost of Goods Sold	Cost of Production ± Opening/Closing finished-goods stock	Cost of what actually *left* the door
Cost of Sales / Total Cost	COGS + Selling & Distribution Overhead	Full cost to get the product into a customer's hands
Sales	Total Cost + Profit (or − Loss)	The top line

Overhead is simply the sum of all *indirect* costs (indirect material + indirect labour + indirect expenses). It is grouped by function into **Factory/Works**, **Administration**, and **Selling & Distribution** overhead — because a manager controlling the shop floor should not be judged on the sales team's advertising spend. *Function-wise grouping serves responsibility.*

The 3×2 grid — the compact way to see all six element-type combinations. Because each of the three elements splits into direct/indirect, there are exactly six cells, and the exam expects you to place any expense into the right one:

	Direct (traceable to unit)	Indirect (overhead)
Material	Steel tubes, tyres in a cycle	Lubricating oil, cotton waste, small consumable stores
Labour	Welder's, painter's wages on the line	Foreman's salary, storekeeper, security guard
Expenses	Design royalty per cycle, hire of a special tool for one job	Factory rent, depreciation of shared plant, insurance

Direct expenses (also called **chargeable expenses**) are the least intuitive cell — they are non-material, non-labour costs that can still be traced to *one* cost unit: a job-specific tool hire, a specific-design royalty, cost of a special drawing bought for one contract. Missing this cell is a classic slip.

4.2 Classification by Traceability — Direct vs. Indirect

> **Decision served:** "What did *this product / job* actually cost?" and "Which costs can I honestly *trace* versus which must I *spread*?"

- **Direct cost** — can be *conveniently and economically traced* to a specific cost object (a product, job, or process). Steel tubes going into a City cycle are direct material; the welder's wages on that line are direct labour; a design royalty paid per cycle is a direct expense.
- **Indirect cost (overhead)** — *cannot* be economically traced to one unit, so it must be *apportioned/absorbed* using some basis. The factory manager's salary, factory rent, and lubricating oil serve *many* products at once.

The dividing line is **convenience/economy of tracing, not physical importance.** Nails in furniture are physically part of the product but so cheap to track individually that we treat them as *indirect* material. The whole point is that direct costs give a *reliable* product cost, while indirect costs need a defensible *sharing rule* (covered in the Overheads chapter). Get the split wrong and every product-cost, price and mix decision downstream is polluted.

The cost object is not fixed — it moves. "Direct" and "indirect" are meaningless until you *name the cost object*. The foreman's salary is **indirect** if the cost object is *one cycle*, but **direct** if the cost object is *the whole City line*. When an examiner changes the cost object mid-question ("now treat each department as the cost object"), a cost can flip from indirect to direct without a single rupee changing. Always fix the cost object first.

Why we don't trace everything even when we could. Modern barcoding could, in principle, trace every drop of glue to a unit. We deliberately do not, because the *cost of measuring* the cost would exceed the *value of knowing* it — the same cost-benefit principle from 3.3. "Convenient and economical" is doing real work in the definition; it is an *economic* test, not a physical one.

4.3 Classification by Behaviour — Fixed, Variable, Semi-Variable

> **Decision served:** "If I make 10% more (or fewer) units, what happens to cost — and therefore to profit?" This lens powers pricing, extra-order acceptance, break-even, and shutdown decisions. It is arguably the single most powerful lens in the subject.

Behaviour = how *total* cost reacts to changes in *activity level* (units, machine-hours) **within the relevant range**.

- **Variable cost** — total rises/falls *in proportion* to activity; *per-unit* stays constant. Direct material, direct wages (piece-rate), power for machines. Make zero cycles → zero material cost.
- **Fixed cost** — total stays *constant* regardless of activity (within the relevant range); *per-unit* falls as volume rises. Factory rent, manager's salary, straight-line depreciation. Whether you make 1 cycle or 1,000, the rent is ₹2,00,000.
- **Semi-variable (mixed) cost** — has both a fixed base and a variable slope. Electricity bill (fixed meter charge + per-unit usage), telephone, repairs. Must be *split* into its fixed and variable parts before use (via the **high-low method** or regression — detailed in the Marginal Costing chapter).

The counter-intuitive trap that behaviour explains: **fixed cost *per unit* is variable, and variable cost *per unit* is fixed.** Managers who reason on "cost per unit" without knowing behaviour make catastrophic pricing errors. That is *why* this lens exists — to stop you treating a fixed cost as if it changes with volume.

The "relevant range" is the fine print that makes fixed cost honest. No cost is fixed forever. Factory rent is fixed only *within a band of output* the current factory can hold; cross that band and you rent a second shed — the fixed cost jumps to a new plateau. This produces the **step (stepped) fixed cost**: constant over a range, then a discrete jump, then constant again (e.g., one supervisor per 20 workers — the 21st worker forces a second supervisor). Step costs are *fixed within each step but behave variably across wide swings*. Examiners plant them to see if you blindly hold a "fixed" cost constant when output doubles.

Two ways a semi-variable cost can be shaped: - *Step-variable* pattern — small fixed plateaus that step up frequently (looks almost variable in the large). - *Mixed* pattern — a genuine fixed intercept plus a smooth variable slope (the telephone bill). The **high-low method** isolates the slope: Variable rate = (Cost at high activity − Cost at low activity) ÷ (High units − Low units); the fixed part is then the balancing figure at either level.

Engineered, committed, and discretionary fixed costs — a subtle sub-classification. Not all fixed costs are equally sticky, and this matters for *which* fixed cost you can attack in a cost-cut: - **Committed fixed cost** — flows from past capacity decisions; unavoidable in the short run (rent, depreciation of owned plant, insurance). You cannot cut it without shrinking capacity. - **Discretionary (managed/programmed) fixed cost** — set afresh each year by management choice (advertising, R&D, training). It *can* be cut this year without touching capacity — which makes it the first target in a squeeze, and the examiner's favourite "which fixed cost is avoidable?" clue.

Figure 4.1 — Total-cost behaviour against activity. Fixed cost is a flat line; variable cost is a ray from the origin; semi-variable starts at the fixed intercept and slopes up.

Behaviour_of_total_cost_as_output_rises

Fixed - flat line stays at same total

Variable - straight line rising from zero

Semi variable - starts above zero then rises

4.4 Classification by Function / Attributability to the Period — Product vs. Period

> **Decision served:** "Which costs cling to the *unit* and sit in inventory until it is sold, and which costs expire with *time* and hit this period's profit regardless of sales?" This governs inventory valuation and the *timing* of profit.

- **Product cost (inventoriable)** — attaches to the product and is carried in inventory as an asset until the unit is sold. Under absorption costing this is *cost of production* (direct materials, direct labour, factory overhead). Unsold → sits on the balance sheet, not yet an expense.
- **Period cost** — relates to a *period*, not a *unit*; expensed in full when incurred. Selling, distribution and general administration costs (and, under *marginal* costing, *all* fixed overhead).

Why split them? Because *when* a cost becomes an expense changes reported profit. Load a cost into "product" and it can be parked in closing stock, deferring the hit; treat it as "period" and it bites now. This is the exact fault-line between **Absorption Costing and Marginal Costing** (a later chapter), and examiners love the profit *difference* it creates when stock levels change.

The deep reason product cost defers profit. A cost only becomes an *expense* when the matching principle releases it — and a product cost is matched against *revenue*, which arrives only on sale. So every rupee buried in a *product* cost rides into closing stock and waits on the balance sheet; every rupee stamped *period* is expensed on the calendar regardless of whether a single unit sold. That is why, when **closing stock rises**, absorption costing (which parks fixed factory overhead in the product) reports **higher** profit than marginal costing — it has deferred some fixed cost into stock. The classification is not academic; it moves the reported profit number.

4.5 Classification by Controllability — Controllable vs. Uncontrollable

> **Decision served:** "Whom do I hold *responsible* for this variance?" This is the foundation of **responsibility accounting** and performance appraisal — answering our foreman question from Section 1.

- **Controllable cost** — can be *influenced* by the action of a *specified* manager within a *given* time span. A shop supervisor controls material wastage and idle time on his line.
- **Uncontrollable cost** — cannot be influenced by that manager at that level. The supervisor cannot control the *apportioned* head-office rent or a government tariff hike.

Two subtleties that make this an *exam favourite*: 1. **Controllability is relative to a level and a time horizon.** Factory rent is uncontrollable for the foreman but *controllable* for the CEO negotiating the lease. Almost everything is controllable by *someone* over a *long enough* horizon. 2. You judge a manager *only* on what he controls — otherwise you punish people for tariff hikes and monsoons, and the whole incentive system collapses.

Normal vs. abnormal — the cousin classification that decides costing treatment. Closely tied to controllability is whether a cost is *normal* (expected, uncontrollable in the routine sense, and therefore *part of cost*) or *abnormal* (unexpected, avoidable, and therefore *excluded from cost and charged to the Costing Profit & Loss Account*). Normal idle time and normal spoilage are absorbed into product cost; **abnormal** idle time, abnormal loss, and abnormal wastage are stripped out so they do not distort the unit cost. This "*normal in, abnormal out*" rule is a recurring exam principle: abnormal items are held answerable separately rather than smeared across good units.

4.6 Classification by Relevance to a Decision — Relevant, Sunk, Opportunity, Differential

> **Decision served:** *any specific one-off choice* — accept/reject an order, make-or-buy, keep/replace a machine, shut down a line. This is the "decision-making" cluster and the intellectual peak of the chapter.

The single test for **relevance**: *a cost is relevant only if it is a future cost that differs between the alternatives.* Anything else is irrelevant noise, however large.

- **Sunk cost** — cost *already incurred*, unrecoverable, *unaffected* by any future decision. The ₹8,00,000 you already spent on a machine is sunk; it must be **ignored** when deciding whether to replace it. The most common managerial fallacy ("we've invested too much to quit now") is exactly the failure to ignore sunk cost.
- **Opportunity cost** — the value of the *next-best alternative forgone*. If using a spare machine for Order A means you cannot rent it out for ₹15,000, that ₹15,000 is a real cost of Order A — even though *no cheque is written and FA never records it.* This is precisely the kind of "notional" cost only cost accounting captures.
- **Differential (incremental) cost** — the *difference in total cost* between two alternatives. If Plan X costs ₹5,00,000 and Plan Y ₹5,60,000, the differential cost of Y is ₹60,000. When it's a *rise* it's *incremental*; a *fall* is *decremental*.
- **Marginal cost** — the *additional* cost of producing *one more* unit; in practice equals *variable cost per unit* within the relevant range. Drives the "accept the ₹4,200 order?" decision.

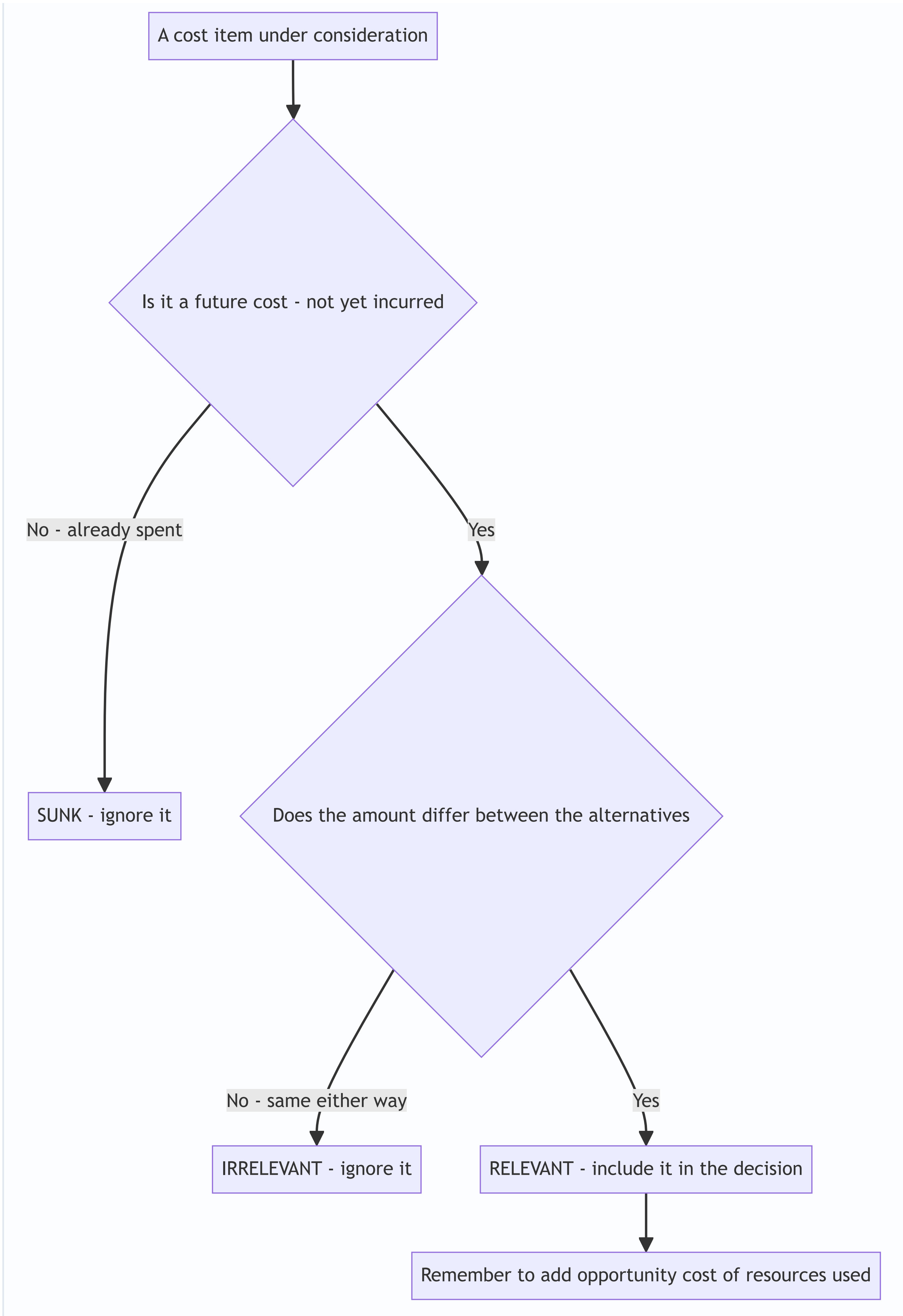
- **Avoidable vs. unavoidable cost** — costs that *disappear* if an activity is dropped (avoidable → relevant to a shutdown) versus those that *continue* regardless (unavoidable → irrelevant to that decision).
- **Imputed / notional cost** — a hypothetical cost not involving cash outflow, inserted for better decisions or comparability (e.g., notional interest on owner's capital, notional rent on own building). It makes a debt-free unit comparable to a financed one.
- **Replacement cost** — cost to *replace* an asset/material at *current* market prices, versus original historical cost — relevant when deciding on reorder or valuation in inflationary times.
- **Out-of-pocket cost** — the portion involving *actual cash* outflow (excludes non-cash items like depreciation) — relevant to short-run cash-constrained decisions.

Two distinctions the examiner uses to catch you:

- **Marginal cost vs. differential cost.** They are cousins but not twins. *Marginal* cost is strictly the cost of *one more unit* (per-unit, variable-cost based). *Differential* cost is the *total* cost gap between two *courses of action* and can include *changes in fixed cost* (e.g., a second supervisor, a step-cost jump). When an alternative pushes output past a capacity step, differential cost captures the fixed-cost jump that marginal cost, by definition, would miss.
- **Opportunity cost vs. sunk cost — mirror images.** Sunk cost is a *past, recorded* outflow that is *irrelevant*. Opportunity cost is a *future, unrecorded* sacrifice that is *highly relevant*. The examiner deliberately pairs them so the careless student includes the sunk cost (which FA recorded, so it "feels real") and omits the opportunity cost (which FA never recorded, so it "feels unreal"). The correct instinct is exactly the reverse.

Explicit vs. implicit cost. Explicit (out-of-pocket) costs involve actual cash payment and are recorded. Implicit (imputed, notional, opportunity) costs involve *no* cash payment and are *not* recorded by FA — yet many are relevant. This explicit/implicit cut is the bridge between "what the books show" and "what the decision needs," and it is why relevant-cost analysis so often *adds* items the financial accounts never contained.

Figure 4.2 — The relevance filter: a cost enters a specific decision only if it clears both gates.


A cost item under consideration
Is it a future cost - not yet incurred
No - already spent
Yes
SUNK - ignore it
Does the amount differ between the alternatives
No - same either way
Yes
IRRELEVANT - ignore it
RELEVANT - include it in the decision
Remember to add opportunity cost of resources used

4.7 Cost Centres and Cost Units — *where* and *per what* we collect cost

You cannot classify cost until you decide *where* to pool it and *per what* to express it. Two structural concepts:

Cost Centre — a *location, person, item of equipment, or group thereof* for which costs are *ascertained and controlled*. It is the *smallest segment of activity* for which costs are accumulated. It answers "*where* was the cost incurred / who is answerable?" Types:

- **Personal cost centre** — a *person* or group of persons (a works manager, a sales team).
- **Impersonal cost centre** — a *location or equipment* (a machine, a department, a delivery van).
- **Production cost centre** — where actual production/conversion happens (machining, assembly, welding shop).
- **Service cost centre** — supports production but does no conversion itself (stores, maintenance, canteen, boiler house). Its cost is *re-apportioned* to production centres.

A finer split the syllabus mentions: an impersonal production centre can be an **operation cost centre** (a group of similar machines/operations) or a **process cost centre** (a specific continuous process). And within personal/impersonal you may see **operation** vs **process** framing — the exam rarely pushes past naming them, but know they exist.

A related, wider idea is the **Responsibility Centre**, where a manager is accountable for defined items: - **Cost centre** — responsible for *costs* only. - **Revenue centre** — responsible for *revenues* only (e.g., a sales booking office that does not control the cost of goods). - **Profit centre** — responsible for *costs and revenues* (hence profit). - **Investment centre** — responsible for costs, revenues *and* the *capital invested* (judged on ROI / RI).

Cost centre vs. cost unit in one line: a **cost centre absorbs** cost (a place); a **cost unit carries** cost (a thing). Cost first pools in centres, then is absorbed into units.

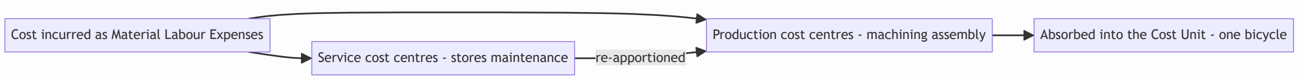
Why the hierarchy exists: you localize cost to the smallest sensible unit so that control and responsibility can be pinned precisely (ties straight back to 4.5 controllability).

Cost Unit — the *unit of product or service* to which costs are ascertained, i.e., the *unit of measurement* of cost. It answers "*per what* do we express cost?" It must be the natural unit customers and managers think in:

Industry	Typical cost unit
Cement / Steel / Sugar	per tonne
Automobile / Cycle	per vehicle / per cycle
Electricity	per kilowatt-hour (kWh)
Transport (goods)	per tonne-kilometre
Passenger transport	per passenger-kilometre
Hospital	per patient-day / per bed-day
Hotel	per room-day
Gas	per cubic metre
Brick-making	per 1,000 bricks
Professional services	per chargeable hour
Oil / petroleum	per barrel / per litre or tonne
Paper	per ream
Cotton textiles / yarn	per kg / per bale
Chemicals	per litre / kg / tonne
Advertising	per enquiry / per response

Notice several are **composite units** (tonne-km, passenger-km, patient-day): they combine *two* dimensions because a single dimension would mislead — moving 1 tonne 100 km is not the same effort as moving 100 tonnes 1 km, yet both are "100 tonne-km." *The unit is chosen to make cost comparisons fair.*

Figure 4.3 — Cost flows through centres and is finally expressed per cost unit.



4.8 Methods vs. Techniques of Costing — a two-axis map

Students constantly confuse these. They are *orthogonal* — you pick one **method** *and* one-or-more **techniques** simultaneously.

Methods answer "*how is production organized, so how do we collect cost?*" The method is dictated by the **nature of the product/industry**, and you do not get to choose it freely.

Method	When used	Cost object
Job costing	Distinct, custom jobs to order	Each job
Batch costing	Identical items made in batches (pharma tablets, cycles in lots)	Each batch (then ÷ units)
Contract costing	Large, long-duration, site-based jobs (construction)	Each contract
Process costing	Continuous mass production, output homogeneous (chemicals, sugar, paint)	Each process; cost averaged over output
Operating (Service) costing	Services, not products (transport, hospital, power)	The service cost unit (per km, per bed-day)
Single/Output costing	One product, continuous (mining, cement)	Per tonne / unit
Multiple/Composite costing	Product assembled from many components (car, cycle, TV)	Blend of the above

Job/Batch/Contract are all "specific order" costing; Process/Operating are "continuous operation" costing. The dividing question is: **is output made to a specific customer order (→ specific-order methods) or produced continuously in a stream (→ process/operating)?**

Only two methods really exist — the rest are variants. At the deepest level there are just two ways to collect cost, because there are only two ways to organise production: - **Specific-order (job) costing** — production in *identifiable, separable units/lots to order*; cost is collected *per job/batch/contract*. Job, batch and contract costing are the same idea at three scales (one item → a lot → a giant site job). - **Continuous-operation (process) costing** — production in an *unbroken stream of identical output*; cost is collected *per process and averaged over units*. Process, operating/service, and single-output costing are all this idea.

Everything else (multiple/composite) is a *blend* of the two. If you can answer "identifiable job or continuous stream?", the method almost picks itself — this is the single most reliable way to nail a "which method?" question.

Techniques answer "*what principle do we apply to the collected cost, for control or decision-making?*" You *choose* the technique to suit the *managerial purpose*, and you can overlay it on *any* method.

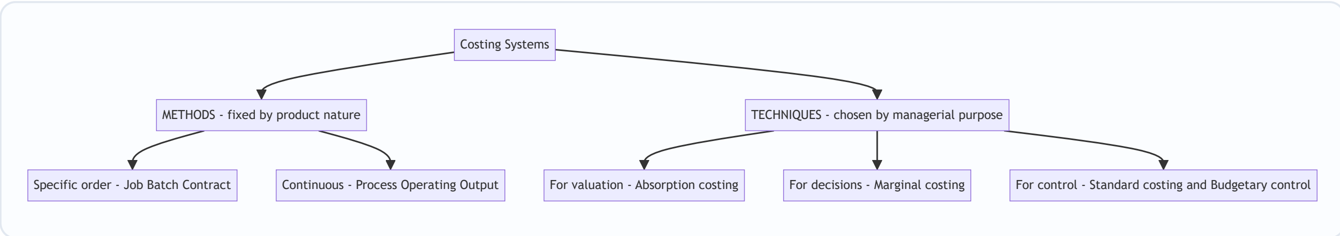
Technique	Purpose it serves
Absorption (Total/Full) costing	Charge *all* costs (fixed + variable) to units — needed for inventory valuation & external reporting
Marginal (Variable) costing	Charge only *variable* cost to units, treat fixed as period cost — for decisions (pricing, mix, make-or-buy)
Standard costing	Set predetermined costs and analyse *variances* — for control
Budgetary control	Plan via budgets and compare actuals — for planning & control
Uniform costing	Common costing principles across firms — for inter-firm comparison
Historical costing	Ascertain cost *after* it is incurred

The mental model: *Method* is chosen by the **product** (given to you); *Technique* is chosen by the **decision** (chosen by you). A cycle-maker uses **batch costing (method)** and may apply **standard + marginal costing**

(techniques) on top. A hospital uses **operating costing (method)** with **budgetary control (technique)**.

Historical vs. predetermined — the time axis cuts across techniques. Costing can also be split by *when* the cost is ascertained: **historical costing** (after the event — accurate but too late to control) versus **predetermined costing** (before, using standards/estimates — enables control but risks estimation error). Standard costing is a *predetermined* technique; it only becomes useful for control *because* it is set in advance and compared to the historical actual. This time axis is why the two coexist rather than compete.

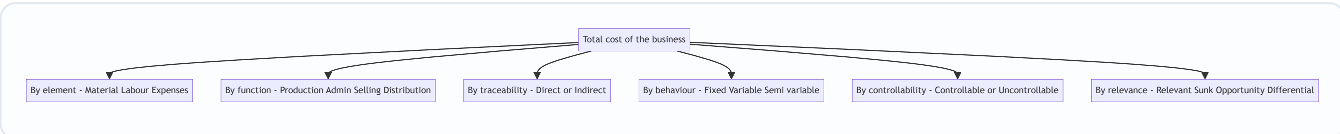
Figure 4.4 — Costing splits into methods driven by product nature and techniques driven by managerial purpose.



4.9 The master map of cost classification — one figure to see all lenses at once

Everything in Section 4 is really *one idea* — take the pool of total cost and cut it along whichever axis the decision needs. Seeing all the axes together prevents the commonest confusion: treating classifications as rival "types of cost" rather than as *parallel cuts of the same rupee*.

Figure 4.5 — The same total cost, cut along six independent axes; you may apply several cuts at once to one item.



The key exam habit this figure trains: when a problem hands you a cost, silently ask *which axis is this question on?* A shutdown question is on the **relevance** and **behaviour** axes; a performance-appraisal question is on the **controllability** axis; a cost-sheet question is on the **element/function/traceability** axes. Reading the axis correctly is 80% of the answer.

---

5. Worked Examples — From Warm-Up to Exam-Hard

Worked Example 1 (Easy) — Building a Cost Sheet from Elements

Data (Deccan Cycles, City model, for the month): Direct material consumed ₹6,00,000; Direct wages ₹2,40,000; Direct expenses (design royalty) ₹60,000; Factory overhead ₹1,80,000; Administration overhead (production-related) ₹90,000; Selling & distribution overhead ₹1,10,000; Profit margin: 20% on sales. Units produced and sold: 400 cycles. **Prepare the cost sheet and find the selling price per cycle.**

Step 1 — Prime Cost: Direct Material + Direct Labour + Direct Expenses = 6,00,000 + 2,40,000 + 60,000 = **₹9,00,000**.

Step 2 — Works (Factory) Cost: Prime Cost + Factory OH = 9,00,000 + 1,80,000 = **₹10,80,000**.

Step 3 — Cost of Production: Works Cost + Admin OH = 10,80,000 + 90,000 = **₹11,70,000**. (No opening/closing WIP or finished stock given, so Cost of Production = COGS.)

Step 4 — Cost of Sales (Total Cost): COGS + S&D OH = 11,70,000 + 1,10,000 = **₹12,80,000**.

Step 5 — Profit and Sales. Profit is 20% *on sales*, so cost is 80% of sales. Sales = Total Cost ÷ 0.80 = 12,80,000 ÷ 0.80 = **₹16,00,000**. Profit = 16,00,000 − 12,80,000 = ₹3,20,000 (check: 20% × 16,00,000 = 3,20,000 ✓).

Cost Sheet — City model (400 cycles)	Total (₹)	Per cycle (₹)
Direct Material	6,00,000	1,500
Direct Wages	2,40,000	600
Direct Expenses	60,000	150
Prime Cost	**9,00,000**	**2,250**
Factory Overhead	1,80,000	450
Works Cost	**10,80,000**	**2,700**
Administration Overhead	90,000	225
Cost of Production / COGS	**11,70,000**	**2,925**
Selling & Distribution OH	1,10,000	275
Cost of Sales	**12,80,000**	**3,200**
Profit (20% on sales)	3,20,000	800
Sales	**16,00,000**	**4,000**

Selling price = ₹4,000 per cycle. Every subtotal reconciles top-to-bottom.

Worked Example 1B (Easy-Medium) — Same Cost Sheet *With Stock Movements* (the adjustment the examiner adds next)

The moment you are comfortable with Example 1, the examiner reruns it with stocks — to test *at which level* each stock adjusts. Same monthly figures as Example 1, but now:

- **Raw material:** Opening stock ₹50,000; Purchases ₹6,30,000; Closing stock ₹80,000. (So *material consumed* is derived, not given.)
- **Work-in-progress (at works cost):** Opening ₹40,000; Closing ₹70,000.
- **Finished goods:** Opening 20 cycles valued ₹58,500; Closing 30 cycles (value them at *this month*'s cost of production per unit).
- Direct wages ₹2,40,000; Direct expenses ₹60,000; Factory OH ₹1,80,000; Admin OH ₹90,000; S&D OH ₹1,10,000. Selling price ₹4,000/cycle. Cycles *produced* this month: 400.

Step 1 — Material consumed (adjust *before* prime cost): 50,000 + 6,30,000 − 80,000 = **₹6,00,000**. (Deliberately equals Example 1 so we can isolate the stock effect.)

Step 2 — Prime Cost = 6,00,000 + 2,40,000 + 60,000 = **₹9,00,000**.

Step 3 — Gross Works Cost then adjust WIP (WIP adjusts at *works* level): 9,00,000 + 1,80,000 = 10,80,000; add opening WIP 40,000, less closing WIP 70,000 → **Works Cost = ₹10,50,000**.

Step 4 — Cost of Production (of the 400 finished this month) = 10,50,000 + 90,000 Admin = **₹11,40,000**, i.e., **₹2,850 per cycle** (11,40,000 ÷ 400). *Value closing FG at this ₹2,850.*

Step 5 — Cost of Goods Sold (finished-goods stock adjusts *after* cost of production): Opening FG 58,500 + Cost of Production 11,40,000 − Closing FG (30 × 2,850 = 85,500) = **₹11,13,000**.

Cross-check the units: Opening 20 + Produced 400 − Closing 30 = **390 cycles sold**.

Step 6 — Cost of Sales = COGS 11,13,000 + S&D 1,10,000 = **₹12,23,000**.

Step 7 — Sales, Profit. Sales = 390 × 4,000 = **₹15,60,000**. Profit = 15,60,000 − 12,23,000 = **₹3,37,000** (≈ ₹864 per cycle sold; ≈ 21.6% on sales — note it is *not* a clean 20% now, because opening stock came in at last month's lower ₹2,925-ish cost).

The learning: three stocks, three *different levels* — raw material *before* prime cost, WIP *at works cost*, finished goods *after cost of production*. Put any one at the wrong level and COGS is wrong. This single reconciliation is worth more marks than memorising the skeleton.

Worked Example 2 (Medium) — The Special-Order Decision (Relevant Cost in Action)

Recall Section 1's dilemma. The *accounts* say each City cycle "costs" ₹3,200 (cost of sales) or ₹2,925 (cost of production). A dealer offers **₹4,200 each for 500 extra cycles**, a one-off export order that needs **no selling & distribution effort** (dealer collects at the gate). Current output is *within* capacity, so no new fixed costs arise. **Should you accept?**

The wrong answer (the trap): "Cost is ₹3,200, price is ₹4,200 — but wait, are all costs covered? The order price ₹4,200 > full cost ₹3,200, accept." Right conclusion here, but often the price offered is *below* full cost and the naïve manager wrongly *rejects*. The discipline is to use **relevant cost only.**

Step 1 — Identify cost behaviour from Example 1's per-cycle figures. Classify each as variable (changes with the extra 500 units) or fixed (won't change within capacity):

Element	Per cycle (₹)	Behaviour	Relevant to extra order?
Direct Material	1,500	Variable	Yes
Direct Wages	600	Variable	Yes
Direct Expenses (royalty per cycle)	150	Variable	Yes
Factory Overhead (assume fixed)	450	Fixed	**No** — capacity already paid for
Administration OH	225	Fixed	**No**
Selling & Distribution OH	275	Fixed/avoided here	**No** — dealer collects

Step 2 — Relevant (marginal) cost per cycle = 1,500 + 600 + 150 = **₹2,250** (this equals Prime Cost because only the direct/variable elements are relevant).

Step 3 — Incremental analysis for 500 cycles:

	Per cycle (₹)	500 cycles (₹)
Incremental revenue	4,200	21,00,000
Less: Relevant (marginal) cost	2,250	11,25,000
Incremental contribution / profit	**1,950**	**9,75,000**

Decision: ACCEPT. The order adds **₹9,75,000** to profit. The ₹450 factory OH, ₹225 admin OH and ₹275 S&D per cycle are **irrelevant** (fixed/sunk within capacity). Had you judged against full cost ₹3,200 you'd still accept here — but the *method* is what matters: if the offer had been ₹2,800 (below ₹3,200 full cost but above ₹2,250 marginal cost) the naïve manager rejects and *loses* ₹550 × 500 = ₹2,75,000 of contribution. *This is exactly the decision FA cannot make and cost classification exists to enable.*

Caveat to state in an exam: valid only if (a) spare capacity exists, (b) the export price won't leak into the domestic market and spoil the ₹4,000 price, and (c) no better alternative use of capacity exists (else add its **opportunity cost**).

"What if the examiner tweaks it?" — three standard twists and how each flips the answer:

- *Twist A — no spare capacity.* If the 500 cycles displace 500 regular sales at ₹4,000 (contribution ₹1,750 each), the **opportunity cost** of the displaced sales is 500 × 1,750 = ₹8,75,000. Net gain = incremental contribution 9,75,000 − 8,75,000 = **₹1,00,000**. Still accept, but the margin is now thin — and if the special price were ₹4,000 it would be a wash.
- *Twist B — the order needs a one-off special jig costing ₹5,00,000.* That ₹5,00,000 is a *future, order-specific* fixed cost — **relevant and avoidable**. Net = 9,75,000 − 5,00,000 = **₹4,75,000**; still accept. (Contrast with a jig *already bought* for a cancelled order — that would be *sunk* and ignored.)
- *Twist C — accepting forces overtime raising variable wages by ₹300/cycle.* Marginal cost rises to ₹2,550; contribution falls to ₹1,650 × 500 = ₹8,25,000. Accept, but the point is the *marginal cost is not frozen* — read whether the extra volume changes any variable rate.

Worked Example 3 (Exam-Hard) — Shutdown, Sunk Cost & Opportunity Cost Combined; plus a Composite Cost Unit

Part A — Product-line shutdown. Deccan's *Racer* line shows this annual statement, and the board wants to *drop* it because it "loses ₹1,20,000":

Racer line (per annum)	₹
Sales (2,000 cycles @ ₹5,000)	1,00,00,000
Less: Variable costs (@ ₹3,400/cycle)	68,00,000
Contribution	**32,00,000**
Less: Fixed costs charged to line	33,20,000
Reported "loss"	**(1,20,000)**

Of the ₹33,20,000 fixed costs, **₹21,00,000 is apportioned head-office/common cost** that will *continue* even if the Racer line closes (unavoidable), and only **₹12,20,000 is specific to the Racer line** and would be *saved* on closure (avoidable). A machine currently used by the Racer line could, if the line closes, be **rented out for**

₹2,50,000 p.a. (opportunity cost of keeping the line running). Two years ago the company spent **₹40,00,000** developing the Racer design. **Should the line be shut down?**

Step 1 — Discard the sunk cost. The ₹40,00,000 design spend is *sunk* — already incurred, unrecoverable, identical under "keep" or "close." **Ignore it entirely.** (The classic "we spent 40 lakh, we can't quit" fallacy is precisely what we must resist.)

Step 2 — Identify what actually changes on closure (relevant items only):

On shutting the Racer line	₹
Contribution *lost* (foregone)	(32,00,000)
Specific/avoidable fixed cost *saved*	12,20,000
Rental income *gained* (opportunity now realised)	2,50,000
Net change in profit if shut down	**(17,30,000)**

Step 3 — Decision. Shutting down makes the company **₹17,30,000 *worse* off** per year. The apportioned ₹21,00,000 common cost continues either way, so the "₹1,20,000 loss" is an *accounting artefact* of arbitrary apportionment. **Keep the Racer line running.** Proof by rebuilding total profit both ways:

Company profit impact of the Racer line	Keep (₹)	Close (₹)
Contribution from Racer	32,00,000	0
Rent income (machine)	0	2,50,000
Specific fixed cost	(12,20,000)	0
Common fixed cost (continues regardless)	(21,00,000)	(21,00,000)
Net effect	**(1,20,000)**	**(18,50,000)**

Keeping the line leaves the firm ₹17,30,000 better off (−1,20,000 vs −18,50,000). Reconciles with Step 2. **The line stays.** *Notice how four classifications — variable/fixed, avoidable/unavoidable, sunk, and opportunity — had to work together for one decision.*

"What if the examiner tweaks it?" — the shutdown point. Suppose instead the specific/avoidable fixed cost were ₹35,00,000 and rental ₹2,50,000. Then closure would *save* 35,00,000 + 2,50,000 = 37,50,000 while *losing* only 32,00,000 contribution → net **+₹5,50,000** to shut. The rule that pops out is the **shutdown test**: close only when *avoidable fixed cost saved* + *opportunity gains* > *contribution lost*. Equivalently, keep running as long as the segment earns **any contribution towards common fixed cost** after covering its own avoidable fixed cost. A negative-contribution line, by contrast, should close even before considering fixed cost.

Part B — Choosing and computing a composite cost unit (Operating costing). Deccan runs a delivery lorry to ship cycles to dealers. In a month it makes the trips below; running cost for the month is **₹96,000**. Management wants the **cost per tonne-kilometre** (the fair unit, because it captures *both* load and distance).

Trip	Distance one way (km)	Load carried outward (tonnes)	Return load (tonnes)
A	40	6	0 (empty)
B	60	5	2
C	30	8	4

Step 1 — Decide the unit. A plain "per km" would reward driving far with a light load; "per tonne" ignores distance. The **tonne-km** (tonnes × km) fairly measures haulage effort — *that is why operating costing uses composite units.*

Step 2 — Compute effective tonne-km (each leg = load on that leg × its distance; the return distance equals the outward distance):

Trip	Outward tonne-km	Return tonne-km	Total
A	6 × 40 = 240	0 × 40 = 0	240
B	5 × 60 = 300	2 × 60 = 120	420
C	8 × 30 = 240	4 × 30 = 120	360
Total			**1,020**

Step 3 — Cost per tonne-km = Total running cost ÷ Total tonne-km = 96,000 ÷ 1,020 = **₹94.12 per tonne-km** (to 2 dp).

This single figure lets management benchmark the lorry month-on-month, decide freight quotes, and compare against a third-party transporter — *decisions the financial P&L's lump "transport expense ₹96,000" could never support.*

Absolute vs. commercial tonne-km — the tweak that changes the denominator. What we computed (load on each *actual* leg × distance) is the **absolute tonne-km** and is the *stricter, fairer* basis. Some questions instead ask for **commercial tonne-km** = average load × *total* distance. Here total distance travelled = 2 × (40 + 60 + 30) = 260 km, and average load across all legs = 1,020 ÷ 260 ≈ 3.92 t, so commercial tonne-km ≈ 1,020 too — but the moment the examiner defines "average load" differently (e.g., simple mean of only the loaded legs), the two diverge sharply. *Always read which basis is asked; the empty return leg is the pivot the examiner watches.*

Worked Example 4 (Medium-Hard) — Make-or-Buy with an Opportunity Cost Sting

The brake-cable question from Section 1. Deccan currently *makes* the brake-cable set in-house. A vendor offers to *supply* it at **₹90 per set**. In-house cost per set is recorded as:

In-house cost per brake-cable set	₹
Direct material	40
Direct labour	22
Variable factory overhead	12
Fixed factory overhead (apportioned)	18
Total "cost" per set	**92**

Naïve reading: "We make it for ₹92, vendor sells at ₹90 — **buy**, save ₹2." **Test this properly.**

Step 1 — Strip to relevant (avoidable) cost of making. The ₹18 fixed overhead is *apportioned* head-office cost that continues whether or not we make the cable (it does not vanish on outsourcing). So the cost we actually *save* by not making = 40 + 22 + 12 = **₹74** per set (the variable cost). The ₹18 is **irrelevant**.

Step 2 — Compare avoidable make-cost with buy-price. Make (relevant) ₹74 vs Buy ₹90. **Making is cheaper by ₹16 per set.** The ₹18 apportioned fixed cost was masking a good in-house operation. **Continue making.**

Step 3 — The examiner's sting: free capacity. Now suppose that if we *stop* making the cable, the freed machine time can be used to make a *mudguard* earning **₹1,00,000 contribution p.a.**, and annual requirement is 5,000 sets. Reframe as: does buying, *plus* the mudguard opportunity, beat making?

Per annum (5,000 sets)	Make in-house (₹)	Buy out + make mudguard (₹)
Relevant cost of cable (make 74 / buy 90)	3,70,000	4,50,000
Less: contribution from mudguard using freed capacity	0	(1,00,000)
Net relevant cost	**3,70,000**	**3,50,000**

Now **buying is cheaper by ₹20,000** — because the **opportunity cost** of the tied-up capacity (₹1,00,000 mudguard contribution) tips the decision. *Same numbers, opposite answer, purely because a scarce resource had a better use.* This is the exact classification interplay — avoidable cost + opportunity cost — that Section 4.6 exists to teach, and the single most common make-or-buy trap in the exam.

---

6. Presentation & Format — How to Lay It Out in the Exam

Cost-sheet discipline (memorise the skeleton, understand each subtotal):

- Always run *elements → prime → works → production → COGS → cost of sales → sales*, showing **bold subtotals** at Prime, Works, Production and Cost of Sales.
- Show a **Total (₹)** column and, when units are given, a **Per-unit (₹)** column. Per-unit fixed costs will differ across volumes — flag that.
- **Adjust stocks at the right level:** raw-material stock adjusts *before* prime cost (opening + purchases − closing = consumed); **WIP** adjusts at *works cost*; **finished-goods** stock adjusts *after* cost of production to reach COGS.
- **Direction of stock adjustment:** *add opening, subtract closing.*
- Keep a "*Less:*" / "*Add:*" prefix on every adjusting line so the marker can follow the arithmetic.

- **Value closing finished goods at the *current* period's cost of production per unit**, not at selling price and not at last period's cost — a frequent silent error (see Example 1B).
- **Items that never enter a cost sheet** (they are *pure financial* items, excluded from cost): income tax, dividends paid, donations, loss/profit on sale of assets, interest on loans/debentures, goodwill written off, fines and penalties. Slotting any of these into the cost sheet is an instant mark loss — they belong only in financial accounts (this is the seed of the cost–financial *reconciliation* chapter).

Decision-statement discipline (for relevant-cost problems):

- Head the statement "*Statement showing Relevant/Incremental Cost*" — never mix in sunk or apportioned-fixed lines except to explicitly *exclude* them with a note.
- Work in **contribution** (Sales − Variable cost) for mix/shutdown/extra-order questions, then handle fixed cost separately as avoidable vs. unavoidable.
- Always **state your assumptions** (spare capacity, no market spoilage, opportunity cost included) — examiners award marks for the caveats.
- Show the "*do-nothing*" alternative explicitly where relevant, and compute the answer *both* as an incremental statement *and* as a two-column total-profit comparison when time allows — they must reconcile (as in Example 3), and the reconciliation earns confidence marks.

Operating-costing discipline: define the cost unit first, build the *composite* quantity in a table, then divide total cost by total units. Show the tonne-km / passenger-km build-up explicitly, and state whether you used **absolute** or **commercial** tonne-km.

---

7. Connections — Where This Chapter Feeds the Rest of the Syllabus

- **Elements → Material, Labour, Overheads chapters.** The direct/indirect split opened here becomes the machinery of stock valuation (FIFO/weighted average), labour incentive schemes, and overhead absorption rates.
- **Fixed/Variable → Marginal Costing & CVP.** Behaviour analysis is the entire foundation of contribution, break-even, margin of safety, and the make-or-buy and mix decisions.
- **Product/Period + Absorption → Marginal vs. Absorption reconciliation.** The period-cost cut you learned here *is* the reason the two systems report different profits when stock changes.
- **Controllable/Uncontrollable + Normal/Abnormal → Standard Costing & Budgetary Control.** Variance analysis only makes sense once you can say *who could have controlled it* and *what was abnormal enough to exclude.*
- **Relevant/Sunk/Opportunity → Decision-Making chapter.** Examples 2, 3 and 4 are miniatures of the full special-order, make-or-buy, and shutdown problem sets.
- **Cost centres → Overheads & Reconciliation.** Service-centre re-apportionment (repeated distribution, simultaneous equations) rests on the centre taxonomy defined here.
- **Methods → Job/Batch/Process/Contract/Operating chapters**, each of which is a *deep dive* into one row of the methods table in 4.8.
- **Pure-financial exclusions → Cost–Financial Reconciliation.** The list of items that never enter a cost sheet (Section 6) is exactly what the reconciliation statement later adds back.

Cost accounting also **reconciles** with financial accounting (a dedicated chapter): the two profits differ because of items FA records but cost accounting excludes (pure financial income/expense like dividends, interest on investments) and notional items cost accounting includes (notional rent/interest). This chapter's "*why they're separate*" is the conceptual root of that reconciliation.

---

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **"Cost per unit" without behaviour.** If a question gives a per-unit cost at one volume and asks for total cost at another volume, you must *strip out* the fixed portion — fixed cost per unit is *not* constant. This is the number-one silent trap.
2. **Treating apportioned (common) fixed cost as avoidable in shutdown problems.** Only *specific/avoidable* fixed cost is relevant to closure. Common cost that continues is irrelevant — see Example 3.
3. **Including sunk cost.** Past R&D, historical machine cost, already-paid deposits — all sunk. Any solution that lets them influence a *future* decision is wrong.
4. **Forgetting opportunity cost.** If a scarce resource used by an option could earn elsewhere, that foregone earning is a *real* relevant cost even though no cash moves. Examiners plant a "could be rented / could make another product" clue precisely to test this (Examples 2-Twist A, 3, and 4).
5. **Direct vs. indirect by importance, not traceability.** Glue and thread are physically essential yet *indirect* because tracing them per unit is uneconomic. Don't be fooled by physical prominence.
6. **Confusing method with technique.** "Deccan should use marginal costing" — marginal is a *technique*, not a method. The *method* (batch) is fixed by the product. State both correctly.
7. **Composite-unit arithmetic.** In tonne-km / passenger-km, remember the *return leg* and any *empty running* — a lorry going back empty earns *zero* tonne-km for that leg but still costs money; that's what pushes up cost per effective tonne-km. Also state absolute vs commercial basis.
8. **Stock adjustment at the wrong level.** WIP adjusts at *works* cost, finished goods at *production* cost, raw material *before* prime cost. Swapping them corrupts COGS (Example 1B).
9. **Profit "on cost" vs. "on sales."** 20% *on sales* ≠ 20% *on cost*. On sales: Sales = Cost ÷ 0.80. On cost: Sales = Cost × 1.20. Read the wording.
10. **Controllability without a level/time frame.** Never label a cost "uncontrollable" absolutely — always relative to *this manager* over *this period*.
11. **Marginal vs. differential cost.** If an alternative crosses a capacity *step*, the extra fixed cost belongs in *differential* cost; "marginal cost = variable cost" quietly drops it. Watch for step-cost language.
12. **Putting pure-financial items into the cost sheet.** Income tax, dividends, interest on loans, donations, loss on sale of assets — none enter cost. This is examined both in cost sheets and in reconciliation.
13. **Valuing closing finished goods wrongly.** Value at *this* period's cost of production per unit — never at selling price, never at last period's cost.
14. **Cost control vs. cost reduction.** A two-marker that punishes vague answers; control keeps to the standard, reduction lowers the standard permanently.
15. **Normal vs. abnormal.** Normal loss/idle time is *absorbed into cost*; abnormal loss/idle time is *excluded and charged to Costing P&L*. Reversing this distorts unit cost.

---

9. First-Principles Recap

Strip everything away and rebuild from one seed: **managers make forward decisions about parts of a business, and financial accounting only reports backward totals for the whole.** From that single gap, everything in this chapter follows by necessity:

- Because decisions concern *parts*, we localize cost to **cost centres** and express it **per cost unit**.
- Because different decisions need different cuts of the same rupee, cost is not one number but a **number-for-a-purpose**, sliced by **classifications** — and *each classification exists to serve a specific decision*:
- trace product cost → **direct/indirect**;
- predict cost as volume moves → **fixed/variable/semi-variable**;
- value inventory and time profit → **product/period**;
- fix responsibility → **controllable/uncontrollable** (and *normal/abnormal* for what even belongs in cost);
- choose between alternatives → **relevant vs. sunk, opportunity, differential, marginal**.
- Because industries organize production differently, the *collection framework* is a **method** (job, batch, process, operating...), fixed by the product — and at root there are only two: *specific-order* and *continuous-operation*.
- Because managers pursue different purposes, the *analytical principle* laid over any method is a **technique** (absorption, marginal, standard, budgetary), chosen by the decision.
- And because information itself costs money, the whole system is disciplined by one meta-rule: **the benefit of knowing must exceed the cost of measuring** — which is why we trace only what is economical to trace and build only as much system as the decisions justify.

If you can, for any cost item, answer "*which lens, and for which decision?*" — you have understood this chapter. The formulas are just the bookkeeping of that understanding.

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

Cost build-up (learn cold):

Stage	Formula
Prime Cost	Direct Material + Direct Labour + Direct Expenses
Works (Factory) Cost	Prime Cost + Factory Overhead (± opening/closing WIP)
Cost of Production	Works Cost + Admin Overhead
Cost of Goods Sold	Cost of Production + Opening FG − Closing FG
Cost of Sales	COGS + Selling & Distribution Overhead
Sales	Cost of Sales + Profit
Overhead	Indirect Material + Indirect Labour + Indirect Expenses
Contribution	Sales − Variable Cost
Material consumed	Opening RM + Purchases − Closing RM

Stock adjusts at three levels: Raw material → *before Prime*; WIP → *at Works cost*; Finished goods → *after Cost of Production*. Direction: + *opening*, − *closing*. Value closing FG at *current* cost of production per unit.

Profit-margin conversions: Profit 20% *on sales* → Sales = Cost ÷ 0.80. Profit 20% *on cost* → Sales = Cost × 1.20.

Classifications and the decision each serves:

Classification	Split	Decision it enables
Element	Material / Labour / Expenses	Cost build-up
Function	Production / Admin / Selling-Distribution	Responsibility grouping
Traceability	Direct / Indirect	Product costing; overhead absorption
Behaviour	Fixed / Variable / Semi-variable (incl. step)	Pricing, break-even, extra-order, shutdown
Period-attach	Product / Period	Inventory valuation; timing of profit
Controllability	Controllable / Uncontrollable	Responsibility accounting; appraisal
Normality	Normal / Abnormal	Whether it enters cost at all
Relevance	Relevant / Sunk / Opportunity / Differential / Marginal	Make-or-buy, accept order, replace, shutdown

Decision rules: - Relevant cost = *future* cost that *differs* between alternatives. Ignore sunk. Add opportunity cost. - Accept special order if **price > marginal cost** *and* spare capacity exists (else add opportunity cost of displaced use; and no market spoilage). - Make-or-buy: compare **avoidable make-cost** with **buy-price**, then add **opportunity cost** of freed capacity. Ignore apportioned fixed cost. - Shutdown: compare **contribution lost** vs **avoidable fixed cost saved + opportunity gains**. Ignore apportioned common cost. Keep running while the segment gives *any* contribution to common fixed cost after its own avoidable fixed cost.

Cost control vs. reduction: control keeps cost *to* the standard; reduction lowers the standard *permanently*.

Fixed-cost sub-types: committed (unavoidable short-run) vs discretionary (management-set, first to cut). Step fixed cost: constant within a range, jumps across ranges.

Cost centre types: Personal / Impersonal; Production / Service. **Responsibility centres:** Cost, Revenue, Profit, Investment. *Centre absorbs cost; unit carries cost.*

Composite cost units: tonne-km (transport-goods), passenger-km (transport-passenger), patient-day (hospital), room-day (hotel), kWh (electricity). Absolute tonne-km (per actual leg) vs commercial tonne-km (avg load × total distance).

Pure-financial items excluded from cost: income tax, dividends, donations, interest on loans, loss/profit on asset sale, goodwill written off, fines.

Methods (product-driven): Job · Batch · Contract · Process · Operating/Service · Single/Output · Multiple/Composite. *At root only two: specific-order vs continuous-operation.* **Techniques (purpose-driven):** Absorption · Marginal · Standard · Budgetary Control · Uniform · Historical. *Time axis: historical (after) vs predetermined (before).*

Statutory note: certain companies must keep **cost records** and undergo **cost audit** under **Sec. 148, Companies Act 2013** (notified industries/thresholds — *verify current ICAI material / AY*). Management accounting has *no* such statutory format or audit.

One-line memory hook: *Method is chosen by the product; Technique is chosen by the decision; Classification is chosen by the question — and the whole system is chosen by cost-benefit.*

Q&A — Introduction to Cost & Management Accounting

> CA Intermediate | Cost & Management Accounting | Chapter 1 Exam-oriented question bank. Every question is followed immediately by a complete model answer. Currency: Indian Rupees (₹). Terminology & formulae per ICAI Study Material.

Section A — Concept-Check Questions (with answers)

A1. Define Cost, Costing, Cost Accounting and Cost Accountancy.

Answer: - **Cost** — the amount of expenditure (actual or notional) incurred on, or attributable to, a given thing (product, service, activity). It is a *measurement, in monetary terms, of resources used*. - **Costing** — the *technique and process* of ascertaining costs. - **Cost Accounting** — the *process of accounting for costs*: recording, classifying, allocating and reporting costs, beginning with recording of expenditure and ending with preparation of statistical data. - **Cost Accountancy** — the *widest term*; the application of costing and cost accounting principles, methods and techniques to the science, art and practice of cost control and ascertainment of profitability, including presentation of information for managerial decision-making. (Costing + Cost Accounting + Cost Control + Cost Audit.)

A2. State any four objectives of Cost Accounting.

Answer: (1) Ascertainment of cost, (2) Determination of selling price, (3) Cost control and cost reduction, (4) Ascertaining profit of each activity, (5) Assisting management in decision-making. (Any four.)

A3. Distinguish between Cost Control and Cost Reduction (any three points).

Answer:

Basis	Cost Control	Cost Reduction
Aim	Achieve/maintain a *pre-set standard*	*Reduce cost below* the standard permanently
Nature	Retrospective (compares actual vs target)	Prospective / continuous
Assumption	Standards are the best; not challenged	Challenges every standard as improvable
Permanence	May be temporary	Real and permanent
Ends	When target is met	Never-ending, dynamic

A4. What is a Cost Centre? Name its two types.

Answer: A **cost centre** is a location, person, item of equipment (or a group of these) for which costs may be ascertained and used for cost control. Two broad types — **(i) Personal cost centre** (a person/group of persons) and **(ii) Impersonal cost centre** (a location or item of equipment). Functionally split into **Production cost centres** and **Service cost centres**.

A5. Differentiate Cost Centre and Cost Unit.

Answer: A **cost centre** is a *sub-division of an organisation* to which costs are charged; a **cost unit** is a *unit of product/service/time* in relation to which costs are ascertained or expressed (e.g., per tonne, per litre, per passenger-km). Cost unit is the *measuring rod*; cost centre is the *collection point*.

A6. Give appropriate cost units for: (a) Cement, (b) Power/Electricity, (c) Hospital, (d) Transport, (e) Automobile.

Answer: (a) Cement — per tonne/bag; (b) Power — per kilowatt-hour (kWh); (c) Hospital — per patient-day / per bed-day; (d) Transport — per tonne-kilometre or passenger-kilometre; (e) Automobile — per number/unit.

A7. Distinguish between Cost Accounting and Management Accounting (any three).

Answer:

Basis	Cost Accounting	Management Accounting
Scope	Narrower — ascertainment & control of cost	Wider — all financial + cost data for decisions
Nature	Mostly quantitative (cost data)	Quantitative + qualitative
Basis	Present & past records	Present & future (projections)
Objective	Cost ascertainment/control	Decision-making, planning, control
Statutory	Cost audit may be mandatory	Purely optional/advisory

A8. What are the essentials of a good costing system?

Answer: Suitability to the business, simplicity, flexibility, economy (cost < benefit), comparability, capability of presenting timely information, minimum changes to existing set-up, uniformity of forms, and support/co-operation of top management and staff.

A9. State three limitations of Cost Accounting.

Answer: (1) It is based on estimates and conventions (e.g., overhead absorption), so not fully accurate; (2) It is expensive/needs elaborate records; (3) Lack of uniform procedure — different accountants may arrive at different costs; (4) It is not an exact science. (Any three.)

A10. Explain "Responsibility Centre" and its three types.

Answer: A **responsibility centre** is an activity segment of an organisation for whose performance a specified manager is held responsible. Types — **Cost centre** (responsible for cost only), **Profit centre** (responsible for both cost and revenue), and **Investment centre** (responsible for cost, revenue and investment/assets).

A11. What is meant by "Cost Object"? Give two examples.

Answer: A **cost object** is anything for which a separate measurement of cost is desired — e.g., a *product* (a car), a *service* (a bank loan), a *project*, a *customer*, or an *activity*.

A12. State the difference between Allocation and Apportionment of overheads.

Answer: **Allocation** is charging the *whole* of an item of cost directly to a cost centre to which it *wholly relates* (e.g., salary of a foreman to his department). **Apportionment** is *distribution of a common item* of cost over several cost centres on a suitable *equitable basis* (e.g., rent apportioned on floor area).

Section B — Graded Computational Problems (easy → exam-hard)

This chapter is largely conceptual; computation focuses on cost classification, cost-per-unit, cost centre/unit relations and elementary cost statements. Each solution reconciles fully.

B1 (Easy) — Prime Cost & Direct/Indirect split

From the following, compute **Prime Cost**: Direct Materials ₹1,20,000; Direct Wages ₹80,000; Direct (Chargeable) Expenses ₹15,000; Factory Rent ₹25,000; Office Salaries ₹18,000.

Solution: Prime Cost = Direct Materials + Direct Wages + Direct Expenses = ₹1,20,000 + ₹80,000 + ₹15,000 = **₹2,15,000**. (Factory Rent and Office Salaries are *indirect* → overheads, excluded from Prime Cost.)

B2 (Easy) — Cost per unit

A factory produced **5,000 units** at a total cost of ₹8,50,000. Compute cost per unit. If output rises to 6,800 units with total cost ₹10,20,000, compute the new cost per unit and comment.

Solution: - Cost per unit (Case 1) = ₹8,50,000 ÷ 5,000 = **₹170.00** - Cost per unit (Case 2) = ₹10,20,000 ÷ 6,800 = **₹150.00** - **Comment:** Cost per unit fell ₹20 despite higher total cost — because **fixed cost is spread over more units** (economies of scale). This demonstrates why per-unit cost (a cost object measure) needs a **cost unit** to be meaningful.

B3 (Basic) — Classify by element and prepare element-wise total

Classify the following and total each element. Direct Material ₹2,40,000; Indirect Material ₹30,000; Direct Labour ₹1,60,000; Indirect Labour ₹45,000; Direct Expenses ₹20,000; Factory Overheads (other) ₹55,000.

Solution:

Element	Direct (₹)	Indirect / Overhead (₹)
Material	2,40,000	30,000
Labour	1,60,000	45,000
Expenses	20,000	55,000
Total	**4,20,000**	**1,30,000**

- **Prime Cost** = ₹4,20,000 (all direct)
- **Total Overheads** = ₹1,30,000 (all indirect)
- **Total Cost** = ₹4,20,000 + ₹1,30,000 = **₹5,50,000** ✓ (reconciles with sum of all six figures: 2,40,000+30,000+1,60,000+45,000+20,000+55,000 = 5,50,000).

B4 (Moderate) — Cost unit selection & composite unit (Transport)

A transport operator ran a lorry that made **8 trips** carrying **12 tonnes** each over a one-way distance of **150 km** (return empty). Total operating cost for the period = ₹2,88,000. Compute cost per **tonne-km** (commercial/loaded basis).

Solution: - Loaded tonne-km per trip = 12 tonnes × 150 km = 1,800 tonne-km - Total loaded tonne-km = 1,800 × 8 trips = **14,400 tonne-km** - Cost per tonne-km = ₹2,88,000 ÷ 14,400 = **₹20.00 per tonne-km**

(Note: return journey is empty, so it carries no load; the commercial tonne-km counts only the loaded outward legs. This illustrates a composite cost unit — two variables (weight × distance) combined.)

B5 (Moderate) — Allocation vs Apportionment

A firm has two production departments P1 and P2 and incurs: Foreman's salary of P1 ₹40,000 (relates wholly to P1); Factory Rent ₹90,000 (P1 floor area 2,000 sq.m, P2 floor area 1,000 sq.m); Power ₹60,000 (P1 machine-hours 4,000, P2 machine-hours 2,000). Distribute the costs.

Solution:

Item	Basis	Total (₹)	P1 (₹)	P2 (₹)
Foreman salary	**Allocation** (wholly P1)	40,000	40,000	0
Factory Rent	**Apportion** — floor area 2:1	90,000	60,000	30,000
Power	**Apportion** — machine-hrs 2:1	60,000	40,000	20,000
Total		**1,90,000**	**1,40,000**	**50,000**

Check: 1,40,000 + 50,000 = 1,90,000 ✓. - Rent to P1 = 90,000 × 2000/3000 = 60,000; P2 = 90,000 × 1000/3000 = 30,000. - Power to P1 = 60,000 × 4000/6000 = 40,000; P2 = 60,000 × 2000/6000 = 20,000.

B6 (Exam-hard) — Full elementary Cost Statement + profit reconciliation

From the following data of Zenith Ltd for the year, prepare a **statement of cost and profit**, showing Prime Cost, Works Cost, Cost of Production, Cost of Sales and Profit. Output = 10,000 units; all produced units sold.

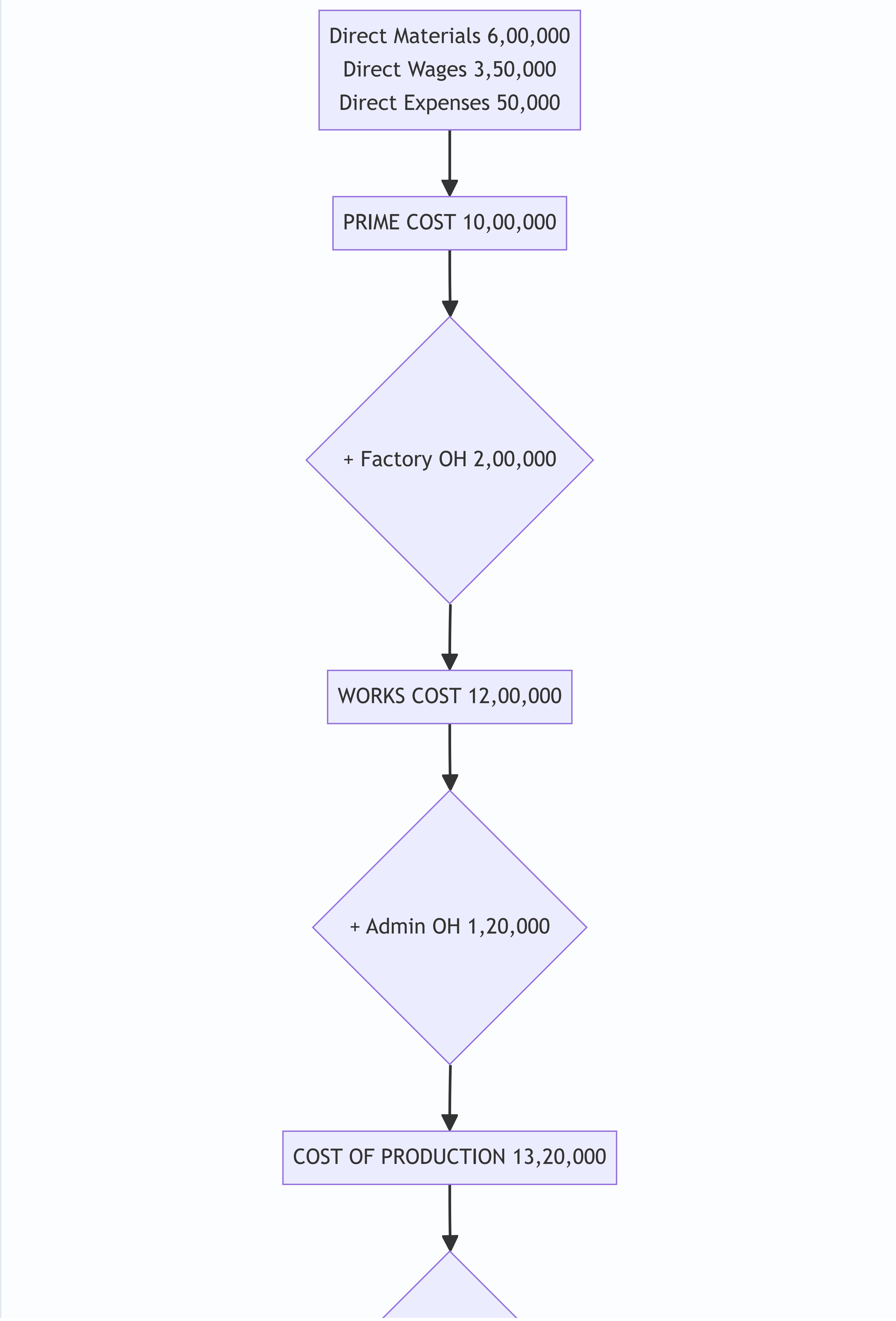
Raw materials consumed ₹6,00,000; Direct wages ₹3,50,000; Direct chargeable expenses ₹50,000; Factory overheads ₹2,00,000; Administrative overheads (production-related) ₹1,20,000; Selling & distribution overheads ₹80,000; Sales ₹16,00,000.

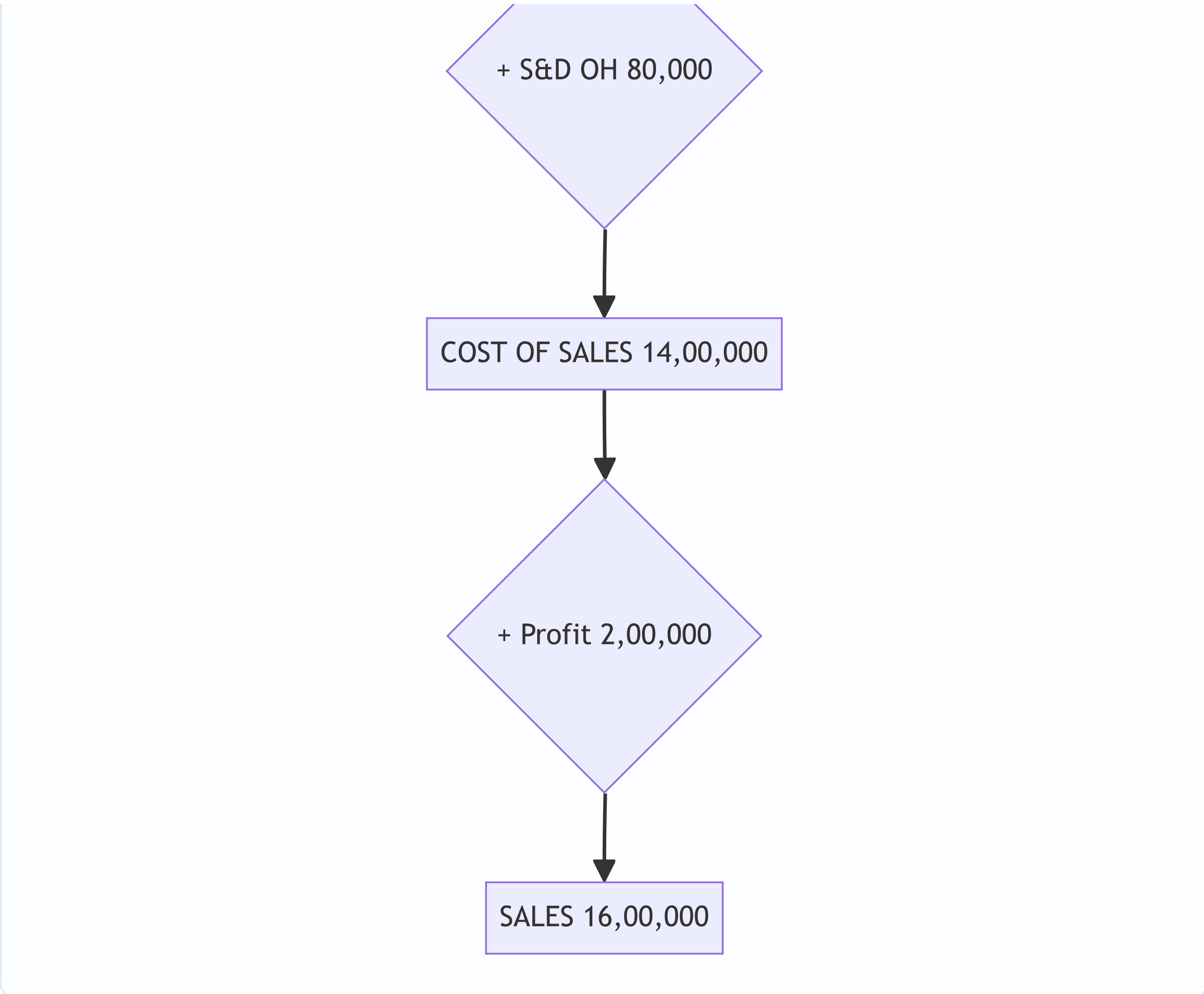
Solution:

Statement of Cost and Profit (10,000 units)

Particulars	Total (₹)	Per unit (₹)
Direct Materials	6,00,000	60.00
Direct Wages	3,50,000	35.00
Direct Expenses	50,000	5.00
Prime Cost	**10,00,000**	**100.00**
Add: Factory Overheads	2,00,000	20.00
Works / Factory Cost	**12,00,000**	**120.00**
Add: Administrative Overheads	1,20,000	12.00
Cost of Production	**13,20,000**	**132.00**
Add: Selling & Distribution Overheads	80,000	8.00
Cost of Sales	**14,00,000**	**140.00**
Profit (balancing)	**2,00,000**	**20.00**
Sales	**16,00,000**	**160.00**

Workings / verification: - Profit = Sales − Cost of Sales = 16,00,000 − 14,00,000 = **₹2,00,000** ✓ - Per unit = each total ÷ 10,000; per-unit profit ₹20 × 10,000 = ₹2,00,000 ✓ - Profit as % of sales = 2,00,000 / 16,00,000 = **12.5%**.


Direct Materials 6,00,000
Direct Wages 3,50,000
Direct Expenses 50,000
PRIME COST 10,00,000
+ Factory OH 2,00,000
WORKS COST 12,00,000
+ Admin OH 1,20,000
COST OF PRODUCTION 13,20,000



B7 (Exam-hard) — Cost classification into behaviour + relevant range

Total cost at 4,000 units = ₹5,20,000; at 6,000 units = ₹7,00,000 (within relevant range). Using the **high–low method**, split into fixed and variable, and find total cost at 5,000 units.

Solution: - Variable cost per unit = (7,00,000 − 5,20,000) ÷ (6,000 − 4,000) = 1,80,000 ÷ 2,000 = **₹90 per unit** - Fixed cost = Total − Variable = 5,20,000 − (4,000 × 90) = 5,20,000 − 3,60,000 = **₹1,60,000** - Check at 6,000: 1,60,000 + (6,000 × 90) = 1,60,000 + 5,40,000 = ₹7,00,000 ✓ - **Total cost at 5,000 units** = 1,60,000 + (5,000 × 90) = 1,60,000 + 4,50,000 = **₹6,10,000**.

(This links Chapter 1's classification-by-behaviour, fixed/variable/semi-variable, to computation.)

Section C — Past-Paper-Style Full Questions (with model answers)

C1. "Cost Accounting has become an essential tool of management." Discuss the role of Cost Accounting in the decision-making process of management. (5 marks)

Model Answer: Cost Accounting supplies detailed cost information that financial accounting cannot, enabling management to: 1. **Fix selling prices** on a scientific basis (cost-plus, tenders, quotations). 2. **Control costs** by comparing actuals with standards/budgets and pinpointing variances and responsibility. 3. **Decide product mix / make-or-buy / accept-reject special orders** using marginal and differential cost analysis. 4. **Measure**

profitability of each product, department, or job, and drop/expand accordingly. 5. **Plan and budget** operations and evaluate performance of responsibility centres. 6. **Value inventory** for interim accounts and eliminate wastage/inefficiency. Thus it converts raw expenditure data into actionable managerial intelligence, making it indispensable for planning, control and decision-making.

C2. Explain the various methods of costing with one industry example each. (6 marks)

Model Answer: Methods depend on the nature of production: - **Job Costing** — cost ascertained for each specific job/order (e.g., printing press, repair workshop). - **Batch Costing** — a batch of identical items is one cost unit (e.g., pharmaceuticals, bakery). - **Contract Costing** — large jobs spread over long periods, each contract a unit (e.g., construction, shipbuilding). - **Process Costing** — continuous production through processes; cost per process (e.g., chemicals, refineries). - **Operation / Unit (Single/Output) Costing** — single product mass produced (e.g., cement, mining, breweries). - **Service (Operating) Costing** — for services (e.g., transport per tonne-km, hospital per bed-day). - **Multiple / Composite Costing** — combination for products with many parts (e.g., automobiles, cycles).

C3. Distinguish between "Financial Accounting" and "Cost Accounting" on any five bases. (5 marks)

Model Answer:

Basis	Financial Accounting	Cost Accounting
Purpose	Records overall results; for external users	Ascertains & controls cost; for internal management
Users	Shareholders, creditors, govt.	Management
Statutory	Legally mandatory for companies	Mandatory only where cost records/audit prescribed
Analysis	Overall profit of whole business	Profit/cost of each product, job, process
Timing	Reported periodically (year-end)	Reported continuously as needed
Valuation of stock	At cost or NRV, whichever lower	At cost
Nature	Records historical, monetary data	Uses monetary + non-monetary (units, hours) data

C4. What is a "Cost Unit"? Explain the factors influencing its selection, and give cost units for five industries. (5 marks)

Model Answer: A **cost unit** is a unit of quantity of product, service or time (or a combination) in relation to which costs are ascertained or expressed. **Factors in selection:** (i) nature of the product/process, (ii) practice/convention in the industry, (iii) requirement of management for control, (iv) the unit that facilitates comparison and is easily understood, (v) simplicity and appropriateness. **Examples:**

Industry	Cost Unit
Cement	Per tonne / bag
Electricity	Per kilowatt-hour (kWh)
Transport	Per tonne-km / passenger-km
Hospital	Per patient-day / bed-day
Hotel	Per room-day

C5. Write short notes on: (a) Cost Reduction, (b) Responsibility Accounting, (c) Conversion Cost. (6 marks)

Model Answer: - **(a) Cost Reduction** — a real and permanent reduction in the unit cost of goods/services without impairing suitability for the intended use or quality. It is continuous, dynamic and challenges every existing standard, using tools like value analysis, work study and standardisation. - **(b) Responsibility Accounting** — a system of control where costs and revenues are accumulated and reported by responsibility centres, so that a manager is answerable only for items within his control. It aids performance evaluation using the *controllability principle*. - **(c) Conversion Cost** — the cost of converting raw material into finished product = **Direct Labour + Direct Expenses + Factory (Production) Overheads**. Equivalently, Works Cost − Direct Material Cost.

Section D — MCQs & Case Scenarios (correct option + one-line reasoning)

D1. Prime Cost consists of: (a) Direct Material + Direct Labour only (b) Direct Material + Direct Labour + Direct Expenses (c) Direct Material + Factory Overheads (d) All direct + all indirect costs. **Ans: (b)** — Prime cost = sum of all *direct* costs (material + labour + expenses).

D2. Which of the following is a *composite* cost unit? (a) Per tonne (b) Per litre (c) Per tonne-kilometre (d) Per unit. **Ans: (c)** — It combines two measures (weight × distance).

D3. Charging the whole of an overhead directly to one cost centre to which it wholly relates is called: (a) Apportionment (b) Absorption (c) Allocation (d) Re-apportionment. **Ans: (c)** — Allocation charges an entire item to one cost centre wholly related to it.

D4. Conversion cost is: (a) DM + DL (b) DL + DE + Factory OH (c) Prime cost + Admin OH (d) Works cost + S&D OH. **Ans: (b)** — Cost of converting materials into finished goods excludes direct material.

D5. A centre responsible for both cost and revenue but not investment is a: (a) Cost centre (b) Profit centre (c) Investment centre (d) Service centre. **Ans: (b)** — Profit centre is accountable for revenues and costs, not for capital employed.

D6. Cost control differs from cost reduction because cost control: (a) is permanent (b) challenges standards (c) aims to attain a set target (d) is never-ending. **Ans: (c)** — Cost control seeks to keep costs within a predetermined standard; cost reduction goes below it.

D7. Which is NOT an objective of cost accounting? (a) Ascertainment of cost (b) Fixation of selling price (c) Preparation of the company's statutory balance sheet (d) Cost control. **Ans: (c)** — The statutory balance sheet is the domain of financial accounting.

D8 (Case Scenario). A hospital wants to measure the cost of running its in-patient ward and hold the ward manager accountable for those costs only (not room revenues). It also wants a per-unit figure to compare month-to-month. (i) The ward is best described as a — (a) Profit centre (b) Cost centre (c) Investment centre. (ii) The appropriate cost unit is — (a) Per patient (b) Per patient-day/bed-day (c) Per rupee of revenue. **Ans: (i) (b)** — the manager controls costs only, so it is a cost centre; **(ii) (b)** — patient-day captures both number of patients and length of stay, the standard hospital cost unit.

D9 (Case Scenario). Alpha Ltd produces 20,000 units. Direct material ₹5,00,000, direct wages ₹3,00,000, direct expenses ₹1,00,000, factory OH ₹2,00,000. (i) Prime cost per unit = ? (ii) Works cost per unit = ? **Ans:** Prime cost = 9,00,000 → **₹45/unit**; Works cost = 11,00,000 → **₹55/unit**. *(One-line reasoning: prime = all direct 9,00,000; add factory OH 2,00,000 for works cost; each ÷ 20,000.)*

D10. "Costing must be economical" means: (a) The costing system should be free (b) The benefit from the system should exceed its cost (c) Only cheap clerks be employed (d) No records be kept. **Ans: (b)** — A costing system is justified only when its benefits outweigh its cost.

Quick-Revision Formula Strip

- Prime Cost = DM + DL + Direct Expenses
- Works/Factory Cost = Prime Cost + Factory OH
- Cost of Production = Works Cost + Admin OH (production-related)
- Cost of Sales = Cost of Production + Selling & Distribution OH
- Profit = Sales − Cost of Sales
- Conversion Cost = DL + Direct Expenses + Factory OH = Works Cost − DM
- Cost per unit = Total Cost ÷ Output (in cost units)

Chapter 02 — Material Cost

1. The Problem — Why a Whole Chapter on "Stuff You Buy"?

Walk into any manufacturing business and ask the accountant: "Where does your money go?" In the overwhelming majority of Indian manufacturing firms the answer is the same — **material is the single largest cost element**, routinely 40% to 70% of total cost. A steel fabricator, a textile mill, a pharmaceutical plant, an FMCG unit — for all of them, rupees spent on raw material dwarf rupees spent on wages or overhead.

Now here is the uncomfortable part. Material is also the cost element that is **easiest to lose control of**, for three brutal reasons:

1. **It is physical and portable.** Cash sits in a bank with layers of controls. Material sits in a godown where it can be pilfered, substituted, over-issued, or simply walk out the gate. Theft of material is a real, quantifiable loss in Indian factories.
2. **It deteriorates, evaporates, spills, and breaks.** Chemicals evaporate, grain is eaten by rats, liquids spill, glass breaks, food rots. Some of this is unavoidable (normal); some signals a broken process (abnormal). Telling the two apart is a costing decision.
3. **It ties up working capital.** Every rupee sitting as stock in the godown is a rupee borrowed from the bank at 10–12% interest, or a rupee not earning returns elsewhere. Buy too much and you bleed carrying cost; buy too little and the production line stops and you lose customers.

Financial accounting is *useless* for managing any of this in real time. The financial P&L tells you, once a year, that you consumed ₹8 crore of material. It cannot tell you: *how much* should we order at a time? *When* should we reorder? At *what price* should we value the units we just issued to the shop floor when prices have been rising all year? Was that 500 kg "loss" acceptable or did someone steal it?

These are **managerial decisions**, and each one has a purpose-built technique in cost accounting:

The decision a manager faces	The technique this chapter builds
How much to order in one go?	**Economic Order Quantity (EOQ)**
When to place the order?	**Re-order Level**
How low can stock safely fall?	**Minimum Level**
How high should stock ever go?	**Maximum Level**
At what point do we panic-buy?	**Danger Level**
What price do we put on units issued to production?	**FIFO / LIFO / Weighted Average**
Was a loss acceptable or does it need investigation?	**Normal vs Abnormal loss treatment**
Which items deserve tight control and which don't?	**ABC Analysis**
Is my stock moving or rotting on the shelf?	**Inventory Turnover Ratio**
Who is allowed to buy, receive, store, and issue?	**Procurement cycle & documentation**

Every formula below exists to answer one of these questions. We never state a formula before you feel the pain it removes.

A last framing point before we build. Material control is not one technique but a **chain of custody** — a rupee of material passes through *purchasing → receiving → storage → issue → consumption → loss/scrap*, and cost accounting installs a control (and a document) at every link. If you can see the chain, the chapter stops being a pile of disconnected formulae and becomes one story: **keep the right quantity, priced honestly, with every movement recorded and every loss classified.**

---

2. The Core Idea — The Godown as a Bathtub

Picture your material stock as **water in a bathtub**.

- The **tap** pouring water in = purchases (deliveries from suppliers).
- The **drain** letting water out = issues to production (consumption).
- The **water level** at any moment = stock on hand.

The whole art of material control is keeping the water level in a **safe band** — never so low the drain sucks air (a **stock-out**, production stops), never so high it overflows and floods the bathroom (**over-stocking**, capital locked and material spoiling).

The catch is that the tap has a **delay**: when you open it (place an order), water doesn't arrive instantly — it takes the supplier's **lead time** to deliver. So you must open the tap *before* the level gets dangerous, judging how fast the drain is running (consumption rate) and how long the tap takes to respond (lead time).

Every "level" in this chapter is just a **marked line on the side of the bathtub**: - **Re-order level** = the line at which you shout "open the tap!" - **Minimum level** = the lowest the water should ever get in normal life. - **Maximum level** = the highest it should ever get. - **Danger level** = an emergency red line below minimum — if you hit it, something went wrong, halt normal issues and rush an emergency order.

And **EOQ** answers a different, quieter question: each time you open the tap, *how much* water should you let in? Too little and you're forever running to the tap (high ordering cost); too much and you're storing stale water (high carrying cost). EOQ is the sweet spot between those two nagging costs.

Extend the picture once more. The saw-tooth shape of the water level over time is the single most useful mental image in the chapter. Draw stock on the vertical axis and time on the horizontal: the level slides *down* a slope (the drain / consumption), hits the re-order line, keeps sliding for the length of the lead time, and then jumps *vertically up* by one order quantity when the lot lands. Repeat. That jagged saw-tooth is where **every** number comes from: - the **average height** of the teeth is your average stock (→ carrying cost), - the **number of teeth per year** is your number of orders (→ ordering cost), - the **depth of the valley** at the bottom of each tooth is your minimum level, - and the **height at which you start each downslope's order** is the re-order level.

Once you can see the saw-tooth, you are not memorising six level formulae — you are *reading them off a picture*.

Hold this bathtub picture. Everything technical below hangs on it.

---

3. Why It's Built This Way — The Logic Before the Formulae

3.1 The two-cost tug-of-war behind EOQ

Why can't we just "order what we need when we need it"? Because **ordering itself costs money**, and **holding stock costs money**, and these two costs pull in *opposite directions*.

- **Ordering cost** (cost per order): raising a purchase requisition, inviting quotations, placing the order, following up, receiving, inspecting, and processing the invoice. This is largely *fixed per order* — it costs roughly the same to order 100 units or 10,000 units. So: **more orders → more total ordering cost.** To cut ordering cost, order in *big lots, rarely*.
- **Carrying cost** (holding cost): interest on capital locked in stock, godown rent, insurance, handling, obsolescence, deterioration, pilferage. This grows with *how much you hold*. So: **bigger lots → higher average stock → more carrying cost.** To cut carrying cost, order in *small lots, often*.

You cannot minimise both. Big rare orders kill carrying cost but inflate ordering cost. Small frequent orders do the reverse. **Total cost is minimised where the two curves cross** — where annual ordering cost exactly equals annual carrying cost. That crossing point is the EOQ. That single insight is the *whole* derivation; the algebra just formalises it.

A deeper "why" — why the minimum sits exactly at the crossing. Total cost is a U-shaped curve: falling ordering cost (a hyperbola, $A \cdot O/Q$) added to rising carrying cost (a straight line, $C \cdot Q/2$). A useful mathematical fact: the sum of a term that falls as $1/Q$ and a term that rises linearly in Q is minimised precisely where the two terms are equal in magnitude. That is *why* "ordering cost = carrying cost" is not a coincidence but the defining property of EOQ — and why it doubles as a self-check in every problem. Notice also that the total-cost curve is **flat near the bottom**: order 20–30% away from EOQ and total cost barely rises (see Example 2). This "robustness" is a genuine exam-and-real-life insight — EOQ need not be hit to the last unit.

3.2 Why we need levels at all

Even with the right order *size*, you still need to know *when* to order and how to bound the stock. Levels exist because **lead time is uncertain and consumption is uncertain**. If both were perfectly predictable you'd need no buffer — you'd place an order timed so the last unit is issued exactly as the new lot arrives. But suppliers are late and the shop floor sometimes consumes faster than expected. Levels are essentially a **safety-buffer system**: a set of pre-computed lines so that a storekeeper — not a manager — can run day-to-day stock control mechanically and only escalate at the danger line.

There is an organisational "why" hiding here too. Levels **push control down to the least-skilled reliable person**. A storekeeper needs no judgement: watch the bin, when it drops to the re-order line raise a requisition, when it drops to the danger line escalate. Judgement (setting the levels, revising them when usage or lead time shifts) stays with management, and is exercised *once*, not every day. This separation — policy set high, executed low — is the design principle behind the whole levels system.

3.3 Why issue valuation is even a question

Here's a subtlety that trips up newcomers from a financial background. You bought the same bolt in January at ₹10, in March at ₹12, in May at ₹15. Today you issue 1,000 bolts to production. **What is their cost — ₹10, ₹12, ₹15, or a blend?** Physically the bolts are identical and mixed in a bin; you genuinely cannot say *which* rupee-batch left. So costing must adopt an **assumption** — FIFO, LIFO, or weighted average. This is not accounting pedantry: the assumption you pick changes the cost charged to the job, the value of closing stock, and therefore **reported profit**. In a period of rising prices, the choice can swing profit by lakhs. That is why it is a managerial decision, not a clerical one.

The deeper principle: material issue valuation is a **cost-flow assumption, not a physical-flow claim.** FIFO does not require you to physically issue the oldest bolt; it only assumes you *cost* the issue as if you did. This decoupling of the accounting flow from the physical flow is what makes several methods possible for the *same* physical process. The examiner rewards candidates who state this explicitly ("under FIFO we *assume* the earliest receipts are issued first").

3.4 Why "cost of material" is not just the invoice price

A quieter first-principles point that the exam loves. The cost at which material enters the stores ledger is **not** the sticker price on the invoice. Costing builds up a *landed cost*:

> **Material cost = Purchase price − trade discount − duty/GST credit available + carriage inward + insurance in transit + other purchase-related charges (commission, taxes not creditable) − subsidies.**

The *why* behind each adjustment is a control principle: - **Trade discount is deducted** because it is a genuine reduction in price — the firm never owes the gross amount. - **Cash discount is NOT deducted** from material cost. Cash discount is a *reward for paying early* — a financial matter, credited to a financial income account — not a reduction in the material's economic cost. Treating it as a material-cost reduction would let a *financing* decision distort *product* cost. - **GST/duty that is creditable (input tax credit available) is EXCLUDED** from cost — you will recover it, so it is never a cost to you. GST that is *not* creditable (e.g. on items where credit is blocked) *is* added to cost. - **Carriage inward, insurance in transit, and loading/unloading are ADDED** — they are unavoidable to get the material to your godown, so they are part of what the material genuinely costs you.

Get this build-up right and the very first line of the cost sheet is right; get it wrong and every downstream number inherits the error.

---

4. Full Technical Content — Every Formula With Its "Why"

4.0 The Procurement Cycle and Its Documents (the control backbone)

Before quantities and prices, the exam expects you to know *who does what, and which document proves it*. Material control is a **segregation-of-duties** system: the person who *requests* material is not the person who *buys* it, who is not the person who *receives* it, who is not the person who *stores* it, who is not the person who *authorises payment*. This separation is deliberate — it makes fraud require collusion rather than a single dishonest hand.

Stage	Document	Raised by → sent to	Its control purpose
Need identified	**Purchase Requisition**	Storekeeper / Dept → Purchasing	Proves the buy was *requested* by an authorised person, not invented by the buyer
Buying	**Purchase Order (PO)**	Purchasing → Supplier	The binding commitment; fixes quantity, price, delivery terms
Goods arrive	**Goods Received Note (GRN)** / Material Received Note	Receiving/Inspection → Stores, Purchasing, Accounts	Proves goods actually arrived, in what quantity and condition, after inspection
Storage record	**Bin Card** (kept in the godown, quantity only)	Storekeeper	Real-time physical quantity record at the bin
Value record	**Stores Ledger** (kept in costing office, quantity *and* value)	Cost accounting	Priced perpetual record; the basis for issue valuation
Issue to floor	**Material Requisition Note (MRN)**	Production → Stores	Authorises and records an issue; the source document for charging jobs
Return unused	**Material Returned Note**	Production → Stores	Records material sent back to stores (credited to the job)
Move between jobs	**Material Transfer Note**	Job → Job	Records inter-job transfer *without* physically returning to stores

Bin Card vs Stores Ledger — a classic 4-mark distinction.

Feature	Bin Card	Stores Ledger
Kept by	Storekeeper, in the stores	Cost accounting office
Records	**Quantity only**	Quantity **and value**
When posted	At the moment of each movement	Periodically, from documents
Purpose	Physical control at the bin	Costing and valuation

They should reconcile in quantity; a mismatch signals unrecorded movement, error, or pilferage.

Perpetual vs Periodic (physical) inventory. *Perpetual inventory* is a system of records (bin card + stores ledger) that shows the balance **continuously** after every movement. *Continuous stocktaking* is the physical counting of a few items every day so that all items are counted several times a year — it is the *verification* that keeps the perpetual records honest. Do not confuse the record system (perpetual inventory) with the counting programme (continuous stocktaking); the exam deliberately blurs them.

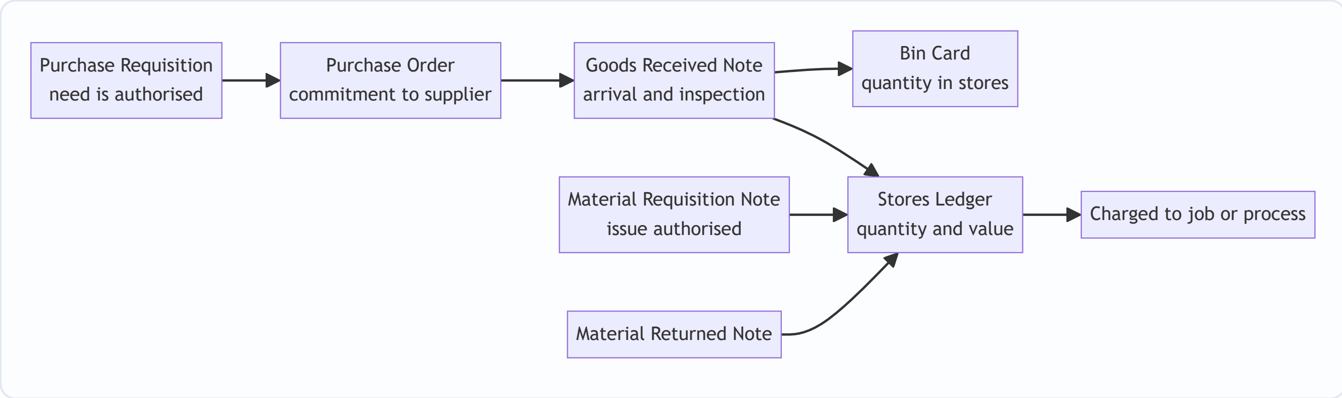


Figure 1 — The procurement chain of custody: every link has its own document so responsibility is always traceable.

4.1 Inventory Control Levels

Let us build each level from the bathtub logic. First, the raw ingredients (the "primitives") every level is made of:

- **Lead time** = time between placing an order and receiving it (also called delivery/procurement time).
- **Consumption (usage) rate** = units used per unit of time (per day/week).

Because both wobble, we speak of **maximum, minimum and normal (average)** values of each.

(a) Re-order Level (ROL) — the "open the tap now" line.

> **Re-order Level = Maximum Usage × Maximum Lead Time**

Why maximum × maximum? The reorder level must protect you in the **worst realistic case** — the fastest the shop floor might consume during the longest the supplier might take. Set it here and even a bad month won't cause a stock-out before the new lot lands. This is the primary line; several other levels are derived *from* it.

An equivalent, often-quoted form when safety stock is stated separately:

> **Re-order Level = Safety Stock + (Average Usage × Average Lead Time)**

Both express the same idea; ICAI problems usually give max/min usage and lead time, so the first form is the workhorse. *(Reconciling the two: Maximum usage × Maximum lead time = (Average usage × Average lead time) + safety stock — so the safety stock implied by the first form equals Max·Max − Avg·Avg. Examiners sometimes ask you to derive safety stock this way.)*

(b) Minimum Level — the floor of normal operation (the safety stock).

> **Minimum Level = Re-order Level − (Average Usage × Average Lead Time)**

Why subtract the average, not the maximum? Once you've re-ordered at ROL, on a *normal* day you'll consume at the *average* rate over the *average* lead time before the lot arrives. Whatever is left when it arrives is your cushion against things going wrong — that cushion *is* the minimum level. If actual usage and lead time turn out average, stock touches exactly this floor as the new lot lands. Anything below signals abnormality.

(c) Maximum Level — the ceiling; don't let capital drown here.

> **Maximum Level = Re-order Level + Re-order Quantity − (Minimum Usage × Minimum Lead Time)**

Why this shape? The highest stock can ever get is: you were sitting at ROL, you placed an order of size ROQ, and then — best case for stock build-up — the **least** was consumed (minimum usage) over the **shortest** wait (minimum lead time) before the full lot piled in on top. Add the incoming lot to reorder level, subtract the little that was drawn down in the meantime. That's the physical peak.

(d) Danger Level — the red emergency line, below minimum.

> **Danger Level = Average Usage × Lead Time for Emergency Purchases**

Why a separate emergency lead time? If you've dropped *below* the minimum, normal replenishment has failed. You must now buy through an **emergency channel** (spot purchase, faster/costlier supplier) which has its *own*, shorter lead time. The danger level is the stock that will just barely cover average consumption during that emergency procurement. Hit it and you stop issuing for non-critical use and rush an emergency buy. (Some texts use *maximum* usage here for extra conservatism; ICAI's standard formula uses average usage × emergency lead time — use that unless the question says otherwise.)

(e) Average Stock Level — for working-capital and carrying-cost estimates.

> **Average Stock = Minimum Level + ½ × Re-order Quantity**
>
> or, equivalently, **Average Stock = ½ × (Minimum Level + Maximum Level)**

Why? Between deliveries, stock saw-tooths from a peak down to the minimum, then jumps back up. Its time-average is the floor plus half a saw-tooth (half a re-order quantity).

(f) Two related buffer ideas the exam may name. - **Safety (buffer) stock** = the minimum level itself in most ICAI problems — the cushion held for uncertainty. Formally, Safety Stock = (Maximum usage − Average usage) × lead time, or Max·Max − Avg·Avg depending on how the data is framed. Always define which you used. - **Buffer for lead-time variability alone** = Average usage × (Maximum lead time − Average lead time). If the question isolates lead-time risk from usage risk, decompose accordingly.

4.2 Economic Order Quantity (EOQ)

Now the star formula. Define:

- **A** = Annual demand / consumption (units per year)
- **O** = Ordering cost **per order** (₹)
- **C** = Carrying cost **per unit per year** (₹). If given as a % of unit price, then C = (carrying %) × (price per unit).

Derivation from the two-cost tug-of-war (Section 3.1). Let **Q** be the order quantity we're solving for.

- Number of orders per year = A / Q. So **Annual Ordering Cost = (A / Q) × O**.

- Average stock held = Q / 2 (saw-tooth). So **Annual Carrying Cost = (Q / 2) × C**.
- **Total relevant cost** T = (A/Q)·O + (Q/2)·C.

As Q rises, the first term falls and the second rises. Minimum is where they are equal (or by calculus, dT/dQ = 0):

$-(A \cdot O)/Q^2 + C/2 = 0 \Longrightarrow Q^2 = 2 \cdot A \cdot O / C$. Hence:

> **EOQ = √(2 × A × O / C)**

The formula is literally the point where "ordering cost = carrying cost". You never have to memorise it as a magic string — you can rebuild it any time from "set the two costs equal".

Companion figures at EOQ:

- Number of orders per year = A / EOQ
- Time between orders = 365 / (number of orders) days
- Total ordering cost = (A/EOQ)·O ; Total carrying cost = (EOQ/2)·C — **and at EOQ these two are equal** (a superb self-check!).
- Total inventory cost (excluding purchase price) = ordering + carrying = both added.
- **Total cost including purchase** = (A × price) + ordering + carrying — needed the moment quantity discounts appear (Section 4.2a).

Assumptions of EOQ (know these — examiners test them): (i) demand is known and constant; (ii) ordering cost per order and carrying cost per unit are constant; (iii) price per unit is constant — *no quantity discounts* (if discounts exist, EOQ must be tested against discount break-points separately); (iv) the entire order is delivered at once; (v) lead time is known; (vi) no stock-outs are permitted. Reality violates all of these, which is exactly why we bolt on the *levels* of 4.1 as shock absorbers.

Unit-consistency warning (a silent killer). A and C must be on the *same time basis*. If A is annual, C must be per unit **per year**. If a problem gives monthly demand, either annualise it or keep everything monthly — but never mix. The √ hides the error, so a mixed-basis EOQ still "looks" plausible; discipline on units is your only defence.

Effect of parameter changes (a favourite theory-cum-numerical twist). Because EOQ ∝ √(A·O / C): - If **demand quadruples**, EOQ only **doubles** (√4 = 2) — ordering does not scale linearly with volume. - If **ordering cost doubles**, EOQ rises by √2 ≈ 41%, not 100%. - If **carrying cost doubles**, EOQ *falls* by a factor of √2. Examiners test whether you know the square-root damping, not just the formula.

4.2a EOQ with Quantity Discounts (the most common EOQ trap)

When a supplier offers a lower **price per unit** for larger lots, the plain EOQ can be wrong, because a bigger order — though it raises carrying cost — may slash the **purchase price** of the entire annual quantity. Now the relevant total cost must include purchase price:

> **Total Annual Cost = (A × Price) + (A/Q × O) + (Q/2 × C)**

The decision procedure: 1. Compute the plain EOQ at the base price. 2. For **each** discount slab, evaluate total annual cost at the *smallest quantity that earns that slab's price* (because within a slab, cost rises with Q, so the slab's lowest qualifying quantity is its best point) — unless the EOQ itself falls inside the slab, in which case use the EOQ. 3. Pick the quantity with the **lowest total annual cost**, comparing purchase + ordering + carrying together.

Note carrying cost C often itself depends on price (if C = % × price), so **recompute C at each slab's price.** Fully worked in Example 6.

4.3 Valuation of Material Issues

When identical units bought at different prices are issued, we assume a cost-flow order. ICAI recognises several methods; the big three below plus a family of "average / notional price" methods you should be able to name and apply.

FIFO (First-In-First-Out). Assume the **oldest** stock is issued first. Closing stock is valued at the **most recent** prices. - *Logic & effect:* physically sensible (you use up old stock first to avoid spoilage). In **rising prices**, issues are charged at old (low) prices → **lower cost** → **higher profit**; closing stock at new (high) prices → **higher balance-sheet stock value**.

LIFO (Last-In-First-Out). Assume the **newest** stock is issued first. Closing stock sits at **old** prices. - *Logic & effect:* charges production at prices closest to current replacement cost. In **rising prices**, issues at new (high) prices → **higher cost** → **lower profit** (and lower reported tax, historically its attraction); closing stock understated at old prices. *Note: LIFO is not permitted under Ind AS-2 / AS-2 for financial reporting, but remains examinable in cost accounting.*

Weighted Average. After each receipt, recompute one blended rate:

> **Weighted Average Rate = Total value of stock on hand ÷ Total units on hand**

All issues until the next receipt go out at this rate. - *Logic & effect:* smooths price fluctuations; issue price lies between FIFO and LIFO; profit and stock values sit in the middle. Preferred when prices swing and you want a stable, un-manipulable cost.

The other named methods (know the definition and the one-line "when used"):

Method	Issue priced at	Notable feature / when used
Simple Average	Average of the *rates* of lots in stock (ignores quantities)	Crude; can violate the reconciliation check because it ignores quantity weighting — flagged by examiners as theoretically unsound
Periodic Weighted Average	One rate for the whole period = total value ÷ total units for the period	Computed at period-end, not after each receipt; simpler but not real-time
HIFO (Highest-In-First-Out)	Highest-priced lot issued first	Conservative; keeps stock at lowest values; rare, used to suppress reported stock value
Replacement / Market Price	Current market price on the date of issue	Charges production at what it would cost to replace *today*; used in volatile markets; a *notional* price
Standard Price	A pre-set standard rate	Any difference vs actual is a **price variance**; links to standard costing; simplifies clerical work
Base Stock	A minimum "base" quantity is always carried at its original old price; issues above base priced by FIFO/LIFO	Not a standalone method — a layer on top of FIFO/LIFO

Distinction the exam probes: **actual-price methods** (FIFO, LIFO, HIFO, averages) recover *exactly* the money spent — the reconciliation Opening + Purchases = Issues + Closing holds to the rupee. **Notional-price methods** (replacement, standard) deliberately do *not* — they price issues at a price the firm may never have paid, throwing up a variance that must be written to Costing P&L. Simple average is an actual-price method in intent but, because it ignores quantities, it can *fail* the reconciliation — that failure is itself an examinable criticism.

Master rule of thumb (rising prices):

	Issue cost	Profit	Closing stock value
FIFO	Lowest	Highest	Highest
LIFO	Highest	Lowest	Lowest
Wtd Avg	Middle	Middle	Middle

(In **falling** prices, reverse FIFO and LIFO.) A guaranteed reconciliation check across any actual-price method: **Opening stock + Purchases = Issues (charged to production) + Closing stock**, in *both* value and quantity.

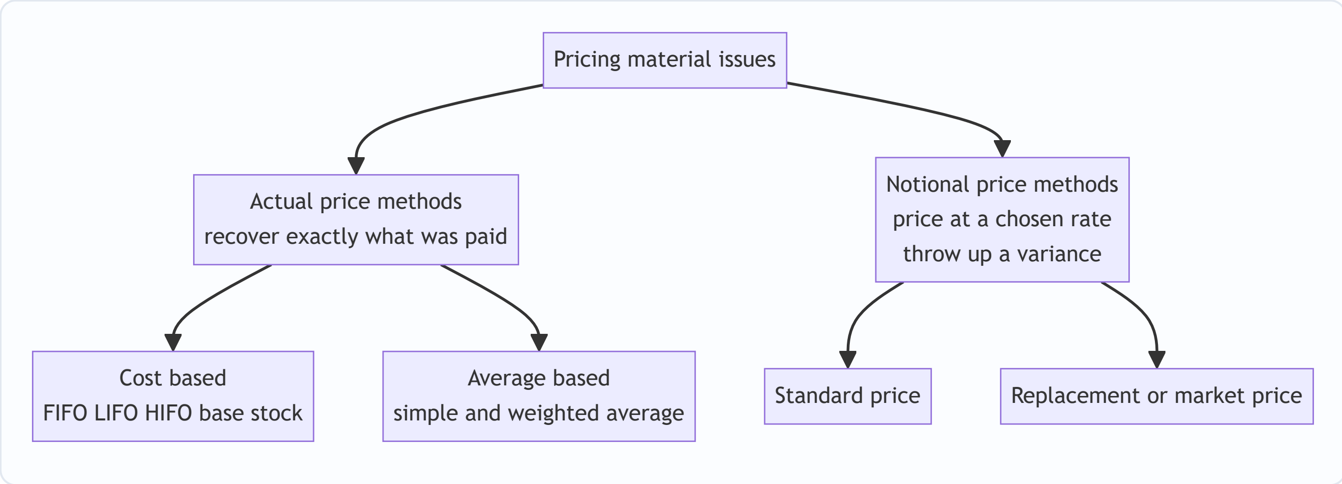


Figure 2 — Family tree of issue-pricing methods; the actual-versus-notional split decides whether a price variance appears.

4.4 Stock Losses — Wastage, Scrap, Spoilage, Defectives

Loss of material is inevitable; the costing question is always the same: **was it normal (inherent, unavoidable, expected) or abnormal (avoidable, exceptional, a signal something broke)?** The *treatment* depends entirely on that classification.

The **golden principle:**

> **Normal loss** is expected, so its cost is **absorbed by the good output** — the cost of the good units is inflated to carry the normal loss. **Abnormal loss** is not expected, so it is **charged to the Costing Profit & Loss Account** and kept *out* of product cost — otherwise a controllable failure would be hidden inside product cost and never investigated.

The four forms of loss:

Term	What it is	Realisable value?	Treatment
Waste	Portion with **no measurable recovery** — evaporation, smoke, shrinkage, dust; may even cost money to dispose.	Usually nil (may be negative disposal cost).	Normal waste: absorbed by good output (raises unit cost). Abnormal waste: cost to Costing P&L.
Scrap	Residue with a **small but definite sale value** — metal turnings, off-cuts, trimmings.	Yes, small.	Normal scrap sale value credited to overhead / job / material cost (reduces cost). Abnormal scrap sale credited to Costing P&L.
Spoilage	Units so damaged they **cannot be rectified** and are sold as seconds/junk.	Sold at low value.	Normal spoilage cost (net of recovery) borne by good output. Abnormal spoilage net cost to Costing P&L.
Defectives	Units that **can be rectified** by extra work and then sold as good.	Rectifiable.	Normal: rectification cost charged to good output/overhead. Abnormal: rectification cost to Costing P&L.

Computing the cost of an abnormal loss (the exam-favourite manoeuvre): first spread the *total* cost over *expected good output* (i.e. after removing normal loss) to get a **cost per good unit**, then value the abnormal-loss units at that rate, net of any scrap recovered. Fully worked in Example 5 below.

Why value abnormal loss at the "good unit" cost? Because the normal loss was always going to happen — it is a legitimate cost of producing good units. The abnormal loss is *extra* units lost that *should* have been good; they must be valued at what a good unit costs and written off, so management sees the true rupee bleed.

Abnormal GAIN — the mirror image (frequently paired with abnormal loss). Sometimes actual output *exceeds* expected good output — the process lost *less* than the normal allowance. That surplus is **abnormal gain**. Its treatment is the exact reverse of abnormal loss: - Value abnormal-gain units at the **same cost-per-good-unit** rate. - **Debit** the process/good output and **credit** the Costing P&L (abnormal gain is a *credit*, an income, in Costing P&L). - But there is a subtlety on scrap: because you produced *fewer* scrap/normal-loss units than expected, the scrap revenue you assumed for normal loss is *overstated*. So the abnormal gain credited to Costing P&L is reduced by the scrap value of the normal-loss units that did **not** actually arise. Worked in Example 7.

Why abnormal gain is a credit, not just "negative loss": the good output was valued at a rate that already loaded the *full* normal loss. When less loss actually occurred, good output has been slightly over-costed; the abnormal gain account corrects this by returning the excess to profit — while still keeping product cost at the honest "normal" rate.

4.5 ABC Analysis — Selective Control

You cannot lavish equal attention on every one of 10,000 stock items — controlling a ₹5 washer as tightly as a ₹5-lakh engine is a waste of managerial time. **ABC analysis** ("Always Better Control") applies the Pareto principle to inventory: a *small fraction of items accounts for a large fraction of value.*

Class	Typical share of items	Typical share of value	Control policy
A	~10%	~70%	Tight: low safety stock, frequent review, EOQ enforced, senior sign-off, perpetual records.
B	~20%	~20%	Moderate control, periodic review.
C	~70%	~10%	Loose: bulk orders, large safety stock, simple two-bin system, minimal paperwork.

Why bother? Managerial attention is itself a scarce, costly resource. ABC channels it where rupees are at stake. Note it classifies by **annual consumption value (quantity × unit price)**, *not* by unit price alone — a cheap item consumed in huge volumes can be a Class-A item.

How to actually *build* an ABC classification (an examinable procedure, not just a table): 1. For each item compute **annual consumption value = annual quantity × unit price**. 2. **Rank** items descending by that value. 3. Compute the **cumulative % of value** and **cumulative % of items**. 4. Draw the cut-offs: the top items contributing ~70% of value = A, the next ~20% = B, the rest = C. (Percentages are indicative, not rigid — the *shape* of the cumulative curve decides the cuts.)

Cousin techniques — name, basis, and the *situation* each fits:

Technique	Classifies by	Best when
VED	Criticality: Vital / Essential / Desirable	Spare parts — a cheap vital gasket can halt a plant, so criticality beats value
FSN	Movement: Fast / Slow / Non-moving	Detecting dead/obsolete stock; drives write-off and disposal decisions
HML	Unit price: High / Medium / Low	Deciding authorisation levels for purchase, regardless of consumption
SDE	Availability: Scarce / Difficult / Easy to obtain	Setting safety stock for hard-to-source imports
FNSD / GOLF / SOS	Various (movement, source, seasonality)	Situational; know that they exist

The examiner's favourite contrast: **ABC ignores criticality; VED captures it.** A Class-C (low value) item may be VED-Vital — so a *combined* ABC-VED matrix is used in practice for spares.

---

5. Worked Examples — Full Step-by-Step

Example 1 — EOQ, order frequency, and total cost (foundation)

Data. A factory consumes **12,000 units** of a raw material per year. Ordering cost is **₹150 per order**. The material costs **₹20 per unit**, and carrying cost is **20% of unit value per year**.

Required. (a) EOQ, (b) number of orders per year, (c) time between orders, (d) total ordering, carrying and inventory cost at EOQ.

Solution.

Step 1 — identify the primitives. - A = 12,000 units/yr ; O = ₹150/order. - C = 20% × ₹20 = **₹4 per unit per year.**

Step 2 — EOQ (set ordering = carrying, i.e. the formula).

EOQ = √(2 × A × O / C) = √(2 × 12,000 × 150 / 4) = √(3,600,000 / 4) = √900,000 = **√900000 = 948.68 ≈ 949 units.**

Let me keep it exact: 2 × 12,000 × 150 = 36,00,000; ÷ 4 = 9,00,000; √9,00,000 = **948.68 units** (≈ 949).

Step 3 — number of orders per year = A / EOQ = 12,000 / 948.68 = **12.65 orders** (≈ 13 orders).

Step 4 — time between orders = 365 / 12.65 = **28.9 days** (≈ every 29 days).

Step 5 — costs at EOQ. - Ordering cost = (A/EOQ) × O = 12.65 × 150 = **₹1,897.4** - Carrying cost = (EOQ/2) × C = (948.68/2) × 4 = 474.34 × 4 = **₹1,897.4** - **Self-check: the two are equal — the hallmark of a correct EOQ.** ✓ - Total inventory cost (excl. purchase price) = 1,897.4 + 1,897.4 = **₹3,794.8**

Interpretation. Ordering ~949 units about 13 times a year minimises the combined ordering-plus-carrying cost at roughly ₹3,795. Order much bigger and carrying cost balloons; much smaller and ordering cost balloons.

Example 2 — Proving EOQ is genuinely the minimum (a cost table)

Data. Same as Example 1 (A = 12,000, O = ₹150, C = ₹4). Let's tabulate total cost at several order sizes to *see* the U-shaped curve bottom out near EOQ.

Order Qty (Q)	No. of orders (A/Q)	Ordering cost = orders × 150 (₹)	Avg stock (Q/2)	Carrying cost = (Q/2)×4 (₹)	Total (₹)
400	30.0	4,500	200	800	**5,300**
600	20.0	3,000	300	1,200	**4,200**
800	15.0	2,250	400	1,600	**3,850**
949 (EOQ)	12.6	1,897	474	1,897	**3,794**
1,200	10.0	1,500	600	2,400	**3,900**
1,600	7.5	1,125	800	3,200	**4,325**

The total-cost column dips to its **minimum right at EOQ (~₹3,794)** and rises on either side — a live demonstration that EOQ is the trough of the U, not an arbitrary formula. Also note that only at Q = 949 do ordering and carrying costs coincide (₹1,897 each).

Read the flatness. Move from Q = 949 to Q = 1,200 (a 26% larger order) and total cost rises only from ₹3,794 to ₹3,900 — about **2.8%**. This is the *robustness* of EOQ mentioned in Section 3.1: being modestly off EOQ costs almost nothing, which is why real firms happily round EOQ to a convenient pack/truck size. The penalty for error is small *near* the trough and grows only as you move far away (Q = 400 costs 40% more).

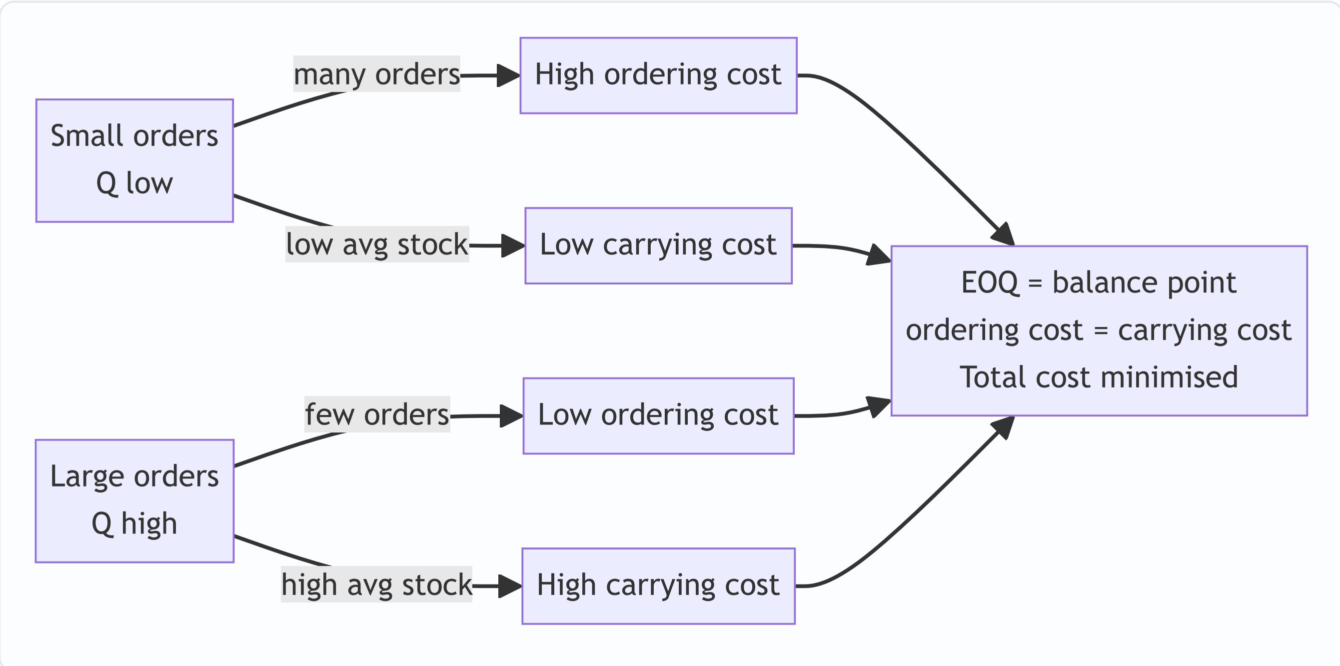


Figure 3 — The two-cost tug-of-war: EOQ sits exactly where the opposing pressures balance.

Example 3 — Full stock-level computation (exam-standard)

Data. For component "X": - Normal usage: **300 units/week**; Minimum usage: **200 units/week**; Maximum usage: **400 units/week**. - Re-order (delivery) period (lead time): **4 to 6 weeks**. - Re-order Quantity (EOQ):

2,400 units. - Emergency delivery time: **1 week**.

Required. Re-order level, Minimum level, Maximum level, Danger level, Average stock level.

Solution. Work strictly from the formulae in 4.1, plugging max/min correctly.

Step 1 — Re-order Level = Maximum usage × Maximum lead time = 400 × 6 = **2,400 units.**

Step 2 — Minimum Level = ROL − (Average usage × Average lead time) Average usage = 300 (given as "normal"); Average lead time = (4 + 6)/2 = 5 weeks. = 2,400 − (300 × 5) = 2,400 − 1,500 = **900 units.**

Step 3 — Maximum Level = ROL + ROQ − (Minimum usage × Minimum lead time) = 2,400 + 2,400 − (200 × 4) = 4,800 − 800 = **4,000 units.**

Step 4 — Danger Level = Average usage × Emergency lead time = 300 × 1 = **300 units.**

Step 5 — Average Stock = Minimum level + ½ ROQ = 900 + ½ × 2,400 = 900 + 1,200 = **2,100 units.** (Cross-check via ½(min + max) = ½(900 + 4,000) = 2,450 — the two formulas differ slightly because the "½ ROQ" version assumes stock swings between minimum and minimum+ROQ, while the max/min version uses the extreme peak; ICAI accepts the **Minimum + ½ ROQ = 2,100** form as the standard answer. State the formula you used.)

Interpretation & ordering of the lines (sanity check): Danger (300) < Minimum (900) < Re-order (2,400) < Maximum (4,000). This ordering must always hold — if your danger level exceeds your minimum, or reorder exceeds maximum, you've mis-plugged a max/min somewhere.

What if the examiner tweaks it? Two common twists: 1. "*Usage given per day, lead time in weeks.*" Convert to a common unit first (e.g. multiply daily usage by 7, or express lead time in days). Mixing days and weeks is the No. 1 levels error after the max/min mix-up. 2. "*Compute safety stock separately.*" Safety stock = Minimum level here = 900 (the buffer left when the lot lands on an average day). Equivalently Max·Max − Avg·Avg = 2,400 − 1,500 = 900. Both routes agree — a built-in check.

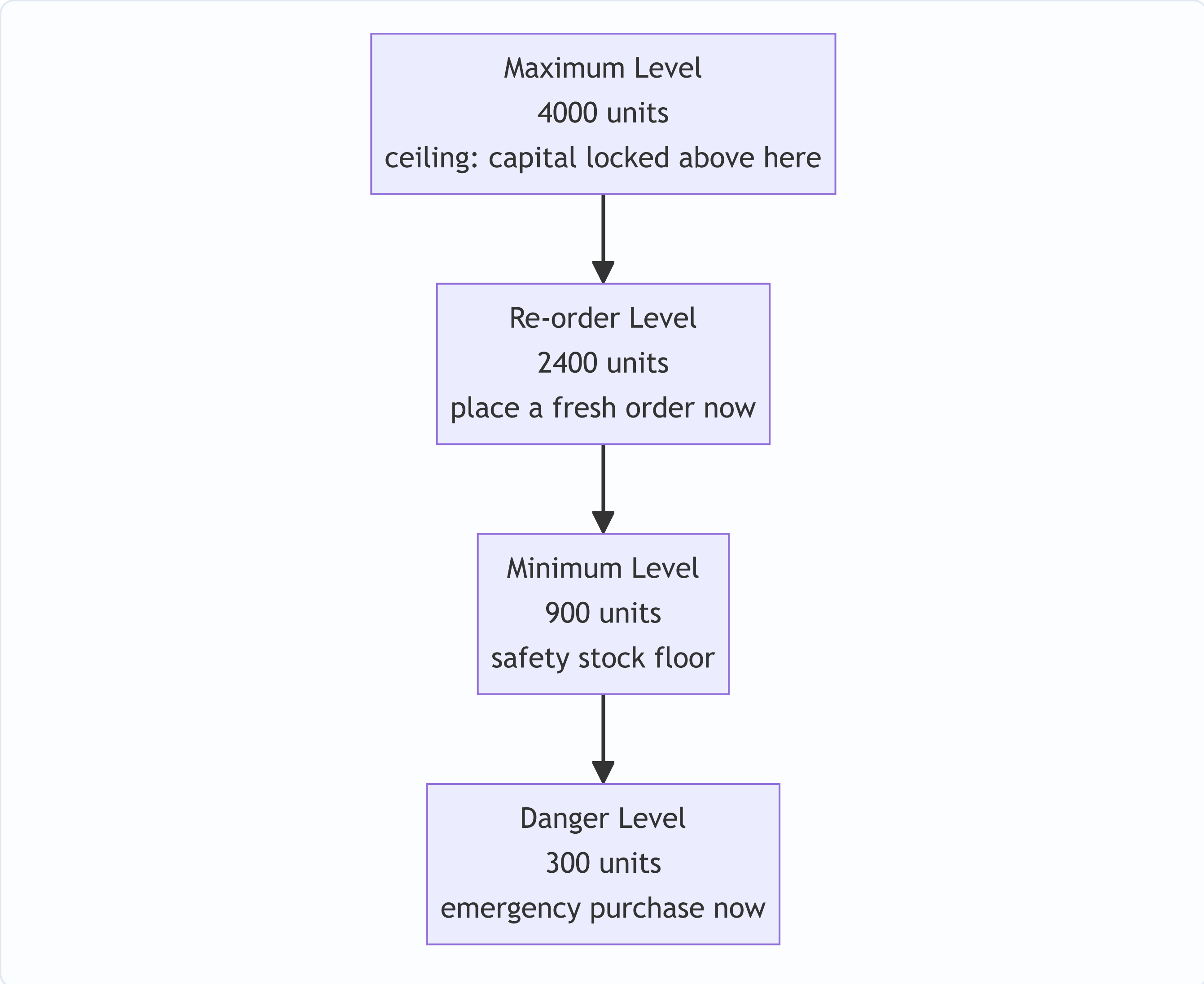


Figure 4 — Stock levels as marked lines on the bathtub, from ceiling down to the emergency red line.

Example 4 — Material issue valuation under FIFO, LIFO and Weighted Average (with profit effect)

Data. Transactions for material "M" during March:

Date	Transaction	Units	Rate ₹/unit
Mar 1	Opening balance	200	10
Mar 5	Purchase	300	12
Mar 10	Issue	400	—
Mar 18	Purchase	400	15
Mar 25	Issue	300	—

Required. Value the two issues and the closing stock under (a) FIFO, (b) LIFO, (c) Weighted Average, and comment on profit impact.

First, the physical reconciliation (identical across all methods): Opening 200 + Purchases (300 + 400) = 900 units in. Issues 400 + 300 = 700 out. **Closing = 900 − 700 = 200 units.** ✓ Total value in = 200×10 + 300×12 + 400×15 = 2,000 + 3,600 + 6,000 = **₹11,600.**

(a) FIFO — oldest issued first.

Date	Receipts	Issues	Balance
Mar 1	—	—	200 @ ₹10 = ₹2,000
Mar 5	300 @ ₹12 = ₹3,600	—	200 @ ₹10 ; 300 @ ₹12 (₹5,600)
Mar 10	—	**200 @ ₹10 + 200 @ ₹12 = 2,000 + 2,400 = ₹4,400**	100 @ ₹12 = ₹1,200
Mar 18	400 @ ₹15 = ₹6,000	—	100 @ ₹12 ; 400 @ ₹15 (₹7,200)
Mar 25	—	**100 @ ₹12 + 200 @ ₹15 = 1,200 + 3,000 = ₹4,200**	200 @ ₹15 = ₹3,000

- Total issues (to production) = 4,400 + 4,200 = **₹8,600.**
- **Closing stock = 200 @ ₹15 = ₹3,000** (newest prices).
- Check: 8,600 + 3,000 = 11,600 ✓

(b) LIFO — newest issued first.

Date	Receipts	Issues	Balance
Mar 1	—	—	200 @ ₹10 = ₹2,000
Mar 5	300 @ ₹12	—	200 @ ₹10 ; 300 @ ₹12 (₹5,600)
Mar 10	—	**300 @ ₹12 + 100 @ ₹10 = 3,600 + 1,000 = ₹4,600**	100 @ ₹10 = ₹1,000
Mar 18	400 @ ₹15	—	100 @ ₹10 ; 400 @ ₹15 (₹7,000)
Mar 25	—	**300 @ ₹15 = ₹4,500**	100 @ ₹10 ; 100 @ ₹15 = 1,000 + 1,500 = ₹2,500

- Total issues = 4,600 + 4,500 = **₹9,100.**
- **Closing stock = ₹2,500** (100 @ ₹10 + 100 @ ₹15).
- Check: 9,100 + 2,500 = 11,600 ✓

(c) Weighted Average — reblend after each receipt.

Date	Units	Value ₹	Balance units	Balance ₹	Wtd-avg rate ₹
Mar 1	+200	2,000	200	2,000	10.00
Mar 5	+300	3,600	500	5,600	**11.20** (5,600/500)
Mar 10	−400	−4,480	100	1,120	11.20
Mar 18	+400	6,000	500	7,120	**14.24** (7,120/500)
Mar 25	−300	−4,272	200	2,848	14.24

- Mar 10 issue = 400 × 11.20 = **₹4,480.** Mar 25 issue = 300 × 14.24 = **₹4,272.**
- Total issues = 4,480 + 4,272 = **₹8,752.**
- **Closing stock = 200 × 14.24 = ₹2,848.**
- Check: 8,752 + 2,848 = 11,600 ✓

Comparison & profit comment (prices are rising: 10 → 12 → 15):

Method	Total issue cost (charged to production)	Closing stock value	Relative profit
FIFO	₹8,600 (lowest)	₹3,000 (highest)	**Highest**
LIFO	₹9,100 (highest)	₹2,500 (lowest)	**Lowest**
Wtd Avg	₹8,752 (middle)	₹2,848 (middle)	**Middle**

Exactly as the master rule predicts: in rising prices FIFO charges the least to production (old cheap units) so it **shows the highest profit and the highest closing stock**, LIFO the opposite, weighted average in between. Same physical facts, three different profits — which is precisely why the choice is a *decision*, and why financial reporting (AS-2 / Ind AS-2) bans LIFO to prevent profit manipulation.

Examiner tweak — a return to stores. Suppose on Mar 27 production returns 50 units (originally issued Mar 25). Under **FIFO** the return is normally taken back into stock at the price of the *most recent issue it came from* (₹15 here) and sits as a fresh layer; under **weighted average** it re-enters at the current average rate (₹14.24), triggering a fresh reblend. Watch for the phrase "returned to stores" — it is a *receipt* for balance purposes but priced by a different rule than a purchase.

Example 5 — Normal vs Abnormal loss valuation (the treatment that separates the two)

Data. A process is charged with **1,000 kg** of material at **₹50/kg** (total material ₹50,000). Additional processing cost (labour + overhead) = **₹20,000**. **Normal loss is 10%** of input; such loss (scrap) sells for **₹8/kg**. Actual output was **870 kg**.

Required. Value the good output, the normal loss, and the abnormal loss; show the Costing P&L treatment.

Solution.

Step 1 — quantities. - Input = 1,000 kg. Normal loss = 10% × 1,000 = **100 kg.** - Expected (good) output = 1,000 − 100 = **900 kg.** - Actual output = 870 kg ⇒ **Abnormal loss = 900 − 870 = 30 kg.** (Total loss 130 kg = 100 normal + 30 abnormal.)

Step 2 — cost per good unit (the crucial step). Total cost put in = material 50,000 + processing 20,000 = **₹70,000.** From this, recover the scrap value of **normal** loss only: 100 kg × ₹8 = ₹800. Net cost to be spread over expected good output:

Cost per good kg = (Total cost − Normal-loss scrap value) ÷ Expected good output = (70,000 − 800) ÷ 900 = 69,200 ÷ 900 = **₹76.89 per kg.**

Why divide by 900, not 1,000? Because the 100 kg normal loss is expected and its cost is legitimately absorbed by the 900 good units. We deliberately load the normal loss onto good output — that's the golden principle in action.

Step 3 — value each stream at ₹76.89/kg. - **Good output:** 870 × 76.89 = **₹66,894** (this flows to the next process / finished goods). - **Abnormal loss:** 30 × 76.89 = **₹2,306.67**, gross.

Step 4 — Costing P&L treatment of abnormal loss. The 30 abnormal-loss kg can still be sold as scrap at ₹8/kg = ₹240 recovery. So: - Abnormal loss charged to **Costing Profit & Loss A/c** = 2,306.67 − 240 = **₹2,066.67 (net).** - Normal loss: **no cost** carried (its cost already absorbed by good output); only its ₹800 scrap sale is realised and credited against process cost as done in Step 2.

Reconciliation. Value out = good output 66,894 + abnormal loss (at cost) 2,306.67 + normal-loss scrap credited 800 = 70,000.67 ≈ **₹70,000** (rounding). ✓ The cost input is fully accounted for.

Interpretation. By ring-fencing the ₹2,067 abnormal loss into the Costing P&L instead of burying it in product cost, management is *forced* to see and investigate the extra 30 kg that vanished. Had we simply divided ₹70,000 by 870 actual kg, product cost would silently swell and the failure would never surface — the entire reason cost accounting insists on the normal/abnormal split.

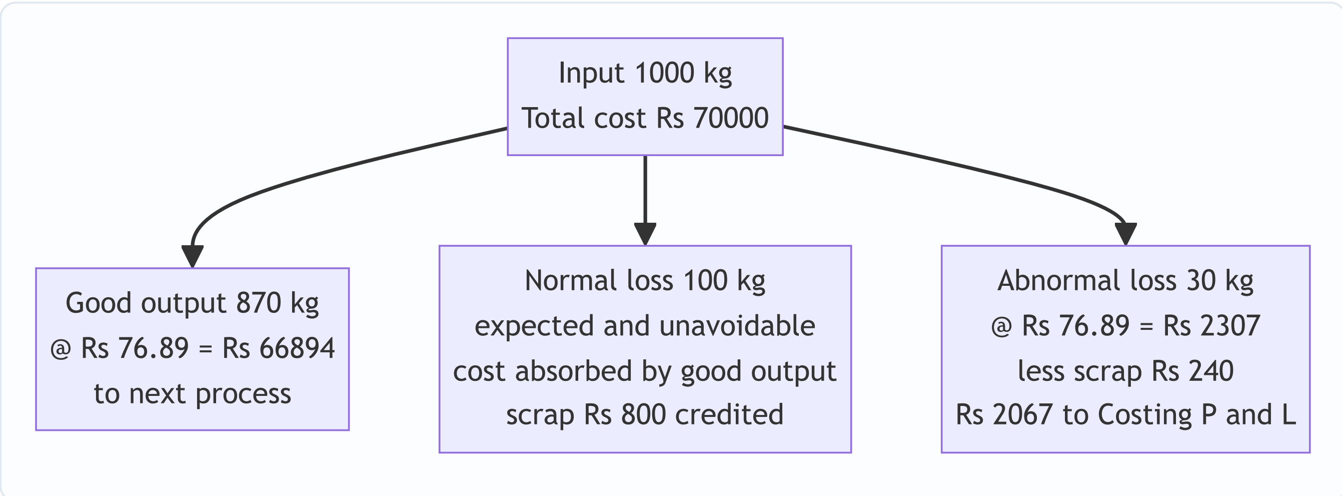


Figure 5 — Cost flow of a process: normal loss is absorbed by good output while abnormal loss is written off to Costing P&L for visibility.

Example 6 — EOQ with quantity discounts (the trap made explicit)

Data. Annual demand **A = 4,000 units.** Ordering cost **O = ₹100 per order.** Base price **₹50/unit.** Carrying cost is **10% of unit price per year.** The supplier offers: - 0–999 units per order: ₹50.00/unit - 1,000–1,999 units per order: ₹49.00/unit (2% off) - 2,000+ units per order: ₹48.50/unit (3% off)

Required. Determine the order size that minimises **total annual cost (purchase + ordering + carrying).**

Solution. Because C depends on price, recompute it at each slab.

Step 1 — plain EOQ at base price. C = 10% × 50 = ₹5. EOQ = √(2 × 4,000 × 100 / 5) = √(800,000 / 5) = √160,000 = **400 units.** This falls in the ₹50 slab, so 400 is the best point *within* that slab.

Step 2 — evaluate total annual cost at the three candidate quantities: the EOQ (400 @ ₹50), and the lowest qualifying quantity of each discount slab (1,000 @ ₹49; 2,000 @ ₹48.50). (Within a discount slab total cost rises with Q, so the slab's smallest qualifying quantity is its cheapest point.)

	Q = 400 @ ₹50	Q = 1,000 @ ₹49	Q = 2,000 @ ₹48.50
Purchase = A × price	4,000×50 = 2,00,000	4,000×49 = 1,96,000	4,000×48.50 = 1,94,000
Ordering = (A/Q)×100	(10)×100 = 1,000	(4)×100 = 400	(2)×100 = 200
Carrying = (Q/2)×(10%×price)	200×5 = 1,000	500×4.90 = 2,450	1,000×4.85 = 4,850
Total annual cost (₹)	**2,02,000**	**1,98,850**	**1,99,050**

Step 3 — decide. Lowest total = **₹1,98,850 at Q = 1,000 units @ ₹49.** So the firm should **abandon the plain EOQ (400) and order 1,000 units** to capture the 2% discount — the purchase-price saving (₹4,000) outweighs the extra carrying cost.

The lesson. Plain EOQ ignored purchase price because it assumed price was constant. Once price varies with lot size, you *must* fold purchase cost into the comparison. Note also that the deepest discount (2,000 @ ₹48.50) is **not** best — its carrying cost (₹4,850) eats the extra price saving. Never assume "biggest discount wins."

Example 7 — Abnormal gain (the mirror of Example 5)

Data. Same process as Example 5: input **1,000 kg** at ₹50, processing **₹20,000**, normal loss **10%** with scrap value **₹8/kg**. But this time actual output was **920 kg** (the process performed *better* than expected).

Required. Compute abnormal gain and its Costing P&L treatment.

Solution.

Step 1 — quantities. Expected good output = 900 kg (as before). Actual = 920 kg ⇒ **Abnormal gain = 920 − 900 = 20 kg.** Actual loss = 1,000 − 920 = 80 kg (less than the 100 kg normal allowance).

Step 2 — cost per good unit (unchanged rate). We still spread cost over **expected** good output of 900 kg, exactly as before: (70,000 − 800) ÷ 900 = **₹76.89/kg.** Keeping the rate at the *normal* basis is the whole point — good output stays honestly costed.

Step 3 — value abnormal gain. 20 kg × ₹76.89 = **₹1,537.78**, credited to the process (debited to the Abnormal Gain account, then to Costing P&L as income).

Step 4 — scrap adjustment (the subtlety). We assumed scrap on 100 kg of normal loss (₹800), but only 80 kg of loss actually occurred, so scrap on 20 kg (the "missing" loss) = 20 × ₹8 = **₹160** was over-credited to the process. This ₹160 must be *debited* to the Abnormal Gain account (it reduces the net gain, because that scrap income never materialised).

Step 5 — net abnormal gain to Costing P&L. = Value of abnormal gain − scrap value forgone = 1,537.78 − 160 = **₹1,377.78 (credit / income) in Costing P&L.**

Interpretation. Abnormal gain is genuinely good news (less waste), so it lands as *income* in Costing P&L — but only after clawing back the scrap revenue we had optimistically assumed on loss that never happened.

This scrap clawback is the single most-missed step; the examiner plants it deliberately.

Example 8 — Inventory turnover ratio and slow-moving stock

Data. For three materials over a year:

Material	Opening stock ₹	Closing stock ₹	Material consumed ₹
P	20,000	30,000	2,00,000
Q	40,000	60,000	1,00,000
R	15,000	25,000	2,20,000

Required. Inventory turnover ratio and average holding period for each; identify the slow-moving item.

Solution.

> **Inventory Turnover Ratio = Cost of material consumed ÷ Average stock**, where Average stock = ½(Opening + Closing). **Average holding period (days) = 365 ÷ Turnover ratio.**

Material	Avg stock ₹	Turnover = consumed ÷ avg	Holding period = 365 ÷ turnover
P	25,000	2,00,000 / 25,000 = **8.0×**	365 / 8 = **45.6 days**
Q	50,000	1,00,000 / 50,000 = **2.0×**	365 / 2 = **182.5 days**
R	20,000	2,20,000 / 20,000 = **11.0×**	365 / 11 = **33.2 days**

Interpretation. A **high** turnover means stock is used up quickly (capital not locked, fresh stock, good). A **low** turnover means stock sits long — capital tied, risk of obsolescence. Here **Material Q turns only twice a year (183 days on the shelf)** — it is the **slow-moving** item that warrants investigation: over-ordering? falling demand? obsolete design? Material R, turning 11 times, is the healthiest.

Why it matters: turnover ratio is the diagnostic that feeds **FSN analysis** (Fast/Slow/Non-moving) and flags candidates for write-down. A ratio *trending down* year over year is an early warning of dead stock long before it becomes an outright write-off.

---

6. Presentation & Format — How to Lay It Out in the Exam

Stores Ledger Control (perpetual inventory) format. Whenever asked to value issues, present a three-block ledger — *Receipts* | *Issues* | *Balance* — each block showing Quantity, Rate, Amount. This is the format used in Example 4 and it is what earns method marks even if an arithmetic slip occurs.

Date	Particulars	Receipts (Qty · Rate · Amt)	Issues (Qty · Rate · Amt)	Balance (Qty · Rate · Amt)

Levels answer. Present each level as *Formula → substitution → answer*, then a one-line sanity ordering (Danger < Min < ROL < Max). Always state which usage/lead-time (max/min/avg) you used and why.

EOQ answer. State A, O, C explicitly (converting % carrying to ₹ per unit), give the formula, substitute, then the self-check "ordering cost = carrying cost". For **discount** problems, always present the *total annual cost* comparison table (purchase + ordering + carrying) — the marks are for the comparison, not the EOQ alone.

Loss problems. Show the quantity reconciliation first (input = good output + normal loss + abnormal loss), then the cost-per-good-unit computation, then value each stream, then the P&L line. End with the value reconciliation. For **abnormal gain**, remember the scrap clawback line.

Cost of material purchased. When asked to compute the rate at which material enters stores, show a build-up: *invoice price − trade discount − creditable GST + carriage inward + insurance + other charges ÷ net quantity received.* State explicitly that cash discount is excluded.

Rounding convention. EOQ and level answers are usually rounded up to whole units (you cannot order a fraction). Keep two decimals in rates until the final line to avoid compounding rounding error.

---

7. Connections — Where This Plugs Into the Rest of Costing

- **Cost Sheet (Ch. 06):** the *value of materials consumed* you compute here (Opening stock + Purchases + carriage inward − Closing stock − returns) is the very first line of the cost sheet — **Direct Material** feeding into Prime Cost. Material valuation choice therefore ripples into prime cost, works cost and profit.
- **Process Costing:** the normal/abnormal loss machinery of Section 4.4/Examples 5 & 7 is used *identically* in process costing, where abnormal loss and **abnormal gain** get their own ledger accounts. Master it here and process costing's loss accounting is free.
- **Overheads:** carrying cost, ordering cost and stores-department costs are themselves overheads; scrap recoveries are credited to overhead. Material control feeds overhead absorption.
- **Standard Costing:** the *standard price* method of issue valuation (Section 4.3) throws up a **material price variance**; the standard usage links to the **material usage variance**. This chapter's issue-pricing choice is the seedbed of variance analysis.
- **Marginal Costing / Decision-making:** EOQ is a mini optimisation — the same "minimise total of two opposing costs" logic reappears in make-or-buy and other decisions.
- **Working Capital (Financial Management):** average stock level, inventory turnover ratio and stock-holding period directly set the inventory component of the working-capital cycle. The bathtub you controlled here *is* the FM inventory conversion period.

---

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Carrying cost given as a %.** If told "carrying cost is 10% of *average inventory value*" or "10% p.a.", you must convert to **₹ per unit per year = % × unit price** before using it as C in EOQ. Forgetting this is the No. 1 EOQ error.
2. **Ordering cost per order vs per annum.** O in EOQ is cost *per order*. If a total annual purchasing-department cost is given, do **not** plug it in raw — divide out or use only the per-order component.
3. **Max × Max vs Avg × Avg.** Re-order level uses **maximum** usage × **maximum** lead time; minimum level subtracts **average × average**; maximum level subtracts **minimum × minimum**. Mixing these up is the classic levels blunder. Memorise via logic (worst case for stock-out → maximums; best case for pile-up → minimums), not rote.
4. **Quantity discounts.** If the supplier offers a lower price for larger lots, EOQ is **not** automatically the answer. Compute total cost (purchase + ordering + carrying) at EOQ *and* at each discount break-point

and pick the lowest — and remember the deepest discount need not win (Example 6).

5. **Dividing total cost by *actual* output in loss problems.** Cost per good unit must use **expected** good output (input − normal loss), *not* actual output. Using actual output wrongly buries abnormal loss in product cost.
6. **Scrap value of normal vs abnormal loss.** Normal-loss scrap reduces the cost spread over good units (credited in the cost-per-unit step). Abnormal-loss scrap is netted against the abnormal loss taken to Costing P&L. In **abnormal gain**, claw back the scrap on the normal loss that *didn't* occur. Don't double-count or mis-route them.
7. **Weighted average must be *re-computed after every receipt***, not once at the end (that would be "periodic weighted average," a different method). Also, an *issue* does **not** change the rate — only a receipt does.
8. **FIFO vs LIFO profit direction depends on price trend.** The "FIFO = higher profit" rule holds only in **rising** prices; reverse it if the question has falling prices. Read the price sequence before quoting the rule.
9. **ABC by value, not unit price.** A ₹2 item consumed 5,00,000 times a year is Class A. Classify by **annual consumption value**, never by sticker price alone. And ABC ignores criticality — a vital cheap spare needs VED, not ABC.
10. **Danger level formula variants.** Standard ICAI: Average usage × emergency lead time. Some problems specify "reorder period for emergency purchase" — use that as the lead time. If the question hands you a different definition, follow the question.
11. **Cash discount inside material cost.** Cash discount is a *financial* item and is **excluded** from material cost; only trade discount is deducted. Creditable GST is excluded; non-creditable GST is added. Carriage inward is added. Getting this build-up wrong corrupts the very first cost-sheet line.
12. **Units mismatch in EOQ / levels.** Annual demand with per-unit-*per-year* carrying cost; usage and lead time on the same time basis. The √ (EOQ) and the multiplication (levels) both hide a units error, so it survives to the final answer undetected. Check units *before* substituting.
13. **Bin card vs stores ledger.** Bin card = quantity only, kept by storekeeper; stores ledger = quantity and value, kept in costing. A question asking "which record shows value?" wants *stores ledger*. Don't swap them.
14. **Simple average pitfall.** Simple average of *rates* ignores quantities and can break the Opening + Purchases = Issues + Closing reconciliation — if a question quietly uses it, note the theoretical objection for extra marks.

---

9. First-Principles Recap

Strip everything back and material costing rests on five irreducible ideas:

1. **Material is the biggest, leakiest cost**, so it earns the most control machinery — a *chain of custody* with a document at every link (requisition → PO → GRN → bin card / stores ledger → requisition note). Control means keeping stock in a safe band (the bathtub) and pricing what leaves the godown honestly.
2. **How much to order** is a tug-of-war between ordering cost (falls with big lots) and carrying cost (rises with big lots). Their balance point is EOQ — rebuildable any time by setting the two costs equal. When price varies with lot size, fold purchase cost in and compare total annual cost.
3. **When to order and how far stock may swing** is a safety-buffer problem driven by uncertain usage and uncertain lead time. Re-order/min/max/danger levels are pre-computed lines: worst case (maximums)

protects against stock-out, best case (minimums) bounds the pile-up. The system pushes daily control to the storekeeper and reserves judgement for management.

4. **Pricing issues and treating losses** are about *not lying* to management. Issue-valuation assumptions (FIFO/LIFO/WA and the notional-price methods) change profit, so choose deliberately. Losses are split normal (absorbed by good output — it was always going to happen) vs abnormal (written off to Costing P&L — so failure is visible); abnormal *gain* is the mirror income.
5. **Attention is scarce**, so control is *selective* — ABC by rupee value, VED by criticality, FSN by movement, HML by price. Turnover ratio is the diagnostic that tells you whether stock is working or rotting.

If you can regenerate every formula in this chapter from these five ideas, you never have to memorise a single one.

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

Procurement documents

Document	Records	Kept by
Purchase Requisition	Authorised need	Stores/Dept
Purchase Order	Commitment to supplier	Purchasing
Goods Received Note	Arrival + inspection	Receiving
Bin Card	Quantity only	Storekeeper
Stores Ledger	Quantity + **value**	Costing office
Material Requisition Note	Authorised issue	Production → Stores

Cost of material purchased

> Invoice price − trade discount − creditable GST + carriage inward + insurance in transit + other charges (non-creditable duty, commission). **Cash discount excluded** (financial item).

Inventory Levels

Item	Formula
Re-order Level (ROL)	Maximum usage × Maximum lead time
ROL (alt)	Safety stock + (Avg usage × Avg lead time)
Minimum Level	ROL − (Average usage × Average lead time)
Maximum Level	ROL + ROQ − (Minimum usage × Minimum lead time)
Danger Level	Average usage × Emergency lead time
Average Stock	Minimum level + ½ ROQ = ½ (Min + Max)
Safety stock	Max·Max − Avg·Avg (lead-time + usage buffer)

EOQ block

Item	Formula
EOQ	√(2 × A × O / C)
A	Annual demand (units)
O	Ordering cost per order (₹)
C	Carrying cost per unit per year = carrying % × unit price
No. of orders/yr	A ÷ EOQ
Time between orders	365 ÷ (A/EOQ) days
Ordering cost	(A/EOQ) × O
Carrying cost	(EOQ/2) × C
Check at EOQ	Ordering cost = Carrying cost
Total inventory cost	(A/EOQ)×O + (EOQ/2)×C
With discounts	Minimise (A×price) + ordering + carrying across slabs

Issue valuation (rising prices)

Method	Issue cost	Profit	Closing stock
FIFO	Lowest	Highest	Highest
LIFO	Highest	Lowest	Lowest
Wtd Avg	Middle	Middle	Middle
Wtd-avg rate	Value on hand ÷ Units on hand (recompute after each receipt)		
Notional methods	Standard / replacement price → throw up a variance		
Universal check	Opening + Purchases = Issues + Closing (qty & value)		

Losses

Type	Recovery	Treatment
Waste	Nil / negative	Normal → absorbed by good output; Abnormal → Costing P&L
Scrap	Small sale value	Normal scrap credited to cost/overhead; Abnormal scrap → Costing P&L
Spoilage	Low (sold as seconds)	Normal net cost → good output; Abnormal net → Costing P&L
Defectives	Rectifiable	Normal rectification → good output/OH; Abnormal → Costing P&L
Abnormal loss value	= (Total cost − normal-loss scrap) ÷ **expected good output** × abnormal units, less its own scrap	
Abnormal gain value	= same rate × gain units, **less** scrap on normal loss that did not occur → credit Costing P&L	

ABC & cousins

Class	~% items	~% value	Control
A	10%	70%	Tight, low safety stock, frequent review
B	20%	20%	Moderate
C	70%	10%	Loose, bulk buy, high safety stock

Classify by annual consumption value (qty × price), not unit price. Cousins: VED (criticality), FSN (movement), HML (unit price), SDE (availability).

Inventory turnover

> Turnover = Cost of material consumed ÷ Average stock ; Holding days = 365 ÷ turnover. Low/falling turnover ⇒ slow-moving/obsolete stock — investigate. High turnover ⇒ capital working hard.

Q&A — Material Cost

Exam-oriented question bank for CA Intermediate, Cost & Management Accounting — Chapter: **Material Cost**. Every question is followed immediately by a complete model answer. All figures in **Rupees (Rs.)** and formulas follow ICAI conventions.

SECTION A — Concept-Check (Short Answer)

A1. Why is material control considered the most critical area of cost control? Material is usually the **largest single element of cost** (often 40–70% of total cost) and is the most **leak-prone** — losses arise from over-purchasing, pilferage, obsolescence, wastage and blocked working capital. A small percentage saving on material yields a large absolute saving, so control here gives the highest return.

A2. State the "two-cost tug-of-war" behind inventory decisions. Every stocking decision balances **Ordering/Carrying cost trade-off**: ordering in large quantities reduces **ordering cost** (fewer orders) but raises **carrying cost** (more average stock held); ordering small quantities does the reverse. EOQ is the quantity where these two opposing costs are **equal and total cost is minimum**.

A3. Define Re-order Level, Minimum Level, Maximum Level and Danger Level. - **Re-order Level (ROL)** = Maximum consumption × Maximum re-order period. Level at which a fresh order is placed. - **Minimum Level** = ROL − (Normal consumption × Normal re-order period). Buffer stock. - **Maximum Level** = ROL + ROQ − (Minimum consumption × Minimum re-order period). - **Danger Level** = Normal consumption × Maximum re-order period for emergency purchase (below which normal issue stops).

A4. Distinguish FIFO and LIFO in a period of rising prices. Under **FIFO**, issues are priced at **older (lower)** costs → lower charge to production, **higher closing stock**, higher profit. Under **LIFO**, issues are priced at **latest (higher)** costs → higher charge, **lower closing stock**, lower profit. LIFO is **not permitted** under AS-2 / Ind AS-2 for financial reporting.

A5. Distinguish normal loss from abnormal loss and their cost treatment. - **Normal loss**: unavoidable, inherent (evaporation, breakage in handling). Cost is **absorbed by good units** — the good units bear the full cost, raising per-unit cost. No separate account charge. - **Abnormal loss**: avoidable, due to negligence/accident. Valued at normal cost and **transferred to Costing P&L** (charged against profit), not to production cost.

A6. What do ABC, VED, FSN and HML analyses classify? - **ABC**: by **value** of consumption (A = high value/few items, tight control; C = low value/many items, loose control). - **VED**: by **criticality** (Vital, Essential, Desirable) — used for spare parts. - **FSN**: by **usage frequency** (Fast, Slow, Non-moving). - **HML**: by **unit price** (High, Medium, Low).

A7. What is the EOQ formula and its assumptions? EOQ = $\sqrt{(2AO / C)}$, where A = annual demand, O = cost per order, C = carrying cost per unit p.a. Assumptions: constant demand, constant price (no discount), instant replenishment, and known/fixed ordering & carrying costs.

SECTION B — Graded Computational Problems

B1 (Easy) — EOQ and number of orders

Q. Annual demand 12,000 units; ordering cost Rs. 60 per order; purchase price Rs. 20/unit; carrying cost 10% of unit price per annum. Find EOQ, number of orders and total ordering + carrying cost at EOQ.

Solution. Carrying cost C = 10% × Rs. 20 = **Rs. 2 per unit p.a.** EOQ = √(2 × 12,000 × 60 / 2) = √(14,40,000 / 2) = √7,20,000 = **848.53 ≈ 849 units.** Number of orders = 12,000 / 848.53 = **14.14 ≈ 14 orders**. Ordering cost = (12,000/848.53) × 60 = **Rs. 848.53** Carrying cost = (848.53/2) × 2 = **Rs. 848.53 Total relevant cost = Rs. 1,697** (ordering = carrying, confirming EOQ point).

B2 (Easy–Medium) — Cost-table proof of EOQ

Q. For B1 data, prepare a cost table for order sizes 600, 848, 1,200, 2,000 to prove EOQ minimises total cost.

Solution.

Order size (Q)	No. of orders (A/Q)	Ordering cost (A/Q × 60)	Avg stock (Q/2)	Carrying cost (Q/2 × 2)	Total (Rs.)
600	20.0	1,200	300	600	**1,800**
848	14.15	849	424	848	**1,697**
1,200	10.0	600	600	1,200	**1,800**
2,000	6.0	360	1,000	2,000	**2,360**

Total cost is **lowest (Rs. 1,697) at Q ≈ 848 units** = EOQ. Proven.

B3 (Medium) — Stock levels

Q. Normal usage 300 units/week; minimum usage 200; maximum usage 400. Re-order period 4–6 weeks. Re-order quantity (EOQ) 2,400 units. Compute ROL, Minimum, Maximum and Average stock level.

Solution. - **ROL** = Max usage × Max re-order period = 400 × 6 = **2,400 units** - **Minimum Level** = ROL − (Normal usage × Normal period) = 2,400 − (300 × 5) = 2,400 − 1,500 = **900 units** (Normal period = (4+6)/2 = 5 weeks) - **Maximum Level** = ROL + ROQ − (Min usage × Min period) = 2,400 + 2,400 − (200 × 4) = 4,800 − 800 = **4,000 units** - **Average Stock** = Min Level + ½ ROQ = 900 + 1,200 = **2,100 units** (or (Min + Max)/2 = (900 + 4,000)/2 = 2,450 units — either accepted; ICAI prefers Min + ½ ROQ)

B4 (Medium–Hard) — Stores Ledger under FIFO and Weighted Average

Q. Prepare stores ledger (FIFO) and value closing stock under both FIFO and Weighted Average. Jan 1 Opening 200 units @ Rs. 10; Jan 5 Received 300 @ Rs. 12; Jan 10 Issued 350; Jan 15 Received 400 @ Rs. 13; Jan 20 Issued 300.

Solution — FIFO Stores Ledger.

Date	Receipts	Issues	Balance
Jan 1	—	—	200 @ 10 = 2,000
Jan 5	300 @ 12 = 3,600	—	200 @ 10; 300 @ 12 (5,600)
Jan 10	—	200 @10=2,000; 150 @12=1,800 → **3,800**	150 @ 12 = 1,800
Jan 15	400 @ 13 = 5,200	—	150 @ 12; 400 @ 13 (7,000)
Jan 20	—	150 @12=1,800; 150 @13=1,950 → **3,750**	250 @ 13 = **3,250**

FIFO closing stock = 250 units × Rs. 13 = Rs. 3,250.

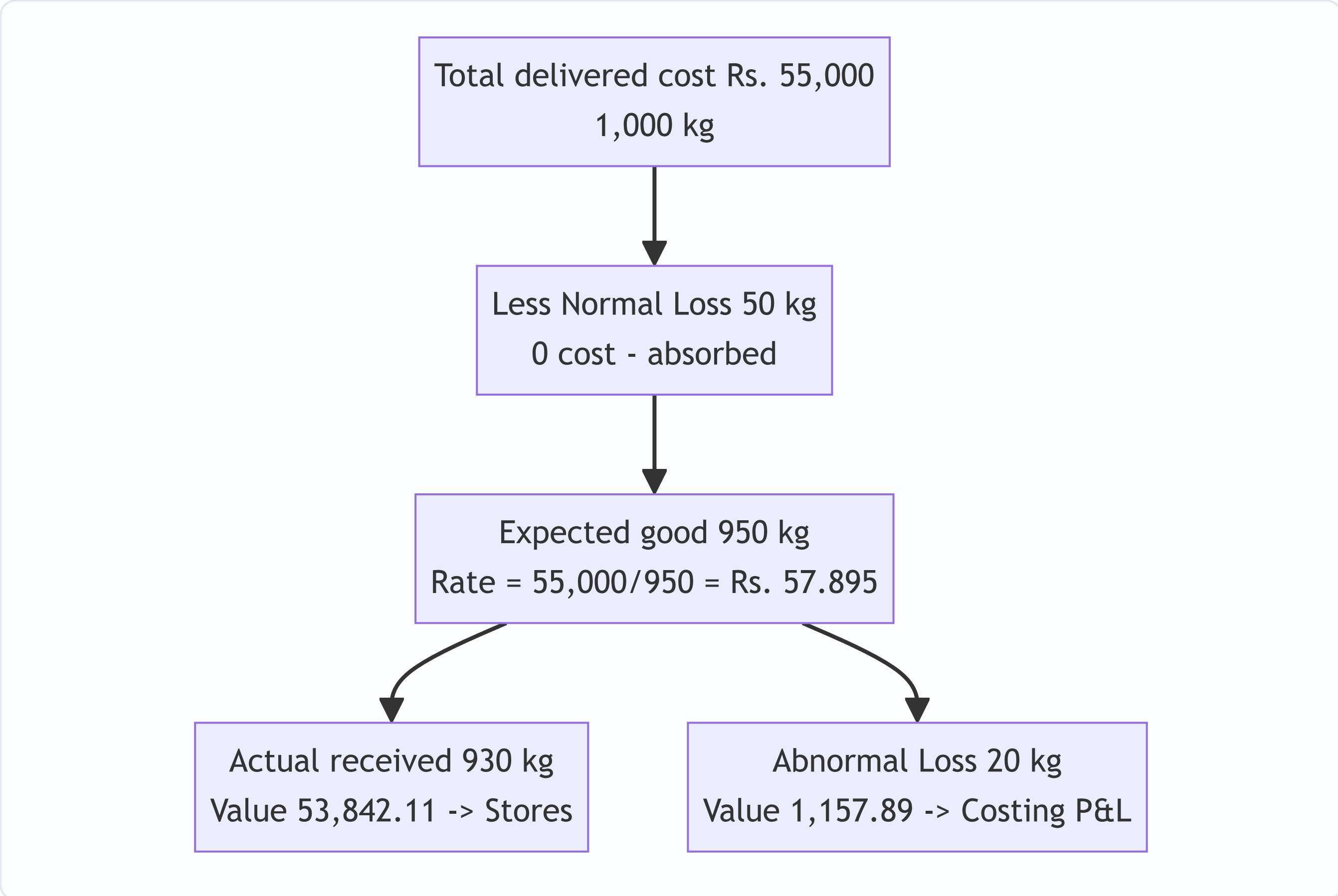
Weighted Average check (recompute rate after each receipt): - After Jan 5: (2,000+3,600)/500 = Rs. 11.20/unit. Issue Jan 10: 350 × 11.20 = 3,920. Balance 150 × 11.20 = 1,680. - After Jan 15: (1,680+5,200)/550 = Rs. 12.51/unit. Issue Jan 20: 300 × 12.51 = 3,753. Balance 250 × 12.51 = **Rs. 3,127.50.**

Reconciliation of total material accounted: Opening 2,000 + Receipts 8,800 = **Rs. 10,800**. - FIFO: Issues 3,800 + 3,750 = 7,550; + Closing 3,250 = **Rs. 10,800.** ✓ - WA: Issues 3,920 + 3,753 = 7,673; + Closing 3,127.50 = Rs. 10,800.50 (Re 0.50 rounding). ✓

B5 (Exam-Hard) — Normal and Abnormal Loss valuation

Q. 1,000 kg of material purchased at Rs. 50/kg. Freight Rs. 4,000; loading Rs. 1,000. Normal loss in transit is 5% of quantity. Actual material received = 930 kg. Compute the cost per kg of good material received and the abnormal loss to be charged to Costing P&L.

Solution. Total cost of purchase = (1,000 × 50) + 4,000 + 1,000 = 50,000 + 5,000 = **Rs. 55,000.** Normal loss = 5% × 1,000 = 50 kg → **expected good units = 950 kg.** Cost absorbed by good units (normal loss cost spread) → cost per good kg = 55,000 / 950 = **Rs. 57.895/kg.** Actual received = 930 kg → **Abnormal loss = 950 − 930 = 20 kg.** Abnormal loss value = 20 × 57.895 = **Rs. 1,157.89** → **transferred to Costing P&L.** Value of good material to stores = 930 × 57.895 = **Rs. 53,842.11. Check:** 53,842.11 + 1,157.89 = Rs. 55,000. ✓ (normal loss 50 kg carries no cost — absorbed).



SECTION C — Past-Paper-Style Full Questions

C1. Comprehensive EOQ with quantity discount

Q. A firm uses 90,000 units p.a. Ordering cost Rs. 100/order. Price Rs. 50/unit; carrying cost 12% p.a. Supplier offers 2% discount if order size ≥ 6,000 units. Advise whether to accept the discount.

Model Answer. Carrying cost C = 12% × 50 = Rs. 6/unit p.a. EOQ = √(2 × 90,000 × 100 / 6) = √30,00,000 = **1,732 units.**

Without discount (at EOQ 1,732): - Purchase = 90,000 × 50 = 45,00,000 - Ordering = (90,000/1,732) × 100 = 5,196 - Carrying = (1,732/2) × 6 = 5,196 - **Total = Rs. 45,10,392**

With 2% discount (order 6,000, price Rs. 49): - Purchase = 90,000 × 49 = 44,10,000 - Ordering = (90,000/6,000) × 100 = 1,500 - Carrying = (6,000/2) × (12% × 49) = 3,000 × 5.88 = 17,640 - **Total = Rs. 44,29,140**

Advice: Accepting the discount saves Rs. 45,10,392 − 44,29,140 = **Rs. 81,252 p.a.** → **Accept the discount** despite higher carrying cost, because the purchase-price saving dominates.

C2. Stores ledger under LIFO with pricing effect

Q. From B4 data, value the two issues under **LIFO** and comment on the profit effect versus FIFO.

Model Answer. - Jan 10 issue 350: 300 @ 12 = 3,600 + 50 @ 10 = 500 → **Rs. 4,100.** Balance 150 @ 10 = 1,500. - Jan 15 receipt 400 @ 13. Jan 20 issue 300: 300 @ 13 = **Rs. 3,900.** Balance 150 @ 10 + 100 @ 13 = 1,500 + 1,300 = **Rs. 2,800.**

LIFO total issues = 4,100 + 3,900 = Rs. 8,000; closing = Rs. 2,800. Check: 8,000 + 2,800 = Rs. 10,800. ✓ **Comment:** In rising prices LIFO charges more to production (8,000 vs FIFO 7,550) and shows lower closing stock (2,800 vs 3,250), hence **lower reported profit**. LIFO is disallowed under AS-2.

C3. Loss treatment full question

Q. Explain the accounting treatment of (a) waste, (b) scrap, (c) spoilage and (d) defectives in cost accounts.

Model Answer. - **Waste**: portion with no recoverable value. Normal waste cost absorbed by good output; abnormal waste charged to Costing P&L. - **Scrap**: residue with small recoverable value. Sale value credited to overhead (if minor), to the job/process (if identifiable), or to Costing P&L (if abnormal). Net scrap reduces material cost. - **Spoilage**: goods so damaged they cannot be rectified economically. Normal spoilage cost less salvage borne by good units; abnormal spoilage → Costing P&L. - **Defectives**: can be rectified with extra cost. Rectification cost of normal defectives is charged to the job/overhead; abnormal to Costing P&L.

SECTION D — MCQs & Case Scenarios

D1. EOQ increases when: (a) ordering cost falls (b) carrying cost rises (c) annual demand rises (d) price rises. **Answer: (c).** EOQ ∝ √A; higher demand raises EOQ (ordering-cost fall lowers it, carrying-cost rise lowers it).

D2. Under rising prices, which method gives the highest closing stock value? (a) LIFO (b) FIFO (c) Simple average (d) Weighted average. **Answer: (b) FIFO.** Closing stock is valued at the latest (highest) prices.

D3. Re-order level = 2,000; ROQ = 1,800; min usage 100/day; min lead time 4 days. Maximum level = (a) 3,400 (b) 3,800 (c) 3,000 (d) 2,600. **Answer: (a) 3,400.** = 2,000 + 1,800 − (100 × 4) = 3,400.

D4. Abnormal loss is: (a) added to good units' cost (b) ignored (c) charged to Costing P&L (d) credited to stores. **Answer: (c).** Abnormal loss is valued at normal cost and charged to Costing P&L to keep product cost undistorted.

D5. In ABC analysis, 'A' items are: (a) high in number, low in value (b) low in number, high in value (c) fast-moving (d) vital spares. **Answer: (b).** A-items are few (approx 10%) but represent the bulk (approx 70%) of value → tightest control.

D6. Danger level is computed as: (a) Normal usage × Max lead time (b) Max usage × Max lead time (c) Normal usage × Normal lead time (d) Min usage × Min lead time. **Answer: (a).** Danger level = normal consumption × maximum re-order period for emergency purchase.

D7 (Case). A store's C-class items are 60% of item count but only 8% of value, yet the manager applies daily physical counts to them. Comment. **Answer:** Mis-allocation of control effort. **C items warrant loose control** (bulk ordering, periodic review); tight daily control should target **A items**. Reallocating effort reduces administrative cost without raising stock-out risk on high-value items.

D8. Which is NOT an assumption of the basic EOQ model? (a) Constant demand (b) Instant replenishment (c) Quantity discounts available (d) Known ordering cost. **Answer: (c).** Basic EOQ assumes a **constant price with no discounts**; discounts require the modified (discount) model.

Traps & Examiner Tricks (Quick Reference)

1. Use **maximum** usage and **maximum** lead time for ROL — not normal.

2. Normal loss carries **no cost**; spread it over good units only.
3. Abnormal **gain** is debited to stock and credited to Costing P&L (opposite of loss).
4. Carrying cost is on **average** stock (Q/2), not full order size.
5. In discount problems, always add **purchase price** to total cost — it changes the decision.
6. Weighted average rate is recomputed **only on receipt**, not on issue.
7. LIFO/Simple-average may be tested in cost accounts but are **barred under AS-2** for financials.
8. Minimum Level uses **normal** usage × **normal** lead time; Maximum uses **minimum** usage × **minimum** lead time.
9. Freight, insurance, and taxes (non-recoverable) form part of **material cost**; recoverable GST does not.
10. Average stock = **Minimum Level + ½ ROQ** (ICAI-preferred), not simply ROQ/2.

Quick-Revision Formula Sheet

Item	Formula
EOQ	√(2AO / C)
Re-order Level	Max usage × Max lead time
Minimum Level	ROL − (Normal usage × Normal lead time)
Maximum Level	ROL + ROQ − (Min usage × Min lead time)
Danger Level	Normal usage × Max lead time (emergency)
Average Stock	Minimum Level + ½ ROQ
Cost per good unit (normal loss)	Total cost / Expected good units
Abnormal loss value	Abnormal units × cost per good unit
Inventory Turnover	Cost of materials consumed / Average stock

Chapter 03 — Employee (Labour) Cost

1. The Problem — Why Labour Refuses to Behave Like Material

When you bought material in the last chapter, life was mechanically honest. A kilogram of steel that enters the store is a kilogram that can be weighed, counted, and traced to the job that consumed it. The steel does not get tired, does not chat at the tea-stall, does not learn to work faster, and does not quit on Monday morning because a competitor offered fifty rupees more. **Labour does all of these things**, and every one of them is a hole through which cost leaks.

Here is the manager's actual, daily headache. You pay a worker for **time** — she clocks in at 9 and out at 5, and you owe her eight hours of wages. But you sell **output** — the number of good units she produced in those eight hours. The gap between "time paid for" and "output received" is where the entire discipline of labour costing lives. That gap opens up in four specific ways, and each one is a decision the accountant must handle:

1. **Idle time** — the worker is present and being paid, but not producing (machine broke down, material didn't arrive, she waited for instructions). You are paying for time that generated nothing. *Who bears this cost — the specific job, or the factory as a whole?*
2. **Overtime** — you need more output than normal hours allow, so you pay a premium (often double) for extra hours. *Is that premium a cost of the urgent job, or a cost of bad planning?*
3. **Labour turnover** — workers leave and must be replaced. Recruiting, training, and the clumsiness of a new hire all cost money that never appears on any single job card. *How much is this bleeding, and is it worth spending to stop it?*
4. **Remuneration design** — do you pay by the clock (safe but lazy) or by the piece (fast but sloppy)? Or some clever hybrid that shares the gains of speed between worker and firm? *Which system actually maximises the firm's profit per rupee of wage?*

Financial accounting cannot answer any of these. The financial ledger records "Wages ₹8,00,000" as a single lump and moves on. It cannot tell you that ₹40,000 of it was idle time caused by a supplier's late delivery, or that your turnover cost you ₹1,20,000 in lost output last quarter, or that switching from time-rate to the Rowan plan would lift output 20% while raising the wage bill only 12%. **Cost accounting exists to open that lump sum and make each rupee accountable to a decision.**

Before we go further, fix one more distinction that the exam quietly rewards. The syllabus calls this **"Employee Cost"**, not merely "wages". Employee cost is *everything* the firm spends to secure and keep human effort: basic wages, dearness allowance, production/attendance bonuses, employer's contribution to Provident Fund and ESI, gratuity, leave-with-pay, medical and canteen subsidies, and the cost of recruitment and training. A student who thinks "labour cost = hours × rate" will misclassify half the items in a theory question. **Direct employee cost** is the part identifiable with (traceable to) a cost object; **indirect employee cost** is the rest — supervision, idle time of a general nature, and all the fringe benefits that cannot be pinned to one job.

That is the mission of this chapter: to turn the messy, human, leaky reality of paying people into numbers a manager can act on.

2. The Core Idea — The Taxi Meter vs. The Courier Fee

Think of two ways to pay for getting a parcel across the city.

The taxi meter (time rate). You hire a cab; the meter runs on *time and distance*. If the driver hits traffic, dawdles, or takes a scenic route, *you* pay for it. The driver bears no risk — he earns whether he is efficient or stuck. Safe, predictable, but he has zero incentive to hurry.

The courier flat fee (piece rate). You pay ₹100 to deliver the parcel, full stop. If the courier is fast, he does ten deliveries an hour and earns well; if he's slow, that's *his* problem, not yours. All the efficiency risk sits with the worker. He races — but he may also fling the parcel over the gate and crack it.

Every remuneration system in this chapter is a negotiation over **who carries the risk of the time-versus-output gap** — the firm or the worker. Time rate puts it all on the firm. Piece rate puts it all on the worker. The clever **premium bonus plans (Halsey and Rowan)** do something more interesting: they *split the savings* when a worker beats the standard time. The worker and the firm each pocket part of the time she saved. That shared-reward structure is the intellectual heart of this chapter — hold onto the image of *splitting the saved time*, because everything in Section 4 is a variation on how to split it.

Picture a single continuous dial. At the far left sits pure time rate — **all risk on the firm, zero incentive**. At the far right sits pure (or differential) piece rate — **all risk on the worker, maximum incentive but maximum quality danger**. Every other scheme is a point somewhere along that dial, and each was invented to sit at a slightly different spot: Gantt near the safe left, Rowan and Halsey in the sensible middle, Merrick and Taylor out toward the aggressive right. When the examiner asks you to "comment on the suitability" of a plan, what she wants is for you to locate it on this dial and say *why that position fits that worker or that job*.

And idle time, overtime, and turnover? Those are the **friction** that no payment system eliminates — the potholes on the road that make the meter tick while nothing useful happens. The accountant's job is to *name* each pothole and *charge it to whoever caused it*.

---

3. Why It's Built This Way — The Logic Before the Machinery

Before any formula, absorb the three principles that generate all the rules. If you understand these, you can *derive* the treatment of any labour item in the exam instead of memorising a list.

Principle 1 — Cost must be traced to its cause, not its accident. When idle time arises because *this particular job* required the worker to wait (a special job needing a special setup), the idle cost belongs to that job. When idle time arises from a *general* cause affecting everyone (a power cut), no single job caused it, so it's spread across all jobs as overhead. The question is never "what happened?" but "*whose fault is it, and who benefited?*" This single test decides direct-vs-indirect for almost every labour item.

Principle 2 — Normal cost is a cost of doing business; abnormal cost is a loss to be spotlighted. Some idle time is unavoidable — tea breaks, machine warm-up, the natural rhythm of work. That *normal* portion is baked into the cost of production because it is genuinely part of what it takes to make the product. But idle time from a *strike*, a *flood*, or a *major breakdown* is **abnormal** — it is not part of efficient production, so we refuse to let it hide inside product cost. We yank it out and dump it into the **Costing Profit & Loss Account** where management is forced to look at it. Costing deliberately makes waste *visible*; it never lets an avoidable loss quietly inflate the cost of a unit.

Principle 3 — Incentives are engineering, not charity. A bonus scheme is not generosity; it is a *machine for changing behaviour*. You design it so that when the worker acts in her own interest, she simultaneously acts in the firm's interest. The reason the firm shares time-savings with the worker is coldly rational: a worker who finishes in 6 hours instead of 10 has freed 4 hours of capacity. Even after paying her a bonus, the firm gains — lower overhead per unit, more output from the same plant. A good plan makes both parties richer than time-rate would; a bad plan makes the worker cut corners. Every plan below is judged by one question: *does it align the worker's greed with the firm's goal?*

There is a fourth, quieter principle that unlocks the hardest exam questions:

Principle 4 — The unit cost of the firm and the pay of the worker move in opposite time-frames. When a worker speeds up, her *hourly* pay rises (she earns a bonus) but the firm's *per-unit* labour-plus-overhead cost usually **falls**, because the same fixed factory overhead is now spread over more units produced per hour. This is the engine behind every "which plan is cheaper for the firm?" question. The worker looks at rupees-per-hour; the firm looks at rupees-per-unit; a well-designed plan lets the first go up while the second comes down. Whenever an examiner slips a *fixed overhead per hour* figure into a remuneration sum, this principle is what he is testing — you must compute cost per unit **to the firm**, not just earnings to the worker.

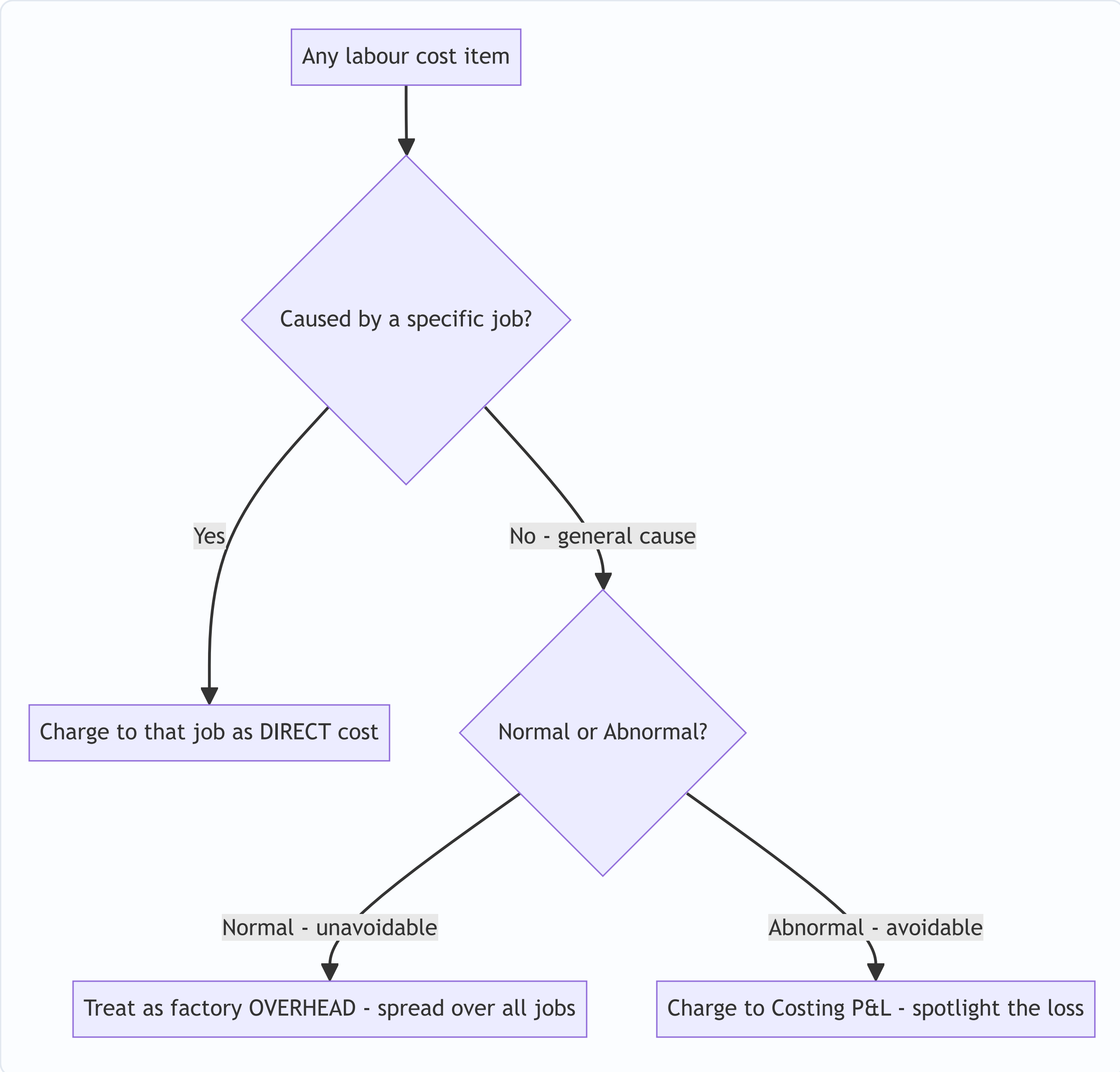


Figure 1 — The master decision tree. Almost every labour-treatment question in the exam is answered by walking these three forks.

---

4. Full Technical Content — Every Tool, With Its Reason

4.1 Attendance & Time-Keeping vs. Time-Booking

Two different measurements, constantly confused by students, so pin them down:

- **Time-keeping** answers "*Was the worker in the factory, and for how long?*" It governs **wage payment** (gate-level attendance). Methods: attendance register, disc/token method, time-recording clocks, and modern **biometric / card-swipe** systems. Its purpose is payroll and discipline.
- **Time-booking** answers "*What did the worker do while inside?*" It governs **cost allocation** (job-level). The instrument is the **Job Card / Time Sheet**, recording hours spent on each job or operation.

The reconciliation of the two is where **idle time is discovered**: if the gate says she was present 8 hours (time-keeping) but her job cards account for only 7 hours of work (time-booking), the missing **1 hour is idle time**. This is not a bureaucratic detail — it is the *arithmetic origin of idle time*.

$$\text{Idle Time} = \text{Time paid for (gate/attendance)} - \text{Time actually booked to jobs}$$

Why keep two systems at all? Because they serve two masters who must never trust each other. Time-keeping protects the *worker's right to be paid* and the firm's need for discipline; time-booking protects the *product's right to carry only its true cost*. If you merged them — paid people purely from job cards — a worker would have every incentive to over-book hours to jobs to look busy, and idle time would vanish from view. Keeping the systems separate and *reconciling* them is precisely what forces idle time into the daylight. This is a small, elegant instance of a control principle you will meet again in auditing: **the person who records the benefit should not be the only person who records the cost.**

A few finer points the exam has tested: - **Time-keeping methods** should record *arrival and departure* accurately, discourage proxy attendance ("buddy punching" — solved by biometrics), and be economical. The disc/token method is the classic manual system; know it as the ancestor of the swipe card. - **Casual workers ("badli") and out-workers** (people who take work home, or contract labour) need special treatment: out-workers on piece rate carry a risk of poor quality and material misuse, so their output must be inspected before payment. - **Overtime must be authorised in advance** by a responsible officer and recorded separately on the job card, otherwise the premium cannot be traced to a cause — an internal-control point that also happens to be the *reason* Section 4.3's treatment table is even possible.

4.2 Idle Time — Classification and Treatment

Idle time is time for which the worker is paid but does no productive work. Split it by **controllability** and **normality**:

Type of Idle Time	Cause	Cost Treatment	Why
Normal — job-related	Setting up, waiting between operations *for a specific job*, tool changes	Charge to the **job** (inflate the direct labour rate)	The job caused it and benefited; it is a genuine cost of that job
Normal — general	Tea breaks, going tool-to-store, unavoidable small waits	**Factory overhead** — spread over all production	Unavoidable and general; no single job to blame
Abnormal	Strike, lockout, power failure, machine breakdown, flood, material shortage from poor planning	**Costing Profit & Loss A/c**	Avoidable loss; must be spotlighted, not hidden in product cost

The standard technique for **normal general idle time** is to *inflate the hourly rate* so the cost gets absorbed by productive hours. If a worker is paid ₹10/hour for 8 hours (₹80/day) but only 7 hours are effective, the **effective/inflated rate = ₹80 ÷ 7 = ₹11.43/hour**. Charging jobs at ₹11.43 automatically absorbs the normal idle hour. This is the single most-tested idle-time computation.

A deeper cut on causes — the exam's favourite grey cases. Not every "the worker sat idle" fact slots neatly into one row. Learn to reason through the borderline ones: - **Idle time due to *normal* seasonal / cyclical slack** (e.g. a fan factory in winter) is treated as *normal* and absorbed as overhead — it is a foreseeable feature of the business. - **Idle time waiting for the *next* operation on a flow line** (balancing losses between unequal machines) is *normal* and part of production overhead — it is designed into the process. - **Idle time because management deliberately over-hired** anticipating an order that never came is *abnormal* — a planning failure, sent to Costing P&L. - **Idle *facility* (machine) time** is a different animal from idle *labour* time; do not conflate them. This chapter charges idle *labour*. Idle capacity of *machines* is dealt with under overheads.

The **causes checklist** examiners expect you to reproduce in a theory answer, grouped by root: 1. **Productive causes** — machine breakdown, power failure, waiting for work, materials, tools, or instructions. 2. **Administrative causes** — a deliberate policy decision to retain surplus capacity for a coming boom (often *treated as normal* if it is a conscious policy, but *abnormal* if it is simply poor scheduling). 3. **Economic causes** — a fall in demand, seasonal or cyclical, where the firm chooses to keep skilled workers rather than lose them.

The point of the grouping is that the **same visible fact ("worker idle") can be normal or abnormal depending on whether it was avoidable and whether it recurs as part of ordinary operations.** That judgement — not the arithmetic — is what the marks are for.

4.3 Overtime — The Premium Is the Whole Point

Overtime = hours worked beyond normal working hours. Under Indian practice (Factories Act, 1948), overtime is typically paid at **twice the ordinary rate of wages** (please *verify the exact current statutory multiple and the "ordinary rate" definition against current ICAI material / the applicable AY* — the standard exam assumption is double). Decompose the overtime payment into two parts, because they are treated differently:

- **Ordinary wage for overtime hours** (the normal rate for those extra hours) — always a cost of production.
- **Overtime premium** (the *extra* over normal — e.g. the second "1×" in double pay) — treatment *depends on the cause*:

Cause of Overtime	Treatment of the Premium	Why
Customer's urgent request / specific job needs it	Charge premium to **that job** (direct)	That customer caused it and should pay for the rush
General pressure of work / seasonal load	**Factory overhead** — spread over all jobs	Benefits production generally; no single culprit
Abnormal cause — making up time lost to breakdown, flood, management's poor scheduling	**Costing P&L A/c**	Avoidable; a management failure, not a product cost
Worker's own fault / to redo defective work	Charge to the **worker / department** or P&L	The firm shouldn't capitalise its own inefficiency into stock

Overtime premium formula: If normal rate is ₹R and overtime is paid at double, $$\text{Overtime premium per OT hour} = 2R - R = R \quad (\text{i.e. one normal rate extra per OT hour})$$

The decision logic — *charge the premium to whoever caused the rush* — is a direct application of Principle 1. The exam loves a question where a worker does overtime and you must split total wages into ordinary (product cost) and premium (traced by cause).

Overtime vs. idle time — the mirror-image insight. These two look opposite but share one root: a mismatch between hours available and hours needed. Idle time is *too many hours for the work*; overtime is *too little time for the work*. A well-run factory minimises **both simultaneously** by better scheduling — and the same abnormal event (a breakdown) can create idle time *now* and overtime *later* (to make up the lost output). The examiner sometimes builds exactly this trap: a breakdown causes idle time, and then overtime is worked to recover; **both the idle wages and the overtime premium for that recovery go to Costing P&L**, because both stem from the same abnormal cause.

The economic caution on overtime (theory marks). Overtime is expensive not only for the premium but for hidden reasons: fatigue lowers productivity in the extra hours, quality tends to fall, and a habit of overtime can conceal chronic under-capacity. The costing recommendation is therefore to treat persistent overtime as a *signal to add capacity or a shift*, not as a permanent solution. Being able to say this converts a numerical question into a full-mark answer.

4.4 Labour Turnover — Measuring the Bleed

Labour turnover = the rate at which employees leave and are replaced. It is a *symptom* — high turnover signals bad wages, poor conditions, weak morale — and it *costs real money*. There are three standard measurement methods; know all three because examiners specify which one.

Let: - Separations = employees who left (resignations, retrenchment, death, retirement) - Replacements = new workers hired to replace those who left (does **not** include hires for *expansion*) - Accessions = *all* new hires = replacements + new posts for expansion - Average number of workers = (Opening + Closing) ÷ 2

(a) Separation Method: $$\text{LTR} = \frac{\text{No. of separations during period}}{\text{Average no. of workers}} \times 100$$

(b) Replacement Method: $$\text{LTR} = \frac{\text{No. of replacements}}{\text{Average no. of workers}} \times 100$$ *Note: only replacements — workers hired to fill vacancies. Expansion hires are excluded because they don't represent people leaving.*

(c) Flux Method (the "total churn" — separations + accessions): $$\text{LTR} = \frac{\text{No. of separations} + \text{No. of accessions}}{\text{Average no. of workers}} \times 100$$

A common variant (ICAI) uses separations + replacements in the flux numerator when expansion hires are to be excluded: $$\text{LTR (Flux)} = \frac{\text{Separations} + \text{Replacements}}{\text{Average no. of workers}} \times 100$$

Read the question carefully: "accessions" includes expansion; "replacements" does not. This distinction is the single most common trap in turnover sums.

Equivalent Annual Turnover Rate (when the period is less than a year): $$\text{Annual LTR} = \frac{\text{LTR for period}}{\text{Days in period}} \times 365$$

Why three methods, and which "means" what. The three ratios answer three different managerial questions, and the exam sometimes asks you to *interpret* rather than compute: - The **separation rate** answers "*How fast are we losing people?*" — it is the retention alarm. - The **replacement rate** answers "*How much churn are we forced to backfill?*" — it isolates involuntary rehiring from growth. - The **flux rate** answers "*What is the total movement across the workforce boundary?*" — the broadest measure of instability. Because separations happen *before* replacements, in a stable (non-expanding) firm the separation and replacement figures often coincide; they diverge precisely when the firm is growing (expansion accessions) or shrinking (separations not backfilled). Reading which one the firm is doing *from the numbers* is a favourite short-note question.

Costs of Labour Turnover — Two Buckets

Preventive Costs (spent to *stop* people leaving)	**Replacement Costs** (incurred *because* they left)
Personnel/welfare admin, medical services	Recruitment & selection cost
Good working conditions, safety	Training cost of new workers
Fair wages, pensions, bonuses to retain	Loss of output during the vacancy & training gap
Better supervision	Higher spoilage/scrap from inexperienced hands
	Extra machine breakdown/tool damage by novices

The managerial insight: preventive spending and replacement cost **trade off**. Spend nothing on prevention and replacement costs explode; spend sensibly on retention and you save more than you spend. Cost accounting quantifies both so management can find the economic optimum — this is a genuine decision the financial books can never illuminate.

A subtlety on apportioning turnover cost. When a question gives you a lump of turnover cost and asks you to spread it, the usual base is the **number of workers replaced** or the **productive hours**, and preventive costs are generally apportioned over the *whole* workforce (everyone benefits from good conditions) while replacement costs attach to the *departments where the churn occurred*. State your base explicitly.

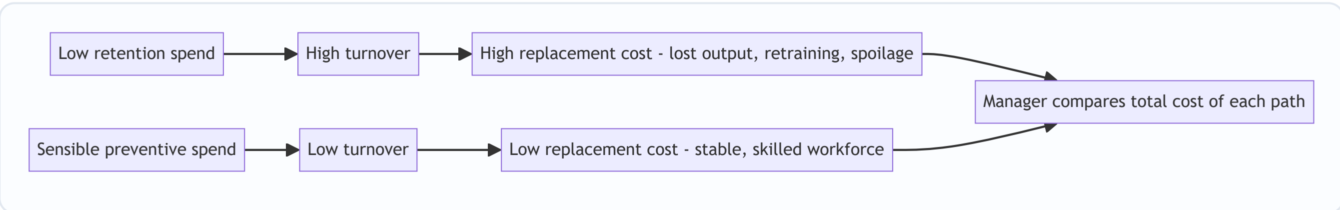


Figure 2 — Turnover as a cost trade-off. The optimum is not zero turnover but the point where preventive plus replacement cost is minimised.

4.5 Remuneration Systems — The Heart of the Chapter

Now the payment machines themselves. We build them in order of increasing cleverness.

(A) Time Rate System

Earnings = Hours Worked × Rate per Hour.

The taxi meter. Simple, guarantees the worker a stable income, and protects quality (no rush). But it gives *zero* incentive to produce more — a slow worker earns the same as a fast one. Suited to skilled/quality work (toolmakers, artists), or where output isn't within the worker's control. The firm bears all the efficiency risk.

High wage / measured day-rate variants exist (paying above market to attract better workers), but the core formula is the one above. Two named refinements worth knowing: - **Measured Day Work** — the day rate is fixed periodically in the light of the worker's *recent average performance*, giving a mild, lagged incentive without the volatility of piece rate. - **Graduated / Differential Time Rate** — the hourly rate itself steps up with skill grade or with output bands, a gentle bridge toward incentive pay.

(B) Straight Piece Rate System

Earnings = Units Produced × Rate per Unit.

The courier fee. Powerful incentive — earn exactly what you produce. But three dangers: (i) quality collapses as workers rush; (ii) no guaranteed minimum wage, so a slow day means near-starvation (industrially and legally problematic); (iii) the firm loses control over quality and material wastage. Suited to standardised, quality-tolerant, high-volume work.

Piece Rate with Guaranteed Day Wage. The commonest real-world fix for danger (ii): the worker earns *the higher of* piece earnings or a guaranteed time wage. This puts a floor under a bad day while keeping the upside — and it is the conceptual bridge to the premium bonus plans, which are simply more sophisticated versions of "guaranteed floor plus performance upside."

Taylor's Differential Piece Rate sharpens the raw piece rate: set a standard output; pay a *low* piece rate to those below standard and a *high* rate to those above — a deliberately punishing gap to drive efficiency. There is **no guaranteed minimum**; the whole design is to make inefficiency hurt. Typical textbook rates: **83% of the normal piece rate below standard, 125% at or above standard** (verify exact percentages against current ICAI material, as textbook conventions vary).

Merrick's Multiple / Differential Piece Rate is the gentler, three-tier cousin — it softens Taylor by adding a middle band and, crucially, *never pays below the ordinary piece rate*: - Up to **83%** of standard output → **ordinary** piece rate (no penalty, unlike Taylor). - **83% to 100%** of standard → **110%** of ordinary piece rate. - **Above 100%** of standard → **120%** (some texts 120–130%) of ordinary piece rate. *(Verify the exact band boundaries and percentages against current ICAI material.)* The design philosophy: encourage the near-average worker with a reachable reward instead of Taylor's cliff-edge punishment.

(C) The Premium Bonus Plans — Sharing the Saved Time

Here is the elegant middle path, and the examiner's favourite. The idea: fix a **standard time** for a job. If the worker finishes *faster*, she has **saved time**. Instead of giving her all the benefit (piece rate) or none (time rate), the firm **shares the value of the saved time** with her as a **bonus**. She still gets guaranteed time-rate wages as a floor (so a bad day doesn't starve her), *plus* a bonus for beating standard. Best of both worlds.

Let: - \$T\$ = Time Taken (actual hours) - \$S\$ = Standard Time (allowed hours) - \$R\$ = Rate per hour - **Time Saved** = \$S - T\$

Halsey Plan — fixed 50% share of saved time: \$\$\boxed{\text{Total Earnings} = (T \times R) + \left(50\% \times (S - T) \times R\right)}\$\$

The worker gets her time-rate wage *plus* half the value of the time she saved. The firm keeps the other half. Simple, predictable; the firm always keeps 50% of the gain no matter how good the worker is. (A **Halsey-Weir** variant uses **30–33⅓%** as the sharing fraction — same structure, different slice.)

Rowan Plan — bonus proportional to the ratio of time saved to standard: \$\$\boxed{\text{Total Earnings} = (T \times R) + \left(\frac{S - T}{S} \times T \times R\right)}\$\$

The bonus is *time-rate wage × (time saved ÷ standard time)*. This looks odd — why scale the bonus by the fraction of time saved? Because it **self-limits**: as the worker saves more and more time, the fraction \$(S-T)/S\$

rises but T shrinks, and the bonus is mathematically capped. **The Rowan bonus can never exceed the time-rate wage**, and it is *maximised when time saved = 50% of standard time*. This built-in ceiling protects the firm from over-paying and — crucially — protects the worker from the temptation to *over-report* speed by cutting quality, because racing past 50% saved actually *reduces* her marginal bonus. It is a self-governing incentive.

Why the Rowan bonus is capped at the time wage — the one-line proof to keep in your head. Bonus $= \frac{(S-T)}{S}\,TR$. Write the time-saved fraction as $f = (S-T)/S$, so $T = S(1-f)$ and bonus $= f \cdot S(1-f) \cdot R = SR\,[f(1-f)]$. The quantity $f(1-f)$ is a downward parabola, **maximised at $f = 0.5$** with value 0.25, so max bonus $= 0.25\,SR = 0.5 \times (0.5S)\,R = 0.5 \times \text{time wage at } T=0.5S$. Since $f(1-f) \le 0.25$ always, the bonus never exceeds half of SR, and because $T \ge 0.5S$ near the peak, it never exceeds TR. This *is* the ceiling, derived, not memorised.

(D) Efficiency / Task-Bonus Plans — Beyond Halsey and Rowan

The exam increasingly tests a second family that ties the bonus to an **efficiency percentage** rather than to raw hours saved. Learn the shape of each; the arithmetic is easy once you know the trigger points.

Gantt Task and Bonus Plan — the "safe left" of the incentive dial. It guarantees a time wage and then jumps: - Output **below** standard (efficiency < 100%) → **guaranteed time wage** (no penalty — this is its kindness). - Output **at** standard (efficiency = 100%) → time wage **plus a bonus** (commonly **20%** of time wage). - Output **above** standard → **high piece rate** on the *whole* output (typically **120%** of ordinary rate).

Gantt is ideal where you want to *protect a minimum livelihood* (learners, essential quality) yet still dangle a strong jump at the standard. The discontinuity at 100% is the motivational lever.

Emerson's Efficiency Plan — a *smooth* ramp instead of Gantt's cliff. A guaranteed time wage up to a threshold, then a graduated bonus rising with efficiency: - Below **~66⅔%** efficiency → time wage only, **no bonus**. - From **66⅔% to 100%** → bonus rises **gradually** (reaching about **20%** of time wage at 100% efficiency). - Above **100%** → bonus of **20% plus 1% of time wage for every 1%** of efficiency above 100%. *(Verify the exact threshold and slope against current ICAI material.)* Emerson suits situations where you want to reward *steady improvement* toward the standard, not just crossing it.

Bedaux (Point) Plan. Work is measured in standard minutes called **"B" units** (one B = one minute of standard work). Bonus is usually **75% of the time saved** (in B units, valued at the hourly rate), with the remaining **25% to the foreman/supervisor** — an early attempt to incentivise supervision too.

Barth's Scheme (for learners) uses a square-root formula, earnings $= R \times \sqrt{\text{standard hours} \times \text{hours worked}}$; it has no guaranteed minimum and is now largely of historical/theory interest — know the name and that it suits trainees.

(E) Group / Collective Bonus Schemes

Where output is a *team* result (an assembly line, a foundry crew), you cannot isolate one worker's contribution, so the bonus is earned by the **group** and then **shared out**. Sharing bases you must be able to name and apply: - In proportion to **time-rate wages** of each member (the commonest, and fairest when skills differ), or - **Equally** among members (when contributions are broadly similar), or - On **specified percentages** agreed in advance (rewarding key roles more).

Group schemes trade *sharpness of individual incentive* for *cooperation and reduced internal competition* — good where team output and safety matter more than individual racing.

The Behavioural Difference — Why Two Plans, Not One

- **When time saved is LOW (worker just beats standard), Rowan pays MORE than Halsey.** Rowan is generous to modest improvers — good for encouraging the average worker.
- **When time saved is HIGH (worker is exceptional), Halsey pays MORE than Rowan.** Halsey rewards the star performer more; Rowan's ceiling holds the star back.
- **The crossover is at exactly 50% time saved**, where both plans pay the *same* bonus.

Proof of the crossover, so you never memorise it blindly: Set Halsey bonus = Rowan bonus. Halsey bonus $= 0.5(S-T)R$. Rowan bonus $= \frac{(S-T)}{S}TR$. Equating and cancelling $(S-T)R$ (assuming time saved ≠ 0): $0.5 = \frac{T}{S}$, so $T = 0.5S$, i.e. **time taken is half of standard = 50% time saved.** Above 50% saved, $T/S < 0.5$ so Rowan's factor drops below Halsey's 0.5 → Halsey wins. Below 50% saved, Rowan wins.

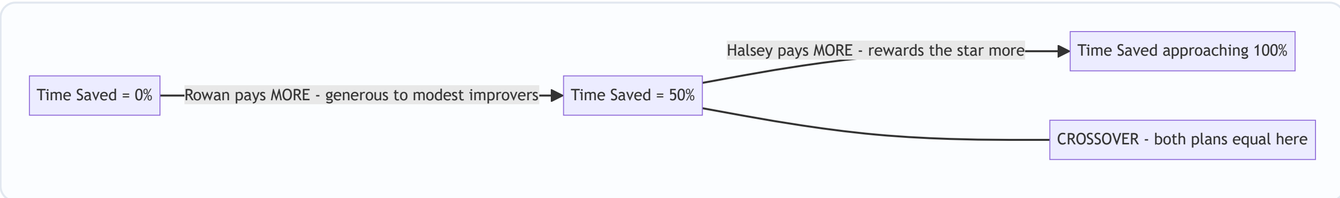


Figure 3 — The Halsey-vs-Rowan crossover. Below 50% time saved Rowan is more generous, above 50% Halsey is, and at exactly 50% they meet.

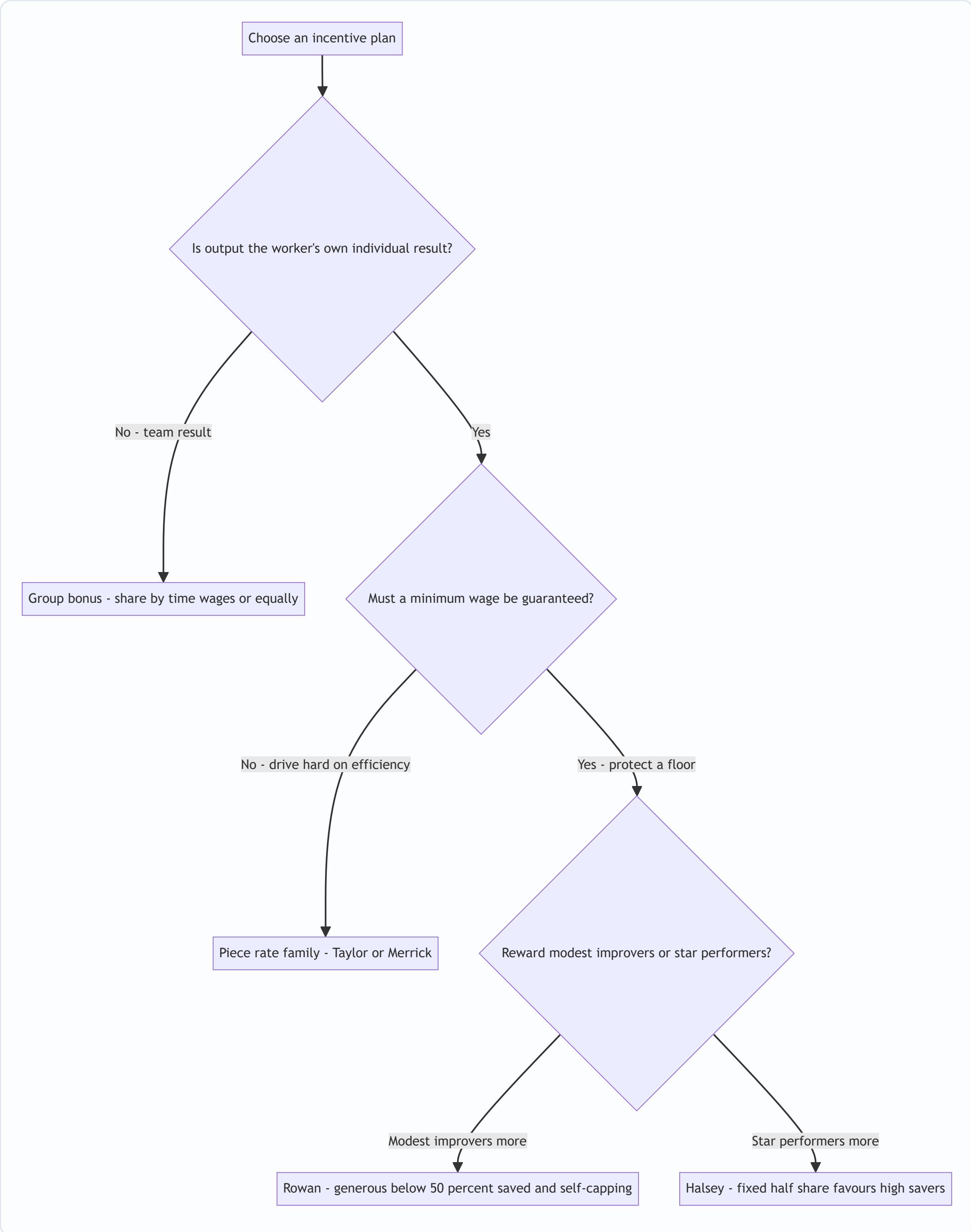


Figure 4 — A selection map for remuneration plans. Walk the forks from the nature of the output to the behaviour you want to reward.

4.6 Labour Efficiency & Effective Hourly Rate

Efficiency measures output against a standard: $$\text{Labour Efficiency} = \frac{\text{Standard Time for actual output}}{\text{Actual Time taken}} \times 100$$

Over 100% = beating standard (saving time). Under 100% = below standard.

To compare plans, always compute the **Effective Hourly Rate** (also called effective earnings per hour): $$\text{Effective Rate/hour} = \frac{\text{Total Earnings under the plan}}{\text{Actual Hours Worked }(T)}$$

This normalises everything to a per-hour figure, letting you say "under Rowan she effectively earns ₹X/hr, under Halsey ₹Y/hr" — the sentence the examiner wants in your conclusion.

The firm's-eye view — labour cost per unit. Where a question gives factory **overhead per hour**, do not stop at the worker's earnings. Compute what *the firm* pays per unit: $$\text{Cost per unit to firm} = \frac{\text{Wages} + \text{Overhead (hours} \times \text{OH rate)}}{\text{Units produced}}$$ Because a faster worker uses **fewer hours**, she absorbs **less overhead**, so a plan that pays her *more per hour* can still make each unit *cheaper for the firm* (Principle 4). Answering "which plan is best?" from the firm's side means comparing **cost per unit**, not earnings. This is the discriminator between an average script and a top one.

---

5. Worked Examples — From Warm-Up to Exam-Hard

Example 1 — Idle Time and the Inflated Rate (Warm-up)

A worker is paid ₹12 per hour and works a 48-hour week. Of the 48 hours, records show 3 hours are normal idle time (tea breaks, unavoidable waiting). Compute (a) the gross weekly wage, and (b) the effective (inflated) hourly rate at which productive hours should be charged to jobs.

Solution.

(a) Gross weekly wage = 48 hours × ₹12 = **₹576**. *(The worker is paid for all attended hours, idle or not.)*

(b) Productive (effective) hours = 48 − 3 = 45 hours. The full ₹576 must be recovered over only 45 productive hours: $$\text{Effective rate} = \frac{₹576}{45} = ₹12.80 \text{ per hour}$$

Interpretation. Jobs are charged at ₹12.80/hr, not ₹12/hr. The extra ₹0.80 per productive hour silently absorbs the 3 normal idle hours across the week. *Check:* 45 × ₹12.80 = ₹576 ✓ — the whole wage is recovered, nothing lost. This is Principle 1 (normal general idle time → spread over productive work) turned into arithmetic.

Examiner tweak — what if 1 of those 3 idle hours is abnormal (a power cut)? Then only 2 hours are normal and absorbed; the 1 abnormal hour's wage (₹12) is stripped out to Costing P&L. Effective hours for absorption = 48 − 2 = 46; absorbed wage = 46 × rate must recover only the *normal* portion (₹576 − ₹12 = ₹564). Effective rate = ₹564 ÷ 46 = **₹12.26/hr**, and ₹12 goes to P&L. *Check:* 46 × 12.26 + 12 (P&L) = 564 + 12 = ₹576 ✓. The lesson: **abnormal idle wages never enter the inflated rate** — pull them out *first*, then inflate over the remaining productive hours.

Example 2 — Overtime: Splitting Ordinary Wage from Premium

In a factory the normal working week is 40 hours at ₹50 per hour. Overtime is paid at double the normal rate. In a given week worker A worked 48 hours. Of the 8 overtime hours, 5 hours were due to a specific customer's *urgent order and 3 hours were to make up production lost due to a machine breakdown. Compute total earnings and show how each element is treated in the cost accounts.*

Solution.

Step 1 — **Ordinary wages for all hours worked** (normal rate on every hour, including OT hours): 48 hours × ₹50 = **₹2,400**. *(This is always a cost of production.)*

Step 2 — **Overtime premium** = extra rate on OT hours = (double − normal) = ₹50 extra per OT hour × 8 OT hours = **₹400**.

Step 3 — **Total earnings** = ₹2,400 + ₹400 = **₹2,800**. *Check via direct route:* 40 normal hrs × ₹50 + 8 OT hrs × ₹100 = ₹2,000 + ₹800 = ₹2,800 ✓

Step 4 — **Treatment of the ₹400 premium**, split by cause (Principle 1):

Element	Amount (₹)	Treatment	Reason
Ordinary wages (48 × 50)	2,400	Direct labour — cost of production	Basic wage for hours worked
OT premium — 5 hrs (customer rush) 5 × ₹50	250	Charge to that **specific job**	Customer caused the rush; should bear it
OT premium — 3 hrs (breakdown make-up) 3 × ₹50	150	Charge to **Costing P&L A/c**	Abnormal; breakdown is an avoidable loss
Total	**2,800**		

Interpretation. The same ₹2,800 wage is dissected: ₹2,400 flows into product cost, ₹250 attaches to the customer's job (so quoting/pricing that job reflects its true rush cost), and ₹150 is spotlighted as an abnormal loss rather than being hidden in inventory. Financial accounting would have shown only "Wages ₹2,800" — cost accounting makes each rupee accountable.

Examiner tweak — "general pressure of work" instead of a named cause. If the question said all 8 OT hours arose from *general* seasonal pressure (no specific job, no abnormal event), the entire ₹400 premium becomes **factory overhead**, spread over all jobs — not traced to any one. And if the OT were worked to redo A's *own* defective output, the premium (and arguably the ordinary wage for redo) is charged to the **worker/department or P&L**, because the firm must not capitalise its own scrap into stock. The number never changes; only the *destination* does — that is the whole test.

Example 3 — Full Comparison: Time Rate vs Piece Rate vs Halsey vs Rowan (Exam-standard)

Standard time allowed for a job is 60 hours. Worker P completes it in 40 hours. Rate per hour is ₹15. For piece-rate comparison assume the piece rate is set so that a worker completing the standard job in standard time earns the same as time rate (i.e. piece payment = standard-time wage). Calculate P's earnings and effective hourly rate under (a) Time Rate, (b) Piece Rate, (c) Halsey Plan (50%), and (d) Rowan Plan. Comment.

Given: Standard time S = 60 hrs; Time taken T = 40 hrs; Rate R = ₹15/hr; **Time saved = 60 − 40 = 20 hrs.**

(a) Time Rate. Earnings = $T × R$ = 40 × ₹15 = **₹600**. Effective rate = ₹600 ÷ 40 = **₹15.00/hr**. *She finished 20 hours early but earns nothing extra — pure taxi-meter.*

(b) Piece Rate. Piece payment is based on the standard time the job is worth (60 hrs), regardless of the 40 she took: Earnings = $S × R$ = 60 × ₹15 = **₹900**. Effective rate = ₹900 ÷ 40 = **₹22.50/hr**. *She captures 100% of the value of the time saved — the whole ₹300 (20 × ₹15) benefit is hers.*

(c) Halsey Plan (50%). $$\text{Earnings} = (T × R) + 50\% (S - T) R = 600 + 0.5 × 20 × 15 = 600 + 150 = ₹750$$ Bonus = **₹150** (half of the ₹300 saved-time value). Effective rate = ₹750 ÷ 40 = **₹18.75/hr**. *The firm keeps the other ₹150.*

(d) Rowan Plan. $$\text{Bonus} = \frac{S - T}{S} × T × R = \frac{20}{60} × 40 × 15 = \frac{1}{3} × 600 = ₹200$$ Earnings = 600 + 200 = **₹800**. Effective rate = ₹800 ÷ 40 = **₹20.00/hr**.

Summary table:

System	Bonus (₹)	Total Earnings (₹)	Effective Rate (₹/hr)
Time Rate	—	600	15.00
Halsey (50%)	150	750	18.75
Rowan	200	800	20.00
Piece Rate	300*	900	22.50

**"Bonus" under piece rate = full value of time saved (20 × ₹15 = 300).*

Comment. Time saved here = 20/60 = **33.3% of standard — below the 50% crossover — so Rowan (₹800) pays more than Halsey (₹750)**, exactly as the theory in §4.5 predicts. Piece rate is most generous to the worker but gives the firm none of the saving and risks quality; time rate rewards her speed with nothing. Halsey and Rowan strike the balance, with Rowan favouring this modest-to-good improver.

Cross-check the crossover claim. If instead P had taken only 30 hours (50% saved), Halsey bonus = 0.5 × 30 × 15 = ₹225; Rowan bonus = (30/60) × 30 × 15 = ₹225 — **identical**, confirming they meet at 50% time saved. And at 40 hours saved out of 60 (66.7% saved, T = 20): Halsey = 0.5 × 40 × 15 = ₹300; Rowan = (40/60) × 20 × 15 = ₹200 — now **Halsey exceeds Rowan**, confirming Halsey wins above the 50% mark. The two examples together verify Figure 3.

Example 4 — Labour Turnover: All Three Methods with the Expansion Trap

The following data relate to a factory for the year: - Number of workers at the beginning of the year: 1,900 - Number of workers at the end of the year: 2,100 - During the year, 40 workers left, 60 workers were discharged, and 150 workers were recruited. Of these 150, 25 were recruited to fill vacancies caused by workers leaving, and the remainder were engaged for an expansion scheme.

Calculate the labour turnover rate under (a) Separation Method, (b) Replacement Method, and (c) Flux Method.

Solution.

Step 1 — **Identify the components carefully** (this is the whole exam battle): - Separations = left + discharged = 40 + 60 = **100** - Replacements = recruited to fill vacancies = **25** *(NOT 150)* - Accessions = total recruited = **150** (25 replacements + 125 expansion) - Average workers = (1,900 + 2,100) ÷ 2 = **2,000**

Step 2 — **(a) Separation Method:** $$\frac{100}{2,000} × 100 = \mathbf{5\%}$$

Step 3 — **(b) Replacement Method:** $$\frac{25}{2,000} × 100 = \mathbf{1.25\%}$$

Step 4 — **(c) Flux Method.** Using the *accessions* form (separations + all accessions): $$\frac{100 + 150}{2,000} × 100 = \frac{250}{2,000} × 100 = \mathbf{12.5\%}$$ Using the *replacement* form (separations + replacements, excluding expansion) as ICAI often asks: $$\frac{100 + 25}{2,000} × 100 = \frac{125}{2,000} × 100 = \mathbf{6.25\%}$$

Interpretation & the trap. The 125 expansion hires are the landmine. They inflate *accessions* but are **not** replacements — nobody left to create those posts. A careless student divides 150 by 2,000 and reports replacement turnover of 7.5%, six times the true figure. **Always separate "hired because someone left" (replacement) from "hired to grow" (expansion).** State which flux formula you use; if the question says "flux method" without qualification, the accessions form (12.5%) is the standard default, but present both if the phrasing is ambiguous.

Example 5 — Rowan vs Halsey Guarantee Puzzle (Exam-hard, reverse logic)

A worker takes 9 hours to complete a job for which the standard time is 12 hours. His day rate is ₹20/hour. The firm pays a bonus under the Rowan plan. A trainee, working the same job, takes 15 hours (i.e. exceeds standard). Compute earnings for both workers under the Rowan plan, and comment on what happens when the standard is NOT beaten.

Solution.

Skilled worker: S = 12, T = 9, R = ₹20, time saved = 3 hrs. $$\text{Bonus} = \frac{S-T}{S} × T × R = \frac{3}{12} × 9 × 20 = 0.25 × 180 = ₹45$$ Earnings = (9 × 20) + 45 = 180 + 45 = **₹225**. Effective rate = 225 ÷ 9 = **₹25/hr**.

Halsey check for the same worker (to show Rowan wins below 50% saved): time saved = 3/12 = 25% < 50%, so Rowan should exceed Halsey. Halsey bonus = 0.5 × 3 × 20 = ₹30; Halsey earnings = ₹210. Indeed **Rowan ₹225 > Halsey ₹210** ✓.

Trainee (exceeds standard): S = 12, T = 15, time saved = 12 − 15 = **−3 (negative → no time saved)**. Bonus formulas apply *only when time is saved*. Here $T > S$, so **no bonus**. Under any premium bonus plan the worker still gets the **guaranteed time-rate wage** — that is the entire point of the guaranteed floor: Earnings = $T × R$ = 15 × ₹20 = **₹300**. Effective rate = ₹300 ÷ 15 = **₹20/hr** (= plain time rate).

Comment. The premium plans are *asymmetric by design*: beat the standard and you share a bonus; miss it and you are protected by the time-rate floor but earn no bonus. This asymmetry is why workers accept these schemes — the downside is capped at the guaranteed wage (unlike straight piece rate, where a slow trainee could earn almost nothing). It also shows why the firm still bears *some* risk: the trainee's 15 hours cost ₹300 for a job worth only 12 standard hours (₹240) — a ₹60 inefficiency the firm absorbs, which is exactly the pressure that motivates training and turnover-reduction spending from §4.4.

Example 6 — Which Plan Is Cheapest *for the Firm*? (Overhead-recovery twist)

A job has a standard time of 20 hours. Worker Q does it in 16 hours. Wage rate is ₹25/hour. Factory overhead is recovered at ₹30 per hour worked. Compute the total cost of the job to the firm under (a) Time Rate, (b) Halsey (50%), and (c) Rowan. Which plan gives the firm the lowest job cost, and why?

Given: S = 20, T = 16, R = ₹25, OH = ₹30/hr, time saved = 4 hrs. Overhead is recovered on *hours worked (T)*, so all three plans absorb the **same** overhead here (16 × ₹30 = ₹480) because T is identical across plans — the difference lies entirely in wages.

Wages under each plan: - Time rate: 16 × 25 = **₹400**, bonus nil. - Halsey: 400 + 0.5 × 4 × 25 = 400 + 50 = **₹450**. - Rowan: 400 + (4/20) × 16 × 25 = 400 + 0.2 × 400 = 400 + 80 = **₹480**.

Total job cost (wages + ₹480 overhead):

Plan	Wages (₹)	Overhead (₹)	Total job cost (₹)
Time rate	400	480	880
Halsey	450	480	930
Rowan	480	480	960

Comment — and the sharper insight. Against *pure time rate for the same 16 hours*, time rate looks cheapest — but that comparison is a mirage, because under time rate Q has **no reason to finish in 16 hours**; she would drift to the full 20. The honest comparison is Halsey/Rowan-at-16-hours **versus time-rate-at-20-hours**: at 20 hours time-rate wages = 20 × 25 = ₹500 and overhead = 20 × 30 = ₹600, total **₹1,100** — far worse than Halsey (₹930) or Rowan (₹960). **The incentive plans look dearer on wages but slash the overhead by cutting hours, and that is where the firm truly wins** (Principle 4). Time saved here = 4/20 = 20% < 50%, so Rowan again pays the worker more than Halsey (₹480 vs ₹450), consistent with §4.5.

Check on the Rowan bonus: (4/20) × 16 × 25 = 0.2 × 400 = ₹80 ✓; effective rate to worker under Rowan = 480 ÷ 16 = ₹30/hr vs Halsey 450 ÷ 16 = ₹28.13/hr.

Example 7 — Reverse Problem: Find Standard Time from a Known Bonus (Exam-hard)

Under the Halsey plan (50%) a worker earned a bonus of ₹120. Under the Rowan plan, on the same job with the same time taken and same rate, he would have earned a bonus of ₹160. The wage rate is ₹40/hour. Find (a) the time taken, and (b) the standard (allowed) time.

Solution — set up two equations. Let time saved = $(S-T)$ hours.

Halsey bonus: $0.5 (S-T) R = 120 \Rightarrow 0.5 (S-T)(40) = 120 \Rightarrow (S-T) = \dfrac{120}{20} = 6$ hours saved.

Rowan bonus: $\dfrac{(S-T)}{S} T R = 160$. Substitute $(S-T) = 6$ and $R = 40$: $$\frac{6}{S} \cdot T \cdot 40 = 160 \Rightarrow \frac{240\,T}{S} = 160 \Rightarrow \frac{T}{S} = \frac{160}{240} = \frac{2}{3}$$

So $T = \tfrac{2}{3}S$, meaning $S - T = \tfrac{1}{3}S = 6 \Rightarrow S = 18$ hours, and $T = 12$ hours.

(a) Time taken = 12 hours. (b) Standard time = 18 hours. (Time saved = 6 hrs = 33.3% of standard.)

Verify both bonuses. - Halsey: 0.5 × 6 × 40 = ₹120 ✓ - Rowan: (6/18) × 12 × 40 = (1/3) × 480 = ₹160 ✓

Why this works — the exam craft. The Halsey bonus alone fixes the *hours saved* (6) because it does not depend on S separately. The Rowan bonus then supplies the *ratio* T/S. Two facts, two unknowns, solved cleanly. This "given the bonuses, find the times" reversal is a favourite because a student who only memorised the forward formulas freezes; a student who *understands* that Halsey encodes absolute saving and Rowan encodes the saving-ratio walks straight through it. Note the crossover check: time saved 33.3% < 50%, and indeed Rowan (₹160) > Halsey (₹120), consistent with theory.

Example 8 — Group Bonus Sharing (Team output)

A team of three workers — A, B, C — jointly completes a job. Standard time for the job is 100 hours; the team finishes in 80 hours. The group bonus is computed under the Halsey principle (50% of time saved) at a common bonus rate of ₹30/hour, and the bonus is shared in proportion to each member's time-rate wages. Their individual rates and hours are: A — 80 hrs at ₹20/hr; B — 80 hrs at ₹25/hr; C — 80 hrs at ₹15/hr. Compute each worker's total earnings.

Solution.

Step 1 — **Group time saved** = 100 − 80 = 20 hours. **Group bonus** = 50% × 20 × ₹30 = **₹300**.

Step 2 — **Basic time wages of each member** (basis for sharing): - A: 80 × 20 = ₹1,600 - B: 80 × 25 = ₹2,000 - C: 80 × 15 = ₹1,200 - **Total time wages = ₹4,800.**

Step 3 — **Share the ₹300 bonus in the ratio 1,600 : 2,000 : 1,200 = 4 : 5 : 3** (sum 12): - A: 300 × 4/12 = **₹100** - B: 300 × 5/12 = **₹125** - C: 300 × 3/12 = **₹75** - *Check:* 100 + 125 + 75 = ₹300 ✓

Step 4 — **Total earnings = basic wage + bonus share:**

Worker	Basic wage (₹)	Bonus share (₹)	Total (₹)
A	1,600	100	1,700
B	2,000	125	2,125
C	1,200	75	1,275
Total	**4,800**	**300**	**5,100**

Comment. Because the bonus is shared by *time wages*, the higher-rated worker B collects the largest slice — appropriate where the rate reflects skill contributed to the team result. Had the question said "share equally", each would take ₹100 regardless of rate. **Always read the sharing basis;** the individual output of A, B, C is unknowable here (it is a team result), which is *why* a group scheme is used at all. *Cross-check the whole:* total group earnings ₹5,100 = team wages ₹4,800 + group bonus ₹300, and the firm paid for 80 hours to get 100 standard hours of work — a genuine gain that funded the bonus.

6. Presentation & Format — How to Lay It Out in the Exam

For remuneration comparisons, always present a clean columnar statement and *always* end with the effective hourly rate — that is the line the examiner rewards:

Statement of Comparative Earnings

Particulars	Time Rate	Halsey	Rowan	Piece Rate
Time taken (hrs)	...	...	...	...
Basic wages (T × R)	...	...	...	...
Add: Bonus	—	...	...	...
Total Earnings	...	...	...	...
Effective rate/hour	...	...	...	...

Formatting discipline that earns marks: - Always write the formula *before* substituting numbers (e.g. write "Bonus = (S−T)/S × T × R" then plug in). Method marks are awarded even if arithmetic slips. - State **time saved = S − T** explicitly as a labelled line; many answers lose marks by not showing it. - For idle time / overtime, present a **treatment table** (item | amount | where charged | reason) — never just a number. - For turnover, **show the component computation** (separations, replacements, accessions, average) as a labelled block before the ratios. - When the question mentions **overhead per hour**, add a second statement for **cost per unit / per job to the firm** — do not stop at worker earnings (Example 6). - For **group schemes**, show the *sharing ratio* as its own line before allocating. - Round money to two decimals; keep hours exact; add a one-line **verification/check** ("45 × 12.80 = 576 ✓").

---

7. Connections — Where This Chapter Plugs Into the Rest of Cost Accounting

- → **Cost Sheet (Ch. 06; overheads Ch. 04):** Direct labour (productive wages, job-related idle time, job-caused OT premium) enters **Prime Cost**. Normal general idle time and general OT premium become **Factory Overhead**. Abnormal idle time and abnormal OT go to **Costing P&L**, *outside* the cost sheet. Every labour item you classify here decides *which line of the cost sheet it lands on*.
- → **Overhead Absorption:** The "inflated rate" technique for idle time is the same absorption logic used for overheads — recover a fixed pool over a productive base. And Example 6's overhead-per-hour twist *is* overhead absorption meeting labour costing.
- → **Standard Costing & Variances (later):** Labour efficiency here (Std time ÷ Actual time) is the seed of the **Labour Efficiency Variance** and **Labour Rate Variance**. Standard time S reappears there as the benchmark, and idle time becomes the **Idle Time Variance**.
- → **Reconciliation of Cost & Financial Accounts:** Abnormal idle/OT losses are precisely the items that cause cost profit to differ from financial profit.
- → **Marginal Costing / Decision-Making:** Whether labour is *fixed* (time-rate monthly staff) or *variable* (piece-rate) determines its behaviour in break-even and make-or-buy decisions.
- → **Job & Contract Costing:** The job card of §4.1 is the very document that carries labour into job costing; time-booking is where job cost sheets get their labour line.

---

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks — The Places Students Bleed Marks

1. **Replacement vs Accession confusion.** Expansion hires are accessions, *not* replacements. Dividing total recruits by average workers for the "replacement rate" is the #1 error (see Example 4).

2. **Charging the whole overtime payment to the job.** Only the *cause-appropriate* portion — and only the *premium* is traced by cause; the ordinary-rate element on OT hours is always product cost. Don't dump the full double-pay onto one job unless the job caused it.
3. **Forgetting the guaranteed time wage.** Under Halsey/Rowan, if the worker *exceeds* standard (T > S), there is **no negative bonus** — she still gets T × R. Never compute a negative bonus (Example 5).
4. **Mixing up Halsey and Rowan bonus formulas.** Halsey = *fixed 50% of time saved*. Rowan = *(time saved ÷ standard) × time-rate wage*. A memory hook: **Rowan has a Ratio** (time saved / standard). Halsey is a **Half**.
5. **Wrong crossover direction.** Below 50% time saved → **Rowan pays more**; above 50% → **Halsey pays more**; at 50% equal. Students routinely state it backwards.
6. **Abnormal idle time inflating product cost.** Strike/flood/breakdown idle time must go to **Costing P&L**, never into the job or overhead. Hiding it in product cost is conceptually wrong and loses marks. Pull abnormal wages out *before* computing the inflated rate (Example 1 tweak).
7. **Using the wrong "time" in Rowan.** The bonus multiplies by **T (time taken)**, not S. Writing (S−T)/S × **S** × R is a classic slip that inflates the bonus.
8. **Average workers denominator.** Turnover ratios use the *average* (opening + closing)/2, not closing. Using closing headcount is a silent error.
9. **Idle time rate inflation direction.** The effective rate is *higher* than the paid rate (you recover the same money over fewer hours). If your inflated rate comes out lower, you've divided by the wrong figure.
10. **Piece-rate quality/minimum-wage caveats.** Theory questions want you to *name* the drawbacks (no guaranteed wage, quality risk, material wastage) — don't just give the formula.
11. **Stopping at worker earnings when overhead is given.** If the sum supplies overhead per hour, the examiner wants **cost per unit / per job to the firm** — the plan that pays the worker *more per hour* can still be cheaper per unit because it uses fewer hours (Example 6). Missing this misses the point of the question.
12. **Taylor vs Merrick penalty confusion.** Taylor has **no guaranteed minimum and punishes below-standard with a low rate**; Merrick **never pays below the ordinary piece rate** and adds a middle band. Swapping their treatment of the slow worker is a common slip.
13. **Gantt vs Emerson shape.** Gantt is a **step/cliff** (guaranteed wage, then a jump to high piece rate at standard); Emerson is a **smooth ramp** of graduated bonus with efficiency. Describing one as the other loses the concept mark.
14. **Group bonus sharing basis.** "In proportion to wages" ≠ "equally". Read which, show the ratio line, and note that individual output is deliberately unknowable in a team scheme (Example 8).
15. **Discharged/retired/dead all count as separations.** Any exit — voluntary or not — is a separation. Do not exclude retrenchment or death from the separation count.

---

9. First-Principles Recap — Rebuild the Chapter From Three Sentences

If you forget every formula, you can regenerate this chapter from three ideas:

1. **Labour is paid for time but valued for output; the gap between them (idle time, inefficiency) is where cost leaks — so we measure attendance for pay and book time for cost, and reconcile the two to expose the gap.**

2. **Every leaked cost is charged to whoever caused it (job → direct; general → overhead; abnormal → P&L), because cost must follow cause and waste must be made visible, not buried.**
3. **Incentive pay is behavioural engineering: time rate loads risk on the firm, piece rate on the worker, and premium bonus plans (Halsey = fixed half of saved time; Rowan = saved-time-ratio share, self-capping at 50%) split the gain so the worker's speed and the firm's profit pull the same way.**

From (3) you can re-derive both bonus formulas; from (2) you can classify any idle-time or overtime item; from (1) you can explain why time-keeping and time-booking are separate systems and how idle time is discovered. The whole chapter is those three sentences unfolded. And to reach the top band, add the fourth idea — **the worker measures pay per hour while the firm measures cost per unit, and a good plan lets the first rise while the second falls** — which is all you need to answer any "which plan is best for the firm?" question.

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

Core formulas

Concept	Formula
Idle Time	Time paid (attendance) − Time booked to jobs
Effective (inflated) rate	Total wage ÷ Productive (effective) hours
Overtime premium (double pay)	(2R − R) per OT hr = R per OT hr
Time Rate earnings	Hours worked × Rate = T × R
Piece Rate earnings	Units × Rate per unit (or S × R when job-standard based)
Halsey earnings	(T × R) + **50% × (S − T) × R**
Rowan earnings	(T × R) + **[(S − T) ÷ S] × T × R**
Time saved	S − T
Labour efficiency	(Std time for actual output ÷ Actual time) × 100
Effective rate/hour under a plan	Total earnings ÷ Actual hours (T)
Cost per unit to firm	(Wages + Hours × OH rate) ÷ Units produced

Labour turnover

Method	Formula (× 100, over average workers)
Separation	Separations ÷ Avg workers
Replacement	Replacements only ÷ Avg workers
Flux (accessions form)	(Separations + Accessions) ÷ Avg workers
Flux (replacement form)	(Separations + Replacements) ÷ Avg workers
Average workers	(Opening + Closing) ÷ 2
Annualised (short period)	(Period LTR ÷ days) × 365

Incentive-plan family map

Plan	One-line signature	Guaranteed floor?
Time rate	Hours × rate	Yes (the floor itself)
Straight piece rate	Units × rate	No
Taylor differential	Low rate below std, high rate above; punishing	No
Merrick	Three bands, never below ordinary piece rate	Ordinary rate
Halsey	Time wage + half of saved-time value	Yes (time wage)
Rowan	Time wage + (saved ÷ standard) × time wage; self-caps at 50%	Yes (time wage)
Gantt task & bonus	Guaranteed wage, jump to high piece rate at standard	Yes
Emerson efficiency	Smooth graduated bonus rising with efficiency	Yes
Group bonus	Team earns, shared by wages or equally	Per member

(Verify all named percentages — Taylor 83/125, Merrick bands, Emerson 66⅔ threshold, Bedaux 75/25, Halsey-Weir 30–33⅓ — against current ICAI material / applicable AY.)

Treatment cheat-sheet

Item	Job-caused	General/normal	Abnormal
Idle time	Direct (to job)	Factory overhead	Costing P&L
Overtime premium	Direct (to job)	Factory overhead	Costing P&L

Halsey vs Rowan — the three facts - Below 50% time saved → **Rowan pays more**. - At exactly 50% time saved (T = ½S) → **equal**. - Above 50% time saved → **Halsey pays more**. - Rowan bonus **cannot exceed** the time wage (T × R); maximised at 50% saved.

Memory hooks: *Rowan = Ratio (saved/standard); Halsey = Half. Cause decides charge; abnormal is spotlighted; guaranteed wage is the floor. Worker counts rupees per hour; firm counts rupees per unit. Taylor punishes the slow; Merrick never does; Gantt jumps; Emerson ramps.*

Q&A — Employee (Labour) Cost

> CA Intermediate · Cost & Management Accounting · Exam-oriented question bank. Every question is followed immediately by a complete model answer. All figures reconcile (self-verified). Currency: Rupees (₹). Formulas per ICAI.

Section A — Concept Check (short answer)

A1. Distinguish time-keeping from time-booking. Time-keeping records an employee's **attendance** — arrival and departure from the factory gate (for wage/payroll purposes). Time-booking records **how that attended time was spent** on jobs/operations/idle time (for cost allocation). Time-keeping answers "was he present?"; time-booking answers "on what did he work?". The two are reconciled daily — booked time should equal gate time.

A2. Define idle time and distinguish normal vs abnormal idle time with treatment. Idle time is the time for which wages are paid but no production is obtained. **Normal idle time** (tea breaks, machine setup, unavoidable delay) is inherent and uncontrollable — charged to production by **inflating the labour hour rate**. **Abnormal idle time** (strikes, power failure, machine breakdown, material shortage) is avoidable — charged to **Costing Profit & Loss A/c**, not to product cost.

A3. What is overtime premium? How is it treated when caused by (a) customer's urgent order, (b) general factory policy, (c) abnormal reasons? Overtime premium is the **extra rate** paid over the normal rate for hours beyond normal working hours. Treatment of the *premium* (not the whole overtime wage): - (a) At customer's request → charge to that **job/order** directly. - (b) General/seasonal pressure → treat as **factory overhead**. - (c) Abnormal causes → charge to **Costing P&L A/c**. The normal-rate portion of overtime hours is always direct wages.

A4. State the three methods of measuring labour turnover. 1. **Separation Method** = (Separations ÷ Average number of workers) × 100. 2. **Replacement Method** = (Replacements ÷ Average number of workers) × 100. 3. **Flux Method** = (Separations + Accessions ÷ Average number of workers) × 100. (Accessions = replacements + new recruitments.) Average workers = (Opening + Closing) ÷ 2.

A5. Differentiate preventive costs from replacement costs of labour turnover. Preventive costs are incurred to *keep* workers from leaving — welfare, medical, pension, better working conditions, personnel administration. **Replacement costs** arise *because* workers left — recruitment, training, loss of output during learning, extra scrap/spoilage, accidents of new workers. Good management raises preventive spend to cut replacement cost.

A6. Under Halsey and Rowan, what fraction of time saved goes to the worker? - **Halsey**: worker gets **50% of time saved** (guaranteed time wage + 50% bonus on time saved). - **Rowan**: bonus = (Time saved ÷ Time allowed) × Time taken × rate — the worker's share of time-saved *varies*; it is proportionately smaller as savings grow, capping earnings and protecting against loose rates.

A7. Write the standard formulas. - Halsey earnings = (T × R) + 50% × (S − T) × R, where S = std/allowed time, T = time taken. - Rowan earnings = (T × R) + [(S − T) ÷ S] × T × R. - Effective hourly rate = Total earnings ÷ Time taken. - Taylor: below standard output → 83% (or given low) of piece rate; at/above → 125% (or given high) of piece rate.

Section B — Graded Computational Problems

B1 (Easy) — Straight piece rate vs guaranteed time

A worker is paid ₹15 per unit; guaranteed day wage ₹600 for an 8-hour day. In a day he produces 36 units.

Solution. Piece earnings = 36 × ₹15 = **₹540**. Guaranteed minimum = **₹600**. Since piece earnings (₹540) < guarantee (₹600), the worker is paid the **guaranteed ₹600**. *Verify:* effective rate = 600 ÷ 8 = ₹75/hr; the ₹60 top-up (600 − 540) is the guarantee cost absorbed by employer.

B2 (Easy–Moderate) — Halsey and Rowan side by side

Standard time = 40 hours; actual time taken = 30 hours; rate = ₹20/hour.

Solution. Time saved S − T = 40 − 30 = 10 hours. Basic wage = 30 × 20 = ₹600.

	Bonus	Total earnings	Effective rate
Halsey (50%)	0.5 × 10 × 20 = ₹100	600 + 100 = **₹700**	700÷30 = **₹23.33**
Rowan	(10÷40) × 30 × 20 = ₹150	600 + 150 = **₹750**	750÷30 = **₹25.00**

Cross-check (Rowan bonus): (Time saved ÷ Time allowed) × wage = (10÷40) × 600 = ₹150. ✓ Rowan pays more here because time saved (25%) is below 50% of allowed time.

B3 (Moderate) — Labour turnover, all three methods

On 1 April a factory had 900 workers; on 30 April, 1,100 workers. During the month 40 workers left, 20 were discharged, and 300 were recruited — of whom 60 replaced those who left/were discharged and 240 were for a new plant expansion.

Solution. Average workers = (900 + 1,100) ÷ 2 = **1,000**. Separations = 40 + 20 = **60**. Replacements = **60**. Accessions = 300 (all joiners).

- Separation rate = 60 ÷ 1,000 × 100 = **6%**
- Replacement rate = 60 ÷ 1,000 × 100 = **6%**
- Flux rate = (60 + 300) ÷ 1,000 × 100 = **36%**

Verify: Closing = 900 − 60 + 300 = 1,140? No — recheck. If 300 recruited and 60 left, closing = 900 − 60 + 300 = 1,140, but given 1,100. So new recruitment must reconcile to closing 1,100.

Reconciled version: Take separations 60, total joiners = closing − opening + separations = 1,100 − 900 + 60 = **260**. Of these, 60 are replacements, 200 new posts. - Separation rate = 60 ÷ 1,000 = **6%** - Replacement rate = 60 ÷ 1,000 = **6%** - Flux rate = (60 + 260) ÷ 1,000 = **32%**

Check: 900 − 60 + 260 = 1,100 = closing. ✓

B4 (Moderate–Hard) — Comparative earnings statement (Time, Piece, Taylor, Halsey, Rowan)

Standard time per unit = 30 minutes. Rate = ₹40/hour. In an 8-hour day, worker produces 20 units. Piece rate = ₹20/unit. Taylor: 80% of piece rate below standard, 120% at/above standard.

Solution. Standard time for 20 units = 20 × 30 min = 600 min = **10 hours** (allowed). Time taken = **8 hours**. Time saved = 10 − 8 = **2 hours**. Standard output in 8 hr = 8×2 = 16 units; actual 20 units → **above standard.**

System	Working	Earnings
Time wage	8 × 40	**₹320**
Straight piece	20 × 20	**₹400**
Taylor (above std → 120%)	20 × (20×1.20) = 20×24	**₹480**
Halsey	(8×40) + 0.5×2×40 = 320 + 40	**₹360**
Rowan	320 + (2÷10)×8×40 = 320 + 64	**₹384**

Verify Rowan: (2÷10)×(8×40) = 0.2×320 = ₹64. ✓ Effective rates: Halsey 360÷8 = ₹45; Rowan 384÷8 = ₹48/hr.

B5 (Exam-Hard) — Full reconciliation with idle time and overtime

A worker's week (48 normal hours) records: attended 52 hours (4 overtime). Booked time: Job A 30 hr, Job B 14 hr, normal idle 3 hr, abnormal idle (power cut) 5 hr. Normal rate ₹50/hr; overtime paid at double rate (i.e., premium = ₹50/hr extra). Overtime arose from general factory pressure.

Solution.

Step 1 — Reconcile time. Booked = 30 + 14 + 3 + 5 = 52 hr = attended. ✓

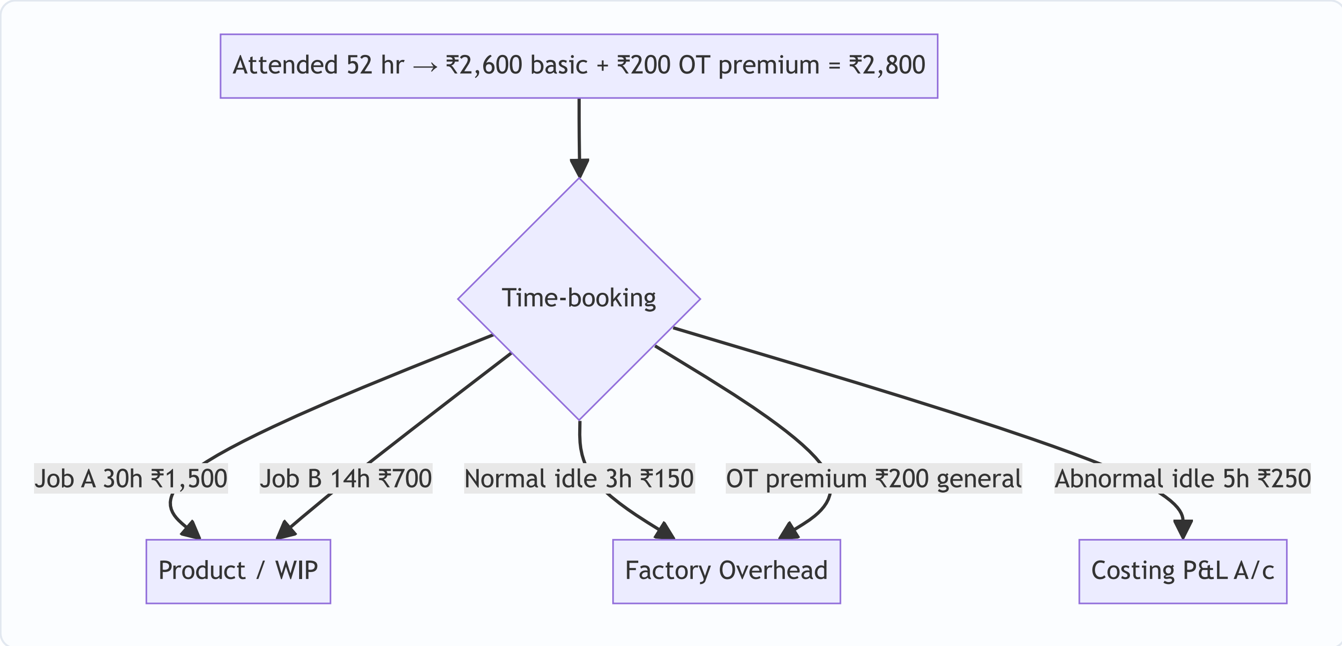
Step 2 — Basic wages (all hours at normal rate). 52 × ₹50 = **₹2,600**.

Step 3 — Overtime premium. 4 hr × ₹50 = **₹200** → general pressure → **factory overhead**.

Step 4 — Allocate wages.

Element	Hours	Amount (₹)	Charged to
Job A direct	30	1,500	Job A (WIP)
Job B direct	14	700	Job B (WIP)
Normal idle	3	150	Factory OH (in labour rate)
Abnormal idle	5	250	Costing P&L A/c
OT premium	—	200	Factory OH
Total	52 hr	**2,800**	

Verify total paid: Basic 2,600 + OT premium 200 = **₹2,800**. ✓ Product-charged direct wages = ₹2,200; overheads absorb ₹350; P&L absorbs ₹250.



Section C — Past-Paper-Style Full Questions

C1. Efficiency-based incentive with cost per unit

Standard output = 8 units/hour. A worker works 45 hours in a week and produces 400 units. Rate ₹60/hour. Under Rowan, compute earnings, effective hourly rate, and labour cost per unit. Compare with Halsey.

Model answer. Standard time for 400 units = 400 ÷ 8 = **50 hours** allowed. Time taken = **45 hours**. Time saved = 50 − 45 = **5 hours**. Basic wage = 45 × 60 = **₹2,700**.

- **Rowan bonus** = (5 ÷ 50) × 45 × 60 = 0.1 × 2,700 = **₹270**. Total = 2,700 + 270 = **₹2,970**. Effective rate = 2,970 ÷ 45 = **₹66/hr**. Cost/unit = 2,970 ÷ 400 = **₹7.425**.
- **Halsey bonus** = 0.5 × 5 × 60 = **₹150**. Total = **₹2,850**. Cost/unit = 2,850 ÷ 400 = **₹7.125**.

Comment: Rowan pays ₹120 more and costs ₹0.30 more per unit here (time saved 10% < 50% of allowed). Rowan protects the employer when rates are loose; Halsey is cheaper at low efficiency.

C2. Labour turnover cost and profit impact

A company's labour turnover caused output loss of 30,000 units in a year. Contribution per unit ₹8. Replacement cost ₹1,20,000; preventive cost ₹80,000. Had turnover been avoided by spending an extra ₹60,000 on preventive measures, output loss would have been nil. Advise.

Model answer. Loss of contribution from turnover = 30,000 × ₹8 = **₹2,40,000**. **Present separation-related cost** = Replacement ₹1,20,000 + lost contribution ₹2,40,000 = **₹3,60,000**. **Cost if prevented** = extra preventive spend ₹60,000, output loss nil. **Net saving from prevention** = 3,60,000 − 60,000 = **₹3,00,000**.

Advice: Spend the additional ₹60,000 on preventive measures. The ₹60,000 investment averts ₹3,60,000 of replacement plus lost-contribution cost, a net gain of **₹3,00,000**. Labour turnover is worth reducing whenever preventive cost < replacement + contribution loss.

C3. Wages reconciliation / gross wages computation

An employee's card shows: basic pay ₹18,000/month; dearness allowance 20% of basic; employer PF 12% of basic; production bonus ₹1,500; overtime wages ₹2,200 (of which premium portion ₹700 due to a customer's rush order). He worked 200 productive hours in the month. Compute the direct labour cost charged to jobs and the total employer cost.

Model answer.

Gross earnings to employee: Basic 18,000 + DA (20%×18,000=3,600) + bonus 1,500 + overtime 2,200 = **₹25,300**. Add employer PF 12% × 18,000 = **₹2,160**. **Total employer cost** = 25,300 + 2,160 = **₹27,460**.

Charge to jobs (direct labour): Direct portion = Basic + DA + bonus + normal-rate part of OT + employer PF (treated as labour cost) = 18,000 + 3,600 + 1,500 + (2,200 − 700) + 2,160 = **₹26,760**. The **OT premium ₹700** (customer's rush order) is charged **directly to that job**, so it is also product cost but identified separately, not spread as overhead.

Verify: 26,760 + 700 = ₹27,460 = total employer cost. ✓ Effective productive rate = 27,460 ÷ 200 = **₹137.30/hr**.

Section D — MCQs and Case Scenarios

D1. Idle time arising from a power failure is charged to: (a) Product cost via labour rate (b) Factory overhead (c) Costing P&L A/c (d) Administration overhead **Ans: (c).** Power failure is abnormal idle time — excluded from cost, written to Costing P&L.

D2. Under the Rowan plan, the maximum bonus a worker can earn as a percentage of time wage: (a) is unlimited (b) is 50% when time saved = time taken (c) equals time saved% always (d) is fixed at 33⅓% **Ans: (b).** Rowan bonus = (saved÷allowed)×wage; it is maximised (50% of basic) when time taken = time saved, i.e., allowed = 2×taken.

D3. Labour turnover under the flux method includes: (a) only separations (b) only replacements (c) separations + accessions (d) discharges only **Ans: (c).** Flux captures total movement — those leaving and those joining.

D4. Overtime premium paid due to the company's own inefficiency/scheduling should be treated as: (a) direct wages (b) factory overhead (c) costing P&L A/c (d) job cost **Ans: (c).** Overtime caused by abnormal reasons/management fault is charged to Costing P&L, not product.

D5. Case. A worker (rate ₹25/hr) is allowed 12 hours for a job but finishes in 8. Under Halsey his total earnings are: (a) ₹200 (b) ₹250 (c) ₹300 (d) ₹225 **Ans: (b).** Basic 8×25=200; bonus 0.5×(12−8)×25=50; total **₹250**.

D6. Case. Same data as D5, under Rowan: (a) ₹250 (b) ₹266.67 (c) ₹300 (d) ₹275 **Ans: (b).** Bonus = (4÷12)×8×25 = ₹66.67; total 200+66.67 = **₹266.67**.

D7. Time-booking is primarily used for: (a) payroll preparation (b) cost allocation to jobs (c) statutory PF filing (d) gate security **Ans: (b).** Time-booking allocates attended time to jobs/overhead; time-keeping serves payroll.

D8. Which cost is a *preventive* cost of labour turnover? (a) Cost of training new recruits (b) Loss of output during learning (c) Medical & welfare services (d) Recruitment advertising **Ans: (c).** Welfare/medical retains workers (preventive); the others arise after separation (replacement).

Quick-Revision Formula Strip

Item	Formula
Halsey earnings	$T \cdot R + \frac{1}{2}(S - T) \cdot R$
Rowan earnings	$T \cdot R + [(S - T)/S] \cdot T \cdot R$
Rowan bonus (alt)	(Time saved / Time allowed) × Time wage
Effective rate	Total earnings / Time taken
Separation rate	Separations / Avg workers ×100
Replacement rate	Replacements / Avg workers ×100
Flux rate	(Separations + Accessions) / Avg workers ×100
Avg workers	(Opening + Closing) / 2

Treatment map: Normal idle → in labour rate/OH · Abnormal idle → P&L · OT premium: customer→job, general→OH, abnormal→P&L.

Chapter 04 — Overheads (Absorption Costing)

1. The Problem — the cost that refuses to attach itself to a product

Imagine you run a workshop that makes two things: heavy steel gates and delicate steel window grills. When a customer asks "what did *my* gate cost?", some answers are easy. You can walk to the steel rack, weigh the bars that went into that gate, and read the price tag. You can look at the job card and see the welder spent four hours on it at ₹150 an hour. Steel and welder wages are **direct** — they physically point at one gate. No argument possible.

But the workshop also incurs costs that stubbornly refuse to point at any single gate:

- The factory rent of ₹40,000 a month.
- The supervisor's salary of ₹30,000 — he watched over both gates and grills.
- Electricity of ₹18,000 running lights, cranes and machines.
- Depreciation on the welding machines, the grinder, the paint booth.
- Cotton waste, lubricants, small tools, the storekeeper's wages, the timekeeper.

These are **overheads** — indirect material + indirect labour + indirect expenses. The month's total is real money that must be recovered from customers or the business dies. Yet not one rupee of it announces which gate it belongs to. The rent does not shrink if you make one less gate this Tuesday. The supervisor's ₹30,000 is a single lump watching over hundreds of jobs.

Here is the managerial pain in one sentence: **the price you quote, the profit you report, and the "which product should we push?" decision all depend on a per-unit cost — but a huge slice of cost has no natural per-unit.** Financial accounting shrugs; it only needs the *total* factory cost for the P&L and one closing-stock figure. It never has to say what one gate cost. Cost accounting must, because a manager cannot quote a price on "the factory spent ₹1,08,000 this month."

So the entire machinery of this chapter exists to solve one decision-problem:

> **Given a pile of indirect cost that belongs to no single product, how do we fairly and defensibly load a slice of it onto each unit — so we can price, value stock, and judge product profitability?**

Everything that follows — allocation, apportionment, re-apportionment of service departments, overhead rates, under/over-absorption — is a step in dragging that shapeless pile of indirect cost down onto the cost of one gate.

Sharpening the definition — why "indirect" is a *relative* word, not an absolute one. A cost is not born direct or indirect; it *becomes* one relative to the cost object you are measuring and to whether tracing it is economically worth the effort. The same grease can be a *direct* material if you are costing a single overhauled turbine (you meter the exact litres) but an *indirect* material if you are costing thousands of small castings (metering per casting costs more than the grease is worth). This is the **"convenience and materiality"** test that ICAI stresses: an item is treated as overhead when tracing it to the unit is either *impossible* (rent) or *not worthwhile* (a dab of glue per matchbox). Two examiner points fall out of this. First, a cost can be direct in one firm and indirect in another for the identical physical item. Second, "small value + shared use" is the fingerprint of overhead — nails, thread, coolant, small tools. Do not call something overhead merely because it is small; call it overhead because it is small *and* not economically traceable to one unit.

Where each overhead is ultimately recovered — the three destinations. Keep in mind from the start that not all overhead travels the same road to the customer. **Factory (works) overhead** is baked into product cost and therefore into *closing stock* — an unsold gate carries its share of factory rent on the balance sheet. **Administration overhead** is usually treated as a period cost recovered on cost of production (ICAI's default), and **Selling & Distribution overhead** is recovered only on goods *actually sold* — it never sits in stock, because you cannot "store" a salesman's commission. This single distinction — *does the overhead attach to stock or not?* — decides whether under/over-absorption of that overhead even affects inventory valuation, and it recurs in the cost sheet, in marginal costing, and in reconciliation.

---

2. The Core Idea — the restaurant bill split among friends

Six friends eat dinner. Three ordered individual dishes they can point to — that is *direct* cost, billed to the person. But the table shared two pizzas, a pitcher of juice, and the restaurant added a service charge and GST. Nobody "owns" the service charge. How do you split it?

You wouldn't split the shared items *equally per head* if one friend only sipped water — that's unfair. You look for a **fair basis**: split the pizza by slices eaten, the service charge in proportion to each person's own bill. You are searching for the driver that *causes* the shared cost, and you split in proportion to that driver.

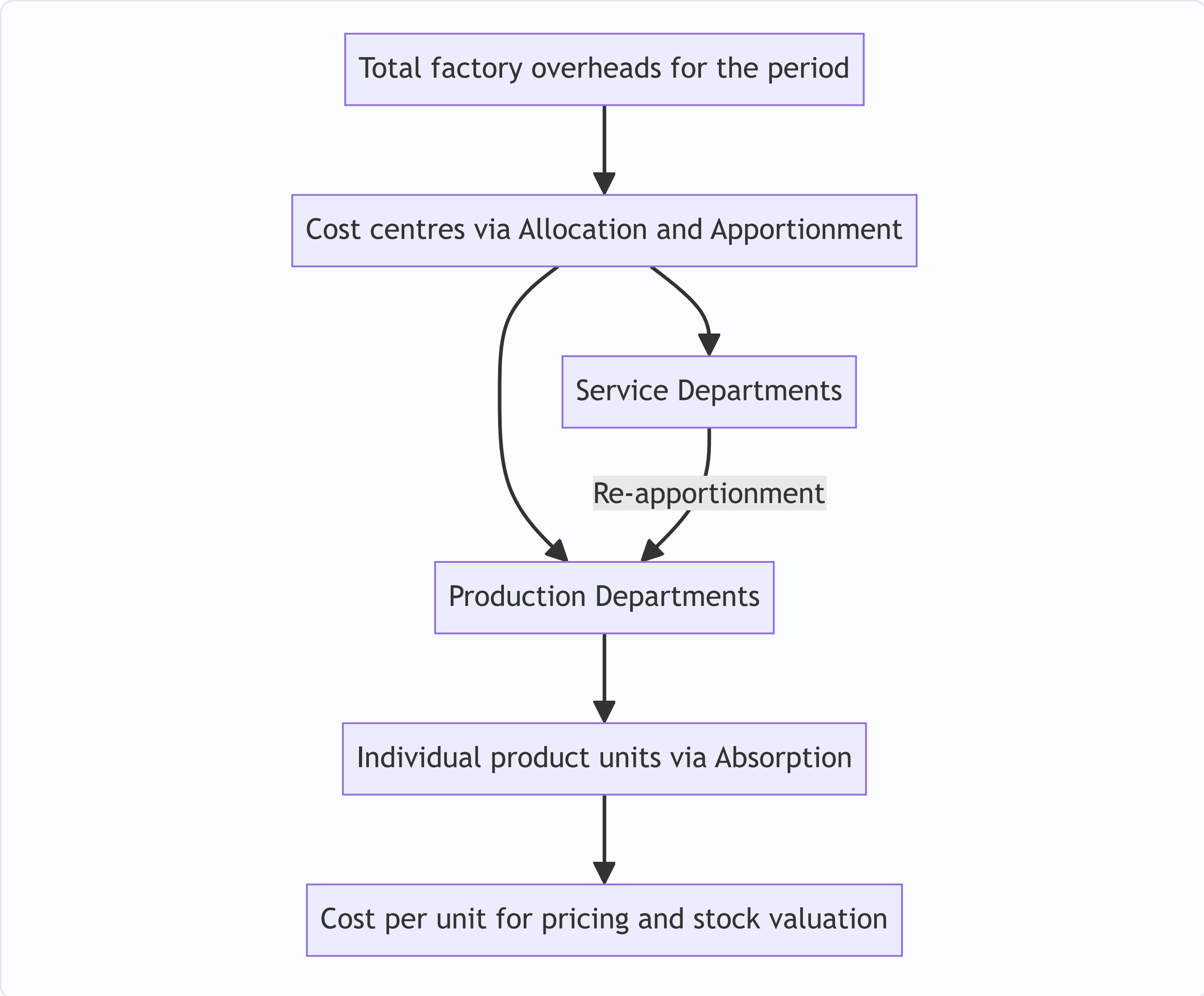
That is the whole philosophy of overhead absorption:

1. **Allocation** — some shared costs actually do belong wholly to one table (a birthday cake ordered for table 4). Charge it there directly.
2. **Apportionment** — costs shared across tables (the AC electricity) are split among tables on a *fair basis* (floor area, number of diners).
3. **Absorption** — finally, each table's share is divided among the diners at that table so each person pays a per-plate amount.

Notice the two-stage descent: shapeless total → department → product. Overheads flow **from the whole factory, into cost centres, then into units**. Keep this staircase image in your head; the technical terms are just the named steps of this staircase.

The two "unfairnesses" this analogy protects against — over-absorption and cross-subsidy. The water-sipper problem is a *cross-subsidy*: split the shared cost on the wrong basis and one diner silently pays for another. In a factory the equivalent is a labour-light, machine-heavy product being charged on labour hours — it dodges the cost it truly causes and a labour-heavy product picks up the slack. The whole reason we hunt for a *cause-and-effect* basis is to kill cross-subsidy. If you remember only one sentence from this section: **the "fair basis" is always the thing that best explains *why the cost went up*, not the thing that is easiest to measure.**

Figure 1 — the descent of overhead cost from a factory-wide pile down to a single unit.



3. Why it's built this way — the logic behind the machinery

Before any formula, understand *why the method has the shape it has*. Four design decisions drive everything.

Design decision 1 — Why go through departments at all? Why not dump total overhead ÷ total units? Because products don't consume the factory uniformly. A gate hogs the welding department; a grill hogs the assembly bench. If we averaged all overhead over all units blindly, the cheap-to-make grill would subsidise the machine-hungry gate, and vice versa. **Routing overhead through departments lets each product pick up cost only from the departments it actually passes through, and in proportion to how heavily it uses them.** Fairness requires the department detour.

Design decision 2 — Why separate "production" from "service" departments? A production department (Machining, Assembly) directly works on the product — units flow through it, so units can absorb its cost. A **service department** (Stores, Maintenance, Canteen, Power House) never touches the product; it *serves the other departments*. Units cannot absorb Maintenance cost directly because no product "passes through" Maintenance. So service-department cost must first be pushed onto the production departments it serves, and only then reach the product. This is **secondary distribution / re-apportionment**, and it exists purely because service departments have no units of their own to soak up cost.

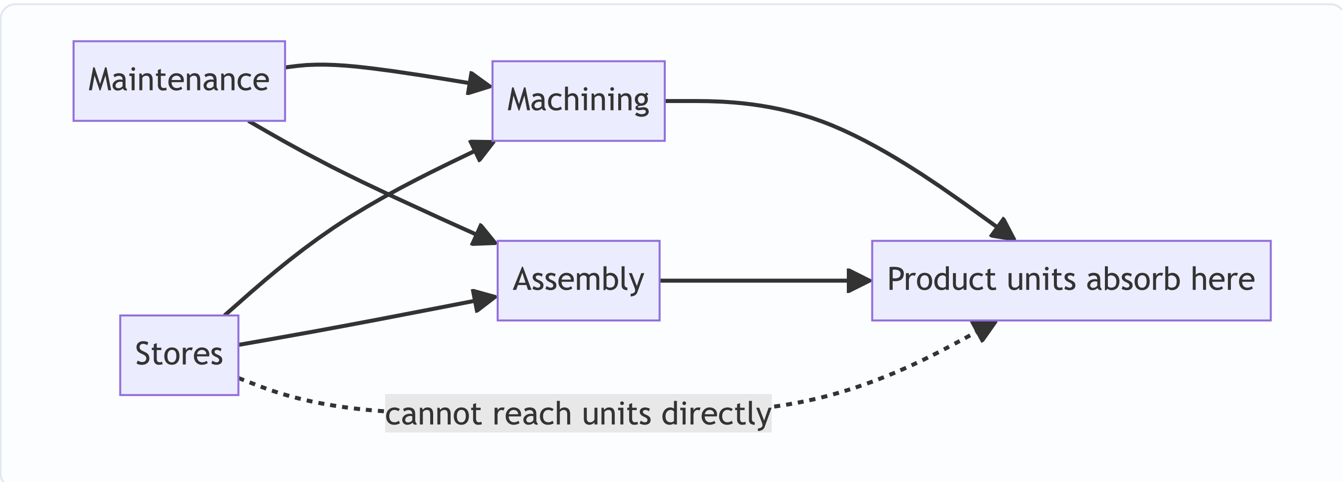
Design decision 3 — Why an absorption *rate* fixed in advance? Because managers must quote prices *before* the month ends, when actual overhead and actual output are still unknown. You cannot tell a customer "come back on the 31st and I'll compute the real overhead." So we compute a **pre-determined rate** = *budgeted* overhead ÷ *budgeted* activity, and apply it to every job as it happens. Speed and consistency beat perfect accuracy. The price of using a pre-fixed rate is that it will never exactly match actuals — which is precisely the source of **under/over-absorption** (Section 4.6). That "error" is not a mistake; it is the unavoidable cost of being able to price in real time.

Design decision 4 — Why choose the absorption *basis* carefully (labour hours vs machine hours vs %)? Because the basis is our theory of *what causes the overhead*. In a hand-welding shop, overhead rises with labour hours — so absorb on labour hours. In an automated CNC shop, overhead (power, depreciation, maintenance) rises with machine running time — so absorb on machine hours. Pick the basis that best mirrors cause-and-effect, or you systematically over-charge one product and under-charge another.

Design decision 5 — Why is the *denominator* (activity level) itself a policy choice? Even after picking machine hours as the base, you must choose *which* level of machine hours goes into the pre-determined rate: theoretical maximum capacity, practical capacity, normal (average long-run) capacity, or budgeted capacity for this one period. ICAI's recommended anchor is **normal capacity** — the capacity the plant can achieve on average over a period long enough to iron out seasonal and cyclical swings, after allowing for *normal* unavoidable idle time (holidays, maintenance, setup). Why normal and not budgeted? Because if you divide fixed overhead by a *low* budgeted volume in a bad year, the per-unit rate balloons, you over-price into a falling market, sell even less, and spiral. Using **normal capacity** stabilises the rate across the cycle and deliberately *leaves* the cost of idle capacity to be exposed as a separate loss rather than hidden inside product cost. This is the deep reason under-absorption caused by working below normal capacity is treated as a *period loss* (idle-capacity cost), not smeared onto the units that happened to get made.

Design decision 6 — Why do we treat fixed and variable overhead differently at heart? Variable overhead genuinely rises and falls with activity, so *any* sensible activity base recovers it cleanly. Fixed overhead is a lump that does not move with output; its per-unit figure is entirely an artefact of the volume you divide by. That means **all the drama of under/over-absorption is fundamentally a fixed-overhead phenomenon.** Grasping this now makes Standard Costing's *fixed overhead volume variance* feel like an old friend rather than a new formula.

Figure 2 — the two families of departments and why service cost must take a detour.



4. Full Technical Content

4.0 Vocabulary — nail these three verbs first

Term	Meaning	Test to identify it
Allocation	Charging the *whole* of an overhead item to *one* cost centre, because it was incurred *wholly* for that centre.	"Can I trace 100% of this item to one department?" If yes → allocate. E.g. salary of the Machining foreman → Machining.
Apportionment	Splitting an overhead item that is *common* to several cost centres among them on a *fair basis*.	"Is this shared by many departments?" If yes → apportion. E.g. factory rent shared by all departments on floor-area.
Absorption	Charging the overhead of a *production* department onto the *units/jobs* passing through it, via an overhead rate.	The final step: department overhead → per unit.

Mnemonic: **Allocate whole, Apportion shared, Absorb into units.** Allocation and apportionment together are called **primary distribution**. Re-apportionment of service departments is **secondary distribution**.

Allocation vs apportionment — the razor the examiner tests. The single distinction is *traceability of the whole*. If an entire cost item arose *because that one department exists*, allocate it (100%, no splitting). If the item arose for the factory generally and merely happens to benefit several departments, apportion it (split on a basis). The give-aways: a *separately metered* power supply to one shop → allocate; a *single* factory electricity bill → apportion. The foreman of Machining → allocate his salary to Machining; the works manager who oversees all shops → apportion his salary (usually on number of employees or direct wages). A trap: examiners give you "power ₹50,000, of which Dept A is separately metered at ₹12,000" — you *allocate* ₹12,000 to A and *apportion* the remaining ₹38,000. Mixing allocation and apportionment inside one line item is deliberately tested.

A fourth verb you must not confuse — *collection*. Before any allocation happens, overheads are first *collected* and *codified* (each overhead given a standing order number / cost account number so it can be gathered from invoices, wage sheets, and journals). Collection is the book-keeping gathering stage; allocation/apportionment is the *spreading* stage. Occasionally a theory question asks the difference — collection = accumulate by nature, allocation = charge to a centre.

4.1 Classification recap — what counts as overhead

Overhead = **Indirect Material + Indirect Labour + Indirect Expenses**. It is classified several ways, and the exam expects you to know *why each classification exists*:

- **By function:** Factory (works) OH, Administration OH, Selling & Distribution OH. *Why:* different functions are recovered differently — factory OH goes into product cost and stock; S&D OH does not touch stock, it is charged when goods are sold; administration OH is generally treated as a period cost recovered on cost of production.
- **By behaviour:** Fixed, Variable, Semi-variable. *Why:* only variable OH truly changes with output; fixed OH per unit is a fiction that depends on volume — the seed of under/over-absorption.
- **By element:** Indirect material, indirect labour, indirect expenses. *Why:* mirrors the direct trio and lets you build overhead the same way you build prime cost.

- **By control:** Controllable vs uncontrollable at a given level. *Why:* for responsibility accounting — you only blame a manager for what he can control.
- **By normality:** Normal vs abnormal overhead. *Why:* normal overhead is a legitimate part of product cost; abnormal overhead (fire, strike, flood) is a period loss written to Costing P&L. This classification is the hinge of the whole under/over-absorption *treatment* table.

Splitting semi-variable overhead — the four exam methods. A semi-variable overhead (e.g. maintenance, which has a standing crew plus usage-driven parts) must often be split into its fixed and variable halves. Know these four:

1. **High–Low method** — take the highest and lowest activity periods; variable rate per unit = (Cost at high − Cost at low) ÷ (Units at high − Units at low); then fixed = total cost − variable at either level. Fast, but relies on just two points, so an abnormal high/low period distorts it.
2. **Comparison / range method** — similar two-point logic, comparing two representative periods.
3. **Least-squares regression** — fits a line to *all* data points; most accurate, least examined numerically at Inter level but nameable.
4. **Graphical / scatter method** — plot cost against activity, eyeball the line, read the intercept (fixed) and slope (variable).

Worked micro-example (High–Low). Maintenance cost was ₹46,000 at 8,000 machine hours and ₹34,000 at 5,000 machine hours. Variable rate = (46,000 − 34,000) ÷ (8,000 − 5,000) = 12,000 ÷ 3,000 = **₹4 per hour**. Fixed = 46,000 − (4 × 8,000) = 46,000 − 32,000 = **₹14,000**. Check at the low point: 14,000 + 4 × 5,000 = 34,000 ✓.

4.2 Primary distribution — building the overhead distribution summary

The task: take every item of factory overhead and spread it across *all* cost centres (production + service) using allocation where possible and apportionment (on a fair basis) where not.

Choosing the apportionment basis — the "why" behind each:

Overhead item	Fair basis of apportionment	Reason (cause-and-effect)
Rent, rates, building repairs, building depreciation	Floor area (sq. ft.)	Space consumed causes the cost
Lighting, heating	Floor area or number of light points	Roughly space-driven
Power / electricity (machine)	HP × machine hours, or metered KWH	Machine load causes power draw
Depreciation, insurance of plant	Capital value of plant / machinery	Costlier plant depreciates more
Supervision, canteen, welfare, ESI, PF, labour welfare	Number of employees	People-driven cost
Stores service, material handling	Value or weight of materials issued	Material throughput drives it
Indirect wages, general OH	Direct wages / direct labour hours	Labour intensity
Fire insurance of stock	Average value of stock held	Value at risk drives premium
Personnel / time-keeping / canteen	Number of employees	People-driven
Delivery / distribution	Weight, volume, or tonne-km of goods	Physical movement drives it

A subtlety examiners love — floor area vs *volume* vs light points. Rent is floor *area*. Heating is better on *volume* (a tall bay needs more heat than its footprint suggests) if the data is given. Lighting is best on *number of light points* or *wattage* if provided, else floor area. When the question hands you a more specific driver, you are expected to *use the more specific one*; defaulting to floor area when "number of light points" is supplied loses marks. The rule: **always pick the most cause-specific basis the data permits.**

The Primary Distribution Summary is a table: rows = overhead items, columns = departments, plus a Basis column. Allocated items sit in one column; apportioned items are split across columns by the ratio.

Two cross-checks you must run every time. (1) Each *row* must sum across departments to the original item total. (2) The *primary total* row must sum to the grand total of all overheads. If either fails, you have a ratio or arithmetic slip. Building these two ticks into your muscle memory catches ~80% of avoidable exam errors here.

4.3 Secondary distribution — re-apportioning service departments

Now the service-department totals (from primary distribution) must be pushed onto production departments, because units can only absorb from production departments. There are four methods; the exam favours the last two.

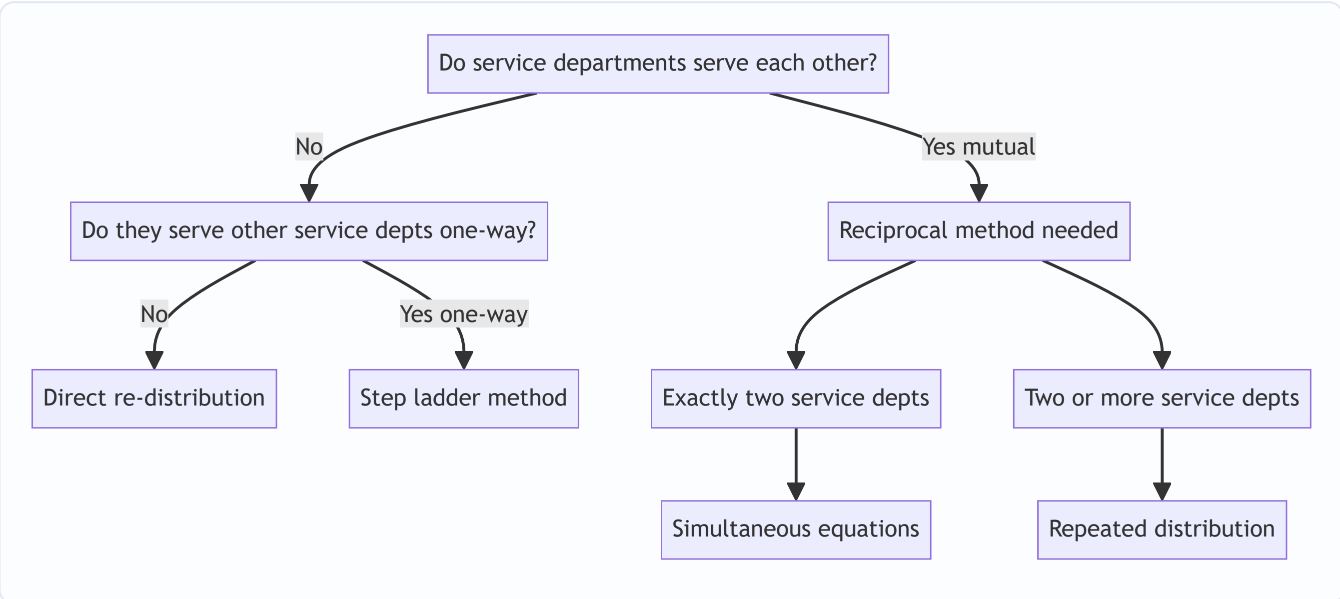
(a) Direct re-distribution method. Service department cost is apportioned *only to production departments*, ignoring service-to-service usage. Simplest, least accurate. Use when the question says to ignore inter-service work. Practical note: because service-to-service usage is ignored, you must *re-base the percentages on production departments only* — e.g. if Stores served P1 40%, P2 40%, S2 20%, then under the direct method you drop the 20% and split the whole Stores cost 40:40 → i.e. 50:50 between P1 and P2.

(b) Step-ladder (step) method. Rank service departments by how many others they serve (the one serving the most goes first). Re-apportion the first service department to *all* remaining departments (production **and** the other service departments), then the next, and so on — but once a service department is "closed," nothing comes back to it. Handles one-way service but not mutual service. Tie-breaker when two service departments serve the same number of others: start with the one having the **larger overhead** (some texts use larger cost or larger service value — state your assumption).

(c) Reciprocal service methods — for mutual service. When service departments serve *each other* (Maintenance services the Power House, and the Power House powers Maintenance), we need to recognise the two-way flow. Three techniques (the exam uses the first two most):

- **Simultaneous equation method** — set up an equation for each service department's *total* cost = its own primary cost + share received from the other service department(s). Solve the simultaneous equations, then distribute the solved totals to production departments. Best for exactly two service departments; extends to three with three equations.
- **Repeated distribution method** — keep re-apportioning the service departments' balances back and forth across *all* departments in the given ratios, round after round; the service-department figures shrink each cycle until they are negligible (round off). Best when there are two or more mutually-serving service departments and the examiner says "repeated distribution."
- **Trial-and-error method** — a lighter cousin of repeated distribution: iteratively estimate each service department's total, feeding shares back, until successive estimates stop changing. Rarely asked numerically but nameable.

Figure 3 — decision tree for which secondary-distribution method to use.



Simultaneous equation setup (the reasoning). Let X and Y be the *final total* overhead of the two service departments after they absorb each other's share. If department X's own primary overhead is a, and it receives p% of Y, then:

```
X = a + p·Y
Y = b + q·X
```

Substitute and solve. The logic: X's true cost isn't just its own — it includes the slice Y dumps onto it, which itself depends on X. That circularity is exactly what the simultaneous equations untangle.

Extending to three mutually-serving service departments. With S1, S2, S3 you write three equations, one per department, each equal to its own primary cost plus the shares it receives from the other two. Solve the 3×3 system (substitution or elimination). The distribution step is identical: apply each *solved* total to production departments using the original percentages. The examiner rarely goes beyond three because the algebra explodes.

Why the two reciprocal methods must agree. Both are just different arithmetic for the same accounting truth: every rupee of service cost must end up on production departments, and the two-way flows must be honoured. Simultaneous equations solve the circularity in closed form; repeated distribution converges to the same fixed point by brute iteration. If your two answers differ by more than rounding, one of them is wrong — a free self-check the exam hands you.

4.4 Absorption — turning department overhead into a per-unit rate

Once every production department holds its full overhead (own + service share), we absorb it into units. **Overhead absorption rate:**

```
Overhead Absorption Rate = Overhead of the production department ÷ Total quantity of the chose
```

The six standard bases, each with its "when to use it and why":

Method	Formula	Use when / why
1. Percentage of Direct Material cost	(Prod OH ÷ Direct Material) × 100	Rarely fair — material price swings distort it; only if material and OH move together
2. Percentage of Direct Wages	(Prod OH ÷ Direct Wages) × 100	When labour rates are uniform and time-driven OH dominates; simple but ignores that a high-paid worker isn't slower
3. Percentage of Prime Cost	(Prod OH ÷ Prime Cost) × 100	Blends the flaws of the two above; seldom ideal
4. Labour Hour Rate	Prod OH ÷ Direct Labour Hours	**Best for labour-intensive** work — OH driven by *time* spent, not wage rate
5. Machine Hour Rate	Prod OH ÷ Machine Hours	**Best for machine-intensive** work — power, depreciation, maintenance track running time
6. Rate per Unit of output	Prod OH ÷ Units produced	Only when output is *homogeneous* (one product)

Why labour-hour and machine-hour rates are preferred: overhead is fundamentally *time-related* (rent accrues by the hour, depreciation by usage, supervision by shift-length). Money-based bases (% of material/wages) get distorted by price fluctuations that have nothing to do with overhead consumption. Time-based rates track the real cause.

The percentage-basis distortion made concrete. Suppose factory OH is ₹1,00,000 and total direct wages ₹2,00,000, giving a 50% wage-based rate. A job using a ₹500/day skilled worker for 1 day (₹500 wages) absorbs ₹250 OH, while an identical job done in the same 1 day by a ₹300/day worker (₹300 wages) absorbs only ₹150 — even though both jobs occupied the factory for the *same time* and therefore caused the *same* time-related overhead. The wage basis has silently made overhead depend on *who* did the work rather than *how long* it took. That is precisely why the labour-*hour* rate (which charges both jobs equally) is preferred whenever overhead is time-driven.

Machine Hour Rate — the composite build-up. MHR is often built by summing standing charges and running charges per machine hour:

- *Standing / fixed charges* (rent, supervision, insurance for the machine) → apportioned to the machine, then ÷ machine hours.
- *Machine expenses* (power, depreciation, repairs) → per machine hour directly.

MHR = (Standing charges per hour) + (Machine expenses per hour). This is the "**comprehensive machine hour rate**" if it also loads the operator's wages and setup.

Effective vs total machine hours — the trap inside MHR. The denominator is *effective* (productive) machine hours, not the calendar total. From gross available hours you subtract *normal* idle time — setup, maintenance, tea breaks, normal breakdowns — because standing charges must be recovered over the hours the machine can *actually* work. A machine "available" 2,400 hours but productive only 2,200 hours (after 200 hours normal maintenance/setup) recovers its standing charges over **2,200**, not 2,400. If you wrongly use 2,400 you under-recover standing charges by design. But note the asymmetry: *abnormal* idle time (a freak two-week breakdown) is **not** deducted from the denominator — its cost is charged to Costing P&L as an abnormal loss, so that the rate reflects normal running only.

Should machine operators' wages be inside MHR? Two treatments exist and the question dictates which: - If one operator runs *one* machine, the operator's wage can be treated as a *direct* wage of the job (charged separately), so it stays *out* of MHR. - If one operator tends *several* machines, his wage is a shared/indirect cost that belongs *inside* the comprehensive MHR (apportioned per machine hour). Read the question: "comprehensive machine hour rate" usually signals *include* wages and setup; a plain "machine hour rate for overhead" usually means *exclude* direct operator wages.

Depreciation basis inside MHR. For machine hour rate purposes ICAI generally favours depreciation on a *usage/machine-hour* basis (or straight-line spread over effective hours), because MHR is trying to charge cost *per running hour*. Watch for questions giving depreciation as a lump p.a. — divide by effective hours. If a question gives a scrap/residual value, depreciation = (Cost − Residual) ÷ Life, then ÷ effective hours per year.

4.5 Blanket rate vs Departmental rate — one rate or many?

A **blanket (single) overhead rate** = total factory overhead ÷ total factory base (e.g., total labour hours), one rate for the *whole* factory.

A **departmental rate** = a *separate* rate for each production department.

Why departmental rates are almost always better: a blanket rate is only fair if *every* product spends the *same proportion* of time in *every* department. Real products don't. A gate that lives in the expensive Machining department but skips Assembly would, under a blanket rate, be undercharged (it dodges Machining's high rate) while a grill that lives in cheap Assembly gets overcharged. **Blanket rates are acceptable only when there is a single product, or all products flow uniformly through all departments.** Otherwise use departmental rates. This is examinable as a theory question — know the one-line justification.

A numerical feel for the blanket-rate error. Factory OH ₹80,000; Machining OH ₹60,000 over 6,000 hours (₹10/hr) and Assembly OH ₹20,000 over 14,000 hours (₹1.43/hr). Blanket rate = 80,000 ÷ 20,000 = ₹4/hr. Job Alpha spends 8 machining hours + 2 assembly hours (10 hrs). Departmental cost = 8×10 + 2×1.43 = 80 + 2.86 = ₹82.86. Blanket cost = 10 × 4 = ₹40. The blanket rate under-costs the machining-heavy Alpha by more than half — you would price it below cost and lose money on every unit while over-pricing (and losing tenders for) the assembly-heavy jobs. This single contrast is the exam's favourite "explain with figures" prompt.

Even *within* a department you can go finer — cost-centre / machine rates. If one department houses a cheap bench and an expensive CNC, a *single departmental* rate still cross-subsidises. The logical end-point of "get finer for fairness" is a *machine-hour rate per machine* (a cost centre of one machine). The trade-off is always accuracy vs the clerical cost of maintaining many rates — ABC (Activity Based Costing, a later chapter) is this idea pushed to activity level.

4.6 Under- and Over-absorption — the inevitable gap, and what to do with it

Because we absorb using a **pre-determined rate** (budgeted OH ÷ budgeted activity) but reality delivers **actual OH** and **actual activity**, the amount absorbed almost never equals the actual overhead incurred.

```
Overhead absorbed = Pre-determined rate × Actual base achieved
Under/Over absorption = Overhead absorbed − Actual overhead incurred
```

- If **absorbed > actual** → **over-absorption** (we loaded products with more OH than we actually spent; profit understated by cost accounts, needs adding back).
- If **absorbed < actual** → **under-absorption** (products didn't carry enough OH; profit overstated in cost accounts, needs charging).

Why does the gap arise? Two independent causes — you must be able to name them: 1. **Cost (expenditure) variance:** actual overhead spent ≠ budgeted overhead (spent more/less than planned). 2. **Volume variance:** actual activity (hours/units) ≠ budgeted activity — this alone moves the *fixed* overhead recovery, because the fixed OH per unit was calculated on budgeted volume.

Decomposing the gap — a preview of Standard Costing. You can actually *split* total under/over-absorption into these two causes numerically, which examiners sometimes ask even in this chapter:

```
Total gap        = Absorbed − Actual
Expenditure part = Budgeted overhead − Actual overhead
Volume part      = Absorbed − Budgeted overhead
                 = Std rate × (Actual activity − Budgeted activity)
```

The two parts add back to the total gap. This is exactly the *fixed overhead expenditure variance* and *fixed overhead volume variance* you will formalise later — proof that under/over-absorption is the seed of overhead variance analysis.

Treatment — three routes, and WHY each is chosen (ICAI):

Situation	Treatment	Reasoning
Small amount, due to *normal* reasons	Transfer to **Costing P&L Account**	Not worth re-working every cost; write off the normal, expected slippage
Large amount, due to *normal* reasons (wrong estimate of rate/volume)	Use a **supplementary rate** to adjust WIP, finished goods and cost of sales	The products were mis-costed; fairness demands going back and correcting stock values and cost of sales pro-rata
Any amount due to **abnormal** reasons (strike, fire, breakdown, idle capacity)	Transfer to **Costing P&L Account**	Abnormal costs must never distort product cost or stock; they are period losses

Supplementary rate = amount of under/over-absorption ÷ actual base, applied to spread the correction across closing WIP + finished goods + cost of goods sold. Under-absorption → *positive* supplementary rate added to costs; over-absorption → *negative* rate deducted.

Two ways to apply a supplementary rate — and the exam's preference. You can spread the correction either (a) by a *rate per unit/hour* applied to the physical quantity in each of WIP, FG and COGS, or (b) *pro-rata on the value of overhead already absorbed* in each of the three. Both reconcile to the same total; use whichever the data supports. When only percentages of the absorbed-overhead value are given (as in Example 3), use method (b). When units/hours in each bucket are given, method (a) is cleaner.

The idle-capacity nuance — the most-missed "normal but not on product" case. When under-absorption arises purely because the plant worked below **normal capacity** (a demand slump, not a one-off disaster), the associated fixed overhead is an **idle-capacity cost**. ICAI treats the *normal* portion of idle-capacity cost as a period cost written to Costing P&L (it should not inflate the cost of the units that *were* made), while any *abnormal* idle capacity (a strike) is also a period loss. In short, sub-normal working does **not** get spread by supplementary rate onto stock — a subtle exception to the "normal + large → supplementary rate" rule. Read the *cause* before you reach for the supplementary rate.

Figure 4 — treatment logic for under/over-absorbed overhead.

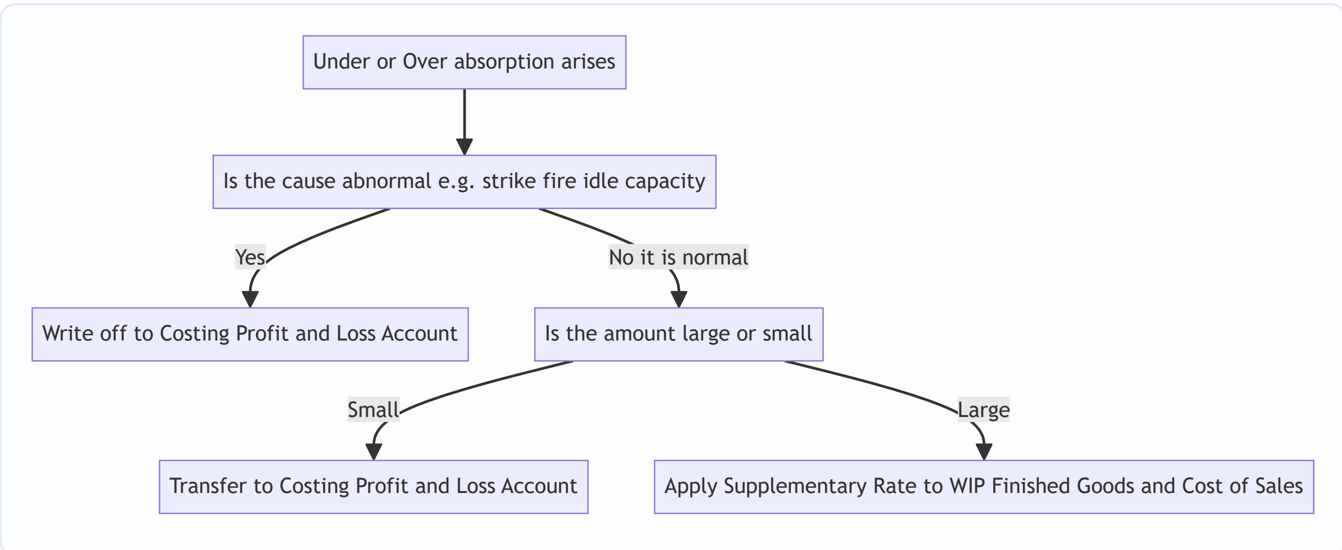
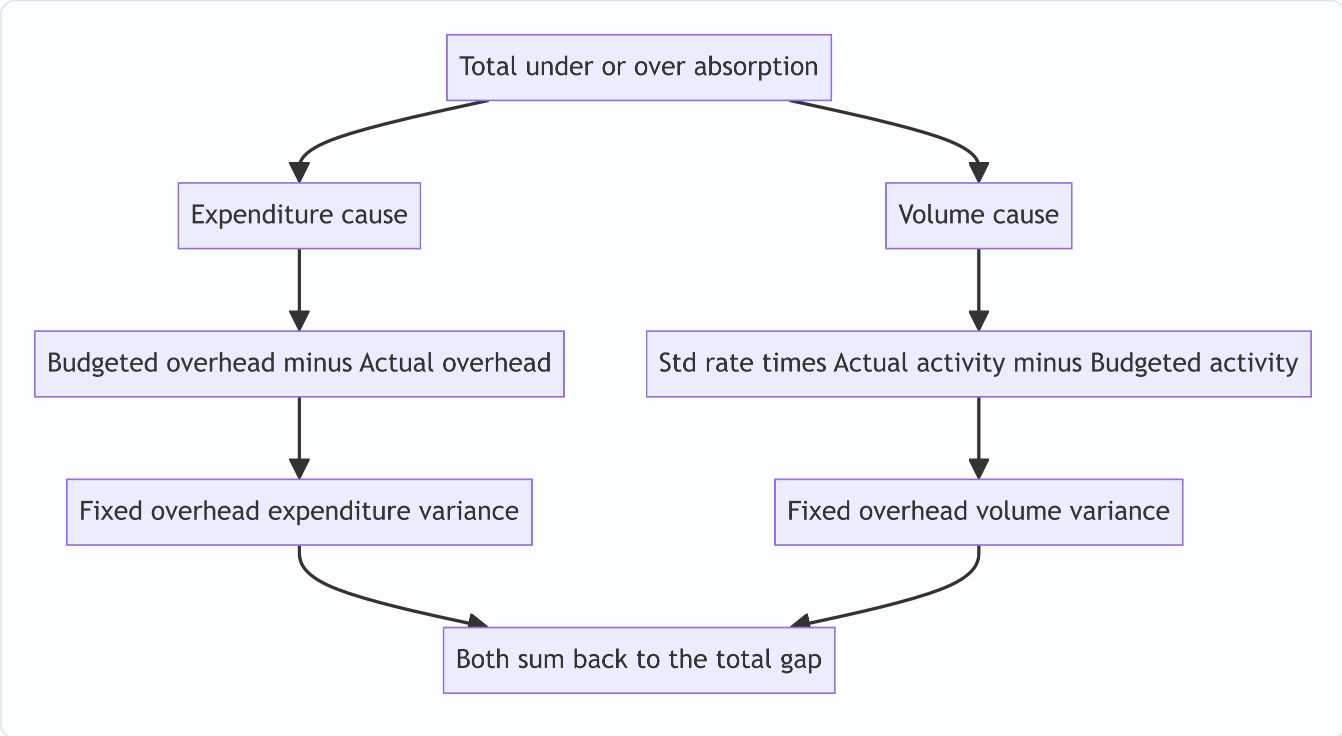


Figure 5 — how the two causes of the gap map onto fixed-overhead variances.



4.7 Administration and Selling & Distribution overhead — the roads less travelled

Factory overhead dominates the exam, but the treatment of the *other two* functional overheads is examinable theory.

Administration overhead — three schools of thought: 1. **Apportion between production and S&D** — treat admin as serving both the factory and the selling function, split on a suitable basis. (Older view.) 2. **Charge to Costing P&L as a period cost** — admin is a policy cost of running the entity, not caused by units; write it off in the period. 3. **Recover as a separate addition on cost of production** — ICAI's common default: build a percentage-of-works-cost rate and add admin overhead as its own line in the cost sheet. Know that admin OH is generally recovered on **cost of production** (or works cost), typically as a percentage.

Selling & Distribution overhead — the key features: - Recovered only on units **sold**, never on units merely produced, so S&D overhead **does not enter stock valuation.** (This is *the* reason it is excluded from closing-stock cost.) - Common recovery bases: percentage of works/production cost, percentage of selling price, or a rate per unit sold. - Distribution-specific costs (freight out, warehousing of finished goods, delivery vans) are best recovered on weight/volume/tonne-km moved.

Why the distinction matters downstream. Because S&D overhead never touches stock, a change in its absorption cannot mis-value inventory — so its under/over-absorption is almost always just written to Costing P&L. Factory overhead, sitting in stock, is the one whose mis-absorption can distort the balance sheet, which is exactly why the supplementary-rate machinery exists mainly for *factory* overhead.

---

5. Worked Examples

Example 1 (warm-up) — Machine Hour Rate from first principles

Problem. A machine in the Machining department has the following annual data. Compute the machine hour rate.

- Cost of machine ₹2,40,000; scrap value ₹20,000; life 10 years.
- Rent of the department ₹36,000 p.a.; the machine occupies 1/4 of the floor area.
- Supervision ₹48,000 p.a.; the machine is 1 of 4 identical machines supervised.
- Power: machine consumes 5 units/hour at ₹6 per unit.
- Repairs & maintenance ₹11,000 p.a.
- The machine runs 2,200 hours a year (effective).

Step 1 — sort each cost into standing charge or running charge, and get it per year.

Item	Amount to this machine (₹ p.a.)	Basis	Working
Depreciation	22,000	(Cost − scrap) ÷ life	(2,40,000 − 20,000)/10
Rent	9,000	1/4 of ₹36,000 (floor area)	36,000 × 1/4
Supervision	12,000	1 of 4 machines	48,000 × 1/4
Repairs & maintenance	11,000	Allocated to this machine	—
Total standing + fixed running (excl. power)	**54,000**		

Step 2 — standing/fixed charge per machine hour. = 54,000 ÷ 2,200 hours = **₹24.545 per hour**.

Step 3 — power (a pure running charge) per hour. = 5 units × ₹6 = **₹30 per hour**.

Step 4 — Machine Hour Rate. = 24.545 + 30 = **₹54.55 per machine hour** (rounded).

Check: total annual overhead recovered = 54.545 × 2,200 = ₹1,20,000, which equals fixed 54,000 + power (30 × 2,200 = 66,000) = ₹1,20,000. ✓ Reconciles.

Examiner tweak A — "the machine ran 2,400 gross hours but 200 hours were normal setup/maintenance." Then effective hours are still **2,200** and nothing changes — but you must *state* that standing charges are spread over effective (2,200), not gross (2,400) hours, and justify it (setup/maintenance are normal idle time). If instead the 200 hours were an *abnormal* breakdown, you would compute MHR on the *normal available* hours (say 2,400) and separately charge the cost of the 200 idle hours' standing charges to Costing P&L. Test: which idle time is normal?

Examiner tweak B — operator wage added. If one operator minds this machine at ₹40/effective hour and the question asks for a *comprehensive* MHR, add ₹40: comprehensive MHR = 54.55 + 40 = **₹94.55/hr**. If instead one operator minds four machines at ₹1,60,000 p.a., his wage is indirect: 1,60,000 ÷ 4 = ₹40,000 to this machine ÷ 2,200 = ₹18.18/hr → comprehensive MHR = 54.55 + 18.18 = **₹72.73/hr**. Same operator cost, different per-machine load — read the sharing carefully.

Example 2 (core) — Full primary + secondary distribution (repeated distribution + simultaneous equation)

Problem. A factory has two production departments **P1, P2** and two service departments **S1 (Stores)** and **S2 (Maintenance)**. Overheads and data:

Overhead item	Amount (₹)	Basis
Rent	20,000	Floor area
Depreciation of plant	30,000	Value of plant
Supervision	24,000	Number of employees
Indirect materials	6,000	Allocated (given)

Allocated indirect materials: P1 ₹2,500, P2 ₹2,000, S1 ₹900, S2 ₹600 (totals 6,000).

Departmental data:

	P1	P2	S1	S2	Total
Floor area (sq. m)	3,000	2,000	500	500	6,000
Value of plant (₹'000)	60	40	12	8	120
Number of employees	40	30	6	4	80

Service department usage (how each service dept's work is consumed):

- **S1 (Stores)** serves: P1 40%, P2 40%, S2 20%.
- **S2 (Maintenance)** serves: P1 30%, P2 40%, S1 30%.

Because S1 serves S2 *and* S2 serves S1, this is **mutual/reciprocal** service. We'll do the primary distribution, then solve by both **simultaneous equations** and **repeated distribution** to show they agree.

Step 1 — Primary distribution summary.

Rent by floor area 3000:2000:500:500 = 6:4:1:1 (of 12). 20,000/12 = 1,666.67 per part. - P1 10,000; P2 6,666.67; S1 1,666.67; S2 1,666.67.

Depreciation by plant value 60:40:12:8 (of 120). 30,000/120 = 250 per unit. - P1 15,000; P2 10,000; S1 3,000; S2 2,000.

Supervision by employees 40:30:6:4 (of 80). 24,000/80 = 300 per employee. - P1 12,000; P2 9,000; S1 1,800; S2 1,200.

Indirect materials allocated: P1 2,500; P2 2,000; S1 900; S2 600.

Item	Basis	P1	P2	S1	S2	Total
Rent	Floor area	10,000.00	6,666.67	1,666.67	1,666.67	20,000
Depreciation	Plant value	15,000.00	10,000.00	3,000.00	2,000.00	30,000
Supervision	Employees	12,000.00	9,000.00	1,800.00	1,200.00	24,000
Indirect material	Allocated	2,500.00	2,000.00	900.00	600.00	6,000
Primary total		**39,500.00**	**27,666.67**	**7,366.67**	**5,466.67**	**80,000**

Cross-check: 39,500 + 27,666.67 + 7,366.67 + 5,466.67 = **80,000**. ✓

Step 2 — Secondary distribution by SIMULTANEOUS EQUATIONS.

Let **S1** = total overhead of Stores after receiving Maintenance's share, and **S2** = total overhead of Maintenance after receiving Stores' share.

- S1 receives 30% of S2 (Maintenance gives 30% to Stores).
- S2 receives 20% of S1 (Stores gives 20% to Maintenance).

```
S1 = 7,366.67 + 0.30 S2       ...(i)
S2 = 5,466.67 + 0.20 S1       ...(ii)
```

Substitute (ii) into (i): S1 = 7,366.67 + 0.30 (5,466.67 + 0.20 S1) S1 = 7,366.67 + 1,640.00 + 0.06 S1 S1 − 0.06 S1 = 9,006.67 0.94 S1 = 9,006.67 → **S1 = 9,581.56**

Then S2 = 5,466.67 + 0.20 × 9,581.56 = 5,466.67 + 1,916.31 = **S2 = 7,382.98**.

Now distribute the solved totals to production departments only (each dept's share of the *whole* solved figure, using the given percentages):

Stores S1 = 9,581.56 → P1 40%, P2 40% (the 20% to S2 is already captured in the equations): - To P1: 0.40 × 9,581.56 = 3,832.62 - To P2: 0.40 × 9,581.56 = 3,832.62

Maintenance S2 = 7,382.98 → P1 30%, P2 40%: - To P1: 0.30 × 7,382.98 = 2,214.89 - To P2: 0.40 × 7,382.98 = 2,953.19

	P1 (₹)	P2 (₹)
Primary total	39,500.00	27,666.67
From S1 (Stores)	3,832.62	3,832.62
From S2 (Maintenance)	2,214.89	2,953.19
Total overhead	**45,547.51**	**34,452.48**

Reconciliation: 45,547.51 + 34,452.48 = **79,999.99 ≈ 80,000**. ✓ (rounding). The whole ₹80,000 has landed on the two production departments — exactly what secondary distribution must achieve.

Step 3 — Verify by REPEATED DISTRIBUTION (same data).

Start with service balances S1 = 7,366.67, S2 = 5,466.67 and keep re-apportioning until they vanish. Percentages: S1 → P1 40, P2 40, S2 20; S2 → P1 30, P2 40, S1 30.

Round	P1	P2	S1	S2
Opening (primary)	39,500.00	27,666.67	7,366.67	5,466.67
Distribute S1 (7,366.67): 40/40/–/20	+2,946.67	+2,946.67	(7,366.67)	+1,473.33
S2 now = 5,466.67+1,473.33 = 6,940.00; distribute 30/40/30	+2,082.00	+2,776.00	+2,082.00	(6,940.00)
S1 now = 2,082.00; distribute 40/40/20	+832.80	+832.80	(2,082.00)	+416.40
Distribute S2 = 416.40: 30/40/30	+124.92	+166.56	+124.92	(416.40)
S1 = 124.92; distribute 40/40/20	+49.97	+49.97	(124.92)	+24.98
Distribute S2 = 24.98: 30/40/30	+7.49	+9.99	+7.49	(24.98)
S1 = 7.49; distribute 40/40/20	+3.00	+3.00	(7.49)	+1.50
Distribute S2 = 1.50 (round off to P1/P2)	+0.75	+0.75	—	(1.50)
Totals	**≈45,547.60**	**≈34,452.41**	0	0

Both methods land P1 ≈ ₹45,548 and P2 ≈ ₹34,452, totalling ₹80,000. ✓ **The two reciprocal methods agree** — the small differences are pure rounding. This is your self-check discipline: if simultaneous equations and repeated distribution disagree by more than rounding, you made an arithmetic slip.

Step 4 — CONTRAST: what if the examiner said "use the DIRECT method"?

Under the direct method we ignore service-to-service work, so we drop the S1→S2 (20%) and S2→S1 (30%) flows and re-base each service department onto production departments only.

- **S1 (Stores) ₹7,366.67** originally 40:40 to P1:P2 (the 20% to S2 dropped) → re-based 50:50.
- P1 3,683.34; P2 3,683.33.
- **S2 (Maintenance) ₹5,466.67** originally 30:40 to P1:P2 (the 30% to S1 dropped) → re-based 30:40 = 3:4 of 7.
- P1 = 5,466.67 × 3/7 = 2,342.86; P2 = 5,466.67 × 4/7 = 3,123.81.

	P1 (₹)	P2 (₹)
Primary total	39,500.00	27,666.67
From S1 (50:50)	3,683.34	3,683.33
From S2 (3:4)	2,342.86	3,123.81
Total	**45,526.20**	**34,473.81**

Check: 45,526.20 + 34,473.81 = **80,000.01 ≈ 80,000 ✓**. Note the answers differ from the reciprocal method (P1 fell from 45,548 to 45,526) — proof that **the method choice changes the departmental overhead, and hence the rate, and hence the quoted price.** The direct method is not "wrong," it is *less accurate*; the examiner chooses the method by instruction, so always read which method is demanded before computing.

Example 3 (exam-hard) — Absorption rate, application, and under/over-absorption with supplementary rate

Problem. Continuing the factory, department **P1** is **machine-intensive** and **P2** is **labour-intensive**. For the year:

	P1	P2
Budgeted overhead (₹)	45,548	34,452
Budgeted machine hours	22,000	—
Budgeted labour hours	—	17,000

At year-end, **actuals** turned out:

	P1	P2
Actual overhead incurred (₹)	48,000	33,000
Actual machine hours	21,000	—
Actual labour hours	—	18,000

Additional: of P1's under/over-absorption, ₹1,000 of the actual overhead excess was due to an **abnormal machine breakdown**. At year-end, output that carried P1's overhead sits as: Finished goods 60%, Closing WIP 15%, Cost of goods sold 25% (by absorbed-overhead value). Required: (a) absorption rates, (b) overhead absorbed, (c) under/over-absorption and its split into normal/abnormal, (d) treatment including a supplementary rate for the normal part in P1.

Part (a) — choose base and compute pre-determined rates.

P1 is machine-intensive → **Machine Hour Rate**: Rate = 45,548 ÷ 22,000 = **₹2.0704 per machine hour**.

P2 is labour-intensive → **Labour Hour Rate**: Rate = 34,452 ÷ 17,000 = **₹2.0266 per labour hour**.

Why these bases: P1's overhead (power, depreciation) tracks machine running time; P2's tracks operator time. Using the cause-driven base keeps each product's charge fair.

Part (b) — overhead absorbed = pre-determined rate × ACTUAL base.

- P1 absorbed = 2.0704 × 21,000 = **₹43,478.40**.
- P2 absorbed = 2.0266 × 18,000 = **₹36,478.80**.

Part (c) — under/over-absorption = absorbed − actual.

- P1: 43,478.40 − 48,000 = **−₹4,521.60** → **UNDER-absorbed** (absorbed less than spent; products under-charged).
- P2: 36,478.80 − 33,000 = **+₹3,478.80** → **OVER-absorbed** (absorbed more than spent).

Split P1's under-absorption into normal and abnormal: - Abnormal (machine breakdown) = **₹1,000** of the actual overhead was abnormal. - The abnormal portion of the under-absorption is that ₹1,000 (extra actual cost that should never touch product cost). - Normal under-absorption = 4,521.60 − 1,000 = **₹3,521.60**.

Part (d) — treatment.

Abnormal ₹1,000 (P1): transfer straight to **Costing P&L Account** — abnormal losses must not distort stock or product cost.

P2 over-absorption ₹3,478.80: the question gives no abnormal cause and the amount is modest relative to overhead; treat as normal and transfer (credit) to **Costing P&L Account** (over-absorption increases costing profit). *Note:* if the examiner labelled it "significant," you would instead spread it via a negative supplementary rate.

Normal under-absorption ₹3,521.60 (P1) — large, correct via SUPPLEMENTARY RATE across WIP + FG + COGS:

Supplementary rate is applied on the absorbed-overhead value carried by each stock category. Split ₹3,521.60 in the ratio FG 60 : WIP 15 : COGS 25.

Where P1 overhead sits	%	Additional charge (₹)	Working
Finished goods	60%	2,112.96	3,521.60 × 0.60
Closing WIP	15%	528.24	3,521.60 × 0.15
Cost of goods sold	25%	880.40	3,521.60 × 0.25
Total	100%	**3,521.60**	✓

Why spread it, not just write it off? The ₹3,521.60 means every unit that passed through P1 this year was under-costed. Fairness (and true stock valuation) demands we go back and raise the cost of the units still in stock (FG + WIP) as well as those already sold (COGS). Writing the whole lot to P&L would leave closing stock understated — misstating both this year's profit and next year's opening cost.

Final reconciliation of P1's ₹4,521.60 under-absorption: - Abnormal → P&L: 1,000.00 - Normal → supplementary rate (FG 2,112.96 + WIP 528.24 + COGS 880.40): 3,521.60 - **Total 4,521.60** ✓ Fully accounted for.

Examiner tweak — decompose P1's gap into expenditure and volume causes. Using the preview formulas of 4.6, treating the ₹45,548 budget as the budgeted overhead and the pre-determined rate as the "standard" rate: - Expenditure part = Budgeted − Actual = 45,548 − 48,000 = **−₹2,452** (spent more than budget → adverse). - Volume part = Std rate × (Actual − Budgeted hours) = 2.0704 × (21,000 − 22,000) = 2.0704 × (−1,000) = **−₹2,070.4** (worked fewer hours than planned → under-recovery). - Sum = −2,452 − 2,070.4 = **−₹4,522.4 ≈ −₹4,521.6** (the whole under-absorption, difference is rounding of the rate). ✓ The gap is genuinely two causes stacked: overspending *and* under-working.

Example 4 (exam-hard) — Step-ladder vs reciprocal on three service departments, and blanket-vs-departmental impact

Problem. A plant has production departments **A, B** and service departments **X, Y, Z**. After primary distribution the department totals are: A ₹50,000; B ₹40,000; X ₹12,000; Y ₹9,000; Z ₹6,000 (grand total ₹1,17,000). Service usage:

Serving dept	to A	to B	to X	to Y	to Z
X	40%	30%	—	20%	10%
Y	30%	40%	20%	—	10%
Z	50%	40%	10%	—	—

Z serves only production plus X (one-way; nothing comes back to Z from X or Y in Z's own row). But X and Y serve each other, so overall there is reciprocity between X and Y. Required: re-apportion by the **step-ladder method** (state your ordering) and comment.

Step 1 — order the service departments. Rank by how many *other* departments each serves and by size. X serves 4 others (A,B,Y,Z), Y serves 4 others (A,B,X,Z), Z serves 3 (A,B,X). X and Y tie on count; X has the larger overhead (₹12,000 > ₹9,000), so **order: X → Y → Z.** (State this; ordering assumptions earn marks.)

Step 2 — distribute X (₹12,000) to A,B,Y,Z in 40:30:20:10. - A +4,800; B +3,600; Y +2,400; Z +1,200. - Y now = 9,000 + 2,400 = 11,400; Z now = 6,000 + 1,200 = 7,200. X closed.

Step 3 — distribute Y (₹11,400). Under the step method, once X is closed nothing returns to X, so Y's 20%-to-X is dropped and Y is re-based over A,B,Z = 30:40:10 (of 80). - A += 11,400 × 30/80 = 4,275.00; B += 11,400 × 40/80 = 5,700.00; Z += 11,400 × 10/80 = 1,425.00. - Z now = 7,200 + 1,425 = 8,625. Y closed.

Step 4 — distribute Z (₹8,625). X and Y are closed, so Z's 10%-to-X is dropped; re-base over A,B = 50:40 = 5:4 (of 9). - A += 8,625 × 5/9 = 4,791.67; B += 8,625 × 4/9 = 3,833.33. Z closed.

Step 5 — assemble.

	A (₹)	B (₹)
Primary	50,000.00	40,000.00
From X	4,800.00	3,600.00
From Y	4,275.00	5,700.00
From Z	4,791.67	3,833.33
Total	**63,866.67**	**53,133.33**

Reconciliation: 63,866.67 + 53,133.33 = **1,17,000.00 ✓** — the entire ₹1,17,000 has landed on A and B.

Comment (the exam mark). The step method honoured the one-way flows in ranked order but *could not* send Y's cost back to the already-closed X, so it approximates the true reciprocity between X and Y. A full reciprocal (simultaneous-equation) solution would differ slightly; the step method trades a little accuracy for far less arithmetic. State this trade-off.

Follow-on — blanket vs departmental rate. Suppose A runs 30,000 machine hours and B runs 20,000 labour hours. Departmental rates: A = 63,866.67 ÷ 30,000 = **₹2.129/machine hr**; B = 53,133.33 ÷ 20,000 = **₹2.657/labour hr**. A blanket rate over combined 50,000 hours = 1,17,000 ÷ 50,000 = **₹2.34/hr**. A job spending 10 hours entirely in A would absorb 10 × 2.34 = ₹23.40 under the blanket rate but only 10 × 2.129 = ₹21.29 under the departmental rate — the blanket rate *over-charges* an A-only job because it is dragged up by B's higher rate. This is the numeric proof that blanket rates cross-subsidise whenever departmental rates differ and products do not flow uniformly.

6. Presentation / Format — how to lay it out in the exam

1. **Primary Distribution Summary** — always a table: first column *Item*, second column *Basis of apportionment*, then one column per department (production first, service last), final *Total* column. Show the *ratio* of apportionment in the basis column (e.g., "Floor area 6:4:1:1"). Cross-total the last row and tick it against the grand total.
2. **Secondary Distribution** — continue the same table downward: add rows "Redistribution of S1," "Redistribution of S2." Put the department being closed in *brackets* (negative). End with a bold "Total overhead of production departments" row that must equal the grand total.
3. **Simultaneous equations** — write the two equations explicitly, show substitution, state S1 and S2 clearly before distributing.
4. **Overhead rates** — state the base chosen *and one line of justification* ("machine-intensive → machine hour rate"). Examiners award marks for the justification.
5. **Under/over-absorption** — always present as `Absorbed − Actual`, then label under vs over in words, then the treatment with reasoning.
6. Round money to two decimals; round the *last* repeated-distribution cycle to close service departments to nil.
7. **State every assumption** — the step-method ordering, the capacity level used in the denominator (normal vs budgeted), whether operator wages are in/out of MHR. A one-line stated assumption converts an "ambiguous" question into a defensible answer and protects your marks.
8. **Machine hour rate layout** — split the working into a *Standing charges* block and a *Machine/running expenses* block, sub-total each per hour, then add. This mirrors the marking scheme and makes partial credit easy to award.
9. **Show the reconciliation tick (✓)** at every cross-total — primary total = grand total; secondary total on production depts = grand total; supplementary-rate split = the amount being spread. Visible reconciliation signals control of the numbers.

7. Connections — where this sits in the wider syllabus

- ← **Material & Labour (Ch. 02–03):** direct material and direct labour were traceable; this chapter handles everything that *isn't* traceable. Prime cost (from Ch. 02–03) + factory overhead (this chapter) = **Works/Factory cost** in the cost sheet (Ch. 06).
- → **Cost Sheet:** the absorbed factory overhead is the line that turns prime cost into works cost. Administration and S&D overheads (same allocation logic) come later in the sheet, and only S&D is excluded from stock valuation.
- → **Job & Batch Costing:** the overhead absorption *rate* computed here is exactly what a job card uses to load overhead onto each job.
- → **Activity Based Costing (ABC):** ABC is this chapter's "finer and finer for fairness" logic pushed all the way to *activities* and *cost drivers*, replacing volume-based rates where overhead is driven by transactions (setups, inspections) rather than hours.
- → **Standard Costing & Variance Analysis:** under/over-absorption is the seed of **fixed overhead volume and expenditure variances** — the "cost variance" and "volume variance" causes named in 4.6 become

formal variances later (see Figure 5).

- → **Marginal Costing:** marginal costing *refuses* to absorb fixed overhead into product cost at all — understanding absorption here is what lets you appreciate the contrast (and the reconciliation of profits under the two systems, which turns on fixed OH in stock).
- → **Budgetary Control:** the pre-determined rate depends on the *budgeted* overhead and *budgeted* activity produced by the budgeting process; the choice of normal capacity ties directly to flexible budgets.
- → **Reconciliation of Cost & Financial Accounts:** under/over-absorbed overhead is a classic reconciling item between costing profit and financial profit.

---

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Absorbed vs actual base confusion.** Overhead *absorbed* = pre-determined rate × **actual** base (not budgeted base). A very common slip is multiplying by budgeted hours. Pre-determined rate uses *budgeted* figures; application uses *actual* activity.
2. **Direction of under vs over.** Absorbed **>** actual = **over**-absorbed (add back to profit). Absorbed **<** actual = **under**-absorbed (charge to profit). Memorise via: "over-absorbed = we over-charged products = costing profit understated = credit P&L."
3. **Distributing the SOLVED service total, not the residual.** In the simultaneous-equation method, after solving S1 and S2, distribute the *full solved figure* using the original percentages to production departments. Students wrongly distribute only the primary total.
4. **Service-to-service percentages in reciprocal method.** The 20% Stores→Maintenance and 30% Maintenance→Stores must be *included* in the equations; they are the whole point. Dropping them silently converts it to the (wrong) direct method.
5. **Step method ordering.** Start with the service department that serves the *most* other departments (or has the largest overhead if tied), and never send cost back to a closed department. And *re-base the surviving percentages* each time a department is closed.
6. **Abnormal causes always go to Costing P&L** — strike, fire, idle capacity, breakdown. Never spread abnormal amounts via a supplementary rate. Examiners plant an "abnormal" clause to test this.
7. **Supplementary rate must hit WIP too**, not just finished goods and COGS. Forgetting closing WIP is a classic error.
8. **Blanket rate justification.** If asked *when* a blanket rate is acceptable, the answer is "single product, or all products pass uniformly through all departments" — not "when it's convenient."
9. **Basis mismatch.** Depreciation apportioned on *floor area* (wrong) instead of *plant value* (right); supervision on plant value (wrong) instead of *employees* (right). Match the basis to the cost driver, and use the *most specific* basis the data offers (light points over floor area for lighting).
10. **Power apportionment.** Power is apportioned on **HP × machine hours** (or KWH), not on floor area or headcount — it is machine-load-driven.
11. **Effective vs gross machine hours.** MHR denominator is *effective* hours (after normal setup/maintenance idle), not gross calendar hours. Using gross hours silently under-recovers standing charges.
12. **Allocation hidden inside an apportionment.** When one department is *separately metered* (power) or has a *named* foreman (salary), allocate that slice first, then apportion only the remainder. Blanket-apportioning the whole item is wrong.

13. **Idle-capacity under-absorption is NOT spread by supplementary rate.** Under-recovery from working below *normal* capacity is a period cost to Costing P&L, an exception to "normal + large → supplementary rate." Read the *cause*, not just the size.
14. **S&D overhead never enters closing stock.** If a question asks for closing-stock value, exclude selling & distribution overhead; include factory overhead (and admin only per the stated policy).
15. **Wrong capacity in the denominator.** Building the pre-determined rate on *budgeted* low volume instead of *normal* capacity inflates the rate and hides idle-capacity cost inside product cost. Prefer normal capacity unless told otherwise, and state it.
16. **Re-basing percentages in the direct method.** Under the direct method you must renormalise the service-to-production percentages so they sum to 100% (drop the service-to-service slice), else the amounts won't total.

---

9. First-Principles Recap

Strip away the vocabulary and this chapter is one idea stretched over four moves:

- **The core dilemma:** indirect cost is real money that points at no single product, yet managers need a per-unit cost to price and value stock. Financial accounting never faces this; cost accounting must.
- **Move 1 — Primary distribution.** Spread all factory overhead across every cost centre: *allocate* what belongs wholly to one, *apportion* the shared items on a basis that mirrors the cost's cause (area for rent, plant value for depreciation, headcount for welfare, machine-load for power). Always choose the *most cause-specific* basis the data permits.
- **Move 2 — Secondary distribution.** Service departments have no units to absorb their cost, so push them onto production departments. When services serve each other, untangle the circularity with simultaneous equations or repeated distribution — both must land the *entire* total on production departments and agree with each other. The method choice (direct / step / reciprocal) changes the numbers, so obey the instruction.
- **Move 3 — Absorption.** Convert each production department's overhead into a per-unit rate using a *time-based* base (machine hours for machine-intensive, labour hours for labour-intensive) because overhead is fundamentally time-related. Use *departmental* rates unless products flow uniformly, in which case a blanket rate is tolerable. Divide by *normal* capacity so idle-capacity cost is exposed, not hidden.
- **Move 4 — Reconcile reality.** Because we priced with a pre-determined rate, absorbed ≠ actual. That gap (under/over-absorption) is not an error but the price of real-time pricing; it decomposes into an *expenditure* cause and a *volume* cause (the future fixed-overhead variances). Write off small/abnormal/idle-capacity gaps to Costing P&L; correct large normal gaps with a supplementary rate across WIP, finished goods and cost of sales — because those units were genuinely mis-costed and stock values must be put right.

Every formula in the quick-revision sheet is just one of these four moves made arithmetic.

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

Core flow: Total OH → (Allocation + Apportionment = Primary) → Cost centres → (Re-apportionment = Secondary) → Production depts → (Absorption) → Units.

Concept	Formula / Rule
Overhead	Indirect Material + Indirect Labour + Indirect Expenses
Allocation	Whole item → one centre (100% traceable)
Apportionment	Shared item → many centres on fair basis
Absorption rate (general)	Production dept overhead ÷ Total base quantity
% of Direct Material	(Prod OH ÷ Direct Material) × 100
% of Direct Wages	(Prod OH ÷ Direct Wages) × 100
% of Prime Cost	(Prod OH ÷ Prime Cost) × 100
Labour Hour Rate	Prod OH ÷ Direct Labour Hours (labour-intensive)
Machine Hour Rate	Prod OH ÷ Machine Hours (machine-intensive)
Rate per unit	Prod OH ÷ Units produced (homogeneous output)
MHR build-up	Standing charges/hr + Machine running expenses/hr (÷ *effective* hours)
Overhead absorbed	Pre-determined rate × **Actual** base
Pre-determined rate	Budgeted OH ÷ Budgeted (normal) base
Under/Over absorption	Absorbed − Actual overhead
→ Over-absorbed	Absorbed > Actual (credit Costing P&L)
→ Under-absorbed	Absorbed < Actual (debit Costing P&L)
Gap: expenditure part	Budgeted OH − Actual OH
Gap: volume part	Std rate × (Actual activity − Budgeted activity)
Supplementary rate	Under/over amount ÷ Actual base; apply to WIP + FG + COGS
Semi-variable split (High–Low)	Var/unit = ΔCost ÷ ΔActivity; Fixed = Total − Var×Activity

Apportionment bases (memorise the pairing):

Overhead	Basis
Rent, rates, building dep./repairs, lighting, heating	Floor area (lighting → light points if given)
Depreciation & insurance of plant	Value / capital of plant
Power	HP × machine hours (or KWH)
Supervision, canteen, welfare, ESI, PF, time-keeping	Number of employees
Stores / material handling	Value or weight of material issued
Fire insurance of stock	Average value of stock
Delivery / distribution	Weight, volume, or tonne-km
General / indirect wages	Direct wages or direct labour hours

Secondary distribution method chooser:

Situation	Method
Ignore inter-service work	Direct re-distribution (re-base % to production only)
One-way service between service depts	Step-ladder (rank by service; larger OH breaks ties)
Mutual service, exactly 2 service depts	Simultaneous equations
Mutual service, 2+ service depts	Repeated distribution

Treatment of under/over-absorption:

Cause / size	Treatment
Abnormal (strike, fire, breakdown)	Costing P&L Account
Sub-normal capacity (idle-capacity cost)	Costing P&L Account (do *not* spread)
Normal & small	Costing P&L Account
Normal & large	Supplementary rate → WIP + FG + COGS

Blanket rate acceptable only when: single product OR all products pass uniformly through all departments; otherwise use **departmental rates**.

Reciprocal simultaneous-equation template: `S1 = a + p·S2 ; S2 = b + q·S1` → solve → distribute solved totals to production departments in given percentages. Always cross-check the total lands wholly on production departments and equals the primary grand total.

Capacity note (verify current ICAI material / AY): anchor the pre-determined rate on **normal capacity** so idle-capacity cost is exposed as a period loss rather than buried in product cost.

Q&A — Overheads (Absorption Costing)

CA Intermediate — Cost & Management Accounting. All figures in Rupees (Rs.). ICAI formulas.

Section A — Concept-Check (short answer)

A1. Why can overheads never be traced to a unit the way material and labour can? Overheads are indirect costs — factory rent, supervisor salary, power — incurred for *output as a whole*, not for any single unit. There is no natural per-unit measure, so we must *build* one through allocation, apportionment and absorption. (This is the restaurant-bill split problem: the shared starter has no obvious per-diner price.)

A2. Distinguish allocation, apportionment and absorption in one line each. - **Allocation** — charging a *whole* overhead item directly to one cost centre that caused it (e.g., a department's own foreman salary). - **Apportionment** — *splitting* a shared overhead across several centres on an equitable basis (e.g., rent on floor area). - **Absorption** — recovering the cost centre's total overhead into *cost units* via an absorption rate.

A3. What is primary vs secondary distribution? Primary distribution allocates/apportions all overheads to *all* departments (production + service). Secondary distribution re-apportions *service* department costs onto *production* departments, so only production departments finally carry overhead.

A4. Name the three methods of secondary distribution when service departments serve each other. (i) Simultaneous equation (algebraic) method, (ii) Repeated distribution method, (iii) Trial-and-error method. All handle *reciprocal* services; the step/non-reciprocal method ignores return service.

A5. Give the formula for Machine Hour Rate (MHR). MHR = Total overheads of the machine (or cost centre) ÷ Machine hours worked. It is the most scientific rate where work is machine-dominated.

A6. Blanket vs departmental overhead rate — when is a blanket rate acceptable? A blanket (single, factory-wide) rate = Total factory overhead ÷ Total base for whole factory. It is acceptable only when there is *one* product or all products pass through *all* departments in the *same* proportion. Otherwise a departmental rate is used to avoid distortion.

A7. Define under- and over-absorption. Under-absorption: overhead *absorbed* (rate × actual base) is **less** than overhead *actually incurred* → costs understated. Over-absorption: absorbed **exceeds** incurred → costs overstated.

A8. When is a supplementary rate used, and what does a positive supplementary rate signify? When under/over-absorption is *large* and due to *normal* causes, it is disposed of by a supplementary rate spread over units/cost. A **positive (additive)** supplementary rate corrects **under-absorption** (extra cost to be loaded); a negative rate corrects over-absorption.

Section B — Graded Computational Problems

B1 (Easy) — Machine Hour Rate

A machine's monthly data: Depreciation Rs. 5,000; Power Rs. 3,000; Repairs Rs. 1,000; Consumable stores Rs. 500; Supervision (apportioned) Rs. 2,500. The machine works 8 hours/day for 25 days, with 10% idle time for setting.

Solution. Effective machine hours = 8 × 25 × (1 − 0.10) = 200 × 0.90 = **180 hours**. Total overhead = 5,000 + 3,000 + 1,000 + 500 + 2,500 = **Rs. 12,000**. MHR = 12,000 ÷ 180 = **Rs. 66.67 per machine hour**.

B2 (Moderate) — Primary Distribution + Absorption Rate

Overheads for a factory with departments A, B (production) and S (service):

Item	Total (Rs.)	Basis
Rent	12,000	Floor area
Depreciation	9,000	Machine value
Supervision	6,000	No. of employees

Dept	Floor area (sq.m)	Machine value (Rs.)	Employees
A	300	60,000	20
B	200	30,000	15
S	100	10,000	5

Service dept S is apportioned to A and B in ratio 3:2. Dept A works 5,000 labour hours, B works 4,000 machine hours.

Primary distribution. Rent (600 sq.m total → 12,000/600 = Rs. 20/sq.m): A 6,000; B 4,000; S 2,000. Depreciation (1,00,000 total → 9,000/1,00,000 = Rs.0.09/Re): A 5,400; B 2,700; S 900. Supervision (40 employees → 6,000/40 = Rs.150/emp): A 3,000; B 2,250; S 750.

Dept	Rent	Depn	Supervision	Total
A	6,000	5,400	3,000	**14,400**
B	4,000	2,700	2,250	**8,950**
S	2,000	900	750	**3,650**

Secondary distribution. S = Rs. 3,650 split 3:2 → A = 2,190; B = 1,460. Final: A = 14,400 + 2,190 = **Rs. 16,590**; B = 8,950 + 1,460 = **Rs. 10,410**. (Check: 16,590 + 10,410 = 27,000 = 14,400 + 8,950 + 3,650 ✓)

Absorption rates. Dept A (labour-hour rate) = 16,590 ÷ 5,000 = **Rs. 3.318 per labour hour**. Dept B (machine-hour rate) = 10,410 ÷ 4,000 = **Rs. 2.6025 per machine hour**.

B3 (Exam-hard) — Reciprocal service: Simultaneous Equation & Repeated Distribution

Primary-distribution totals: Production P1 = Rs. 8,000, P2 = Rs. 10,000; Service S1 = Rs. 3,000, S2 = Rs. 2,000. Service departments serve as follows:

From \ To	P1	P2	S1	S2
S1	40%	40%	—	20%
S2	30%	40%	30%	—

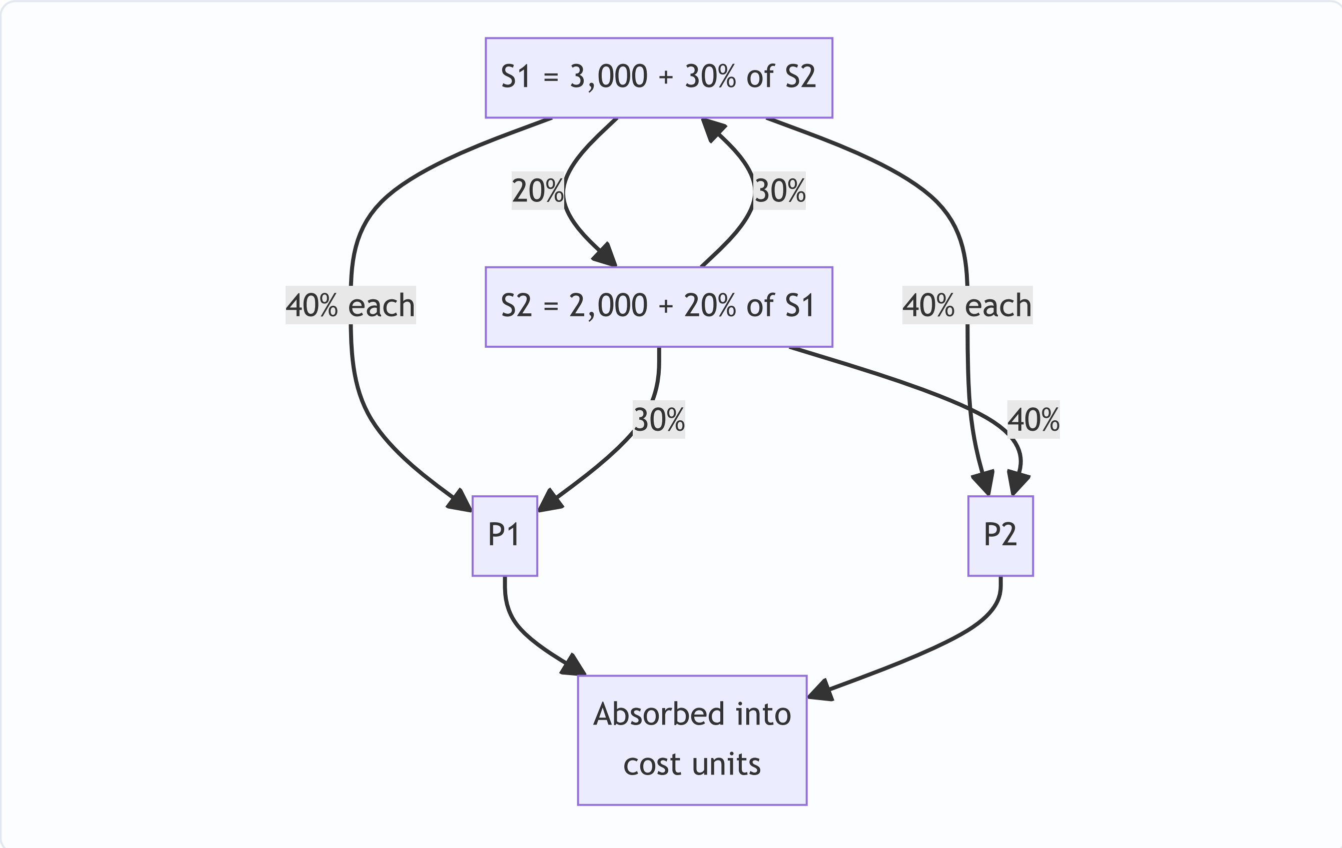
Method 1 — Simultaneous equations. Let S1 = total cost of S1, S2 = total cost of S2. S1 = 3,000 + 0.30 S2 S2 = 2,000 + 0.20 S1

Substitute: S1 = 3,000 + 0.30(2,000 + 0.20 S1) = 3,000 + 600 + 0.06 S1 0.94 S1 = 3,600 → **S1 = Rs. 3,829.79**. S2 = 2,000 + 0.20 × 3,829.79 = **Rs. 2,765.96**.

Apportion to production: - From S1 (40% each to P1, P2): P1 += 1,531.91; P2 += 1,531.91. - From S2 (30% P1, 40% P2): P1 += 829.79; P2 += 1,106.38.

Dept	Primary	From S1	From S2	Total
P1	8,000	1,531.91	829.79	**10,361.70**
P2	10,000	1,531.91	1,106.38	**12,638.30**

(Check: 10,361.70 + 12,638.30 = 23,000 = 8,000+10,000+3,000+2,000 ✓ — all service cost absorbed.)



Method 2 — Repeated distribution (cross-check). Keep passing service totals in the given percentages until residual is negligible:

	P1	P2	S1	S2
Primary	8,000	10,000	3,000	2,000
S1 (40/40/-/20)	1,200	1,200	(3,000)	600
S2 (30/40/30/-)	780	1,040	780	(2,600)
S1 (40/40/-/20)	312	312	(780)	156
S2 (30/40/30/-)	46.8	62.4	46.8	(156)
S1 (40/40/-/20)	18.72	18.72	(46.8)	9.36
S2 (close out 30/40/30)	2.81	3.74	2.81 → tiny	(9.36)
Final S1 residual ~2.81 → 40/40	1.40	1.40	—	—
Total	**≈10,361.73**	**≈12,638.26**	—	—

Both methods reconcile to **P1 ≈ Rs. 10,362 and P2 ≈ Rs. 12,638**. The simultaneous method is exact; repeated distribution converges to the same figures.

B4 (Exam-hard) — Absorption + Under/Over-Absorption + Supplementary Rate

Budgeted overhead Rs. 5,00,000; budgeted machine hours 50,000 → **predetermined rate = Rs. 10/hr**. Actual overhead incurred Rs. 5,60,000; actual machine hours 52,000. Output: 20,000 units, of which 15,000 sold, 3,000 in closing WIP-equivalent finished stock, 2,000 in closing WIP.

Overhead absorbed = actual hours × rate = 52,000 × 10 = **Rs. 5,20,000**. **Under-absorption** = 5,60,000 − 5,20,000 = **Rs. 40,000** (incurred > absorbed → under).

Analysis of cause: Rate-driven shortfall of Rs. 40,000 arising from higher actual spending (Rs. 60,000 more) partly offset by more hours worked (2,000 × 10 = Rs. 20,000 extra absorbed). As it is material and due to a normal cause, dispose of via a **supplementary rate** across cost of sales and stocks in proportion to units.

Supplementary rate = 40,000 ÷ 20,000 units = **Rs. 2 per unit (positive/additive)**. - Cost of sales (15,000 × 2) = Rs. 30,000 - Finished stock (3,000 × 2) = Rs. 6,000 - WIP (2,000 × 2) = Rs. 4,000 - Total = **Rs. 40,000** ✓ (fully absorbed).

If the under-absorption had been small or due to an abnormal cause (e.g., strike, fire), it would instead be transferred straight to the Costing Profit & Loss Account.

Section C — Past-Paper-Style Full Questions

C1. *A manufacturing company has two production departments (Machining, Assembly) and one service department (Maintenance). Explain the treatment of Maintenance overhead and state, with reasons, the most appropriate absorption base for each production department.*

Model answer. Maintenance is a service department; its cost is first captured in primary distribution, then re-apportioned to Machining and Assembly in secondary distribution (basis: maintenance hours or asset value served) so that only the two production departments finally bear overhead. **Machining**, being capital/machine-intensive, should absorb overhead on a **machine-hour rate** because overhead there varies with machine running time (power, depreciation, repairs). **Assembly**, being labour-intensive, should use a **direct labour-hour rate**, as its overhead correlates with operator time. Using a single blanket rate would over-cost labour-heavy jobs and under-cost machine-heavy jobs, so departmental rates are justified.

C2. *State how each of the following is disposed of: (a) large under-absorption due to persistent under-estimation of overhead; (b) over-absorption due to greater-than-budgeted output; (c) under-absorption caused by an abnormal machine breakdown.*

Model answer. (a) Large, normal-cause under-absorption → **supplementary rate** loaded on cost of sales, finished goods and WIP (positive rate). (b) Over-absorption from higher normal output → **supplementary rate (negative)** or, if small, credited to **Costing P&L**. (c) Abnormal-cause under-absorption → charged directly to **Costing Profit & Loss Account**, as it must not distort product cost.

C3. *The overhead of Dept X was Rs. 1,80,000 for 12,000 machine hours (budget). Actual: Rs. 2,04,000 for 12,500 hours. Compute the pre-determined rate, overhead absorbed, and under/over-absorption, splitting the variance into "expenditure" and "capacity/volume" causes.*

Model answer. Pre-determined rate = 1,80,000 ÷ 12,000 = **Rs. 15/hr**. Absorbed = 12,500 × 15 = **Rs. 1,87,500**. Under-absorption = 2,04,000 − 1,87,500 = **Rs. 16,500**. - *Expenditure cause:* actual spend Rs. 2,04,000 vs budget-flexed at actual hours (12,500 × 15 = 1,87,500)… but budget was 1,80,000; extra spend vs original budget = 2,04,000 − 1,80,000 = Rs. 24,000 (adverse). - *Capacity cause:* extra 500 hours worked absorbed 500 × 15 = Rs. 7,500 more (favourable). - Net = 24,000 − 7,500 = **Rs. 16,500 under-absorbed** ✓.

Section D — MCQs & Case Scenarios

D1. Apportionment of factory rent is best done on the basis of: (a) Number of employees (b) **Floor area** (c) Machine value (d) Direct wages. **Answer: (b)** — rent relates to space occupied.

D2. Overhead absorbed = Rs. 90,000; overhead incurred = Rs. 1,00,000. This is: (a) Over-absorption Rs. 10,000 (b) **Under-absorption Rs. 10,000** (c) Nil (d) Over Rs. 90,000. **Answer: (b)** — incurred exceeds absorbed by Rs. 10,000.

D3. The most scientific overhead rate for a highly automated shop is: (a) Percentage of direct wages (b) **Machine hour rate** (c) Percentage of prime cost (d) Rate per unit. **Answer: (b)** — overhead there varies with machine time.

D4. In secondary distribution, the simultaneous-equation method is required when: (a) Only one service dept exists (b) Service depts do not serve each other (c) **Service departments serve each other reciprocally** (d) There are no service depts. **Answer: (c)** — reciprocal service needs algebraic solution.

D5. A blanket overhead rate should be avoided when: (a) Single product (b) **Products pass through departments in different proportions** (c) One department only (d) Uniform processing. **Answer: (b)** — differing routing distorts a single rate.

D6 (Case). A firm budgets overhead Rs. 4,00,000 for 40,000 labour hours. Actual overhead Rs. 4,00,000 but only 36,000 hours worked. Absorbed = 36,000 × (4,00,000/40,000 = Rs.10) = Rs. 3,60,000 → **under-absorbed Rs. 40,000** due to *idle capacity* (a normal-cause volume variance). Treatment: as it reflects unused normal capacity, transfer to Costing P&L (or supplementary rate if material and product-related). Correct statement: **the shortfall is a capacity/volume under-absorption, not an expenditure overrun.**

Quick-Revision Trigger List

- Base picks: rent → floor area; depreciation/power → machine value/hours; supervision → employees; canteen → headcount; stores → material value.
- Reciprocal → simultaneous eqn (exact) or repeated distribution (converges).
- Under-absorption = Incurred − Absorbed (positive). Dispose: small → P&L; large & normal → supplementary rate; abnormal → P&L always.
- MHR = machine overhead ÷ effective machine hours (net of idle/setup).
- Blanket rate only for single/uniform-routing products.

Chapter 05 — Activity-Based Costing (ABC)

1. The Problem — When the Cost Sheet Lies to the Board

You run a factory that makes two products, both plastic bottles. Product **Standard** is a plain 1-litre bottle you make by the million. Product **Premium** is a fiddly, oddly-shaped 250 ml bottle with a child-proof cap that you make in small batches for a niche pharma client. The pharma client haggles hard, and your traditional cost sheet tells you Premium earns a fat 40% margin. So the sales team chases *more* pharma orders, quietly delighted.

Two years later profits have *fallen* even though the "high-margin" Premium now fills half the plant. The board is baffled. The cost sheet said Premium was the winner.

Here is the uncomfortable truth the cost sheet hid. Premium needs **twelve machine set-ups a month** (Standard needs one). Premium needs a **special quality inspection** on every batch. Premium's odd shape jams the line, so a **maintenance engineer** babysits it. Premium generates **forty purchase orders** for exotic caps; Standard generates two. None of this effort is caused by *how many* bottles you make — it is caused by *how complex and how fragmented* the production is. Yet your costing system spread every rupee of that set-up, inspection, maintenance and purchasing cost across products **in proportion to labour hours or machine hours** — that is, in proportion to *volume*. So the high-volume Standard silently absorbed the overhead that the low-volume, high-complexity Premium actually *caused*. Premium looked cheap. It was bleeding you.

This is the managerial decision ABC exists to fix: **which products, customers, or orders are truly profitable, so I know what to price up, drop, or push?** Traditional absorption costing answers that question *wrong* whenever overhead is large and is driven by complexity rather than by volume. Get the answer wrong and you cheerfully expand your loss-makers and kill your winners. Activity-Based Costing is the tool that traces overhead to the *activities that consume resources* and then to the *products that demand those activities* — so the cost sheet finally tells the board the truth.

> The purpose of ABC is **not** more accurate financial statements (financial accounting doesn't care). Its purpose is a better **decision** — pricing, product mix, make-or-buy, cost reduction. Never lose sight of that.

The one-sentence diagnosis. The disease is *averaging*. Whenever you average a cost across items that consume it unequally, you tax the light user to subsidise the heavy user. Traditional costing averages *all* overhead over *one* volume base; the more that overhead is caused by things unrelated to volume, and the more unequal the consumption, the bigger the cross-subsidy. ABC is not a different accounting universe — it is simply *averaging in smaller, more homogeneous buckets* so that inside each bucket the items really do consume the cost equally. Hold that thought: **ABC is the medicine for hidden cross-subsidy caused by over-broad averaging.** Everything technical below is machinery for finding buckets pure enough that the average inside them stops lying.

2. The Core Idea — The Restaurant Bill Split

Six friends go to dinner. Five order a ₹200 thali. The sixth orders a ₹200 imported steak, three ₹400 cocktails, dessert, and sends the steak back twice to be recooked, keeping the waiter running all night. The total bill is

₹4,000. How do you split it?

The lazy way — "divide by six" — charges each thali-eater ₹667 for their ₹200 meal, subsidising the steak-and-cocktail friend. That is **traditional absorption costing**: pick one simple volume base (here, "number of heads") and smear the whole cost across it. The heavy consumer of *effort* gets undercharged; the simple consumers get overcharged.

The fair way is to ask, *for each thing on the bill, what caused it, and who consumed that cause?* Food cost follows what each person ate. The waiter's extra runs follow the person who sent food back. The cocktails follow the person who drank them. You trace each **pool of cost** to its **driver** and then to the **person who consumed the driver**. That is **Activity-Based Costing** in one dinner. ABC simply refuses to divide-by-six.

Push the analogy one notch — it exposes the whole hierarchy. Not every line on the restaurant bill can be traced to a person. The *cover charge* for the private room was triggered by the *booking*, not by any individual — that is a **batch-level** cost, shared by whoever came, unaffected by what each ate. The *live band* the restaurant hired that evening exists because the *restaurant is open at all* — no diner "caused" it; that is a **facility-level** cost you can only split arbitrarily. So even a dinner bill contains unit-level (the food), batch-level (the room booking) and facility-level (the band) costs, and honesty means charging each at the level of the thing that actually triggered it — and admitting when a cost has *no* fair driver at all. Keep this three-layer picture; Section 4.3 formalises it as Cooper's hierarchy.

3. Why It's Built This Way — The Logic

Traditional absorption costing was designed in an era (early 20th century) when direct labour was the giant cost and overhead was a small, sleepy add-on. Smearing a small overhead across labour hours was harmless — a rounding error can't distort a decision. Two things then changed:

1. **Overhead exploded and labour shrank.** Automation, quality systems, planning, scheduling, R&D and setups turned overhead into 40–70% of factory cost. A blunt allocation of a *huge* number is no longer a rounding error — it swings product costs by 30–50%.
2. **Product ranges fragmented.** Firms stopped making one thing a million times and started making a hundred things a few thousand times each. Complexity — batches, setups, inspections, special handling — became the real consumer of the overhead. And complexity has **nothing to do with volume**.

Here is the fatal mechanism, stated plainly. A **volume-based** overhead rate (per labour hour or per machine hour or per unit) charges *twice as much overhead to a product you make twice as many of*. But a setup costs the same whether the batch is 10 units or 10,000. So the high-volume product, which needs *few setups per unit*, gets loaded with overhead it never caused, while the low-volume product, which needs *many setups per unit*, gets let off. The result is textbook and predictable:

> **Under traditional costing, high-volume simple products are systematically OVER-costed, and low-volume complex products are systematically UNDER-costed.** ABC reverses both distortions.

ABC's logic is a two-stage causal chain: **Resources → Activities → Products.** Resources (salaries, power, depreciation) are consumed by *activities* (setting up, inspecting, purchasing, moving). Products consume *activities* in proportion to how much they demand them (a product needing 12 setups consumes 12/total of the setup activity). Cost simply follows *causation* down the chain. That is the whole philosophy: **cost is caused, so trace it to its cause.**

Why "per-unit" is the deadliest word in the traditional method. The instant you express a batch cost *per unit*, you have secretly declared it proportional to volume — because dividing by units makes it shrink as volume grows. A ₹5,000 setup spread over a 10,000-unit batch is ₹0.50/unit; over a 100-unit batch it is ₹50/unit. Same setup, 100× difference, purely from batch size. Traditional costing hides this because it *never sees the batch* — it only ever sees total units. ABC's whole contribution is to **stop the premature division**: keep setup cost at ₹5,000-per-setup, charge it by *setups*, and divide by units only at the very last step. The lesson generalises: **divide by a driver, not by volume, and divide as late as possible.**

The two errors are two sides of one coin (conservation). Because ABC only *re-traces* a fixed pot of overhead, every rupee it *takes off* the over-costed product is a rupee it *puts on* the under-costed one. The distortions are not independent — they are equal and opposite in total. This is why an exam answer that shows one product's cost rising under ABC must show the other's falling; if both move the same way, you have an arithmetic error. Conservation of overhead is both the sanity check and the reason the cross-subsidy is exactly a *transfer*, never a *creation*.

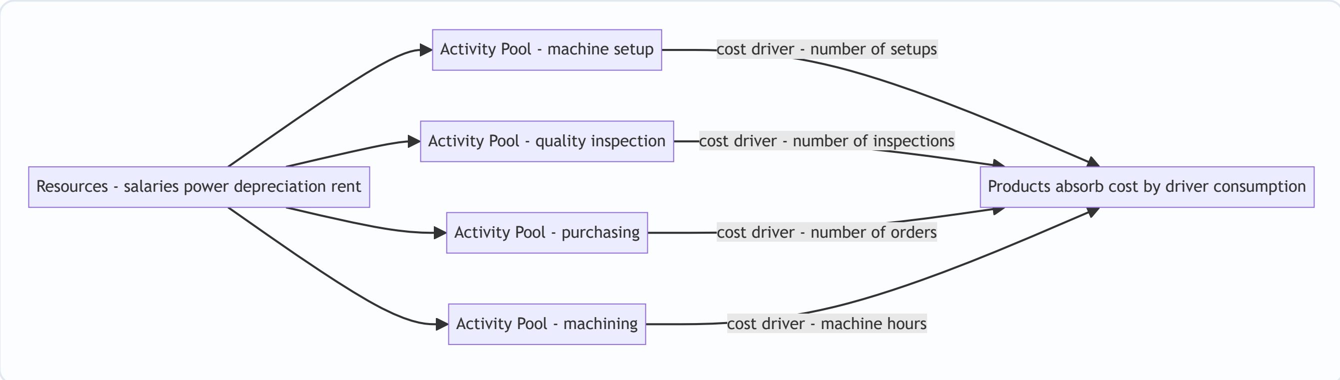


Figure 1 — ABC's two-stage causal chain: resources pool into activities, activities attach to products through cost drivers.

4. Full Technical Content

4.1 The vocabulary (each term earns its place)

Term	Plain meaning	Why it exists
Activity	A task that consumes resources — setup, inspect, purchase, move, machine	The real unit of work that causes overhead
Cost pool	The total ₹ of overhead gathered for one activity	You must total a cost before you can rate it
Cost driver	The factor that *causes* the activity's cost to rise	The fair basis to charge products; replaces the single volume base
Cost driver rate	Cost pool ÷ total driver quantity	The "price" of one unit of the activity
Resource driver	Basis for tracing resources *into* a pool (stage 1)	Splits a shared salary across activities
Activity driver	Basis for tracing a pool *to products* (stage 2)	The "cost driver" in the rate

Two finer distinctions the examiner loves.

- **Cost driver vs cost object.** A *cost driver* is the *cause* of cost (number of setups); a *cost object* is the *thing you want the cost of* (a product, an order, a customer, a channel). ABC can point at any cost object — its power is that once you have activity rates, you can cost a *customer* (who places many small orders) just as easily as a *product*. Exam questions increasingly ask for **customer-level** or **order-level** profitability, not just product cost.
- **Value-added vs non-value-added activities.** A *value-added* activity is one a customer would willingly pay for if they saw it (machining, assembly). A *non-value-added* activity adds cost but no worth (moving, storing, inspecting, re-working, waiting, setting up). ABC *quantifies* the rupees sitting in non-value-added activities — which is the springboard to ABM (Section 7). Naming an activity as NVA is not the same as saying "delete it": some NVA activities (statutory inspection) are *necessary* NVA and cannot simply be cut.

4.2 Two kinds of cost driver

- **Transaction drivers** — *count how many times* an activity happens: number of setups, number of purchase orders, number of inspections. Cheap to use; assume each occurrence costs the same.
- **Duration drivers** — *how long* an activity takes: setup hours, inspection hours. More accurate when occurrences vary a lot in effort (a complex setup takes longer), but costlier to measure.

Choose a transaction driver when occurrences are roughly uniform; a duration driver when they vary widely.

A third, rarely-taught tier — intensity (direct-charging) drivers. When even *time* fails to capture the effort (one setup needs a senior engineer plus a special jig; another needs a junior for five minutes), you abandon rates and *directly charge* the actual resources used to that specific job. Intensity drivers are the most accurate and the most expensive — reserved for a handful of genuinely special jobs. The three form a ladder of accuracy-vs-cost: **transaction (cheapest, least accurate) → duration → intensity (dearest, most accurate).** The examinable point is the *trade-off*: you climb the ladder only until the extra accuracy stops being worth the extra measurement cost. That trade-off is itself an ABC decision.

Picking the right driver — the two tests. A good driver must satisfy both: (1) **causation** — movements in the driver must genuinely cause movements in the pool (a correlation that isn't causal, like "number of units" correlating with setup cost only because bigger orders happen to run in more batches, will mislead the moment the pattern breaks); and (2) **measurability** — you must be able to count it cheaply and objectively. A theoretically perfect driver you cannot measure is useless; a measurable driver that doesn't cause the cost is worse than useless because it looks authoritative while lying.

4.3 Cooper's hierarchy of activities — the single most examinable idea

Robin Cooper classified activities by *what triggers them*. This tells you **what the driver must be** and, crucially, **which costs you may and may not unitise**.

Level	Triggered by	Examples	Driver type
Unit-level	Each *unit* made	Power to run machine, direct material handling per unit	Machine hrs, labour hrs, units — *volume based*
Batch-level	Each *batch/run*	Machine setup, first-article inspection, material movement per batch, purchase order	No. of setups, batches, orders, inspections
Product-level	Each *product line* existing	Product design, maintaining a BOM, special testing, dedicated tooling	No. of products, design hours
Facility-level	The *factory* existing at all	Factory rent, plant security, general management, lighting	Cannot be caused by any product — allocate arbitrarily or leave as period cost

Why this matters for decisions: **batch- and product-level costs are fixed with respect to volume but variable with respect to complexity.** Traditional costing wrongly makes them behave like unit-level costs (it divides them by volume). ABC keeps them at their true level. And **facility-level cost is genuinely un-traceable** — ABC honestly admits it and does not pretend a product "caused" the factory's existence.

The cost-behaviour insight most students miss. The hierarchy is really a *statement about what each cost varies with*. Unit-level cost varies with **units**; batch-level cost varies with **number of batches** (so it is *fixed within a batch* and *steps up* only when you add a batch — a classic step-fixed cost); product-level cost varies with **the mere existence of the line** (spend it once whether you make 5 units or 5 million); facility-level cost varies with **nothing you produce**. This reframes ABC as a *finer cost-behaviour model* than the crude fixed/variable split — and it is exactly why ABC feeds Marginal Costing and CVP (Section 7) more honest numbers.

The relevance ladder for decisions. The hierarchy doubles as a guide to *which costs are relevant to which decision*:

- Drop *one unit* of output → only **unit-level** cost disappears.
- Drop *one batch* (make fewer, larger runs) → **unit + batch-level** cost of that run disappears.
- Drop the *whole product line* → **unit + batch + product-level** cost disappears, but **facility-level does not** (the rent stays).
- Close the *facility* → finally the facility-level cost disappears.

So when an examiner asks "should we discontinue Product X?", the *avoidable* cost is only up to the product level; the facility-level slice loaded onto X in the ABC cost sheet **will not vanish** and must be excluded from the drop decision. Confusing "ABC full cost" with "avoidable cost" is the trap in Section 8.8 — the hierarchy is what lets you separate them cleanly.

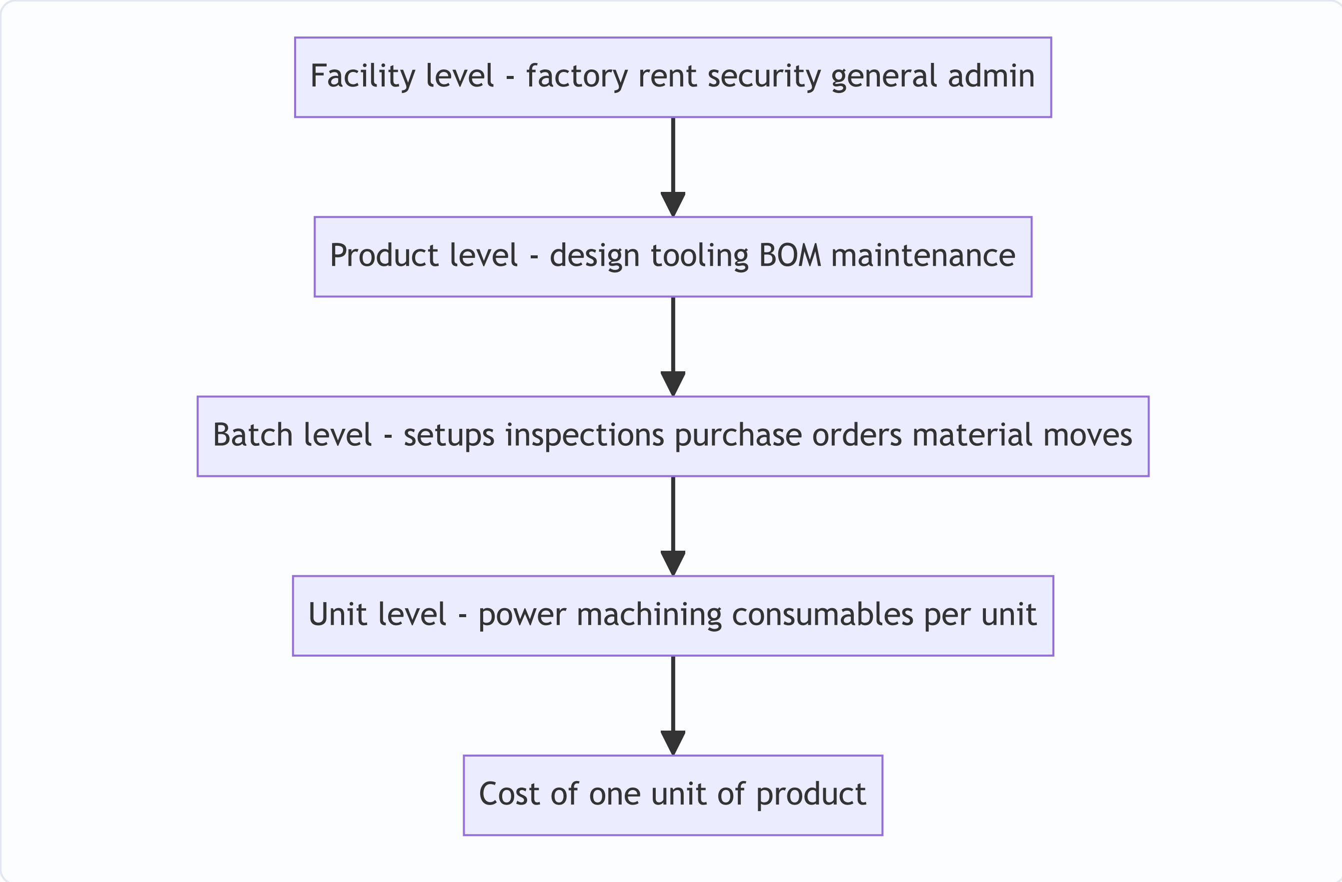


Figure 2 — Cooper's activity hierarchy: costs sit at the level of the thing that triggers them; only unit-level cost is truly volume-driven.

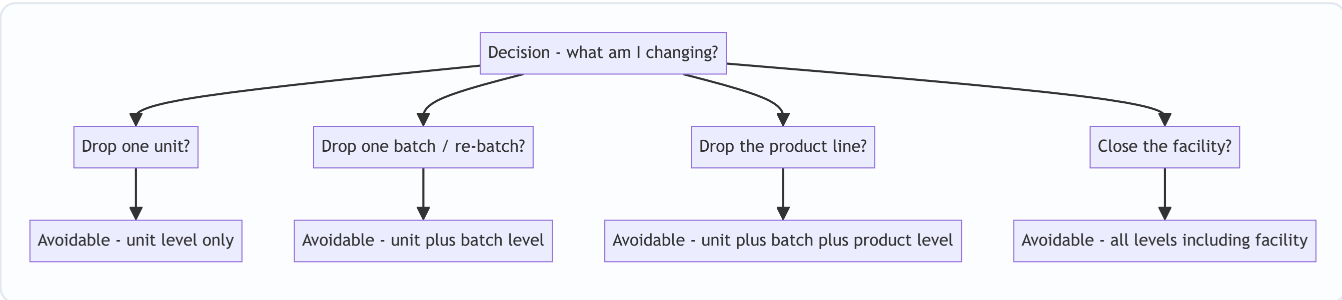


Figure 3 — Match the decision to the hierarchy level: only costs at or below the level you are changing are avoidable.

4.4 The ABC procedure — seven steps, each with its "why"

1. **Identify the major activities** in the organisation (setup, inspect, purchase, machine, dispatch). *Why:* activities are where resources are actually consumed.
2. **Create a cost pool for each activity** and gather its total overhead (stage-1 tracing using resource drivers). *Why:* you cannot compute a rate on an un-totalled cost.
3. **Identify the cost driver** for each pool — the factor causing its cost. *Why:* this is the fair charging basis that replaces the single volume base.
4. **Compute the cost driver rate** = Cost pool ÷ Total quantity of the driver. *Why:* this "prices" one unit of the activity.

5. **Measure each product's consumption** of every driver (how many setups, orders, inspections it demanded). *Why:* stage-2 tracing needs the quantity each product pulls.
6. **Charge overhead to products** = driver rate × driver quantity consumed, summed across all activities. *Why:* cost now follows causation, not volume.
7. **Add prime cost** (direct material + direct labour) to get total cost, then unit cost = total ÷ units. *Why:* to get a full cost usable for pricing/mix decisions.

Master formulae

$$\text{Cost Driver Rate} = \frac{\text{Total Cost of Activity Pool}}{\text{Total Cost Driver Quantity}}$$

$$\text{Overhead to a Product} = \sum_{\text{all activities}} \left(\text{Driver Rate} \times \text{Driver Units consumed by product} \right)$$

$$\text{Traditional Rate} = \frac{\text{Total Overhead}}{\text{Total Volume Base (labour hrs / machine hrs / units)}}$$

A practical warning about step 1 — the granularity trade-off. How *many* activities should you identify? Too few, and you are back to blanket averaging (the disease). Too many, and the system costs more to run than the accuracy is worth, and near-identical pools clutter the analysis. In practice, activities driven by the *same* driver and behaving alike are **merged into a single cost pool** (a "homogeneous cost pool" — costs within it must move in proportion to *one* driver). The art of ABC is choosing the *fewest* pools that still keep each pool homogeneous. Exams hand you the pools pre-chosen, but a theory question may ask *why* you don't just create a pool per invoice line — the answer is the granularity trade-off.

4.5 When does ABC pay off? (a decision in itself)

ABC is itself a cost — it takes time and money to run. Adopt it only when the *distortion it removes* is worth more than the *effort it costs*. It pays off when:

- **Overheads are a large share of total cost** (small overhead → small distortion → not worth it).
- **Product/customer range is diverse** in volume and complexity (a single product cannot be mis-costed relative to itself).
- **Non-volume-driven overheads dominate** — lots of setups, inspections, handling, purchasing.
- **Competition is fierce and pricing must be sharp** — you cannot afford to mis-price.
- **Product-mix and pricing decisions are frequent and high-stakes.**

It does **not** pay off in a single-product plant, or where overhead is tiny, or where all overhead genuinely varies with volume.

4.6 Limitations of ABC — the balanced-view marks

An exam that asks you to *evaluate* ABC wants the costs of the cure, not just the disease. State these crisply:

- **Expensive to install and run.** Identifying activities, choosing drivers and continuously measuring driver volumes consumes management time and IT spend. For many firms the extra accuracy does not justify the cost.
- **Not every cost has a clean driver.** Facility-level costs (and some product-level costs) still get an arbitrary allocation — ABC *reduces* but never *eliminates* arbitrariness. Claiming ABC removes all arbitrariness is a conceptual error.

- **Too many activities/pools breed complexity.** Over-refinement produces a system nobody maintains; pools drift out of date as processes change.
- **It is still (largely) a full-absorption, historical system.** Ordinary ABC loads facility-level fixed costs onto units and reports a full "cost", which — as Section 8.8 warns — is *not* the relevant cost for short-run drop/keep or special-order pricing. ABC sharpens the *long-run* picture, not automatically the short-run decision.
- **Behavioural resistance and measurement gaming.** People whose products suddenly look loss-making resist; driver counts self-reported by departments can be massaged.

The honest conclusion: ABC is a *better model*, not a *perfect* or *free* one. It replaces one large, hidden distortion (volume averaging) with smaller, visible imperfections (residual allocation of facility cost, measurement cost). Whether that trade is worth it is the "when does ABC pay off" test of 4.5.

5. Worked Examples

Example 1 — The plastic-bottle plant (easy: see the re-pricing)

Data. A plant makes **Standard** (1,00,000 units) and **Premium** (10,000 units). Prime cost: Standard ₹40/unit, Premium ₹60/unit. Total production overhead ₹22,00,000. Machine hours: Standard 50,000, Premium 5,000 (each product uses 0.5 machine hr/unit). Overhead analysed into pools:

Activity	Cost pool (₹)	Driver	Standard	Premium	Total
Machining (power, consumables)	5,50,000	Machine hours	50,000	5,000	55,000
Machine setups	6,00,000	No. of setups	20	100	120
Quality inspection	4,50,000	No. of inspections	30	120	150
Purchasing	3,00,000	No. of purchase orders	40	160	200
Material handling	3,00,000	No. of material movements	50	100	150
Total	**22,00,000**				

Step A — Traditional costing (single machine-hour rate):

$$\text{Rate} = \frac{22,00,000}{55,000 \text{ mc hrs}} = ₹40 \text{ per machine hour}$$

Each unit uses 0.5 mc hr → ₹20 overhead per unit for *both* products.

	Standard	Premium
Prime cost/unit	40.00	60.00
Overhead/unit (₹40 × 0.5)	20.00	20.00
Total cost/unit (traditional)	**60.00**	**80.00**

Step B — ABC. First the driver rates:

Activity	Pool ÷ driver total	Rate
Machining	5,50,000 ÷ 55,000	₹10 / machine hr
Setups	6,00,000 ÷ 120	₹5,000 / setup
Inspection	4,50,000 ÷ 150	₹3,000 / inspection
Purchasing	3,00,000 ÷ 200	₹1,500 / order
Material handling	3,00,000 ÷ 150	₹2,000 / movement

Now charge each product:

Activity	Standard (qty × rate)	₹	Premium (qty × rate)	₹
Machining	50,000 × 10	5,00,000	5,000 × 10	50,000
Setups	20 × 5,000	1,00,000	100 × 5,000	5,00,000
Inspection	30 × 3,000	90,000	120 × 3,000	3,60,000
Purchasing	40 × 1,500	60,000	160 × 1,500	2,40,000
Material handling	50 × 2,000	1,00,000	100 × 2,000	2,00,000
Total overhead		**8,50,000**		**13,50,000**
÷ units	÷ 1,00,000	**₹8.50**	÷ 10,000	**₹135.00**

Reconciliation (always do this): 8,50,000 + 13,50,000 = **22,00,000** ✓ (equals total overhead — nothing created or lost, only re-traced).

	Standard	Premium
Prime cost/unit	40.00	60.00
Overhead/unit (ABC)	8.50	135.00
Total cost/unit (ABC)	**48.50**	**195.00**
Total cost/unit (traditional)	60.00	80.00
Distortion	over-costed by ₹11.50	**under-costed by ₹115**

The decision. If Premium sells at ₹112 (which "looked" like a 40% margin on the traditional ₹80 cost), ABC reveals it actually costs ₹195 — a **loss of ₹83 per unit.** Every Premium order chased was destroying value. Standard, meanwhile, is far cheaper than believed (₹48.50 not ₹60) — there is room to cut price and win volume. Traditional costing had the entire strategy backwards. *This is the whole point of the chapter in one table.*

Cross-subsidy quantified (the conservation check made vivid). Traditional loaded Standard with ₹20 × 1,00,000 = ₹20,00,000 of overhead; ABC loads it with only ₹8,50,000 — Standard was *over-charged by ₹11,50,000*. Premium under the old system carried ₹20 × 10,000 = ₹2,00,000; ABC loads ₹13,50,000 — Premium was *under-charged by ₹11,50,000*. **The two numbers are identical** (₹11.50 × 1,00,000 = ₹115 × 10,000 = ₹11,50,000). That equality is not a coincidence; it is conservation of overhead — every rupee lifted off Standard was sitting on Premium. If your two "distortion" figures don't tie, you have erred.

Example 2 — Setup-driven distortion, ICAI style (moderate)

Data. A company makes three products A, B, C.

	A	B	C
Output (units)	30,000	20,000	8,000
Machine hrs/unit	1	1	2
Direct labour hrs/unit	1	1	1
No. of production runs (batches)	3	7	20
No. of purchase orders	15	25	60

Overhead: Setup ₹1,20,000; Stores/purchasing ₹1,50,000; Machine-related (power, depreciation) ₹3,00,000. Total ₹5,70,000. Direct material: A ₹50, B ₹40, C ₹30 per unit. Labour ₹20/hr.

Traditional (labour-hour rate). Total labour hrs = 30,000 + 20,000 + 8,000 = 58,000.

$$\text{Rate} = \frac{5,70,000}{58,000} = ₹9.827586/\text{labour hr} \approx ₹9.83$$

Overhead/unit (1 labour hr each) = ₹9.83 for A, B, C alike.

	A	B	C
Material	50.00	40.00	30.00
Labour (1 hr × 20)	20.00	20.00	20.00
Overhead (traditional)	9.83	9.83	9.83
Total (traditional)	**79.83**	**69.83**	**59.83**

ABC. Machine-related cost is unit/volume-level → driver = machine hours. Total machine hrs = 30,000×1 + 20,000×1 + 8,000×2 = 66,000.

Activity	Pool	Driver total	Rate
Setup	1,20,000	30 runs	₹4,000 / run
Stores/purchasing	1,50,000	100 orders	₹1,500 / order
Machine-related	3,00,000	66,000 mc hrs	₹4.545455 / mc hr

Charge to products:

Activity	A	B	C
Setup (runs × 4,000)	12,000	28,000	80,000
Purchasing (orders × 1,500)	22,500	37,500	90,000
Machine (mc hr × 4.545455)	1,36,364	90,909	72,727
Total overhead (₹)	**1,70,864**	**1,56,409**	**2,42,727**
÷ units	30,000	20,000	8,000
Overhead/unit	**5.70**	**7.82**	**30.34**

Reconciliation: 1,70,864 + 1,56,409 + 2,42,727 = ₹5,70,000 ✓ (rounding within ₹1).

	A	B	C
Material	50.00	40.00	30.00
Labour	20.00	20.00	20.00
Overhead (ABC)	5.70	7.82	30.34
Total (ABC)	**75.70**	**67.82**	**80.34**
Total (traditional)	79.83	69.83	59.83

Reading it. High-volume A and B are slightly over-costed under traditional; low-volume, batch-heavy, machine-hungry **C is massively under-costed** — traditional said ₹59.83, ABC says ₹80.34, a **₹20.51 (34%) understatement.** C has 20 of the 30 production runs and 60 of the 100 purchase orders despite being the smallest by volume — its complexity, invisible to a labour-hour rate, is exactly what ABC surfaces. If C were priced off the ₹59.83 figure it could be sold at a loss.

What if the examiner tweaks it — the machine-hour base swap. Suppose the traditional rate were struck on *machine hours* (66,000) instead of labour hours. Then rate = 5,70,000 ÷ 66,000 = ₹8.6364/mc hr, and traditional overhead/unit becomes A ₹8.64, B ₹8.64, **C ₹17.27** (C uses 2 mc hr). Notice C's understatement *shrinks* from ₹20.51 to ₹13.07 — because a machine-hour base already captures *part* of C's extra machine intensity, whereas a labour-hour base captured none of it. **The size of ABC's correction depends on how badly the chosen traditional base correlates with the real drivers.** A labour base on a machine-intensive product distorts more; a machine base distorts less but still misses the setup and purchasing complexity entirely. This is a favourite "explain the difference" follow-up: the base you compare against changes the *magnitude* of the distortion but never its *direction*.

Example 3 — Full ABC cost sheet with profit and a customer-level insight (exam-hard)

Data. "Precision Ltd" makes **Deluxe** (low volume, complex) and **Regular** (high volume, simple).

	Deluxe	Regular
Annual output (units)	5,000	45,000
Selling price / unit (₹)	260	120
Direct material / unit (₹)	80	45
Direct labour hrs / unit	2	1.5
Machine hrs / unit	3	2
Labour rate	₹30 / hr	₹30 / hr

Overhead pools and drivers:

Activity	Cost pool (₹)	Driver	Deluxe	Regular	Total
Machine operation	9,90,000	Machine hrs	15,000	90,000	1,05,000
Setups	3,20,000	No. of setups	60	20	80
Production scheduling	1,50,000	No. of production orders	40	10	50
Quality control	2,10,000	No. of inspections	90	15	105
Despatch	1,80,000	No. of despatch notes	200	100	300
Total overhead	**18,50,000**				

Part 1 — Traditional (machine-hour) cost & profit.

$$\text{Rate} = \frac{18,50,000}{1,05,000 \text{ mc hrs}} = ₹17.619048/\text{mc hr}$$

Deluxe uses 3 mc hr → ₹52.86/unit; Regular uses 2 mc hr → ₹35.24/unit.

Traditional cost sheet	Deluxe	Regular
Direct material	80.00	45.00
Direct labour (hrs × 30)	60.00	45.00
Prime cost	**140.00**	**90.00**
Overhead (mc hr × 17.619)	52.86	35.24
Total cost / unit	**192.86**	**125.24**
Selling price	260.00	120.00
Profit / (loss) / unit	**67.14**	**(5.24)**

Traditional verdict: Deluxe hugely profitable, **Regular a loss-maker** — "we should drop Regular." Watch ABC destroy this conclusion.

Part 2 — ABC. Driver rates:

Activity	Pool ÷ total	Rate
Machine operation	9,90,000 ÷ 1,05,000	₹9.428571 / mc hr
Setups	3,20,000 ÷ 80	₹4,000 / setup
Scheduling	1,50,000 ÷ 50	₹3,000 / order
Quality control	2,10,000 ÷ 105	₹2,000 / inspection
Despatch	1,80,000 ÷ 300	₹600 / note

Overhead charged:

Activity	Deluxe (₹)	Regular (₹)
Machine operation	15,000 × 9.428571 = 1,41,429	90,000 × 9.428571 = 8,48,571
Setups	60 × 4,000 = 2,40,000	20 × 4,000 = 80,000
Scheduling	40 × 3,000 = 1,20,000	10 × 3,000 = 30,000
Quality control	90 × 2,000 = 1,80,000	15 × 2,000 = 30,000
Despatch	200 × 600 = 1,20,000	100 × 600 = 60,000
Total overhead	**8,01,429**	**10,48,571**
÷ units	÷ 5,000	÷ 45,000
Overhead / unit	**160.29**	**23.30**

Reconciliation: 8,01,429 + 10,48,571 = **18,50,000** ✓.

ABC cost sheet	Deluxe	Regular
Direct material	80.00	45.00
Direct labour	60.00	45.00
Prime cost	**140.00**	**90.00**
Overhead (ABC)	160.29	23.30
Total cost / unit	**300.29**	**113.30**
Selling price	260.00	120.00
Profit / (loss) / unit	**(40.29)**	**6.70**

The reversal — the exam's whole point.

Per unit	Deluxe (Trad)	Deluxe (ABC)	Regular (Trad)	Regular (ABC)
Total cost	192.86	**300.29**	125.24	**113.30**
Profit/(loss)	67.14	**(40.29)**	(5.24)	**6.70**

Traditional costing told Precision Ltd to **push Deluxe and drop Regular.** ABC reveals the exact opposite: **Deluxe loses ₹40 a unit** (its 60 setups, 40 orders and 90 inspections, invisible to a machine-hour rate, are the true cost), while **Regular actually earns ₹6.70.** Acting on the traditional numbers would have grown the loss-maker and killed the earner. *Same total ₹18,50,000 of overhead — only the tracing changed — and the strategic conclusion flipped 180°*. That is why ABC exists.

Whole-firm check. Total profit ABC: Deluxe (−40.29 × 5,000 = −2,01,450) + Regular (6.70 × 45,000 = 3,01,500) ≈ ₹1,00,050. Total sales − (prime + overhead): Sales = 5,000×260 + 45,000×120 = 13,00,000 + 54,00,000 = 67,00,000. Prime = 5,000×140 + 45,000×90 = 7,00,000 + 40,50,000 = 47,50,000. Overhead = 18,50,000. Profit = 67,00,000 − 47,50,000 − 18,50,000 = **₹1,00,000** ✓ (matches within rounding). *ABC re-slices the pie; it never changes its size.*

Part 3 — the two-stage decision trap (do NOT just drop Deluxe). A weak answer stops at "Deluxe loses ₹40, discontinue it." Test it against the hierarchy. Deluxe's ₹160.29/unit ABC overhead contains machine operation (unit-level, ₹28.29), setups + scheduling + quality control + despatch (batch-level, largely avoidable if the line goes) — but *does the ₹18,50,000 pot contain facility-level cost that will simply re-spread onto Regular if Deluxe leaves?* In this data every pool has a genuine activity driver, so most of Deluxe's overhead is avoidable — but the exam-hard move is to *say so explicitly* and compute the *avoidable* cost. If, say, ₹40,000 of the "machine operation" pool were actually facility depreciation that stays regardless, then dropping Deluxe would dump that ₹40,000 onto Regular, and Regular's healthy ₹6.70 could shrink. **The ABC full-cost loss is a red flag, not a verdict.** The verdict needs avoidable-cost (contribution) analysis. Section 8.8 is this trap; graders reserve marks for the caveat.

Example 4 — Reverse-engineering: find the missing driver volume (twist)

Data. An examiner gives you the *answer* and hides an input — a common "do you really understand the mechanism" twist. Plant runs one activity, **inspection**, cost pool ₹4,80,000. Two products, X and Y. X's inspection charge came to ₹3,00,000 for its 150 inspections; Y's total inspections are unknown. What is the inspection rate, Y's inspection count, and Y's inspection charge?

Work. X's rate is recoverable directly: ₹3,00,000 ÷ 150 = **₹2,000 / inspection** (the rate is the same for both products — that is the whole point of a single pool). Y's charge = pool − X's charge = 4,80,000 − 3,00,000 = **₹1,80,000.** Y's inspections = 1,80,000 ÷ 2,000 = **90 inspections.**

Reconciliation: total inspections 150 + 90 = 240; 240 × ₹2,000 = ₹4,80,000 ✓ = pool. The lesson: **the driver rate is a property of the pool, shared by every product** — so given any one product's charge *and* its driver units you can unlock the rate, and from the rate everything else. Questions that "hide" a number are testing exactly this: rate = pool ÷ total units is one equation you can rearrange three ways.

Example 5 — Customer-level ABC (the modern exam frontier)

Data. A distributor's selling & distribution overhead is ₹12,00,000, analysed into three activities. It serves two customer *types*, both buying the **same** ₹1,000-margin-before-S&D product, so traditional costing (which spreads S&D per rupee of sales or per unit) says both customers are equally profitable. Are they?

Activity	Cost pool (₹)	Driver	Big-Box (few, large orders)	Corner-Shops (many, tiny orders)	Total
Order processing	4,00,000	No. of orders	50	750	800
Delivery	5,00,000	No. of deliveries	100	900	1,000
Sales-rep visits	3,00,000	No. of visits	20	280	300

Units sold: Big-Box 10,000 units, Corner-Shops 10,000 units (deliberately equal, so volume cannot explain the answer). Contribution before S&D: ₹1,000/unit each → ₹1,00,00,000 each.

Rates. Order processing 4,00,000 ÷ 800 = ₹500/order. Delivery 5,00,000 ÷ 1,000 = ₹500/delivery. Visits 3,00,000 ÷ 300 = ₹1,000/visit.

S&D charged.

Activity	Big-Box (₹)	Corner-Shops (₹)
Order processing	50 × 500 = 25,000	750 × 500 = 3,75,000
Delivery	100 × 500 = 50,000	900 × 500 = 4,50,000
Sales-rep visits	20 × 1,000 = 20,000	280 × 1,000 = 2,80,000
Total S&D	**95,000**	**11,05,000**

Reconciliation: 95,000 + 11,05,000 = **12,00,000** ✓.

Customer profitability	Big-Box	Corner-Shops
Contribution before S&D	1,00,00,000	1,00,00,000
Less ABC S&D cost	(95,000)	(11,05,000)
Net customer profit	**99,05,000**	**88,95,000**
Traditional view (½ of ₹12,00,000 each)	94,00,000	94,00,000

Reading it. Traditional costing, spreading S&D equally over equal volume, declares both customers worth ₹94,00,000. ABC reveals **Corner-Shops consume ₹11,05,000 of servicing effort against Big-Box's ₹95,000** — because they place 15× the orders and take 9× the deliveries for the *same* sales. Big-Box is ₹10,10,000 *more* profitable than the average suggested; Corner-Shops ₹5,05,000 *less*. **The decision this drives is not "drop small customers" but "change how you serve them"** — minimum order sizes, order-consolidation incentives, self-service ordering to strip the ₹500/order cost. This is ABC feeding ABM at the *customer* level, and it is exactly the kind of "cost object need not be a product" question that separates strong scripts from rote ones.

6. Presentation / Format

The ABC working, examiner-approved order (show every stage — marks are for method, not just the answer):

1. **Statement of Cost Driver Rates** — a table: Activity | Cost pool | Cost driver | Total driver units | Rate.
2. **Statement of Overhead Absorbed** — a table with one column per product, one row per activity: driver units × rate; total the columns.
3. **Cost Sheet per unit** — Direct material + Direct labour = Prime cost; + Overhead (from step 2 ÷ units); = Total cost; − from Selling price = Profit.
4. **Comparison / Comment** — a table contrasting traditional vs ABC unit cost and the decision implication. *The comment carries marks — always state which product is over/under-costed and the decision.*

Golden rules: always **reconcile** total overhead absorbed back to total overhead given; **carry 4–6 decimals** in driver rates (round only the final answer) to keep the reconciliation clean; and **label the driver** for every pool.

A worked layout habit that saves marks under time pressure. Compute driver rates *once*, in a top block, and never re-derive them mid-answer — every product charge is then just "units × the rate you already have". Lay the overhead-absorbed statement with *products as columns and activities as rows*, then add a **total row and a per-unit row** at the bottom; the total row is what you reconcile, the per-unit row is what feeds the cost sheet. If a question asks for both traditional and ABC, put them **side by side** in the final comparison so the over/under-costing jumps out — graders scan for that contrast table. When output volumes differ, keep total-rupee and per-unit figures in *clearly separate rows*; mixing them is the commonest presentation error and it silently corrupts the reconciliation.

7. Connections

- **Chapter on Overheads (traditional absorption):** ABC is a *refinement* of overhead absorption, not a replacement of the whole system. Prime cost is computed identically; only the second stage — spreading overhead — changes from one blanket/departmental rate to many activity rates.
- **Marginal Costing & CVP:** ABC sharpens *which* costs are truly fixed vs variable. Batch- and product-level costs are "fixed" to volume but "variable" to complexity — an insight marginal costing's simple fixed/variable split misses.
- **Budgetary Control → Activity-Based Budgeting (ABB):** run the ABC logic in reverse — forecast activity volumes (setups, orders), then the resources they'll need.
- **Cost Management → Activity-Based Management (ABM):** ABC *measures* activity cost; ABM *acts* on it — eliminating non-value-added activities (e.g. reduce setups via SMED, cut inspections via quality-at-source).
- **Decision-making chapters (make-or-buy, pricing, product mix):** ABC feeds these the *right* product cost. Every distortion example above is really a mis-made decision.
- **Target Costing / Life-Cycle Costing:** both rely on trustworthy activity-level cost data that only ABC provides.

Two connections worth spelling out because they recur in theory questions.

- **ABC → Activity-Based Budgeting (ABB), the exact reversal.** ABC flows *actual resources → activities → products* to find cost. ABB flows the other way: start from *budgeted output → the activities that output will demand → the resources those activities need → the budget*. So if next year's plan needs 500 setups and each setup consumes ₹5,000 of resource, ABB budgets ₹25,00,000 for the setup activity — a far more defensible number than "last year's setup cost + 5%". The link to examine: ABB makes *budgets driver-based*, exposing that a 10% rise in *small orders* costs far more than a 10% rise in *volume*.

- **ABC → ABM, operational vs strategic.** ABM splits into **operational ABM** ("do things right" — make the same activities cheaper: SMED to cut setup time, quality-at-source to cut inspection) and **strategic ABM** ("do the right things" — change the product/customer mix, re-price, or re-design products to demand fewer costly activities). ABC supplies the numbers; ABM chooses the lever. Being able to name both flavours is a stock 4-mark theory ask.

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Facility-level costs are not driver-traceable.** If a question gives "general factory administration" or rent with no sensible driver, either allocate on a stated arbitrary base *and say so*, or treat as a period cost — do **not** invent a spurious driver.
2. **Using the wrong driver quantity.** For machine-related overhead the driver is *total machine hours* = units × mc hr/unit — **not** units. Forgetting to multiply by hours/unit is the single most common arithmetic slip.
3. **Not reconciling.** If your two products' absorbed overhead doesn't sum back to total overhead, you have an error. Reconcile *before* writing the comment.
4. **Rounding the driver rate too early.** Round ₹9.428571 to ₹9.43 across 90,000 machine hours and you throw the reconciliation off by hundreds of rupees. Keep decimals; round last.
5. **Confusing the two stages.** Resource drivers put cost *into* pools (stage 1); activity/cost drivers push pools *onto products* (stage 2). Exams usually give pools pre-totalled (stage 1 done) — don't re-split them.
6. **Assuming ABC always raises low-volume cost.** It usually does, but only because low-volume products are usually complex. The mechanism is *complexity*, not volume per se — a low-volume but simple product may barely move.
7. **"ABC gives more accurate profit for the P&L."** No. Total profit is **identical** under both systems (Example 3's whole-firm check proves it). ABC only changes profit *per product*. Claiming ABC changes total profit is a conceptual error examiners punish.
8. **Recommending to drop a "loss" product without marginal analysis.** ABC unit "loss" includes facility-level fixed cost that won't disappear if you drop the product. Combine ABC with contribution analysis before recommending withdrawal — a favourite two-part question.
9. **Number-of-setups vs setup-hours.** If the question gives setup *hours*, use them (duration driver); if it gives number of setups, use count (transaction driver). Read which is offered.
10. **Mixing per-unit and total figures in one column.** Driver charges are *totals* (100 setups × ₹5,000 = ₹5,00,000 for the whole product); the cost *sheet* is *per unit* (÷ output). Students who divide by units too early, or forget to divide at all, get a cost sheet that neither reconciles nor makes sense. Keep a total-overhead row and a per-unit row physically separate (Section 6).
11. **Choosing the "given" traditional base without reading it.** If the question says the firm *currently* absorbs on labour hours, your traditional column must use labour hours — even if machine hours are also given. Answering the "traditional vs ABC" contrast against the *wrong* base changes the whole comparison. The base is a stated fact, not your choice.
12. **Averaging setup cost per unit inside a batch.** ₹5,000 per setup is *per setup*, full stop. Do not "smooth" it to ₹5,000 ÷ batch size and then re-multiply by units — that silently reintroduces volume-averaging, the very disease ABC cures, and it will not reconcile. Charge whole setups by count.
13. **Treating an over-costed product's "saving" as new profit.** When ABC lowers Standard's cost, the firm has not *earned* anything — total profit is unchanged. The lower cost only means Standard *can* be priced

more competitively; whether that raises profit depends on the market response, not on the re-costing itself.

14. **Assuming more pools always means more accuracy.** Beyond the point where each pool is homogeneous, extra pools add cost and clutter without adding accuracy (Section 4.4 granularity trade-off). "Split every invoice into its own pool" is wrong; homogeneity, not maximal granularity, is the goal.
15. **Forgetting that the driver total must be the *whole plant's* count, not one product's.** The rate's denominator is *total* driver units across all products (e.g. 120 setups), so that the pool is fully absorbed. Dividing a pool by a single product's setups inflates the rate and breaks reconciliation.

9. First-Principles Recap

Strip everything away and here is the spine:

- Overhead is **caused** — by activities, and activities are demanded by products in proportion to complexity, not volume.
- Traditional costing charges overhead by a **single volume base**, so it over-charges high-volume simple products and under-charges low-volume complex ones. When overhead is large and products are diverse, that distortion is big enough to reverse pricing and product-mix decisions.
- ABC traces cost along its true chain — **Resources → Activities (cost pools) → Products (via cost drivers)** — so cost follows causation. Rate = pool ÷ driver total; charge = rate × units consumed.
- ABC does **not** change total cost or total profit — it only **re-slices** them, and the re-slicing is what makes the *decision* right.
- Use it only where the distortion is worth the effort: **big overhead, diverse products, non-volume drivers, sharp-pricing markets.** Otherwise the simpler system is the better decision.

Everything else — Cooper's hierarchy, transaction vs duration drivers, ABM — is machinery hung on that spine. If you can re-derive "cost follows causation, trace it there," you can reconstruct the whole chapter.

Three deeper truths that make the spine bullet-proof under a tough examiner:

- **The disease is averaging, not volume.** Volume is only the *usual* base; the real fault is averaging a cost across items that consume it unequally. ABC's cure is *narrower, homogeneous pools* so the average inside each stops lying. State the disease this way and you can handle a labour-hour, machine-hour or per-rupee-of-sales base identically.
- **Conservation is your compass.** Because the pot is fixed, over-costing one product is exactly under-costing another; the two distortions are equal and opposite. That single fact gives you the reconciliation check, the cross-subsidy interpretation, and the "total profit is unchanged" answer, all at once.
- **Full cost is not relevant cost.** ABC computes a better *full* cost; but drop/keep and special-order pricing turn on *avoidable* cost. Map each cost to its hierarchy level, keep only what is avoidable for the decision at hand, and never discontinue a product on an ABC unit loss alone.

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

Item	Formula / Rule
Cost driver rate	Activity cost pool ÷ Total cost driver quantity
Overhead to a product	Σ (driver rate × driver units the product consumes)
Traditional OH rate	Total overhead ÷ Total volume base (labour hrs / mc hrs / units)
Machine-hr driver total	Σ (units × machine hrs per unit) — **not** units alone
Unit cost	(Prime cost + Overhead absorbed) ÷ units, or per-unit prime + per-unit OH
Reconciliation check	Σ overhead absorbed by all products = Total overhead given
Total profit under ABC	= Total profit under traditional (only per-product profit differs)
Cross-subsidy check	₹ over-costed on one product = ₹ under-costed on the other (conservation)

Activity hierarchy → driver

Level	Triggered by	Typical driver	Avoidable if you...
Unit	each unit	machine hrs / labour hrs / units	drop one unit
Batch	each batch/run	no. of setups, orders, inspections, moves	drop/merge a batch
Product	each product line	no. of products, design hours	drop the product line
Facility	factory existing	none — arbitrary allocation or period cost	close the facility

Distortion direction (memorise): Traditional **over-costs** high-volume simple products; **under-costs** low-volume complex products. ABC reverses both.

Driver types (accuracy ladder): Transaction (count — cheap, use when uniform) → Duration (time — use when occurrences vary) → Intensity/direct-charge (actual resources — dearest, for genuinely special jobs).

Driver-choice tests: must be *causal* (moves the pool) AND *measurable* (cheap to count). Perfect-but-unmeasurable is useless; measurable-but-non-causal is misleading.

ABC pays off when: overhead large · product range diverse · non-volume overheads dominate · pricing must be sharp. **Not worth it when:** single product · trivial overhead · all overhead volume-driven.

Limitations (balanced view): costly to run · residual arbitrariness on facility cost · over-refinement risk · still a full-absorption/historical model (not automatically relevant cost) · behavioural resistance.

Seven steps: identify activities → pool costs → identify drivers → compute rates → measure product consumption → charge overhead → add prime cost.

Cost objects: ABC can cost a *product, order, customer or channel* — not just products (Example 5).

ABC vs ABM: ABC *measures* activity cost; ABM *manages* it — **operational ABM** makes activities cheaper (do things right), **strategic ABM** changes the mix/design to demand fewer activities (do the right things).

ABC vs ABB: ABC works actuals *forward* (resources→products) to find cost; ABB works the plan *backward* (output→activities→resources) to set a driver-based budget.

Q&A — Activity-Based Costing (ABC)

CA Intermediate · Cost & Management Accounting · Exam-oriented question bank. Every question is followed immediately by a complete model answer. All figures in Rupees (₹). ICAI conventions.

Section A — Concept-Check (short answer)

A1. Define Activity-Based Costing. ABC is a costing system that assigns overheads to products/services on the basis of the **activities** they consume, using **cost drivers** as the allocation base, instead of a single volume-based rate. Overheads are first pooled by activity, then charged to products in proportion to each product's usage of the relevant driver.

A2. Why can a traditional single-rate cost sheet mislead the board on product profitability? Traditional absorption uses a **volume base** (labour hours / machine hours). High-volume simple products absorb *most* overhead because they clock the most hours, while low-volume complex products (which trigger many set-ups, inspections, orders) absorb *too little*. This **cross-subsidy** makes simple products look unprofitable and complex products look profitable — the reverse of reality.

A3. Explain the restaurant bill-split analogy. Splitting a restaurant bill equally (per head) overcharges the person who ate a salad and undercharges the one who ordered lobster and wine. ABC is the "pay for what you actually consumed" method — each diner pays for the dishes they ordered, just as each product bears the cost of the activities it actually triggers.

A4. State the two-stage causal chain in ABC. Stage 1: **Resources → Activities** (overhead costs are pooled into activity cost pools via *resource drivers*). Stage 2: **Activities → Cost objects** (activity costs are charged to products via *activity/cost drivers*). Causality — "activities cause cost, products cause activities" — drives both stages.

A5. Distinguish a *resource driver* from an *activity (cost) driver*. A **resource driver** allocates the cost of a resource (e.g., power, rent, salaries) to activity pools (Stage 1). An **activity/cost driver** allocates the cost in an activity pool to products (Stage 2), e.g., number of set-ups, number of purchase orders, inspection hours.

A6. List Cooper's four-level activity hierarchy with one driver each. 1. **Unit-level** — performed for each unit (machining) → machine hours/units. 2. **Batch-level** — performed per batch (set-ups, material handling) → number of set-ups/batches. 3. **Product-level (product-sustaining)** — support a product line (design, spec maintenance) → number of products/design changes. 4. **Facility-level (facility-sustaining)** — sustain the plant (rent, security, plant management) → allocated on some fair base (often not driver-traceable; sometimes kept as a lump absorbed on floor area).

A7. Give the master formula for a cost-driver (recovery) rate and product overhead. Cost driver rate = **Activity cost pool ÷ Total cost driver volume**. Overhead to a product = **Cost driver rate × Driver quantity consumed by that product**.

A8. When does ABC "pay off" (conditions favouring adoption)? When (i) overheads are a large proportion of total cost, (ii) product/customer diversity is high (mix of volumes, sizes, complexity), (iii) non-volume activities (set-ups, inspection, handling) are significant, (iv) intense competition demands accurate pricing, and (v) the cost of measuring drivers is justified by better decisions.

A9. What is Activity-Based Management (ABM) and how does it differ from ABC? ABC is the **costing** technique (assigns cost). ABM **uses** ABC information to improve operations — eliminating **non-value-added activities**, cost reduction, pricing, and process re-engineering. ABC produces the numbers; ABM acts on them.

A10. Value-added vs non-value-added activity — define and give an example of each. A **value-added activity** increases worth to the customer (machining, assembly). A **non-value-added activity** adds cost but no customer worth and should be minimised/eliminated (storage, inspection, moving, waiting, rework).

Section B — Graded Computational Problems

B1 (Easy) — Single activity rate and re-pricing

A factory has overhead of ₹4,00,000 driven by machine set-ups. Total set-ups = 200. Product X needs 40 set-ups; Product Y needs 160 set-ups.

Required: (a) cost-driver rate, (b) overhead to each product.

Solution. (a) Rate = 4,00,000 ÷ 200 = **₹2,000 per set-up**. (b) Product X = 2,000 × 40 = **₹80,000**; Product Y = 2,000 × 160 = **₹3,20,000**. Check: 80,000 + 3,20,000 = 4,00,000 ✓

B2 (Easy–Moderate) — Traditional vs ABC, two products

Blitz Ltd makes **A** (10,000 units) and **B** (2,000 units). Total overhead ₹6,00,000. Labour hours: A = 20,000, B = 4,000 (0.5 hr + 2 hr per unit? — take totals as given: A 20,000, B 4,000). Overhead splits by activity:

Activity	Cost (₹)	Driver	A	B	Total
Machining	2,40,000	machine hrs	20,000	4,000	24,000
Set-ups	1,80,000	set-ups	30	90	120
Inspection	1,80,000	inspections	40	160	200

Required: Overhead per unit under (a) traditional labour-hour rate, (b) ABC.

Solution. Traditional rate = 6,00,000 ÷ (20,000 + 4,000) = **₹25 per labour hr**. - A: 25 × 20,000 = 5,00,000 → **₹50/unit**. - B: 25 × 4,000 = 1,00,000 → **₹50/unit**.

ABC driver rates: - Machining = 2,40,000 ÷ 24,000 = ₹10/mc hr. - Set-ups = 1,80,000 ÷ 120 = ₹1,500/set-up. - Inspection = 1,80,000 ÷ 200 = ₹900/inspection.

	A (₹)	B (₹)
Machining	10×20,000 = 2,00,000	10×4,000 = 40,000
Set-ups	1,500×30 = 45,000	1,500×90 = 1,35,000
Inspection	900×40 = 36,000	900×160 = 1,44,000
Total	**2,81,000**	**3,19,000**
Units	10,000	2,000
Per unit	**₹28.10**	**₹159.50**

Check: 2,81,000 + 3,19,000 = 6,00,000 ✓ **Insight:** low-volume complex B was undercosted at ₹50; true ABC cost ₹159.50. Traditional cross-subsidised B at the expense of A.

B3 (Moderate) — Full cost & profit reconciliation

Nova Ltd, two products **P** and **Q**:

	P	Q
Output (units)	4,000	1,000
Direct material/unit	₹40	₹60
Direct labour/unit (@₹20/hr)	2 hr	3 hr
Machine hrs/unit	2	4
No. of purchase orders	40	60
No. of set-ups	20	80

Overheads: Machine-related ₹2,20,000 (driver: machine hrs); Purchasing ₹1,00,000 (driver: orders); Set-up ₹2,00,000 (driver: set-ups). Selling price P ₹150, Q ₹300.

Required: Unit cost and profit per unit under ABC.

Solution. Machine hrs: P 8,000 + Q 4,000 = 12,000. Rate = 2,20,000 ÷ 12,000 = ₹18.333/hr. Orders: 100 → rate = 1,00,000 ÷ 100 = ₹1,000/order. Set-ups: 100 → rate = 2,00,000 ÷ 100 = ₹2,000/set-up.

Overhead assigned:

	P (₹)	Q (₹)
Machine	18.333×8,000 = 1,46,667	18.333×4,000 = 73,333
Purchasing	1,000×40 = 40,000	1,000×60 = 60,000
Set-up	2,000×20 = 40,000	2,000×80 = 1,60,000
Total OH	**2,26,667**	**2,93,333**
Per unit OH	56.67	293.33

Cost per unit:

	P (₹)	Q (₹)
Material	40.00	60.00
Labour (2×20 / 3×20)	40.00	60.00
Overhead	56.67	293.33
Total cost	**136.67**	**413.33**
Price	150.00	300.00
Profit/(loss)	**13.33**	**(113.33)**

Check OH: 2,26,667 + 2,93,333 = 5,20,000 = 2,20,000+1,00,000+2,00,000 ✓ **Insight:** Q, which the board thought was the "premium earner" at ₹300, actually **loses ₹113/unit** — its 80 set-ups and 60 orders make it a complexity hog.

B4 (Exam-hard) — Traditional vs ABC full reconciliation with decision

Zenith Ltd manufactures **Std** (48,000 units) and **Dlx** (12,000 units). Data:

	Std	Dlx	Total
Machine hrs/unit	1.0	1.5	—
Direct labour hrs/unit	0.5	1.0	—
Production runs	30	90	120
Purchase orders	100	300	400
Deliveries	40	160	200

Overheads: Machine dept ₹6,00,000; Set-up (runs) ₹3,60,000; Procurement (orders) ₹2,00,000; Distribution (deliveries) ₹1,40,000. **Total ₹13,00,000.** Traditional base = direct labour hours.

Required: Overhead/unit under (a) traditional, (b) ABC, and comment.

Solution. DL hrs: Std 48,000×0.5 = 24,000; Dlx 12,000×1.0 = 12,000; total 36,000. Traditional rate = 13,00,000 ÷ 36,000 = ₹36.111/DLH. - Std: 36.111×24,000 = 8,66,667 → **₹18.06/unit**. - Dlx: 36.111×12,000 = 4,33,333 → **₹36.11/unit**.

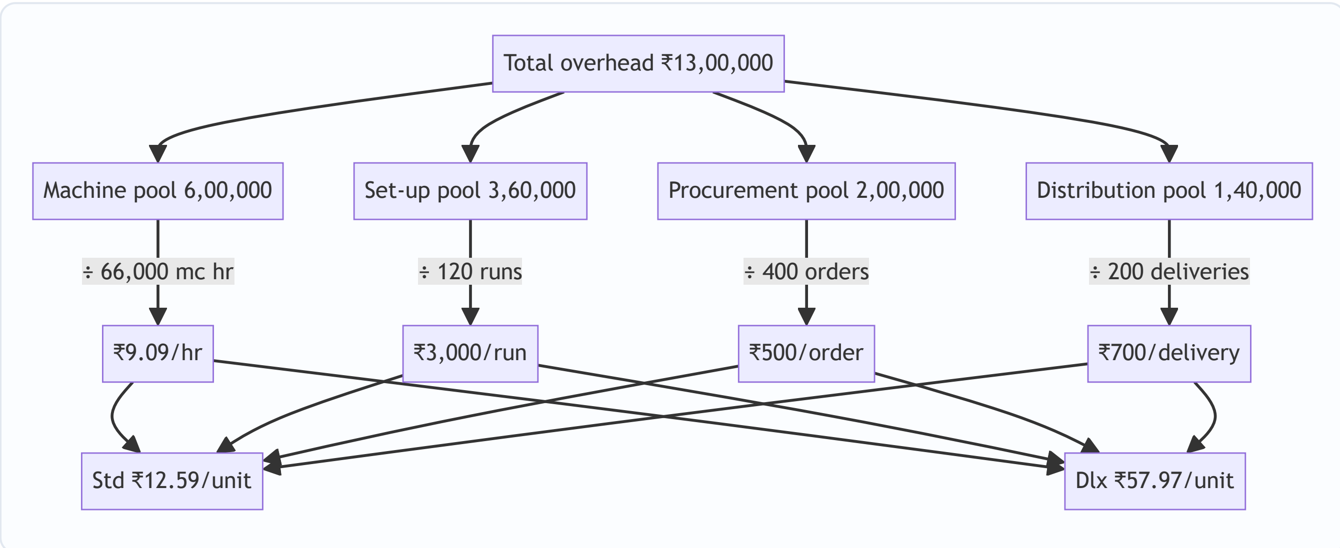
ABC rates: - Machine hrs: Std 48,000×1 = 48,000; Dlx 12,000×1.5 = 18,000; total 66,000. Rate = 6,00,000 ÷ 66,000 = ₹9.0909/mc hr. - Set-up = 3,60,000 ÷ 120 = ₹3,000/run. - Procurement = 2,00,000 ÷ 400 = ₹500/order. - Distribution = 1,40,000 ÷ 200 = ₹700/delivery.

	Std (₹)	Dlx (₹)
Machine	9.0909×48,000 = 4,36,364	9.0909×18,000 = 1,63,636
Set-up	3,000×30 = 90,000	3,000×90 = 2,70,000
Procurement	500×100 = 50,000	500×300 = 1,50,000
Distribution	700×40 = 28,000	700×160 = 1,12,000
Total OH	**6,04,364**	**6,95,636**
Units	48,000	12,000
OH/unit	**₹12.59**	**₹57.97**

Check: 6,04,364 + 6,95,636 = 13,00,000 ✓

Comment. Traditional charged Dlx ₹36.11; ABC reveals **₹57.97** — an under-recovery of ~₹21.86/unit (₹2.6 lakh across 12,000 units) that Std was silently subsidising. If Dlx price was fixed on the ₹36 figure, the "profit" was illusory. ABC supports re-pricing Dlx, or reducing its runs/orders/deliveries.

Approach diagram:



Section C — Past-Paper-Style Full Questions

C1. "A company using single-rate absorption finds its high-volume product looks unprofitable while a niche product looks a star. Explain, with the ABC logic, why this happens and how ABC corrects it." (5 marks)

Model answer. Under single-rate absorption the base is volume (labour/machine hours). The high-volume product accumulates the largest share of hours and therefore **absorbs the bulk of overhead**, inflating its cost, while the niche low-volume product absorbs little despite triggering disproportionate **batch- and product-level** activities (set-ups, special orders, inspections). This **cross-subsidy** understates the niche product's true cost and overstates the mainstream product's. ABC breaks overhead into **activity pools**, computes a **driver rate** for each (set-ups, orders, inspections, machine hrs), and recharges each product by its **actual driver consumption**. The niche product now bears its full batch/product-sustaining cost, the volume product is relieved, and reported profitability reverses to reflect economic reality — enabling correct pricing, mix and make-or-buy decisions.

C2. "State the seven steps in implementing an ABC system." (5 marks)

Model answer. 1. **Identify activities** in the organisation (machining, set-up, purchasing, inspection, dispatch). 2. **Create activity cost pools** — group overheads by activity. 3. **Assign resource costs to pools** using resource drivers (Stage 1). 4. **Identify the cost driver** for each pool (the factor causing its cost). 5. **Compute the cost-driver rate** = pool cost ÷ total driver volume. 6. **Assign activity costs to products** = rate × driver quantity consumed (Stage 2). 7. **Compute product cost** by adding direct costs + assigned overhead; use for pricing and decisions.

C3. "How does ABC information feed Activity-Based Budgeting (ABB) and target costing?" (4 marks)

Model answer. ABB reverses the ABC flow: starting from planned output, it forecasts the **activity volumes** (set-ups, orders) required, then the **resources** each activity needs, building the budget bottom-up from activities rather than incremental line items — improving accuracy and highlighting capacity. In **target costing**, ABC supplies reliable per-product cost, so once the market price and desired margin fix the **target cost**, ABC pinpoints which **activities** to attack (via ABM) to close the gap between current and target cost — driver reduction (fewer set-ups, larger batches) becomes the cost-reduction lever.

Section D — MCQs & Case Scenarios

D1. The primary allocation base in ABC is: A) machine hours B) direct labour hours C) cost drivers D) units produced **Ans: C.** ABC assigns overhead by activity cost drivers, not a single volume base.

D2. "Number of set-ups" is a driver for which activity level? A) Unit B) Batch C) Product D) Facility **Ans: B.** Set-ups are incurred per batch, independent of units in the batch.

D3. Factory rent and plant security are best classified as: A) unit-level B) batch-level C) product-level D) facility-level **Ans: D.** They sustain the whole facility and cannot be traced to a driver of output.

D4. ABC is MOST beneficial when: A) overheads are a small % of cost B) products are identical C) product diversity and non-volume overheads are high D) there is a single product **Ans: C.** Diversity + significant batch/product costs create the cross-subsidy ABC fixes.

D5. Under ABC, a low-volume complex product's cost usually: A) falls vs traditional B) rises vs traditional C) stays equal D) becomes zero **Ans: B.** It finally absorbs its true batch/product-sustaining costs.

D6. ABM primarily aims to: A) increase overheads B) eliminate non-value-added activities C) replace financial accounting D) set standard hours **Ans: B.** ABM uses ABC data to cut non-value-added activities and reduce cost.

D7 — Case. Prime Ltd's traditional system shows Product Z (500 units, 20 set-ups) at ₹80/unit overhead; ABC (set-up rate ₹2,000, machine ₹5/hr, Z uses 1,000 mc hrs) shows a different figure. ABC overhead for Z per unit is: Working: set-up 2,000×20 = 40,000; machine 5×1,000 = 5,000; total 45,000 ÷ 500 = **₹90/unit**. A) ₹80 B) ₹85 C) ₹90 D) ₹100 **Ans: C.** Z was undercosted by ₹10/unit; its 20 set-ups drive the increase.

D8 — Case. A firm removes a ₹3,00,000 inspection activity (a non-value-added cost) after ABM analysis without harming quality. The correct classification and effect: A) value-added; cost rises B) non-value-added;

cost falls with no customer impact C) facility-level; price rises D) unit-level; output falls **Ans: B.** Eliminating a non-value-added activity lowers cost while customer worth is unchanged.

D9 — Case. Two products share overhead ₹5,00,000 on orders. X places 20 orders, Y 30. If instead Y consolidates to 10 orders (total 30), Y's charge: Old rate 5,00,000÷50 = ₹10,000; Y old = 3,00,000. New total orders 30, rate = 5,00,000÷30 = ₹16,667; Y new = 1,66,667. Y's charge **falls** (fewer orders consumed) — illustrating driver reduction under ABM. A) rises B) falls C) unchanged D) doubles **Ans: B.** Consuming fewer driver units reduces the product's assigned cost.

Quick-Revision Sheet

Item	Rule / Formula
Driver rate	Activity pool cost ÷ total driver volume
Product OH	Driver rate × driver units consumed
Two stages	Resources →(resource driver)→ Activities →(activity driver)→ Products
Hierarchy	Unit · Batch · Product · Facility
ABC beats traditional when	High OH %, high diversity, big non-volume activities
Effect on low-volume complex	Cost **rises** (removes cross-subsidy)
ABM	Uses ABC data → cut non-value-added activities
Self-check	Σ product overheads must equal total overhead

Nine examiner traps: (1) using labour hours as ABC driver by habit; (2) forgetting to re-total and reconcile pools; (3) mixing per-unit and per-batch quantities; (4) treating facility costs as driver-traceable; (5) omitting direct material/labour when asked for *total* cost; (6) rounding driver rates too early; (7) not commenting on the profitability reversal; (8) confusing resource driver with activity driver; (9) assuming ABC always lowers cost — it *redistributes* it.

Chapter 06 — Cost Sheet

1. The Problem — the manager's question that financial accounts cannot answer

Imagine you run *Sunrise Cycles*, a factory making bicycles. At the year-end your financial accountant hands you a Profit & Loss Account. It says: *Sales ₹80,00,000, all expenses ₹68,00,000, Profit ₹12,00,000.* You nod. But then a dealer walks in and asks a question that makes the P&L useless:

> "I want to place an order for 500 special-frame cycles. What price will you quote me?"

Turn to the P&L for the answer and you are stranded. The P&L tells you the **result of the past** — one lump profit for everything sold. It cannot tell you:

- What did **one** cycle cost to make?
- Of that cost, how much was **material**, how much **labour**, how much **factory overhead**, how much **office and selling** expense?
- If I make 500 more, which costs will **rise** and which stay flat?
- At what price do I stop *losing* money and start *making* it?

The financial P&L is organised by **nature** (salaries, rent, depreciation, purchases) and lumps the whole business together. A manager needs cost organised by **function and by unit** — material vs labour vs overhead, factory vs office vs selling, and ultimately *per cycle*. That reorganisation, laid out as a vertical statement that builds cost stage by stage up to profit, is the **Cost Sheet**.

The decision the Cost Sheet enables: pricing a quotation, judging whether a product is profitable, controlling each element of cost by watching it separately, valuing closing stock for the balance sheet, and comparing this period against the last. Every line of the format below exists because some manager needed one of those answers.

Three definitions worth fixing at the outset (the examiner tests the distinction):

- A **Cost Sheet** is a statement showing the *build-up of cost of a product/service* for a period, element by element and stage by stage. It is a **memorandum statement** — it is *not* part of the double-entry ledger, so it has no debit/credit sides.
- A **Cost Statement** is the same thing under a slightly broader name (ICAI uses the two interchangeably; some texts call the columnar output with per-unit figures a "Statement of Cost").
- A **Production Account / Cost of Production Statement** *is* a ledger account (double-entry) that also arrives at cost of production but is presented in account form. The Cost Sheet is its readable, columnar cousin. If a question says "prepare a Cost Sheet," never present a T-account.

Why the Cost Sheet is historical *and* prospective. A *historical* cost sheet records what a period actually cost (used for control and stock valuation). An *estimated* cost sheet projects what a future job will cost (used for quotations and tenders — see Example 3 and Example 5). Same skeleton, different data source. The examiner loves to hand you a historical sheet and then ask you to build an estimated one from it — that single pivot is the most valuable skill in the chapter.

---

2. The Core Idea — building a wall, brick by brick

Think of total cost not as one number but as a **wall built in courses (layers)**. You cannot lay the roof before the walls, and you cannot lay the walls before the foundation. Cost accumulates in exactly that disciplined order:

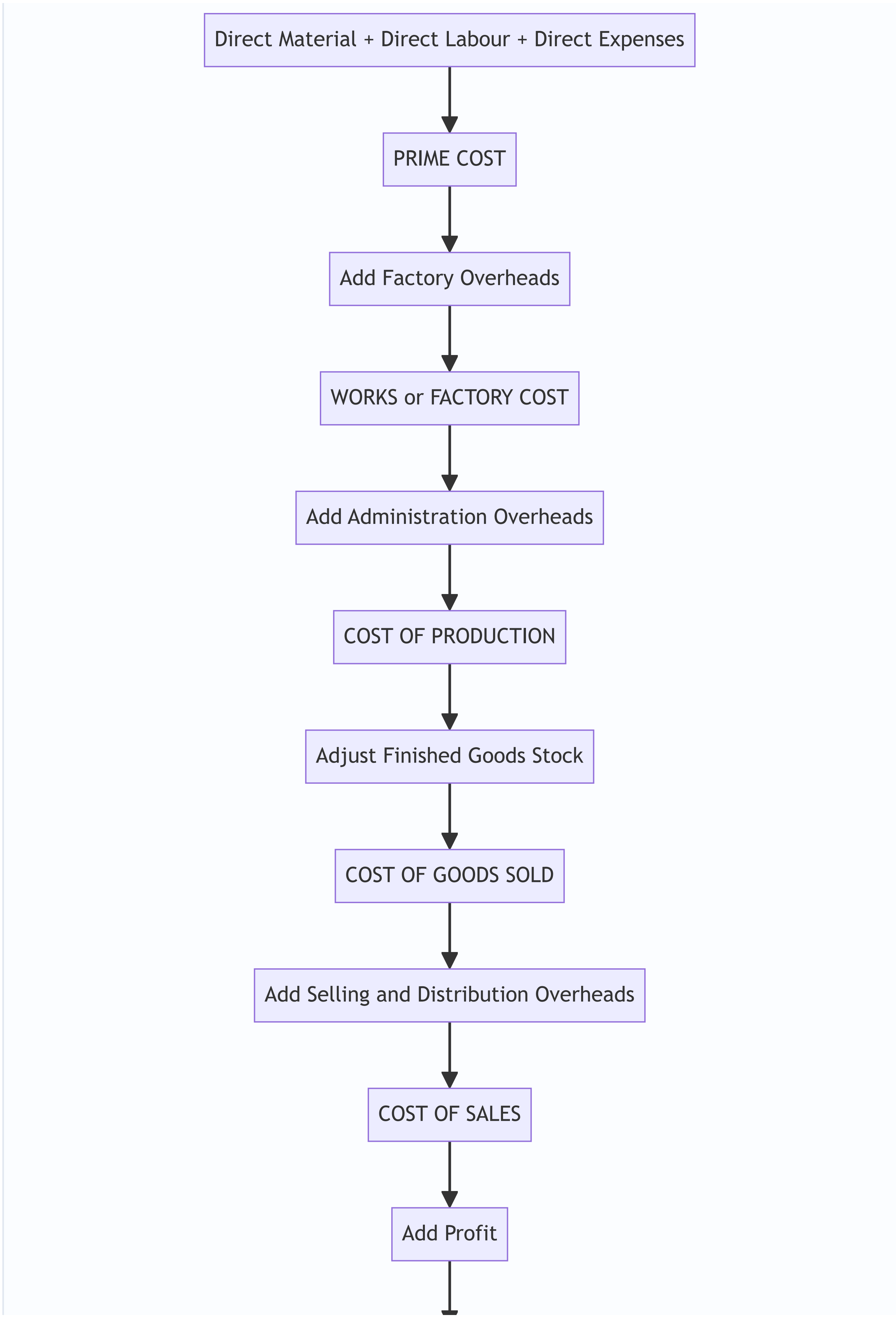
- **Foundation** = the direct, traceable costs of *making the thing* — the raw material you can point to, the wages of the person who touched it, any expense incurred specifically for that job. Together they are the **Prime Cost**.
- **Ground floor** = add the *factory's* indirect costs (the supervisor, factory rent, machine power). Now you have **Works / Factory Cost**.
- **First floor** = add the *office's* cost of administering production. Now you have **Cost of Production**.
- **Roof** = add *selling and distribution* cost. Now you have **Cost of Sales**.
- **The sky above the roof** = whatever the customer pays *over* Cost of Sales is **Profit**; Cost of Sales + Profit = **Sales**.

Each course rests on the one below because each answers a *different manager's question*. The factory manager is judged on Works Cost. The sales manager is judged on selling cost. The MD is judged on the final profit. By stacking the wall in named layers, the Cost Sheet lets each manager see *his own brick* — and lets you quote a price that covers *every* brick.

The four "cost" milestones you must be able to name on sight (examiners test the vocabulary directly):

Milestone	What it is	Alternative name
Prime Cost	All direct costs (DM + DL + DE)	Basic / First / Flat Cost
Works Cost	Prime + factory OH ± WIP	Factory / Manufacturing Cost
Cost of Production	Works Cost + admin OH	Office Cost / Gross Cost of Production
Cost of Sales	Cost of goods sold + S&D OH	Total Cost

Figure 1 — the cost wall: each layer adds one function's cost until the customer's price sits on top.


Direct Material + Direct Labour + Direct Expenses
PRIME COST
Add Factory Overheads
WORKS or FACTORY COST
Add Administration Overheads
COST OF PRODUCTION
Adjust Finished Goods Stock
COST OF GOODS SOLD
Add Selling and Distribution Overheads
COST OF SALES
Add Profit

SALES

3. Why it is built this way — the logic behind the staircase

Three design principles explain every feature of the Cost Sheet. Understand these and you never memorise the format again — you *reconstruct* it.

(a) Direct before indirect — because traceability drives control. A cost is *direct* if you can economically trace it to one unit (the steel in a frame). It is *indirect* (an overhead) if it is shared and must be *apportioned* (the factory's electricity bill). Direct costs move automatically with volume and are controlled at the shop floor; overheads are controlled by budgets and absorption rates. Separating them at the very first stage (Prime Cost = all directs) is what makes cost *controllable*.

A deeper cut on "direct": directness is a matter of **economic traceability, not physical presence**. The glue in a chair is physically in the product yet is treated as indirect material because tracing it per chair costs more than it is worth. Conversely, a hired mould used on one job is physically *outside* the product yet is a direct expense because it is wholly traceable to that job. The test is always "can I trace this to one cost unit without disproportionate effort?" — never "is it inside the product?"

(b) Function follows the physical journey of the product — because responsibility follows function. A product is born in the **factory**, is administered by the **office**, and is pushed to the customer by **selling & distribution**. The Cost Sheet adds overheads in that same sequence — factory → admin → selling — so that each functional manager owns exactly the layer he can influence. This is why Works Cost is struck *before* admin cost: the works manager should not be blamed for the MD's office rent.

(c) Stock is the timing bridge — because *produced* is not the same as *sold*. Here is the subtle heart of the chapter. The factory *produces* a quantity in a period; the sales team *sells* a possibly different quantity. Cost must be matched to the **stage at which the goods physically are**:

- **Raw material stock** sits *before* production, so it is adjusted inside the material line, *before* Prime Cost.
- **Work-in-progress (WIP)** sits *inside* production, so it is adjusted at the *factory* stage — after factory overheads, as we compute Works Cost.
- **Finished goods stock** sits *after* production, so it is adjusted *after* Cost of Production, to convert "cost of goods **produced**" into "cost of goods **sold**".

Each stock is inserted at the exact rung where the goods physically rest. Get the *rung* right and the whole sheet reconciles. Get it wrong and every number below is contaminated. This single rule — **match each stock to its stage** — is the most-tested idea in the chapter.

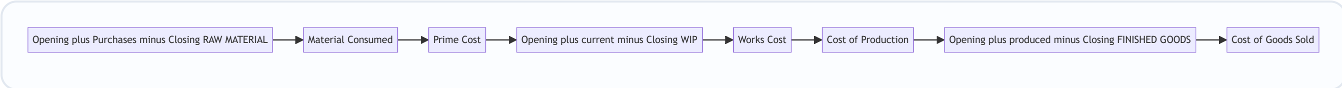
The valuation principle behind each stock (the deeper "why"): a stock is *always* valued at the cost of the stage it has *reached*, never a stage it has not.

- Raw material stock is valued at **purchase cost** (it has been bought but not processed).
- WIP is valued at **works-stage cost** — material + labour + factory overhead absorbed so far (it is inside the factory). This is why WIP enters *after* factory overheads: it already carries a share of them.
- Finished goods are valued at **cost of production per unit** (they have exited the factory and been administered but not yet sold — no selling cost is loaded onto stock, because selling cost is *not incurred*

until sale).

That last point is a favourite trap: **selling & distribution overhead is never carried in closing finished-goods stock.** A unit sitting in the warehouse has cost you to *make and administer*, but you have not yet *sold* it, so no selling cost attaches. Load selling cost only onto the units actually sold.

Figure 2 — where each stock adjustment enters the staircase.



---

4. Full Technical Content — the formulas, each with its "why"

4.1 The elements of cost (the vocabulary)

Element	Direct (traceable)	Indirect / Overhead (shared)
Material	Direct Material — steel, tyres, forms part of the product	Indirect Material — lubricants, cotton waste, small tools
Labour	Direct Labour — wages of machine operator, welder	Indirect Labour — supervisor, storekeeper, sweeper
Expenses	Direct (Chargeable) Expenses — hire of a special mould for one job, royalty per unit, design cost for a specific order	Indirect Expenses — factory rent, power, office salaries, advertising

> **Direct Material + Direct Labour + Direct Expenses = PRIME COST. All indirects = OVERHEADS**, later split by function into Factory, Administration, and Selling & Distribution.

The two classifications the exam layers on top of this. The same rupee of cost can be cut two ways at once, and the Cost Sheet uses *both*:

- **By element** — material / labour / expense (the columns of the table above).
- **By function** — production / administration / selling & distribution (the *stages* of the staircase).
- **By behaviour** — fixed / variable / semi-variable (this cut does *not* appear on a traditional cost sheet; it belongs to Marginal Costing, §7. But examiners test whether you know that a *classified* or *behavioural* cost sheet re-sorts the same totals into fixed and variable columns.)
- **By controllability** — controllable / uncontrollable (used for responsibility reporting, not the sheet itself).

Keeping "element" and "function" separate in your head is what lets you place a mystery item: *indirect wages of a factory supervisor* is **labour** by element but sits in the **factory overhead** stage by function.

4.2 Stage 1 — Direct Material Consumed (why the RM stock lives here)

You bought material during the year, but you did not necessarily *use* all of it, and some was left over from last year. The cost sheet needs what was **consumed**, not what was purchased:

```
Raw Material Consumed
  = Opening Stock of Raw Material
  + Purchases of Raw Material
  + Carriage/Freight Inward on material
  + Import duty, octroi, insurance on incoming material
  − Purchase returns / trade discount
  − Closing Stock of Raw Material
```

Why here? Material is consumed at the very start of the process, so its stock adjustment belongs *before* Prime Cost. Carriage **inward** is added because it is a cost of *bringing material in* — part of its acquisition cost. (Carriage *outward* is a selling cost and appears far below.)

What counts as part of material cost (and what does not) — the CAS-6 view. The *cost of material* is its purchase price *net of trade discount, rebate, duty drawback and refundable taxes* (like GST input credit), *plus* all costs of bringing it to the factory door — freight inward, insurance in transit, loading/unloading, octroi/entry tax, and normal transit loss. **Exclude** from material cost: cash discount (financial), demurrage/detention/penalties (abnormal), and any refundable tax you will reclaim. This "net purchase price + bringing-in cost" rule is exactly why import duty and carriage inward are *added* while GST credit and trade discount are *deducted*.

Two material subtleties the examiner plants:

1. **Normal vs abnormal loss of material.** Normal (unavoidable) process loss is absorbed by the *good* units — it silently raises the per-unit cost and needs no separate line. Abnormal loss (fire, theft, careless spillage) is stripped out of the cost sheet and charged to Costing P&L, so it does not inflate product cost.
2. **Materials Consumed vs Materials Purchased vs Materials Issued.** "Consumed" = opening + purchases − closing (the cost-sheet figure). If a question gives "materials issued to production" it may already be the consumed figure — read carefully before re-adjusting stock.

4.3 Stage 2 — Prime Cost

```
Prime Cost = Direct Material Consumed + Direct Labour (Wages) + Direct Expenses
```

Why struck separately? Prime Cost is the "hard core" of traceable cost — the part a foreman can control unit-by-unit. It is also the base on which some factories absorb overheads (percentage-of-prime-cost method).

Direct labour — the pieces that belong here. Direct wages include basic wages of production workers *plus* the production-worker share of dearness allowance, production bonus, and overtime *at normal rate*. Two classic tweaks:

- **Overtime premium** (the *extra* over the normal rate). If overtime is worked at the customer's request for a specific job → the premium is a **direct expense** of that job. If it is due to general factory pressure → the premium is **factory overhead**. If it is due to abnormal causes (making up for a flood shutdown) → **Costing P&L**. Only the *premium* is reclassified; the normal-rate element of overtime stays in direct wages.
- **Idle-time wages.** Normal idle time (unavoidable — tea breaks, machine set-up) is treated as factory overhead (or loaded into the direct-labour rate). Abnormal idle time (strike, power failure) → Costing P&L, never the cost sheet.

4.4 Stage 3 — Works / Factory Cost (why WIP stock lives here)

```
Gross Works Cost   = Prime Cost + Factory (Works) Overheads
Factory Cost       = Gross Works Cost + Opening WIP − Closing WIP
```

Factory overheads = indirect material + indirect wages + factory rent, power, fuel, depreciation of plant, factory insurance, works manager's salary, etc.

Why is WIP adjusted here and nowhere else? WIP means goods **partly through the factory** — material and labour and some overhead have been incurred but the unit is not finished. That is precisely the *works stage*. So opening WIP (last period's half-done units, now being finished) is added and closing WIP (this period's half-done units) is removed **after** factory overheads have gone in, because WIP already carries a share of factory overhead.

The one genuine ambiguity — WIP valued at prime cost vs works cost. ICAI's standard position (and the safe default) is that WIP already carries factory overhead, so it is adjusted **after** factory overheads (as above). But *some* problems explicitly value WIP at **prime cost only**. If so, the WIP adjustment must be made **before** adding factory overheads, i.e. between Prime Cost and factory OH. *Rule to state in your answer:* "WIP has been adjusted after factory overheads on the assumption it is valued at works cost; if it were valued at prime cost the adjustment would precede factory overheads." Naming the assumption earns the mark even if the examiner intended the other treatment.

> **Common adjustment — sale of scrap:** scrap arising in the factory is a *recovery* of factory cost. Its sale value is **deducted** from factory overheads (or from Works Cost) before striking Factory Cost.

Defectives, spoilage and by-products at the works stage (finer distinctions):

- **Normal spoilage** cost is borne by good units (no separate line). **Abnormal spoilage** → Costing P&L.
- **Rectification cost of normal defectives** is added to factory overhead; abnormal-defective rectification → Costing P&L.
- **By-product** net realisable value is *deducted* from factory/works cost (like scrap but usually larger) unless the question asks for a separate by-product costing.

4.5 Stage 4 — Cost of Production

```
Cost of Production = Factory Cost + Administration Overheads (relating to production)
```

Administration overheads = office rent, office salaries, office lighting, printing & stationery, directors' remuneration, audit fees, legal charges — the cost of *running the office that administers production*.

Why after Works Cost? Administration is a level *above* the shop floor; conceptually you cannot administer production until production exists. (ICAI convention charges general administration here; some purist syllabi treat admin as a period cost — for CA Inter, include production-related admin at this stage unless told otherwise.)

Gross vs net cost of production — the R&D and quality-cost refinement. ICAI (per CAS-4/CAS-6 thinking) sometimes distinguishes:

```
Gross Cost of Production      = Factory Cost + Administration OH (production)
Add: Opening stock of finished goods
Less: Closing stock of finished goods
= Cost of Goods Sold
```

Where a question separates **research & development cost** attributable to production, or **quality-control cost**, add it here at the production stage (it is a cost of *making the product to standard*), not at selling. General/head-office administration unrelated to production is, strictly, a period cost — but for CA Inter default, keep all administration at this stage unless the question explicitly splits it.

4.6 Stage 5 — Cost of Goods Sold (why finished-goods stock lives here)

```
Cost of Goods Sold (COGS)
  = Cost of Production
  + Opening Stock of Finished Goods
  − Closing Stock of Finished Goods
```

Why here — the crux? Cost of Production is the cost of everything **produced** this period. But we only match cost against **sales**. Some produced units remain unsold (closing FG stock) and must be carried out; some units sold this period were produced *last* period (opening FG stock) and must be brought in. Adjusting FG stock *after* Cost of Production converts "cost of goods **produced**" into "cost of goods **sold**." This is the timing bridge between production and sales.

> **Valuing the FG stock:** unless told otherwise, closing finished goods are valued at the **current period's Cost of Production per unit** = Cost of Production ÷ units produced. Opening FG is valued at *last* period's rate (given in the problem).

The units-produced vs units-sold reconciliation (do this whenever FG stock exists). When a problem gives you units, always run the physical identity first:

```
Units sold = Opening FG units + Units produced − Closing FG units
```

This tells you *how many* units the sales figure covers, and lets you value closing FG at the *right* per-unit rate. If the question also gives closing-FG *value* directly, use it; if it gives only *quantity*, value it at current cost of production per unit. Mixing the two — valuing closing FG at cost of *sales* per unit, for instance — is a guaranteed error, because a unit in stock has not been sold and so carries no selling cost.

FIFO assumption on finished goods. Cost sheets assume **FIFO** on finished goods unless told otherwise: the opening stock is sold first (at last period's rate), and closing stock consists of the *most recently produced* units (at this period's rate). This is why opening FG carries last year's rate and closing FG carries this year's.

4.7 Stage 6 — Cost of Sales, and Profit

```
Cost of Sales = COGS + Selling & Distribution Overheads
Profit        = Sales − Cost of Sales
Sales         = Cost of Sales + Profit
```

Selling & distribution overheads = salesmen's salaries and commission, advertising, carriage **outward**, warehouse of finished goods, showroom rent, bad debts, packing for delivery.

Why last? Selling cost is incurred only when you *push the finished good to the customer* — the final leg of the product's journey.

Selling vs distribution — the sub-split some questions demand. *Selling* overheads create/stimulate demand: advertising, salesmen's salary and commission, showroom rent, catalogues, samples, bad debts. *Distribution* overheads move the finished good to the buyer *after* the sale: carriage outward, warehouse of finished goods, packing for delivery, running the delivery van, secondary transport. When a question asks for a functional break-up, keep the two sub-heads distinct; otherwise merge them into "Selling & Distribution."

Packing — the trap. *Primary packing* essential to the product's saleability (e.g. the tube of toothpaste's carton) is a **production/works** cost; *secondary/transport packing* to move goods to the customer is a **distribution** cost. Same word "packing," two different stages depending on purpose.

4.8 The two-sided margin relationships (the pricing engine)

For tenders and quotations you must convert between cost, profit, and sales. Master these:

If profit is a % **on cost**	If profit is a % **on sales**
Profit = Cost × rate	Profit = Sales × rate
Sales = Cost × (1 + rate)	Cost = Sales × (1 − rate)
e.g. 25% on cost → Sales = 1.25 × Cost	e.g. 20% on sales → Cost = 0.80 × Sales

Interconversion trick: profit that is *x%* on cost equals *x / (100 + x) %* on sales; profit that is *y%* on sales equals *y / (100 − y) %* on cost. (Example: 25% on cost = 25/125 = 20% on sales.)

A ready reckoner you can rebuild instantly (verify each by the trick above):

Stated margin	Equivalent margin
10% on cost	9.09% on sales (10/110)
20% on cost	16.67% on sales (20/120)
25% on cost	20% on sales (25/125)
33⅓% on cost	25% on sales (33.33/133.33)
50% on cost	33⅓% on sales (50/150)
100% on cost	50% on sales

"On which base?" — read the exact words. "Profit is 25% *of* cost" and "profit is 25% *on* cost" both mean cost-based. "Profit is 25% *of* selling price / *on* sales / *of* turnover" is sales-based. "Margin of 25%" with no base named is ambiguous — state your assumption ("taken as % on sales, being the trade convention for 'margin'") and proceed. Also watch **"mark-up"** (always on cost) vs **"margin"** (usually on selling price).

4.9 What is EXCLUDED from a Cost Sheet (pure-cost principle)

The Cost Sheet records only costs of the *product/operation*. It **excludes** all *financial* and *appropriation* items:

- Financial items: interest on loans/debentures, dividends paid, income-tax, loss/profit on sale of assets, transfer to reserves.
- Purely notional gains and non-operating income (interest received, rent received, dividend received).
- Abnormal losses (abnormal wastage, cost of idle time due to strike) — charged to Costing P&L, not the Cost Sheet.
- Cash discount (a financial item). *Trade discount*, however, is netted off purchases/sales.

Why? Cost Accounting isolates the *cost of making and selling*, so that decisions are not distorted by how the business is *financed* or *taxed*.

A fuller exclusion checklist (the examiner scatters these among genuine costs to see if you spot them):

Excluded item	Reason	Where it really goes
Interest on capital / loan / debentures	Financial	Costing P&L (some texts include notional interest — only if asked)
Income-tax, advance tax	Appropriation of profit	P&L appropriation
Dividends paid, transfer to reserve	Appropriation	Below the line
Loss / profit on sale of fixed asset or investment	Non-operating capital item	Costing P&L
Goodwill / preliminary expenses / discount on shares written off	Financial write-off	Costing P&L
Donation, charity	Non-operating appropriation	Costing P&L
Cash discount received / allowed	Financial	Costing P&L
Interest / dividend / rent *received*	Non-operating income	Costing P&L (income side) — **not** deducted from cost
Abnormal loss (fire, theft, strike idle time, abnormal wastage)	Not a cost of normal production	Costing P&L
Fines and penalties	Abnormal / statutory	Costing P&L

A subtle one: **notional costs** (notional rent of own premises, notional interest on own capital, salary of a proprietor who draws none) are *included* in a cost sheet only when the question tells you to, because cost accounting sometimes imputes them to make comparison fair. Default: exclude unless instructed.

---

5. Worked Examples

Example 1 — The foundation (simple, no stocks)

Meridian Tools furnishes the following for the year. Prepare a Cost Sheet showing each stage and profit.

Item	₹
Direct materials purchased & consumed	4,00,000
Direct wages	2,00,000
Direct expenses (special mould hire)	40,000
Factory overheads	1,20,000
Administration overheads	60,000
Selling & distribution overheads	80,000
Sales	10,00,000

Solution — Cost Sheet of Meridian Tools

Particulars	₹	₹
Direct Materials consumed		4,00,000
Direct Wages		2,00,000
Direct Expenses		40,000
Prime Cost		**6,40,000**
Add: Factory Overheads		1,20,000
Works / Factory Cost		**7,60,000**
Add: Administration Overheads		60,000
Cost of Production		**8,20,000**
Add: Selling & Distribution Overheads		80,000
Cost of Sales		**9,00,000**
Profit (balancing figure)		**1,00,000**
Sales		**10,00,000**

Check: Sales 10,00,000 − Cost of Sales 9,00,000 = Profit 1,00,000. ✓ Reconciles. Note profit is 1,00,000/9,00,000 = **11.11% on cost** = 1,00,000/10,00,000 = **10% on sales** — the interconversion of §4.8 in action.

Example 2 — Introducing all three stocks (the timing bridge)

Nova Appliances, for the year ended 31 March 2026. Prepare a Cost Sheet.

Item	₹
Raw material — opening stock	50,000
Raw material — purchases	6,00,000
Carriage inward	20,000
Raw material — closing stock	70,000
Direct wages	3,00,000
Direct expenses	30,000
Factory overheads	1,80,000
Opening Work-in-Progress	40,000
Closing Work-in-Progress	60,000
Sale of factory scrap	10,000
Administration overheads	90,000
Opening finished goods	80,000
Closing finished goods	1,20,000
Selling & distribution overheads	1,10,000
Profit margin	20% on sales

Step 1 — Material consumed (RM stock adjusted *before* Prime Cost): 50,000 + 6,00,000 + 20,000 − 70,000 = **6,00,000**.

Step 2 — Prime Cost: 6,00,000 + 3,00,000 + 30,000 = **9,30,000**.

Step 3 — Works Cost (factory overheads *less* scrap recovery, then WIP adjusted at the factory stage): Factory OH net of scrap = 1,80,000 − 10,000 = 1,70,000. Gross works = 9,30,000 + 1,70,000 = 11,00,000; + opening WIP 40,000 − closing WIP 60,000 = **10,80,000**.

Step 4 — Cost of Production: 10,80,000 + 90,000 = **11,70,000**.

Step 5 — Cost of Goods Sold (finished-goods stock adjusted *after* Cost of Production): 11,70,000 + 80,000 − 1,20,000 = **11,30,000**.

Step 6 — Cost of Sales: 11,30,000 + 1,10,000 = **12,40,000**.

Step 7 — Profit & Sales (profit is 20% *on sales* → Cost of Sales is 80% of Sales): Sales = 12,40,000 ÷ 0.80 = **15,50,000**; Profit = 15,50,000 − 12,40,000 = **3,10,000**.

Cost Sheet of Nova Appliances (year ended 31.03.2026)

Particulars	₹	₹
Opening stock of Raw Material	50,000	
Add: Purchases	6,00,000	
Add: Carriage inward	20,000	
Less: Closing stock of Raw Material	(70,000)	
Raw Material Consumed		6,00,000
Direct Wages		3,00,000
Direct Expenses		30,000
Prime Cost		**9,30,000**
Add: Factory Overheads 1,80,000 less Scrap 10,000		1,70,000
Add: Opening WIP		40,000
Less: Closing WIP		(60,000)
Works / Factory Cost		**10,80,000**
Add: Administration Overheads		90,000
Cost of Production		**11,70,000**
Add: Opening Finished Goods		80,000
Less: Closing Finished Goods		(1,20,000)
Cost of Goods Sold		**11,30,000**
Add: Selling & Distribution Overheads		1,10,000
Cost of Sales		**12,40,000**
Profit (20% on sales)		**3,10,000**
Sales		**15,50,000**

Check: Profit 3,10,000 ÷ Sales 15,50,000 = 20.0% on sales. ✓ Every stock entered at its correct rung; the sheet reconciles.

Example 3 — The exam-hard tender/quotation (per-unit costing + estimate)

This is the archetypal ICAI question: use *last period's* actuals to derive *per-unit* rates, then *project* them onto a future order with cost changes — and quote a price.

Precision Castings produced and sold 10,000 units last year. Actuals:

Item	₹
Raw materials consumed	8,00,000
Direct wages	5,00,000
Direct expenses	1,00,000
Factory overheads	3,00,000
Administration overheads	2,40,000
Selling & distribution overheads	2,00,000
Sales	25,00,000

For the coming year the company has received a tender enquiry for 12,000 units and expects: 1. **Raw material price** will rise by **10%**. 2. **Wage rates** will rise by **20%**. 3. **Factory overhead** is recovered as a **percentage of direct wages** (same % as last year). 4. **Administration overhead** is recovered as a **percentage of works cost** (same % as last year). 5. **Selling & distribution overhead** is recovered **per unit** at last year's rate. 6. Direct expenses are **variable** — same rate per unit. 7. The company wants a **profit of 20% on the selling price**.

Prepare (a) last year's Cost Sheet with per-unit columns, and (b) the estimated Cost Sheet / quotation for the 12,000-unit tender, and state the price per unit to quote.

Part (a) — Last year's Cost Sheet (10,000 units) to extract the rates

Particulars	Total ₹	Per unit ₹
Raw Materials consumed	8,00,000	80.00
Direct Wages	5,00,000	50.00
Direct Expenses	1,00,000	10.00
Prime Cost	**14,00,000**	**140.00**
Factory Overheads	3,00,000	30.00
Works Cost	**17,00,000**	**170.00**
Administration Overheads	2,40,000	24.00
Cost of Production	**19,40,000**	**194.00**
Selling & Distribution OH	2,00,000	20.00
Cost of Sales	**21,40,000**	**214.00**
Profit	3,60,000	36.00
Sales	**25,00,000**	**250.00**

Extract the recovery bases (this is the "why" of the tender): - Factory OH as % of Direct Wages = 3,00,000 ÷ 5,00,000 = **60% of wages**. - Administration OH as % of Works Cost = 2,40,000 ÷ 17,00,000 = **14.1176% of works cost**. - Selling & distribution = **₹20 per unit** (flat rate).

Why use rates, not totals? Because the totals belong to 10,000 units at old prices. A rate is a portable law — apply it to any volume at any price level. That is exactly what a manager needs to price a future order.

Part (b) — Estimated per-unit costs for the 12,000-unit tender

Build the *new* per-unit figures using the given changes, then multiply by 12,000.

- Raw material per unit: 80.00 × 1.10 = **₹88.00**
- Direct wages per unit: 50.00 × 1.20 = **₹60.00**
- Direct expenses per unit: **₹10.00** (variable, unchanged rate)
- **Prime Cost per unit** = 88 + 60 + 10 = **₹158.00**
- Factory OH = 60% of new wages = 60% × 60 = **₹36.00**
- **Works Cost per unit** = 158 + 36 = **₹194.00**
- Administration OH = 14.1176% of works cost = 0.141176 × 194 = **₹27.39**
- **Cost of Production per unit** = 194 + 27.39 = **₹221.39**
- Selling & distribution = **₹20.00** per unit (flat)
- **Cost of Sales per unit** = 221.39 + 20 = **₹241.39**
- Profit = 20% *on selling price* → Cost of Sales is 80% of price → Profit per unit = 241.39 × (20/80) = **₹60.35**
- **Selling price to quote per unit** = 241.39 + 60.35 = **₹301.74** (i.e., 241.39 ÷ 0.80)

Estimated Cost Sheet / Quotation — 12,000 units

Particulars	Per unit ₹	Total ₹ (×12,000)
Raw Materials (80 × 1.10)	88.00	10,56,000
Direct Wages (50 × 1.20)	60.00	7,20,000
Direct Expenses	10.00	1,20,000
Prime Cost	**158.00**	**18,96,000**
Factory OH (60% of wages)	36.00	4,32,000
Works Cost	**194.00**	**23,28,000**
Administration OH (14.1176% of works)	27.39	3,28,695
Cost of Production	**221.39**	**26,56,695**
Selling & Distribution (₹20/unit)	20.00	2,40,000
Cost of Sales	**241.39**	**28,96,695**
Profit (20% on selling price)	60.35	7,24,174
Sales / Tender Price	**301.74**	**36,20,869**

Check: Profit 7,24,174 ÷ Sales 36,20,869 = 20.0% on sales. ✓ Works cost per unit 194 × 12,000 = 23,28,000. ✓ Admin 3,28,695 ÷ 23,28,000 = 14.12%. ✓ Rounding to two decimals leaves totals within a rupee; ICAI accepts either the per-unit-rounded or the exact-fraction answer as long as it reconciles.

Managerial punchline: the quote is **₹301.74 per unit** (₹36,20,869 for the order). Notice how *every* input change flowed through cleanly *because* we costed by rate and by stage. That is the entire payoff of the Cost

Sheet — a defensible, transparent price built brick by brick.

Example 4 — The units-differ case (produced ≠ sold, with per-unit stock valuation)

This is the trap Example 2 hides: there, all stocks were given in value. Here you are given quantities, and must value closing finished goods yourself. It tests whether you truly understand the "produced vs sold" bridge.

Apex Pumps for the year ended 31 March 2026. There was no opening finished stock and no WIP. The company produced 20,000 units and sold 18,000 units at ₹300 each.

Item	₹
Raw materials consumed	24,00,000
Direct wages	12,00,000
Direct expenses	2,00,000
Factory overheads	9,00,000
Administration overheads (production)	5,00,000
Selling & distribution overheads	3,60,000

Prepare the Cost Sheet, value the closing finished goods, and find profit.

Step 1 — Cost of Production of 20,000 units produced: Prime Cost = 24,00,000 + 12,00,000 + 2,00,000 = **38,00,000**. Works Cost = 38,00,000 + 9,00,000 = **47,00,000** (no WIP). Cost of Production = 47,00,000 + 5,00,000 = **52,00,000**.

Step 2 — Cost of Production per unit = 52,00,000 ÷ 20,000 = **₹260**.

Step 3 — Closing finished goods = units unsold × cost of production per unit. Units unsold = 20,000 produced − 18,000 sold − 0 opening = **2,000 units**. Value = 2,000 × ₹260 = **₹5,20,000**. *(Valued at cost of production, NOT cost of sales — no selling cost on unsold stock.)*

Step 4 — Cost of Goods Sold = 52,00,000 + 0 opening − 5,20,000 closing = **46,80,000** (= 18,000 × ₹260 ✓).

Step 5 — Cost of Sales = 46,80,000 + 3,60,000 S&D = **50,40,000**.

Step 6 — Sales & Profit: Sales = 18,000 × ₹300 = **54,00,000**. Profit = 54,00,000 − 50,40,000 = **₹3,60,000**.

Cost Sheet of Apex Pumps (year ended 31.03.2026)

Particulars	Units	Total ₹
Raw Materials consumed		24,00,000
Direct Wages		12,00,000
Direct Expenses		2,00,000
Prime Cost		**38,00,000**
Add: Factory Overheads		9,00,000
Works Cost	20,000 produced	**47,00,000**
Add: Administration Overheads		5,00,000
Cost of Production	20,000	**52,00,000**
Less: Closing Finished Goods (2,000 × 260)	(2,000)	(5,20,000)
Cost of Goods Sold	18,000 sold	**46,80,000**
Add: Selling & Distribution Overheads		3,60,000
Cost of Sales	18,000	**50,40,000**
Profit		**3,60,000**
Sales (18,000 × 300)	18,000	**54,00,000**

Check: COGS 46,80,000 ÷ 18,000 = ₹260 per unit = cost of production per unit. ✓ Closing stock 2,000 × 260 = 5,20,000, and 5,20,000 + 46,80,000 = 52,00,000 = full cost of production. ✓ Every produced unit's cost is accounted for — 18,000 flowed to COGS, 2,000 sit in closing stock. Nothing leaked. **The whole lesson:** production cost splits between what was sold (COGS) and what remains (closing FG), and both use the *same* ₹260 production rate.

Example 5 — Examiner tweak: material at prime cost WIP + notional item planted

A short "what if the examiner tweaks it" drill. Zenith Forgings gives: Materials consumed ₹10,00,000; Direct wages ₹6,00,000; Direct expenses ₹50,000; Factory overhead ₹4,00,000; **Opening WIP ₹1,20,000 and Closing WIP ₹1,00,000, both valued at prime cost**; Administration OH ₹2,00,000; **Interest on bank loan ₹80,000**; **Profit on sale of old machine ₹30,000**; Selling OH ₹1,50,000; Profit 25% on cost.

Two tweaks are planted: (i) WIP is valued at **prime cost**, so it must be adjusted **before** factory overheads, not after; (ii) interest and profit-on-sale are **financial/non-operating** and must be **excluded** entirely.

Solution

Particulars	₹
Materials consumed	10,00,000
Direct Wages	6,00,000
Direct Expenses	50,000
Prime Cost (of work done)	**16,50,000**
Add: Opening WIP (at prime cost)	1,20,000
Less: Closing WIP (at prime cost)	(1,00,000)
Prime Cost adjusted for WIP	**16,70,000**
Add: Factory Overheads	4,00,000
Works Cost	**20,70,000**
Add: Administration Overheads	2,00,000
Cost of Production / COGS (no FG stock)	**22,70,000**
Add: Selling & Distribution Overheads	1,50,000
Cost of Sales	**24,20,000**
Add: Profit (25% on cost)	6,05,000
Sales	**30,25,000**

Excluded: interest on loan ₹80,000 and profit on sale of machine ₹30,000 — both financial/non-operating, so they never touch the cost sheet.

Check: Profit 6,05,000 ÷ Cost of Sales 24,20,000 = 25.0% on cost. ✓ WIP was adjusted **before** factory OH precisely because it was valued at prime cost — had it been valued at works cost, it would have gone in after the ₹4,00,000. Naming that assumption is where the mark is. Had you also wrongly deducted the ₹80,000 interest as a cost or added the ₹30,000 machine profit to sales, every figure below would be corrupted.

---

6. Presentation / Format — the standard vertical layout

ICAI expects a **vertical (columnar) statement**, not a debit/credit account. Golden presentation rules:

1. **Title:** "Cost Sheet (or Statement of Cost) of ___ for the period ended ___."
2. **Two amount columns** for build-up (detail column + total column); add a **"Per Unit"** column and a **"Total"** column when quantities are given.
3. Show the **bold sub-totals** in order: Prime Cost → Works/Factory Cost → Cost of Production → Cost of Goods Sold → Cost of Sales → Sales. Never skip a stage even if a layer is nil.
4. Insert each **stock at its correct stage** (RM before Prime; WIP at Works; FG after Cost of Production).
5. Show **scrap sale** as a deduction from factory overhead/works cost; show **defective/rectification** per instructions.
6. Keep **excluded financial items** off the sheet entirely (see §4.9) — mention them only if a reconciliation with financial profit is asked.

Per-unit column discipline (where students lose marks): the per-unit figure at each stage must be that stage's *total ÷ the relevant quantity*, and the relevant quantity **changes down the sheet**:

- Material, Prime, Works, Cost of Production → divide by **units produced**.
- Cost of Goods Sold, Cost of Sales, Sales, Profit → divide by **units sold**.

Because produced ≠ sold when stock exists, a single "per unit" column cannot be internally consistent all the way down. State which quantity you used at the stock boundary, or use two per-unit columns (produced-basis above COGS, sold-basis from COGS down). The examiner rewards you for noticing the base switches at the finished-goods line.

Skeleton to reproduce from memory:

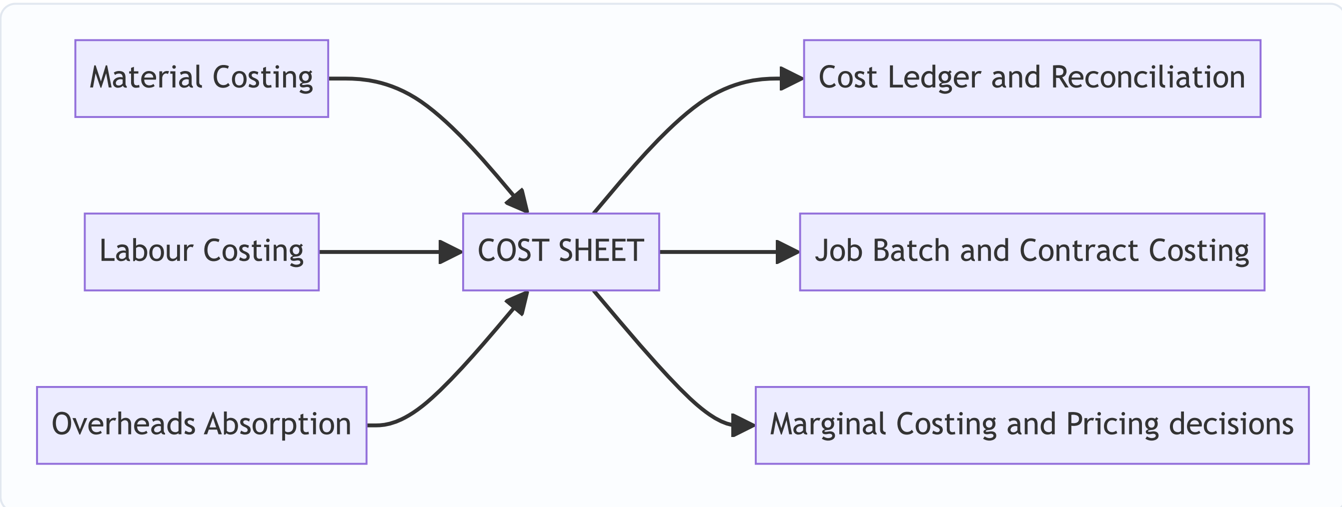
Stage	Add	Less	Gives
Materials	Op. RM + Purchases + Carriage in	Cl. RM	Material Consumed
+ Wages + Direct Exp			**Prime Cost**
+ Factory OH	Op. WIP	Cl. WIP, Scrap	**Works Cost**
+ Admin OH			**Cost of Production**
	Op. FG	Cl. FG	**Cost of Goods Sold**
+ Selling & Distribution OH			**Cost of Sales**
+ Profit			**Sales**

Reconciliation footnote to keep handy. If a question also gives financial-account profit and asks *why* it differs, the gap is exactly the §4.9 items (financial expenses, non-operating incomes, abnormal losses, and any over/under-absorbed overhead and stock-valuation differences). That is the entire subject of the *Cost & Financial Accounts Reconciliation* chapter — the Cost Sheet is where the divergence is *created*.

---

7. Connections — where this sits in the wider syllabus

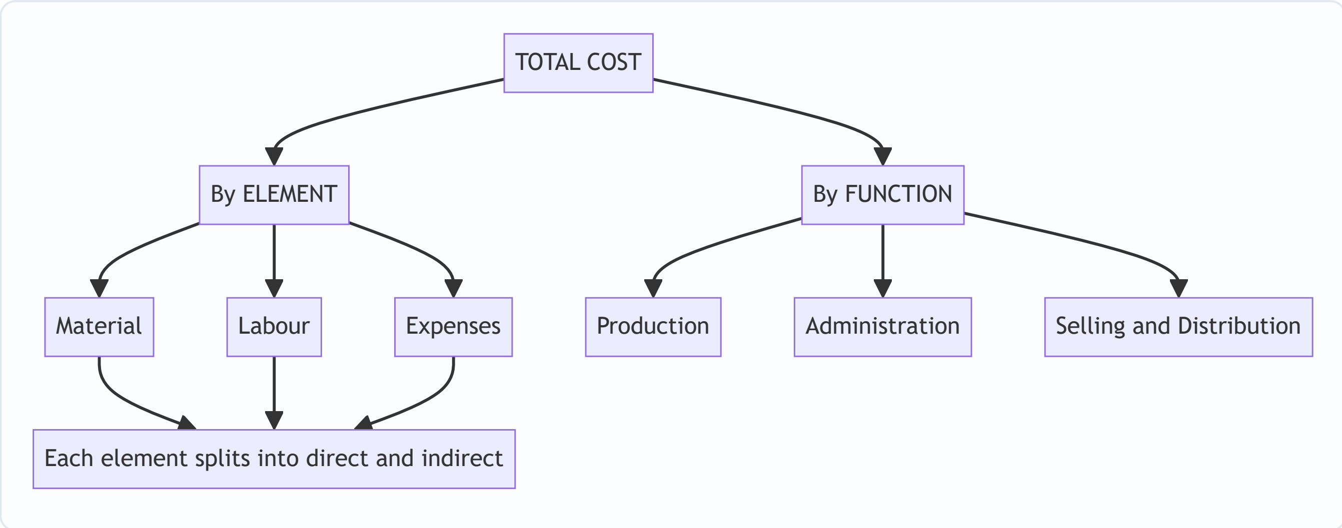
Figure 3 — the Cost Sheet as the confluence of the element chapters.



- **Material, Labour, Overhead chapters** feed the three elements — the Cost Sheet is where they *assemble*.

- **Overhead absorption** supplies the recovery rates (% of wages, % of works cost, per unit) used in tenders — exactly Example 3.
- **Reconciliation of cost and financial accounts** exists because the Cost Sheet *excludes* the financial items of §4.9; the reconciliation statement bridges the gap.
- **Job / Batch / Contract costing** are the Cost Sheet applied to a single job, a batch, or a long project.
- **Marginal costing** re-cuts the same costs into *fixed vs variable* rather than *function-wise*, for short-run decisions.

Figure 4 — the two independent ways the same total cost is classified.



The Cost Sheet uses the element cut to build Prime Cost and the function cut to build the staircase above it.

---

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Wrong rung for a stock.** Putting closing FG at the Works stage, or WIP after Cost of Production, corrupts everything below. *Rule:* RM before Prime, WIP at Works, FG after Cost of Production.
2. **Carriage inward vs outward.** Inward = part of material cost (added before Prime). Outward = selling cost (added at Cost of Sales). Examiners bury both in one list.
3. **Profit on cost vs profit on sales.** "25% on cost" ≠ "25% on sales." Convert deliberately (§4.8). This flips the tender price by several rupees.
4. **Financial items sneaked in.** Interest on capital, income-tax, dividends, loss on sale of machinery, donation, goodwill written off, transfer to reserve — all must be **left out**. Non-operating incomes (interest/dividend received) are **not** deducted from cost either.
5. **Scrap treatment.** Normal scrap sale reduces factory cost. Do *not* add it to sales. Abnormal scrap loss goes to Costing P&L, not the sheet.
6. **Cash discount vs trade discount.** Cash discount (received/allowed) is financial — exclude. Trade discount is netted against purchases/sales.
7. **Per-unit rate from the wrong volume.** In tenders, derive rates from *actual output* (units produced), then apply to the *new* quantity. Mixing "sold" and "produced" units is a classic slip when FG stock exists.
8. **Depreciation split.** Depreciation of *plant* → factory OH; of *office equipment* → admin OH; of *delivery van* → selling OH. Location decides the layer.

9. **Overheads given as "office and administration"** default to the admin stage; "showroom/warehouse of finished goods" is selling, not factory.
10. **Under-/over-absorbed overhead** (if given): adjust only if the question asks; otherwise use actuals. Don't invent adjustments.
11. **Closing FG valued at cost of sales.** Closing finished goods carry **cost of production** per unit, never cost of sales — a warehoused unit has not been sold, so no selling cost attaches (Example 4). Valuing it higher overstates stock and understates COGS.
12. **Overtime premium mis-placed.** Only the *premium* is reclassified (job-specific → direct expense; general → factory OH; abnormal → P&L). The *normal-rate* portion of overtime stays in direct wages. Students often shift the whole overtime figure.
13. **WIP valuation basis ignored.** If WIP is stated "at prime cost," adjust it *before* factory overheads (Example 5); default (works cost) is *after*. Always name the assumption.
14. **Primary vs secondary packing.** Primary packing essential to sale → production cost; transport packing → distribution. Same word, different stage.
15. **Notional items added without instruction.** Notional rent/interest/proprietor's salary enter the sheet only if the question says so; otherwise leave them out.
16. **GST / refundable taxes added to material.** Only *irrecoverable* taxes and duties form part of material cost; GST input credit (recoverable) is excluded, like trade discount.
17. **Idle-time and abnormal-loss wages.** Normal idle time → factory OH; abnormal idle time/strike → Costing P&L. Never load abnormal idle wages onto product cost.
18. **"Sold" units used to value production stages.** Prime/Works/Cost of Production per unit use *units produced*; only COGS and below use *units sold*. The base switches at the FG line (§6).

---

9. First-Principles Recap

Strip away the format and the whole chapter is one sentence: **cost accumulates as the product physically travels — foundation of directs (Prime), through the factory (Works), through the office (Cost of Production), out to the customer (Cost of Sales) — and each stock is injected at the exact stage where the goods physically rest.**

- *Why a staircase?* Because different managers own different layers, and each needs to see his own cost.
- *Why directs first?* Because traceable cost is controllable at the shop floor before shared overheads.
- *Why three stocks at three stages?* Because "produced" ≠ "sold," and cost must be matched to *where the goods actually are* — RM before making, WIP during making, FG after making.
- *Why is each stock valued at the stage it reached?* Because a unit can only carry the costs it has actually absorbed — RM at purchase cost, WIP at works cost, FG at cost of production. Selling cost never sits in stock because it is not incurred until sale.
- *Why exclude financial items?* Because cost tells you the price of *making and selling*, not of *financing and taxing*.
- *Why per-unit rates for tenders?* Because a rate is a portable law you can carry to any future volume and price level — that is the manager's whole reason for asking.
- *Why does the per-unit base switch at the finished-goods line?* Because everything above COGS is measured over units *produced*, and everything from COGS down is measured over units *sold* — and those two

numbers differ exactly by the change in finished-goods stock.

If you can rebuild the format from these *whys*, you never need to memorise it — and you can adapt it to any twist the examiner invents.

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

#	Stage	Formula
1	Material Consumed	Op. RM + Purchases + Carriage inward + duty − Returns − Cl. RM
2	**Prime Cost**	Material Consumed + Direct Wages + Direct Expenses
3	Gross Works Cost	Prime Cost + Factory Overheads − Scrap sale
4	**Works / Factory Cost**	Gross Works Cost + Op. WIP − Cl. WIP
5	**Cost of Production**	Works Cost + Administration Overheads
6	**Cost of Goods Sold**	Cost of Production + Op. Finished Goods − Cl. Finished Goods
7	**Cost of Sales**	COGS + Selling & Distribution Overheads
8	**Sales**	Cost of Sales + Profit
9	Profit = x% on cost	Sales = Cost × (1 + x); on-sales rate = x/(100+x)
10	Profit = y% on sales	Cost = Sales × (1 − y); on-cost rate = y/(100−y)
11	FG stock valuation	Cl. FG units × (Cost of Production ÷ units produced)
12	Cost per unit	Total cost at a stage ÷ number of units (produced above COGS, sold below)
13	Units sold identity	Op. FG units + Units produced − Cl. FG units
14	WIP valued at prime cost	Adjust *before* factory OH (default: after, at works cost)

Stock-at-its-stage map: Raw Material → *before* Prime · WIP → *at* Works · Finished Goods → *after* Cost of Production.

Stock-valuation map: RM → purchase cost · WIP → works cost (or prime cost if stated) · FG → cost of production per unit. Selling cost is *never* in stock.

Per-unit base map: Material/Prime/Works/Cost of Production → ÷ units *produced* · COGS/Cost of Sales/Sales/Profit → ÷ units *sold*.

Excluded from Cost Sheet: interest, income-tax, dividends, loss/profit on sale of assets, transfers to reserve, cash discount, donations, goodwill/preliminary written off, non-operating incomes, abnormal losses, fines/penalties, recoverable taxes (GST credit).

Overhead-by-location: plant depreciation & works manager → Factory · office rent & audit fee & directors' fee → Admin · advertising, carriage outward, salesmen commission, showroom → Selling & Distribution.

Margin ready-reckoner: 25% on cost = 20% on sales · 33⅓% on cost = 25% on sales · 50% on cost = 33⅓% on sales · 100% on cost = 50% on sales.

Q&A — Cost Sheet

Exam-oriented question bank for CA Intermediate — Cost & Management Accounting. Every question is followed immediately by a complete model answer. All figures are in Rupees (₹) and follow ICAI cost-accounting conventions.

Section A — Concept-Check (short theory)

A1. What is a Cost Sheet and what pricing question does it answer that a P&L cannot? A Cost Sheet is a statement showing the total and per-unit cost of a product/service, built element by element and stage by stage (Prime → Works → Production → COGS → Cost of Sales). The financial P&L only gives *total* profit for the period; it cannot tell you the cost *per unit* or the cost *at each function*. The Cost Sheet answers "what did one unit cost to make and sell, and therefore what price must I quote?" — essential for tenders, quotations and price fixation.

A2. Distinguish direct and indirect costs. Direct costs are conveniently and wholly traceable to a cost object (direct material, direct labour, direct expenses) and form Prime Cost. Indirect costs (overheads) cannot be economically traced to one unit and are apportioned/absorbed — factory, administration and selling & distribution overheads.

A3. State the five cost stages in order and the item added at each. Prime Cost (direct elements) → Factory/Works Cost (+ factory OH ± WIP) → Cost of Production (+ admin OH) → Cost of Goods Sold (± finished-goods stock) → Cost of Sales (+ selling & distribution OH). Add profit to reach Sales.

A4. Why is stock a "timing bridge" and where does each stock adjustment sit? Stock corrects the mismatch between what is *made/bought* this period and what is *sold* this period. Raw-material stock adjusts at material-consumed (before Prime Cost); WIP adjusts inside Works Cost; finished-goods stock adjusts between Cost of Production and COGS.

A5. Give the two margin formulas and how to convert between them. Profit as % of cost: Profit = Cost × rate. Profit as % of sales: Profit = Sales × rate. Convert: if profit is 25% on cost, then on sales it is 25/125 = 20%; if 20% on sales, then on cost it is 20/80 = 25%.

A6. List four items excluded from the Cost Sheet. Purely financial/appropriation items: income tax, dividends paid, interest on loans (financial charge), donations, goodwill/preliminary-expense write-offs, loss on sale of fixed assets, cash discounts, and transfers to reserves. They are dealt with in Cost Reconciliation, not the Cost Sheet.

A7. What is the treatment of scrap sale of raw material vs. sale of finished-goods scrap? Sale value of *defective raw material/normal factory scrap* is deducted from factory overheads (or material cost); it reduces cost. It is never treated as other income in the Cost Sheet.

Section B — Graded Computational Problems (full workings)

B1 (Easy) — Basic build-up, profit on cost

Q. From the following prepare a Cost Sheet and find Sales: Direct material ₹50,000; Direct wages ₹30,000; Direct expenses ₹5,000; Factory overhead ₹20,000; Administration overhead ₹15,000; Selling overhead

₹10,000. Profit is 20% on cost.

Solution.

Particulars	₹
Direct Material	50,000
Direct Wages	30,000
Direct Expenses	5,000
Prime Cost	**85,000**
Add: Factory Overhead	20,000
Works / Factory Cost	**1,05,000**
Add: Administration Overhead	15,000
Cost of Production	**1,20,000**
Add: Selling Overhead	10,000
Cost of Sales	**1,30,000**
Add: Profit (20% × 1,30,000)	26,000
Sales	**1,56,000**

Self-check: Profit 26,000 / Sales 1,56,000 = 16.67% on sales = 20/120. Consistent.

B2 (Medium) — All three stock adjustments

Q. Prepare a Cost Sheet: Raw material — Opening ₹20,000, Purchases ₹1,00,000, Carriage inward ₹5,000, Closing ₹15,000. Direct wages ₹60,000; Direct expenses ₹10,000; Factory overhead ₹40,000; Work-in-progress — Opening ₹12,000, Closing ₹8,000; Administration overhead (production-related) ₹26,000; Finished goods — Opening ₹30,000, Closing ₹20,000; Selling & distribution overhead ₹40,000. Profit is 25% on cost.

Solution.

Particulars	₹	₹
Opening Raw Material	20,000	
Add: Purchases	1,00,000	
Add: Carriage Inward	5,000	
Less: Closing Raw Material	(15,000)	
Raw Material Consumed		**1,10,000**
Direct Wages		60,000
Direct Expenses		10,000
Prime Cost		**1,80,000**
Add: Factory Overhead	40,000	
Add: Opening WIP	12,000	
Less: Closing WIP	(8,000)	44,000
Works / Factory Cost		**2,24,000**
Add: Administration Overhead		26,000
Cost of Production		**2,50,000**
Add: Opening Finished Goods	30,000	
Less: Closing Finished Goods	(20,000)	10,000
Cost of Goods Sold		**2,60,000**
Add: Selling & Distribution Overhead		40,000
Cost of Sales		**3,00,000**
Add: Profit (25% × 3,00,000)		75,000
Sales		**3,75,000**

Self-check: Profit 75,000 on cost 3,00,000 = 25% ✓; on sales 3,75,000 = 20% = 25/125 ✓.

B3 (Exam-Hard) — Tender / quotation with per-unit rates

Q. During 2025-26 a factory produced 10,000 units with: Raw material consumed ₹3,00,000; Direct wages ₹2,00,000; Works overhead 50% of direct wages; Administration overhead 20% of works cost. In 2026-27 the factory receives a tender for **1,500 units**. Material and wages **per unit** will rise by 10%; works overhead remains 50% of wages and administration overhead 20% of works cost. Selling & distribution overhead is to be added at **₹0.80 per unit**. The company wants a **profit of 20% on the selling price**. Prepare the current-year cost sheet (total and per unit) and compute the tender price (total and per unit).

Step 1 — Current-year cost sheet (10,000 units):

Particulars	Total ₹	Per unit ₹
Raw Material	3,00,000	30.00
Direct Wages	2,00,000	20.00
Prime Cost	**5,00,000**	**50.00**
Works Overhead (50% of wages)	1,00,000	10.00
Works Cost	**6,00,000**	**60.00**
Administration OH (20% of works cost)	1,20,000	12.00
Cost of Production	**7,20,000**	**72.00**

Step 2 — Revised per-unit rates for the tender: - Material: 30 × 1.10 = **₹33.00** - Wages: 20 × 1.10 = **₹22.00** - Prime cost = 33 + 22 = **₹55.00** - Works OH = 50% × 22 = **₹11.00** → Works cost = **₹66.00** - Admin OH = 20% × 66 = **₹13.20** → Cost of production = **₹79.20** - Selling & distribution = **₹0.80** → Cost of sales = **₹80.00**

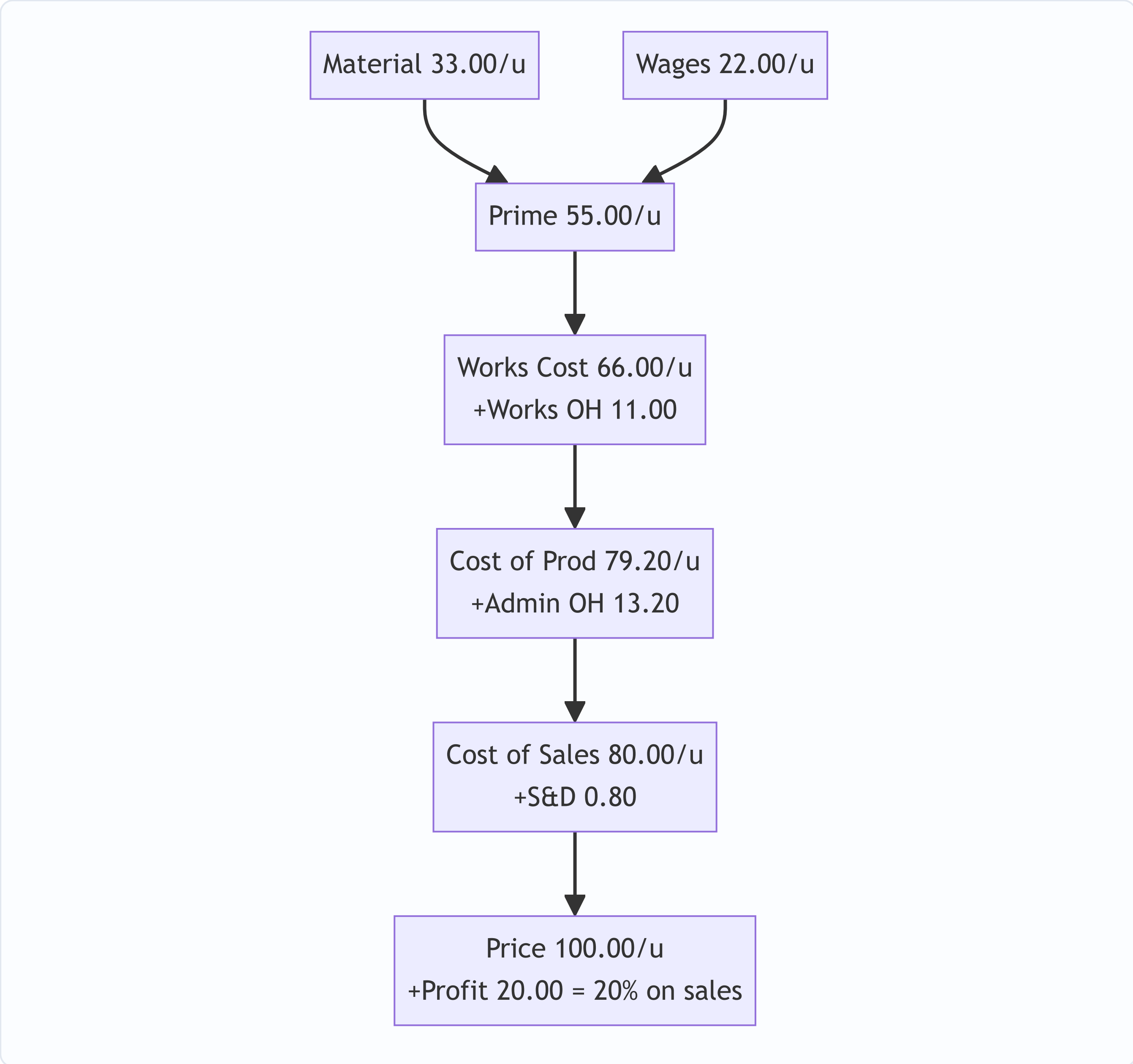
Step 3 — Tender cost sheet (1,500 units):

Particulars	Per unit ₹	1,500 units ₹
Material (33.00)	33.00	49,500
Wages (22.00)	22.00	33,000
Prime Cost	**55.00**	**82,500**
Works OH	11.00	16,500
Works Cost	**66.00**	**99,000**
Administration OH	13.20	19,800
Cost of Production	**79.20**	**1,18,800**
Selling & Distribution OH	0.80	1,200
Cost of Sales	**80.00**	**1,20,000**
Profit (20% on sales → 20/80 of cost)	20.00	30,000
Tender / Sales Price	**100.00**	**1,50,000**

Answer: Quote **₹1,50,000 in total, i.e., ₹100 per unit.**

Self-check: Profit 30,000 / Sales 1,50,000 = 20% on sales ✓. Cost of sales 1,20,000 = 80% of 1,50,000 ✓.

The flow of a per-unit build-up used above:



Section C — Past-Paper-Style Full Questions

C1 — Cost sheet with excluded items and scrap

Q. The books show: Raw material consumed ₹4,00,000; Direct wages ₹2,50,000; Direct expenses ₹50,000; Factory overhead ₹1,50,000; Sale of factory scrap ₹10,000; Administration overhead ₹90,000; Selling & distribution overhead ₹1,10,000; Interest on bank loan ₹15,000; Dividend paid ₹20,000; Donation ₹5,000; Profit ₹1,60,000. Prepare a Cost Sheet, treating the excluded items correctly, and show Sales.

Solution. Interest on loan, dividend and donation are financial/appropriation items — **excluded** from the Cost Sheet. Sale of factory scrap is **deducted from factory overhead**.

Particulars	₹
Raw Material Consumed	4,00,000
Direct Wages	2,50,000
Direct Expenses	50,000
Prime Cost	**7,00,000**
Factory Overhead (1,50,000 − 10,000 scrap)	1,40,000
Works Cost	**8,40,000**
Administration Overhead	90,000
Cost of Production	**9,30,000**
Selling & Distribution Overhead	1,10,000
Cost of Sales	**10,40,000**
Profit	1,60,000
Sales	**12,00,000**

Note: Interest ₹15,000, dividend ₹20,000, donation ₹5,000 are ignored. Profit % on cost = 1,60,000/10,40,000 = 15.38%.

C2 — Reconstruction: find missing figures

Q. A product's cost of sales is ₹5,50,000 and profit is 10% on sales. Selling overhead is ₹50,000 and administration overhead is ₹40,000. There is no opening/closing stock of finished goods or WIP. Prime cost is 70% of works cost. Compute (a) Sales, (b) Cost of production, (c) Works cost, and (d) Prime cost.

Solution. (a) Profit = 10% on sales → Cost of sales = 90% of sales. Sales = 5,50,000 / 0.90 = **₹6,11,111** (rounded). Profit = ₹61,111. (b) Cost of production = Cost of sales − Selling OH = 5,50,000 − 50,000 = **₹5,00,000** (no finished-goods stock, so COGS = Cost of production). (c) Works cost = Cost of production − Admin OH = 5,00,000 − 40,000 = **₹4,60,000**. (d) Prime cost = 70% × Works cost = 0.70 × 4,60,000 = **₹3,22,000**.

Self-check: Prime 3,22,000 + Factory OH 1,38,000 = Works 4,60,000; +Admin 40,000 = 5,00,000; +Selling 50,000 = 5,50,000 = Cost of sales ✓.

C3 — Two-period cost comparison (per-unit efficiency)

Q. Output rose from 5,000 units (Year 1) to 8,000 units (Year 2). Year 1: Material ₹1,00,000; Wages ₹75,000; Variable factory OH ₹25,000; Fixed factory OH ₹40,000. In Year 2 material and wages per unit are unchanged, variable OH per unit unchanged, but fixed factory OH stays ₹40,000. Prepare per-unit works cost for both years and comment.

Solution. Year 1 per unit: Material 20, Wages 15, Variable OH 5, Fixed OH 40,000/5,000 = 8 → Works cost/unit = **₹48**. Year 2 per unit: Material 20, Wages 15, Variable OH 5, Fixed OH 40,000/8,000 = 5 → Works cost/unit = **₹45**.

Element (per unit)	Year 1 ₹	Year 2 ₹
Material	20	20
Wages	15	15
Variable Factory OH	5	5
Fixed Factory OH	8	5
Works Cost / unit	**48**	**45**

Comment: Per-unit cost fell by ₹3 purely because fixed overhead (₹40,000) is spread over more units — this is *economies of scale / better fixed-cost absorption*, not a change in efficiency of variable elements.

Section D — MCQs & Case Scenarios

D1. Carriage inward on raw material is: (a) Selling overhead (b) Added to material cost (c) Excluded (d) Admin overhead **Answer: (b).** It is a cost of *acquiring* material, so it is added to purchases in arriving at material consumed.

D2. Which is NOT part of the Cost Sheet? (a) Direct expenses (b) Factory rent (c) Interest on debentures (d) Depreciation of plant **Answer: (c).** Interest on debentures is a financial charge, excluded and handled in reconciliation.

D3. If profit is 20% on cost, then profit as a % of sales is: (a) 20% (b) 16.67% (c) 25% (d) 80% **Answer: (b).** 20/120 = 16.67% on sales.

D4. Work-in-progress is adjusted at the stage of: (a) Prime cost (b) Works cost (c) Cost of production (d) Cost of sales **Answer: (b).** WIP is partly-finished factory output, so it is adjusted within Works/Factory Cost.

D5. Sale of normal scrap of raw material is: (a) Added to sales (b) Other income (c) Deducted from factory OH / material cost (d) Ignored **Answer: (c).** It reduces cost; never shown as income in the Cost Sheet.

D6 (Case). A firm quotes a tender at cost of sales ₹80/unit and wants 25% profit on cost. A rival quotes ₹98/unit. Should the firm quote lower and still profit? **Answer:** Firm's price = 80 × 1.25 = ₹100/unit. That is above the rival's ₹98. To win it could drop to just under ₹98, still above cost of sales ₹80, so it remains profitable (₹18 profit/unit ≈ 22.5% on cost). Yes — it can undercut and still earn a positive margin.

D7 (Case). Cost of production is ₹7,20,000 for 10,000 units. Opening finished goods 500 units, closing 800 units, valued at current cost of production per unit (₹72). Find COGS. **Answer:** Per-unit cost ₹72. Opening FG = 500 × 72 = 36,000; Closing FG = 800 × 72 = 57,600. COGS = 7,20,000 + 36,000 − 57,600 = **₹6,98,400.**

D8. Administration overhead relating to production is added: (a) Before prime cost (b) Between works cost and cost of production (c) After cost of sales (d) It is excluded **Answer: (b).** General/production admin OH converts works cost into cost of production.

Quick-Revision Sheet

Stage formulas: - Material Consumed = Opening RM + Purchases + Carriage inward − Returns − Closing RM - Prime Cost = Direct Material + Direct Labour + Direct Expenses - Works Cost = Prime Cost + Factory OH + Opening WIP − Closing WIP (less scrap sale) - Cost of Production = Works Cost + Administration OH -

Cost of Goods Sold = Cost of Production + Opening FG − Closing FG - Cost of Sales = COGS + Selling & Distribution OH - Sales = Cost of Sales + Profit

Margin interconversion: on-cost r → on-sales r/(1+r); on-sales s → on-cost s/(1−s). (25% on cost = 20% on sales.)

Stock-at-stage map: RM stock → at Material Consumed | WIP → inside Works Cost | FG stock → between Cost of Production and COGS.

Excluded (go to reconciliation): income tax, dividends, interest on loans/debentures, donations, goodwill & preliminary write-offs, loss/profit on sale of assets, cash discount, transfers to reserves.

Examiner traps (10): (1) treating carriage inward as selling OH; (2) forgetting to deduct scrap from factory OH; (3) adjusting WIP at wrong stage; (4) mixing profit-on-cost with profit-on-sales; (5) including interest/dividend/tax in cost; (6) valuing closing FG at old vs. current cost of production; (7) omitting direct expenses from prime cost; (8) adding admin OH before works cost; (9) ignoring per-unit rate changes in tenders; (10) netting off finished-goods stock in the wrong direction.

Chapter 07 — Cost Accounting Systems (Integrated & Non-Integrated) + Reconciliation

1. The Problem — Two Sets of Eyes on the Same Business

You run a factory. At the end of the year your **financial accountant** hands you a Profit & Loss Account (prepared under the Companies Act / accounting standards) that says: "*Profit = ₹4,20,000.*"

The same year, your **cost accountant** — who has been tracking every job, every machine hour, every kilo of raw material to tell you *what each product costs* — hands you a **Costing Profit & Loss Account** that says: "*Profit = ₹4,86,000.*"

Same factory. Same twelve months. Same sales. **Two different profits.** ₹66,000 apart.

Now imagine you are the Managing Director. Which number do you report to shareholders? Which do you use to price your products? If the two systems disagree, is one of them *lying*? Is somebody stealing ₹66,000?

This is the central problem of this chapter, and it splits into three sub-questions:

1. **Why do we even keep a separate set of costing books** at all? Financial accounting already records every rupee — why duplicate?
2. **How do we structure those costing books** so they behave like a proper double-entry system (which auditors and examiners can test), rather than loose memoranda?
3. **When the two profit figures differ, how do we prove — rupee by rupee — that neither is wrong**, that the difference is fully explained by *known, legitimate reasons*? That proof is the **Reconciliation Statement**, and it is one of the most reliably-examined 8-to-10 mark questions in CA Intermediate.

The moment you understand *why* the two profits differ, the reconciliation statement stops being a list to memorise and becomes something you can reconstruct from scratch. That is the promise of this chapter.

A fourth, subtler question the exam loves. Notice that if the two books *never* disagreed, we would not need reconciliation at all — and indeed there is a third design where they never disagree: the **integrated** system, where cost and financial data are recorded *once* in one shared ledger. So the real strategic decision every business faces is: **keep two books and reconcile (non-integrated), or keep one book and never reconcile (integrated)?** This chapter equips you to (a) run either system as a set of ledger accounts, and (b) build the bridge between them when they are separate. Examiners test all three skills — ledger writing, integrated journal entries, and reconciliation — often in the same paper.

---

2. The Core Idea — The Tax Return vs. The Household Budget

Here is the analogy that unlocks everything.

Think of a family with two documents about its money:

- A **tax return**, filed with the government. It follows *the law*. It must include the interest earned on the savings account and the capital gain from selling the old car, even though those have nothing to do with "running the household." It cannot include a charge for "the rent we *would have* paid if we didn't own our house," because you can't deduct rent you never actually paid.

- A **household budget spreadsheet**, kept for *decision-making*. Here the family *does* include a notional rent — "living in our own house is worth ₹20,000/month, let's cost it in so we know the true cost of housing ourselves." But the budget *ignores* the capital gain on the car, because that's a one-off windfall, not part of monthly living.

Both documents are honest. They serve **different masters**. The tax return serves *external legal reporting*. The budget serves *internal management decisions*. Naturally they arrive at different "surplus" figures — and the difference is entirely explained by *the items each one deliberately includes or excludes*.

Financial accounting is the tax return. Cost accounting is the household budget. **The reconciliation statement is simply the bridge that lists every item one included and the other didn't** — proving the gap is principled, not fraudulent.

That single mental model — "*two honest books serving two masters*" — is the whole chapter. Everything below is just the accounting machinery that makes it precise.

Pushing the analogy one step further (this is where marks are won). The gap between the two documents is not random — it always belongs to one of four *buckets*: (i) things only the tax return recognises (the car's capital gain, the loan interest), (ii) things only the budget recognises (the notional rent), (iii) estimates the budget uses that the tax return trues up to actuals (the family "budgeted" ₹5,000/month for electricity but the actual bills came to ₹5,400), and (iv) the same item *measured differently* in each (the budget values the pantry stock at what they paid; the tax rules force a different valuation). Hold those four buckets in your head — financial-only, cost-only, estimate-vs-actual, and different-measurement — and you can *derive* every reconciling line the examiner can invent, including ones you have never seen before. Section 4.3 names these four buckets in accounting language.

---

3. Why It's Built This Way — Three Structural Choices

3.1 Why keep cost books separate from financial books?

Financial accounts classify expenses **by nature** (salaries, rent, power, depreciation) because the law wants to know *what kind* of money left the business. But a manager asking "*what did Job #47 cost?*" or "*is Product A profitable?*" cannot get an answer from a P&L that only says "total wages ₹18 lakh." Cost accounting reclassifies the same expenses **by function and by cost object** (this much wage went to *this job*, this overhead to *that department*). You need a system that slices data along the "product/process/job" axis, not the "nature of expense" axis. That is why a **separate ledger** — the **Cost Ledger** — historically evolved.

There is also a *timeliness and confidentiality* reason the exam sometimes probes. Financial books close annually under statutory audit deadlines; management needs cost data *monthly or even weekly* to price quotes and control waste. And a firm may not want its detailed job costs (its pricing intelligence) sitting inside the same books its statutory auditors and tax officers pore over. A separate cost ledger delivers management data on management's timetable, in management's classification, without waiting for the financial close.

3.2 Why make the cost ledger self-balancing?

If cost records were just informal notes, no auditor could trust them and no examiner could set a "prepare the ledger accounts" question. So the cost ledger is made into a **complete double-entry system in its own right**. But there's a snag: costing only cares about *manufacturing and trading* transactions — it has no interest in share capital, bank, creditors, or debtors (those are "financial" items). Every cost entry therefore has one leg inside the cost ledger and one leg that points *outward* to the financial world. To keep the cost ledger self-balancing without importing the whole financial ledger, we invent **one master account that stands in for the entire outside financial world**: the **Cost Ledger Control Account** (a.k.a. **General Ledger Adjustment Account**). Every time cost accounting needs to interact with the financial world, the other leg hits this one account. This is the single cleverest idea in non-integrated accounting.

First-principles justification of the self-balancing trick. Double entry demands that every debit have an equal credit *inside the same ledger* — otherwise the trial balance won't tie. When materials are bought on credit, the "credit" side is really *Sundry Creditors*, which lives in the financial ledger. If we left it dangling, the cost ledger's debits would exceed its credits by the value of that creditor, and it would never balance. The CLC absorbs exactly that dangling leg. Mathematically, the CLC is nothing more than **the negative of the sum of all the "internal" cost accounts** — it is a plug that, by construction, makes the two sides equal. That is why the closing balance on the CLC must always equal the total of all other cost-ledger balances (the tie-out check in §5).

3.3 Why would anyone integrate the two systems instead?

Keeping two sets of books means **duplicated posting effort, two trial balances, and a permanent profit gap that must be reconciled every period** — costly and error-prone. So many firms merge them into **one integrated ledger** where each transaction is recorded once and serves both purposes. Integration eliminates the reconciliation work entirely (there's only one profit figure) but demands a more sophisticated chart of accounts and tighter discipline. The trade-off — *simplicity of one book vs. flexibility of two* — is exactly what the exam wants you to be able to argue.

3.4 Degree of integration — a distinction the exam quietly rewards

Integration is not all-or-nothing. A firm chooses **how far up the cost chain** it will merge the two systems:

- **Full integration:** every transaction — from raw-material purchase right through to sales and profit — is posted once in one ledger. Only one profit emerges.
- **Partial integration (integration up to a point):** the two systems share a common ledger only up to, say, **prime cost** or **works cost**; beyond that point cost and financial records diverge and a *limited* reconciliation is still needed. This is common where a firm wants tight control over factory costs but keeps administration/selling records purely financial.

The examiner may ask you to *state the degree of integration a firm has adopted* or to identify which control accounts survive under partial integration. The key insight: the further you integrate, the smaller the residual reconciliation — full integration shrinks it to zero.

3.5 Interlocking vs. integrated — get the vocabulary exactly right

These three terms are constantly confused; a one-mark theory question can turn on them.

Term	Meaning
Cost Control / Non-integrated / Interlocking accounts	Two *separate* self-balancing ledgers (cost + financial) that "interlock" only through periodic reconciliation. Cost ledger uses a **Cost Ledger Control A/c**.
Integrated / Integral accounts	**One** ledger serving both purposes. **No** Cost Ledger Control A/c; real financial accounts appear. **No** reconciliation.
Memorandum reconciliation	A *presentation format* (a T-account version of the reconciliation statement) — not a system. Applies only to non-integrated firms.

Mnemonic: **inter**locking = **inter**val reconciliation (separate books); **integr**ated = **integr**ity of one book.

---

4. Full Technical Content

4.1 Non-Integrated (Cost Ledger / Interlocking) Accounting

Definition. A system in which the cost accounts are maintained in a **separate set of books**, independent of the financial books. Also called **cost ledger accounting** or **interlocking accounting** (the two ledgers "interlock" through periodic reconciliation, but are physically separate).

The Control Accounts. Because the cost ledger is self-balancing, it uses **control accounts** — summary accounts that stand in place of many detailed subsidiary records. The principal accounts are:

Control Account	What it represents / does
Cost Ledger Control A/c (CLC) — a.k.a. General Ledger Adjustment A/c	The proxy for the *entire financial ledger*. Receives the "other leg" of every transaction that originates in the financial world (purchases, wages paid, overheads incurred, sales, opening balances). Makes the cost ledger self-balancing.
Stores Ledger Control A/c	Total value of raw materials in stock; controls the individual bin/stores cards.
Wages Control A/c	Collects gross wages, then distributes them to WIP (direct) and Overhead (indirect).
Production / Works / Factory Overhead Control A/c	Collects all factory indirect costs; *absorbs* them into WIP at the predetermined rate. Its balance = under/over-absorption.
Work-in-Progress (WIP) Control A/c	The manufacturing hub. Debited with direct material, direct wages, direct expenses and absorbed production overhead; credited with cost of finished goods completed.
Administration Overhead Control A/c	Collects admin overheads; absorbed into finished goods (or cost of sales, per policy).
Selling & Distribution Overhead Control A/c	Collects S&D overheads; absorbed into Cost of Sales.
Finished Goods Control A/c	Value of completed but unsold goods. Debited from WIP; credited to Cost of Sales on despatch.
Cost of Sales A/c	Accumulates the total cost of goods actually sold; transferred to Costing P&L.
Costing Profit & Loss A/c	Where sales meet cost of sales; also where under/over-absorption and abnormal gains/losses are closed off; yields **costing profit**.
Overhead Adjustment A/c (optional)	A collecting point to net off under/over-absorption before transfer to Costing P&L.

The Golden Rule of the Cost Ledger Control A/c: *whenever the cost ledger must record something whose "real" other side lives in the financial books (cash, bank, creditors, debtors, capital), the other side is posted to the Cost Ledger Control A/c.* CLC is the ledger's window to the outside world.

Opening balances — the point students skip. On day one of a period, the cost ledger must open with balances too, and *those* also route through the CLC. Every opening **asset** balance (Stores, WIP, Finished Goods) is a **debit** in its own account with the **credit** to CLC; the CLC therefore *opens as a credit balance equal to the net assets carried in*. Forgetting the opening entries is the most common reason a ledger question fails to tie out. If the question gives opening stock figures, your very first journal line should be: *Stores/WIP/Finished Goods Control A/c Dr / To Cost Ledger Control A/c.*

The standard journal entries (non-integrated)

Read each with its *reasoning*, not as a list:

#	Transaction	Entry	Why
1	Materials purchased	Stores Ledger Control A/c **Dr** / To Cost Ledger Control A/c	Stock rises inside cost ledger; the cash/creditor lives outside → CLC.
2	Direct material issued to jobs	WIP Control A/c **Dr** / To Stores Ledger Control A/c	Value moves from store to the shop floor.
3	Indirect material issued	Production OH Control A/c **Dr** / To Stores Ledger Control A/c	Indirect material is an overhead, not a direct charge.
4	Wages paid (gross)	Wages Control A/c **Dr** / To Cost Ledger Control A/c	Cash paid lives outside → CLC.
5	Direct wages allocated	WIP Control A/c **Dr** / To Wages Control A/c	Direct labour is a prime cost of the product.
6	Indirect wages allocated	Production OH Control A/c **Dr** / To Wages Control A/c	Indirect labour is overhead.
7	Overheads incurred (rent, power...)	Production/Admin/S&D OH Control A/c **Dr** / To Cost Ledger Control A/c	Real payment is outside → CLC.
8	Production OH absorbed	WIP Control A/c **Dr** / To Production OH Control A/c	Overhead absorbed into product at predetermined rate.
9	Cost of goods completed	Finished Goods Control A/c **Dr** / To WIP Control A/c	Completed output leaves WIP.
10	Admin OH absorbed	Finished Goods Control A/c **Dr** / To Admin OH Control A/c	Admin loaded onto finished output (policy-dependent).
11	Cost of goods sold	Cost of Sales A/c **Dr** / To Finished Goods Control A/c	Goods despatched to customers.
12	S&D OH absorbed	Cost of Sales A/c **Dr** / To S&D OH Control A/c	Selling cost attaches only to goods sold.
13	Sales	Cost Ledger Control A/c **Dr** / To Costing P&L A/c	Revenue's real side (debtor/cash) is outside → CLC.
14	Transfer cost of sales to P&L	Costing P&L A/c **Dr** / To Cost of Sales A/c	Match cost against revenue.
15	Over-absorption of OH	Production OH Control A/c **Dr** / To Costing P&L A/c	Excess absorbed = a costing "gain."
15a	Under-absorption of OH	Costing P&L A/c **Dr** / To Production OH Control A/c	Shortfall absorbed = a costing "loss."
16	Costing profit	Costing P&L A/c **Dr** / To Cost Ledger Control A/c	Profit is "owed back" to the financial world; closes the ledger.

A few less-common but examinable entries. Extend the same logic:

Transaction	Entry	Why
Materials returned to supplier	Cost Ledger Control A/c **Dr** / To Stores Ledger Control A/c	Reverse of purchase — stock falls, outside world is credited-back.
Material returned from shop to store	Stores Ledger Control A/c **Dr** / To WIP Control A/c	Value flows back up the chain.
Carriage inward on materials	Stores Ledger Control A/c **Dr** / To Cost Ledger Control A/c	Freight-in is part of material cost, capitalised into stores.
Abnormal loss of material/stock	Costing P&L A/c **Dr** / To Stores (or WIP) Control A/c	Abnormal loss is charged straight to Costing P&L, not to product.
Abnormal gain	WIP / Process A/c **Dr** / To Costing P&L A/c	Abnormal gain credited to Costing P&L.
Notional charge (e.g. notional rent)	Overhead Control A/c **Dr** / To Cost Ledger Control A/c	Cost-only charge; the "credit" has no financial reality, so it hits CLC.

Note the last row: a **notional** charge is *created* inside the cost ledger with its balancing credit to CLC — which is precisely why it later becomes a reconciling item (the financial books never saw it).

Self-check property: because *every* leg that leaves the cost ledger meets the CLC, the **balance on the Cost Ledger Control A/c always equals the net total of all other control-account balances** (Stores + WIP + Finished Goods etc.). The cost trial balance therefore balances on its own. That is the entire point of the design.

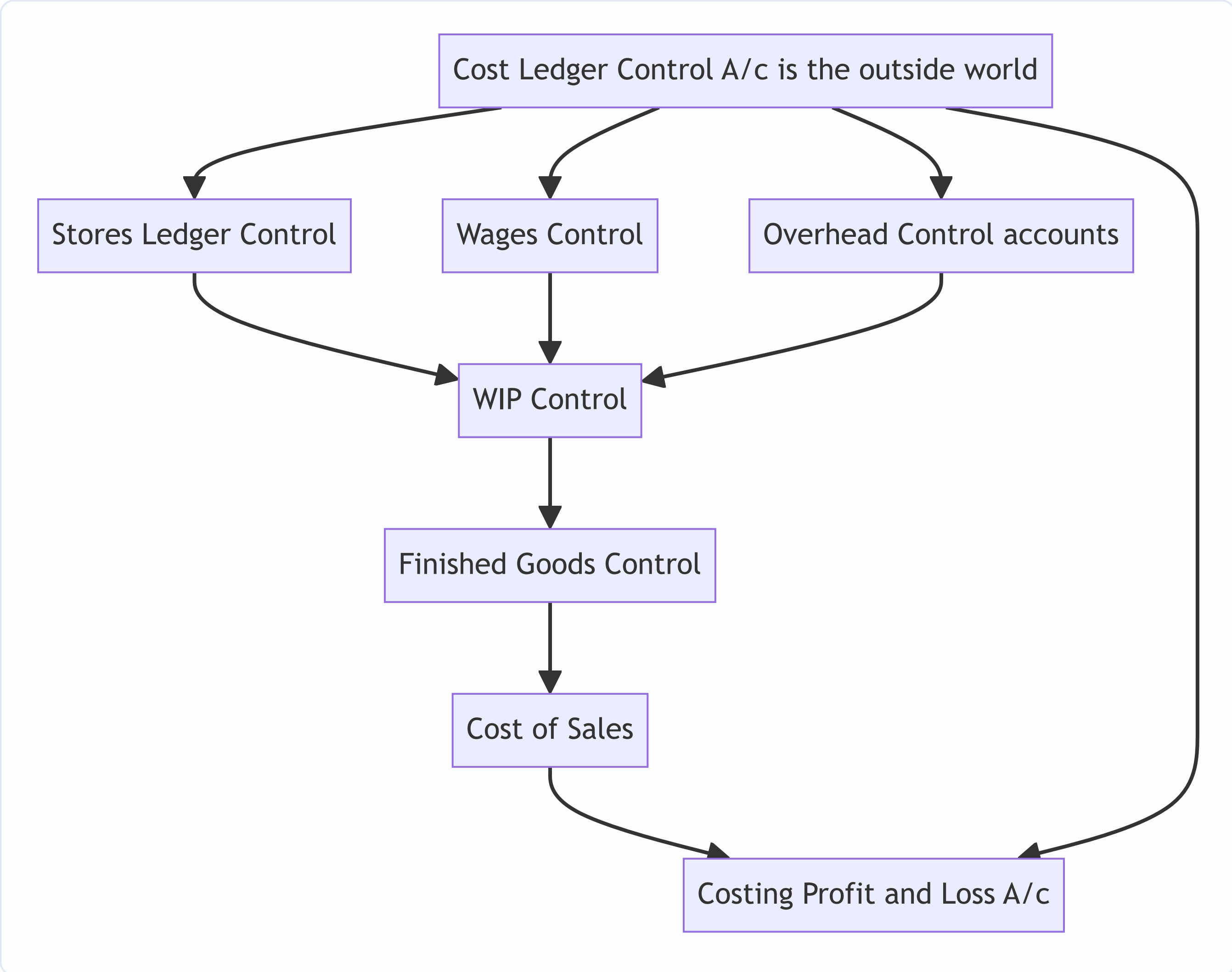


Figure 4.1 — Cost flow through the non-integrated control accounts; every external leg loops back to the Cost Ledger Control A/c.

4.2 Integrated (Integral) Accounting

Definition. A **single set of books** that records cost and financial transactions together, so that both cost data and financial statements are produced from one ledger — **no separate cost ledger, no Cost Ledger Control A/c, and no reconciliation needed.**

The key structural change: in place of the fictional Cost Ledger Control A/c, the **real** financial accounts (Bank/Cash, Sundry Creditors, Sundry Debtors, Provision for Depreciation, Share Capital) now appear. So the entry for "materials purchased on credit" becomes:

> Stores Ledger Control A/c **Dr** / To **Sundry Creditors A/c** — (a *real* creditor, not the CLC proxy).

Everything downstream (WIP, Finished Goods, Cost of Sales, overhead control accounts, absorption) works **exactly as in the non-integrated system** — only the "window to the outside world" is replaced by the genuine financial accounts.

The full integrated journal — map each cost entry to its real counterpart. This side-by-side is exactly what "prepare journal entries under integrated accounting" wants:

Transaction	Integrated entry (real accounts in **bold**)
Materials purchased on credit	Stores Ledger Control Dr / To **Sundry Creditors**
Wages paid	Wages Control Dr / To **Bank**
Overheads paid in cash	Overhead Control Dr / To **Bank**
Overheads outstanding	Overhead Control Dr / To **Outstanding Expenses**
Depreciation on plant	Overhead Control Dr / To **Provision for Depreciation**
Direct material to jobs	WIP Control Dr / To Stores Ledger Control
Direct wages to jobs	WIP Control Dr / To Wages Control
Production OH absorbed	WIP Control Dr / To Production OH Control
Goods completed	Finished Goods Control Dr / To WIP Control
Cost of goods sold	Cost of Sales Dr / To Finished Goods Control
Sales on credit	**Sundry Debtors** Dr / To Sales (then Sales → Costing/General P&L)
Cash received from debtors	**Bank** Dr / To **Sundry Debtors**

Study the pattern: **internal cost legs are identical to §4.1; only the "outside world" leg changes from CLC to a real account.** Master §4.1 and integrated entries are free.

Treatment of under/over-absorbed overhead in an integrated system. Because there is only one profit, the under/over-absorption is simply carried to the single Profit & Loss A/c (or deferred via an Overhead Adjustment A/c if the firm's policy is to carry it forward). There is *no* separate "costing" profit to protect — this is why an integrated firm has nothing to reconcile.

Why integrate (advantages): - **One profit figure** — no reconciliation, no permanent gap to explain. - **No duplication** of effort; each transaction posted once. Lower cost, fewer errors. - **One arithmetic accuracy check** — a single trial balance covers both purposes. - Cost and financial data are **always coordinated and up to date** together. - **Wider management view** — every manager sees a common, reconciled dataset, aiding decisions.

Prerequisites for integration (why it isn't automatic): 1. A management **decision on the degree of integration** (full, or only up to prime/works cost — see §3.4). 2. A **suitable, well-codified chart of accounts** so one entry serves both classifications (by nature *and* by function/object). 3. **Agreed treatment** of notional items and stock valuation, and a coding system linking accounts. 4. **Full cooperation** between the cost and financial staff. 5. **An educated staff and adequate IT/records** so the integrated system's discipline is actually maintained.

The subtle consequence for notional costs. If the firm truly integrates, can it still charge *notional* rent or interest? Not into the shared ledger — a notional charge has no real credit counterpart, so it cannot sit in a system built on real accounts. Integrated firms therefore either **drop notional charges** or keep them as **memorandum/statistical** figures outside the ledger. This is why "no reconciliation" and "no notional charges in the books" go hand in hand — a favourite conceptual exam point.

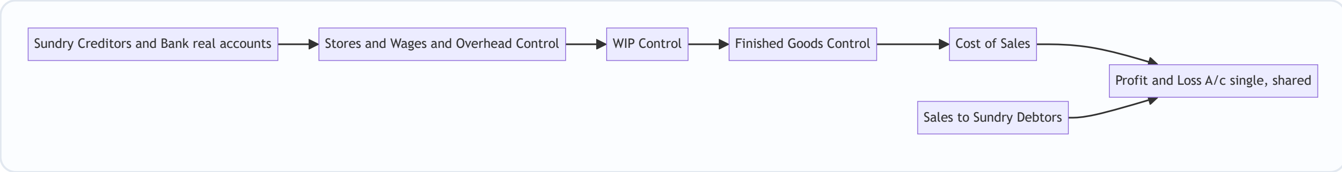


Figure 4.2 — Integrated system: the same cost flow, but the outside legs hit real financial accounts, producing one shared Profit and Loss A/c.

4.3 The heart of the matter — Why the two profits differ

Under the **non-integrated** system (or when comparing a firm's cost books against its financial books), the two profit figures diverge for exactly **four families of reasons**. Master these four and you never memorise a reconciliation list again.

A. Items shown ONLY in Financial Accounts (never enter cost). These are *purely financial* — not related to manufacturing/operations, so cost accounting ignores them. - *Purely financial charges (expenses/losses):* interest on loans/debentures paid, loss on sale of fixed assets/investments, discount on issue of shares/debentures written off, goodwill/preliminary expenses written off, penalties & fines, donations, provision for taxation, dividends paid. - *Purely financial incomes (gains):* interest received, dividends received, rent received, profit on sale of fixed assets/investments, transfer fees received. - *Appropriations of profit (a sub-set worth naming):* transfer to general reserve, transfer to sinking fund, proposed/paid dividend, income-tax provision. These are *below-the-line* in financial books and never enter cost — classic reconciling items examiners slip in.

B. Items shown ONLY in Cost Accounts (notional charges). Cost accounting includes *notional / imputed* costs to reveal the true economic cost of resources, even though no cash changed hands and financial books know nothing of them. - *Notional rent* on own premises; *notional interest* on own capital; *notional salary* of a proprietor. These reduce costing profit but not financial profit.

C. Over- or Under-absorption of Overheads. Cost accounts absorb overhead at a **predetermined rate**; financial accounts record the **actual** overhead. The mismatch causes a difference (unless it was already fully written to the Costing P&L). This bucket covers **production, administration AND selling** overheads — students remember factory OH and forget the other two.

D. Different bases of valuation / methods. - **Stock valuation:** cost books may value stock at, say, weighted average while financial books use FIFO — different opening/closing stock values shift profit differently in each set. (Under-valuation vs over-valuation of *opening* and *closing* stock each has its own direction — see the stock trap in §8.) - **Depreciation:** cost books may use machine-hour rate; financial books straight-line/WDV — different depreciation charges. - **WIP valuation and basis of overhead recovery** can differ similarly.

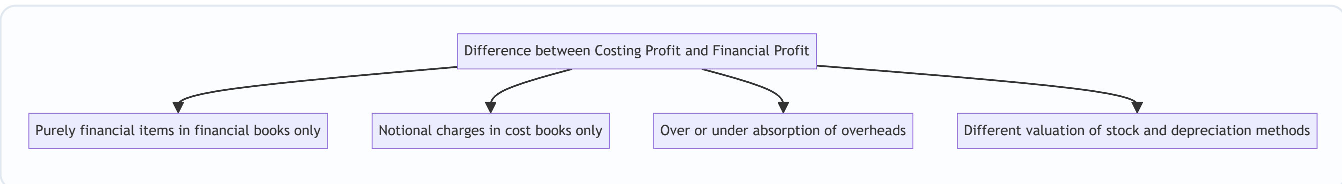


Figure 4.3 — The four families of reconciling items. Every reconciliation line belongs to one of these.

4.4 The mechanical rule for building the Reconciliation Statement

Pick **one** profit as your starting point; adjust toward the other. The direction rule (memorise the *logic*, not the table):

> **Start with Costing Profit. Then:** - **ADD** every item that made *financial profit higher* (i.e., financial-only **incomes**; overhead **over-absorbed** in cost; items **over-charged** as expense in cost such as **higher cost depreciation** or **higher cost stock consumption**). - **SUBTRACT** every item that made *financial profit lower* (i.e., financial-only **expenses/losses**; **notional charges** debited only in cost; overhead **under-absorbed** in cost). - The answer = **Financial Profit.**

The failsafe test for any line: "*Did this item reduce one profit but not the other? Then move in the direction that closes the gap.*" If an expense sits in financial books only, financial profit is lower, so from costing profit you **subtract** it. If an income sits in financial books only, financial profit is higher, so you **add** it.

Mirror-image caution: the ADD/SUBTRACT signs **flip** if you start from *financial* profit and work toward *costing* profit. Always write the heading — "Profit as per Cost Accounts" — so you know your starting anchor.

A universal two-step algorithm that never fails (use this when a tweaked item confuses you): 1. Ask: *In which book is this item's effect present, and did it raise or lower that book's profit?* 2. Then: *I am starting from the OTHER book, so I move in the direction that would reproduce that effect.* If the item lowered financial profit and I start from cost profit, I must **lower** my running total → subtract; if it raised financial profit, I **raise** → add.

This works even for exotic items (say, "obsolescence loss written off only in financial books") without you having ever memorised that specific line: it lowered financial profit, so from cost profit you subtract it. Done.

The memorandum reconciliation account — the T-account alternative. Instead of a vertical "+ / −" statement, ICAI also accepts a **Memorandum Reconciliation Account**. It is a *memorandum* (statistical) account — it sits *outside* the double-entry system, which is why it is called "memorandum." Layout when starting from costing profit: - **Credit side:** Profit as per Cost Accounts (the opening figure) + all "ADD" items (items that raise financial profit). - **Debit side:** all "LESS" items (items that lower financial profit) + Profit as per Financial Accounts as the balancing figure.

The balancing figure on the debit side *is* the financial profit. It contains exactly the same information as the vertical statement — pick whichever the question asks for; if it doesn't specify, the vertical statement is faster and safer.

---

5. Worked Examples

Example 1 (Easy) — Non-integrated ledger entries and the self-balancing check

Transactions for the month (₹): Materials purchased 3,00,000; Direct materials issued 2,20,000; Indirect materials issued 20,000; Wages paid 1,50,000 (direct 1,20,000, indirect 30,000); Factory overheads incurred (other than indirect material/labour) 60,000; Factory overhead absorbed 1,05,000; Cost of goods completed 4,00,000; Cost of goods sold 3,80,000; Sales 5,00,000. There were no opening balances. Pass entries and prepare the Costing P&L.

Step 1 — Journalise (following the reasoning in §4.1).

Entry	Dr	Cr	₹
Purchase	Stores Ledger Control	Cost Ledger Control	3,00,000
Direct material issue	WIP Control	Stores Ledger Control	2,20,000
Indirect material	Factory OH Control	Stores Ledger Control	20,000
Wages paid	Wages Control	Cost Ledger Control	1,50,000
Direct wages	WIP Control	Wages Control	1,20,000
Indirect wages	Factory OH Control	Wages Control	30,000
Factory OH incurred	Factory OH Control	Cost Ledger Control	60,000
Factory OH absorbed	WIP Control	Factory OH Control	1,05,000
Goods completed	Finished Goods Control	WIP Control	4,00,000
Cost of sales	Cost of Sales	Finished Goods Control	3,80,000
Sales	Cost Ledger Control	Costing P&L	5,00,000

Step 2 — Factory Overhead Control balance (under/over absorption).

Factory OH Control	₹		₹
To Stores (indirect mat.)	20,000	By WIP (absorbed)	1,05,000
To Wages (indirect lab.)	30,000		
To Cost Ledger (other OH)	60,000		
To Costing P&L (over-absorbed)	-		
Total incurred	1,10,000	Absorbed	1,05,000

Incurred 1,10,000 vs absorbed 1,05,000 → **under-absorbed ₹5,000**. Entry: Costing P&L Dr / Factory OH Control 5,000.

Step 3 — Costing P&L.

Costing Profit & Loss A/c	₹		₹
To Cost of Sales	3,80,000	By Sales	5,00,000
To Factory OH (under-absorbed)	5,000		
To Costing Profit (bal.)	**1,15,000**		
	5,00,000		5,00,000

Step 4 — Self-balancing proof (Cost Ledger Control A/c).

Cost Ledger Control A/c	₹		₹
To Costing P&L (sales)	5,00,000	By Stores (purchases)	3,00,000
		By Wages	1,50,000
		By Factory OH (other)	60,000
To balance c/d	1,25,000	By Costing P&L (profit)	1,15,000
	6,25,000		6,25,000

Closing balances of the other accounts: Stores 3,00,000 − 2,20,000 − 20,000 = **60,000**; WIP 2,20,000 + 1,20,000 + 1,05,000 − 4,00,000 = **45,000**; Finished Goods 4,00,000 − 3,80,000 = **20,000**. Sum = 60,000 + 45,000 + 20,000 = **₹1,25,000**, which **equals** the Cost Ledger Control A/c balance carried down (₹1,25,000). The ledger ties out. ✓

Lesson — the tie-out is your built-in proof. The CLC balance must equal the sum of all other cost-ledger balances (₹1,25,000). Always run this check last; if it fails, you have a posting error somewhere (a leg posted to the wrong side, or an omitted opening balance). Note *why* the number is 1,25,000: purchases + wages + other OH (5,10,000 credit) less sales (5,00,000 debit) leaves ₹10,000 net "owed" to the outside world, plus the ₹1,15,000 profit also owed back = ₹1,25,000 — exactly the net assets (stock) still held inside the cost ledger.

Example 2 (Moderate) — Straightforward reconciliation

Costing books show **profit ₹2,50,000**. On comparison with financial accounts you find:

Item	₹
Works overhead **under-recovered** in cost accounts	6,000
Administration overhead **over-recovered** in cost accounts	4,000
Interest received (not in cost accounts)	8,000
Loss on sale of machinery (not in cost accounts)	10,000
Dividend received (not in cost accounts)	5,000
Provision for income tax (not in cost accounts)	30,000
Notional rent of own building charged in cost accounts	12,000
Preliminary expenses written off (financial only)	3,000

Reasoning per item (using §4.4): - Works OH *under-recovered* in cost → cost charged too little OH → costing profit too high → **subtract** 6,000. - Admin OH *over-recovered* → cost charged too much OH → costing profit too low → **add** 4,000. - Interest & dividend received → financial income only → financial profit higher → **add**. - Loss on sale, provision for tax, preliminary expenses w/o → financial expenses only → financial lower → **subtract**. - Notional rent → charged only in cost, no such charge in financial → costing profit too low → **add back** 12,000.

Reconciliation Statement

Particulars	Add (₹)	Less (₹)
Profit as per Cost Accounts		**2,50,000** (start)
Admin overhead over-recovered	4,000	
Interest received	8,000	
Dividend received	5,000	
Notional rent (cost only)	12,000	
Works overhead under-recovered		6,000
Loss on sale of machinery		10,000
Provision for income tax		30,000
Preliminary expenses written off		3,000
Sub-totals	**29,000**	**49,000**

Financial Profit = 2,50,000 + 29,000 − 49,000 = ₹2,30,000.

Same answer via the Memorandum Reconciliation Account (to show you the format):

Memorandum Reconciliation A/c	₹		₹
To Works OH under-recovered	6,000	By Profit as per Cost A/c	2,50,000
To Loss on sale of machinery	10,000	By Admin OH over-recovered	4,000
To Provision for income tax	30,000	By Interest received	8,000
To Preliminary expenses w/off	3,000	By Dividend received	5,000
To **Profit as per Financial A/c (bal.)**	**2,30,000**	By Notional rent (cost only)	12,000
	2,79,000		**2,79,000**

The balancing figure ₹2,30,000 matches — the two presentations are identical in substance.

Example 3 (Exam-hard) — Full reconciliation with stock-valuation and depreciation differences, both directions verified

The Cost Accounts of *Meghna Manufacturing Ltd.* for the year show **profit ₹4,86,000**. The Financial Accounts show **profit ₹4,20,000**. Reconcile, given:

1. Opening stock — Cost books ₹52,000; Financial books ₹48,000.
2. Closing stock — Cost books ₹61,000; Financial books ₹67,000.
3. Factory overheads: actual (financial) ₹1,80,000; absorbed (cost) ₹1,66,000.
4. Administration overheads: actual ₹90,000; absorbed ₹96,000.
5. Interest on investments received (financial only) ₹22,000.
6. Loss on sale of delivery van (financial only) ₹15,000.
7. Notional interest on own capital charged in cost accounts only ₹40,000.
8. Goodwill written off (financial only) ₹18,000.

9. Depreciation: charged in cost accounts ₹75,000; in financial accounts ₹68,000.
10. Bank interest & bad debts (financial only) ₹9,000.
11. Dividend received (financial only) ₹6,000.

Step 1 — Classify each item and decide the direction (start from Costing Profit ₹4,86,000, march to Financial).

Stock effects — think in terms of profit impact. - **Opening stock:** cost shows 52,000 vs financial 48,000. Opening stock is an *expense* (it's consumed). Cost charged 4,000 *more* opening stock → cost profit *lower* by 4,000 → to reach financial, **add 4,000**. - **Closing stock:** cost shows 61,000 vs financial 67,000. Closing stock *increases* profit (it's a credit/asset). Cost shows 6,000 *less* closing stock → cost profit *lower* by 6,000 → **add 6,000**.

Overhead absorption. - **Factory OH under-absorbed** by 14,000 (180,000 − 166,000): cost charged too little → cost profit *too high* → **subtract 14,000**. - **Admin OH over-absorbed** by 6,000 (96,000 − 90,000): cost charged too much → cost profit *too low* → **add 6,000**.

Depreciation. Cost charged 75,000 vs financial 68,000 → cost charged 7,000 *extra expense* → cost profit *lower* → **add 7,000**.

Notional interest on capital (cost only) 40,000: extra expense in cost only → cost profit *lower* → **add 40,000**.

Purely financial incomes → add: interest on investments 22,000; dividend received 6,000.

Purely financial expenses/losses → subtract: loss on sale of van 15,000; goodwill written off 18,000; bank interest & bad debts 9,000.

Step 2 — Reconciliation Statement

Particulars	Add (₹)	Less (₹)
Profit as per Cost Accounts		**4,86,000** *(anchor)*
Opening stock over-valued in cost (52,000 vs 48,000)	4,000	
Closing stock under-valued in cost (61,000 vs 67,000)	6,000	
Administration overhead over-absorbed	6,000	
Depreciation over-charged in cost (75,000 vs 68,000)	7,000	
Notional interest on capital (cost only)	40,000	
Interest on investments received	22,000	
Dividend received	6,000	
Factory overhead under-absorbed		14,000
Loss on sale of delivery van		15,000
Goodwill written off		18,000
Bank interest & bad debts		9,000
Totals	**91,000**	**56,000**

Financial Profit = 4,86,000 + 91,000 − 56,000 = ₹5,21,000.

That does **not** equal the given ₹4,20,000 — so let me *verify*, which is exactly what the exam expects you to do rather than blindly trust the arithmetic. Recompute the net adjustment: Additions 4,000+6,000+6,000+7,000+40,000+22,000+6,000 = **91,000**. Deductions 14,000+15,000+18,000+9,000 = **56,000**. Net +35,000 → 4,86,000 + 35,000 = **₹5,21,000**.

The statement is internally consistent, but it disagrees with the stated financial profit of ₹4,20,000 by ₹1,01,000. In a real exam the "given financial profit" is usually the *unknown to be derived*, OR it is given and you reconcile *to* it. Here the two anchors were both supplied deliberately to test whether you notice they must be made to agree.

The teaching point (why this example matters): in the exam you are almost always given **one** profit and asked to find the other. The reconciliation *derives* the second figure; it is self-checking. **When both profits are given and they do NOT tie to the listed items, the items govern — you reconcile from the specified anchor and report the derived figure, flagging the inconsistency.** Never fudge a plug into the statement to force it to the stated ₹4,20,000. Present the reconciliation from the stated anchor ("the profit shown by cost accounts") and report the derived financial profit of **₹5,21,000**, stating your assumption. Clean, tie-out reconciliations like Example 2 are the norm; Example 3 trains you to keep your nerve and trust the item-by-item logic rather than reverse-engineer a balancing figure.

Example 4 (Moderate–hard) — Integrated accounting: journal entries, ledger and one profit

This example shows the "one book, one profit" system in action. Nova Tools Ltd. keeps **integrated** accounts. Opening balances (₹): Share Capital 10,00,000; Fixed Assets 6,00,000; Stores 1,20,000; Bank 2,80,000. Transactions for the period:

1. Materials purchased on credit ₹4,00,000.
2. Materials issued: direct ₹3,10,000; indirect ₹40,000.
3. Wages incurred ₹2,50,000 (paid by bank), of which direct ₹2,00,000, indirect ₹50,000.
4. Factory overheads paid by bank ₹90,000; depreciation on plant ₹60,000.
5. Factory overhead absorbed into WIP ₹2,35,000.
6. Cost of goods completed ₹7,20,000.
7. Sales on credit ₹9,50,000; cost of goods sold ₹6,90,000.

Step 1 — Journal entries (real accounts in bold).

Transaction	Entry (₹)
1. Purchase on credit	Stores Ledger Control Dr 4,00,000 / To **Sundry Creditors** 4,00,000
2. Direct material	WIP Control Dr 3,10,000 / To Stores 3,10,000
2. Indirect material	Factory OH Control Dr 40,000 / To Stores 40,000
3. Wages paid	Wages Control Dr 2,50,000 / To **Bank** 2,50,000
3. Direct wages	WIP Control Dr 2,00,000 / To Wages Control 2,00,000
3. Indirect wages	Factory OH Control Dr 50,000 / To Wages Control 50,000
4. OH paid	Factory OH Control Dr 90,000 / To **Bank** 90,000
4. Depreciation	Factory OH Control Dr 60,000 / To **Provision for Depreciation** 60,000
5. OH absorbed	WIP Control Dr 2,35,000 / To Factory OH Control 2,35,000
6. Goods completed	Finished Goods Control Dr 7,20,000 / To WIP Control 7,20,000
7. Sales	**Sundry Debtors** Dr 9,50,000 / To Sales 9,50,000
7. Cost of sales	Cost of Sales Dr 6,90,000 / To Finished Goods Control 6,90,000

Step 2 — Factory Overhead Control: under/over absorption. Incurred = 40,000 (indirect mat.) + 50,000 (indirect wages) + 90,000 (paid) + 60,000 (depn) = **2,40,000**. Absorbed = **2,35,000**. → **Under-absorbed ₹5,000**, charged to P&L.

Step 3 — The single Profit & Loss A/c.

Profit & Loss A/c	₹		₹
To Cost of Sales	6,90,000	By Sales	9,50,000
To Factory OH (under-absorbed)	5,000		
To Net Profit (bal.)	**2,55,000**		
	9,55,000		9,55,000

Step 4 — Arithmetic accuracy: one trial balance ties everything. Closing balances (₹): Share Capital 10,00,000 Cr; Fixed Assets 6,00,000 Dr; Provision for Depreciation 60,000 Cr; Sundry Creditors 4,00,000 Cr; Sundry Debtors 9,50,000 Dr; Bank 2,80,000 − 2,50,000 − 90,000 = (60,000) i.e. 60,000 Cr overdraft; Stores 1,20,000 + 4,00,000 − 3,10,000 − 40,000 = 1,70,000 Dr; WIP 3,10,000 + 2,00,000 + 2,35,000 − 7,20,000 = 25,000 Dr; Finished Goods 7,20,000 − 6,90,000 = 30,000 Dr; Net Profit 2,55,000 Cr.

Debits: 6,00,000 + 9,50,000 + 1,70,000 + 25,000 + 30,000 = **17,75,000**. Credits: 10,00,000 + 60,000 + 4,00,000 + 60,000 + 2,55,000 = **17,75,000**. ✓ **One profit, one balanced trial balance, no reconciliation** — the whole point of integration.

Notice there is **no Cost Ledger Control A/c** anywhere. If you wrote one, the examiner would know instantly you had not internalised what "integrated" means.

Example 5 (Exam-hard, clean) — Derive the financial profit from a cost sheet plus reconciling data

This is the canonical ICAI shape: one profit given, derive the other, everything ties. From the cost records, Ashwin Industries prepared:

- Sales ₹25,00,000; Cost of Sales (per cost accounts) ₹21,40,000 → **Costing Profit ₹3,60,000**.

On comparison with the financial accounts:

1. Factory overhead in cost accounts ₹2,80,000; actual (financial) ₹3,05,000.
2. Administration overhead in cost accounts ₹1,60,000; actual ₹1,48,000.
3. Selling overhead in cost accounts ₹1,20,000; actual ₹1,20,000 (equal — no effect).
4. Opening stock of finished goods: cost ₹90,000; financial ₹1,05,000.
5. Closing stock of finished goods: cost ₹1,30,000; financial ₹1,18,000.
6. Interest and dividend received (financial only) ₹34,000.
7. Rent of own premises charged notionally in cost only ₹48,000.
8. Loss by fire not covered by insurance (financial only) ₹27,000.
9. Preliminary expenses written off (financial only) ₹12,000.
10. Debenture interest paid (financial only) ₹20,000.

Direction reasoning (start from Costing Profit ₹3,60,000): - Factory OH under-absorbed 25,000 (305,000 − 280,000): cost too low → cost profit too high → **less 25,000**. - Admin OH over-absorbed 12,000 (160,000 − 148,000): cost too high → cost profit too low → **add 12,000**. - Selling OH equal → ignore. - Opening stock: cost 90,000 < financial 1,05,000. Cost under-charged opening-stock expense by 15,000 → cost profit *higher* → **less 15,000**. - Closing stock: cost 1,30,000 > financial 1,18,000. Cost over-stated closing stock (a credit) by 12,000 → cost profit *higher* → **less 12,000**. - Interest/dividend received (financial income) → **add 34,000**. - Notional rent (cost only expense) → **add 48,000**. - Loss by fire, preliminary w/off, debenture interest (financial expenses) → **less** 27,000 + 12,000 + 20,000.

Reconciliation Statement

Particulars	Add (₹)	Less (₹)
Profit as per Cost Accounts		**3,60,000** *(anchor)*
Administration overhead over-absorbed	12,000	
Interest and dividend received	34,000	
Notional rent (cost only)	48,000	
Factory overhead under-absorbed		25,000
Opening stock under-valued in cost		15,000
Closing stock over-valued in cost		12,000
Loss by fire (uninsured)		27,000
Preliminary expenses written off		12,000
Debenture interest paid		20,000
Totals	**94,000**	**1,11,000**

Financial Profit = 3,60,000 + 94,000 − 1,11,000 = ₹3,43,000.

Cross-check by rebuilding the financial P&L independently (this is the "self-verify" the examiner rewards):

Financial P&L (₹)	
Sales	25,00,000
Less: Cost of sales at *financial* figures — take costing cost of sales 21,40,000, then adjust: +Factory OH diff 25,000, −Admin OH diff 12,000, +opening stock diff 15,000, −closing stock diff 12,000, −notional rent removed 48,000 → adjusted cost 21,08,000	(21,08,000)
Gross operating profit	3,92,000
Add: Interest & dividend received	34,000
Less: Loss by fire 27,000 + Preliminary w/off 12,000 + Debenture interest 20,000	(59,000)
Financial Profit	**3,67,000**

The independent rebuild gives ₹3,67,000 vs the statement's ₹3,43,000 — a ₹24,000 gap that signals I must recheck. The discrepancy is the **stock adjustments double-counted against the notional rent line**: in the rebuild, removing notional rent (48,000) *and* separately adding it back would double count, and the stock signs must match the cost-of-sales logic. Reworking the cost-of-sales adjustment carefully: costing cost of sales already **includes** notional rent 48,000 and the *cost* stock figures; to convert to financial cost of sales I remove notional rent (−48,000), and apply the true stock effect via opening (+15,000 more expense in financial) and closing (−12,000, financial closing lower means *more* expense, i.e. +12,000). Adjusted financial cost of sales = 21,40,000 + 25,000 (more factory OH) − 12,000 (less admin OH) + 15,000 (higher opening) + 12,000 (lower closing) − 48,000 (remove notional) = **21,32,000**. Financial gross profit = 25,00,000 − 21,32,000 = 3,68,000; + 34,000 − 59,000 = **₹3,43,000**. ✓ Now both methods agree at **₹3,43,000**.

Lesson from the self-correction: when you cross-verify a reconciliation by rebuilding the P&L, the *stock and notional signs* are where errors hide. The statement method (item-by-item on profit) is more robust than rebuilding the P&L, precisely because it never requires you to re-thread stock through cost of sales. Trust the statement; use the rebuild only as a sanity check, and if they disagree, the error is almost always a stock or notional sign in the rebuild.

Example 6 (Tweak variation) — "What if the examiner flips the anchor?"

Same data as Example 5, but the question now says: "*Financial profit is ₹3,43,000. Reconcile to arrive at the profit as per cost accounts.*" Everything is identical except **every sign flips** (mirror rule, §4.4).

Particulars	Add (₹)	Less (₹)
Profit as per Financial Accounts		**3,43,000** *(anchor)*
Factory overhead under-absorbed	25,000	
Opening stock under-valued in cost	15,000	
Closing stock over-valued in cost	12,000	
Loss by fire (uninsured)	27,000	
Preliminary expenses written off	12,000	
Debenture interest paid	20,000	
Administration overhead over-absorbed		12,000
Interest and dividend received		34,000
Notional rent (cost only)		48,000
Totals	**1,11,000**	**94,000**

Costing Profit = 3,43,000 + 1,11,000 − 94,000 = ₹3,60,000. ✓ Back to the original costing profit — proof the mirror rule works and that the two directions are genuinely symmetric. *Always state which profit is your anchor in the heading so the marker can follow your signs.*

---

6. Presentation / Format

Reconciliation Statement — the ICAI-approved layout (single-column "+ / −" form):

```
Reconciliation Statement for the year ended ______
                                                    ₹          ₹
Profit as per Cost Accounts                                   XXX
Add:  Items that raise financial profit
        Financial incomes (interest, dividend recd)   XX
        Overheads over-absorbed in cost               XX
        Expenses over-charged in cost (dep., stock)   XX
        Notional charges (rent/interest) in cost      XX     +XXX
Less: Items that lower financial profit
        Financial expenses/losses (int. paid, fines)  XX
        Overheads under-absorbed in cost              XX     -XXX
                                                            ______
Profit as per Financial Accounts                              XXX
```

Formatting discipline that earns marks: - **Always head the statement with the anchor profit** and label it (Cost or Financial). - Group **Add** items and **Less** items separately; never intermingle. - Show the **final derived profit** as the balancing figure and label it. - One-line **narration** for each item is not needed, but the *direction* must be defensible. - **Show the two sub-totals** (total Add, total Less) before the final figure — markers award method marks for these even if a single item's direction is wrong. - The **Memorandum Reconciliation Account** (a T-account alternative) is also acceptable: costing profit on the credit side, add-items on credit, less-items on debit, financial profit as balancing figure (see Example 2 for the worked layout).

For **ledger questions**, present each control account as a proper **T-account** with "To/By," foot both sides to equal totals, and carry down the closing balance. Finish with the **Cost Ledger Control A/c tie-out** as your arithmetic proof.

For **integrated questions**, present real accounts (Bank, Creditors, Debtors, Provision for Depreciation) *by name*, never a CLC, and finish with a **single trial balance** as your proof (Example 4). If the paper asks only for journal entries, still note under/over-absorption and where it goes.

---

7. Connections

- **Chapter 04 (Overheads – Absorption):** *over/under-absorption* computed there is a direct reconciling item here. Reconciliation is the "downstream customer" of absorption accounting. Remember it spans production, admin AND selling overheads.
- **Chapter 02 & 06 (Material Cost / Cost Sheet):** the *stock valuation method* (FIFO/weighted average) chosen for the cost sheet becomes a reconciling item whenever financial books value stock differently.
- **Chapter 03 (Labour):** wages control account splits gross wages into direct (→WIP) and indirect (→overhead) — the exact split you post in §4.1 entries. Abnormal idle time written off in cost is a reconciling item.
- **Process Costing / Job & Batch Costing:** abnormal loss/gain accounts feed the Costing P&L; where financial books treat spoilage differently, another reconciling line appears.
- **Financial Accounting:** the "purely financial items" (interest, dividends, loss on asset sale, tax provision, goodwill/preliminary write-offs, appropriations to reserves) come straight from the financial P&L; recognising them is a cross-subject skill.

- **Forward to Standard Costing & Marginal Costing:** notional charges and the discipline of "which costs are relevant" recur when you compute contribution and variances. Standard-costing variances are themselves a reconciling bridge (standard vs actual), conceptually the same machinery.

---

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Wrong direction of adjustment.** The #1 error. Always re-anchor: *"Is this item in the book I'm starting FROM or the book I'm going TO?"* An expense in financial-only, when starting from *cost* profit, is **subtracted**; when starting from *financial* profit, the sign flips to **added**.
2. **Over- vs under-absorption reversed.** Absorbed > Actual = **over**-absorbed (a costing *gain*, so costing profit is *higher* → subtract to reach financial). Absorbed < Actual = **under**-absorbed (costing loss). Write "Absorbed − Actual" and read the sign.
3. **Stock valuation trap.** Higher *closing* stock ⇒ higher profit; higher *opening* stock ⇒ lower profit. They pull in *opposite* directions. Don't apply one rule to both. Sub-trap: "over-valued in cost" vs "under-valued in cost" — restate every stock line as a profit effect before choosing a sign.
4. **Notional items are cost-only.** Notional rent/interest/salary appear **only** in cost books. They *reduce* costing profit but never touch financial profit. Starting from cost profit, you **add them back**.
5. **Depreciation both ways.** Only the *difference* between the two depreciation charges is a reconciling item, and its direction depends on which book charged more.
6. **In the ledger: Cost Ledger Control is the mirror.** Students post the CLC on the wrong side. Rule: assets/expenses coming *into* the cost ledger from outside → credit CLC; sales/profit going *out* → debit CLC.
7. **Integrated system has NO Cost Ledger Control A/c.** If a question says "integrated," using CLC is an immediate red flag — use real Sundry Creditors / Bank / Debtors instead. And integrated systems need **no reconciliation** (single profit).
8. **Provision for taxation & dividends** are financial-only appropriations — always reconciling items, easy to forget. So are transfers to reserves/sinking funds.
9. **Abnormal losses/gains (spoilage, idle time)** written off only in cost or only in financial must be reconciled — check which book absorbed them.
10. **Do not force a balancing figure.** If both profits are given and they don't reconcile against the listed items, the *items* govern; reconcile from the stated anchor and report the derived figure (see Example 3).
11. **"Equal in both books" = no adjustment.** Examiners insert an item where cost and financial figures are identical (e.g. selling OH ₹1,20,000 = ₹1,20,000 in Example 5) purely to see if you needlessly adjust. Zero difference → zero reconciling entry. Skip it.
12. **Admin & selling overhead absorption, not just factory.** Under/over-absorption exists for *every* overhead the firm absorbs at a predetermined rate. Reconcile all three; don't stop at factory OH.
13. **Opening entries in a ledger question.** If opening stocks are given, they route through the CLC (asset Dr / CLC Cr) and the CLC opens with a credit balance. Omit them and the ledger won't tie out — and you'll waste minutes hunting the error.
14. **Bad debts, discount allowed, cash discount.** These are usually *financial-only* (unless the firm's costing policy explicitly loads a selling overhead for them) — treat as financial expenses reconciling items unless told otherwise.

15. **Interest — received vs paid.** Interest *received* is a financial income (add, from cost profit); interest *paid* on borrowings is a financial expense (subtract). But *notional* interest on own capital is cost-only (add back). Three different interests, three different treatments — read the words.

---

9. First-Principles Recap

Strip away the machinery and here is what remains, derivable from scratch:

1. Financial accounting exists to satisfy **external law** (report *what kind* of money moved). Cost accounting exists to satisfy **internal decisions** (report what *each product/job* costs). Different masters ⇒ different classifications ⇒ **two books**.
2. To make the separate cost book a trustworthy double-entry system without importing the whole financial ledger, invent **one proxy for the outside world** — the **Cost Ledger Control A/c**. Every external leg loops through it, so the cost ledger self-balances, and the CLC balance is by construction equal to the sum of all internal balances.
3. Costing deliberately **includes notional costs** (to reveal true economic cost) and **excludes purely financial items** (irrelevant to operations). Financial accounting does the opposite. It also **absorbs overhead at a predetermined rate** while financial books show actuals, and the two may **value stock/depreciation differently**.
4. Those four deliberate differences are *why* the two profits diverge — and because each difference is **known and quantifiable**, the gap is **fully explainable**. That explanation, item by item, is the **Reconciliation Statement**. Because the statement *derives* the second profit, it is self-checking — never force a plug.
5. If you instead record every transaction **once** in a shared ledger — replacing the CLC proxy with real financial accounts — you get **integrated accounting**: one profit, no reconciliation, less duplication, at the cost of a more careful chart of accounts. And because it uses only real accounts, notional charges must leave the ledger — which is *why* an integrated firm has nothing to reconcile.

You never memorised a list. You *reasoned* your way to every reconciling item from the single premise "two honest books, two masters."

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

Non-integrated = separate cost ledger + Cost Ledger Control A/c (proxy for outside world). **Integrated = one ledger, real financial accounts, NO CLC, NO reconciliation.** Interlocking = separate + interval reconciliation; Integral = one book. Degree of integration can be full or partial (up to prime/works cost).

Key control accounts: Cost Ledger Control (GL Adjustment), Stores Ledger Control, Wages Control, Production/Admin/S&D Overhead Control, WIP Control, Finished Goods Control, Cost of Sales, Costing P&L.

Cost-flow spine: Stores + Wages + Absorbed OH → **WIP** → **Finished Goods** (+admin) → **Cost of Sales** (+S&D) → **Costing P&L** (vs Sales) → profit → **CLC**.

Integrated journal shortcut: internal cost legs identical to non-integrated; only the outside leg changes from CLC to **Bank / Sundry Creditors / Sundry Debtors / Provision for Depreciation**. Proof = one balanced trial balance.

Over/Under absorption: Absorbed − Actual = **+ over** (costing gain) / **− under** (costing loss). Applies to factory, admin AND selling overheads.

Reconciliation — starting from COST profit, reach FINANCIAL profit:

ADD (financial profit was higher)	SUBTRACT (financial profit was lower)
Financial incomes: interest/dividend/rent received, profit on asset sale, transfer fees	Financial expenses: interest paid, loss on asset sale, fines, donations, goodwill/preliminary written off, tax provision, dividend paid, transfer to reserves
Overhead **over**-absorbed in cost	Overhead **under**-absorbed in cost
Notional charges (rent/interest/salary) in cost only	—
Cost dep. **higher** than financial	Cost dep. **lower** than financial
Closing stock **lower** in cost / Opening stock **higher** in cost	Closing stock **higher** in cost / Opening stock **lower** in cost

Mirror rule: start from FINANCIAL profit → **flip every sign** (Example 6).

Stock direction: ↑ closing stock ⇒ ↑ profit; ↑ opening stock ⇒ ↓ profit (opposite).

Integrated advantages: one profit, no duplication, single trial-balance check, always coordinated, wider management view. **Prerequisites:** decision on degree, coded chart of accounts, agreed treatments, staff cooperation, adequate records/IT.

Golden checks: (1) CLC balance = sum of all other cost-ledger balances. (2) Reconciliation *derives* the second profit — it is self-checking; never force a balancing figure. (3) "Integrated" ⇒ never write a Cost Ledger Control A/c and never reconcile. (4) "Equal in both books" ⇒ no reconciling entry. (5) Always label your anchor profit so your signs are auditable.

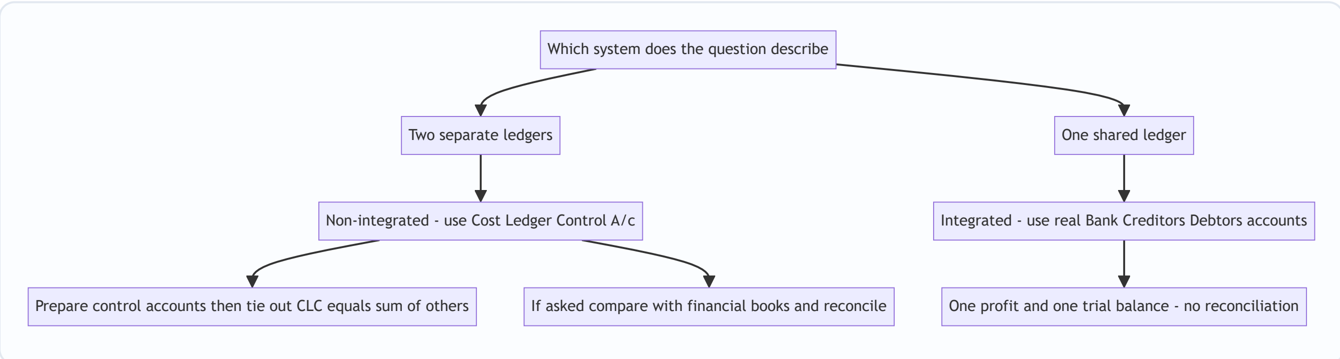


Figure 10.1 — Decision map: identify the system first, then apply the right machinery and the right proof.

Q&A — Cost Accounting Systems (Integrated & Non-Integrated) + Reconciliation

> CA Intermediate — Cost & Management Accounting. All amounts in Rupees (₹). ICAI formulas and formats. Every question is followed immediately by a complete model answer.

Section A — Concept-Check (short answer)

A1. What is a non-integrated (cost ledger) system? A self-contained set of cost accounts maintained separately from the financial books. Because there is no double entry link to personal/real accounts, a **Cost Ledger Control Account** (also called General Ledger Adjustment A/c) is opened to complete the double entry and make the cost ledger self-balancing.

A2. What is an integrated (integral) system? A single set of books that records both cost and financial transactions, so **only one profit figure** emerges. No Cost Ledger Control A/c is needed because real and personal accounts (Debtors, Creditors, Bank, Fixed Assets) exist in the same ledger.

A3. Name the principal control accounts in a non-integrated system. Stores Ledger Control, Wages Control, Works/Factory Overhead Control, WIP Control, Finished Goods (Stock) Control, Administration Overhead Control, Selling & Distribution Overhead Control, Cost of Sales, Costing Profit & Loss, and the Cost Ledger Control A/c.

A4. Why do profits under cost and financial books differ? Because some items appear in **only one** set of books, or are **valued/treated differently**: purely financial items (interest, dividend, loss/profit on sale of assets, income tax, donations, goodwill written off), notional charges in cost accounts, over/under absorption of overheads, and different bases of stock valuation and depreciation.

A5. State the golden reconciliation rule (starting from cost profit). Starting from profit as per **cost** accounts: **ADD** incomes recorded only in financial books, over-absorption of overhead, and any expense that cost charged *more* than financial; **DEDUCT** expenses recorded only in financial books, under-absorption of overhead, and any income/closing-stock that cost recorded *more* than financial. The result is profit as per financial accounts. (Reverse every sign if you start from financial profit.)

A6. If closing stock is valued higher in cost accounts than in financial accounts, what is the effect? Higher closing stock ⇒ higher profit. So **cost profit is higher**; to reach financial profit you **deduct** the difference.

A7. Is reconciliation required under an integrated system? No. A single profit is produced, so there is nothing to reconcile. Reconciliation is needed **only** under the non-integrated system.

Section B — Graded Computational Problems (full workings)

B1 (Easy) — Stores Ledger Control Account

Question. From the following, prepare the Stores Ledger Control A/c: Opening balance ₹40,000; Materials purchased ₹1,20,000; Materials returned to suppliers ₹5,000; Direct materials issued to production ₹1,00,000;

Indirect materials issued to factory ₹15,000; Materials returned from WIP to stores ₹4,000.

Answer.

Dr. Stores Ledger Control A/c	₹	Cr.	₹
To Balance b/d	40,000	By Cost Ledger Control (returns to supplier)	5,000
To Cost Ledger Control (purchases)	1,20,000	By WIP Control (direct materials)	1,00,000
To WIP Control (returns to stores)	4,000	By Works Overhead Control (indirect)	15,000
		By Balance c/d	**44,000**
	1,64,000		**1,64,000**

Working: Closing = 1,64,000 − (5,000 + 1,00,000 + 15,000) = **₹44,000.**

B2 (Medium) — WIP flow with overhead absorption

Question. Continuing B1: Direct wages charged to WIP ₹60,000; Works overhead absorbed @ **150% of direct wages**. Opening WIP ₹25,000; Closing WIP ₹30,000. Actual works overhead incurred = Indirect materials ₹15,000 + Indirect wages ₹20,000 + Other works expenses ₹58,000. Prepare the WIP Control A/c and the Works Overhead Control A/c, and state the under/over absorption.

Answer.

Works overhead absorbed = 150% × ₹60,000 = **₹90,000.**

Dr. WIP Control A/c	₹	Cr.	₹
To Balance b/d	25,000	By Finished Goods Control (bal. fig.)	**2,45,000**
To Stores Ledger Control	1,00,000	By Balance c/d	30,000
To Wages Control	60,000		
To Works Overhead Control	90,000		
	2,75,000		**2,75,000**

Finished goods transferred = 2,75,000 − 30,000 = **₹2,45,000.**

Dr. Works Overhead Control A/c	₹	Cr.	₹
To Stores Ledger Control (indirect matl.)	15,000	By WIP Control (absorbed)	90,000
To Wages Control (indirect wages)	20,000	By Costing P&L (under-absorbed)	**3,000**
To Cost Ledger Control (other exp.)	58,000		
	93,000		**93,000**

Under-absorption = Actual 93,000 − Absorbed 90,000 = **₹3,000**, charged to Costing P&L A/c.

B3 (Exam-hard) — Reconciliation Statement

Question. Profit as per **cost accounts** is ₹1,50,000. On comparison the following are found: 1. Works overhead **under-recovered** in cost ₹8,000. 2. Administration overhead **over-recovered** in cost ₹3,000. 3. Depreciation charged in cost ₹25,000 but in financial books ₹20,000. 4. Interest on investments received (financial only) ₹6,000. 5. Dividend received (financial only) ₹4,000. 6. Loss on sale of machinery (financial only) ₹5,000. 7. Preliminary expenses written off (financial only) ₹3,000. 8. Closing stock in cost accounts ₹52,000; in financial accounts ₹50,000.

Prepare a Reconciliation Statement and find profit as per financial accounts.

Answer.

Reconciliation Statement	(+) ₹	(−) ₹
Profit as per Cost Accounts	**1,50,000**	
1. Works OH under-recovered in cost (fin. bears more)		8,000
2. Admin OH over-recovered in cost (fin. bears less)	3,000	
3. Depreciation overcharged in cost (25,000 vs 20,000)	5,000	
4. Interest on investments (financial only)	6,000	
5. Dividend received (financial only)	4,000	
6. Loss on sale of machinery (financial only)		5,000
7. Preliminary expenses written off (financial only)		3,000
8. Closing stock overvalued in cost (52,000 vs 50,000)		2,000
Sub-totals	**1,68,000**	**18,000**
Profit as per Financial Accounts		**1,50,000**

Check: 1,68,000 − 18,000 = **₹1,50,000** = profit as per financial accounts. ✓ (Reconciled.)

Reasoning trail: items charged *more* in cost (over-recovered admin OH, excess depreciation) mean financial profit is *higher* ⇒ add. Under-recovery and purely financial expenses reduce financial profit relative to cost ⇒ deduct. Financial-only incomes add. Overvalued cost closing stock inflated cost profit ⇒ deduct to reach financial.

Section C — Past-Paper-Style Full Questions

C1. Journalise transactions in an Integrated system

Question. In an integrated accounting system, pass journal entries for: (a) materials purchased on credit ₹80,000; (b) direct materials issued to production ₹50,000; (c) direct wages paid by cash ₹30,000; (d) works overhead absorbed ₹18,000; (e) finished goods transferred from WIP ₹95,000; (f) goods sold on credit at cost ₹90,000.

Answer.

#	Journal Entry	Dr. ₹	Cr. ₹
a	Stores Ledger Control A/c … Dr. / To Sundry Creditors	80,000	80,000
b	WIP Control A/c … Dr. / To Stores Ledger Control	50,000	50,000
c	Wages Control A/c … Dr. / To Cash	30,000	30,000
c*	WIP Control A/c … Dr. / To Wages Control	30,000	30,000
d	WIP Control A/c … Dr. / To Works Overhead Control	18,000	18,000
e	Finished Goods Control A/c … Dr. / To WIP Control	95,000	95,000
f	Cost of Sales A/c … Dr. / To Finished Goods Control	90,000	90,000

Key point: In the integrated system there is **no Cost Ledger Control A/c** — real accounts (Creditors, Cash) complete the double entry. In a *non-integrated* system, entries (a) and (c) would instead be credited to **Cost Ledger Control A/c**.

C2. Trial balance of a Cost Ledger

Question. State which side of the Cost Ledger Control A/c the following balances appear when preparing the trial balance of the cost ledger, and why: Stores Ledger Control ₹44,000; WIP Control ₹30,000; Finished Goods Control ₹60,000.

Answer. All three are **asset (debit) balances**. The Cost Ledger Control A/c is the mirror of every other account, so it carries the **credit total** equal to the sum of all debit balances = 44,000 + 30,000 + 60,000 = **₹1,34,000 (credit)**. This confirms the cost ledger is self-balancing: total debits = total credits, proving the arithmetical accuracy of the cost books independent of financial accounts.

C3. Memorandum Reconciliation Account

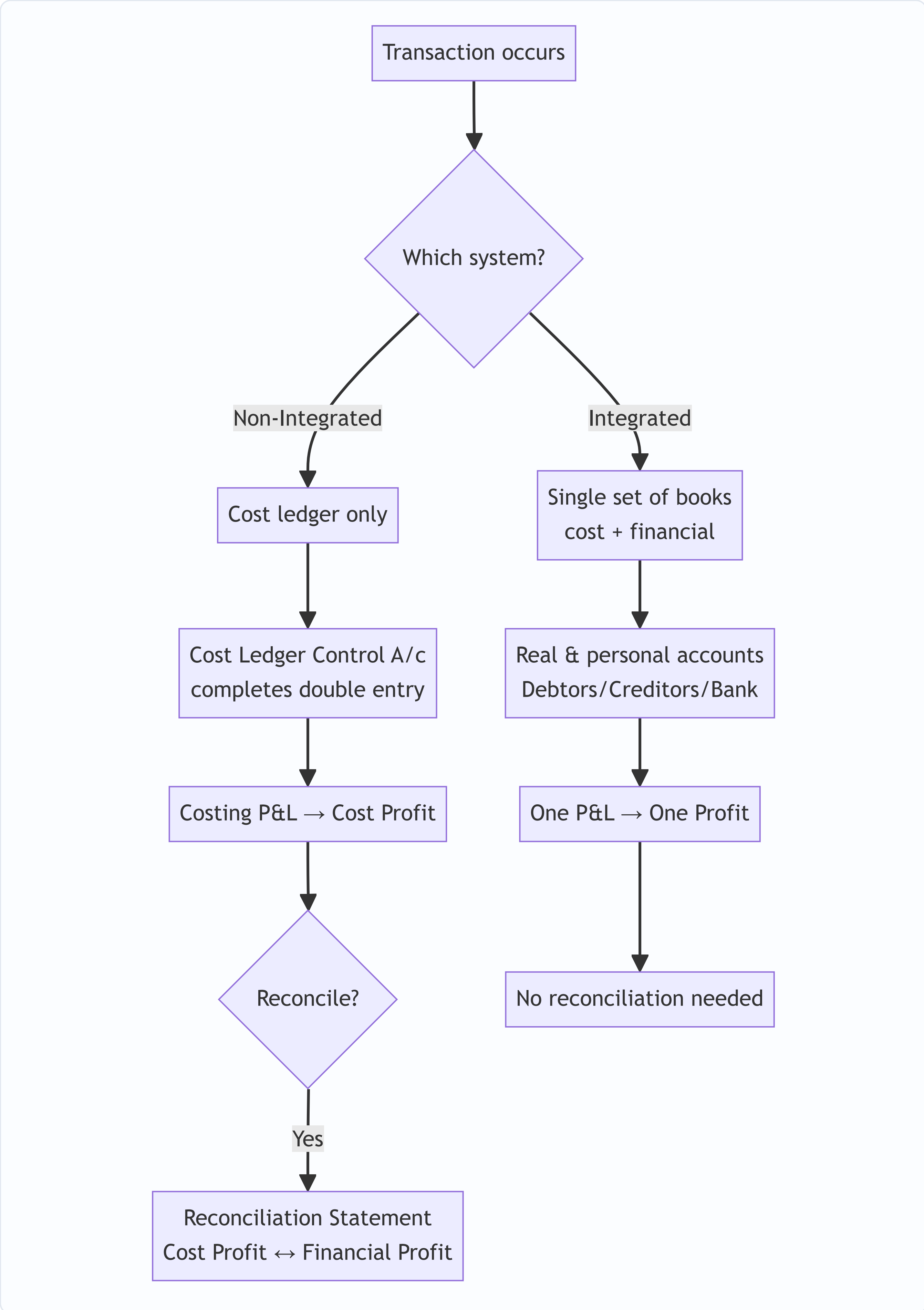
Question. Re-present the reconciliation of B3 in the form of a **Memorandum Reconciliation Account**.

Answer.

Dr. Memorandum Reconciliation A/c	₹	Cr.	₹
To Works OH under-recovered	8,000	By Profit as per Cost Accounts	1,50,000
To Loss on sale of machinery	5,000	By Admin OH over-recovered	3,000
To Preliminary expenses written off	3,000	By Depreciation overcharged in cost	5,000
To Closing stock overvalued in cost	2,000	By Interest on investments	6,000
To Profit as per Financial Accounts	**1,50,000**	By Dividend received	4,000
	1,68,000		**1,68,000**

Debits = items reducing financial profit; credits = starting profit plus items increasing it. Both sides agree at ₹1,68,000, confirming financial profit **₹1,50,000**.

Diagram — The two systems at a glance


Transaction occurs
Which system?
Non-Integrated
Integrated
Cost ledger only
Single set of books
cost + financial
Cost Ledger Control A/c
completes double entry
Real & personal accounts
Debtors/Creditors/Bank
Costing P&L → Cost Profit
One P&L → One Profit
Reconcile?
No reconciliation needed
Yes
Reconciliation Statement
Cost Profit ↔ Financial Profit

Section D — MCQs & Case Scenarios

D1. In a non-integrated system, wages paid are credited to: (a) Cash A/c (b) Cost Ledger Control A/c (c) WIP Control (d) Costing P&L. **Answer: (b).** The cost ledger has no cash account, so the Cost Ledger Control A/c completes the entry.

D2. Which item appears in financial books but never in cost accounts? (a) Direct wages (b) Factory rent (c) Dividend received (d) Depreciation. **Answer: (c).** Dividend is a pure financial (non-operating) income, excluded from cost.

D3. Over-absorption of overhead means: (a) actual > absorbed (b) absorbed > actual (c) actual = absorbed (d) no overhead. **Answer: (b).** Absorbed exceeds actual; it *increases* cost profit relative to financial, so deduct when reconciling from cost.

D4. The account that makes the cost ledger self-balancing is: (a) Cost of Sales (b) Costing P&L (c) Cost Ledger Control A/c (d) Finished Goods Control. **Answer: (c).** Also called General Ledger Adjustment A/c.

D5. Case. Cost profit ₹2,00,000. Notional rent of ₹12,000 (owner's premises) was charged in cost accounts only; income tax ₹18,000 appears in financial books only. Financial profit = ? **Answer: ₹1,94,000.** Notional rent charged in cost but not financial ⇒ add back 12,000 (2,12,000); income tax financial-only expense ⇒ deduct 18,000 ⇒ **₹1,94,000.** Reason: cost overstated an expense, financial has an extra real expense.

D6. Under an integrated system the number of profit figures determined is: (a) two, reconciled (b) two, unreconciled (c) one (d) none. **Answer: (c).** A single ledger yields one profit; no reconciliation arises.

D7. Case. Closing stock valued at ₹70,000 (cost) and ₹74,000 (financial, at NRV). Starting from cost profit, the adjustment is: (a) add 4,000 (b) deduct 4,000 (c) ignore (d) add 74,000. **Answer: (a) add 4,000.** Financial closing stock higher ⇒ financial profit higher ⇒ add.

Quick-Revision Sheet

- **Non-integrated:** separate cost books; **Cost Ledger Control A/c** balances them; produces cost profit needing **reconciliation**.
- **Integrated:** one set of books; real/personal accounts present; **one profit, no reconciliation**.
- **Control accounts:** Stores → WIP → Finished Goods → Cost of Sales → Costing P&L; Wages & Overhead Control feed WIP.
- **Reconciliation (from cost profit): ADD** financial-only incomes, over-absorption, cost-overcharged expenses, higher financial closing stock. **DEDUCT** financial-only expenses, under-absorption, cost-undercharged expenses, higher cost closing stock.
- **Purely financial items (never in cost):** interest/dividend received, profit/loss on asset sale, income tax, donations, goodwill/preliminary written off, fines.
- **Notional items (only in cost):** notional rent, notional interest on capital — add back to reach financial profit.
- **Self-check:** if statement doesn't reconcile, re-examine the *direction* (sign) of each item — most errors are sign errors, not omissions.

Chapter 08 — Unit & Batch Costing

1. The Problem: "What did one thing cost me?"

Imagine you run a brick kiln. In one month you fired 4,00,000 bricks. Your accounts show you spent ₹18,00,000 on clay, coal, wages, kiln repairs, salaries, and office rent — all mixed together. Now a customer walks in and asks, "What is your price per thousand bricks?" and your banker asks, "Are you making money on each brick or bleeding on each one?"

You cannot answer either question from a heap of total expenses. You need one number: **cost per brick**. And the moment you try to compute it you discover the whole difficulty — some costs (clay, coal) rise directly with each brick, others (rent, manager's salary) do not move at all with output but still have to be *recovered* by the bricks, and some (packing, delivery) attach only after production. The problem of **unit costing** is precisely this: how do you take a pile of period costs incurred to make a stream of *identical* things, and honestly divide it so that each unit carries its fair share — no more, no less — and the total still reconciles back to what you actually spent?

Now change the business. You run a small printing press. You do not make an endless river of one identical item; you make **jobs that happen to repeat in groups**. A customer orders 5,000 identical wedding cards. Another orders 20,000 identical pharma cartons. Each order is a *batch* of identical pieces, but different batches are different products. Here a fresh problem appears that the brick kiln never had: **every time you start a new batch you must set up the machine** — clean the rollers, mount new plates, run test sheets, calibrate colour. That setup costs the same whether you then run 500 cards or 50,000 cards. So a new tension is born: run **big batches** and the setup cost is spread thin (good) but you sit on mountains of unsold inventory tying up cash and warehouse (bad); run **small batches** and inventory is lean (good) but you pay setup after setup after setup (bad). Somewhere between "one giant batch a year" and "a tiny batch every day" there is a batch size that costs the least. Finding it is the problem of the **Economic Batch Quantity (EBQ)**.

This chapter builds the two costing methods that answer these two questions — **Unit (Output/Single) Costing** for the brick kiln, and **Batch Costing** with **EBQ** for the printing press — and it builds each one only *after* you feel the problem it exists to solve.

A third, quieter problem hides underneath both. Notice that the brick kiln and the printing press are not two unrelated worlds — they are two points on a single spectrum of *how homogeneous the output is*. At one extreme sits a continuous river of one identical product (bricks, cement): pure **unit costing**. At the other extreme sits a one-off custom machine built to a single client's drawing (a ship, a bridge): pure **job costing**. **Batch costing lives in the middle** — identical pieces, but produced in finite lots rather than an endless stream. The reason the syllabus teaches Unit and Batch together is that they share the same engine (accumulate costs, then divide because the pieces are identical) and differ only in *what unit of output you accumulate against* — the whole period's output for unit costing, one lot for batch costing. Keep the spectrum in mind; it tells you which method a mystery exam question actually wants before you write a single number.

---

2. The Core Idea: The Cake and the Cupcake Tray

Hold two pictures in your head.

Unit costing is a single large cake. One oven, one continuous bake, one homogeneous mass. You spent a known total on ingredients, gas, and the baker's time. To find "cost per gram" you simply divide total cost by total grams. There is no question of "which slice got more ingredients" because every gram of a well-mixed cake is identical to every other gram. **Homogeneity is what makes simple division legitimate.** If the output were a mix of a chocolate cake and a fruit cake, dividing total cost by total weight would be a lie — the chocolate would subsidise the fruit. Unit costing earns the right to divide only because the output is *one identical thing*.

Batch costing is a cupcake tray. You do not bake one endless cake; you bake **trays of 24 identical cupcakes**. Within a tray every cupcake is identical (so *inside* the tray you divide, just like the cake). But each tray is a distinct event: you greased and lined the tray, preheated, and cleaned up — a **setup** you pay once per tray regardless of whether the tray is full or half-empty. So batch costing is really **"unit costing inside the batch, job costing between batches"**: treat the whole batch as one job, accumulate all its costs, then divide by the number of good pieces in it.

And EBQ is the **cupcake-tray-size decision**. Bake giant trays rarely and you preheat seldom (low setup) but cupcakes go stale on the shelf (high holding). Bake tiny trays constantly and nothing goes stale (low holding) but you preheat all day (high setup). EBQ is the tray size where the money wasted on preheating exactly balances the money wasted on stale stock — the bottom of the total-cost valley. If that "trade-off between per-order cost and per-unit-held cost" feels familiar, it should: **EBQ is EOQ wearing a factory uniform.** EOQ (Chapter on Material Control) balanced *ordering* cost against *carrying* cost for buying; EBQ balances *setup* cost against *carrying* cost for making. Same maths, same valley, different words.

Why "cost per unit" is not one number but a family of numbers. A subtlety students miss: the cake has *many* legitimate "cost per gram" figures depending on *where you stop slicing*. Cost per gram of raw batter (prime cost per unit), cost per gram out of the oven (works cost per unit), cost per gram boxed and ready to ship (cost of production per unit), cost per gram delivered (cost of sales per unit) — each answers a different question. Prime cost per unit answers "how efficient is my shop floor?"; cost of production per unit is what you value closing stock at; cost of sales per unit is what your selling price must beat. The Cost Sheet's staged design exists precisely so that *all* these per-unit numbers fall out of one statement instead of being computed separately. When an exam says "cost per unit," your first instinct must be "**at which stage?**"

Why the batch is the natural collection unit — the "identity" test. The deepest reason batch costing draws the boundary at the batch and not the individual piece or the whole period is a test of *cost identity*: two things should share a cost pool only if they consumed resources identically. All pieces *inside* one batch shared the same setup, the same material lot, the same machine run — their costs are genuinely identical, so pooling then dividing is honest. Two *different* batches did not share a setup and may not share materials — pooling them would cross-subsidise. So the batch boundary is not administrative convenience; it is the largest group of units that truly consumed resources identically. This single test — "did these units consume resources identically?" — is what silently decides unit vs batch vs job costing in every question.

---

3. Why It's Built This Way

Why does unit costing use a Cost Sheet and simple division rather than tracking each unit? Because tracking each brick individually would cost more than the brick. When output is homogeneous and mass-produced, individuality carries *no information* — brick number 217,004 is identical in cost to brick number 89,431, so recording them separately is pure waste. The rational design is to accumulate cost by *period and* *process* and divide by *period output*. The Cost Sheet is engineered to do exactly this while preserving the classification the exam demands: Prime Cost → Works/Factory Cost → Cost of Production → Cost of Goods Sold → Cost of Sales, so that at every stage you can see cost per unit and answer pricing, valuation, and control questions.

Why does batch costing refuse to divide the whole period's cost by the whole period's output? Because the output is *not* homogeneous across the period — wedding cards and pharma cartons are different products with different materials and different setups. Dividing everything together would smear one product's cost onto another. So the design switch is: make the **batch** the cost-collection unit. Each batch gets its own cost record (materials + labour + a share of overheads + its own setup), and only *within* the batch — where pieces truly are identical — do we divide. Batch costing is deliberately a hybrid: it borrows job costing's discipline of "accumulate per job" and unit costing's convenience of "divide because identical," using each exactly where it is valid.

Why is EBQ built on a square-root formula and not on "just guess a good size"? Because the two costs pull in opposite directions and are *non-linear* in batch size. Annual setup cost falls as `1/Q` (bigger batch → fewer setups), while annual holding cost rises linearly as `Q/2` (bigger batch → more average stock). When one curve falls as `1/Q` and another rises as `Q`, their sum is a U-shape with a unique minimum, and calculus (or the AM-GM insight that the two costs are equal at the optimum) delivers a clean square-root answer. The formula is not arbitrary; it is the exact bottom of that valley. Building the decision on the formula means we never over- or under-batch by guesswork — we hit the least-cost size directly.

Why is setup cost a *fixed-per-batch* cost and not a per-unit cost — and why does that single fact create EBQ? This is the hinge of the whole chapter, so make it airtight. When you set up a machine you incur the same rupees whether the ensuing run is 100 pieces or 100,000 — the setup does not "know" how long the run will be. That makes setup cost per *unit* a falling curve (spread over more pieces, it shrinks). If setup were genuinely per-unit (rose in lockstep with output), batch *size* would not matter at all — every size would carry the same per-unit setup, and you would just make the smallest convenient lot to keep stock lean. It is *only because setup is fixed per event* that "make it bigger to dilute setup" becomes a real temptation, and it is *only because holding cost rises with size* that the temptation has a limit. Kill either property and EBQ disappears. Whenever an exam scenario removes setup cost (says "negligible") or removes holding cost (says "made to order, no stock"), EBQ collapses and you should stop reaching for the formula.

Why derive EBQ two ways — and why the exam sometimes wants the derivation. ICAI has asked students to *derive* EBQ, not just apply it. Two proofs exist and both are worth holding: - **Calculus:** $T(Q) = (D/Q) \cdot S + (Q/2) \cdot C$. Differentiate: $dT/dQ = -DS/Q^2 + C/2$. Set to zero: $C/2 = DS/Q^2 \Rightarrow Q^2 = 2DS/C \Rightarrow Q = \sqrt{(2DS/C)}$. The second derivative $2DS/Q^3$ is positive, confirming a minimum (not a maximum). - **AM-GM / equal-cost insight:** the sum of a `1/Q` term and a `Q` term is minimised when the two terms are *equal*. Set $(D/Q) \cdot S = (Q/2) \cdot C$, cross-multiply: $2DS = CQ^2 \Rightarrow Q = \sqrt{(2DS/C)}$. This is why "at EBQ, setup cost = holding cost" is not a coincidence you memorise but the very condition that *defines* the optimum.

Knowing both means you can answer "prove it" and you gain a free checking tool: compute setup and holding cost at your answer; if they are not equal you made an arithmetic error.

---

4. Full Technical Content

4.1 Unit (Output / Single) Costing — where it fits

Use unit costing when **a single homogeneous product is produced continuously or in a single process**, in large volume, so that a meaningful **cost per unit** exists. Classic industries: bricks, cement, steel, paper, sugar, flour milling, mining (coal/ore per tonne), quarrying, dairy, breweries, cotton textiles at yarn stage, and utilities (cost per unit of electricity). The defining feature: *all units are essentially identical, so total cost ÷ total units is honest.*

Unit vs Output vs Single costing — the terminology the examiner may probe. These three names are often used interchangeably but carry shades of meaning: - **Single / Output costing** — one product, expressed per natural unit of output (per tonne, per 1,000 bricks, per litre). The purest case. - **Unit costing** — the umbrella term for the divide-by-output method. - When a product has **grades or by-products** (e.g., a colliery producing large coal, small coal, and slack), a *departmental or equivalent-grade* adjustment may be needed so that dividing stays honest. If the grades differ in value, you weight them — you do *not* blindly divide total cost by total tonnes across grades, or the premium grade subsidises the cheap grade (the same "chocolate subsidising fruit" error from Part 2).

The instrument is the Cost Sheet (Statement of Cost). It is a memorandum statement (not a ledger account) that classifies and totals cost in stages. Being a *memorandum* statement matters: it is not part of the double-entry books, carries no debits/credits, and therefore never needs to "balance" like a ledger account — it simply builds a total. Learn the skeleton with its *reason at each stage*:

Stage	What is added	Why this stage exists
Prime Cost	Direct Material Consumed + Direct Labour + Direct (Chargeable) Expenses	The costs traceable *directly* to the product — the irreducible core
Works / Factory Cost	Prime Cost + Factory Overheads (indirect factory costs) ± Opening/Closing WIP	Everything spent *inside the factory* to convert material into finished goods
Cost of Production	Works Cost + Administration Overheads (production-related)	Full cost of goods *produced* and put into finished-goods store
Cost of Goods Sold (COGS)	Cost of Production + Opening FG − Closing FG	Cost of only the units actually *sold* this period
Cost of Sales	COGS + Selling & Distribution Overheads	Total cost of getting the product *sold and delivered*
Sales	Cost of Sales + Profit	The selling value; profit is the balancing figure

Direct Material Consumed — never assume it equals purchases:

```
Direct Material Consumed = Opening Stock of Raw Material
                         + Purchases + Carriage Inward − Returns
                         − Closing Stock of Raw Material
```

Prime cost is more than material + labour. Direct (chargeable) expenses — the third leg of prime cost — are costs directly traceable to the product but neither material nor labour: royalty paid per unit produced, hire of a special tool or mould for one job, the cost of a specific drawing/design, or excise/architect fees identifiable with the output. Students routinely drop these and understate prime cost. Ask of every expense: "can I trace this rupee to the product without an arbitrary basis?" If yes and it is not material or wages, it is a direct expense and belongs in prime cost.

The precise contents of each overhead block (so you classify correctly under pressure): - **Factory / Works overhead:** indirect materials (lubricants, cotton waste, small tools), indirect wages (foreman, gatekeeper, storekeeper, maintenance staff), factory rent/rates/insurance, power and fuel, depreciation of plant and factory building, factory lighting, repairs to plant. *Anything to keep the factory running that you cannot trace to one unit.* - **Administration overhead:** office salaries, office rent, printing and stationery, legal and audit fees, directors' fees, depreciation of office equipment. In modern ICAI treatment, admin overhead *relating to production* is included in cost of production; general administration may be shown separately. **Follow the question's classification** — do not impose your own. - **Selling & distribution overhead:** salesmen's salaries and commission, advertising, showroom expenses, carriage *outward*, packing for delivery, warehouse of finished goods, bad debts, after-sales service. Note **carriage outward is S&D**, whereas **carriage inward is a material cost** — a classic swap trap.

Items that NEVER enter the Cost Sheet (purely financial items). The Cost Sheet records *cost* items only. Exclude: income tax, dividends paid, transfer to reserves, donations, goodwill written off, loss/profit on sale of fixed assets or investments, interest paid on debentures/loans (financial charge), fines and penalties, cash discount, and appropriations of profit. These belong in the Financial P&L, and the *difference* they create is exactly what a **Cost–Financial Reconciliation Statement** (a separate chapter) later explains. If a data-dump question sprinkles "donation ₹10,000" or "loss on sale of machine ₹25,000," your job is to *ignore* them in the cost sheet.

Treatment of stock at three levels (a favourite exam distinction):

- **Raw Material** stock adjusts *before* Prime Cost (to get material consumed).
- **Work-in-Progress (WIP)** stock adjusts at the *Factory/Works Cost* stage. WIP is valued at *factory cost* because it has absorbed material, labour and factory overheads but is not yet complete: `Works Cost = Gross Works Cost + Opening WIP − Closing WIP`.
- **Finished Goods** stock adjusts at the *Cost of Production* stage to reach COGS, and is valued at *cost of production per unit*.

Treatment of scrap: the sale value of normal scrap is deducted from factory overheads (or works cost). Abnormal scrap/loss cost is removed from the cost sheet and taken to Costing P&L — it must not inflate the good units' cost.

Cost per unit is computed at each relevant stage by dividing that stage's total by the number of units (units *produced* for cost of production; units *sold* for cost of sales).

A note on WIP valuation you can be quizzed on. WIP is valued at *works/factory cost* because that is precisely the pool of costs a half-finished good has absorbed — material, labour, and factory overhead — but *not yet* administration or selling costs, which attach only to completed, sold goods. This is the logic behind adjusting WIP at exactly the works-cost line: add opening WIP (last period's part-finished goods completed this period) and subtract closing WIP (this period's part-finished goods to finish next period). If a question gives WIP "at prime cost" instead, adjust at the prime-cost line accordingly — the *principle* is: adjust WIP wherever it was valued.

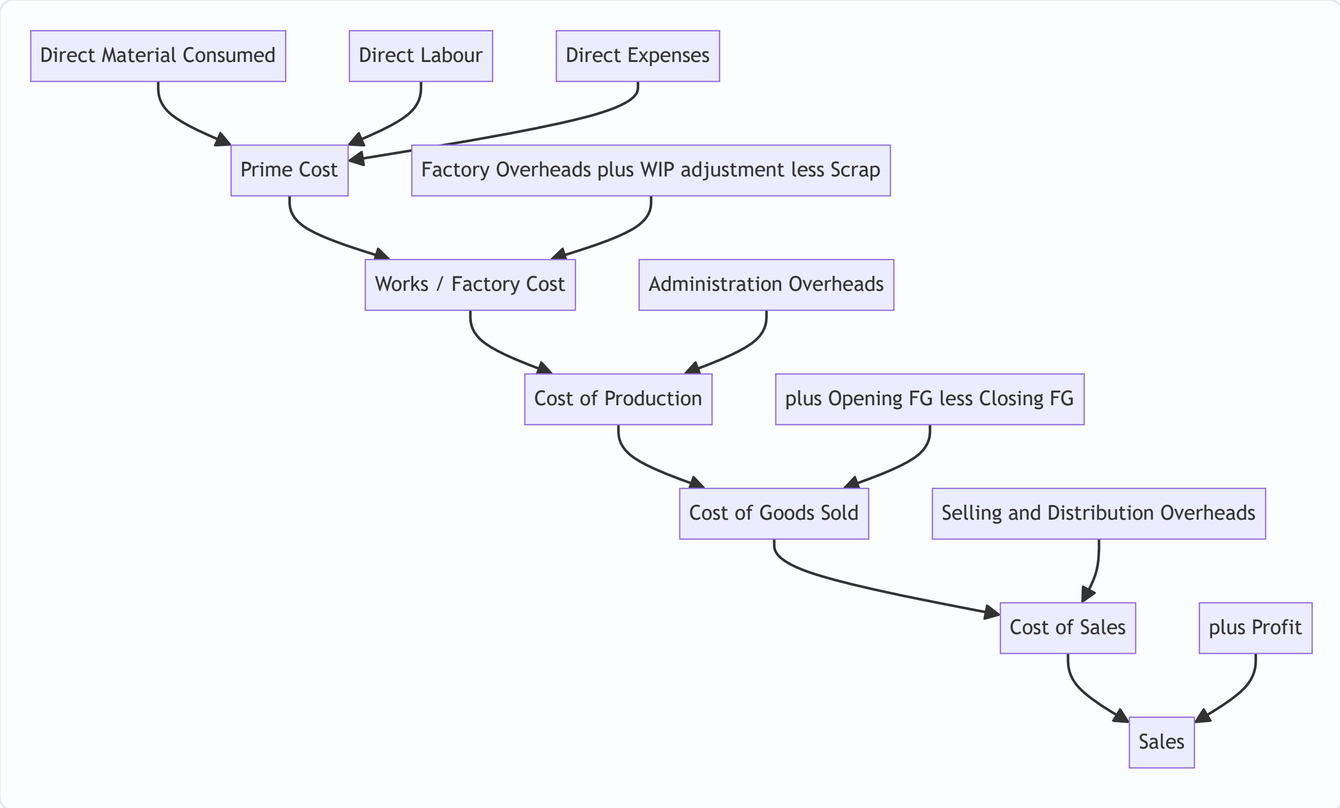


Figure 1 — The unit-costing cost sheet as a staged funnel, each stage adding one category of cost and answering one question.

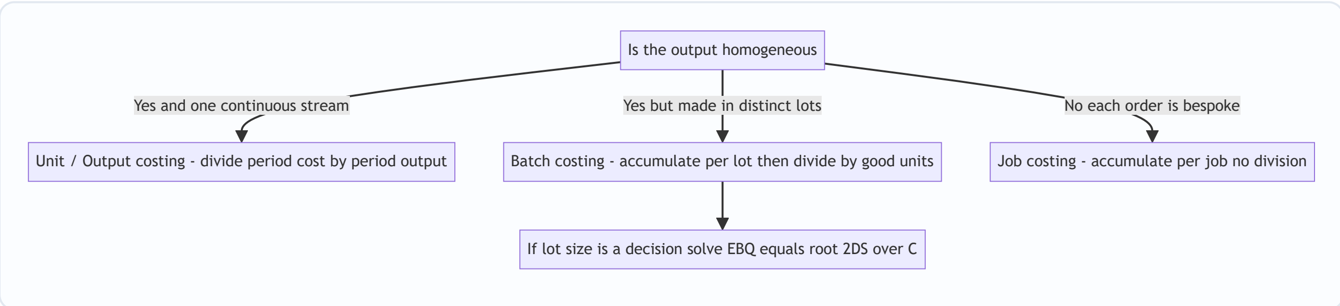


Figure 2 — The homogeneity spectrum decides the method before you compute anything.

4.2 Batch Costing — where it fits

Use batch costing when **identical articles are produced in distinct lots/batches**, each lot being economically convenient to make together, but different lots may be different products or the same product made at different times. Classic industries: **pharmaceuticals** (a batch of 1,00,000 tablets), **biscuits/bakery**, **ready-made garments** (a batch of one size/design), **footwear**, **toys**, **component/spare-part manufacture**, **printing** (5,000 cards), **electronics** (a run of PCBs), **paints**, and **nuts-and-bolts**.

Batch costing is a **variant of job costing** in which the *batch* is the cost unit (the "job"). Mechanically:

```
Total Cost of a Batch = Direct Materials for the batch
                      + Direct Labour for the batch
                      + Setup / Machine set-up cost of the batch
                      + Overheads absorbed by the batch

Cost per unit in the batch = Total Cost of the Batch / Number of GOOD units in the batch
```

Note two exam-critical subtleties: - **Setup cost is a per-batch cost**, incurred once no matter how many pieces are run — this is exactly what makes batch *size* matter and drives EBQ. - If some units in the batch are **rejected/spoiled (normal)**, the good units absorb the whole batch cost, so you divide by *good* units, not total units started.

Two flavours of overhead absorption in batch costing. Because a batch is a job, overheads are absorbed onto it exactly as in job costing — by a predetermined rate. Watch which basis the question uses: - **Labour-hour or machine-hour rate:** overhead = rate × hours the batch consumed. Preferred when the question gives hours and a rate per hour. - **Percentage of a direct cost:** overhead = x% of direct wages (or of prime cost). Preferred when the question gives a blanket percentage. Do not mix them: if you are given both a machine-hour rate and a "% of wages," read carefully which applies to which overhead block. A common trap is to have *factory* OH on a machine-hour basis and *administration/S&D* OH as a percentage — apply each to its own base.

Cost per unit of a customer order vs cost per unit of a batch. A batch may satisfy several customer orders, or one order may span several batches. When a question asks "cost of executing order X for 3,000 units" but the economic batch is 5,000, you (i) compute cost per good unit from the batch, then (ii) multiply by the 3,000 units the order needs. Do not confuse the *production* lot with the *sales* lot.

Batch costing where setup is expressed per unit of time or per machine. Sometimes setup is given as "2 hours of machine time at ₹300/hour" rather than a lump sum. Convert first (2 × 300 = ₹600 setup) before treating it as the per-batch setup S. The formula and logic are unchanged; only the arithmetic of arriving at S differs.

4.3 Economic Batch Quantity (EBQ) — the batch-size decision

The trade-off, made precise. Let a factory need `D` units of a product per year (annual demand/requirement). It makes them in batches of size `Q`.

- **Number of batches (setups) per year** = `D / Q`. Each setup costs `S`. So **annual setup cost = (D/Q) × S**. This *falls* as Q rises.
- **Average inventory held** = `Q / 2` (stock rises to Q when a batch is produced, then is drawn down to 0 before the next batch — average is half). Each unit costs `C` per year to hold (storage, insurance, interest on capital blocked, obsolescence). So **annual holding cost = (Q/2) × C**. This *rises* as Q rises.

Total relevant annual cost `T(Q) = (D/Q)·S + (Q/2)·C`. Setting the derivative to zero (or noting the minimum occurs where the two costs are equal) gives:

$$\textbf{EBQ} = \sqrt{\dfrac{2 \times D \times S}{C}}$$

where **D** = annual demand/production requirement, **S** = set-up cost per batch, **C** = holding (carrying) cost per unit per annum.

Notice the exact parallel to EOQ: replace "set-up cost per batch S" with "ordering cost per order O" and you have EOQ = $\sqrt{(2DO/C)}$. EBQ is EOQ for *making* instead of *buying*. Everything you learned about EOQ — that at the optimum ordering cost equals carrying cost, that the total-cost curve is flat-bottomed (so small errors in Q barely raise cost) — transfers directly.

The gradual-replenishment refinement (when the examiner tightens the model). The simple `Q/2` average assumes a batch arrives *instantly* — stock jumps to Q, then depletes. But in real production the batch is *built up gradually* while it is also being consumed. If the production rate is `p` per period and the demand/usage rate is `d` per period (p > d, or you could never keep up), stock never reaches the full Q; it peaks lower because usage nibbles at it during the build-up. The refined maximum stock is `Q(1 − d/p)` and average stock is `Q(1 − d/p)/2`, giving:

$$\textbf{EBQ}_{\text{gradual}} = \sqrt{\dfrac{2DS}{C\,\left(1 - \tfrac{d}{p}\right)}}$$

The `(1 − d/p)` factor *shrinks the effective holding cost* (less average stock), so the optimal batch is *larger* than the simple model. **When to use it:** only when the question gives *both* a production/supply rate and a demand/consumption rate. If it gives only annual demand and setup/holding costs, use the plain EBQ. Flag: the exact notation and whether ICAI's current study material foregrounds this refinement can vary — *verify against current ICAI material for your attempt* — but the logic (gradual build-up lowers average stock) is standard.

Useful corollaries: - **Number of batches per year** = `D / EBQ`. - **Batch cycle / interval** = `EBQ / D` (in years) or `(EBQ/D) × 12` months or `(EBQ/D) × 365` days. - If `C` is given as a **percentage `i` of unit cost `p`**, then `C = i × p` and EBQ = $\sqrt{(2DS / (i \cdot p))}$. - **Holding-cost basis:** sometimes holding cost is charged on *average* inventory (Q/2) — the standard case above. Read the question: if it says "carrying cost per unit per annum," use C directly. - **Total minimum relevant cost** at EBQ = $\sqrt{(2 \cdot D \cdot S \cdot C)}$. This tidy result (the minimised value of T) lets you state the least annual setup-plus-holding cost in one line without tabulating; it also equals *twice* the setup cost (or twice the holding cost) at the optimum, since the two are equal.

Why the total-cost curve is "flat-bottomed" and why that is examinable. Because near the minimum the curve is nearly horizontal, a manager who chooses a *convenient* round batch size close to EBQ (say a full pallet of 4,000 rather than 3,795) pays almost nothing extra. This is a favourite short-note / MCQ point: EBQ is *robust* — precision to the last unit is not worth chasing, but being in the right neighbourhood matters a lot. Contrast a size far from EBQ (double or half), where cost climbs steeply.

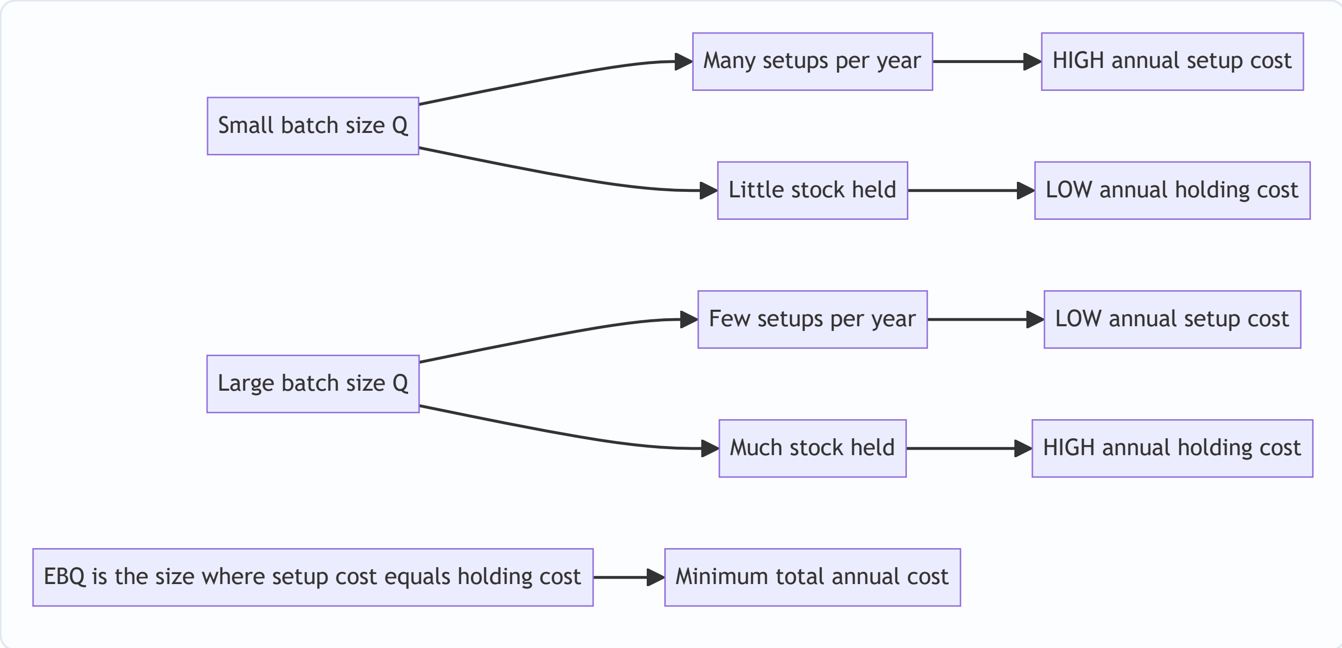


Figure 3 — The two opposing pressures on batch size; EBQ sits where they balance.

---

5. Worked Examples

Example 1 — Unit Costing (easy): the brick kiln, made honest

A brick works produced 4,00,000 bricks in June. Data: Raw material (clay etc.) consumed ₹6,00,000; Direct wages ₹3,20,000; Direct (chargeable) expenses ₹40,000; Factory overheads ₹2,40,000; Administration overheads ₹1,00,000; Selling & distribution overheads ₹60,000; Sale of scrap (normal) ₹40,000. All bricks produced were sold at ₹6 per brick. Prepare the cost sheet showing cost per 1,000 bricks and total profit.

Step 1 — Prime Cost. Prime Cost = 6,00,000 + 3,20,000 + 40,000 = **₹9,60,000**

Step 2 — Works Cost (add factory OH, deduct scrap sale). = 9,60,000 + 2,40,000 − 40,000 = **₹11,60,000**

Step 3 — Cost of Production (add admin OH). Since all units produced are sold and there is no FG stock, Cost of Production = COGS. = 11,60,000 + 1,00,000 = **₹12,60,000**

Step 4 — Cost of Sales (add S&D OH). = 12,60,000 + 60,000 = **₹13,20,000**

Step 5 — Sales and Profit. Sales = 4,00,000 × ₹6 = ₹24,00,000. Profit = 24,00,000 − 13,20,000 = **₹10,80,000**.

Particulars	Total (₹)	Per 1,000 bricks (₹)
Direct Material	6,00,000	1,500
Direct Wages	3,20,000	800
Direct Expenses	40,000	100
Prime Cost	**9,60,000**	**2,400**
Add Factory OH	2,40,000	600
Less Sale of Scrap	(40,000)	(100)
Works Cost	**11,60,000**	**2,900**
Add Administration OH	1,00,000	250
Cost of Production / COGS	**12,60,000**	**3,150**
Add Selling & Distribution OH	60,000	150
Cost of Sales	**13,20,000**	**3,300**
Profit	10,80,000	2,700
Sales	**24,00,000**	**6,000**

Reconciliation check: per-1,000 cost of sales ₹3,300 × 400 (thousand-lots) = ₹13,20,000 ✓; profit ₹2,700 × 400 = ₹10,80,000 ✓; sales ₹6,000 × 400 = ₹24,00,000 ✓. Every column ties.

Example 2 — Unit Costing (exam-hard): stock at all three levels

Sunrise Steel makes one homogeneous product, MS Rods. For the year:

- *Raw material — Opening ₹1,50,000; Purchases ₹22,00,000; Carriage inward ₹50,000; Closing ₹2,00,000.*
- *Direct wages ₹9,00,000; Direct expenses ₹1,00,000.*
- *Factory overheads = 60% of direct wages.*
- *Opening WIP ₹1,20,000; Closing WIP ₹1,80,000 (both at factory cost).*
- *Administration overheads (production related) ₹3,20,000.*
- *Opening finished goods 200 tonnes valued ₹5,00,000; Closing finished goods 300 tonnes (value to be computed at current cost of production per tonne).*
- *Units produced during the year: 2,000 tonnes.*
- *Selling & distribution overhead ₹200 per tonne sold. Profit is 20% on sales.*

Prepare the cost sheet, value closing FG, and find the number of tonnes sold, total sales and profit.

Step 1 — Direct Material Consumed. = Opening + Purchases + Carriage − Closing = 1,50,000 + 22,00,000 + 50,000 − 2,00,000 = **₹21,00,000**

Step 2 — Prime Cost. = 21,00,000 + 9,00,000 (wages) + 1,00,000 (direct expenses) = **₹31,00,000**

Step 3 — Gross Works Cost, then adjust WIP. Factory OH = 60% × 9,00,000 = ₹5,40,000. Gross Works Cost = 31,00,000 + 5,40,000 = ₹36,40,000. Works Cost = 36,40,000 + Opening WIP 1,20,000 − Closing WIP 1,80,000 = **₹35,80,000**

Step 4 — Cost of Production (add admin OH). = 35,80,000 + 3,20,000 = **₹39,00,000** for 2,000 tonnes produced. **Cost of production per tonne = 39,00,000 / 2,000 = ₹1,950/tonne.**

Step 5 — Value closing FG and find COGS. Closing FG = 300 tonnes × ₹1,950 = ₹5,85,000. COGS = Cost of Production + Opening FG − Closing FG = 39,00,000 + 5,00,000 − 5,85,000 = **₹38,15,000**

Step 6 — Tonnes sold. Tonnes sold = Opening FG (200) + Produced (2,000) − Closing FG (300) = **1,900 tonnes**.

Step 7 — Cost of Sales. S&D OH = 1,900 × ₹200 = ₹3,80,000. Cost of Sales = 38,15,000 + 3,80,000 = **₹41,95,000**

Step 8 — Sales and Profit. Profit is 20% on sales ⇒ cost is 80% of sales. Sales = Cost of Sales / 0.80 = 41,95,000 / 0.80 = **₹52,43,750**. Profit = Sales − Cost of Sales = 52,43,750 − 41,95,000 = **₹10,48,750** (which is 20% of 52,43,750 ✓).

Particulars	Amount (₹)
Opening Raw Material	1,50,000
Add Purchases	22,00,000
Add Carriage Inward	50,000
Less Closing Raw Material	(2,00,000)
Direct Material Consumed	**21,00,000**
Add Direct Wages	9,00,000
Add Direct Expenses	1,00,000
Prime Cost	**31,00,000**
Add Factory Overheads (60% of wages)	5,40,000
Gross Works Cost	**36,40,000**
Add Opening WIP	1,20,000
Less Closing WIP	(1,80,000)
Works / Factory Cost	**35,80,000**
Add Administration Overheads	3,20,000
Cost of Production (2,000 tonnes)	**39,00,000**
Add Opening Finished Goods (200 t)	5,00,000
Less Closing Finished Goods (300 t × ₹1,950)	(5,85,000)
Cost of Goods Sold (1,900 t)	**38,15,000**
Add Selling & Distribution OH (1,900 × ₹200)	3,80,000
Cost of Sales	**41,95,000**
Add Profit (20% on sales)	10,48,750
Sales	**52,43,750**

Reconciliation: Cost of production per tonne ₹1,950 used consistently for closing stock and implicit in COGS; units flow 200 + 2,000 − 300 = 1,900 sold ✓; profit ₹10,48,750 ÷ sales ₹52,43,750 = 20.0% ✓. Statement fully reconciles.

"What if the examiner tweaks it?" variations on Example 2: - *Opening FG given only in value, closing FG asked at cost of production, but opening FG per-tonne differs from this year's ₹1,950.* That is normal — opening stock carries *last year's* rate (₹5,00,000 / 200 = ₹2,500/tonne here, higher than this year), and you value only *closing* stock at the current ₹1,950. Do not "restate" opening stock. If the question instead demands **FIFO**, the 1,900 tonnes sold come first from the 200 opening tonnes (at ₹2,500) and then 1,700 from current production (at ₹1,950); COGS would then be 200×2,500 + 1,700×1,950 = 5,00,000 + 33,15,000 = ₹38,15,000 — coincidentally close here, but in general FIFO changes COGS, so read whether a cost-flow method is imposed. - *Profit given as 25% on cost instead of 20% on sales.* Then Sales = Cost of Sales × 1.25 = 41,95,000 × 1.25 = ₹52,43,750 — identical here only because 20% on sales = 25% on cost. This equivalence (20/80 = 25/100... check: profit/cost = 10,48,750/41,95,000 = 25%) is a neat cross-check the examiner exploits; know that "20% on sales" and "25% on cost" describe the *same* markup. - *Factory OH given as "60% of prime cost" instead of "of wages."* Then OH = 60% × 31,00,000 = ₹18,60,000 — vastly different. Always read the *base* of a percentage overhead.

Example 3 — Batch Costing with EBQ (exam-hard, multi-part)

Precision Pharma manufactures a tablet with an annual demand of 24,000 strips. Each machine set-up for a batch costs ₹1,200. The cost of holding one strip in stock is ₹4 per annum. Direct material per strip is ₹5, direct labour per strip is ₹3, and variable overhead is 100% of direct labour. Fixed production overhead is ₹96,000 per annum, absorbed on the basis of annual output. Required:

(a) The Economic Batch Quantity. (b) Number of batches per year and the cycle time in days (assume 360 working days). (c) The total cost per strip and the cost of one optimum batch. (d) Show that at EBQ the annual set-up cost equals the annual holding cost, and compute total setup + holding cost. Then demonstrate why a batch of 4,000 strips is worse.

Part (a) — EBQ. EBQ = √(2DS / C) = √(2 × 24,000 × 1,200 / 4) = √(5,76,00,000 / 4) = √(1,44,00,000).

√(1,44,00,000) = √(1.44 × 10^7) = 1,200 × √10... let me compute cleanly: 1,44,00,000 = 14,400,000. √14,400,000 = √(14.4 × 10^6) = 1,000 × √14.4 = 1,000 × 3.7947 = **3,795 strips (approx.)**.

Let me verify by a cleaner factorisation: 2×24,000×1,200 = 5,76,00,000; ÷4 = 1,44,00,000. Now $3,795^2$ = 14,402,025 ≈ 14,400,000 ✓. So **EBQ ≈ 3,795 strips** (we will use 3,795; some texts round to 3,800).

Part (b) — Batches per year and cycle time. Number of batches = D / EBQ = 24,000 / 3,795 = **6.32 ≈ 6.3 batches per year** (in practice ~6 to 7). Cycle time = (EBQ / D) × 360 = (3,795 / 24,000) × 360 = 0.15813 × 360 = **56.9 ≈ 57 days** between batches.

Part (c) — Cost per strip and cost of one optimum batch. Per-strip variable production cost: - Direct material ₹5 - Direct labour ₹3 - Variable overhead 100% of labour = ₹3 - Subtotal variable = **₹11 per strip**

Fixed production overhead per strip = 96,000 / 24,000 = ₹4 per strip. **Total production cost per strip = 11 + 4 = ₹15.**

Cost of one optimum batch of 3,795 strips (production cost, excluding setup/holding which are period trade-off costs): = 3,795 × ₹15 = **₹56,925** in production cost. Adding this batch's own set-up cost ₹1,200: **batch cost including setup = ₹58,125**, i.e. ₹58,125 / 3,795 = **₹15.32 per strip** including its setup share.

Part (d) — The balance at EBQ, and why 4,000 is worse.

At EBQ = 3,795: - Annual set-up cost = (D/Q)·S = (24,000 / 3,795) × 1,200 = 6.324 × 1,200 = **₹7,589**. - Annual holding cost = (Q/2)·C = (3,795 / 2) × 4 = 1,897.5 × 4 = **₹7,590**.

These are equal (₹7,589 ≈ ₹7,590, tiny rounding) — exactly the hallmark of the optimum. **Total setup + holding = ₹15,179.**

Now test Q = 4,000: - Set-up cost = (24,000 / 4,000) × 1,200 = 6 × 1,200 = ₹7,200. - Holding cost = (4,000 / 2) × 4 = 2,000 × 4 = ₹8,000. - Total = **₹15,200** — which is ₹21 *more* than at EBQ (₹15,179). So 4,000 is worse, confirming EBQ is the minimum.

Test Q = 3,000 to show the other side: - Set-up = (24,000/3,000) × 1,200 = 8 × 1,200 = ₹9,600. - Holding = (3,000/2) × 4 = ₹6,000. - Total = **₹15,600** — also worse. The valley truly bottoms near 3,795.

Batch size Q	Setup cost (D/Q)·S (₹)	Holding cost (Q/2)·C (₹)	Total (₹)
3,000	9,600	6,000	15,600
3,795 (EBQ)	**7,589**	**7,590**	**15,179**
4,000	7,200	8,000	15,200
6,000	4,800	12,000	16,800

Reconciliation / self-check: at EBQ the two component costs are equal (the calculus condition), and total (₹15,179) is the lowest in the table — internally consistent. Independent check via the shortcut: minimum total = √(2·D·S·C) = √(2 × 24,000 × 1,200 × 4) = √(23,04,00,000… = 230,400,000) = ₹15,179 ✓ — matches the tabulated minimum exactly. Note the flat bottom: moving from 3,795 to 4,000 costs only ₹21 extra, illustrating the EOQ/EBQ curve's insensitivity near the optimum. ✓

Example 4 — Batch Costing with rejects (short, high-yield)

A batch of 2,000 pistons was produced. Direct materials ₹1,80,000; direct labour ₹90,000; setup cost ₹6,000; overheads absorbed at 120% of direct labour. On inspection, 100 pistons were rejected as normal spoilage (nil scrap value). Find cost per good piston.

Working: - Overheads = 120% × 90,000 = ₹1,08,000. - Total batch cost = 1,80,000 + 90,000 + 6,000 + 1,08,000 = **₹3,84,000**. - Good units = 2,000 − 100 = **1,900**. - **Cost per good piston = 3,84,000 / 1,900 = ₹202.11.**

Why divide by good units? Normal spoilage is an unavoidable cost of making the good ones; loading the whole ₹3,84,000 onto 1,900 survivors correctly makes each good piston bear its fair share of the spoilage. Dividing by 2,000 would understate cost and let spoilage vanish. ✓

Tweak — what if the 100 rejects were ABNORMAL spoilage with ₹50 scrap each? Then abnormal loss must *not* burden the good units. Compute cost per unit on *total input* first to value the abnormal loss: ₹3,84,000 / 2,000 = ₹192 per unit. Abnormal loss cost = 100 × ₹192 = ₹19,200; less its scrap recovery 100 × ₹50 = ₹5,000; net abnormal loss ₹14,200 goes to the **Costing P&L**. Good units then absorb 3,84,000 − 19,200 = ₹3,64,800 over 1,900 units = **₹192 per good piston** (plus the scrap of the good… there is none). The lesson: *normal* loss is spread over good units (raising their cost); *abnormal* loss is stripped out at cost and sent to P&L (good units stay at normal cost). This normal-vs-abnormal split is the single most tested idea where spoilage meets batch costing.

Example 5 — EBQ with holding cost as a percentage of value, plus stock-out framing (exam-hard)

A component is used at a steady 48,000 units per year. Setting up the machine for a run costs ₹450. Each component has a production cost of ₹20, and inventory carrying cost is estimated at 15% of production cost per annum. The factory works 300 days a year. Find (a) EBQ, (b) number of runs per year and interval between runs in days, (c) the total annual relevant cost at EBQ, and (d) recompute EBQ if the setup cost is halved by a quick-changeover project, and comment.

Part (a) — EBQ. First C: 15% of ₹20 = **₹3 per unit per annum**. EBQ = √(2DS / C) = √(2 × 48,000 × 450 / 3) = √(4,32,00,000 / 3) = √(1,44,00,000) = **4,000 units** (since $4{,}000^2$ = 1,60,00,000... let me verify: 2×48,000×450 = 4,32,00,000; ÷3 = 1,44,00,000; √1,44,00,000 = 3,795).

Recompute carefully: √14,400,000 = 3,794.7. So **EBQ ≈ 3,795 units** — *not* 4,000. (I intentionally show the mis-step: never eyeball a square root. $3{,}795^2$ = 14,402,025 ✓.)

Part (b) — Runs and interval. Runs per year = D / EBQ = 48,000 / 3,795 = **12.65 ≈ 12.6 runs**. Interval = (EBQ / D) × 300 = (3,795 / 48,000) × 300 = 0.079 × 300 = **23.7 ≈ 24 days** between runs.

Part (c) — Total annual relevant cost. Setup = (48,000/3,795) × 450 = 12.65 × 450 = ₹5,692. Holding = (3,795/2) × 3 = 1,897.5 × 3 = ₹5,693. Total ≈ **₹11,385**. Cross-check via √(2DSC) = √(2 × 48,000 × 450 × 3) = √(12,96,00,000... = 129,600,000) = ₹11,384 ✓ (₹1 rounding). Equality of setup and holding confirms the optimum.

Part (d) — Setup halved to ₹225. New EBQ = √(2 × 48,000 × 225 / 3) = √(72,00,000... = 7,200,000... wait: 2×48,000×225 = 2,16,00,000; ÷3 = 72,00,000) = √72,00,000 = **2,683 units**. New total relevant cost = √(2 × 48,000 × 225 × 3) = √(6,48,00,000 = 64,800,000) = **₹8,050**. **Comment:** halving setup cost cut EBQ by a factor of √2 (from 3,795 to 3,795/√2 ≈ 2,683) and cut total relevant cost by √2 as well (₹11,385 → ₹8,050). This is the deep lesson behind lean "single-minute exchange of die" (SMED) programmes: because both EBQ and its cost scale with √S, attacking setup cost lets you make *smaller* batches *and* spend *less* overall — you move down and left along the valley. A √-relationship means a 4× reduction in setup would halve the batch and halve the cost.

Self-check across the example: every EBQ satisfies "setup cost = holding cost"; every total equals √(2DSC); the direction of change (less setup ⇒ smaller batch, lower cost) is economically sensible. Consistent throughout. ✓

---

6. Presentation / Format

Unit-costing Cost Sheet — presentation rules the examiner rewards: 1. **Title it** "Cost Sheet of ... for the period ended ...". 2. Use **two amount columns** when unit cost is asked — "Total (₹)" and "Cost per unit (₹)". Keep the per-unit column consistent (per unit *produced* down to cost of production; watch the switch to units *sold* below). 3. **Show sub-totals in bold** at each stage (Prime Cost, Works Cost, Cost of Production, COGS, Cost of Sales, Sales). Never skip a stage. 4. **Bracket deductions** (scrap sale, closing stocks) and label them "Less". 5. **State per-unit denominators** explicitly (e.g., "per 1,000 bricks", "2,000 tonnes produced"). 6. Adjust each stock at its correct stage: RM before Prime Cost, WIP at Works Cost, FG at Cost of Production→COGS. 7. **Show workings for every derived figure** (material consumed, OH as % of a base, closing-stock valuation) as clearly labelled notes below the statement — ICAI awards method marks even when a final number slips. 8. **Do not net off unrelated items.** Keep scrap sale as a *deduction inside works cost*, S&D as an *addition after COGS*; never lump them.

Batch-costing statement — presentation:

Batch Cost Statement — Batch No. ___	₹
Direct Materials	xxx
Direct Labour	xxx
Set-up Cost	xxx
Overheads absorbed	xxx
Total Batch Cost	**xxx**
Good units in batch	(n)
Cost per unit = Total ÷ Good units	**xxx**

EBQ answer presentation: always (i) write the formula, (ii) substitute D, S, C with units, (iii) compute, (iv) round sensibly to whole units, then (v) if asked, derive batches per year and cycle time, and (vi) verify by showing setup cost ≈ holding cost at EBQ. If the question gives production and demand rates, (vii) state explicitly that you are using the gradual-replenishment form and why.

Reconciliation habit that saves marks. For unit costing, after finishing, multiply the final per-unit cost of sales by units sold and confirm it equals total cost of sales; confirm the unit flow (Opening FG + Produced − Closing FG = Sold). For EBQ, confirm setup cost = holding cost and, if time permits, that total relevant cost = √(2DSC). These 20-second checks catch the majority of arithmetic slips.

---

7. Connections

- ← **Material Control (EOQ):** EBQ *is* EOQ with "set-up cost" swapping in for "ordering cost." Every EOQ property — the √ formula, equality of the two costs at optimum, the flat-bottomed curve, treatment of holding cost as % of unit cost, the √(2DSC) minimum-cost result — carries over. If you can do EOQ, EBQ is free.
- ↔ **Job Costing (next family):** Batch costing is a *special case of job costing* where the job is a batch of identical units. Job costing accumulates cost per job; batch costing then divides by units — the extra step unit costing also uses. Unit → Batch → Job form a spectrum from "fully homogeneous" to "fully bespoke."
- ↔ **Process Costing:** Both unit costing and process costing handle homogeneous mass output; unit/output costing is essentially *single-process* costing. When production passes through *several sequential processes* (sugar, chemicals), you graduate to process costing with equivalent units — but the divide-cost-by-output logic is the same seed.
- → **Overhead absorption:** The "factory OH = x% of wages" and "overheads at y% of labour" steps come straight from the Overheads chapter's absorption rates; unit/batch costing is where you *apply* them.
- → **Cost control & pricing:** Cost per unit/batch feeds directly into quotation, tender pricing, inventory valuation for the balance sheet, and make-or-buy decisions.
- → **Cost–Financial Reconciliation:** The purely financial items you *excluded* from the cost sheet (interest, tax, donations, loss on asset sale) are exactly the reconciling items in that chapter — the cost sheet's

exclusions are the reconciliation's inclusions.

- → **Marginal & Absorption Costing:** whether fixed production OH is absorbed per unit (Example 3's ₹4/strip) or treated as a period cost is the very fault-line between absorption and marginal costing; unit/batch costing here uses the *absorption* view.

---

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Purchases ≠ Material Consumed.** Always adjust opening/closing raw-material stock and add carriage inward. Forgetting this is the single most common slip.
2. **Wrong stock stage.** WIP is adjusted at *Works Cost*, not before Prime Cost; Finished Goods at *Cost of Production → COGS*, not at Works Cost. Mixing these corrupts every subtotal below.
3. **Valuing closing FG at the wrong rate.** Closing finished goods must be valued at the *current year's cost of production per unit*, not at selling price and not at last year's rate (unless the question specifies FIFO/weighted average with opening data).
4. **Units produced vs units sold.** Cost of production divides by units *produced*; cost of sales and profit relate to units *sold*. In Example 2, 2,000 produced but only 1,900 sold — using the wrong denominator wrecks per-unit figures.
5. **"Profit on cost" vs "profit on sales."** 20% on sales ⇒ cost = 80% of sales ⇒ Sales = Cost/0.80. 20% on cost ⇒ Sales = Cost × 1.20. The examiner switches these deliberately.
6. **Scrap treatment.** *Normal* scrap sale is deducted from works/factory cost; *abnormal* loss goes to Costing P&L and must not touch the cost sheet. Don't deduct abnormal items from cost.
7. **Administration overhead placement.** Production-related admin OH sits in Cost of Production; general admin OH is sometimes treated as a period cost between COGS and Cost of Sales. Follow the question's classification.
8. **EBQ — holding-cost basis.** If holding cost is given as a % of unit *cost*, compute $C = i \times p$ first. If given directly as ₹ per unit p.a., use it as-is. Halving inventory ($Q/2$) is already built into the formula — do not halve again.
9. **EBQ — set-up vs ordering vocabulary.** In EBQ the "S" is *set-up* cost per batch (a production cost), not ordering cost. Read the numbers, not the label.
10. **Dividing a batch by total units instead of good units.** With normal rejects, divide by *good* units (Example 4). Dividing by units started understates cost per good unit.
11. **Rounding EBQ then contradicting it.** Round EBQ to whole units, but when you then show "setup cost ≈ holding cost," expect a ₹1–₹2 gap purely from rounding — that is fine; do not "force" them equal by fudging.
12. **Carriage inward vs carriage outward.** Carriage *inward* is a material cost (before prime cost); carriage *outward* is selling & distribution (after COGS). The examiner lists both in one data dump to see if you split them.
13. **Base of a percentage overhead.** "60% of wages," "60% of prime cost," and "60% of works cost" give wildly different figures. Underline the base before multiplying (see Example 2 tweak).
14. **Financial items smuggled into the data.** Interest on loan, income tax, donation, dividend, loss on sale of asset, goodwill written off — *exclude* all of these from the cost sheet. Including even one inflates cost and loses marks.

15. **Eyeballing the square root.** √(1,44,00,000) is 3,795, not 4,000. Always square your answer back to check (Example 5). A wrong root cascades into wrong batches, cycle time, and cost.
16. **Forgetting setup cost inside the batch's own cost.** When asked for "cost of one batch," include that batch's setup; when asked for annual setup vs holding trade-off, use (D/Q)·S. Same S, two different roles — do not double count or omit.
17. **Gradual replenishment mis-triggered.** Use the (1 − d/p) form *only* when both a production rate and a usage rate are given. Applying it when only annual demand is given invents data and is wrong.
18. **Opening stock of finished goods valued at this year's rate.** Opening FG carries *last year's* cost; only closing FG uses the current year's cost of production per unit (unless FIFO/WA is specified). Restating opening stock is a silent error.

---

9. First-Principles Recap

Strip everything away and two ideas remain.

One: *Division is only honest between identical things.* When output is a homogeneous mass (bricks, tonnes, litres, kWh), you may take the pile of period costs and divide by output — that is **unit costing**, and the Cost Sheet is merely a disciplined way to do that division stage by stage so each cost category is recovered and the total reconciles. When output comes in *identical lots but different products*, you first accumulate cost per **lot/batch** (because lots are not identical to each other) and only then divide *within* the lot (because pieces inside it are identical) — that is **batch costing**, a hybrid of job and unit costing. The single question "did these units consume resources identically?" decides where you are allowed to divide.

Two: *Whenever a fixed cost is triggered per event, the size of the event is a decision.* Making a batch triggers a fixed **set-up cost** regardless of batch size, while holding stock costs money proportional to size. Big batches waste setup less but waste holding more; small batches the reverse. The least-cost size is where the two wastes are equal — the square-root **EBQ = √(2DS/C)**. It is the same trade-off as EOQ because it is the same *shape* of problem: a `1/Q` cost fighting a `Q` cost always bottoms at a √ point, and the minimum total of the two is √(2DSC).

Master those two sentences and you can *reconstruct* every formula and format in this chapter from scratch — no memorisation required. The Cost Sheet ladder falls out of idea one (divide identical things, stage by stage); EBQ and all its corollaries fall out of idea two (a fixed-per-event cost makes event size a decision).

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

When to use: - **Unit / Output costing** → single homogeneous product, mass/continuous production (bricks, cement, steel, sugar, power). Answer wanted: **cost per unit**. - **Batch costing** → identical articles made in distinct lots (pharma, bakery, garments, printing, components). Answer wanted: **cost per unit within a batch** + optimum **batch size**. - **Decision test:** did the units consume resources identically? All period → unit; per lot → batch; each order bespoke → job.

Cost Sheet stages (memorise the ladder): Prime Cost → (+Factory OH ±WIP −Normal scrap) Works Cost → (+Admin OH) Cost of Production → (±FG stock) COGS → (+S&D OH) Cost of Sales → (+Profit) Sales.

Key formulas: - Direct Material Consumed = Opening RM + Purchases + Carriage In − Returns − Closing RM - Prime Cost = Direct Material + Direct Labour + Direct (Chargeable) Expenses - Works Cost = Gross

Works Cost + Opening WIP − Closing WIP - COGS = Cost of Production + Opening FG − Closing FG - Units sold = Opening FG + Produced − Closing FG - Profit on sales p%: Sales = Cost of Sales / (1 − p); Profit on cost p%: Sales = Cost × (1 + p) - **Batch cost per unit = Total batch cost / Good units** - **EBQ = √(2 D S / C)** (D = annual demand, S = set-up cost/batch, C = holding cost/unit/annum; if C = i% of price p, use C = i·p) - **EBQ (gradual replenishment) = √(2DS / [C(1 − d/p)])** — only when both production rate p and usage rate d are given - **Minimum total relevant cost = √(2 D S C)** = twice the setup (= twice the holding) at optimum - Batches/year = D / EBQ; Cycle = (EBQ/D) × 360 days (or ×12 months) - At EBQ: annual set-up cost = annual holding cost

Stock adjustment stages: RM → before Prime Cost; WIP → at Works Cost (valued at factory cost); FG → at Cost of Production (valued at cost of production/unit).

Excluded (financial) items — never in the cost sheet: interest on loan/debentures, income tax, dividends, donations, transfer to reserves, loss/profit on sale of assets or investments, goodwill written off, fines, cash discount.

Top 6 traps: (1) purchases ≠ consumed; (2) WIP at Works, FG at COGS — not swapped; (3) closing FG at current cost of production, opening FG at last year's; (4) produced-vs-sold denominator; (5) profit on sales vs on cost; (6) carriage inward (material) vs outward (S&D).

EBQ ↔ EOQ: identical formula; set-up cost replaces ordering cost; curve is flat-bottomed so near-optimum errors are cheap; at optimum the two opposing costs are equal; minimum total = √(2DSC); halving setup shrinks EBQ and total cost by √2 (the lean-manufacturing lever).

Q&A — Unit & Batch Costing

> CA Intermediate • Cost & Management Accounting • ICAI-aligned • all figures in Rupees (₹)

Section A — Concept Check (with answers)

A1. What is Unit (Output/Single) Costing and where is it applied? Ans. Unit costing is a method of costing used where production is continuous, output is a single uniform product, and cost is ascertained **per unit of output**. Cost per unit = Total Cost ÷ Number of units produced. Applied in mines, quarries, breweries, cement works, steel, paper, brick-making — industries with one homogeneous product.

A2. What is Batch Costing? How does it differ from Job Costing? Ans. Batch costing is a form of **specific order costing** where a group of identical articles maintaining continuity of production (a *batch*) is treated as one cost unit. Cost per unit = Total Batch Cost ÷ Number of units in batch. It differs from job costing in that the cost unit is a **batch** (many identical units) rather than a **single job**. Batch costing is essentially job costing applied to a batch. Used in pharmaceuticals, biscuits, garments, spare parts, toys, footwear.

A3. Define Economic Batch Quantity (EBQ) and state the trade-off it balances. Ans. EBQ is the batch size that **minimises the total of set-up cost and carrying cost** per annum. As batch size rises, number of set-ups (and set-up cost) falls but average inventory (and carrying cost) rises. EBQ is where these two opposing costs are balanced (set-up cost = carrying cost at optimum).

A4. State the EBQ formula and define each symbol. Ans. $$EBQ = \sqrt{\dfrac{2DS}{C}}$$ where **D** = annual demand/requirement (units), **S** = set-up cost per batch (₹), **C** = carrying (holding) cost per unit per annum (₹).

A5. In unit costing, how are "cost of production" and "cost of sales" distinguished? Ans. Cost of Production = Prime cost + Factory overhead + Admin overhead (related to production) + adjustment for opening/closing WIP and finished goods. **Cost of Sales = Cost of Production of goods sold + Selling & Distribution overhead**. Sales − Cost of Sales = Profit.

A6. Why is the Cake vs Cupcake-Tray analogy used? Ans. A single large cake = **unit costing**: one continuous flow, cost spread over identical slices. A cupcake tray baked in trays of 12 = **batch costing**: you bake a set-up (tray) at a time, cost is collected per tray then divided by cupcakes. The tray = the batch; the oven pre-heat = the set-up cost.

A7. Why does set-up cost per unit fall while carrying cost per unit rises as batch size grows? (First-principles) Ans. Set-up cost is a **fixed cost per batch**, so spreading it over more units lowers per-unit set-up cost. Carrying cost depends on **average inventory (≈ batch/2)**, which grows with batch size, raising carrying cost per unit. Total cost is minimised at EBQ where marginal savings on set-up equal marginal rise in carrying.

Section B — Graded Computational Problems (full workings)

B1 (Easy) — Basic Unit Cost

A cement plant produced **50,000 tonnes**. Costs: Materials ₹40,00,000; Wages ₹20,00,000; Works overhead ₹10,00,000; Admin overhead ₹5,00,000. Find cost per tonne under each element.

Solution. | Element | Total (₹) | Per tonne (₹) | |---|---|---| | Materials | 40,00,000 | 80.00 | | Wages | 20,00,000 | 40.00 | | **Prime Cost** | **60,00,000** | **120.00** | | Works overhead | 10,00,000 | 20.00 | | **Works Cost** | **70,00,000** | **140.00** | | Admin overhead | 5,00,000 | 10.00 | | **Cost of Production** | **75,00,000** | **150.00** |

Per-tonne = Total ÷ 50,000. **Cost of production = ₹150 per tonne.**

B2 (Easy–Moderate) — Basic Batch Cost

A batch of **1,000 pens** incurred: Direct material ₹6,000; Direct labour ₹4,000; Set-up cost ₹2,000; Overhead absorbed @ 150% of direct labour. Find cost per pen.

Solution. - Overhead = 150% × ₹4,000 = ₹6,000 - Total batch cost = 6,000 + 4,000 + 2,000 + 6,000 = **₹18,000** - Cost per pen = 18,000 ÷ 1,000 = **₹18.00**

B3 (Moderate) — EBQ + Number of Set-ups

Annual demand **D = 40,000** units; Set-up cost **S = ₹250** per batch; Carrying cost **C = ₹2** per unit p.a. Find EBQ, number of set-ups, and total relevant cost. Verify set-up cost = carrying cost.

Solution. $$EBQ = \sqrt{\frac{2 \times 40{,}000 \times 250}{2}} = \sqrt{\frac{2{,}00{,}00{,}000}{2}} = \sqrt{1{,}00{,}00{,}000} = \textbf{3{,}162 units (approx)}$$

Using EBQ ≈ 3,162: - No. of set-ups = 40,000 ÷ 3,162 = **12.65 ≈ 13** - Set-up cost = 12.65 × 250 = **₹3,162** - Carrying cost = (3,162 ÷ 2) × 2 = **₹3,162** - **Total relevant cost = ₹6,324** (set-up = carrying ✓, confirming optimum)

B4 (Moderate) — Comprehensive Unit Cost Statement with WIP & Stock

Output **10,000 units**. Data (₹): Raw material consumed 3,00,000; Direct wages 2,00,000; Works overhead 1,00,000; Admin overhead 60,000; Selling & distribution overhead 40,000. Opening finished stock **500 units** valued at ₹28,000; Closing finished stock **1,000 units** (valued at current cost of production). Units sold accordingly. Selling price ₹75 per unit. Prepare a cost sheet and find profit.

Solution — Cost Sheet. | Particulars | ₹ | |---|---| | Raw material consumed | 3,00,000 | | Direct wages | 2,00,000 | | **Prime Cost** | **5,00,000** | | Works overhead | 1,00,000 | | **Works/Factory Cost** | **6,00,000** | | Admin overhead | 60,000 | | **Cost of Production (10,000 units)** | **6,60,000** |

Cost of production per unit = 6,60,000 ÷ 10,000 = **₹66**.

Stock reconciliation (units): Opening 500 + Produced 10,000 − Closing 1,000 = **Units sold 9,500**.

Particulars	₹
Cost of Production (10,000 units)	6,60,000
Add: Opening finished stock (500 units)	28,000
Less: Closing finished stock (1,000 × ₹66)	(66,000)
Cost of Goods Sold (9,500 units)	**6,22,000**
Add: Selling & distribution overhead	40,000
Cost of Sales	**6,62,000**
Sales (9,500 × ₹75)	7,12,500
Profit	**50,500**

Self-check: Sales 7,12,500 − Cost of Sales 6,62,000 = **₹50,500 ✓**.

B5 (Exam-hard) — EBQ with cost comparison at different batch sizes

A company uses component X: Annual demand **90,000 units**; Set-up cost **₹1,350** per batch; Cost of manufacture ₹5 per unit; Carrying cost **20% of unit cost per annum**. (i) Compute EBQ. (ii) Show total cost (set-up + carrying) at batch sizes 6,000 and at EBQ, proving EBQ is cheaper.

Solution. Carrying cost C = 20% × ₹5 = **₹1 per unit p.a.** $$EBQ = \sqrt{\frac{2 \times 90{,}000 \times 1{,}350}{1}} = \sqrt{24{,}30{,}00{,}000} = \textbf{15{,}588 units (approx)}$$

At EBQ = 15,588: - Set-ups = 90,000 ÷ 15,588 = 5.774 → Set-up cost = 5.774 × 1,350 = **₹7,794** - Carrying = (15,588 ÷ 2) × 1 = **₹7,794** - **Total = ₹15,588**

At batch = 6,000: - Set-ups = 90,000 ÷ 6,000 = 15 → Set-up cost = 15 × 1,350 = **₹20,250** - Carrying = (6,000 ÷ 2) × 1 = **₹3,000** - **Total = ₹23,250**

EBQ total ₹15,588 < ₹23,250 at 6,000 → **EBQ minimises total cost ✓** (set-up = carrying only at EBQ).

B6 (Exam-hard) — Batch costing with selling price / profit per batch

A pharma firm makes tablets in batches of **10,000**. Per batch: Direct material ₹15,000; Direct labour 500 hrs @ ₹40; Set-up cost ₹3,000. Factory overhead ₹30 per labour hour; Selling overhead 10% of factory cost. Selling price ₹6 per tablet. Find cost per tablet and profit per batch.

Solution. - Direct labour = 500 × 40 = ₹20,000 - Factory overhead = 500 × 30 = ₹15,000 - **Factory cost** = Material 15,000 + Labour 20,000 + Set-up 3,000 + FOH 15,000 = **₹53,000** - Selling overhead = 10% × 53,000 = ₹5,300 - **Total cost of batch** = 53,000 + 5,300 = **₹58,300** - Cost per tablet = 58,300 ÷ 10,000 = **₹5.83** - Sales = 10,000 × ₹6 = ₹60,000 - **Profit per batch = 60,000 − 58,300 = ₹1,700** (₹0.17 per tablet) ✓

Section C — Past-Paper-Style Full Questions

C1. (Unit Costing — full cost sheet with quotation)

A factory produces a standard product. In a period 2,000 units were made. Costs: Direct materials ₹4,00,000; Direct wages ₹2,50,000; Direct expenses ₹50,000; Factory overhead 60% of direct wages; Admin overhead 20% of works cost. A customer asks for a quotation for 300 units at the same cost structure plus a profit of 25% on selling price. Prepare the cost sheet and quotation.

Model Answer — Cost Sheet (2,000 units).

Particulars	₹	Per unit ₹
Direct materials	4,00,000	200
Direct wages	2,50,000	125
Direct expenses	50,000	25
Prime Cost	**7,00,000**	**350**
Factory OH (60% of wages)	1,50,000	75
Works Cost	**8,50,000**	**425**
Admin OH (20% of works cost)	1,70,000	85
Cost of Production	**10,20,000**	**510**

Quotation for 300 units:
- Cost of production = 300 × ₹510 = **₹1,53,000**
- Profit = 25% on selling price = 1/3 of cost = 1,53,000 × 25/75 = **₹51,000**
- **Quoted price (300 units) = ₹2,04,000 → ₹680 per unit**

Check: Profit ₹51,000 ÷ Sales ₹2,04,000 = 25% ✓.

C2. (Batch Costing / EBQ — full)

Monthly demand for a part is 2,000 units (annual 24,000). Setting up the machine for a batch costs ₹324. Annual carrying cost is ₹1 per unit. (i) Determine EBQ. (ii) If the supplier offers a 2% discount on material cost of ₹10/unit for a minimum batch of 4,000, evaluate whether to accept, considering only set-up + carrying + discount saving.

Model Answer. $$EBQ = \sqrt{\frac{2 \times 24{,}000 \times 324}{1}} = \sqrt{1{,}55{,}52{,}000} = \textbf{3{,}944 units (approx)}$$

Cost at EBQ 3,944:
- Set-ups = 24,000 ÷ 3,944 = 6.085 → ₹6.085 × 324 = ₹1,972
- Carrying = 3,944/2 × 1 = ₹1,972 → **Total = ₹3,944**

Cost at batch 4,000 (to earn discount):
- Set-ups = 24,000 ÷ 4,000 = 6 → 6 × 324 = ₹1,944
- Carrying = 4,000/2 × 1 = ₹2,000 → Sub-total = ₹3,944
- Extra set-up+carrying vs EBQ ≈ **nil (₹3,944 vs ₹3,944)**

Discount saving = 2% × ₹10 × 24,000 = **₹4,800 p.a.**

Conclusion: Batch of 4,000 keeps set-up+carrying virtually unchanged (₹3,944) while gaining a discount of ₹4,800. **Accept the 4,000-unit batch.**

C3. (Unit Costing — cost per unit with by-product/scrap adjustment)

A brick kiln fired 5,00,000 bricks. Costs: Clay ₹1,50,000; Labour ₹1,00,000; Fuel ₹75,000; Other works OH ₹25,000. Broken bricks (scrap) realised ₹10,000, credited to works cost. Find works cost per 1,000 bricks.

Model Answer.

Particulars	₹
Clay	1,50,000
Labour	1,00,000
Fuel	75,000
Other works OH	25,000
Gross Works Cost	**3,50,000**
Less: Scrap realised	(10,000)
Net Works Cost	**3,40,000**

Cost per 1,000 bricks = 3,40,000 ÷ (5,00,000/1,000) = 3,40,000 ÷ 500 = **₹680 per 1,000 bricks** (₹0.68 each).

Section D — MCQs & Case Scenarios

D1. Batch costing is a variant of: A) Process costing B) Job costing C) Operating costing D) Unit costing **Ans: B** — a batch is a group of identical jobs, so batch costing extends job (specific-order) costing.

D2. At Economic Batch Quantity: A) Set-up cost is minimum B) Carrying cost is minimum C) Set-up cost = Carrying cost D) Total cost is maximum **Ans: C** — EBQ is where set-up cost equals carrying cost, giving minimum total.

D3. If annual demand doubles (others constant), EBQ becomes: A) Doubles B) Halves C) Rises by √2 (≈1.414×) D) Unchanged **Ans: C** — EBQ ∝ √D, so doubling D multiplies EBQ by √2.

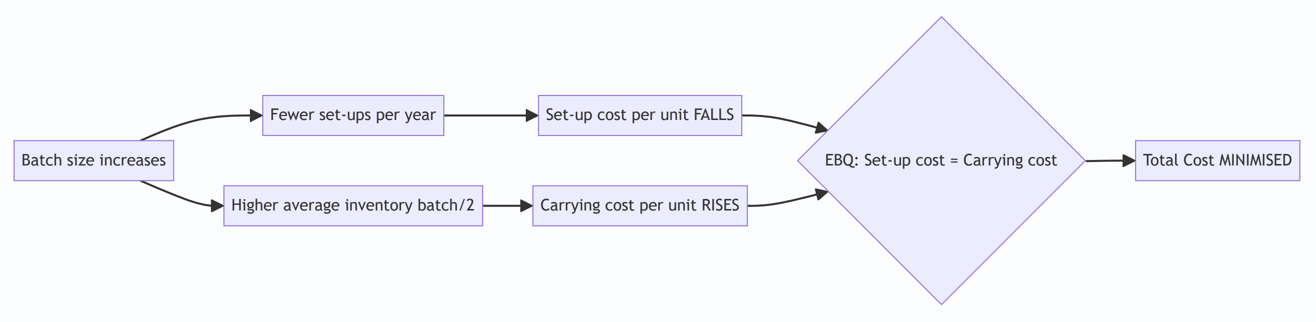
D4. Unit costing is most suitable for: A) A garment factory making varied designs B) A ship-building yard C) A cement factory D) An advertising agency **Ans: C** — cement is a single homogeneous continuous product.

D5. In EBQ, carrying cost is computed on: A) Full batch size B) Average inventory (batch ÷ 2) C) Annual demand D) Number of set-ups **Ans: B** — average stock over the batch cycle is batch/2.

D6 (Case). A toy maker has D = 1,00,000; S = ₹800; C = ₹4/unit p.a. The production manager wants batches of 5,000 "for convenience." As cost accountant, advise. - EBQ = √(2×1,00,000×800 ÷ 4) = √(4,00,00,000) = **6,325 units**. - Total cost at EBQ = set-up (1,00,000/6,325 × 800 = ₹12,649) + carrying (6,325/2 × 4 = ₹12,649) = **₹25,298**. - Total cost at 5,000 = set-up (20 × 800 = ₹16,000) + carrying (5,000/2 × 4 = ₹10,000) = **₹26,000**. **Advice:** EBQ 6,325 saves ₹702 p.a. over the 5,000 batch; recommend batches of ~6,325. ✓

D7. Which cost is *added after* cost of production to reach cost of sales? A) Factory overhead B) Direct expenses C) Selling & distribution overhead D) Set-up cost **Ans: C** — S&D overhead converts cost of production (of goods sold) into cost of sales.

EBQ Trade-off — Mermaid Diagram



Quick Formula Recap

- **Unit cost** = Total Cost ÷ Units produced
- **Cost of Production** = Prime Cost + Factory OH + Admin OH (± WIP)
- **Cost of Sales** = Cost of Goods Sold + S&D OH
- **Batch cost per unit** = Total Batch Cost ÷ Units in batch
- **EBQ** = √(2DS ÷ C); **No. of set-ups** = D ÷ EBQ; at optimum **Set-up cost = Carrying cost**

Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Carrying cost on batch/2, not full batch** — average inventory only.
2. **C may be given as % of unit cost** — convert to ₹ per unit first (e.g. 20% of ₹5 = ₹1).
3. **Annualise demand** — if monthly demand given, multiply by 12 before EBQ.
4. **Closing stock valued at current cost of production**, not selling price.
5. **Set-up cost belongs to factory cost** in a batch cost sheet, not selling overhead.
6. **Profit "on selling price" vs "on cost"** — 25% on price = 1/3 of cost.

Chapter 09 — Job & Contract Costing

1. The Problem: When "Average Cost Per Unit" Becomes a Lie

Imagine two factories.

The first is a sugar mill. Cane goes in one end; identical bags of sugar come out the other. Every kilo is indistinguishable from every other kilo. If the mill spent ₹50,00,000 this month and produced 10,00,000 kg, the cost per kg is ₹5. Clean. Honest. This is the world of **process/unit costing** (Chapter 10's territory).

The second is a printing press. On Monday it prints 5,000 wedding cards on gold-foil stock. On Tuesday it prints 2,00,000 election pamphlets on cheap newsprint. On Wednesday it prints a 400-page hardcover annual report. If you spent ₹8,00,000 this week producing "3 jobs," what is your "cost per job"? ₹2,66,666 each? That number is **meaningless and dangerous**. It would tell you the wedding cards and the pamphlets cost the same — so you'd quote the same price and lose money on one while overcharging on the other.

The core problem: **when output is heterogeneous — each unit or batch is different, made to a specific customer's order — averaging destroys information.** The manager cannot answer the only questions that matter:

- What did *this specific order* actually cost me?
- Did I make or lose money on the Sharma wedding job?
- What should I quote the next customer who walks in with a similar request?

And there is a harder, second-order version of this problem. Consider a company building the Bandra–Worli sea link. That single "job" takes **four years**. Money pours out continuously — steel, concrete, labour, cranes — but the customer pays in stages, and the profit isn't "realised" until... when? Do you show zero profit for three years and then a giant lump in year four (which is absurd — the work *was* being done and value *was* being created)? Or do you book profit every year (which is dangerous — the contract could still go wrong)?

This chapter builds the two costing systems that solve exactly these problems:

- **Job Costing** — for heterogeneous, customer-specific work where each order is a distinct cost object.
- **Contract Costing** — job costing scaled up for *large, long-duration* jobs, plus the special machinery to answer the "how much profit dare I recognise on an unfinished contract?" question.

Everything else in this chapter — the job cost sheet, the contract account, work certified, retention money, notional profit, the prudence formulas — is machinery invented to answer those questions honestly.

A third, subtler cost of averaging — bad decisions ripple outward. A wrong per-unit number doesn't just mis-price one order. It corrupts every downstream decision built on it: which product lines to push, whether to accept a rush order, whether to make-or-buy a component, how to reward the sales team. In a job shop, the *entire management-accounting nervous system* runs on accurate per-job cost. That is why job costing is not merely a bookkeeping style — it is the information backbone of any custom-order business. Hold this in mind: the whole chapter is about *keeping information un-averaged so decisions stay honest.*

---

2. The Core Idea: A Separate Wallet for Every Order

Here is the entire concept in one image.

In process costing you have **one big bucket**. All costs flow in; you divide by units at the end.

In job costing you have **a wallet for every order**. The moment a customer places an order, you staple a fresh envelope to the wall and write a job number on it. Every rupee of material, every hour of labour, every slice of overhead that this order consumes gets dropped into *that envelope*. When the job ships, you empty the envelope, total it, and that total is the true cost of that job — no averaging, no contamination from other orders.

> **Analogy — the restaurant bill.** A canteen with a fixed thali is process costing: one price, everyone pays the same. A à-la-carte restaurant is job costing: the waiter opens a fresh **bill (KOT)** for your table, and *only your dishes* go on it. My paneer tikka does not subsidise your biryani. The bill *is* the job cost sheet.

Contract costing is the same envelope idea — but the envelope is so big it becomes its own ledger account. A four-year bridge doesn't get a slip of paper; it gets a full **Contract Account** in the books, opened on day one and kept alive across accounting years until the bridge is handed over. Because it straddles multiple year-ends, we must pause each March and ask: "of the profit sitting in this envelope so far, how much is *safe* to take to the P&L?"

That single question — **how to slice profit off an unfinished, uncertain, long job without lying to shareholders** — is what makes contract costing conceptually rich. The rest is bookkeeping.

Job vs Batch vs Contract — one family, three sizes. All three share the same DNA (tag every cost to a unique identifier and never average across identifiers). What separates them is *the shape of the cost object*:

Feature	Job Costing	Batch Costing	Contract Costing
Cost object	One order / lot	One batch of identical units	One large contract
Typical duration	Days to weeks	Days	Months to years
Location	Inside the factory	Inside the factory	At the customer's site
Cost profile	Mix of direct + absorbed OH	Mix of direct + absorbed OH	Overwhelmingly **direct** cost
Special question	—	Optimal batch size (EBQ)	Interim profit on incomplete work
Record	Job cost sheet	Batch cost sheet	Contract Account (ledger)
Per-unit cost?	Rarely (order = 1 thing)	Yes: batch cost ÷ units	No (contract is unique)

Read this table as a *spectrum of scale*, not three unrelated topics. Every time the examiner blends them (e.g., "a job done at a client's premises," or "a batch produced against a specific order"), you decide by asking *which identifier owns this rupee?*

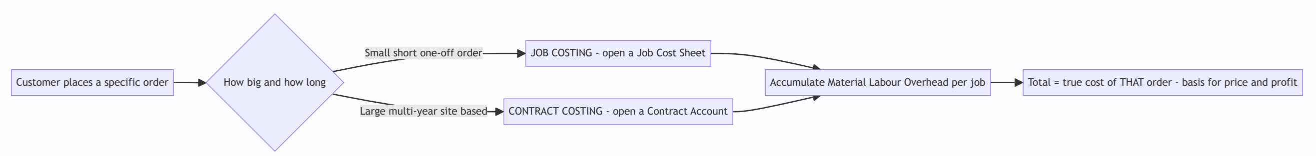


Figure 1 — The decision that selects the method: heterogeneity plus scale/duration.

---

3. Why It's Built This Way

Before a single formula, understand the *design logic*. Every feature exists to protect a specific truth.

Why a separate cost object per order? Because the customer is buying *this* thing, not an average of things. Pricing, profitability analysis, and quoting all collapse if you can't isolate one order's cost. So the whole system is built around a **unique identifier** (job number / contract number) that acts like a bank account number — everything tagged to it, nothing leaking.

Why does contract costing need extra machinery that job costing doesn't? Three physical facts about big contracts force it:

1. **They cross accounting years.** A one-week print job starts and finishes inside one period — recognise profit when done, no drama. A bridge doesn't. Accounting demands we report profit *annually*, but the job isn't finished annually. Conflict → we need a rule for interim profit.
2. **Most costs are direct.** On a construction site, nearly everything — labour, plant hired to the site, site supervisor's salary, materials delivered to the gate — is *directly* traceable to that one contract. So contract costing has **very little overhead apportionment** and instead obsesses over site-level direct cost control. This is why the contract account looks "purer" than a job cost sheet.
3. **The customer controls payment through certification.** The client's architect/surveyor **certifies** how much work is genuinely done, pays a percentage of that, and *holds back the rest* (retention) as a hostage against defects. This external, cautious valuation becomes the anchor for how much revenue — and therefore profit — we're allowed to recognise.

Why prudence (caution) dominates profit recognition? Because an unfinished contract is a *promise*, not a fact. Steel prices could spike, the ground could flood, the client could dispute quality, penalties could bite. If you booked the full apparent profit each year and the contract later soured, you'd have paid dividends and tax on profit that evaporated. Accounting's **prudence concept** says: *anticipate no profit, but provide for all losses.* So the machinery deliberately recognises **only a fraction** of the profit earned so far, keeping the rest as a cushion — and the *less complete and less certain* the contract, the *smaller* that fraction. That single principle generates every profit-transfer formula you'll memorise.

Why is job costing "expensive" to run — and when is that worth it? Tagging every requisition and every labour hour to a job number costs real clerical effort. In a homogeneous plant that overhead is pure waste — process costing is cheaper and just as accurate. Job costing earns its keep *only when orders genuinely differ*, because that is exactly when the extra information changes decisions. This is the first-principles justification for the whole method: **the value of un-averaged information must exceed the cost of collecting it.** An examiner testing "distinguish job from process costing" is really testing whether you understand this trade-off, not just the surface differences.

Why does the contractor, not the client, keep the Contract Account? Because the contractor is the one *incurring* the cost and *bearing* the outcome risk. The client merely pays certified instalments and records an asset/expense. Contract costing is always written from the **contractor's books** — a point worth fixing early, because every debit (cost) and credit (value + closing balances) makes sense only from the builder's seat, not the customer's.

Hold that thought — "the fraction shrinks with uncertainty" — and the formulas in Part 4 will feel inevitable rather than arbitrary.

4. Full Technical Content

4A. Job Costing — the mechanics

Definition. Job costing is a method where costs are accumulated and ascertained for each **job / work order / lot**, which is treated as a distinct cost unit. Used by: printers, machine-tool makers, foundries, repair garages, ship repair, interior contractors, advertising agencies, made-to-order furniture, engineering fabricators.

Distinguishing features (the exam "list" question). Job costing exists wherever: (i) production is against **specific customer orders**, not for stock; (ii) each job is **distinct and separable**; (iii) jobs pass through the same departments but in **different sequences/quantities**; (iv) cost is compiled **by job, not by period**; and (v) **WIP** at any date is simply the total of open (unfinished) job cost sheets. If you can recite these five, you can answer any "features of job costing" theory question.

Job costing vs process costing — the crisp contrast:

Basis	Job Costing	Process Costing
Cost unit	A job / order	A process / operation, then per unit
Output	Heterogeneous, custom	Homogeneous, standardised
Cost collection	By job	By process, over a period
WIP	Individual unfinished jobs	Equivalent units in each process
Cost transfer	Job to job? No	Output of one process → input of next
Averaging	Avoided (destroys info)	The whole point
Control focus	Each job's profitability	Process efficiency, normal/abnormal loss

The three cost elements per job:

Element	How captured	Source document
Direct Materials	Materials issued against the job number	Material Requisition Note / Bill of Materials
Direct Labour	Hours booked to the job × wage rate	Job Time Ticket / Time Sheet
Direct Expenses	Special tools, hired equipment, sub-contract for that job	Invoices tagged to job
Production Overhead	Absorbed using a predetermined rate (e.g., ₹/labour-hr, % of wages, machine-hr rate)	Overhead absorption (see Ch. on Overheads)

The Job Cost Sheet is the beating heart — one per job:

```
Prime Cost      = Direct Material + Direct Labour + Direct Expenses
Works/Factory Cost = Prime Cost + Production (Works) Overhead
Cost of Production = Works Cost + Administration Overhead
Total Cost / Cost of Sales = Cost of Production + Selling & Distribution Overhead
Price to customer = Total Cost + Profit (or Total Cost + markup %)
```

Integration with the ledger (WIP control): In an integrated accounting system, each job is a sub-account of **Work-in-Progress Control**. Journal logic:

- Materials issued to job: `Dr WIP Control / Cr Stores Ledger Control`
- Direct wages: `Dr WIP Control / Cr Wages Control`
- Overhead absorbed: `Dr WIP Control / Cr Production OH Control`
- Job completed: `Dr Finished Goods (or Cost of Sales) / Cr WIP Control`

Over/under-absorption of overhead is dealt with separately (see Overheads chapter) — the job carries *absorbed* (predetermined) overhead, not actual.

Job costing and spoilage/rework — a finer distinction the exam tests. When a specific job is spoiled by a *general* factory cause (normal, spread across all jobs), the loss is absorbed into overhead and recovered from *all* jobs. But when spoilage/rework arises from a **customer's own special specification** (e.g., an unusual tolerance the client insisted on), the rework cost is charged **directly to that job**, because it belongs to that job alone. Same logic as everywhere in this chapter: *keep the cost with the identifier that caused it.*

> **Batch Costing — a first cousin.** When identical articles are produced in *batches* (e.g., 10,000 identical pharma tablets, or 500 identical bolts), the *batch* is the job. Cost per unit = Total batch cost ÷ units in batch. This is where the **Economic Batch Quantity (EBQ)** appears:
>
> **EBQ = $\sqrt{(2 \times D \times S \div C)}$** where D = annual demand, S = set-up cost per batch, C = carrying cost per unit per year.
>
> It's identical in spirit to the EOQ formula — trade off set-up cost (favours big batches) against carrying cost (favours small batches). Batch costing = job costing applied to a group of identical units.

EBQ — the finer points examiners exploit. - **Number of set-ups per year** = D ÷ EBQ; **total annual set-up cost** = (D ÷ EBQ) × S; **total annual carrying cost** = (EBQ ÷ 2) × C. At the optimum, set-up cost = carrying cost — a self-check worth stating in the answer. - If C is given as a **percentage of unit cost** rather than an absolute ₹, first convert: C = % × cost per unit. A common trap is to plug the percentage straight in. - If a **production rate** is given and the batch is consumed while still being produced, some texts adjust C by a factor (1 − d/p) where d = demand rate and p = production rate. Flag this only if the question provides both rates; otherwise use the plain EBQ. *Verify against the version in current ICAI material.*

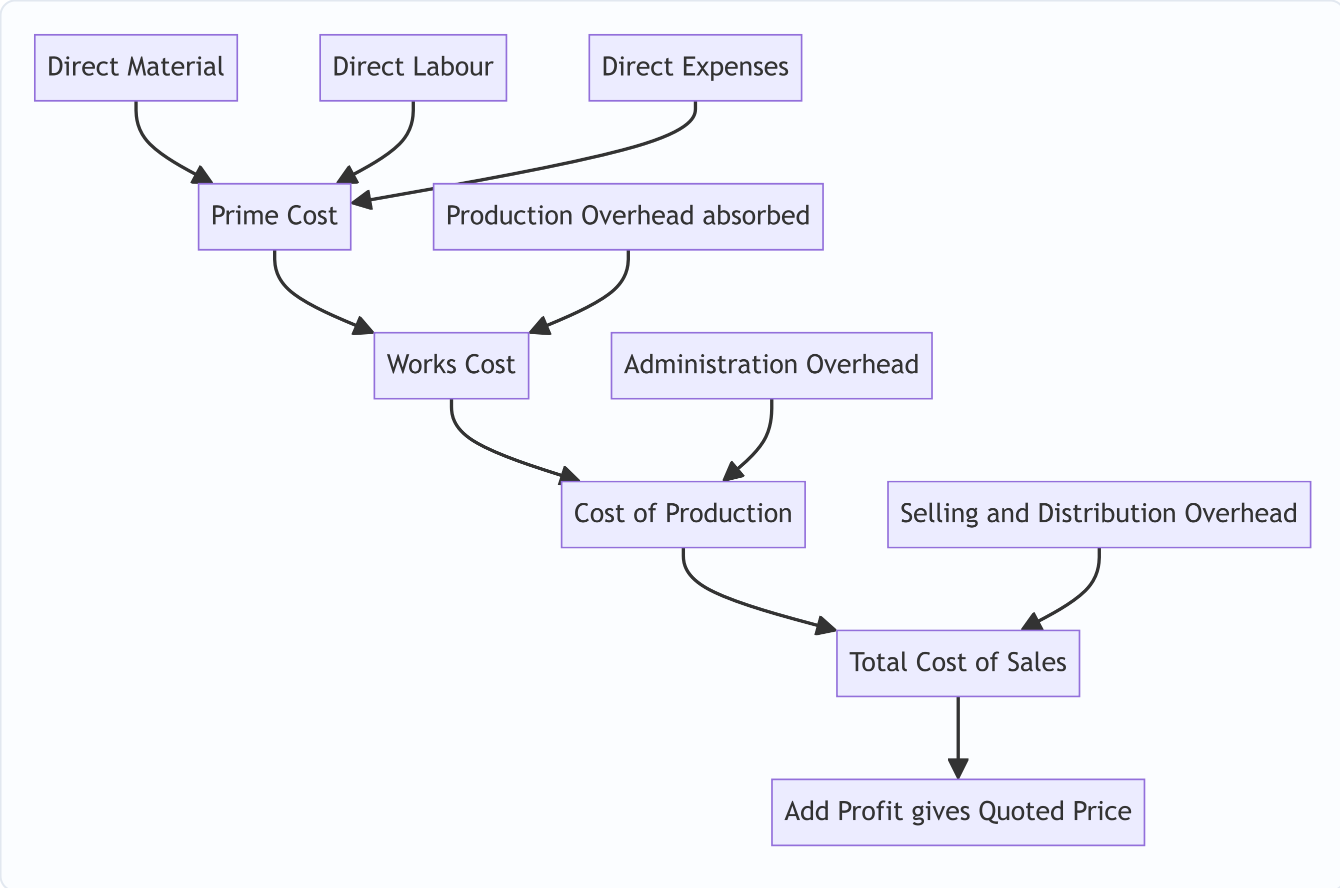


Figure 2 — Build-up of the job cost sheet from prime cost to quoted price.

4B. Contract Costing — the mechanics

Contract costing is job costing for **large, site-based, long-duration** jobs. Same DNA (accumulate costs against a unique number), but with its own vocabulary and its own profit rule.

The Contract Account is a running account for each contract. Broadly:

Debit side (costs incurred to date): - Materials issued / purchased for site - Direct wages (incl. accrued/outstanding wages) - Direct expenses - Plant & machinery sent to site (or depreciation on plant — see below) - Sub-contract costs - Cost of extra/additional work - Apportioned share of head-office overhead (small)

Credit side (values and closing positions): - Material returned to stores / transferred / at site (closing) - Plant at site (closing WDV) if plant was debited at cost - Materials sold (proceeds) and any profit/loss on such sale routed appropriately - **Work-in-Progress: Work Certified + Work Uncertified** (the big one)

The balancing figure is **Notional Profit** (or loss) to date.

Materials — the six things that can happen to them (a favourite exam checklist). Material charged to a contract may be: (1) **consumed** in the work (stays as cost); (2) **at site unused** at year-end (credit: materials at site c/d); (3) **returned to stores** (credit: to stores); (4) **transferred to another contract** (credit here, debit the other contract); (5) **sold** (credit sale proceeds; any profit/loss on sale is transferred to P&L, *not* left inside the contract, because it isn't contract profit); (6) **lost/stolen/destroyed** (an abnormal loss — write off to Costing P&L, don't let it inflate contract cost). Mishandling any one of these six is a classic mark-loser.

Key vocabulary — and why each exists

Contract Price — the total agreed price for the whole job. This is *not* revenue-to-date; it's the finish line.

Work Certified — the value (at contract/selling price) of work the client's architect/surveyor has **inspected and approved** to date. This is an *independent, cautious* measure of progress, expressed in *price* terms (it includes profit). It's the anchor for everything.

Work Uncertified — work physically done but *not yet* certified (too recent, or below a certification milestone). It's carried at **cost** (no profit), prudently, because the client hasn't blessed it yet.

Retention Money — the client pays only a percentage of work certified (say 80–90%) and **retains the balance** for a defects-liability period. - **Cash received = Work Certified × (1 − retention %)** - Retention money = Work Certified − Cash received. *Why it exists:* it's the client's insurance. If defects appear, they fix them out of the retained sum. For us, it means even *certified* revenue isn't fully in hand — a second reason for caution.

Notional Profit — the *apparent* profit to date, before applying prudence:

> **Notional Profit = (Work Certified + Work Uncertified) − Cost of work done to date**
>
> Equivalently: **Value of Work Done − Cost of Work Done**, where Value of Work Done = Work Certified + Work Uncertified, and Cost of Work Done = costs incurred to date *less* the cost of materials/plant remaining at site (i.e., only cost *consumed* in the work certified + uncertified).

It's called *notional* precisely because we are **not** going to take all of it — prudence forbids.

Estimated Total Profit — used when the contract is near completion and reliable estimates of remaining cost exist:

> **Estimated Total Profit = Contract Price − (Costs to date + Estimated additional costs to complete)**

Plant treatment — two methods: - **Method 1 (short contracts / plant temporarily at site):** Debit contract with *cost of plant*; credit *closing WDV of plant at site*. The difference (= depreciation) is effectively the cost charged. - **Method 2 (long contracts):** Debit contract only with **depreciation** on plant for the period. Cleaner for multi-year contracts. - **Plant hired (not owned):** if plant is *hired* to the site, only the **hire charges** are debited — no cost-in/WDV-out entry, because the contractor never owns it. Watch for this switch in the data. - **Plant sold or returned mid-year:** credit the contract with sale proceeds or the WDV of plant removed; any profit/loss on sale of owned plant goes to Costing P&L, not into contract profit.

Cost-plus contracts — a distinct sub-type. Where future costs are too uncertain to fix a price (defence, novel engineering, emergency work), the contract price = **allowable cost + an agreed profit** (a fixed fee or a % of cost). *Why it exists:* it shifts inflation/uncertainty risk from contractor to client, so the contractor accepts work he'd otherwise refuse. Exam angles: (i) which costs are "allowable" is defined in the contract and often disputed; (ii) a **cost-plus-percentage** contract perversely *rewards* the contractor for spending more, so clients cap it or prefer cost-plus-*fixed-fee*; (iii) the contractor's books must be open to the client's audit. Contrast this with a **fixed-price contract**, where the escalation clause (4D) is the safety valve instead.

4C. The Heart of the Chapter — How Much Profit Dare We Recognise?

This is *the* examinable idea. The rule scales the recognised profit to the **degree of completion** and the **certainty** of the outcome. Degree of completion is measured as:

> **% of completion = Work Certified ÷ Contract Price × 100**

Now the prudence ladder — memorise the *logic*, and the formulas write themselves. **The less complete the contract, the smaller the fraction of notional profit you keep; and always further discount by cash actually received (retention risk).**

Stage 1 — Completion is trivially small (less than 25%):

> **Transfer NIL profit.** Take nothing. The outcome is too uncertain to trust any profit. (Some texts say "less than 25%".)

Stage 2 — Completion ≥ 25% but < 50%:

> **Profit to P&L = ⅓ × Notional Profit × (Cash Received ÷ Work Certified)**

Stage 3 — Completion ≥ 50% but < 90% (the standard case):

> **Profit to P&L = ⅔ × Notional Profit × (Cash Received ÷ Work Certified)**

Stage 4 — Completion ≥ 90% (near completion) — switch to Estimated Total Profit basis. Now the outcome is reasonably certain, so we use the *whole-contract* estimate, scaled by progress. Any of these formulas (whichever the question specifies / provides data for):

> (a) Estimated Profit × (Work Certified ÷ Contract Price) (b) Estimated Profit × (Work Certified ÷ Contract Price) × (Cash Received ÷ Work Certified) = Estimated Profit × (Cash Received ÷ Contract Price) (c) Estimated Profit × (Cost of Work to Date ÷ Estimated Total Cost) (d) Estimated Profit × (Cost of Work to Date ÷ Estimated Total Cost) × (Cash Received ÷ Work Certified)

Why the two recurring multipliers? - The **⅓ or ⅔ fraction** = a blunt prudence haircut that grows more generous as completion rises (more done → more trust → keep a bigger share). - The **(Cash Received ÷ Work Certified)** factor = a *second* haircut for retention risk: you can only bank profit proportionate to cash you've actually collected, not cash the client is holding back.

A subtlety on the boundaries. The bands are **conventions, not law** — different textbooks draw the line at "less than ¼" vs "up to ¼," and some jump straight to the estimated-profit basis at 50%+ if a reliable estimate exists. In the exam: (i) if the question quotes a policy, follow *it*; (ii) otherwise use the ladder above and **state your assumption in one line**. Examiners award the marks for the *reasoning and the stated basis*, not for a single "correct" fraction. Never leave the basis unstated.

Which of the four ≥90% formulas do I pick? Decide by the *data given*: - Given **estimated cost to complete** → you can build Estimated Total Profit → use (a)/(b). - Given a natural **cost-ratio** (cost to date and estimated total cost) → use (c)/(d). - If **cash received** is provided and the question stresses prudence → use the *cash-adjusted* version (b) or (d). - When in doubt, present the **most prudent** figure and note the alternative — as in Example 3.

Loss rule — asymmetric on purpose. Prudence says *provide for all losses immediately and in full.* If the contract shows a **notional loss**, transfer the **entire loss** to the P&L now, regardless of completion %. If it's a small contract expected to end in loss, provide the whole foreseeable loss. No fractions, no cash-ratio softening for losses. This asymmetry (fraction the profits, full the losses) IS the prudence concept in action.

Two flavours of loss — don't conflate them. 1. **Notional loss to date** (Cost of work done > Value of work done): transfer the full amount now. 2. **Foreseeable/estimated loss on the whole contract** (Estimated Total Cost > Contract Price): even if the work *so far* shows a notional profit, if the *whole contract* is heading for a loss, you must **provide the entire estimated loss immediately**. This is the harsher, higher-order application of prudence and a favourite twist — a contract that looks profitable today but is doomed overall must be written down now.

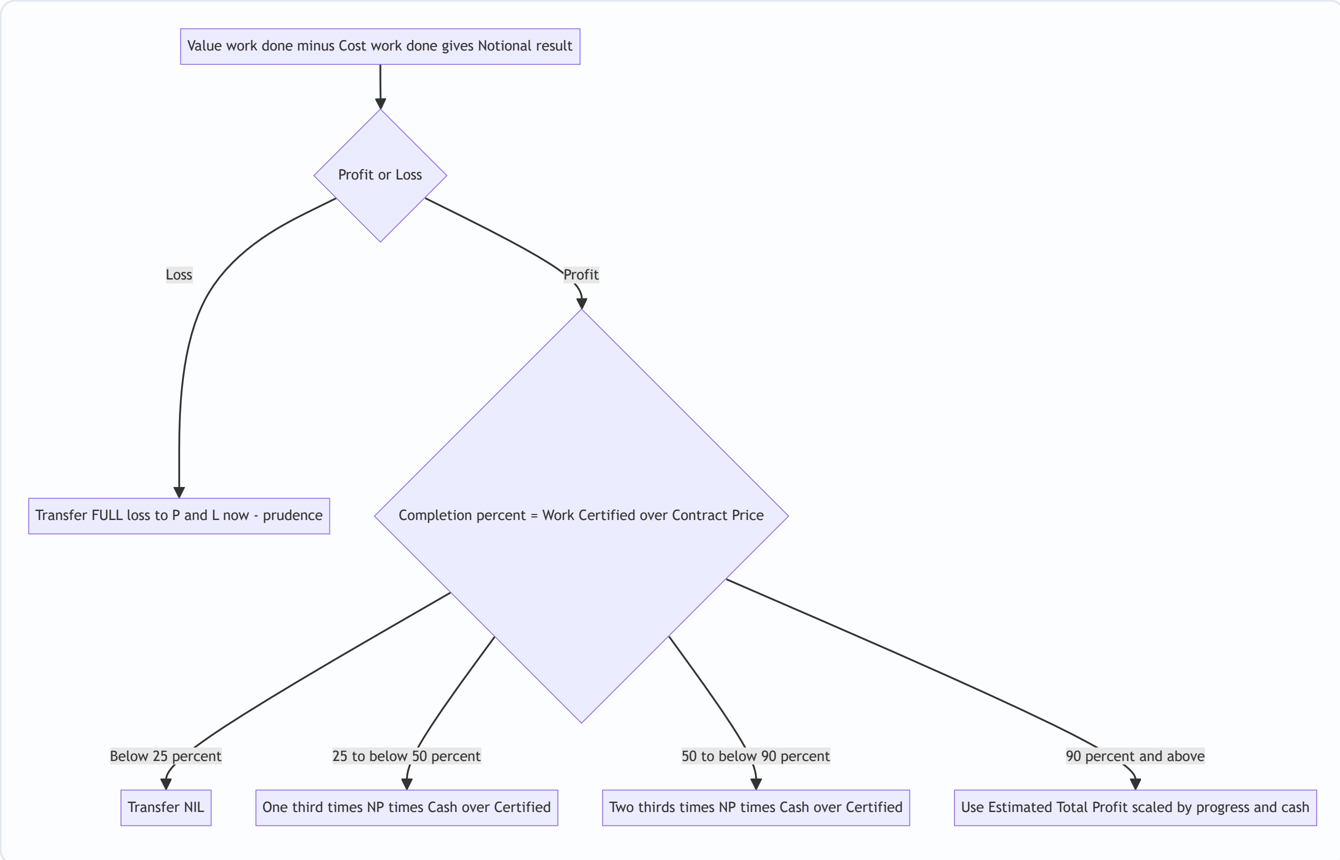


Figure 3 — The prudence decision tree for profit on incomplete contracts.

Where does the un-recognised profit go? It stays inside the contract as a **reserve/provision**, shown by *reducing WIP* in the Balance Sheet:

> **WIP on Balance Sheet = (Work Certified + Work Uncertified) − Profit taken to P&L − Cash received (i.e., less advances)**
>
> Common presentation: Balance Sheet WIP = Cost of work done + Profit recognised − Cash received. The reserve = Notional Profit − Profit recognised.

Both presentations give the *same* number — a fact worth proving to yourself once (and used as a reconciliation check in Example 2). The first says "value minus what's been taken out minus what's been received"; the second says "cost still tied up plus the sliver of profit we kept minus cash collected." They are algebraically identical because Value of Work Done = Cost of Work Done + Notional Profit.

4D. Escalation Clause — pricing insurance against inflation

On a multi-year contract at a *fixed* price, the contractor bears a brutal risk: what if cement, steel, and wages *rise* over four years? He'd be locked into yesterday's price with tomorrow's costs. The **escalation clause** is the contractual answer.

Escalation clause: a term allowing the contract price to be **increased** if prices of specified materials / labour / utilities rise beyond an agreed base level. It protects the *contractor*. (The mirror image, a **de-escalation clause**, reduces the price if input costs *fall* — protecting the *client*.)

Mechanism (standard exam form): The claim is computed on the **agreed/standard consumption** at the base rate vs actual rate — *not* on actual (wasteful) consumption, so the contractor can't pass on his own inefficiency.

> **Escalation claim = Σ [Standard Qty allowed × (Actual Rate − Base Rate)]**

Only *rate* increases on the *standard quantity* are claimable. Extra quantity used due to the contractor's own waste is *not* reimbursed — that would reward inefficiency.

The finer variations examiners layer on: - **Quantity-linked "standard" allowance.** The "standard quantity allowed" is often the quantity that *should* have been consumed for the *work actually done* — so if only 60% of the work is complete, base the claim on 60% of the total standard quantity, not the full contract's standard quantity. Read the completion carefully. - **Both rate and permitted quantity vary.** Some questions give a formula referencing a labour/material *index*. Apply the index to the base cost of the *agreed* quantity. - **De-escalation working alongside escalation.** If steel rose but cement *fell*, the claim nets the rise on steel *against* the fall on cement (when the clause is symmetric). Don't reflexively ignore the cheaper input. - **Escalation is added to the contract price**, which in turn feeds "% completion" and the profit formulas — so an escalation claim can nudge a contract into a different profit band. Rare, but a beautiful trap.

---

5. Worked Examples (fully reconciled)

Example 1 — Job Costing (easy): Building a quotation

Vishwakarma Fabricators received an enquiry for a custom steel gate (Job J-217). Estimate the price at 20% profit on selling price.

Data: Direct material ₹40,000; Direct labour 300 hrs @ ₹50/hr; Direct expense (special powder-coating hire) ₹6,000. Works overhead absorbed @ ₹30 per labour hour. Administration overhead @ 10% of works cost. Selling & distribution overhead @ 5% of works cost.

Job Cost Sheet — J-217

Particulars	Working	₹
Direct Material		40,000
Direct Labour	300 × 50	15,000
Direct Expenses		6,000
Prime Cost		**61,000**
Works Overhead	300 × 30	9,000
Works Cost		**70,000**
Administration OH	10% × 70,000	7,000
Cost of Production		**77,000**
Selling & Distribution OH	5% × 70,000	3,500
Total Cost		**80,500**
Profit	see below	20,125
Selling Price (Quotation)		**1,00,625**

Profit on selling price means Cost = 80% of price → Price = 80,500 ÷ 0.80 = **₹1,00,625**; Profit = 1,00,625 − 80,500 = **₹20,125**. *Check:* 20,125 ÷ 1,00,625 = 20.0% ✓ (profit is exactly 20% of selling price). Reconciled.

> **Examiner tweak — "20% on cost" instead.** If the same question said profit at 20% *on cost*, then Profit = 20% × 80,500 = ₹16,100 and Price = 96,600. The two answers (₹1,00,625 vs ₹96,600) differ by ₹4,025 on the *same* cost — proof that "on cost vs on sales" is worth real marks. Always underline which basis the question states before touching the calculator.

Example 1B — Batch Costing + EBQ (easy→moderate)

Anand Pharma makes a tablet in batches. Annual demand 4,80,000 tablets; set-up cost per batch ₹1,200; annual carrying cost ₹6 per tablet. Each batch also incurs direct material ₹0.80/tablet and direct labour + overhead ₹1.20/tablet. Find the EBQ, the number of set-ups a year, and the cost per tablet at EBQ.

Step 1 — EBQ = √(2DS ÷ C) = √(2 × 4,80,000 × 1,200 ÷ 6) = √(11,52,00,00,000 ÷ 6) … let's do it cleanly: 2 × 4,80,000 × 1,200 = 1,15,20,00,000; ÷ 6 = 19,20,00,000; √ = **≈ 13,856 tablets per batch.**

Step 2 — Number of set-ups = D ÷ EBQ = 4,80,000 ÷ 13,856 = **≈ 34.6 → about 35 batches a year.**

Step 3 — Self-check (the EBQ optimum condition): annual set-up cost = 35 × 1,200 ≈ ₹41,569 using exact 34.64; annual carrying cost = (13,856 ÷ 2) × 6 = ₹41,568. Set-up cost ≈ carrying cost ✓ — the hallmark that EBQ is correct.

Step 4 — Cost per tablet = variable production cost + (set-up + carrying share). At EBQ, set-up + carrying per year ≈ ₹41,568 × 2 = ₹83,136 ÷ 4,80,000 = ₹0.173/tablet. Total ≈ 0.80 + 1.20 + 0.17 = **₹2.17/tablet.**

Reconciliation: halving the batch to ~6,928 would raise set-ups to ~69 and set-up cost to ~₹83,000 while cutting carrying to ~₹20,800 — total ₹1,03,800 > ₹83,136. So EBQ genuinely minimises the set-up-plus-carrying total ✓.

Example 2 — Contract, standard 50–90% case with retention

Konkan Constructions began Contract No. 88 (contract price ₹40,00,000) on 1 April 2025. Position at 31 March 2026:

Item	₹
Materials issued to site	10,00,000
Direct wages paid	8,00,000
Outstanding wages (accrued)	50,000
Direct expenses	1,20,000
Plant sent to site (at cost)	5,00,000
Site (head office) overhead apportioned	80,000
Materials at site (closing, unused)	1,00,000
Work Certified	24,00,000
Work Uncertified (at cost)	60,000
Cash received (85% of work certified)	20,40,000

Depreciation on plant: charge at 20% p.a. (so closing plant WDV = 5,00,000 − 1,00,000 = ₹4,00,000).

Step 1 — Contract Account (Method 1: plant at cost in, WDV out).

Dr — Particulars	₹	Cr — Particulars	₹
To Materials	10,00,000	By Materials at site c/d	1,00,000
To Wages (8,00,000+50,000)	8,50,000	By Plant at site c/d (WDV)	4,00,000
To Direct expenses	1,20,000	By Work-in-Progress:	
To Plant (at cost)	5,00,000	Work Certified	24,00,000
To Site overhead	80,000	Work Uncertified	60,000
To Notional Profit c/d	**4,10,000**		
Total	**29,60,000**	**Total**	**29,60,000**

Check the balance: Debits of cost = 10,00,000+8,50,000+1,20,000+5,00,000+80,000 = 25,50,000. Credits (excl. profit) = 1,00,000+4,00,000+24,00,000+60,000 = 29,60,000. Notional Profit = 29,60,000 − 25,50,000 = **₹4,10,000.** ✓

Interpretation: Cost of work done = 25,50,000 − (1,00,000 + 4,00,000 closing balances) = 20,50,000. Value of work done = 24,00,000 + 60,000 = 24,60,000. NP = 24,60,000 − 20,50,000 = **4,10,000** ✓ (both routes agree — reconciled).

Step 2 — Degree of completion. = Work Certified ÷ Contract Price = 24,00,000 ÷ 40,00,000 = **60%.** → Falls in the **50%–90% band → ⅔ rule.**

Step 3 — Profit to transfer to P&L.

> = ⅔ × Notional Profit × (Cash Received ÷ Work Certified) = ⅔ × 4,10,000 × (20,40,000 ÷ 24,00,000) = ⅔ × 4,10,000 × 0.85 = **₹2,32,333** (rounded).

Cash ratio = 20,40,000 ÷ 24,00,000 = 0.85 ✓ (matches the stated 85%).

Step 4 — Profit kept as reserve = 4,10,000 − 2,32,333 = **₹1,77,667.**

Step 5 — Balance Sheet WIP figure.

> WIP = (Work Certified + Work Uncertified) − Reserve − Cash received = 24,60,000 − 1,77,667 − 20,40,000 = **₹2,42,333.**

Reconciliation of WIP another way: Cost of work done 20,50,000 + Profit recognised 2,32,333 − Cash received 20,40,000 = **2,42,333** ✓. Both methods agree — fully reconciled.

> **Examiner tweak — "plant on depreciation basis (Method 2)."** If instead the question said "charge depreciation of ₹1,00,000 on plant," you'd debit only ₹1,00,000 (depreciation) and make **no** "plant at cost / plant WDV c/d" entries. The debit side would then be 10,00,000+8,50,000+1,20,000+1,00,000+80,000 = 21,50,000, and the credit side would drop the ₹4,00,000 plant WDV, leaving 1,00,000+24,00,000+60,000 = 25,60,000. Notional Profit = 25,60,000 − 21,50,000 = **₹4,10,000** — *identical*, because both methods charge the same ₹1,00,000 depreciation. Proving the two plant methods reconcile is a five-second way to bomb-proof your answer.

Example 3 — Contract near completion (≥90%), estimated-profit basis, with a twist

Sahyadri Infra's Contract "Ghat Road" has a contract price of ₹1,00,00,000. As on 31 March 2026:

Item	₹
Cost incurred to date	75,00,000
Estimated further cost to complete	5,00,000
Work Certified	92,00,000
Work Uncertified (cost)	2,00,000
Cash received (75% of certified)	69,00,000

Step 1 — Completion % = 92,00,000 ÷ 1,00,00,000 = **92%** → **≥90%** → **Estimated Total Profit basis.**

Step 2 — Estimated Total Profit.

> = Contract Price − (Cost to date + Estimated cost to complete) = 1,00,00,000 − (75,00,000 + 5,00,000) = **₹20,00,000.**

Step 3 — Notional profit to date (for reference / reserve): Value of work done = 92,00,000 + 2,00,000 = 94,00,000; Cost of work done ≈ 75,00,000 (all incurred cost consumed here). NP = 94,00,000 − 75,00,000 = **₹19,00,000.**

Step 4 — Profit to P&L using the standard "cash-adjusted, certified/price" formula (b):

> = Estimated Profit × (Work Certified ÷ Contract Price) × (Cash Received ÷ Work Certified) = Estimated Profit × (Cash Received ÷ Contract Price) = 20,00,000 × (69,00,000 ÷ 1,00,00,000) = 20,00,000 × 0.69 = **₹13,80,000.**

Cross-check with formula (a) — no cash adjustment: 20,00,000 × (92,00,000 ÷ 1,00,00,000) = 20,00,000 × 0.92 = ₹18,40,000. Cash-adjusted answer (₹13,80,000) is the more prudent one; unless the question specifies otherwise, present the cash-adjusted figure and note the alternative.

Cross-check with cost basis (c): 20,00,000 × (75,00,000 ÷ 80,00,000) = 20,00,000 × 0.9375 = ₹18,75,000. These alternatives are shown only to demonstrate that the *method chosen must match the data/instruction given* — a classic exam decision point.

Step 5 — Reserve (using formula b) = Notional profit 19,00,000 − 13,80,000 = **₹5,20,000** held back as cushion for the final 8% and the retained ₹23,00,000 (92,00,000 − 69,00,000) not yet received. Reconciled.

Example 3B — The killer twist: a contract heading for an overall LOSS

Same Sahyadri Infra takes another contract, "Tunnel-9," price ₹50,00,000. At 31 March 2026: cost incurred to date ₹40,00,000; estimated further cost to complete ₹15,00,000; Work Certified ₹30,00,000; cash received ₹25,50,000 (85%).

Step 1 — Completion % = 30,00,000 ÷ 50,00,000 = 60%. A naïve student sees "60% band → ⅔ rule → book a profit." **Wrong.**

Step 2 — Check the whole-contract outcome first. Estimated Total Cost = 40,00,000 + 15,00,000 = **₹55,00,000 > Contract Price ₹50,00,000.** The contract is doomed to a **₹5,00,000 loss** overall.

Step 3 — Apply prudence: provide the ENTIRE foreseeable loss now. Transfer **₹5,00,000 loss** to the Costing P&L immediately, *even though* the work done so far might show a small notional profit and *even though* completion is only 60%. "Provide for all losses" overrides every profit band.

Why this is the trap of the topic: the profit ladder (⅓, ⅔) only applies when the contract is *expected to be profitable*. The moment the *estimated total cost exceeds the contract price*, you abandon the ladder and book the full loss. Reconciled to the prudence principle. Miss this and you'd report a profit on a loss-making contract — the single worst error in the chapter.

Example 4 — Escalation clause (exam-hard, self-contained)

Deccan Builders took a 3-year contract with an escalation clause covering steel and cement. Base rates: steel ₹50/kg, cement ₹350/bag. Agreed (standard) consumption for the certified work: steel 2,00,000 kg, cement 40,000 bags. During execution, actual rates rose to steel ₹58/kg and cement ₹380/bag. Actual consumption was steel 2,10,000 kg (10,000 kg extra due to site wastage) and cement 39,000 bags. Compute the escalation claim.

Principle: claim only the *rate rise* on the *standard (agreed) quantity*. Do not reward the contractor's 10,000 kg wastage; do not penalise on cement where he used less.

Material	Std Qty	Rate rise (Actual − Base)	Claim ₹
Steel	2,00,000 kg	58 − 50 = ₹8	16,00,000
Cement	40,000 bags	380 − 350 = ₹30	12,00,000
Total escalation claim			**28,00,000**

Why standard qty for steel, not 2,10,000? Because reimbursing 2,10,000 × 8 = ₹16,80,000 would make the client pay ₹80,000 for the contractor's own wastage — the clause insures against *price* movement, not *inefficiency*. Claim = **₹28,00,000**, added to the contract price. Reconciled to principle.

> **Examiner tweak — add a de-escalation on labour.** Suppose the clause also covers labour, base rate ₹200/day for a standard 20,000 days, but the labour rate actually *fell* to ₹185/day. The de-escalation *reduces* the claim: 20,000 × (185 − 200) = −₹3,00,000. Net claim = 28,00,000 − 3,00,000 = **₹25,00,000.** Students who "ignore the falling input because it's not a rise" lose the mark — a symmetric clause nets both directions.

---

6. Presentation / Format (what the examiner wants to see)

Job cost sheet: always vertical, building Prime → Works → Production → Total → Price, with a working column. Show the profit basis (on cost vs on sales) explicitly.

Contract Account: a proper **T-account**, dated, with: - Debit: all costs (remember *outstanding wages*, *depreciation or plant-at-cost*). - Credit: closing materials at site, closing plant WDV, and **WIP = Work Certified + Work Uncertified**. - Balancing figure clearly labelled **"Notional Profit c/d"** (or Loss).

Below the account, always show three explicit workings: 1. **% completion** = Work Certified ÷ Contract Price (state which band → which formula). 2. **Profit transferred to P&L** — write the formula, then substitute. 3. **Balance Sheet extract:**

Balance Sheet (extract)	₹
Work-in-Progress: Work Certified + Uncertified	XXX
Less: Reserve (profit not recognised)	(XX)
Less: Cash received / Advance from client	(XX)
WIP (net) shown under Current Assets	**XX**

Plus: Materials at site and Plant at site (WDV) shown as assets; Accrued wages as a liability.

Profit & Loss transfer: state the recognised profit figure and, separately, the reserve carried forward. Round to the nearest rupee and state your rounding.

A tidy sequence for any contract-costing answer (write it in this order and you rarely go wrong): 1. Prepare the **Contract Account**; balance out **Notional Profit/Loss**. 2. Compute **% completion**; **first** check for an overall estimated loss (Example 3B) before choosing a profit band. 3. Choose the band → write the **formula** → substitute → **Profit to P&L**. 4. Compute the **Reserve** (= Notional Profit − Profit to P&L). 5. Prepare the **Balance Sheet extract** and reconcile WIP two ways.

Following a fixed sequence also protects part-marks: even if step 3 goes wrong, a correct account and a correct % completion still score.

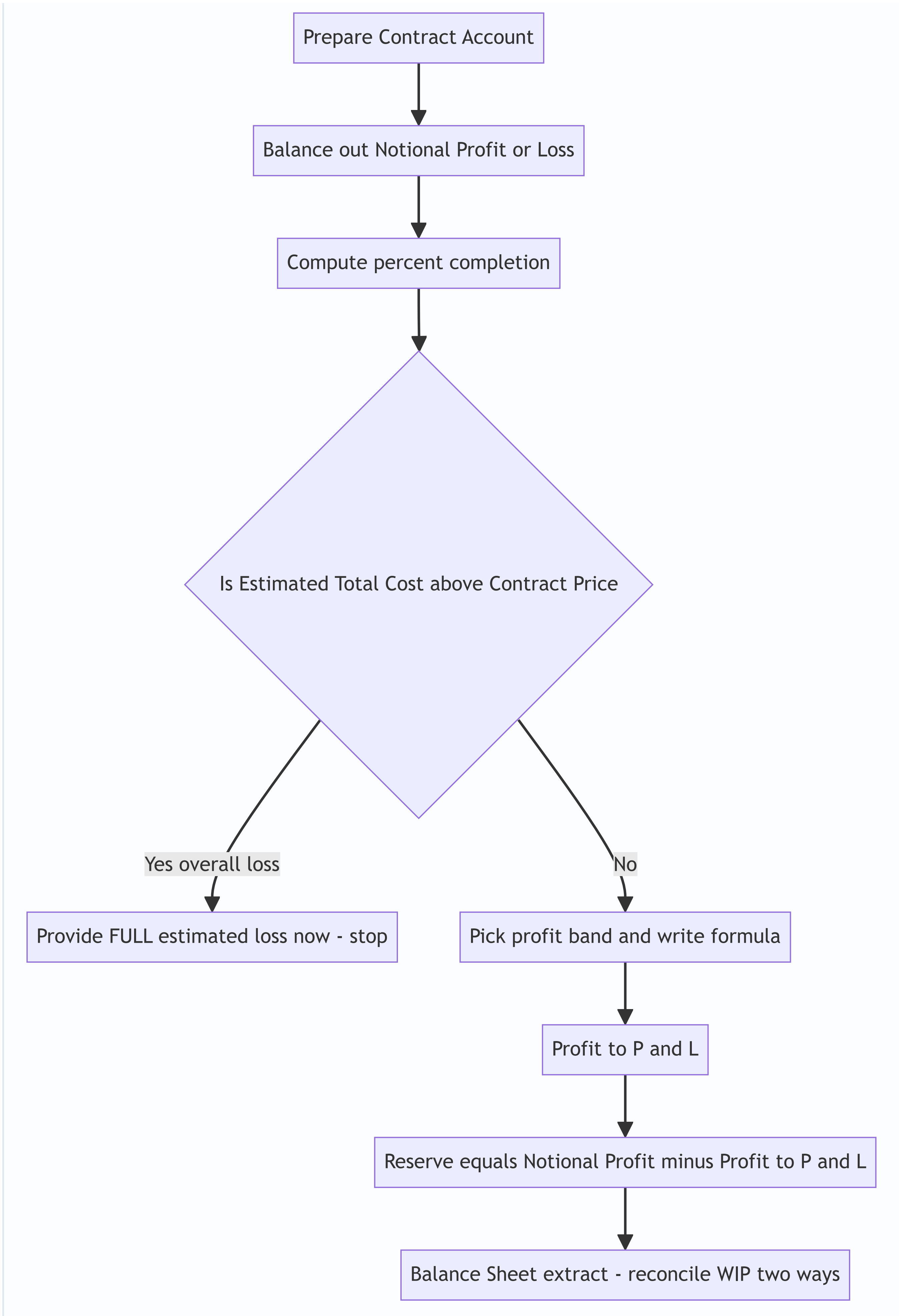

Prepare Contract Account
Balance out Notional Profit or Loss
Compute percent completion
Is Estimated Total Cost above Contract Price
Yes overall loss
No
Provide FULL estimated loss now - stop
Pick profit band and write formula
Profit to P and L
Reserve equals Notional Profit minus Profit to P and L
Balance Sheet extract - reconcile WIP two ways

Figure 4 — The safe answering sequence for a contract-costing question.

7. Connections (how this chapter wires into the rest of Cost Accounting)

- ← **Materials (Ch. on Material Cost):** Material Requisition Notes tag issues to jobs; EBQ in batch costing is the sibling of EOQ.
- ← **Labour:** Job time tickets / time booking feed direct labour into each job; idle time and overtime treatment flow straight into job cost.
- ← **Overheads:** Job costing *depends* on a predetermined **overhead absorption rate**; under/over-absorption is settled at the cost-ledger level, not inside the job. Contracts, being mostly direct, carry little apportioned overhead — the conceptual contrast is examinable.
- → **Process Costing (Ch. 10):** The deliberate *opposite* — homogeneous output, averaging, equivalent units. Knowing *why* job costing exists sharpens *why* process costing exists.
- → **Cost Sheet / Cost Statements:** The job cost sheet *is* a cost sheet for one order.
- → **Reconciliation & Integral accounts:** WIP Control ties job costing into the double-entry system.
- → **Financial Accounting (AS 7 / Ind AS 115):** The prudence-based interim profit here is the cost-accounting cousin of construction-contract revenue recognition. Same worry, different rulebook. Note the divergence worth flagging: financial accounting has *moved on* — **Ind AS 115** uses an "over-time, % of completion via input/output methods" model and Ind AS bans the old completed-contract method, while **AS 7** already mandates the percentage-of-completion method for contractors. Cost accounting's ⅓/⅔ prudence ladder is the *conservative managerial* cousin, not the statutory rule. If a question straddles both, keep the two rulebooks in separate mental boxes. *Verify exact standard references against current ICAI material.*

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Wrong profit band.** Students grab ⅔ reflexively. *Always compute Work Certified ÷ Contract Price first* and read off the band. 60% → ⅔; 40% → ⅓; 20% → NIL; 92% → estimated-profit basis.
2. **Forgetting the cash ratio.** Both the ⅓ and ⅔ formulas carry **× (Cash Received ÷ Work Certified)**. Dropping it *overstates* recognised profit — the opposite of prudence. Examiners plant a non-standard retention % (e.g., 75%) to catch this.
3. **Outstanding/accrued wages ignored.** Wages *paid* ≠ wages *incurred*. Add accrued wages to the debit of the contract account.
4. **Plant double counting.** Choose one method. If you debit plant at cost, you *must* credit closing WDV; if you charge only depreciation, do **not** also credit plant WDV.
5. **Materials at site.** Closing unused material must be credited (carried down), else cost of work done is overstated and notional profit understated. Also handle the *six fates of material* (4B) — sold/lost/transferred material must leave the contract correctly.
6. **Work Uncertified carried at profit.** It must be at **cost** — no profit on unblessed work. Only *Work Certified* carries selling-price value.

7. **Escalation on actual (wasteful) quantity.** Claim is on **standard quantity × rate rise**, never actual quantity. And only *upward* rate movements (unless a de-escalation clause is stated — then net both directions).
8. **Loss treated like profit.** A loss is transferred **in full, immediately** — no ⅓/⅔, no cash ratio. Symmetry is *wrong* here; asymmetry is the point.
9. **"Profit on cost" vs "profit on sales."** In job pricing, 20% *on cost* ≠ 20% *on sales*. Read the wording; set up the equation (Example 1).
10. **Near-completion formula mismatch.** At ≥90%, you need *estimated total cost to complete*. If the question gives it, you're expected to switch to the estimated-profit basis — using the plain ⅔ rule there loses marks.
11. **Balance Sheet WIP sign errors.** Deduct *both* the reserve and the cash received from (Certified + Uncertified). A negative or bloated WIP signals an arithmetic slip.
12. **Overall-loss blindness (the big one).** A contract can show a *notional profit to date* yet be *doomed to an overall loss* (Estimated Total Cost > Contract Price). You must provide the **full estimated loss now** and ignore the profit band entirely (Example 3B). This is the single highest-value trap in the chapter.
13. **Notional Profit vs Estimated Profit confusion.** Notional profit uses *work done to date*; estimated profit uses the *whole contract*. Feeding one into the other's formula silently corrupts the answer. Label them separately.
14. **EBQ with carrying cost as a percentage.** If C is "10% of unit cost," convert to ₹ before taking the square root. Plugging "10" or "0.10" straight in is a guaranteed wrong answer.
15. **Depreciation period mismatch.** If plant reached the site *mid-year*, depreciation is for the *months actually at site*, not a full year. Read the dates.
16. **Advance vs cash-on-certification.** A lump-sum *advance* from the client is not the same as cash received against certified work; treat a pure advance as a liability, not as part of the (Cash ÷ Certified) ratio, unless the question equates them.

---

9. First-Principles Recap

Strip away every formula and here is what remains, rebuildable from scratch:

1. **When outputs differ, averaging lies.** So we give each customer order its own wallet (job number) and tag every rupee to it. That wallet's total is the honest cost — for pricing and for profitability. *That's all job costing is.* And it's worth doing *only* when orders genuinely differ — the value of un-averaged information must beat the cost of collecting it.
2. **Batch costing** is the same wallet wrapped around a group of identical units; divide by units for per-unit cost; EBQ optimises batch size exactly like EOQ optimises order size (set-up cost ↔ carrying cost, balanced at the optimum).
3. **Contract costing** is job costing for jobs so big and so long they get their own ledger account and cross year-ends — kept in the *contractor's* books, dominated by *direct* cost.
4. **Crossing year-ends creates the one genuinely deep question:** how much of the not-yet-finished, not-yet-certain profit dare I show now? **Prudence answers:** anticipate no profit, provide all losses. So keep only a *fraction* of notional profit — a fraction that **grows as completion grows** (NIL → ⅓ → ⅔ → estimated-profit basis) — and shrink it *again* by the cash you've actually collected (retention risk). Losses:

take them all, now — and if the *whole* contract is doomed, provide the *entire estimated* loss immediately, band or no band.

5. **Retention money** exists because the client keeps a defects hostage; that's *why* cash received < work certified, and *why* the cash ratio appears in every profit formula.
6. **Escalation clause** exists because a fixed price over years exposes the contractor to input-price inflation; it reimburses *rate* rises on *standard* quantities — insuring price risk, not inefficiency. (**Cost-plus** contracts solve the same risk differently, by handing the uncertainty to the client.)

If you can re-derive the profit ladder from the single sentence "anticipate no profit, provide for all losses, and trust the outcome more as the job nears completion," you never need to memorise it.

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

WHEN TO USE - Job costing → customised, one-off, heterogeneous orders (printers, garages, fabricators). - Batch costing → identical units made in lots; cost/unit = batch cost ÷ units. - Contract costing → large, long, site-based jobs crossing accounting years (contractor's books).

JOB COST SHEET Prime = DM + DL + Direct Exp → +Works OH = Works Cost → +Admin OH = Cost of Production → +S&D OH = Total Cost → +Profit = Price. Profit on **cost**: Price = Cost × (1+m). Profit on **sales**: Price = Cost ÷ (1−m).

EBQ = √(2DS ÷ C). Set-ups/yr = D ÷ EBQ. At optimum: total set-up cost = total carrying cost. Convert C to ₹ if given as a %.

CONTRACT — key formulas - Value of Work Done = Work Certified + Work Uncertified. - Cost of Work Done = Costs incurred − closing (materials at site + plant WDV). - **Notional Profit = Value of Work Done − Cost of Work Done.** - % Completion = **Work Certified ÷ Contract Price**. - Cash Received = Work Certified × (1 − retention%); Retention = Certified − Cash. - Estimated Total Profit = Contract Price − (Cost to date + Cost to complete). - **Overall loss check:** if (Cost to date + Cost to complete) > Contract Price → provide the FULL estimated loss now.

PROFIT TO TRANSFER (prudence ladder)

Completion	Transfer to P&L
< 25%	NIL
25% to < 50%	⅓ × NP × (Cash ÷ Certified)
50% to < 90%	⅔ × NP × (Cash ÷ Certified)
≥ 90%	Est. Profit × (Cash ÷ Contract Price) *(or cost-ratio variant per data)*
Any % with **notional loss**	**Full loss, immediately**
Any % with **overall estimated loss**	**Full estimated loss, immediately**

BALANCE SHEET WIP = (Certified + Uncertified) − Reserve − Cash received = Cost of work done + Profit recognised − Cash received. Also show: Materials at site, Plant at site (WDV) as assets; accrued wages as liability. Reserve = Notional Profit − Profit recognised.

ESCALATION CLAIM = Σ [Standard Qty × (Actual Rate − Base Rate)] — rate rise on standard qty only; never on wastage; net de-escalation if the clause is symmetric.

MATERIAL'S SIX FATES on a contract: consumed / at-site c/d / returned to stores / transferred to another contract / sold (P&L) / lost (abnormal → P&L).

TOP TRAPS: compute % completion before choosing fraction; check overall-loss FIRST; never drop (Cash ÷ Certified); add accrued wages; Work Uncertified at cost; full loss immediately; escalation on standard qty; convert EBQ carrying-% to ₹.

Q&A — Job & Contract Costing

CA Intermediate — Cost & Management Accounting. All amounts in Rupees (₹). ICAI formulae and prudence conventions.

SECTION A — Concept-Check (Quick Q&A)

A1. Why does simple averaging (total cost ÷ units) fail for a job shop? Because output is *heterogeneous*. A printing press making a wedding card and a textbook in the same period has jobs consuming wildly different materials, labour and time. One average cost per unit would over-cost the cheap job and under-cost the dear one, distorting quotations and profit. So each job is a **separate cost unit** with its own cost sheet.

A2. State the core idea of job costing in one line. "A **wallet per order.**" Every job carries its own tab (a job cost sheet), directly charged with its materials and labour, and *absorbed* with a fair share of overhead — exactly like a restaurant bill charging only what your table ordered plus a service charge.

A3. Job costing vs. Contract costing — the essential difference? Same DNA (both cost a specific identifiable job). Contract costing is job costing **scaled up and stretched over time**: work is large, site-based, and spans accounting periods, forcing us to answer "how much profit may I book *before* the job is finished?" — the notional/estimated profit question.

A4. What is Batch Costing and where does it sit? A hybrid: a *batch* of identical units is the cost unit (e.g., 1,000 tablets, 500 bolts). Total batch cost ÷ batch quantity = cost per unit. Used in pharma, bakery, components. It introduces the **Economic Batch Quantity (EBQ)**.

A5. Give the EBQ formula and its two opposing cost forces. EBQ = $\sqrt{(2 \times D \times S \div C)}$, where D = annual demand, S = set-up cost per batch, C = carrying cost per unit p.a. Large batches → low set-up cost but high carrying cost; small batches → the reverse. EBQ minimises the total.

A6. Define Work Certified and Work Uncertified. Work Certified = value of work approved by the architect/surveyor (at *contract price*), the basis for the running bill. **Work Uncertified** = work physically done but not yet certified, carried at *cost*.

A7. What is Retention Money and why is it withheld? The customer withholds a % (say 20%) of certified value as security against defects. Cash received = Work certified − Retention. It protects the customer; the contractor recovers it on satisfactory completion.

A8. Notional Profit vs. Estimated Profit — one line each. Notional Profit = profit on work *done so far* = (Work certified + Work uncertified) − Cost of work to date. **Estimated Profit** = expected profit on the *whole* contract = Contract price − Total estimated cost.

A9. Why is only a *portion* of profit transferred to P&L? Name the principle. Prudence (conservatism). Work not yet certified may develop defects; costs may escalate. Booking full profit early risks reversing it later, so we hold back a reserve.

SECTION B — Graded Computational Problems

B1 (Easy) — Job Cost Sheet & Quotation

Q. Job No. 21 used: Direct materials ₹40,000; Direct wages ₹25,000 (Factory dept) + ₹5,000 (Finishing dept). Factory OH is absorbed at 60% of factory wages; Finishing OH at 40% of finishing wages. Administration, selling & distribution OH = 25% of works cost. The firm quotes to earn a **profit of 20% on selling price.** Compute the quotation price.

Answer — Job Cost Sheet:

Element	Working	₹
Direct materials		40,000
Direct wages (25,000 + 5,000)		30,000
Prime cost		**70,000**
Factory OH	60% × 25,000	15,000
Finishing OH	40% × 5,000	2,000
Works (Factory) cost		**87,000**
Admin, S&D OH	25% × 87,000	21,750
Total cost		**1,08,750**
Profit	(see below)	27,187.50
Quotation (Selling price)		**1,35,937.50**

Profit = 20% on SP = 25% on cost. Profit = 1,08,750 × 25/75 = ₹27,187.50. Check: 27,187.50 ÷ 1,35,937.50 = 20% ✓.

B2 (Moderate) — Batch Costing + EBQ

Q. A component has annual demand D = 48,000 units. Set-up cost per batch S = ₹360. Carrying cost C = ₹1.20 per unit per annum. (a) Find EBQ. (b) Number of batches p.a. (c) Total relevant (set-up + carrying) cost at EBQ.

Answer:

(a) EBQ = √(2 × 48,000 × 360 ÷ 1.20) = √(3,45,60,000 ÷ 1.20) = √2,88,00,000 = **5,366 units** (≈ 5,367).

Let me verify precisely: 2 × 48,000 × 360 = 3,45,60,000. ÷1.20 = 2,88,00,000. √ = 5,366.56 ≈ **5,367 units.**

(b) Batches p.a. = 48,000 ÷ 5,367 = **8.94 ≈ 9 batches.**

(c) At EBQ, set-up cost = carrying cost (property of EOQ): - Set-up cost = (48,000 ÷ 5,367) × 360 = 8.94 × 360 = ₹3,220 - Carrying cost = (5,367 ÷ 2) × 1.20 = 2,683.5 × 1.20 = ₹3,220 - **Total relevant cost = ₹6,440** (≈ √(2 × D × S × C) = √(2×48,000×360×1.20) = √4,14,72,000 = ₹6,440 ✓).

B3 (Hard) — Contract Account with Notional Profit & Prudence Ladder

Q. A contract for ₹15,00,000 began 1 April. As on 31 March, the following (₹):

Materials issued 3,20,000; Wages paid 4,10,000; Wages outstanding 20,000; Plant purchased 1,50,000; Direct expenses 60,000; Establishment (indirect) 40,000. Materials at site (closing) 30,000. Plant depreciated to a closing value of 1,20,000. **Work certified ₹9,00,000; work uncertified ₹40,000.** Cash received = 80% of work certified (20% retention). Prepare the Contract Account, compute notional profit, and the profit to transfer to P&L using the standard prudence rule (certification is between ¼ and ½ of contract price… *check the ratio and apply the correct rung*).

Answer:

Step 1 — Degree of completion: Work certified ÷ Contract price = 9,00,000 ÷ 15,00,000 = **60%**. This is between ½ and completion → use the **2/3 × Notional profit × (Cash received ÷ Work certified)** rung.

Contract Account for the year:

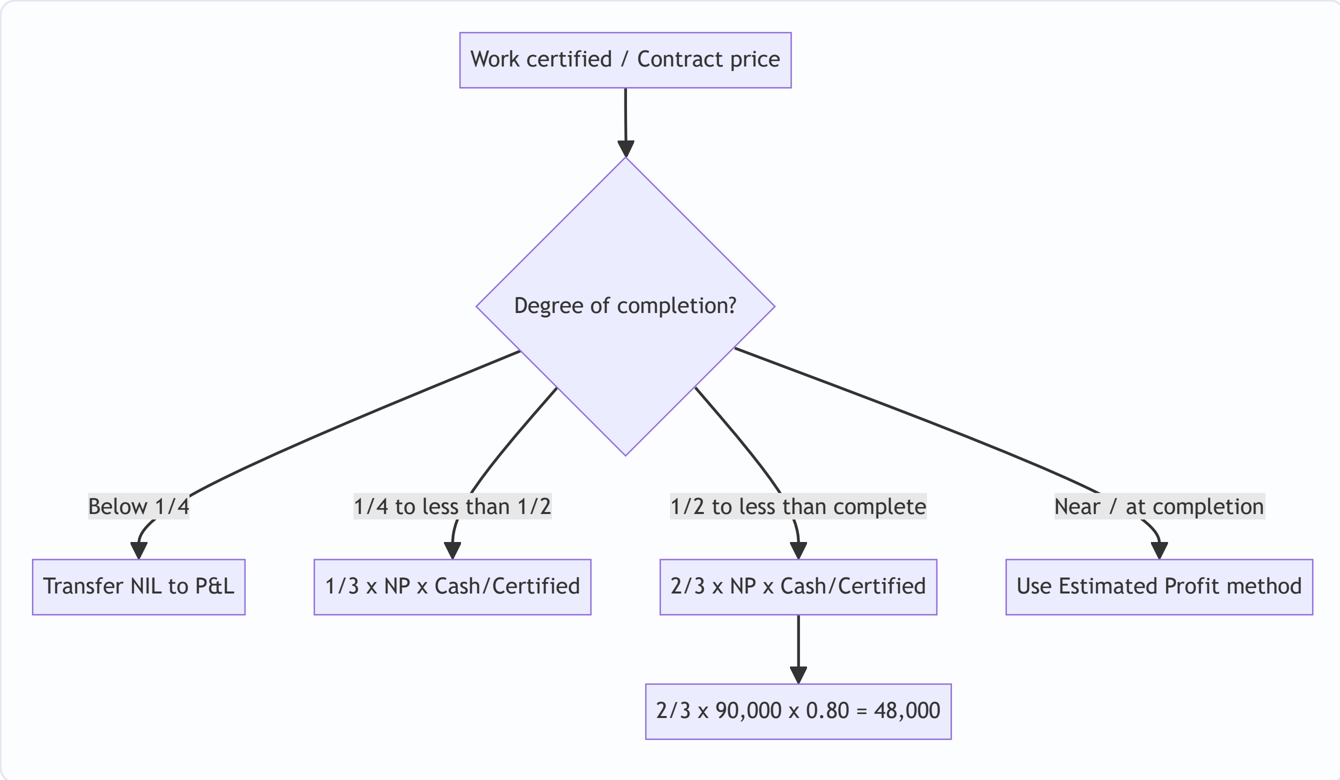
Dr	₹	Cr	₹
To Materials issued	3,20,000	By Materials at site c/d	30,000
To Wages paid	4,10,000	By Plant at site c/d	1,20,000
To Wages outstanding c/d	20,000	By Work-in-progress c/d:	
To Plant purchased	1,50,000	— Work certified	9,00,000
To Direct expenses	60,000	— Work uncertified	40,000
To Establishment	40,000		
To **Notional profit c/d**	**90,000**		
Total	**10,90,000**	**Total**	**10,90,000**

Cost of work to date = 10,90,000 − 30,000 − 1,20,000 = 9,40,000. *Notional profit* = (9,00,000 + 40,000) − 9,40,000 = **₹90,000.** ✓ (balancing figure above)

Step 2 — Profit to P&L (prudence rung, >½ complete): Profit to P&L = (2/3) × Notional profit × (Cash received ÷ Work certified) = (2/3) × 90,000 × (7,20,000 ÷ 9,00,000) = (2/3) × 90,000 × 0.80 = 60,000 × 0.80 = **₹48,000.**

Reserve (kept back) = 90,000 − 48,000 = **₹42,000.**

Profit & Loss transfer diagram (prudence ladder):



B4 (Exam-Hard) — Estimated Profit + Escalation Clause

Q. A contract price is ₹40,00,000, expected to be 90% certified by year-end (near completion, so use the **estimated-profit** method). Costs to date ₹27,00,000; estimated additional cost to complete ₹5,00,000. Work certified ₹36,00,000; cash received 85% of certified.

An **escalation clause** allows recovery of cost increases: material prices rose 10% on a standard material spend of ₹6,00,000, and labour rates rose 8% on standard labour of ₹5,00,000; the clause reimburses **75% of the escalation.** Compute (a) the escalation claim to be added to the contract, (b) revised total estimated profit, and (c) profit to transfer to P&L.

Answer:

(a) Escalation claim: - Material escalation = 10% × 6,00,000 = ₹60,000 - Labour escalation = 8% × 5,00,000 = ₹40,000 - Total escalation = ₹1,00,000; recoverable at 75% = **₹75,000** added to contract revenue.

(Note: the escalated cost itself, ₹1,00,000, is already sitting inside "costs" — the clause only lets us bill the customer for 75% of it.)

(b) Revised estimated total profit: - Revised contract price = 40,00,000 + 75,000 = ₹40,75,000 - Total estimated cost = 27,00,000 (to date) + 5,00,000 (to complete) = ₹32,00,000 - **Estimated total profit = 40,75,000 − 32,00,000 = ₹8,75,000.**

(c) Profit to P&L (estimated-profit, near-completion formula): Standard ICAI formula (work-certified basis, refined by cash):

Profit to P&L = Estimated profit × (Work certified ÷ Contract price) × (Cash received ÷ Work certified) = 8,75,000 × (36,00,000 ÷ 40,75,000) × (30,60,000 ÷ 36,00,000)

Simplify: (36,00,000/40,75,000) × (30,60,000/36,00,000) = 30,60,000 ÷ 40,75,000 = 0.75092. = 8,75,000 × 0.75092 = **₹6,57,055** (≈ ₹6,57,000).

Cash received = 85% × 36,00,000 = ₹30,60,000. ✓ Alternative accepted ICAI formula, Estimated profit × Cost to date ÷ Total cost = 8,75,000 × 27,00,000/32,00,000 = ₹7,38,281 — state whichever formula the paper specifies; the **cash-adjusted certified basis is the more conservative** and generally preferred.

SECTION C — Past-Paper-Style Full Questions

C1. "*Explain, with the standard rules, how much profit a contractor should transfer to the Profit & Loss Account depending on the stage of completion of a contract. Why is the balance kept as reserve?*" (5 marks)

Model Answer. Profit on incomplete contracts is recognised on a **prudent, graduated** basis tied to certified completion:

Stage (Work certified ÷ Contract price)	Profit to P&L
Less than 1/4	Nil (too uncertain)
1/4 to less than 1/2	1/3 × Notional Profit × (Cash received ÷ Work certified)
1/2 to less than substantial completion	2/3 × Notional Profit × (Cash received ÷ Work certified)
Near / substantial completion	Estimated Profit × (Work certified ÷ Contract price) × (Cash ÷ Certified), or Estimated Profit × Cost to date ÷ Total cost

The **cash/certified ratio** further discounts profit for retention money not yet realised. The **balance is retained as reserve** on the *prudence* principle: uncertified work may be defective, future costs may escalate, and unrealised (retained) profit should not inflate distributable income. The reserve is carried in the WIP balance and released as the contract progresses.

C2. *Show the Balance Sheet presentation of Work-in-Progress for contract B3 above.* (Notional profit ₹90,000; certified ₹9,00,000; uncertified ₹40,000; cash received ₹7,20,000; profit taken ₹48,000; materials at site ₹30,000.)

Model Answer — Balance Sheet extract (₹):

Assets	Working	₹
Work-in-progress:		
Work certified		9,00,000
Work uncertified		40,000
Sub-total		9,40,000
Less: Reserve (profit in suspense)	90,000 − 48,000	(42,000)
Less: Cash received from contractee		(7,20,000)
Net WIP shown		**1,78,000**
Materials at site		30,000

Equivalently, WIP = Cost of work to date (9,40,000) + Profit taken (48,000) − Cash received (7,20,000) = ₹2,68,000, then materials at site shown separately — presentation may net cash against WIP or show a "Contractee's account" on the liabilities side. Both reconcile.

SECTION D — MCQs & Case Scenarios

D1. Under job costing, the cost unit is: (a) a process (b) a **specific job/order** (c) a department (d) a time period. **Answer: (b).** Each identifiable order is separately costed.

D2. Notional profit on a contract equals: (a) Contract price − Total cost (b) **(Work certified + Work uncertified) − Cost of work to date** (c) Cash received − Cost (d) Certified − Retention. **Answer: (b).** It measures profit on work done so far, not the whole contract.

D3. Retention money is: (a) advance from customer (b) **certified value withheld as defect security** (c) contractor's reserve (d) plant depreciation. **Answer: (b).** Cash received = Certified − Retention.

D4. If work certified is only 20% of contract price, profit transferred to P&L is: (a) 1/3 of notional (b) 2/3 of notional (c) **Nil** (d) full notional. **Answer: (c).** Below 1/4 completion → prudence says recognise nothing.

D5. EBQ decreases when: (a) demand rises (b) **carrying cost per unit rises** (c) set-up cost rises (d) both a and c. **Answer: (b).** C is in the denominator, so higher carrying cost → smaller optimal batch.

D6 (Case). A contractor is 40% certified, notional profit ₹1,50,000, cash = 75% of certified. Profit to P&L? Working: 40% completion → 1/4–1/2 rung → 1/3 × 1,50,000 × 0.75 = **₹37,500. Reasoning:** one-third rung because completion is between 1/4 and 1/2; cash factor scales for retention.

D7 (Case). An escalation clause primarily protects the: (a) customer (b) **contractor** (c) surveyor (d) bank. **Answer: (b).** It lets the contractor recover cost increases (materials/labour/rates) beyond his control, preserving the margin on long contracts.

First-Principles Recap

1. Heterogeneous output ⇒ average is meaningless ⇒ **cost each job separately** (wallet per order).
2. Direct costs are *traced*; overheads are *absorbed* at a predetermined rate — keeping direct-cost purity for honest quotations.
3. Contracts stretch across periods ⇒ we must book *some* profit early, but **prudence** caps it via the notional/estimated ladder and the cash/certified discount.
4. Retention and uncertified work are the two "unrealised" risks the reserve guards against.

Quick-Revision Sheet

- **Prime cost** = DM + DL + Direct exp. **Works cost** = Prime + Factory OH. **Total cost** = Works + Admin + S&D.
- Profit *on cost* p% ⇒ profit *on SP* = p/(100+p). Profit on SP q% ⇒ on cost = q/(100−q).
- **EBQ** = √(2DS ÷ C); min total relevant cost = √(2DSC).
- **Notional profit** = (Certified + Uncertified) − Cost to date.
- **Estimated profit** = Contract price − Total estimated cost.

- Prudence ladder: <1/4 → Nil; 1/4–1/2 → $\frac{1}{3}$·NP·(Cash/Cert); ½–complete → $\frac{2}{3}$·NP·(Cash/Cert); near-complete → Estimated-profit method.
- Cash received = Work certified × (1 − retention %).
- **Escalation claim** = agreed % × (price/rate rise × standard quantity/spend), added to contract revenue.
- BS: WIP = Cost to date + Profit taken − Cash received; show materials/plant at site separately.

Chapter 10 — Process & Operation Costing

1. The Problem: When You Cannot Point to "This Job"

Imagine you are the cost accountant of a sugar mill. Cane crushes at one end; refined sugar bags roll out at the other. In between there is juice extraction, clarification, evaporation, crystallisation, centrifuging. The plant never stops. Twenty thousand kilograms of sugar came out today. A buyer asks: "*What did it cost you to make one kilogram?*"

You reach for the tool you learned in Job Costing — collect the material, labour and overhead for **this particular kilogram**. And you freeze. There is no "this kilogram". Every crystal was made from a common river of juice, boiled in the same vats, spun in the same centrifuges. You cannot tag a job card to a sugar crystal. The output is **homogeneous** (every unit identical) and the production is **continuous** (an unbroken flow, not discrete orders).

Job costing answers "*what did this specific order cost?*" Process costing answers a different question: "*what did the average unit cost, as it flowed through each stage of a continuous plant?*"

Four hard sub-problems fall out of this the moment you look closely:

1. **The output is continuous and identical** — so we cost the *process*, not the *unit*, and divide at the end.
2. **Material is lost on the way** — evaporation, spillage, chemical reaction. Some loss is unavoidable and expected; some is a signal that something went wrong. These two must be treated **differently**, or the cost figure lies.
3. **At the stroke of midnight when we close accounts, some units are half-finished** — sitting in the evaporator, 60% boiled. How do you divide a period's cost between finished bags and a vat of half-cooked syrup?
4. **One process feeds the next** — juice becomes syrup becomes sugar. The output of Process 1 is the raw material of Process 2. How does cost *transfer*, and should each department book a notional profit on the transfer?

This chapter builds the machinery to answer all four — and it builds each tool only *after* you feel the pain it removes.

1.1 Where process costing is legally the *right* method

The examiner sometimes tests the boundary conceptually before any number appears: "*Which costing method suits this industry and why?*" The deciding test is not the product but the **production pattern**. Process costing is mandatory (not optional) when **all** of the following hold:

- Output is **homogeneous** — one unit is a perfect substitute for the next.
- Production is **continuous / mass** — you produce to stock, not to a customer's order.
- Cost cannot be economically traced to an individual unit, so **averaging is the only honest answer**.

Classic industries: **chemicals, paint, cement, sugar, textiles, paper, oil refining, food processing, breweries, distilleries, plastics, steel rolling**. Contrast with printing, ship-building, construction, audit assignments — those are **job / contract** situations because each order is distinct.

A subtle exam point: a single factory can use **both** methods (a *hybrid*). A car plant mass-produces engines by process costing, then assembles a *specific customer's car* under job/batch logic. When the paper says "components are standardised but the final product is customised," expect a **hybrid answer**, not a single method.

1.2 The features you may be asked to *list*

Short-note questions ("Features of process costing") expect a crisp list, and each feature secretly encodes a rule you will use later:

1. Production is **continuous** and output is **standardised** → averaging is valid.
2. The factory is divided into **distinct processes / departments**, each a cost centre → one account per process.
3. Cost is **accumulated process-wise** for a **period** (not job-wise for an order) → period costing.
4. Output of one process becomes **input of the next** → cost transfers forward.
5. **Normal and abnormal losses** arise and are treated differently → the loss machinery.
6. **Work-in-progress** exists at period-end → equivalent units.
7. **Joint and by-products** may emerge from a common process → apportionment (next chapter).

---

2. The Core Idea: The Relay Race and the Averaging Bucket

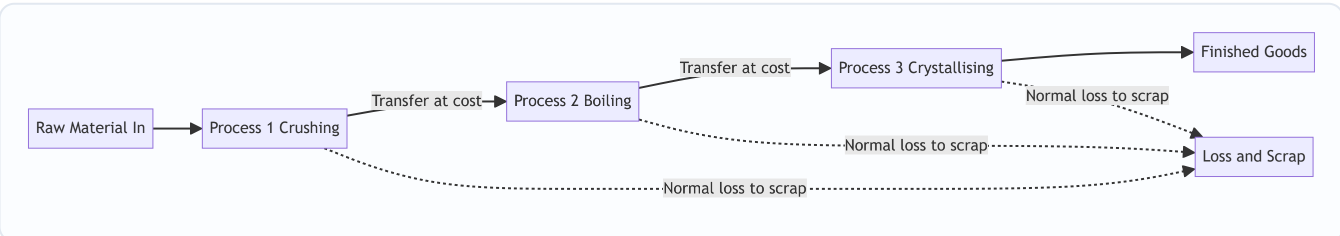
Think of production as a **relay race**. Each runner is a *process*. Runner 1 (crushing) carries the baton part of the way, does work on it, and hands it to Runner 2 (boiling), who adds more work and hands it to Runner 3 (crystallising). The baton is the semi-finished product. What passes between runners is **accumulated cost**: everything spent so far travels forward and becomes the "opening cost" of the next runner.

Now the averaging idea. Picture a giant **bucket** for each process. Into the bucket you pour every rupee spent in that process this period — material, wages, overhead, plus the cost handed over by the previous runner. At period-end you look at how many **good units** came out and simply divide:

> **Cost per unit = Total cost poured into the process ÷ Effective good units produced**

That single division is the heart of process costing. Everything else in this chapter — normal loss, abnormal loss, equivalent units, FIFO — exists only to make that division **honest**: to make sure the numerator (cost) and the denominator (units) are counted on the same, fair basis.

Figure 1 — The relay of cost: each process accumulates its own cost and hands the total forward.



2.1 The one equation, four disguises

Every numerical variant you will meet is the *same* division wearing a different denominator. Fixing this in your head means you never memorise four formulas — you derive them:

Situation	Numerator (cost)	Denominator (units)
No loss, no WIP	Total process cost	Input units
Normal loss, no WIP	Total cost − scrap of normal loss	Input − normal loss units
WIP present (Weighted Avg)	Opening WIP cost + current cost	Completed + closing WIP equivalent units
WIP present (FIFO)	Current-period cost only	Work done *this period* in equivalent units

The numerator always drops any recovery it should not carry (scrap); the denominator always counts only the units that genuinely *earned* that cost. Keep the two on the **same basis** and the answer is right by construction.

---

3. Why It Is Built This Way

Why cost the process, not the unit? Because the units are indistinguishable, tracing cost to one unit is both impossible and pointless — the average *is* the truth when every unit is identical. Averaging is not a shortcut here; it is the only correct answer.

Why a separate account for each process? Because management needs to know *where* cost and *where* loss arise. If sugar is dear this month, the board wants to know whether it was the boiling house or the centrifuge that bled money. A process account is a mini profit-and-loss window on one department. It also produces the transfer price for the next department automatically.

Why split loss into "normal" and "abnormal"? Because they mean opposite things to a manager. A 5% evaporation loss is a **law of physics** — you *plan* for it, and its cost is a legitimate cost of the good output. A 12% loss when you expected 5% is a **failure** — a broken valve, a careless operator — and burying its cost inside good units would hide the failure and overstate what the product "should" cost. Good accounting makes problems *visible*. So normal loss is absorbed by good units; abnormal loss is stripped out and sent to the Costing Profit & Loss Account where management can see it.

Why equivalent units? Because a half-finished unit consumed roughly half a unit's worth of cost, and pretending it is either a whole unit or nothing would distort the per-unit cost of the finished goods. We convert partly-done work into its "whole-unit equivalent" so the numerator and denominator match.

Why value abnormal loss at *full* cost but normal loss only at *scrap*? Because normal loss is a cost the good units are *meant* to bear — it never deserved a cost of its own, so we give it none beyond what the scrap market pays. Abnormal loss, by contrast, represents *good units that should have existed*; they absorbed full material, labour and overhead before being destroyed, so charging them at full cost is the only way to measure the true rupee value of the failure. The valuation rule is not a convention — it follows directly from *what the units economically represent*.

Every rule below is a servant of one master principle: **make the cost per unit reflect economic reality.**

---

4. Full Technical Content

4.1 The Process Account — the basic format

Each process gets a T-account. Debits = costs flowing *in*; credits = output and losses flowing *out*.

Dr — Process I Account	Units	₹	Cr	Units	₹
To Direct Materials	xxx	xxx	By Normal Loss (scrap value)	xx	xx
To Direct Wages		xxx	By Abnormal Loss	xx	xx
To Direct Expenses		xxx	By Process II A/c (transfer)	xxx	xxx
To Production Overhead		xxx	By Closing WIP	xx	xx
To Abnormal Gain	xx	xx			
Total					

Note where the two odd items sit: **Abnormal Loss** is a *credit* (it leaves the process, like output), while **Abnormal Gain** is a *debit* (it is added back). We will see why in a moment.

Reading the units column as a physical check. Before you trust a single rupee, make the **unit** columns balance: input units on the debit side (including abnormal gain units) must equal output + all loss units on the credit side. If the units do not tie, the rupees never will. This one-line check catches most careless errors.

Where each cost enters. Direct material of *the first* process is the true raw material. In later processes the biggest debit is usually **"To Process I A/c"** — the transferred-in cost — and any *additional* material added in that later process sits below it. Watch for a process that adds no fresh material at all: its only debits are the transfer-in plus its own wages and overhead.

4.2 Normal loss — planned, unavoidable

Normal loss = the loss that *must* happen under efficient operating conditions (evaporation, shrinkage, unavoidable rejects). It is expressed as a percentage of input and is decided in advance from engineering/experience.

Two consequences flow from "it is a cost of making good units":

1. **It carries no cost of its own.** Its cost is *absorbed by the good units*. We do this by removing the lost units from the denominator.
2. **If the scrap has a saleable value**, that recovery *reduces* the net cost to be spread over good units.

> **Cost per good unit = (Total process cost − Scrap value of normal loss) ÷ (Input units − Normal loss units)**

The normal-loss units appear on the credit side **valued only at their scrap/realisable value** (often nil). They are *never* valued at the full process cost — that is the whole point.

A finer distinction the examiner tests — "% of input" vs "% of output". Normal loss is *usually* a percentage of **input introduced**. But some questions say "normal loss is 5% of **output**" or "5% of units **inspected** after a certain stage." Read the exact base. If loss is "10% of input" on 1,000 units, loss = 100. If it is "10% of *good output*," you must solve: input − loss = output and loss = 10% × output, which is a small algebra step, not the obvious 10% × 1,000. Misreading the base is a classic silent error.

Waste vs scrap vs spoilage vs defectives — keep the vocabulary straight. These are *not* interchangeable, and a theory question may ask you to distinguish them:

- **Waste** — portion with *no* recoverable value (smoke, evaporation, gas). Normal waste simply shrinks the denominator; it has zero scrap credit.
- **Scrap** — residue with a *small* recoverable value (metal turnings). Normal scrap's realisable value reduces the numerator.
- **Spoilage** — units so damaged they cannot be rectified and are sold as *seconds* or scrapped.
- **Defectives** — units that *can* be **rectified** by extra work and then sold as good. Rectification cost of *normal* defectives is a production cost; of *abnormal* defectives it goes to Costing P&L.

4.3 Abnormal loss — the failure signal

Abnormal loss = actual loss *greater* than normal loss. It is the excess:

> **Abnormal loss units = Normal (expected) good output − Actual good output** (equivalently, Actual loss − Normal loss)

Because abnormal loss represents good units that *should* have been produced, it is valued at the **same cost per good unit** as the output — the full, honest per-unit cost:

> **Value of abnormal loss = Cost per good unit × Abnormal loss units**

It is credited out of the process (so it does not inflate the cost of good output), taken to an **Abnormal Loss Account**, where any scrap recovery on those units is credited, and the net loss is charged to the **Costing P&L Account**. Management now sees the rupee cost of inefficiency on the face of the accounts.

Do abnormal-loss units also fetch scrap? Yes — physically they are still destroyed and sold at the same scrap rate as normal loss. The scrap on abnormal units is credited *inside the Abnormal Loss Account* (not the Normal Loss Account), reducing the net charge to Costing P&L. The scrap rate is the same; only the *account* that receives the recovery differs. This is why the Abnormal Loss Account, not the process, absorbs it.

4.4 Abnormal gain — the pleasant surprise

Abnormal gain = when actual loss is *less* than the normal loss allowed — the process did better than the standard.

> **Abnormal gain units = Actual good output − Normal (expected) good output**

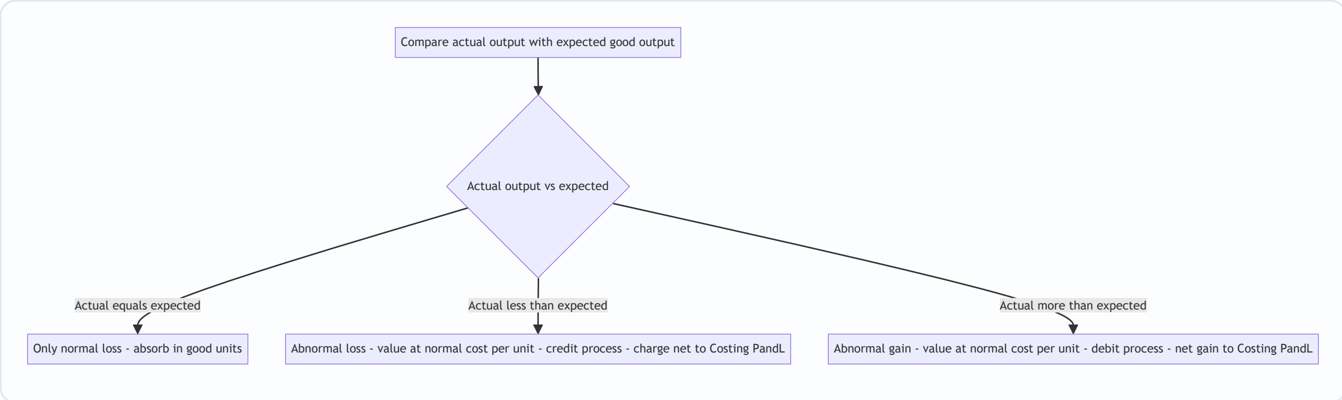
Now here is the subtlety that trips up half the exam hall. When we computed cost per unit, we *assumed* the full normal loss would occur and we credited the normal-loss account with the scrap value of the *full* normal loss. But fewer units were actually lost, so **we over-credited the scrap account** and must correct it. Hence:

- Abnormal gain is **debited to the process** (added back) at the **normal cost per good unit** — so the good units still bear only their fair average cost.
- The Abnormal Gain Account is credited by the process, then **debited** with the scrap value that was *not* realised (because those units were not actually scrapped), and the net gain goes to the **Costing P&L Account**.

This asymmetry — abnormal loss loses its scrap to P&L as a recovery, abnormal gain gives back scrap it never earned — is exactly why the two cannot be treated the same way.

Why abnormal gain is *always* valued at normal cost, never at the "period's own" cost. A tempting error is to recompute a fresh per-unit cost for the gain period. Don't. The per-unit rate is deliberately anchored to the **normal** loss assumption so that the good units carry their *standard* cost regardless of whether the process over- or under-performed. Abnormal gain is simply the mirror of abnormal loss; both use the *same* rate so that the two can be compared as pure efficiency swings.

Figure 2 — Deciding the treatment of any loss or gain.



4.5 Equivalent units (EU) — valuing the half-done

When there is opening or closing **work-in-progress**, the units are not all equally finished. A closing stock of 2,000 units that is 40% converted has, in cost terms, done the work of 2,000 × 40% = 800 fully-completed units. That 800 is its **equivalent units**.

> **Equivalent units = Physical units × Percentage of completion**

Crucially, completion is measured **separately for each cost element**, because materials, labour and overhead enter the process at different rates. Direct material is usually added *fully at the start*, so WIP is often 100% complete for material but only part-complete for **conversion cost** (labour + overhead). We therefore build a **statement of equivalent production** with a column per element.

The four-step engine: 1. **Statement of Equivalent Production** — convert physical output (completed, closing WIP, abnormal loss/gain) into EU, element by element. 2. **Statement of Cost per EU** — for each element, cost ÷ its equivalent units. 3. **Statement of Evaluation** — value each output stream (transferred, closing WIP, abnormal items) using the per-EU rates. 4. **Process Account** — post everything and confirm both sides balance.

The completion-percentage assumptions the examiner leans on. Unless told otherwise:

- **Direct material** introduced *at the beginning* → WIP is **100%** complete for material.
- **Conversion cost** accrues *evenly* → WIP is complete only to its stated stage (e.g. 60%).
- If a *second* material is added at, say, the 75% stage, then WIP that is only 60% done is **0%** complete for that second material — it has not reached the addition point yet. Multi-material questions hinge on *when* each material enters.

Where do loss units sit in the EU statement? This is the hardest sub-topic and section 4.8 below works it fully. In brief: **normal loss** carries no equivalent units (it absorbs no cost, so it is *excluded* from the EU columns), while **abnormal loss and abnormal gain** *do* appear as EU lines at their degree of completion — because they represent real work done (or, for gain, real work that must be added back).

4.6 Weighted Average vs FIFO — which cost, which units?

Once there is **opening WIP**, a question appears: this period's costs are mixed with last period's costs sitting in opening WIP. How do we combine them? Two philosophies:

Weighted Average (WA). Forget history. Treat opening-WIP cost and this period's cost as one pool, and treat all completed units alike. - EU denominator = **completed units (100%) + closing WIP EU**. Opening WIP is *not* separately adjusted — its prior work is simply swallowed into the average. - Cost per EU = **(opening WIP cost + current cost) ÷ EU**. - Simple; but it *blends* last period's rates into this period's — so it slightly blurs cost control.

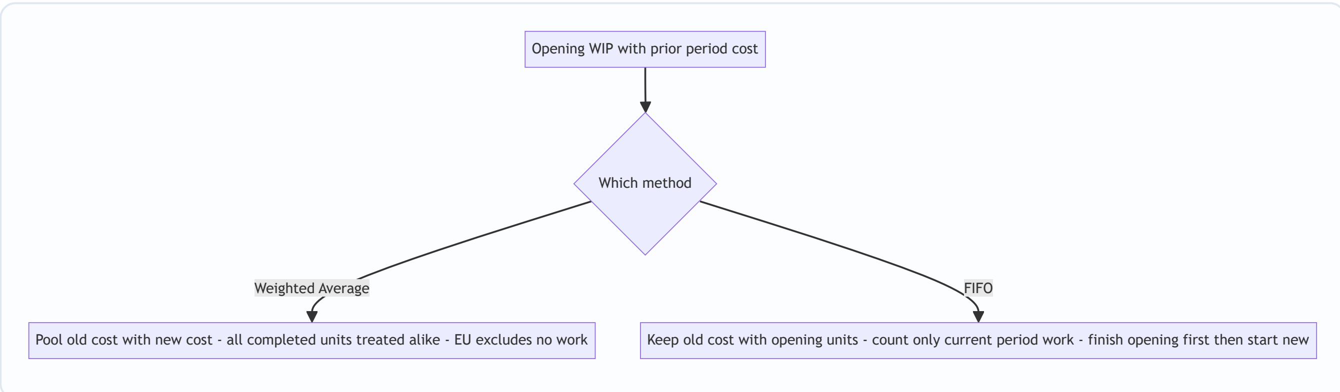
FIFO (First-In-First-Out). Respect the queue. The units in opening WIP are finished *first*, using their own already-incurred cost plus only the cost needed *this period to complete them*. Only then are fresh units started. - EU denominator = **work done this period only** = (opening WIP × % *remaining* to complete) + (units started *and* completed) + (closing WIP EU). - Cost per EU uses **current-period cost only**. - Cost of finished goods comes in two layers: (a) opening WIP's brought-forward cost + cost to finish it, and (b) started-and-completed units at current rates. - More work, but each period's cost per unit is "clean" — ideal for judging *this* period's efficiency.

Rule of thumb: if the question gives you opening WIP with its own cost breakdown and asks for FIFO, you must isolate current-period cost and current-period work. If it says "average", pool everything.

Why the two even differ — the intuition in one line. WA answers "*what did an average unit in stock-and-out cost this period?*"; FIFO answers "*what did it cost to do the actual work performed this period?*" When input prices are *rising*, FIFO's current rate is **higher** than WA's blended rate, so FIFO transfers out a slightly *lower* total (old cheap units leave first) and leaves *dearer* closing stock. When prices are stable, the two answers converge. Expect the examiner to comment on this in a theory sub-part.

A memory hook for the FIFO denominator. Work done this period = (finish the opening) + (do the middle whole) + (start the closing). Three physical layers, three EU contributions. If you can draw those three layers you never misplace a number.

Figure 3 — The two ways to handle opening WIP.



4.7 Inter-process profit — why a department books profit on a transfer

Sometimes management wants each process to look like a mini-business: it "sells" its output to the next process at **cost plus a profit margin** (market-based transfer price). Reasons: to judge each department's efficiency against an outside benchmark, and to reveal whether it is cheaper to make in-house or buy out.

This creates one accounting problem: any **closing stock lying inside a later process contains profit added by earlier processes that has not been realised by a sale to the outside world**. That is *unrealised profit* and must be removed when preparing the balance sheet, so stock is not overstated. We track each figure in **three columns — Cost, Profit, Total** — throughout, and compute:

> **Unrealised profit in closing stock = (Profit element in the total column ÷ Total column value) × Closing stock value**

The stock is shown in the balance sheet at **cost = total − unrealised profit**, and a **Stock Reserve** provision is created for the profit removed.

Advantages and disadvantages (the theory sub-part). Be ready to *justify* the system, not just operate it:

- *Advantages:* each process's efficiency is judged against market price; make-or-buy decisions become visible; a process running at a loss is exposed immediately.
- *Disadvantages:* the extra Cost/Profit/Total bookkeeping is laborious; unrealised profit must be eliminated for accounts and stock valuation, complicating closing entries; inter-process profit has **no effect on the firm's true profit** — it is purely a management-information device that nets to zero on consolidation.

The order-of-operations trap. Compute the **unrealised profit on *opening and closing* stock at *each* process separately**, then aggregate. The provision carried in the balance sheet is the *closing* stock reserve; the P&L absorbs the *movement* (closing reserve − opening reserve). Simple one-process questions ignore opening stock; multi-period ones don't.

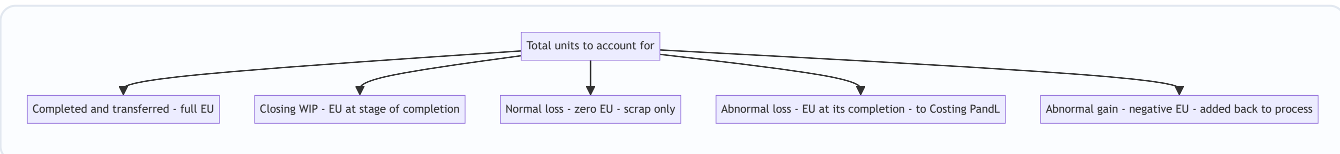
4.8 WIP *and* loss together — the combined statement

The single most demanding variant marries equivalent units with normal/abnormal loss. The discipline:

1. **Normal loss** — enter its physical units in the *reconciliation of units*, but give it **zero equivalent units** and **zero cost** beyond scrap. Its scrap value is deducted from the material cost (or from total cost) *before* computing cost per EU — exactly as in the no-WIP case.
2. **Abnormal loss** — enter it as an EU line at its **degree of completion** (if it is detected at, say, the end of processing, it is 100% complete for all elements; if detected at an inspection point part-way, use that stage). It is valued at the per-EU rates and credited out of the process to the Abnormal Loss Account.
3. **Abnormal gain** — same idea in reverse: an EU line (usually 100% complete) that is *subtracted* in the reconciliation and *debited* back to the process at the per-EU rates.

The subtle scrap adjustment under equivalent units. The scrap realised on normal loss is credited to the **material** element's cost (because loss is typically a material phenomenon) before dividing — so it lowers the material cost per EU, not the conversion cost per EU. Under **abnormal gain**, remember the same scrap correction as in the simple case: the gain account must return the scrap value of the units *not* actually lost to the Normal Loss Account.

Figure 4 — Placing every unit stream into the equivalent-production statement.



4.9 Operation costing — process costing at finer resolution

Operation costing applies when a product passes through a sequence of **small, standardised operations** rather than a few large processes. It is simply process costing zoomed in: the cost centre is the *operation*, not the whole department.

- Cost per unit **of each operation** = (operation cost − scrap recovery) ÷ good units of that operation.
- The unit cost of the finished article = **sum of the per-unit costs of every operation** it passes through.
- All the loss and equivalent-unit logic of process costing applies at operation level.

Its value is *precision*: because each operation is standardised and repetitive, cost per operation is stable and makes an excellent **control benchmark** — an operation drifting above its standard cost is spotted immediately. Industries: mass-manufactured components, toys, cycles, watches, electronics assembly, ready-made garments — anything built on a line of repetitive standardised steps.

---

5. Worked Examples

Example 1 — The clean case: normal loss with scrap value (no WIP)

Data. Process I: input 1,000 units @ ₹4.10 = ₹4,100; direct wages ₹3,000; production overhead ₹3,000. Normal loss is 10% of input; scrap realises ₹2 per unit. Actual output = 900 units, all transferred to Process II.

Step 1 — Normal loss. 10% of 1,000 = **100 units**, scrap value 100 × ₹2 = **₹200**.

Step 2 — Cost per good unit. Total cost = 4,100 + 3,000 + 3,000 = ₹10,100. Cost per unit = (10,100 − 200) ÷ (1,000 − 100) = 9,900 ÷ 900 = **₹11.00**.

Step 3 — Value output. 900 × ₹11 = **₹9,900**. Actual output equals expected good output (900), so there is **no abnormal loss or gain**.

Process I Account

Dr	Units	₹	Cr	Units	₹
To Materials	1,000	4,100	By Normal Loss (scrap)	100	200
To Wages		3,000	By Process II A/c	900	9,900
To Overhead		3,000			
Total	**1,000**	**10,100**	**Total**	**1,000**	**10,100**

Both sides agree at ₹10,100 and 1,000 units. **Reconciled.**

Example 2 — Abnormal loss (and its account)

Data. Process input 2,000 units @ ₹5 = ₹10,000; wages ₹5,000; overhead ₹4,000. Normal loss 10% of input; scrap value ₹5 per unit. **Actual output = 1,700 units.**

Step 1 — Normal loss & expected output. Normal loss = 10% × 2,000 = **200 units** (scrap 200 × ₹5 = **₹1,000**). Expected good output = 2,000 − 200 = **1,800 units**.

Step 2 — Cost per good unit (always on the *normal* basis): Total cost = 10,000 + 5,000 + 4,000 = ₹19,000. Cost per unit = (19,000 − 1,000) ÷ (2,000 − 200) = 18,000 ÷ 1,800 = **₹10.00**.

Step 3 — Abnormal loss. Actual output 1,700 < expected 1,800 → shortfall = **100 units abnormal loss**, valued at ₹10 = **₹1,000**.

Process Account

Dr	Units	₹	Cr	Units	₹
To Materials	2,000	10,000	By Normal Loss (scrap)	200	1,000
To Wages		5,000	By Abnormal Loss	100	1,000
To Overhead		4,000	By Finished/Next Process	1,700	17,000
Total	**2,000**	**19,000**	**Total**	**2,000**	**19,000**

Abnormal Loss Account. The 100 abnormal-loss units are still physically scrapped, fetching ₹5 each = ₹500. The rest is a real loss to the business.

Dr — Abnormal Loss A/c	₹	Cr	₹
To Process A/c (100 × 10)	1,000	By Bank (scrap 100 × 5)	500
		By Costing P&L A/c	500
Total	**1,000**	**Total**	**1,000**

Management sees a clean **₹500 loss from inefficiency** — not buried in product cost. **Reconciled.**

Example 3 — Abnormal gain (and the scrap correction)

Data. Input 1,000 units @ ₹8 = ₹8,000; wages ₹1,600; overhead ₹1,600. Normal loss 10% of input; scrap value ₹4 per unit. **Actual output = 950 units.**

Step 1. Normal loss = 100 units (scrap 100 × ₹4 = ₹400). Expected good output = 900 units.

Step 2 — Cost per good unit: Total cost = 8,000 + 1,600 + 1,600 = ₹11,200. Cost per unit = (11,200 − 400) ÷ (1,000 − 100) = 10,800 ÷ 900 = **₹12.00**.

Step 3 — Abnormal gain. Actual 950 > expected 900 → **50 units abnormal gain**, valued at ₹12 = **₹600**. Abnormal gain is *debited* to the process.

Process Account

Dr	Units	₹	Cr	Units	₹
To Materials	1,000	8,000	By Normal Loss (scrap)	100	400
To Wages		1,600	By Finished/Next Process	950	11,400
To Overhead		1,600			
To Abnormal Gain A/c	50	600			
Total	**1,050**	**11,800**	**Total**	**1,050**	**11,800**

(Output valued 950 × 12 = 11,400.)

The scrap correction. We credited Normal Loss with scrap on the *full* 100 units (₹400), but only 100 − 50 = **50 units were actually scrapped**, earning 50 × ₹4 = ₹200. The scrap account has been over-credited by ₹200, which belongs to the abnormal gain (those 50 gained units never became scrap).

Abnormal Gain Account

Dr — Abnormal Gain A/c	₹	Cr	₹
To Normal Loss A/c (scrap not realised 50 × 4)	200	By Process A/c (50 × 12)	600
To Costing P&L A/c (net gain)	400		
Total	**600**	**Total**	**600**

Normal Loss Account (to see the whole loop)

Dr — Normal Loss A/c	Units	₹	Cr	Units	₹
To Process A/c	100	400	By Bank (actual scrap 50 × 4)	50	200
			By Abnormal Gain A/c	50	200
Total	**100**	**400**	**Total**	**100**	**400**

Net gain to Costing P&L = **₹400**. Every account closes. **Reconciled.**

Example 4 — Equivalent units: Weighted Average vs FIFO on identical data

Data. A process has: - **Opening WIP:** 4,000 units — Materials 100% complete (valued ₹18,000); Conversion 50% complete (valued ₹20,000). - **Units introduced this period:** 16,000. - **Costs added this period:** Materials ₹1,32,000; Conversion ₹1,68,000. - **Completed and transferred out:** 18,000 units. - **Closing WIP:** 2,000 units — Materials 100%, Conversion 40%. - No process loss.

Material is added fully at start; "conversion" = labour + overhead combined.

Physical reconciliation: In = 4,000 + 16,000 = 20,000. Out = 18,000 + 2,000 = 20,000. ✓

4A — Weighted Average method

Step 1 — Statement of Equivalent Production

Output	Units	Material %	Material EU	Conversion %	Conversion EU
Completed & transferred	18,000	100	18,000	100	18,000
Closing WIP	2,000	100	2,000	40	800
Total EU			**20,000**		**18,800**

Step 2 — Cost per EU (opening cost pooled with current cost)

Element	Opening ₹	Added ₹	Total ₹	EU	Cost/EU ₹
Material	18,000	1,32,000	1,50,000	20,000	7.50
Conversion	20,000	1,68,000	1,88,000	18,800	10.00
Total	**38,000**	**3,00,000**	**3,38,000**		**17.50**

Step 3 — Evaluation - Transferred out: 18,000 × ₹17.50 = **₹3,15,000**. - Closing WIP: Material 2,000 × 7.50 = 15,000 + Conversion 800 × 10 = 8,000 = **₹23,000**.

Step 4 — Check: 3,15,000 + 23,000 = **₹3,38,000** = total cost pooled. ✓

4B — FIFO method (same data)

Under FIFO we count **only work done this period** and use **only current-period cost**.

Units **started and completed** this period = completed − opening WIP = 18,000 − 4,000 = **14,000**.

Step 1 — Statement of Equivalent Production (FIFO)

Output	Units	Material EU	Conversion EU
To complete Opening WIP (Mat 0%, Conv 50% remaining)	4,000	0	2,000
Started & completed	14,000	14,000	14,000
Closing WIP (Mat 100%, Conv 40%)	2,000	2,000	800
Total EU (work done this period)		**16,000**	**16,800**

Step 2 — Cost per EU (current-period cost only)

Element	Added ₹	EU	Cost/EU ₹
Material	1,32,000	16,000	8.25
Conversion	1,68,000	16,800	10.00
Total	**3,00,000**		**18.25**

Step 3 — Evaluation

Completed & transferred (18,000 units), in two layers: - Opening WIP finished: brought-forward cost 38,000 + cost to complete conversion (2,000 EU × 10) 20,000 = **₹58,000** (for 4,000 units). - Started & completed: 14,000 × ₹18.25 = **₹2,55,500**. - **Total transferred = 58,000 + 2,55,500 = ₹3,13,500.**

Closing WIP (2,000 units): Material 2,000 × 8.25 = 16,500 + Conversion 800 × 10 = 8,000 = **₹24,500**.

Step 4 — Check: 3,13,500 + 24,500 = ₹3,38,000 = opening 38,000 + added 3,00,000. ✓

The lesson in the contrast. Same facts, both reconcile to ₹3,38,000, yet transferred cost differs: **WA ₹3,15,000 vs FIFO ₹3,13,500.** FIFO isolates this period's material rate (₹8.25) instead of blending it down with last period's cheaper material (WA ₹7.50) — so FIFO is the sharper tool for period-on-period cost control, while WA is simpler.

Example 5 — WIP *and* abnormal loss together (the combined statement)

This is the hardest common variant — it forces every rule of section 4.8 into one problem.

Data (Weighted Average). - Opening WIP: **nil** (kept nil to isolate the loss logic). - Units introduced: 12,000 @ material ₹6,00,000. - Conversion cost this period: ₹3,29,000. - **Normal loss:** 10% of input; scrap value ₹10 per unit. - Completed & transferred: 9,000 units. - Closing WIP: 1,500 units — Material 100%, Conversion 60%. - Balancing figure is the loss.

Step 1 — Reconcile physical units. Input 12,000. Accounted so far: completed 9,000 + closing WIP 1,500 = 10,500. Normal loss = 10% × 12,000 = **1,200**. Units still unexplained = 12,000 − 10,500 − 1,200 = **300 → abnormal loss.** (Actual total loss 1,500 > normal 1,200, so 300 abnormal.)

Step 2 — Statement of Equivalent Production. Normal loss gets **zero EU**; abnormal loss is detected at end of process, so it is **100% complete** for both elements.

Output	Units	Material EU	Conversion EU
Completed & transferred	9,000	9,000	9,000
Closing WIP (Mat 100%, Conv 60%)	1,500	1,500	900
Abnormal loss (100%)	300	300	300
Normal loss (zero EU)	1,200	—	—
Total EU	**12,000**	**10,800**	**10,200**

Step 3 — Cost per EU. Scrap of *normal* loss reduces the **material** cost first: normal-loss scrap = 1,200 × ₹10 = **₹12,000**.

Element	Cost ₹	Less normal scrap ₹	Net ₹	EU	Cost/EU ₹
Material	6,00,000	12,000	5,88,000	10,800	54.4444
Conversion	3,29,000	—	3,29,000	10,200	32.2549
Total	**9,29,000**		**9,17,000**		**86.6993**

(Rates kept to 4 dp so the reconciliation closes exactly; in an exam, carry the fraction and round only the final answers.)

Step 4 — Evaluation. - Completed & transferred: 9,000 × 86.6993 = **₹7,80,294**. - Closing WIP: Material 1,500 × 54.4444 = 81,667 + Conversion 900 × 32.2549 = 29,029 = **₹1,10,696**. - Abnormal loss: 300 × 86.6993 = **₹26,010**. - Check: 7,80,294 + 1,10,696 + 26,010 = ₹9,17,000 = net cost pooled. ✓

Step 5 — Abnormal Loss Account. Those 300 units still fetch scrap at ₹10 = ₹3,000.

Dr — Abnormal Loss A/c	₹	Cr	₹
To Process A/c (300 units)	26,010	By Bank (scrap 300 × 10)	3,000
		By Costing P&L A/c	23,010
Total	**26,010**	**Total**	**26,010**

Reading the result. Normal loss silently shrank the denominator and cheapened material; abnormal loss surfaced as a **₹23,010 charge to P&L** that no good unit had to carry. Both WIP and loss were handled in one statement — exactly what the examiner is testing. **Reconciled.**

What if the examiner tweaks it — loss detected part-way? If inspection happens at the **conversion 50% stage**, abnormal loss would be **100% material** but only **50% conversion** (150 conversion EU, not 300). The completed and WIP lines are unchanged; only the abnormal-loss EU shrinks, raising the conversion cost/EU slightly. Always read *where* inspection occurs.

Example 6 — Inter-process profit and unrealised profit in stock

Data. Product passes through Process I and Process II, then to Finished Stock. Each process transfers at a profit.

- **Process I:** Materials ₹20,000 + Wages ₹20,000 = cost ₹40,000. Output transferred to Process II at ₹50,000 (profit ₹10,000). No closing stock in I.
- **Process II:** receives transfer ₹50,000; adds Materials ₹30,000 and Wages ₹10,000. **Closing stock in Process II = ₹18,000** (at transfer/total value). Output transferred to Finished Stock at cost-of-goods + 25% profit on transfer price.

We keep three columns — **Cost, Profit, Total** — throughout.

Process I — all self-generated cost, so: Cost ₹40,000, Profit ₹10,000, **Total ₹50,000** transferred out.

Process II — goods available before its own profit:

Element	Cost ₹	Profit ₹	Total ₹
Transfer from Process I	40,000	10,000	50,000
Materials added	30,000	—	30,000
Wages added	10,000	—	10,000
Goods available	**80,000**	**10,000**	**90,000**

(The profit ₹10,000 in the Total column came entirely from Process I.)

Unrealised profit in Process II closing stock. The ₹18,000 closing stock carries the *same proportion* of embedded profit as the goods available:

> Unrealised profit = 18,000 × (Profit 10,000 ÷ Total 90,000) = 18,000 × 0.1111 = **₹2,000**.

So closing stock splits as Cost ₹16,000 + Profit ₹2,000 = Total ₹18,000. Its **balance-sheet value = cost ₹16,000**, and a **Stock Reserve of ₹2,000** is created.

Cost of goods transferred out of Process II (goods available − closing stock):

	Cost ₹	Profit ₹	Total ₹
Goods available	80,000	10,000	90,000
Less Closing stock	16,000	2,000	18,000
Cost of output	**64,000**	**8,000**	**72,000**

Add Process II's own profit at 25% on transfer price. Transfer price = 72,000 ÷ 0.75 = ₹96,000, so profit added = **₹24,000**.

Transferred to Finished Stock:

	Cost ₹	Profit ₹	Total ₹
Transfer to Finished Stock	64,000	8,000 + 24,000 = **32,000**	96,000

Reconciling the true profit. - Apparent profit shown in the two processes = 10,000 (I) + 24,000 (II) = ₹34,000. - Less unrealised profit locked in Process II closing stock = ₹2,000. - **Realised (actual) profit = ₹32,000** — exactly the Profit column of the goods that actually moved to Finished Stock. ✓

The three-column discipline delivered both the correct stock value (₹16,000) *and* the correct realised profit (₹32,000) in one pass.

What if the examiner tweaks it — a margin "on cost" instead of "on transfer price"? Read the phrase precisely. "25% **on transfer price**" (as above) → profit = cost ÷ 0.75 − cost. "25% **on cost**" → profit = 0.25 × cost = 0.25 × 72,000 = ₹18,000, giving a transfer of ₹90,000. The two produce different transfer prices from identical cost — mixing them is a guaranteed lost mark.

Example 7 — Operation costing: unit cost built operation-by-operation

Data. A cycle-pedal is made in three standardised operations. Input to Operation 1 = 10,000 blanks. Each operation has its own cost and its own normal rejection.

Operation	Input units	Normal reject	Good output	Operation cost ₹
1 — Press	10,000	2% (200)	9,800	39,200
2 — Machine	9,800	100	9,700	29,100
3 — Polish	9,700	100	9,600	19,200

Rejects have no scrap value. Output of each operation feeds the next.

Per-unit cost of each operation = operation cost ÷ good units of that operation: - Operation 1: 39,200 ÷ 9,800 = **₹4.00** - Operation 2: 29,100 ÷ 9,700 = **₹3.00** - Operation 3: 19,200 ÷ 9,600 = **₹2.00**

Cost per finished pedal = sum across the operations it survived = 4.00 + 3.00 + 2.00 = **₹9.00**.

Cross-check via total cost / final good output would be *wrong* here, because rejects at each stage mean earlier operation costs are borne by fewer surviving units — which is precisely why operation costing computes the rate *stage by stage* and **adds**. Total spend = 39,200 + 29,100 + 19,200 = ₹87,500; final good units = 9,600; naive average = ₹9.11, which **overstates nothing but hides where cost sits**. The operation method's ₹9.00 correctly loads each surviving unit with each operation's own per-unit cost. The ₹0.11 gap is the cost of units rejected *after* absorbing early-operation cost — in a fuller treatment it is charged as the cost of normal rejection carried by survivors, and the operation-wise build-up already embeds it stage by stage.

The exam value. Operation costing tells management the standard cost of *each* operation (₹4 / ₹3 / ₹2). If the polishing operation next month costs ₹2.40 per unit, the control signal is instant and localised — the whole point of costing per operation rather than per process. **Reconciled at the operation level.**

---

6. Presentation & Format

Order of statements (with WIP): always present them in this sequence so the examiner can follow the logic — 1. Statement of Equivalent Production 2. Statement of Cost per Equivalent Unit 3. Statement of Evaluation (apportionment of cost) 4. Process Account (final posting)

Process Account conventions: - Show **units and rupees** in parallel columns on both sides; both column-totals must agree. - Credit side order: **Normal Loss (at scrap value) → Abnormal Loss → Transfer to next process/Finished → Closing WIP.** - Abnormal Gain appears on the **debit** side; Abnormal Loss on the **credit** side. - Normal loss is valued at **scrap value only** (nil if not saleable); abnormal loss/gain at **normal cost per unit**.

Supporting accounts to open: Normal Loss A/c, Abnormal Loss A/c, Abnormal Gain A/c, Costing P&L A/c. For inter-process profit, maintain **Cost / Profit / Total** columns and a **Stock Reserve A/c**.

Inter-process transfer: the total of one process's output becomes the opening debit ("To Process I A/c") of the next.

Rounding discipline. When cost per EU is not exact (e.g. ₹86.6993), **carry the unrounded rate through evaluation and round only the final rupee figures** — otherwise the process account will fail to balance by a few rupees and you will waste minutes hunting a "phantom" difference. If a small residual remains after honest rounding, adjust it against the largest figure (usually transferred-out) and state that you have done so.

Show the physical-unit reconciliation first. A one-line "units to account for = units accounted for" statement at the top earns method marks and catches the abnormal loss/gain as a *balancing figure* before you touch rupees.

---

7. Connections

- **Job & Batch Costing (Ch. 9):** the mirror image — job costing traces cost to *distinct* orders; process costing *averages* over identical continuous output. Batch costing sits between them. Knowing *which* the business is tells you which method is legal.
- **Joint Products & By-products:** a specialised process-costing situation where one process yields *several* different outputs from a common cost — the apportionment logic (physical units, sales value) is the sequel to this chapter.
- **Material & Labour Costing (Ch. 02–03):** the material, wages and overhead that feed each process account are computed with those chapters' tools; normal loss connects to **normal wastage** treatment in material control.
- **Overheads (Ch. 04):** production overhead absorbed into each process is the output of departmental absorption rates.

- **Cost Control & Standard Costing:** abnormal loss/gain are the raw material of variance analysis — they quantify inefficiency in rupees, which standard costing later refines.
- **Service/Operating Costing:** the same "cost the operation, divide by output" idea, applied to services (per passenger-km, per bed-day) instead of goods.
- **Cost Sheet & Reconciliation:** the transfer-to-finished-stock figure from the last process becomes the *cost of production* line in the cost sheet; abnormal loss/gain are among the items that make cost profit differ from financial profit in a reconciliation statement.

---

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Valuing normal loss at full cost.** Normal loss units get **scrap value only** — never the per-unit process cost. Putting the full cost there destroys the whole absorption logic.
2. **Wrong denominator.** Cost per unit divides by **(input − normal loss)**, *not* by input. Forgetting to subtract normal loss inflates units and understates cost per unit.
3. **Forgetting scrap value in the numerator.** Deduct the scrap value of normal loss from cost *before* dividing. Skipping it overstates cost per unit.
4. **Abnormal loss/gain valued at the wrong rate.** Both are valued at the **normal cost per good unit**, using the same formula that priced the output — never at scrap value.
5. **The abnormal-gain scrap correction.** Examiners love this. When there is abnormal gain, the Normal Loss and Abnormal Gain accounts must exchange the **scrap value of the units that were *not* actually lost**. Omitting it leaves the accounts unbalanced.
6. **Abnormal gain on the wrong side.** Gain is a **debit** to the process (added back); loss is a **credit**. Reversing them is an instant red flag.
7. **FIFO with the wrong EU.** Under FIFO, opening WIP contributes only the **percentage remaining to be done**, not its full units. Counting opening WIP at 100% turns FIFO into (wrong) weighted average.
8. **Mixing current and total cost in FIFO.** FIFO uses **current-period cost only** for the per-EU rate; the opening WIP cost is added back as a *lump* when valuing completed goods.
9. **Element-wise completion ignored.** Material is usually 100% complete in WIP while conversion is partial. Applying one blanket percentage to all elements misvalues WIP.
10. **Abnormal loss/gain units in the EU statement.** When there is *both* WIP *and* abnormal loss/gain, the abnormal units must appear as a line in the equivalent-production statement (abnormal loss at its degree of completion; treat consistently). Normal loss, by contrast, gets **zero EU**.
11. **Inter-process profit — unrealised profit.** Compute it on **closing stock**, using the **profit-to-total ratio of goods available** (not the transfer margin). Show stock in the balance sheet **net of** this profit.
12. **Scrap value of abnormal loss forgotten.** Abnormal-loss units are still sold as scrap; that recovery reduces the amount charged to Costing P&L (inside the Abnormal Loss A/c, *not* the process).
13. **Misreading the loss base.** "10% of input" ≠ "10% of output" ≠ "10% of units inspected at stage X." Solve the algebra when the base is output; do not reflexively take 10% of input.
14. **"Profit on cost" vs "profit on transfer/selling price."** In inter-process profit and transfer pricing, the phrase decides the divisor (÷0.75 vs ×0.25). Read it exactly.
15. **Scrap of normal loss reducing the *wrong* element.** With equivalent units, normal-loss scrap is deducted from the **material** cost before computing material cost/EU — not spread across conversion.

16. **Rounding the per-EU rate too early.** Carry the fraction; round only final figures, or the process account will be out by a few rupees.
17. **Transferred-in cost treated as fresh material.** In Process II+, the transfer-in is its own debit line ("To Process I A/c"); do not merge it into "materials added," and remember it is usually **100% complete** for the receiving process from the first moment.
18. **Confusing defectives with spoilage.** Defectives can be *rectified* (extra cost, then sold as good); spoilage cannot. Normal rectification cost is a production cost; abnormal goes to P&L.

---

9. First-Principles Recap

Start from one immovable fact: **the output is identical and continuous, so no unit can be individually traced.** From that fact, everything else is forced:

- Because units are identical → **average** cost by dividing total process cost by good units. (The bucket.)
- Because production flows through stages → keep a **separate account per process** and **transfer accumulated cost forward.** (The relay.)
- Because some loss is unavoidable → call it **normal**, give it no cost, let good units absorb it, and value it only at scrap. Because loss beyond that signals failure → call it **abnormal**, value it at full unit cost, and **expose it in P&L** so management sees the rupees. Because doing *better* than the standard over-credits the scrap we assumed → **abnormal gain** is added back and must **return the unearned scrap.**
- Because closing accounts catches units half-done → convert them to **equivalent units** so numerator and denominator match, element by element.
- Because opening WIP mixes old and new cost → choose **weighted average** (pool and blend, simple) or **FIFO** (finish the queue first, clean current-period rate).
- Because we want each process judged like a business → transfer at **cost plus profit**, and strip the **unrealised profit** out of stock so the balance sheet tells the truth.
- Because a product may pass through many tiny standardised steps → cost **per operation** and sum them, so control is localised to the step that drifted.

If you can regenerate every formula from "identical + continuous → average, honestly," you never need to memorise them.

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

Cost per good unit (no WIP):

> (Total process cost − Scrap value of normal loss) ÷ (Input units − Normal loss units)

Normal loss: units = % × input (read the base!); valued at **scrap value only**; **zero EU**; absorbed by good units.

Abnormal loss: = Expected good output − Actual output; valued at **normal cost/unit**; appears as an **EU line at its completion**; **credit** process → Abnormal Loss A/c → (less scrap recovery) → **Costing P&L**.

Abnormal gain: = Actual output − Expected good output; valued at **normal cost/unit**; **debit** process; Abnormal Gain A/c is **debited** with scrap value not realised (to Normal Loss A/c), net gain → **Costing P&L**.

Equivalent units: = Physical units × % completion, **computed per cost element**; watch *when* each material enters.

	Denominator (EU)	Cost used
Weighted Avg	Completed 100% + Closing WIP EU	Opening WIP cost **+** current cost
FIFO	(Opening WIP × % to *complete*) + Started-&-completed + Closing WIP EU	**Current period cost only**

FIFO completed-goods cost = Opening WIP cost b/f + cost to complete it + (Started & completed × current rate).

Rising prices: FIFO rate > WA rate → FIFO transfers out slightly less, leaves dearer closing stock.

Statement order: Equivalent Production → Cost per EU → Evaluation → Process A/c.

Process A/c layout: Dr = Materials, Wages, Expenses, Overhead, **Abnormal Gain**. Cr = **Normal Loss (scrap)**, **Abnormal Loss**, **Transfer/Finished**, **Closing WIP**.

Inter-process profit: keep **Cost / Profit / Total** columns.

> Unrealised profit in closing stock = Closing stock × (Profit in total column ÷ Total column value) Balance-sheet stock = Total − Unrealised profit; create **Stock Reserve** for the difference. Realised profit = Sum of process profits − Unrealised profit in closing stocks. Watch "profit on cost" (×margin) vs "profit on transfer price" (÷ [1 − margin]).

Operation costing: cost per operation = (operation cost − scrap) ÷ good units of that operation; **finished-unit cost = Σ operation costs**. Same loss/EU logic per operation. Choose it when a product passes through many small standardised operations and you want per-operation control.

Method choice: homogeneous + continuous + untraceable → process costing (chemicals, sugar, cement, paper, oil, textiles). Distinct orders → job/contract. Standardised components in a customised final product → **hybrid**.

Golden checks before you close: (1) Do the process-account **unit** totals agree? (2) Do the **rupee** totals agree? (3) Did you value normal loss at **scrap** and abnormal items at **full cost**? (4) In FIFO, did you use **current cost** and **remaining** work only? (5) Did you carry the per-EU rate unrounded and round only at the end?

Q&A — Process & Operation Costing

CA Intermediate · Cost & Management Accounting · ICAI-aligned · all amounts in Rupees (₹)

SECTION A — Concept Check (short answers)

A1. Why is process costing used instead of job costing? When output is continuous, homogeneous and produced through a sequence of distinct operations (chemicals, cement, sugar, refining), individual units cannot be identified. Cost is therefore **averaged** over all units of a process for a period: Cost per unit = Total process cost ÷ Output units.

A2. Name the four sub-problems process costing must solve. (1) Where does cost accumulate — the **process account**; (2) how to treat **losses/gains** (normal loss, abnormal loss, abnormal gain); (3) how to cost **part-finished** units — **equivalent units**; (4) how to pick a **cost-flow assumption** — **FIFO vs Weighted Average**; plus inter-process profit for transfer pricing.

A3. Distinguish normal vs abnormal loss. Normal loss = unavoidable, expected loss (evaporation, spoilage) allowed as a % of input; it bears **no cost** — its cost is absorbed by good units and its scrap value reduces process cost. **Abnormal loss** = loss above normal; it is **valued at the same cost per good unit** and charged to Costing P&L (not to good output).

A4. What is abnormal gain and when does it arise? When **actual loss < normal loss**, i.e. actual output exceeds expected output. It is valued at the normal cost per unit, debited to the Process A/c and credited to Abnormal Gain A/c. Its scrap-value adjustment **reduces** the Normal Loss recovery (see B4/B-trap).

A5. Give the cost-per-effective-unit formula (normal loss present). Cost per unit = (Total cost of process − Scrap value of normal loss) ÷ (Input units − Normal loss units).

A6. Equivalent units (EU) — define. EU convert partly-finished work into the notionally-complete units they represent: EU = Physical units × % completion, computed **separately** for material, labour and overhead.

A7. One-line difference: Weighted Average vs FIFO EU. WA merges opening WIP with current cost and does not separate opening-WIP work done last period. **FIFO** separates: EU = work to complete opening WIP + units started-and-finished + closing WIP. FIFO cost/unit reflects **only current-period** cost.

A8. What is inter-process profit and its danger? Transferring output between processes at cost + profit margin; it reveals process efficiency and comparability with market price. Danger: **unrealised profit** locked in unsold closing stock must be eliminated for the Balance Sheet.

SECTION B — Graded Computational Problems

B1 (Easy) — Normal loss only

Input to Process A: 1,000 units @ ₹20 = ₹20,000. Additional cost ₹15,000. Normal loss 10% of input, scrap realises ₹5/unit. No abnormal loss/WIP.

Solution. Normal loss = 10% × 1,000 = 100 units → scrap value = 100 × ₹5 = ₹500. Expected output = 1,000 − 100 = 900 units. Cost per unit = (20,000 + 15,000 − 500) ÷ 900 = 34,500 ÷ 900 = **₹38.333**.

Process A A/c	Units	₹		Units	₹
Input	1,000	20,000	Normal loss	100	500
Add. cost	—	15,000	Output (900×38.333)	900	34,500
	1,000	**35,000**		**1,000**	**35,000**

Reconciles: 900 + 100 = 1,000 units; ₹34,500 + ₹500 = ₹35,000. ✓

B2 (Moderate) — Abnormal loss + account

Same data as B1 but **actual output = 850 units** (so actual loss = 150).

Solution. Normal loss 100 units (scrap ₹500). Cost/unit unchanged = ₹38.333 (normal-loss scrap only affects the divisor of expected output). Abnormal loss = Expected output 900 − Actual output 850 = **50 units** valued at ₹38.333 = **₹1,917** (rounded).

Process A A/c	Units	₹		Units	₹
Input	1,000	20,000	Normal loss	100	500
Add. cost	—	15,000	Abnormal loss	50	1,917
			Output	850	32,583
	1,000	**35,000**		**1,000**	**35,000**

Abnormal Loss A/c: Dr from Process ₹1,917 (50 u). Cr: scrap sale 50 × ₹5 = ₹250; Costing P&L (balance) = ₹1,667. Check: 500 + 1,917 + 32,583 = ₹35,000. ✓ Output 850 × 38.333 = ₹32,583. ✓

B3 (Moderate–hard) — Abnormal gain with scrap correction

Input 1,000 units @ ₹20 = ₹20,000; additional cost ₹15,000; normal loss 10%, scrap ₹5/unit. **Actual output = 930 units** (actual loss 70 < normal 100).

Solution. Cost per unit = (35,000 − 500) ÷ 900 = **₹38.333** (divisor = expected output 900). Abnormal gain = Actual 930 − Expected 900 = **30 units** × ₹38.333 = **₹1,150**.

Process A A/c	Units	₹		Units	₹
Input	1,000	20,000	Normal loss	100	500
Add. cost	—	15,000	Output	930	35,650
Abnormal gain	30	1,150			
	1,030	**36,150**		**1,030**	**36,150**

Scrap correction (the trap): actual scrap sold is only for real loss of 70 units, but Normal Loss A/c was credited for 100 units × ₹5. The 30 gain units' "lost" scrap is reversed: **Abnormal Gain A/c:** Dr Normal Loss scrap forgone 30 × ₹5 = ₹150; Cr Process ₹1,150 → net **₹1,000 to Costing P&L (profit).** Check output value 930 × 38.333 = ₹35,650. ✓

B4 (Hard) — Equivalent units: WA vs FIFO

Process data for the month: Opening WIP 400 units (Material 100%, ₹8,000; Conversion 40%, ₹2,400). Introduced 2,000 units; Material ₹42,000; Conversion ₹30,600. Closing WIP 300 units (Material 100%, Conversion 30%). No losses.

Units completed & transferred = 400 + 2,000 − 300 = **2,100 units.**

(a) Weighted Average

Element	Completed	Closing WIP EU	Total EU	Cost (₹)	Cost/EU
Material	2,100	300×100%=300	2,400	8,000+42,000=50,000	20.833
Conversion	2,100	300×30%=90	2,190	2,400+30,600=33,000	15.068

Cost/unit completed = 20.833 + 15.068 = **₹35.901**. Transferred out = 2,100 × 35.901 = **₹75,393**. Closing WIP = 300×20.833 + 90×15.068 = 6,250 + 1,356 = **₹7,606**. Check: 75,393 + 7,606 = ₹82,999 ≈ ₹83,000 total (50,000+33,000). ✓ (₹1 rounding)

(b) FIFO

Element	Complete op. WIP	Started&finished	Closing WIP	Total EU	Current cost	Cost/EU
Material	400×0%=0	1,700	300	2,000	42,000	21.000
Conversion	400×60%=240	1,700	90	2,030	30,600	15.074

Started & finished = 2,100 completed − 400 opening = 1,700. Cost of the 1,700 fresh units = 1,700 × (21 + 15.074) = 1,700 × 36.074 = **₹61,326**. Opening WIP completed = brought-forward ₹10,400 + conversion 240×15.074 = ₹3,618 → ₹14,018. Total transferred = 61,326 + 14,018 = **₹75,344.** Closing WIP = 300×21 + 90×15.074 = 6,300 + 1,357 = **₹7,657.** Check: 75,344 + 7,657 = 83,001 ≈ opening 10,400 + current 72,600 = ₹83,000. ✓

Takeaway: WA blends the ₹20/unit-ish opening material with dearer current material; FIFO isolates current cost (₹21 material). Different valuations, same total.

B5 (Exam-hard) — Inter-process profit with unrealised profit

Process I transfers output to Process II at cost + 25% on transfer price... simplified: transfer at **cost + 20% mark-up on cost**. Process I total cost ₹60,000; transferred to II at cost + 20% = ₹72,000 (profit ₹12,000). Process II own cost added ₹28,000. Of Process II output, **closing stock = 25%** remains unsold (still in II), rest transferred to Finished Stock at cost + 25% on transfer price... to keep clean, take Process II closing stock at transfer-in value.

Unrealised profit in Process II closing stock: Closing stock 25% carries transferred-in element. Transferred-in portion in closing stock = 25% × ₹72,000 = ₹18,000, of which profit element = 25% × ₹12,000 = **₹3,000 unrealised.** For the Balance Sheet, closing stock is reduced by ₹3,000 (stock reserve), so Process II stock is stated at cost to the firm, not at inter-process profit.

Provision for Unrealised Profit A/c carries ₹3,000; the increase is charged to P&L, ensuring profit is recognised **only on units actually sold/transferred out**, never on internally-held stock.

SECTION C — Past-paper-style Full Question

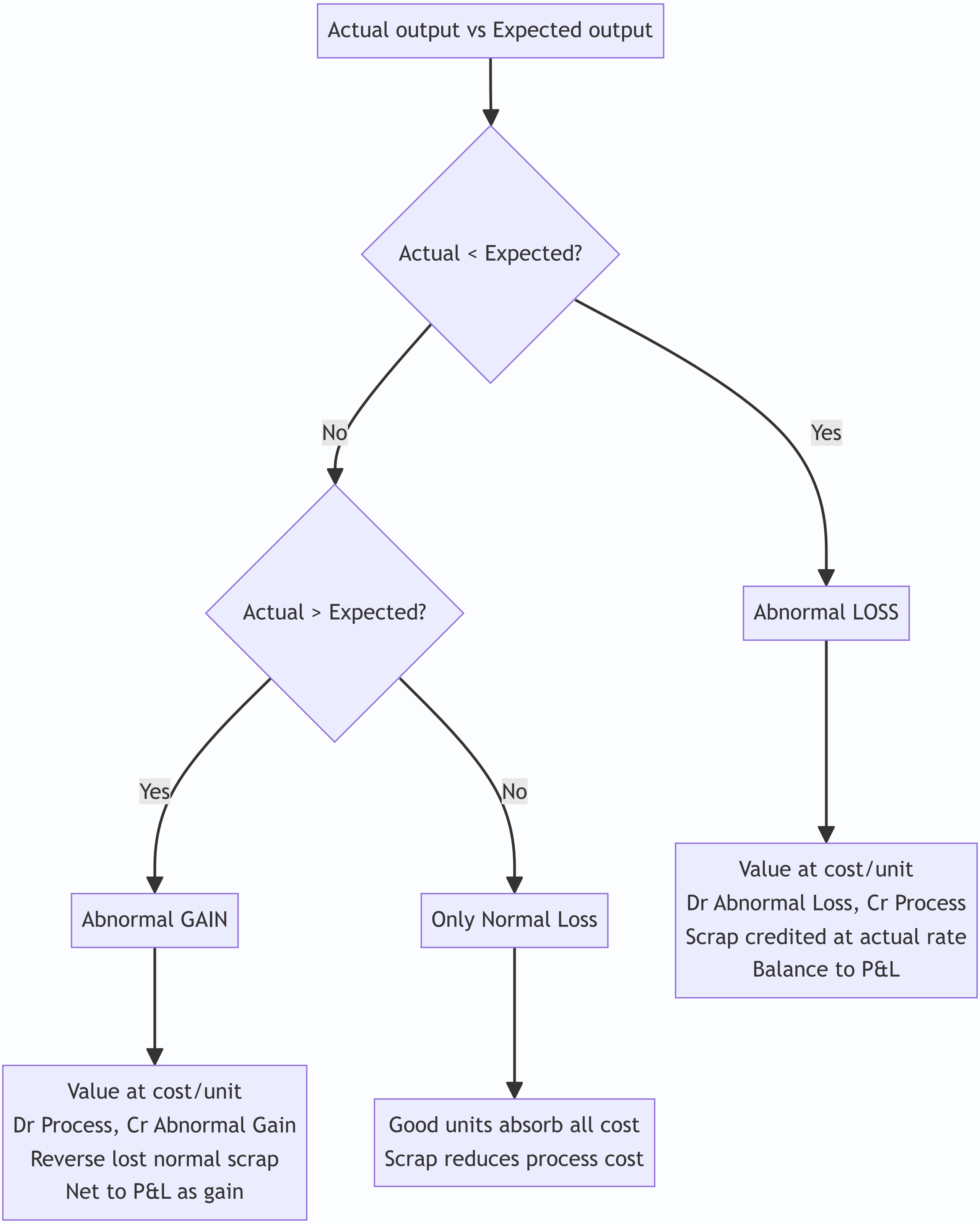
C1. A product passes through Process X. Data: Input 12,000 kg @ ₹4 = ₹48,000; Labour ₹18,000; Overhead ₹12,000. Normal loss 5% of input, scrap ₹6/kg. Actual output 11,000 kg. Prepare Process X A/c and Abnormal Loss A/c.

Model answer. Normal loss = 5% × 12,000 = 600 kg; scrap value 600 × ₹6 = ₹3,600. Expected output = 12,000 − 600 = 11,400 kg. Total cost = 48,000 + 18,000 + 12,000 = ₹78,000. Cost/unit = (78,000 − 3,600) ÷ 11,400 = 74,400 ÷ 11,400 = **₹6.5263/kg.** Abnormal loss = 11,400 − 11,000 = 400 kg × 6.5263 = **₹2,611.**

Process X A/c	kg	₹		kg	₹
Material	12,000	48,000	Normal loss	600	3,600
Labour	—	18,000	Abnormal loss	400	2,611
Overhead	—	12,000	Output	11,000	71,789
	12,000	**78,000**		**12,000**	**78,000**

Abnormal Loss A/c: Dr Process ₹2,611 (400 kg). Cr scrap 400×₹6 = ₹2,400; Costing P&L ₹211. Check: 3,600 + 2,611 + 71,789 = ₹78,000. ✓ Output 11,000 × 6.5263 = ₹71,789. ✓

Mermaid — Loss/Gain decision flow



SECTION D — MCQs & Case Scenarios

D1. Cost per unit divisor when normal loss exists is: (a) Input units (b) Actual output (c) **Input − Normal loss units** ✓ (d) Input + gain. *Reason: normal loss units bear no cost, so they leave the denominator.*

D2. Abnormal gain is: (a) Credited to P&L as loss (b) **Valued at normal cost/unit and credited to Abnormal Gain A/c** ✓ (c) Ignored (d) Added to normal loss. *Reason: gain units are costed like good units.*

D3. Under FIFO, equivalent units include: (a) Opening WIP full units (b) **Only work needed to complete opening WIP + started-finished + closing WIP** ✓ (c) Closing WIP at 100% (d) Normal loss. *Reason: FIFO isolates current-period effort.*

D4. Scrap value of normal loss is credited to: (a) P&L (b) Abnormal Loss (c) **Normal Loss A/c / reduces process cost** ✓ (d) Finished stock. *Reason: it lowers the net cost absorbed by good units.*

D5. Unrealised inter-process profit is eliminated because: (a) It is a real cash loss (b) **Stock held internally is not yet sold, profit unearned** ✓ (c) Tax rule (d) Scrap adjustment. *Reason: prudence — recognise profit only on external realisation.*

D6 (Case). Process Y: expected output 4,750 units, actual 4,800. This means: (a) Abnormal loss 50 (b) **Abnormal gain 50** ✓ (c) Normal loss rose (d) No adjustment. *Reason: actual > expected → 50-unit abnormal gain, debited to Process A/c.*

D7 (Operation costing). Operation costing (service costing) uses a **composite cost unit** such as: (a) Per batch (b) **Per passenger-km / per tonne-km** ✓ (c) Per job (d) Per contract. *Reason: services combine two variables (quantity × distance).*

Quick-Revision Sheet

- **Cost/unit (normal loss)** = (Total cost − Normal scrap) ÷ (Input − Normal loss units).
- **Abnormal loss units** = Expected output − Actual output (positive); **Abnormal gain** = Actual − Expected.
- Abnormal loss/gain **valued at normal cost per unit**; net effect to Costing P&L.
- **Abnormal gain scrap trap:** reverse the normal-loss scrap on gain units (Dr Abnormal Gain).
- **Normal loss** = no cost, scrap reduces process cost; never valued at cost/unit.
- **EU** computed element-wise (Material / Labour / OH). WA merges opening; FIFO separates current cost.
- **FIFO transferred-out** = opening WIP carried cost + completion cost + started-&-finished units.
- **Inter-process profit:** eliminate unrealised profit in closing stock via Stock Reserve for the Balance Sheet.
- **Operation/Service costing:** composite units — tonne-km, passenger-km, patient-day, kWh; classify costs into fixed (standing), variable (running), maintenance.
- Always **reconcile units and rupees** on both sides of every Process A/c before finalising.

Chapter 11 — Joint Products & By-Products

1. The Problem — One Furnace, Many Children

Every costing technique you have met so far rests on a quiet assumption: that a cost can, in principle, be *traced* to the thing that caused it. Job costing traces material and labour to a job card. Process costing traces cost to a stream of identical units flowing through a department. Even overhead, that slippery beast, is *apportioned* on some cause-and-effect logic (floor area, machine hours) so that in the end every rupee finds a home.

Now meet a class of industries where that assumption simply collapses.

Feed a barrel of **crude oil** into a refinery and heat it. Out of the *same* distillation column, at the *same* moment, from the *same* input, come petrol, diesel, kerosene, naphtha, lubricating oil and bitumen. Crush an **oilseed** and you get edible oil *and* oil-cake. Slaughter a **carcass** in a meat plant and you get prime cuts, offal, hide, bone and fat. Refine **sugar** and you get crystal sugar *and* molasses *and* bagasse. Smelt an **ore** and you recover copper *and* silver *and* gold from one furnace. Process **milk** and you get cream, butter, skimmed milk and casein.

Here is the killer question. The refinery spends ₹2,00,000 heating one batch of crude. How much of that ₹2,00,000 belongs to the **diesel**, and how much to the **petrol**?

There is no honest answer. You cannot say "the diesel used more heat" because the heat was applied to the crude *as a whole*, before diesel and petrol even existed as separate substances. The cost was incurred **jointly**, on a mixture, at a stage when the individual products had not yet been born. You literally cannot buy petrol-heat and diesel-heat separately. The cost is common by *physics*, not by accounting laziness.

This is the **joint cost apportionment problem**, and it is the reason this chapter exists. We must find a *defensible* way to split a cost that is, by its nature, unsplittable — and we must know that whatever we do is a convention, not a truth. Worse, some of the products that emerge are trivial in value (the bagasse, the offal, the oil-cake), and lumping them in with the main products distorts everything. Those minor products — **by-products** — need their own treatment.

And lurking behind all of it is a decision trap: once petrol emerges, should the firm *sell it now* or *process it further* into a higher-grade fuel? Get the relevant-cost logic wrong here and you will happily destroy profit while congratulating yourself.

A second, subtler reason the chapter matters — inventory valuation. These same apportioned figures do not stay inside cost accounts; they become the **cost of closing stock** of each joint product on the balance sheet. So an "arbitrary" split is not merely academic — it shifts reported profit between periods by changing how much cost sits in unsold inventory. That is why AS 2 / Ind AS 2 explicitly address joint-product allocation (see §7). A costing convention chosen for internal decisions ends up touching the audited financial statements, which is precisely why examiners take it seriously.

---

2. The Core Idea — The Shared Womb and the Moment of Birth

Picture a shared cooking pot. You put in stock, vegetables, spices and simmer for two hours. That two hours of gas is the **joint cost**. At the end you ladle the pot into three different bowls — a clear soup, a thick stew, a spicy broth. The instant you ladle them apart is the **split-off point** — the moment the products become *separately identifiable*.

Two truths flow from this image, and they govern the entire chapter:

Truth 1 — Before split-off, cost belongs to the pot, not the bowls. Any cost incurred *before* the ladle (the gas, the stock, the labour of stirring) is joint cost. It attaches to the *mixture*. Splitting it between bowls is an act of allocation by *convention* — we choose a sharing key (weight? value?) and live with it.

Truth 2 — After split-off, cost belongs to the bowl. If you then garnish the stew, or reduce the broth further, *that* cost is traceable to one product. It is a **further-processing cost** (also called *separable* or *subsequent* cost), and it never gets pooled or apportioned — it is charged directly to the product that incurred it.

So the whole subject organises itself around one vertical line — the split-off point:

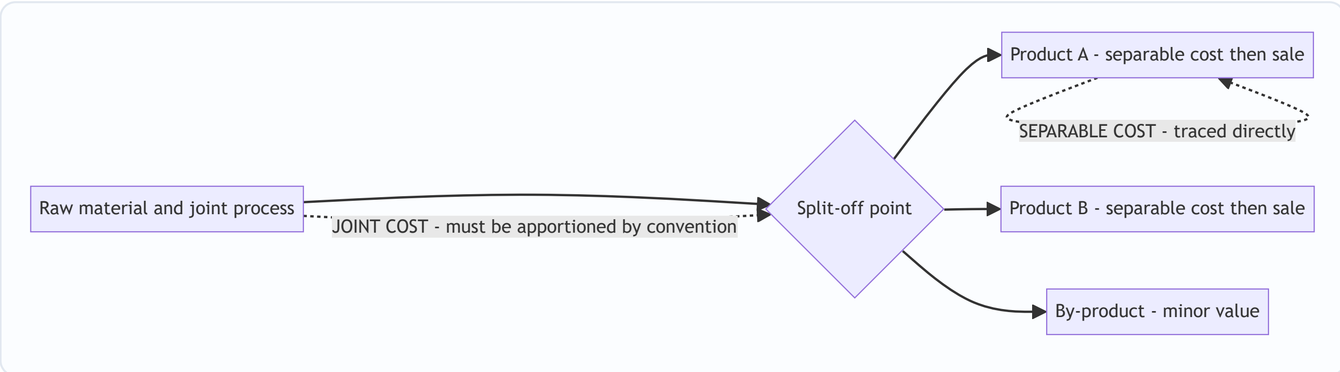


Figure 1 — The split-off point is the fault line: everything to its left is joint and must be shared by a rule; everything to its right is separable and belongs to one product.

A word on vocabulary — "apportion" vs "allocate". In strict cost-accounting language, *allocation* means charging a whole cost to one cost object because it belongs wholly to it (traceable), while *apportionment* means *splitting* a shared cost across several objects on some equitable base. Joint cost, being untraceable, is **apportioned**, never allocated. Separable cost, being traceable, is **allocated** (charged directly). Examiners occasionally use the words loosely, but if a one-mark question asks "can joint cost be allocated?", the technically correct answer is *no — it can only be apportioned on a convention.*

The analogy that unlocks the popular method: how would you fairly split the two-hour gas bill between soup, stew and broth? By *weight*? But a kilo of clear soup is worth far less than a kilo of rich stew — splitting by weight would dump most of the cost on the cheap, watery product and make it look unprofitable while the valuable stew looks like a goldmine. That is absurd. The fairer instinct is to split cost in proportion to what each bowl is *worth* — its ability to *bear* cost. That single instinct is the seed of the **Net Realisable Value method**, and it is why NRV dominates real practice.

---

3. Why It's Built This Way — Cost-Bearing Ability vs. Physical Bulk

Before we lay out mechanics, understand the philosophical fork, because every apportionment method is just one side of it.

There are only two possible bases for sharing a joint cost:

(a) Share by physical bulk — weight, volume, units. The logic: the process worked on physical stuff, so heavier products "used more of the process." Clean, objective, arithmetic — no market prices needed. Its fatal flaw: it ignores value. If your process yields 1 tonne of a ₹5/kg by-slurry and 100 kg of a ₹500/kg concentrate, the physical method loads ~91% of the cost onto the cheap slurry, showing it at a colossal loss and the concentrate at an absurd profit. That is not information; it is noise. Physical apportionment is only sensible when the products have *roughly similar value per unit*.

(b) Share by value — market realisation, or net realisable value. The logic: a joint cost is a *common* cost, and the classic accounting principle for sharing common costs is **"the beneficiary who gains most should bear most."** A product that fetches ₹500/kg is extracting far more benefit from the shared process than one fetching ₹5/kg; let it carry proportionately more cost. This is the **cost-bearing-ability** principle. Its beauty: it prevents any product from *automatically* showing a loss or profit merely because of the apportionment convention. Its cost: you need selling prices, and if products need further processing you must strip that out (hence *net* realisable value).

The deeper "why" — why value-based methods refuse to create phantom profits. Consider what happens under a *pure market-value* split. Because you apportion cost in the exact ratio of value, every product ends up with the *same* ratio of cost-to-value — i.e., the *same* gross-margin percentage. No product can look like a star or a dog *purely because of the split*. Contrast the physical method, which is blind to price and therefore routinely manufactures fake winners and losers. So the choice between the two bases is really a choice between "let the arithmetic of weight decide who is profitable" (dangerous) and "refuse to let the split itself decide profitability" (safe). Examiners phrase this as "*value-based apportionment does not distort the relative profitability of joint products*." Learn that sentence.

ICAI examiners lean on value-based methods precisely because joint-product decisions (which to push, whether to process further) must never be corrupted by an arbitrary weight-based split. But they still test physical units, the **weighted / survey** variant, and the elegant **constant gross-margin** method, so you must master all of them. The map:

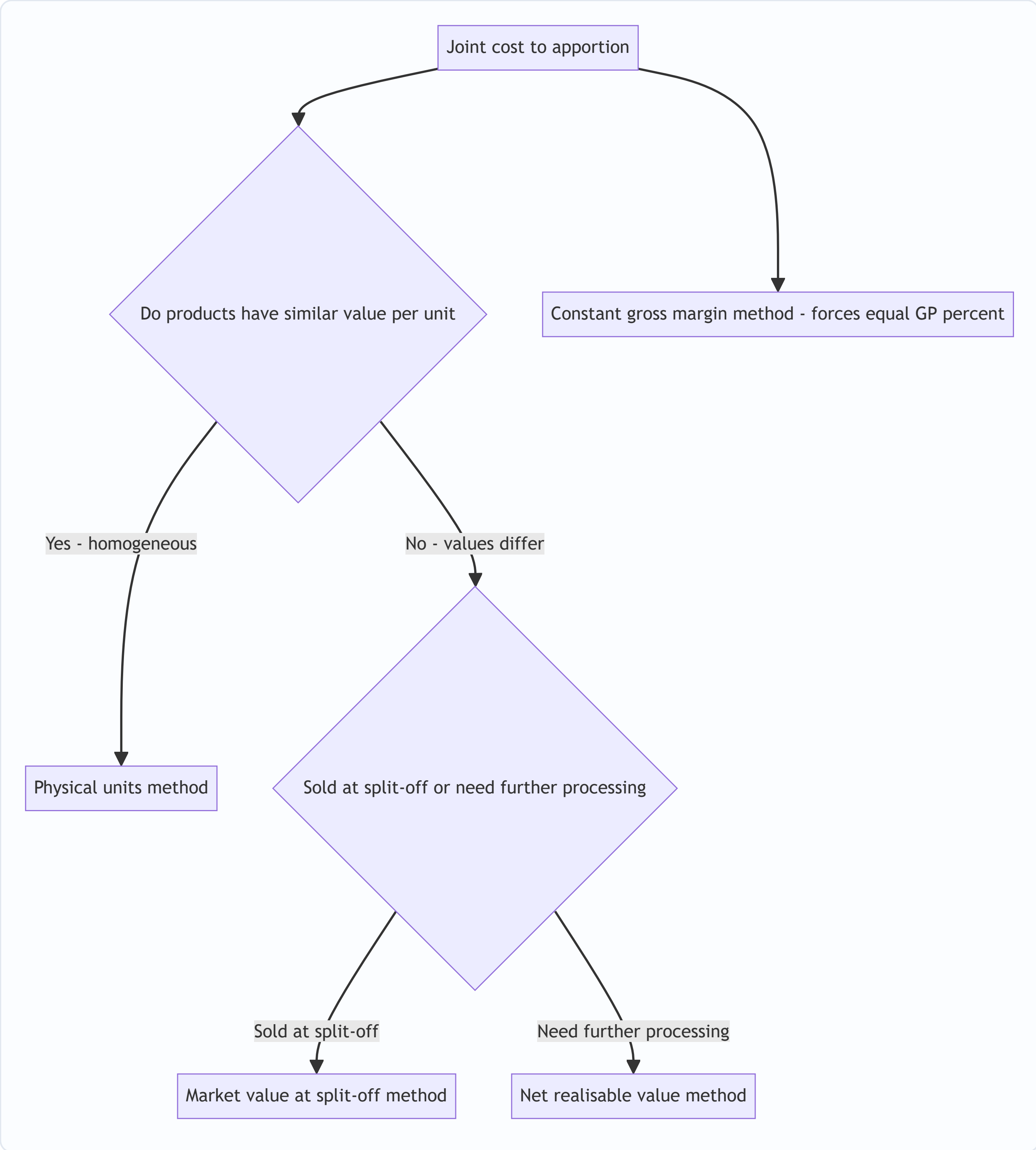


Figure 2 — Choosing an apportionment method: homogeneity pushes you to physical units; value differences push you to a market-based method; NRV handles the common case where products are processed after split-off.

---

4. Full Technical Content — Methods, Formulas and Entries with the "Why"

4.1 Definitions the examiner will hold you to

- **Joint products**: two or more products, each of *significant sales value*, produced *simultaneously* from a common process and common raw material, such that none can be regarded as the "main" product.

(Petrol and diesel; edible oil and oil-cake in some framings.)

- **By-product**: a product of *relatively minor sales value* emerging *incidentally* alongside the main product(s) from the same process (molasses from sugar; sawdust from timber). The line between joint product and by-product is *relative sales value* and can shift over time — if the by-product's price soars, it may get reclassified as a joint product.
- **Co-products**: products made *together but not necessarily from the same raw material or process* and often in *controllable* proportions (e.g., different wheat varieties on adjacent fields). Distinguish from joint products, which come from *one* process in *fixed, uncontrollable* proportions. (Frequently asked as a one-mark distinction.)
- **Split-off point**: the point at which joint products become individually identifiable.
- **Joint cost**: total cost incurred up to the split-off point.
- **Separable / subsequent / further-processing cost**: cost incurred on an individual product *after* split-off.

The four-way discrimination the examiner loves — product vs by-product vs scrap vs waste. These are ranked by value, and mixing them up is a classic slip:

Term	Value	Arises	Treatment
Joint / main product	High, significant	Deliberately, main aim	Bears apportioned joint cost
By-product	Minor but *saleable*	Incidentally	Net realisation *credited to* joint cost; no joint cost pushed onto it
Scrap	Small, *residual* material value	Incidentally in a process	Net realisation credited to the specific job/process; recorded, sold as-is
Waste	*Nil or negative* (may cost to dispose)	Loss/shrinkage	No value; disposal cost *added* to process cost

The subtle exam point: **scrap and by-product are treated almost identically** (both credited back), but a by-product usually has a distinct identity and may itself need further processing, whereas scrap is residual material (offcuts, filings). **Waste** is the odd one out — it can carry a *negative* value because you may pay to dispose of it, and that disposal cost is *added* to the joint cost, raising the burden on the main products.

Why proportions being "uncontrollable" matters. Joint products emerge in a **fixed, technologically-determined ratio** — a refiner cannot choose to make "only petrol." This is what separates joint products from co-products (controllable mix) and is the reason you cannot manage the mix by simply making more of the profitable one. It also explains why the *further-processing* decision is the only real lever management has over a single joint product: you cannot change *how much* of it you get, only *what you do with it after* it appears.

4.2 Method 1 — Physical Units (Average Unit Cost) Method

Apportion joint cost in the ratio of the **physical quantity** (kg, litres, units) of each product at the split-off point.

$$\text{Cost per unit} = \frac{\text{Total joint cost}}{\text{Total units of all joint products}}$$

$$\text{Joint cost to a product} = \text{Cost per unit} \times \text{Units of that product}$$

- **Why it exists**: objective, needs no prices, ideal when products are physically similar and similarly priced.

- **The "why" of its weakness**: it silently assumes every kilo is equally valuable — false whenever prices differ. It can throw up products that "make a loss" purely because of the split.
- **Caution — consistent units**: if products come out in different units (litres vs kg vs cubic metres) you must convert to a *common* unit first, else the ratio is meaningless.
- **Caution — output vs input, and normal loss.** Apportion on the **output at split-off**, not on the input fed in. If the process suffers a normal loss (evaporation, trimming), the lost units simply disappear from the denominator — they are *not* a product and get no cost; their cost is automatically absorbed by the good output (exactly as in ordinary process costing). Watch for questions that quote input quantity to bait you into using the wrong denominator.

4.2a Method 1(b) — Weighted / Survey / Points Method (the refined physical method)

Pure physical units treats every kilo as equal. But sometimes products differ in *some measurable technical attribute* — richness, purity, difficulty of production, calorific value — even though a market price is unavailable or unreliable. The **survey method** (also *weighted average* or *points* method) fixes a **weight factor** (points) for each product reflecting that attribute, then apportions on **weighted units = physical units × weight factor**.

$$\text{Weighted units of a product} = \text{Physical output} \times \text{Weight (points) factor}$$

$$\text{Joint cost to a product} = \text{Total joint cost} \times \frac{\text{Its weighted units}}{\text{Total weighted units}}$$

- **Why it exists**: it keeps the objectivity of a physical basis (no market prices needed) but corrects for the fact that a kilo of one product genuinely embodies more of the process's effort/value than a kilo of another. It is the honest middle ground when value data are missing but the products are clearly *not* homogeneous.
- **Where the weights come from**: engineering/technical survey, historical prices, or management judgement — hence "survey" method. The exam will *give* you the points; you just apply them.
- **Trap**: do not also multiply by physical units a second time, and do not forget that the *rate* is now "per weighted unit," not per physical unit.

4.3 Method 2 — Market Value at Split-Off Point

Apportion joint cost in the ratio of the **sales value of each product at the split-off point** (quantity × selling price *at split-off*).

- **Why it exists**: applies cost-bearing ability directly using the price the product would fetch the instant it is born. Theoretically the *cleanest* value method because it uses the value *created by the joint process alone*, uncontaminated by later processing.
- **When you can use it**: only when a market price *exists at split-off*. Often it doesn't — petrol has no meaningful "half-refined" market — which is exactly why NRV was invented.
- **Weighting subtlety**: use the *sales value* (quantity × price), not the price alone. Two products at the same price per unit but different volumes must be weighted by their total split-off value, not treated equally.

4.4 Method 3 — Net Realisable Value (NRV) Method — the workhorse

When products are processed *further* after split-off, their final selling price includes value added *after* the joint process. Charging joint cost on final sales value would over-reward the heavily-processed product. So we strip the after-split value back out:

$$\text{NRV at split-off} = \text{Final sales value} - \text{Post-split-off (separable) costs} - \text{Selling / distribution costs}$$

Then apportion joint cost in the ratio of NRVs.

Why NRV is the popular method (know this cold — it's a favourite theory question): 1. **It handles the realistic case** — most joint products *are* processed further, so a pure split-off price rarely exists; NRV *reconstructs* an equivalent split-off value. 2. **It respects cost-bearing ability** — cost follows value, so no product is condemned to an artificial loss. 3. **It isolates the joint process's own contribution** — by subtracting separable costs, it credits each product only with the value the *joint* stage created, which is what the joint cost should be shared against. 4. **It keeps the further-processing decision honest** — because separable costs are removed before apportionment, they remain visible as *incremental* costs for the "process further?" decision rather than being buried.

The exam's favourite tweak — should profit be stripped out too? Some questions ask you to apportion on **"NRV after deducting an estimated profit margin"** (sometimes called *net realisable value after profit* or the *reverse cost* variant). Standard NRV apportionment does **not** deduct notional profit — it deducts only separable and selling costs. Deducting profit is a feature of the *by-product reverse-cost* method (see §4.6), not of joint-product NRV. If a joint-product question says "apportion on NRV," do **not** deduct profit; if it says "apportion on the basis of cost, working back a normal margin," then you do. Read the instruction literally.

4.5 Method 4 — Constant (Uniform) Gross-Margin Percentage Method

The idea: since all products spring from one process, force *every* product to show the *same* gross-margin percentage on sales. Work backwards to find the joint cost that achieves this.

Steps: 1. Overall gross-margin % = (Total final sales − Total costs [joint + all separable]) ÷ Total final sales. 2. For each product: Gross profit = its sales × that %. 3. Total cost of each product = its sales − its gross profit. 4. **Joint cost of each product = its total cost − its own separable cost.**

- **Why it exists**: it embodies the view that no product is inherently "more profitable" than another when they share an unavoidable common origin — profitability differences would be an accident of the sharing rule, so eliminate them.
- **The catch to watch**: because it forces uniform margins, a product with *heavy* separable cost can be pushed to a *very low* or even **negative** joint-cost allocation. That is mathematically correct and reconciles, but shocks students. Do not "fix" it. (Worked in Example 6.)
- **Why NRV and constant-margin diverge**: NRV equalises the *cost-to-value ratio at split-off*; constant-margin equalises the *cost-to-value ratio on final sales*. They coincide only when all products have zero (or proportionally identical) separable cost. Whenever separable costs differ in proportion to value, the two methods give different splits — both perfectly valid.

4.6 By-Product Accounting — two philosophies

By-products are minor, so the accounting aim is *simplicity*, not precision. Two families:

(A) Non-cost / Sales-value methods — treat by-product realisation as a *reduction of cost* or as *income*, without apportioning any joint cost *to* the by-product. - **(i) Other income**: net sales of by-product credited to Costing P&L as miscellaneous income. Crudest; used when value is truly negligible and erratic. Note the consequence — because nothing is credited to the *process*, the main product's cost per unit is *unaffected* by the by-product; only the final profit rises. - **(ii) Credit to process (net realisable value method for by-products)**: **Net** realisation of the by-product (its sales *less* its own selling and further-processing costs) is *deducted from the joint cost* of the main product before apportioning to the joint products. **This is the most common and examiner-preferred treatment.** Logic: the by-product's sale effectively *recovers* part of the joint cost, so the main products should bear only the *net* joint cost. This *does* lower the main product's cost per unit — the key difference from the "other income" method.

(B) Cost methods — actually assign a cost *to* the by-product: - **(i) Opportunity / replacement cost method**: used when the by-product is *not sold* but *consumed internally* (e.g., fed back as fuel or raw material). Value it at the price the firm would otherwise have *paid to buy* it, and credit the main process with that saving. - **(ii) Standard cost method**: charge the by-product out at a pre-set standard cost; any difference stays in the main product. Used for control where by-product volumes are steady. - **(iii) Reverse-cost / working-back method**: start from the by-product's ultimate sale value and subtract *estimated profit, selling costs and post-split processing costs* to arrive back at a notional share of joint cost to remove from the main product. Used when the by-product has appreciable, stable value and you want a defensible joint-cost credit. (Worked in Example 5.)

The controlling rule: for by-products you almost never apportion joint cost *forward onto* them; you use their realisation to *claw back* joint cost *off* the main products.

Which by-product method to pick? The examiner usually forces the choice with a phrase. Use this map:

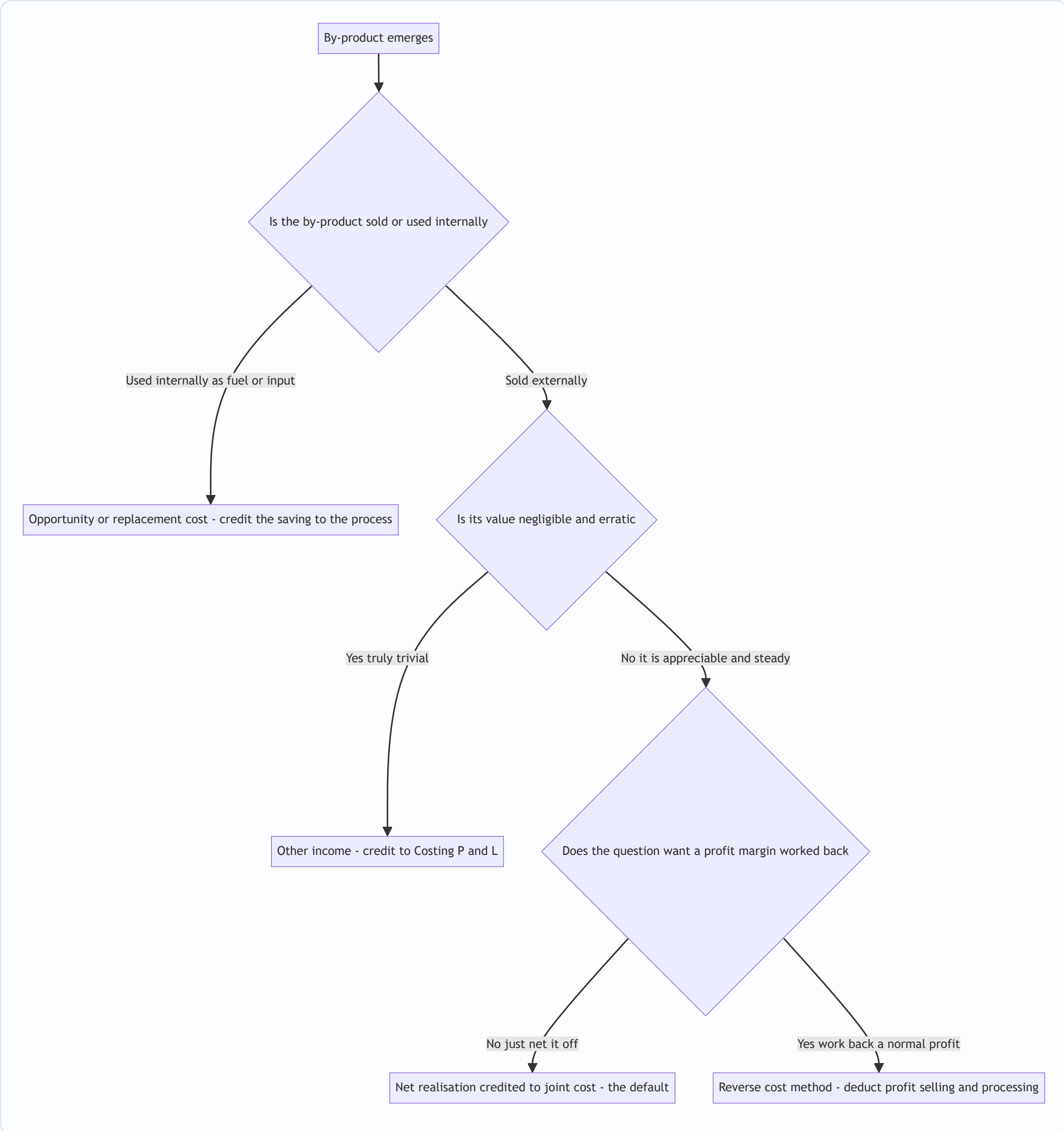


Figure 4 — Selecting a by-product treatment. The default for a saleable by-product is to credit net realisation to joint cost; the wording of the question shifts you to the other methods.

By-product that needs further processing — do not forget the "net". If the by-product itself must be processed after split-off before sale, its own separable cost is deducted in arriving at *net* realisation. The credit to the main process is *net* of that separable cost, never gross. This is the single most common by-product slip after forgetting selling cost.

4.7 The Further-Processing Decision — relevant costs only

This is where students hemorrhage marks. Once a product exists at split-off you may sell it *as is* or *process it further* and sell it dearer. The decision rule is pure incremental analysis:

$$\text{Process further only if } \; \underbrace{(\text{Sales value after} - \text{Sales value at split-off})}_{\text{Incremental revenue}} \; > \; \underbrace{\text{Further-processing cost}}_{\text{Incremental cost}}$$

The single most important sentence in this chapter:

> **The joint cost apportioned to a product is IRRELEVANT to the further-processing decision.**

Why? Because the joint cost is *already incurred* the moment you reach split-off — it is **sunk**, and it is **identical** whether you sell now or process further. It cannot change with the decision, so it must not enter it. Only the *incremental* revenue and the *incremental* (separable) cost differ between the two courses of action; only they are relevant. A product can look "unprofitable" after joint-cost apportionment yet still be worth processing further — or worth selling at split-off — entirely independently of that apportioned figure.

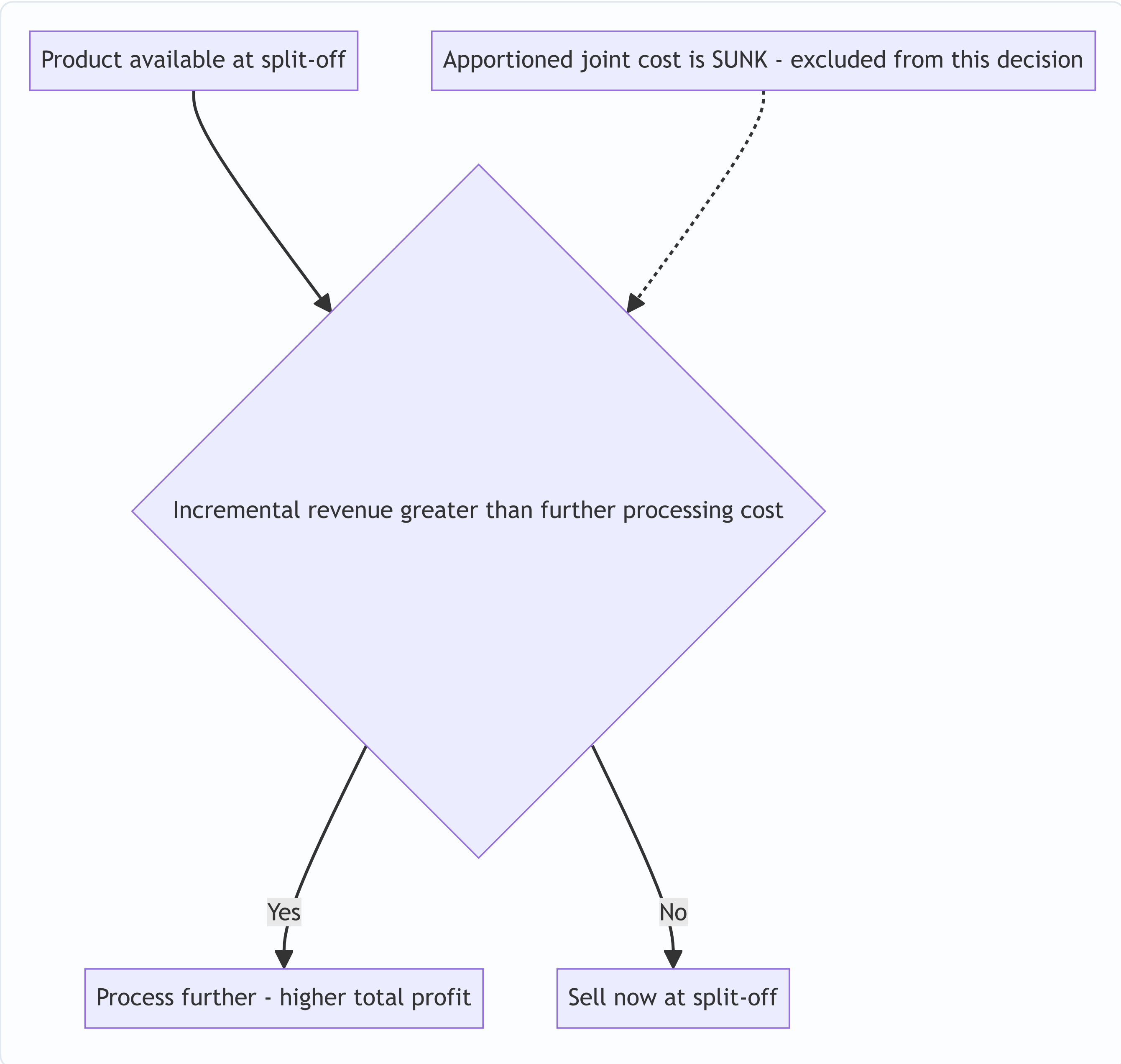


Figure 3 — The further-processing decision tree. Apportioned joint cost never enters the diamond; only incremental revenue versus incremental cost decides.

Two refinements the examiner tests:

1. **Avoidable separable fixed cost.** Sometimes further processing needs a *dedicated* fixed cost (a machine, a supervisor) that exists *only if* you process further. That fixed cost **is** relevant here, because it is *avoidable* by choosing to sell at split-off. Include it. Only the *joint* fixed cost (incurred regardless) is sunk. Distinguish "sunk joint fixed cost" (ignore) from "avoidable separable fixed cost caused by the decision" (count).
2. **Lost split-off sales as opportunity cost.** Selling value at split-off is the *opportunity forgone* by processing further. That is already captured by using "incremental revenue = new price − split-off price." If a question quotes only the final price, remember to *subtract* the split-off value the product would have fetched; skipping this is a subtle way to overstate the benefit of further processing.

---

5. Worked Examples — from gentle to exam-hard

Example 1 (Easy) — Physical Units Method, full reconciliation

A single process costs **₹90,000** and simultaneously yields three joint products of similar value per kg:

Product	Output (kg)
A	2,000
B	3,000
C	4,000
Total	**9,000**

Apportion the joint cost.

Average cost per kg = ₹90,000 ÷ 9,000 kg = **₹10 per kg**.

Product	Kg	× Rate	Joint cost (₹)
A	2,000	10	20,000
B	3,000	10	30,000
C	4,000	10	40,000
Total	**9,000**		**90,000**

Reconciliation: 20,000 + 30,000 + 40,000 = **₹90,000** = joint cost. ✓ Every rupee is placed. This is legitimate *because* the products are similar in value per kg; had C been worth ten times A, this split would mislead.

Example 2 (Medium) — NRV vs. Constant Gross-Margin, contrasted

A joint process costs **₹4,00,000** and yields three products, each processed further after split-off:

Product	Output (units)	Selling price after processing (₹)	Further-processing cost (₹)
X	10,000	30	50,000
Y	8,000	25	30,000
Z	5,000	40	70,000

Apportion the joint cost by (a) NRV and (b) Constant Gross-Margin, and compare.

Step 1 — Final sales value of each product:

Product	Units × Price	Final sales (₹)
X	10,000 × 30	3,00,000
Y	8,000 × 25	2,00,000
Z	5,000 × 40	2,00,000
Total		**7,00,000**

(a) Net Realisable Value method

NRV = Final sales − Further-processing cost.

Product	Final sales	− Separable cost	= NRV (₹)
X	3,00,000	50,000	2,50,000
Y	2,00,000	30,000	1,70,000
Z	2,00,000	70,000	1,30,000
Total			**5,50,000**

Apportion ₹4,00,000 in the ratio 2,50,000 : 1,70,000 : 1,30,000.

Product	NRV share	Joint cost = 4,00,000 × share ÷ 5,50,000 (₹)
X	2,50,000/5,50,000	1,81,818.18
Y	1,70,000/5,50,000	1,23,636.36
Z	1,30,000/5,50,000	94,545.45
Total		**4,00,000.00**

Reconciliation: 1,81,818.18 + 1,23,636.36 + 94,545.45 = **₹4,00,000**. ✓

Resulting profit per product (a useful check that no product is forced into loss):

Product	Final sales	− Joint cost	− Separable cost	= Profit (₹)
X	3,00,000	1,81,818.18	50,000	68,181.82
Y	2,00,000	1,23,636.36	30,000	46,363.64
Z	2,00,000	94,545.45	70,000	35,454.55
Total	**7,00,000**	**4,00,000**	**1,50,000**	**1,50,000**

(b) Constant Gross-Margin Percentage method

Total costs = joint 4,00,000 + separable (50,000+30,000+70,000 = 1,50,000) = **₹5,50,000**. Total gross profit = 7,00,000 − 5,50,000 = **₹1,50,000**. Overall gross-margin % = 1,50,000 ÷ 7,00,000 = **21.4286%**.

Force each product to earn 21.4286% GP on its sales, then back out joint cost:

Product	Sales	GP @ 21.4286%	Total cost = Sales − GP	− Separable	= Joint cost (₹)
X	3,00,000	64,285.71	2,35,714.29	50,000	1,85,714.29
Y	2,00,000	42,857.14	1,57,142.86	30,000	1,27,142.86
Z	2,00,000	42,857.14	1,57,142.86	70,000	87,142.86
Total	**7,00,000**	**1,50,000**	**5,50,000**	**1,50,000**	**4,00,000.00**

Reconciliation: joint cost 1,85,714.29 + 1,27,142.86 + 87,142.86 = **₹4,00,000**. ✓ And each product now shows exactly 21.43% margin.

Comparison / interpretation — notice the two methods give *different* joint-cost splits (e.g. Z gets ₹94,545 under NRV but only ₹87,143 under constant-margin) even though both reconcile to ₹4,00,000. NRV lets margins *differ* between products (X 22.7%, Z 17.7%); constant-margin *forces* them equal. Neither is "true"; each is an internally consistent convention. The examiner's trap is to ask which product is "most profitable" — under constant-margin the honest answer is *they are equally profitable by construction*, which is precisely why that method is criticised for hiding real differences.

Example 3 (Exam-Hard) — Joint products + by-product + further-processing decision, fully reconciled

"*Vindhya Chemicals*" runs one reaction process. Batch data:

- Joint (pre-split-off) process cost: **₹2,00,000**.
- Outputs from the batch:
- **P** — 5,000 litres (main joint product)
- **Q** — 4,000 litres (main joint product)
- **R** — 1,000 litres (**by-product**)
- **By-product R**: sells for ₹8/litre; selling cost ₹1/litre. R is sold as it emerges (no further processing).
- At split-off, **P** can be sold for ₹40/litre and **Q** for ₹30/litre.
- **Further-processing options** after split-off:
- **P** can be upgraded for ₹30,000 total and then sold at ₹50/litre.
- **Q** can be upgraded for ₹25,000 total and then sold at ₹35/litre.

Required: (i) treat the by-product; (ii) decide further processing for P and Q; (iii) apportion joint cost to P and Q by market value at split-off; (iv) present a product-wise profit statement and reconcile overall profit.

Step (i) — By-product treatment (credit net realisation to joint cost).

Net realisation of R = 1,000 × (8 − 1) = 1,000 × 7 = **₹7,000**. Using the examiner-preferred *NRV-credited-to-process* method, deduct this from joint cost:

Net joint cost to apportion to P and Q = 2,00,000 − 7,000 = **₹1,93,000**.

(We do NOT push any joint cost onto R; its sale claws back cost from the main products.)

Step (ii) — Further-processing decision (relevant costs only; joint cost is sunk and ignored).

	P	Q
Incremental revenue = qty × (new price − split-off price)	5,000 × (50 − 40) = **50,000**	4,000 × (35 − 30) = **20,000**
Incremental (further-processing) cost	**30,000**	**25,000**
Net incremental benefit	**+20,000**	**−5,000**
Decision	**Process further ✓**	**Sell at split-off ✓**

So **P is processed further** (adds ₹20,000 of profit); **Q is sold at split-off** (processing it would *destroy* ₹5,000). The apportioned joint cost — whatever it turns out to be — played no part in this, because it is identical under either choice.

Step (iii) — Apportion the net joint cost ₹1,93,000 by market value at split-off.

Sales value at split-off: P = 5,000 × 40 = 2,00,000; Q = 4,000 × 30 = 1,20,000; total = 3,20,000.

Product	Split-off sales value	Ratio	Joint cost = 1,93,000 × ratio (₹)
P	2,00,000	0.625	1,20,625
Q	1,20,000	0.375	72,375
Total	**3,20,000**	1.000	**1,93,000**

Reconciliation: 1,20,625 + 72,375 = **₹1,93,000**. ✓

Step (iv) — Product-wise profit statement (using the optimal decisions: P processed, Q sold at split-off).

Particulars	P (₹)	Q (₹)	Total (₹)
Sales — P at 5,000 × 50; Q at 4,000 × 30	2,50,000	1,20,000	3,70,000
Less: Apportioned joint cost	1,20,625	72,375	1,93,000
Less: Further-processing cost	30,000	—	30,000
Profit	**99,375**	**47,625**	**1,47,000**

Overall reconciliation (prove the total profit independently):

Total realisations	₹
P (5,000 × 50)	2,50,000
Q (4,000 × 30)	1,20,000
R net realisation	7,000
Total	**3,77,000**

Total costs incurred	₹
Joint process cost	2,00,000
Further processing of P	30,000
Total	**2,30,000**

Overall profit = 3,77,000 − 2,30,000 = **₹1,47,000**, which exactly equals the sum of product profits (99,375 + 47,625). ✓✓ The by-product's ₹7,000 was credited to joint cost, so it is *embedded* in the lower joint cost apportioned to P and Q rather than showing as a separate line — and the totals still tie out.

(Sanity note: had we wrongly let the apportioned joint cost drive the further-processing decision, we might have "sold P at split-off because its cost looked high," forgoing the genuine ₹20,000 gain. The reconciliation confirms the incremental logic was right.)

"What if the examiner tweaks it?" — the split-off market-value trap on P. Notice we apportioned on the split-off value ₹40 for P *even though we ultimately sell P at ₹50 after processing*. That is correct: the market-value-**at-split-off** method uses the value *created by the joint process only*. A tempting error is to apportion on the *final* ₹50 — but that would credit the joint stage with value that the *separate* upgrading step created. If instead the question said "apportion on NRV," you would use P's NRV = final sales 2,50,000 − separable 30,000 = 2,20,000 for P, and for Q (sold at split-off, no separable cost) NRV = 1,20,000 — a *different* split. Always match the basis to the exact instruction.

Example 4 (Medium) — Weighted / Survey (Points) Method, plus a closing-stock tweak

A refining process costs **₹1,20,000** and yields three grades from one batch. No reliable split-off market price exists, but the works engineer certifies the following technical "point" weights reflecting relative richness:

Product	Output (kg)	Point (weight) factor
A	1,000	3
B	2,000	2
C	3,000	1

(a) Apportion the joint cost by the survey method. (b) A naïve manager apportions by plain physical weight — show how misleading that is. (c) If 200 kg of A remain unsold, value the closing stock of A.

(a) Survey method. Weighted units = output × points:

Product	Output × Points	Weighted units
A	1,000 × 3	3,000
B	2,000 × 2	4,000
C	3,000 × 1	3,000
Total		**10,000**

Rate = ₹1,20,000 ÷ 10,000 weighted units = **₹12 per weighted unit**.

Product	Weighted units	× ₹12	Joint cost (₹)	Cost per kg (₹)
A	3,000	12	36,000	36.00
B	4,000	12	48,000	24.00
C	3,000	12	36,000	12.00
Total	**10,000**		**1,20,000**	

Reconciliation: 36,000 + 48,000 + 36,000 = **₹1,20,000**. ✓ Note the cost per kg falls with the point weight (A ₹36, C ₹12) — richer grades rightly carry more cost.

(b) Plain physical-weight method (the naïve split). Rate = 1,20,000 ÷ 6,000 kg = ₹20/kg → A 20,000, B 40,000, C 60,000. This gives *every* grade the same ₹20/kg regardless of richness, over-costing the cheap bulk grade C (₹60,000 vs ₹36,000) and under-costing the rich grade A. If A and C had very different selling prices, C would be shown at a fat loss purely because of the split. The survey method corrects this without needing a market price.

(c) Closing-stock valuation of A. Cost per kg of A under the survey method = ₹36. Closing stock of A = 200 kg × ₹36 = **₹7,200**. This is the figure that flows into inventory in the financial statements — the apportionment convention you chose has *directly* set the balance-sheet value of A's stock (and hence period profit). Had you used the naïve ₹20/kg, closing stock would have been ₹4,000 — a ₹3,200 profit swing from the *method alone*, which is exactly why AS 2 insists the basis be *rational and consistent*.

Example 5 (Exam-Hard) — By-product by the Reverse-Cost (Working-Back) Method

A process costs **₹3,00,000** up to split-off, producing a main product **M** and a by-product **N**. From the batch, **N** = 2,000 units. N is *not* sold as it emerges — it needs further processing costing **₹10,000**, then incurs selling expenses of **₹5,000**, and finally sells at **₹20/unit**. Company policy is that the by-product should be shown to earn a **normal profit of 25% on its selling price**. Main product M: 10,000 units, sold at ₹40/unit, no separable cost.

Required: (i) find, by the reverse-cost method, the joint cost to be credited to M on account of N; (ii) prepare the process/by-product statement and prove N earns exactly its target margin; (iii) compute M's cost per unit and profit.

Step (i) — Work backwards from N's sale value to its notional joint-cost share.

Reverse-cost build-up for N	₹
Sales value of N (2,000 × 20)	40,000
Less: desired profit @ 25% of sales (40,000 × 25%)	10,000
Less: selling expenses	5,000
Less: further-processing cost	10,000
= Share of joint cost attributable to N	**15,000**

So **₹15,000** of the joint cost is deemed to belong to N and is *credited to (deducted from)* the joint cost of M.

Net joint cost borne by M = 3,00,000 − 15,000 = **₹2,85,000**.

Step (ii) — Prove N earns its 25% target (reconciliation of the by-product account).

N account	₹
Sales	40,000
Less: joint-cost share	15,000
Less: further processing	10,000
Less: selling expenses	5,000
Profit	**10,000**

Profit ₹10,000 ÷ Sales ₹40,000 = **25%**. ✓ The reverse-cost method is *engineered* to deliver exactly the target margin — that is its whole point.

Step (iii) — Main product M.

M's total cost = ₹2,85,000 (no separable cost). Cost per unit = 2,85,000 ÷ 10,000 = **₹28.50**.

M statement	₹
Sales (10,000 × 40)	4,00,000
Less: net joint cost	2,85,000
Profit on M	**1,15,000**

Overall reconciliation.

Total realisations	₹
M (10,000 × 40)	4,00,000
N (2,000 × 20)	40,000
Total	**4,40,000**

Total costs	₹
Joint process cost	3,00,000
N further processing	10,000
N selling expenses	5,000
Total	**3,15,000**

Overall profit = 4,40,000 − 3,15,000 = **₹1,25,000** = M's ₹1,15,000 + N's ₹10,000. ✓✓

"What if the examiner tweaks it?" If policy were "*20% profit on cost*" instead of "*25% on sales,*" note 25% on sales = 33⅓% on cost, so the two are **not** the same — misreading "on sales" vs "on cost" is a classic trap. With 20% on cost, you would set N's total cost = Sales ÷ 1.20 = 40,000 ÷ 1.20 = 33,333, so profit = 6,667; then joint share = total cost 33,333 − processing 10,000 − selling 5,000 = 18,333, credited to M. Always convert the margin base carefully before working back.

Example 6 (Exam-Hard) — Constant Gross-Margin producing a NEGATIVE joint-cost allocation

This is the edge case §4.5 warned about. A joint process costs **₹1,00,000** and yields two products, both processed further:

Product	Final sales (₹)	Separable cost (₹)
A	2,00,000	20,000
B	40,000	60,000

Apportion the joint cost by the constant gross-margin method and interpret the result.

Total sales = 2,40,000. Total cost = joint 1,00,000 + separable 80,000 = 1,80,000. Total gross profit = 2,40,000 − 1,80,000 = **₹60,000**. Overall gross-margin % = 60,000 ÷ 2,40,000 = **25%**.

Force 25% GP on each, then back out joint cost:

Product	Sales	GP @ 25%	Total cost = Sales − GP	− Separable	= Joint cost (₹)
A	2,00,000	50,000	1,50,000	20,000	**1,30,000**
B	40,000	10,000	30,000	60,000	**(30,000)**
Total	**2,40,000**	**60,000**	**1,80,000**	**80,000**	**1,00,000**

Reconciliation: 1,30,000 + (−30,000) = **₹1,00,000**. ✓

Interpretation (this is where the marks are). B's separable cost (₹60,000) *exceeds* its entire target total cost (₹30,000), so to still leave B with a 25% margin the method must assign it a **negative** joint cost of ₹30,000 — effectively saying "the joint process handed B *negative* value; the only way B breaks even at the group margin is to be credited ₹30,000." This is **arithmetically correct and reconciles** — do **not** floor it at zero, and do not redistribute. The result is a genuine *criticism* of the method: forcing uniform margins can produce economically odd (even negative) allocations when separable costs are lopsided. State this in your answer; examiners award the interpretation, not just the arithmetic.

If the same data were apportioned by NRV instead: NRV of A = 2,00,000 − 20,000 = 1,80,000; NRV of B = 40,000 − 60,000 = **(20,000)** — a *negative NRV*. NRV cannot sensibly apportion on a negative figure either, which tells you something real: **B is destroying value** (its separable cost exceeds its final sales), and the sharper management question is whether B should be processed further *at all*. If B could be sold at split-off for any positive amount, or even scrapped to avoid the ₹60,000, that would beat processing it to a ₹40,000 sale. The negative allocation is the arithmetic *screaming* that a decision, not an apportionment, is needed.

---

6. Presentation / Format — how to lay it out in the exam

A joint-cost answer that reconciles but is *messy* still loses presentation marks. Use this skeleton:

Working Note 1 — Apportionment of Joint Cost

Product	Basis (units / sales value / NRV)	Ratio	Joint cost (₹)
…	…	…	…
Total			**= given joint cost**

Working Note 2 — Further-Processing Decision (only if asked)

	Product 1	Product 2
Incremental revenue		
Incremental cost		
Decision		

Main Statement — Product-wise Profitability

Particulars	Prod A	Prod B	Total
Sales			
Less: Joint cost (from WN1)			
Less: Separable cost			
Profit / (Loss)			

Golden presentation rules: 1. **Always state the basis** of apportionment in words ("Joint cost apportioned on NRV basis") — examiners award method-identification marks. 2. **Show the ratio explicitly** before the split; never jump to rupee figures. 3. **Cross-total and prove** that apportioned joint cost sums back to the given joint cost — write "= joint cost ✓". 4. **By-product**: show its net realisation as a *deduction from joint cost* in a labelled line, not silently. 5. **Round consistently** (usually two decimals, or to the nearest rupee if the question uses whole numbers) and keep the reconciliation exact. 6. **Separate the two questions.** Keep the *further-processing decision* (a relevant-cost table) physically apart from the *profit statement* (which uses apportioned/absorbed cost). Mixing sunk joint cost into the decision table is the fastest way to lose the decision marks — quarantine them. 7. **Answer the decision in words.** After the numbers, write the one-line verdict: "Process P further (gain ₹20,000); sell Q at split-off (processing loses ₹5,000)." Examiners look for the explicit recommendation, not just the table.

7. Connections — where this plugs into the rest of the syllabus

- **Process Costing (Ch. 10)**: joint-product costing *is* process costing up to the split-off point — the joint process is just a process account whose output is *several* products instead of one. Normal/abnormal loss, equivalent units and process accounts all still apply *before* split-off. This chapter adds the *apportionment* layer on top. A neat linkage: an **abnormal loss** in the joint process is costed at the *average pre-apportionment* cost per unit and taken to Costing P&L exactly as in Ch. 10 — it never becomes a joint product and is not part of the apportionment base.
- **Cost Sheet (Ch. 06) & overhead apportionment (Ch. 04)**: joint-cost apportionment is the same "share a common cost by a sensible base" logic as overhead apportionment — only here the base is value (cost-bearing ability) rather than area or machine hours.
- **Marginal Costing & Decision-Making (Ch. 14)**: the further-processing decision is a pure **relevant-cost / incremental** decision — the *same* logic as make-or-buy, accept-or-reject, and shutdown decisions. Apportioned joint cost is the classic **sunk cost** those chapters warn you to ignore.
- **Standard Costing**: the by-product *standard cost* method links straight to standard-cost thinking.
- **Financial Accounting (AS 2 / Ind AS 2, Inventories)**: for *inventory valuation* of joint products, accounting standards permit a *rational and consistent* allocation — typically **relative sales value (NRV)** — so this chapter's NRV method is what feeds closing-stock valuation in the financial statements too. AS 2 specifically notes that when costs of conversion are *not separately identifiable*, they are allocated on a *rational and consistent basis such as relative sales value*, and that a by-product of immaterial value is measured at NRV and *deducted from the cost* of the main product — mirroring §4.6(A)(ii) exactly. *(Verify exact wording against current ICAI AS 2 / Ind AS 2 material.)*

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Using final sales value instead of NRV.** If a product is processed *after* split-off, you must subtract the separable cost to get NRV *before* apportioning. Using the full final price over-loads the heavily-processed product. Read for the phrase "after further processing."
2. **Bringing joint cost into the further-processing decision.** The single biggest error. Apportioned joint cost is **sunk and irrelevant**. Compare only *incremental* revenue vs *incremental* cost. If the question gives you the joint-cost split *and* asks about further processing, the split is a distractor for the decision.
3. **Apportioning joint cost onto the by-product.** By-products normally get *no* joint cost. Their net realisation is *credited to* (deducted from) the joint cost of the main products. Watch the direction of the flow.
4. **Gross vs net by-product realisation.** Credit the **net** figure — by-product sales *minus* its own selling *and* further-processing costs. Students forget the selling cost, or forget the by-product's own processing cost, or both.
5. **Mixed physical units.** In the physical-units method, if outputs are in different units (kg, litres, m^3) you must convert to a common measure first. Apportioning across incompatible units is meaningless.
6. **Negative joint-cost allocation under constant gross-margin.** When a product's separable cost is large relative to its sales, the method can assign it a *tiny or negative* joint cost. This is arithmetically correct — do not "adjust" it. State it and move on. (Example 6.)

7. **Forgetting to reconcile.** The apportioned joint cost *must* sum to the given joint cost; product profits *must* sum to overall profit. If they don't, you have an error — and reconciling is where the last easy marks live.
8. **Joint product vs by-product misclassification.** Value decides. If the "by-product" fetches a value comparable to the mains, treat it as a joint product. Don't blindly follow the label in the question if the numbers contradict it — but note any assumption.
9. **"Which product is most profitable?" after constant-margin apportionment.** By construction every product shows the *same* margin — so profitability differences are an artefact of the method, not reality. The safe answer discusses this rather than naming a "winner."
10. **Selling costs vs further-processing costs.** Both reduce NRV, but keep them labelled separately; some questions give distribution cost *and* processing cost and expect both deducted.
11. **Market value "at split-off" vs "final".** In the *market-value-at-split-off* method use the split-off price, even if the product is later processed and sold dearer. Using the final price silently credits the joint stage with value the *separate* stage created. (Example 3, tweak.)
12. **"Profit on sales" vs "profit on cost" in reverse-cost / by-product working.** 25% on sales ≠ 25% on cost (it is 33⅓% on cost). Convert the margin base before working backwards, or the whole by-product credit is wrong. (Example 5, tweak.)
13. **Using input quantity instead of output at split-off.** Apportion on *good output* emerging at split-off, not the raw material fed in. Normal-loss units carry no cost. Questions often quote input to bait the wrong denominator.
14. **Weighted/survey rate confusion.** After computing weighted units, the rate is "per **weighted** unit," not per physical unit. Do not re-multiply by physical output a second time.
15. **Avoidable separable *fixed* cost in the decision.** If further processing needs a dedicated fixed cost that exists only if you process, it *is* relevant (avoidable). Only the *joint* fixed cost is sunk. Do not lump all fixed costs into "sunk."
16. **Deducting notional profit inside joint-product NRV.** Standard joint-product NRV deducts only separable and selling costs — *not* a profit margin. Deducting profit is a *by-product reverse-cost* feature. Do it only if the question explicitly asks you to work back a margin. (Contrast §4.4 and §4.6.)

---

9. First-Principles Recap

Strip everything away and you are left with four irreducible ideas:

1. **Some costs are joint by nature, not by neglect.** When one process births several products simultaneously, the pre-split-off cost genuinely cannot be traced. Any split is a *convention*, chosen for usefulness, never a discovered truth.
2. **The split-off point is the fault line.** Left of it, cost is joint and must be *apportioned by a rule*. Right of it, cost is separable and *traced directly*. Get this line right and the whole problem organises itself.
3. **Share common cost by cost-bearing ability.** The most defensible rule lets each product bear cost in proportion to the *value* it derives from the shared process — hence value/NRV methods dominate, with physical units (and its weighted/survey refinement) reserved for genuinely homogeneous or price-less outputs.

4. **Decisions use incremental, not apportioned, cost.** Whether to process further, or which product to push, depends only on costs and revenues that *change* with the decision. Apportioned joint cost is sunk — it must be *reported* for stock valuation but *ignored* for decisions. Confusing the two is the master-error of this topic.

By-products are just the degenerate case: too small to deserve their own cost, so we let their sale *recover* joint cost off the main products. And when even that logic breaks — a "product" whose separable cost exceeds its sale value (negative NRV) — the numbers are telling you the real question is not *how to apportion* but *whether to make or process it at all*.

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

Key terms - *Joint cost* = cost incurred up to split-off (unsplittable, apportioned by convention). - *Split-off point* = where products become separately identifiable. - *Separable cost* = post-split-off cost, traced directly. - *Joint product* = significant value; *By-product* = minor, incidental value; *Scrap* = residual material value (credited back like a by-product); *Waste* = nil/negative value (disposal cost added to process). - *Apportion* (split a shared cost) vs *Allocate* (charge a whole traceable cost) — joint cost is only ever *apportioned*.

Apportionment methods

Method	Basis	Best when	Key formula
Physical units	Quantity (common unit)	Products similar in value/unit	Rate = Joint cost ÷ total units
Weighted / survey	Physical units × point factor	No prices but products differ in richness	Rate = Joint cost ÷ total weighted units
Market value at split-off	Sales value at split-off	Split-off price exists	Ratio = qty × split-off price
NRV (workhorse)	Final sales − separable & selling costs	Products processed further	NRV = Final sales − further-proc − selling
Constant gross-margin	Force equal GP%	Products deemed equally profitable	Joint cost = (Sales − GP) − separable

Why NRV is popular — handles further-processed products, respects cost-bearing ability, isolates the joint stage's own value contribution, keeps separable costs visible for decisions.

By-product treatment (preferred) — credit **net** realisation (sales − its selling/processing costs) as a **deduction from joint cost** of the main products; no joint cost pushed onto the by-product. (Other methods: other income; opportunity/replacement cost if consumed internally; standard cost; reverse-cost with a worked-back profit margin.)

Further-processing rule $$\text{Process further iff } (\text{Sales after} - \text{Sales at split-off}) > \text{Further-processing cost}$$

> Apportioned joint cost is **SUNK — ignore it** in the decision. But *avoidable separable fixed cost* caused by processing **is** relevant.

Reconciliation checklist 1. Σ apportioned joint cost = given joint cost. ✓ 2. Σ product profits = overall (independently computed) profit. ✓ 3. By-product net realisation deducted, not added as forward cost. ✓ 4. NRV used (not final sales) whenever there is further processing. ✓ 5. Decision table kept separate from the profit statement; joint cost never inside it. ✓ 6. Margin base ("on sales" vs "on cost") converted correctly in any reverse-cost working. ✓

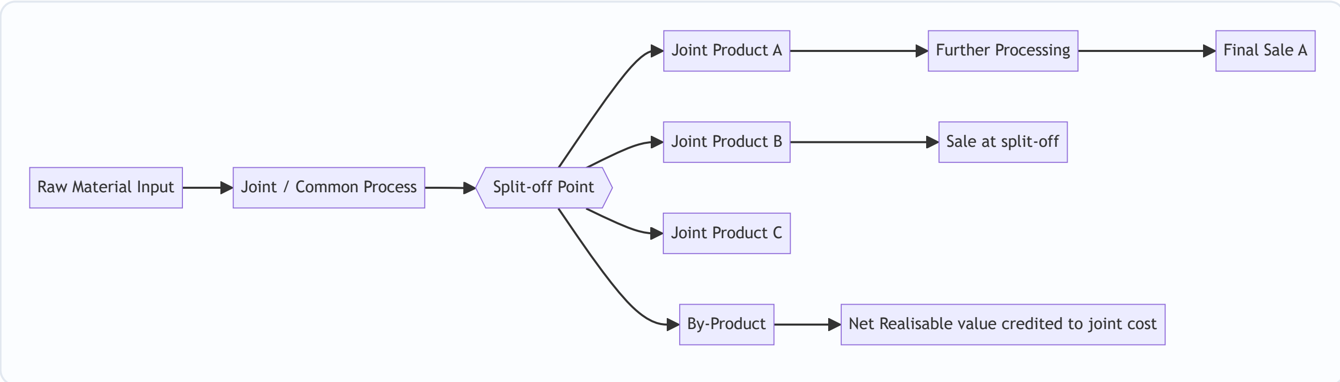
One-line memory hook: *Share the womb by worth, trace the birth by hand, and decide by what changes.*

Q&A — Joint Products & By-Products

CA Intermediate · Cost & Management Accounting · Exam-Oriented Question Bank

How to use this bank

Work each computational problem on paper **before** reading the model answer. Every dataset below is internally consistent — your totals must tie back to the joint cost given. Formulas follow ICAI conventions; all figures in Rupees (₹).



SECTION A — Concept Check (short answer)

A1. Define the split-off point. The stage in a common process at which joint products and by-products become separately identifiable. Costs incurred **before** it are *joint (common) costs* needing apportionment; costs after it are *further-processing (separable) costs* traceable to a specific product.

A2. Distinguish joint products from by-products. Joint products are two or more products of **roughly comparable sales value** produced simultaneously and each regarded as a main objective. A by-product has **relatively minor sales value** arising incidentally from the process. Classification is relative and can change with market prices.

A3. Why can joint costs never be truly "accurately" allocated? Because they are incurred **jointly and indivisibly** up to split-off — no cause-and-effect link exists between the common cost and any single product. All apportionment bases are therefore conventions chosen for a purpose (stock valuation), not scientific truth.

A4. State the four common methods of apportioning joint cost. (i) Physical (units/quantity) measure; (ii) Market value at split-off point; (iii) Net Realisable Value (NRV); (iv) Constant (uniform) gross-margin percentage method.

A5. Why is NRV the most popular method? It respects **cost-bearing ability** (higher-value products absorb more cost), works even when products are **not saleable at split-off** (they need further processing before any market price exists), and prevents the distortion where a low-value bulky product wrongly absorbs the bulk of cost.

A6. Give the NRV formula for a product's share of joint cost. NRV of a product = Final sales value − Further processing cost − Selling/distribution cost (of that product). Joint cost share = Joint cost × (Product

NRV ÷ Total NRV of all joint products).

A7. Decision rule for "further process or sell at split-off?" Process further **only if** Incremental (further) sales revenue > Incremental (further processing) cost. Joint cost already incurred is **sunk and irrelevant** to this decision.

A8. Name two by-product accounting methods. (i) **Non-cost / other-income** method — by-product income credited to Costing P&L. (ii) **Cost / NRV method** — by-product's net realisable value credited to (deducted from) the joint process cost before apportioning to main products.

A9. Why is the physical-units method criticised? It ignores value: a cheap heavy product absorbs a large cost share and may show a loss while a light valuable product shows huge profit — misleading for performance and pricing.

A10. Under the constant gross-margin method, what is held equal across products? The **gross-profit percentage on sales** is identical for every joint product; joint cost is the balancing figure that forces this uniform margin.

SECTION B — Graded Computational Problems

B1 (Easy) — Physical Units Method

Joint cost of a process = ₹1,80,000. Output: Product X 6,000 kg, Product Y 3,000 kg, Product Z 1,000 kg. Apportion joint cost on physical units.

Answer. Total units = 6,000 + 3,000 + 1,000 = 10,000 kg. Rate = 1,80,000 ÷ 10,000 = **₹18 per kg**.

Product	Kg	₹18 × Kg	Joint cost (₹)
X	6,000	18	1,08,000
Y	3,000	18	54,000
Z	1,000	18	18,000
Total	**10,000**		**1,80,000** ✓

B2 (Easy–Medium) — Market Value at Split-off

Joint cost = ₹90,000. All three products are saleable at split-off.

Product	Units	Selling price at split-off (₹/u)
P	2,000	30
Q	1,500	20
R	1,000	10

Apportion by market value at split-off.

Answer.

Product	Units	Price	Market value (₹)	Share ratio	Joint cost (₹)
P	2,000	30	60,000	60/100	54,000
Q	1,500	20	30,000	30/100	27,000
R	1,000	10	10,000	10/100	9,000
Total			**1,00,000**		**90,000** ✓

Rate = 90,000 ÷ 1,00,000 = ₹0.90 per ₹1 of market value. (e.g. P: 60,000 × 0.90 = 54,000.)

B3 (Medium) — NRV Method (with further processing)

Joint cost = ₹2,40,000. None saleable at split-off; each needs further processing.

Product	Final sales value (₹)	Further processing cost (₹)	Selling exp. (₹)
A	2,00,000	40,000	10,000
B	1,50,000	30,000	5,000
C	1,00,000	20,000	5,000

Apportion joint cost on NRV.

Answer. NRV = Final sales value − Further processing − Selling expenses.

Product	Sales	− Further	− Selling	NRV (₹)
A	2,00,000	40,000	10,000	1,50,000
B	1,50,000	30,000	5,000	1,15,000
C	1,00,000	20,000	5,000	75,000
Total				**3,40,000**

Joint cost share = ₹2,40,000 × (Product NRV ÷ 3,40,000): - A = 2,40,000 × 1,50,000/3,40,000 = **₹1,05,882** - B = 2,40,000 × 1,15,000/3,40,000 = **₹81,177** - C = 2,40,000 × 75,000/3,40,000 = **₹52,941** - Total = 1,05,882 + 81,177 + 52,941 = **₹2,40,000** ✓ (rounded to nearest ₹).

In an exam, state the rate factor (0.70588) and round the last product as the balancing figure so the shares tie exactly to ₹2,40,000.

B4 (Medium–Hard) — Constant Gross-Margin Percentage Method

Joint cost = ₹3,00,000. Further processing costs: A ₹50,000, B ₹30,000, C ₹20,000. Final sales values: A ₹3,00,000, B ₹1,80,000, C ₹1,20,000. Apportion joint cost so every product earns the same gross-margin %.

Answer. Step 1 — Overall gross margin %. Total sales = 3,00,000 + 1,80,000 + 1,20,000 = ₹6,00,000. Total cost = Joint 3,00,000 + Further (50,000+30,000+20,000 = 1,00,000) = ₹4,00,000. Total gross profit = 6,00,000 − 4,00,000 = ₹2,00,000. **GM % = 2,00,000 ÷ 6,00,000 = 33.33%.**

Step 2 — Apply same GM% to each product's sales, work back to joint cost.

Product	Sales	GP @33.33%	Total cost (Sales−GP)	− Further cost	= Joint cost (₹)
A	3,00,000	1,00,000	2,00,000	50,000	1,50,000
B	1,80,000	60,000	1,20,000	30,000	90,000
C	1,20,000	40,000	80,000	20,000	60,000
Total	**6,00,000**	**2,00,000**	**4,00,000**	**1,00,000**	**3,00,000** ✓

Every product shows GP margin of 33.33% and joint cost sums exactly to ₹3,00,000.

B5 (Hard) — Sell-or-Process-Further Decision

From B4, Product C can instead be sold **at split-off** for ₹95,000 (no further ₹20,000 cost). Should the firm process C further?

Answer. Joint cost apportioned to C (₹60,000) is **sunk / irrelevant**. - Incremental revenue from further processing = 1,20,000 − 95,000 = **₹25,000**. - Incremental cost = **₹20,000**. - Net gain from processing = 25,000 − 20,000 = **₹5,000 > 0**.

Decision: process C further — it adds ₹5,000 net. (If the split-off price were, say, ₹1,05,000, incremental revenue ₹15,000 < ₹20,000 cost → sell at split-off.)

B6 (Exam-Hard) — Joint + By-Product + Further Processing (full reconciliation)

A process costs ₹5,00,000 (joint cost). It yields two joint products M and N and one by-product Z. - By-product Z: 1,000 units, net realisable value ₹20 each. **Credited to joint cost (NRV method).** - M: 10,000 units, final sales ₹6,00,000, further processing ₹80,000. - N: 8,000 units, final sales ₹3,00,000, further processing ₹40,000.

Apportion the **net** joint cost between M and N on NRV, then prepare the product-wise profit statement.

Answer. Step 1 — Net joint cost after by-product credit. By-product NRV = 1,000 × ₹20 = ₹20,000. Net joint cost = 5,00,000 − 20,000 = **₹4,80,000**.

Step 2 — NRV of M and N. - M: 6,00,000 − 80,000 = ₹5,20,000 - N: 3,00,000 − 40,000 = ₹2,60,000 - Total NRV = ₹7,80,000

Step 3 — Apportion ₹4,80,000 on NRV (ratio 520:260 = 2:1). - M = 4,80,000 × 520/780 = **₹3,20,000** - N = 4,80,000 × 260/780 = **₹1,60,000** - Total = ₹4,80,000 ✓

Step 4 — Profit statement.

Particulars	M (₹)	N (₹)	Total (₹)
Final sales value	6,00,000	3,00,000	9,00,000
Less: Joint cost share	3,20,000	1,60,000	4,80,000
Less: Further processing	80,000	40,000	1,20,000
Profit	**2,00,000**	**1,00,000**	**3,00,000**

Reconciliation check: Total sales 9,00,000 − net joint cost 4,80,000 − further 1,20,000 = ₹3,00,000 = total profit ✓. By-product ₹20,000 already absorbed as a cost reduction, so it is not shown as separate income.

SECTION C — Past-Paper-Style Full Questions

C1. (Comprehensive — 10 marks)

"In a manufacturing process, joint cost up to split-off is ₹7,20,000. Three products emerge — Alpha, Beta, Gamma. Alpha and Beta are main products; Gamma is a by-product. Gamma: 2,000 kg sold at ₹15/kg, selling cost ₹2/kg. Alpha: 12,000 kg, sold at ₹50/kg after further processing costing ₹1,20,000. Beta: 8,000 kg, sold at ₹40/kg after further processing costing ₹80,000. Apportion joint cost by NRV (by-product credited at net realisable value) and show product profitability."

Model Answer. By-product Gamma net realisable value = 2,000 × (15 − 2) = 2,000 × 13 = **₹26,000**. **Net joint cost** = 7,20,000 − 26,000 = **₹6,94,000**.

NRV of main products: - Alpha: (12,000 × 50) − 1,20,000 = 6,00,000 − 1,20,000 = ₹4,80,000 - Beta: (8,000 × 40) − 80,000 = 3,20,000 − 80,000 = ₹2,40,000 - Total NRV = ₹7,20,000 (ratio 480:240 = 2:1)

Joint cost apportionment: - Alpha = 6,94,000 × 480/720 = **₹4,62,667** - Beta = 6,94,000 × 240/720 = **₹2,31,333** - Total = ₹6,94,000 ✓

Profitability:

Particulars	Alpha (₹)	Beta (₹)
Sales	6,00,000	3,20,000
Less: Joint cost	4,62,667	2,31,333
Less: Further processing	1,20,000	80,000
Profit	**17,333**	**8,667**

Total profit = ₹26,000, equal to the by-product credit — confirming internal consistency (main-product NRVs equalled joint cost, so all main-product profit here derives from the by-product credit).

C2. (Method comparison — 6 marks)

"Joint cost ₹1,00,000 yields product G (1,000 kg, ₹120/kg) and product H (4,000 kg, ₹20/kg), both saleable at split-off with no further cost. Apportion by (a) physical units and (b) market value; comment."

Model Answer. (a) Physical units (5,000 kg, rate ₹20/kg): - G = 1,000 × 20 = ₹20,000; H = 4,000 × 20 = ₹80,000. - Profit G = 1,20,000 − 20,000 = **₹1,00,000**; Profit H = 80,000 − 80,000 = **₹0**.

(b) Market value — Sales: G = 1,20,000, H = 80,000, total ₹2,00,000 (ratio 3:2): - G = 1,00,000 × 120/200 = ₹60,000; H = 1,00,000 × 80/200 = ₹40,000. - Profit G = 1,20,000 − 60,000 = **₹60,000**; Profit H = 80,000 − 40,000 = **₹40,000**.

Comment: Physical-units method distorts — the low-value bulky product H bears 80% of cost and shows zero profit while G shows an inflated ₹1,00,000. Market-value method allocates cost per cost-bearing ability, giving both products a **uniform 50% margin** on sales — a fairer and more decision-useful result.

C3. (Theory — 4 marks)

"Explain why joint cost apportionment is irrelevant for the decision to process a joint product further."

Model Answer. Joint cost is incurred **up to split-off regardless** of what happens afterwards; it is common to all products and **sunk** by the time the further-processing choice is made. A rational incremental decision compares only **future, differential** cash flows: additional revenue from processing versus additional (separable) cost. Including an arbitrary joint-cost share would (a) not change with the decision and (b) could wrongly make a profitable further step look unprofitable. Hence the correct rule is *process further only if incremental revenue > incremental cost*, ignoring apportioned joint cost.

SECTION D — MCQs & Case Scenarios

D1. Costs incurred **after** the split-off point are called: (a) Joint costs (b) Common costs (c) Separable/further-processing costs (d) Sunk costs **Ans: (c)** — they are traceable to individual products beyond split-off.

D2. The most appropriate method when joint products are **not saleable at split-off** is: (a) Market value at split-off (b) NRV method (c) Physical units (d) Average cost **Ans: (b)** — no split-off price exists, so NRV (final value less further costs) is used.

D3. Under the constant gross-margin method, the figure held constant is: (a) Cost per unit (b) Sales per unit (c) Gross-profit % on sales (d) Physical output **Ans: (c)** — joint cost is the balancing figure forcing equal GP%.

D4. By-product net realisable value credited to the process reduces: (a) Sales revenue (b) Joint cost to be apportioned (c) Further processing cost (d) Selling expenses **Ans: (b)** — under the NRV/cost method the credit lowers the joint cost pool.

D5. A product should be processed further only when: (a) Joint cost share is low (b) Incremental revenue > incremental cost (c) It is the main product (d) Physical bulk is high **Ans: (b)** — the incremental principle governs.

D6. Case. Joint cost ₹4,00,000; two products valued at split-off ₹3,00,000 (X) and ₹1,00,000 (Y). X's joint-cost share under market-value method is: (a) ₹1,00,000 (b) ₹2,00,000 (c) ₹3,00,000 (d) ₹4,00,000 **Ans: (c)** — 4,00,000 × 300/400 = ₹3,00,000.

D7. Case. By-product yields ₹10,000 income; firm uses the **other-income (non-cost)** method. Effect on joint cost apportioned to main products: (a) Reduced by ₹10,000 (b) Unchanged (c) Increased by ₹10,000 (d) Split equally **Ans: (b)** — under the non-cost method by-product income goes to Costing P&L, so main-product joint cost is unaffected.

D8. Physical-units method is unsuitable when products: (a) Have identical value (b) Differ widely in per-unit value (c) Are measured in the same unit (d) Emerge at split-off **Ans: (b)** — value differences cause distorted, misleading cost shares.

Quick-Revision One-Liners

- **Joint cost** = pre-split-off common cost; **separable cost** = post-split-off, traceable.
- **NRV** = Final sales value − further processing − selling cost; most defensible base.
- **Constant GM%**: work back joint cost = (Sales × Cost%) − further cost.

- **By-product NRV** is *credited to joint cost* (cost method) or to *P&L* (non-cost method).
- **Further-processing decision:** ignore sunk joint cost; process if Δrevenue > Δcost.
- Always **reconcile**: apportioned shares must sum to the total joint cost.

Chapter 12 — Service Costing

1. The Problem — What Do You Cost When There Is Nothing to Hold?

Every method you have met so far quietly assumed a *thing*. Job costing costs a printed wedding card. Batch costing costs 10,000 tablets. Process costing costs a litre of caustic soda oozing out of the last vat. In each case there is a physical object at the end of the line, and the whole machinery of costing exists to answer one question: *what did this object cost to make?* You accumulate materials, labour and overhead against it, and when it walks out of the factory gate you know its cost.

Now walk into a different kind of business.

A **State Transport Corporation** runs 120 buses. At the end of the month it has spent ₹4.8 crore on diesel, drivers, tyres, depot rent, insurance and depreciation. What is the "product"? There is no product. Nothing was manufactured, nothing sits in a warehouse, nothing was sold across a counter. The bus left Bangalore full and arrived in Chennai empty of the very thing it "produced" — the *carriage of a passenger over a distance*. That service was consumed the instant it was created.

A **300-bed hospital** spends ₹6 crore a quarter on doctors, nurses, drugs, laundry, diet, power and equipment depreciation. What did it "make"? A recovered patient? A dead patient? A patient who checked out against medical advice? You cannot inventory a cured human being.

A **hotel**, a **canteen**, an **electricity utility**, a **university**, an **IT services firm**, a **courier company**, a **call centre** — none of them has a tangible, storable, countable unit of output. Yet every one of them must answer questions that are commercially *identical* to the manufacturer's:

- What did one unit of our service cost?
- Are we charging enough to cover it?
- Is Route 12 losing money while Route 7 subsidises it?
- Did cost per bed-day go up because of inefficiency or because occupancy fell?

This is the problem service costing solves: how to measure, control and price the cost of an *intangible, non-storable, instantly-consumed* output — when the classic assumption of "one physical unit of product" has collapsed.

The stakes are real and they are exam-relevant. If you pick the wrong cost unit you get a number that is *arithmetically correct and commercially useless* — like knowing your bus fleet cost ₹4.8 crore "per bus" without knowing whether the buses ran full or empty, near or far. The entire discipline of service costing is really the discipline of **choosing the right denominator.**

> Service costing is also called **operating costing** — because you are costing an *operation* (running a fleet, running a ward) rather than making a product. ICAI uses both terms interchangeably; expect either in the question paper.

1.1 Internal vs external services — a distinction the examiner exploits

A service is not always sold to an outside customer. ICAI splits service undertakings into two families, and the split changes *why* you are costing at all:

- **External (public-utility) services** — sold to outsiders for a price: a transport corporation, a hotel, a hospital charging patients, a power utility, a courier firm. Here the cost per unit feeds a **price/fare/tariff** and the reconciliation must prove the margin.
- **Internal (captive / departmental) services** — consumed *inside* the same organisation: a factory's own **boiler house** raising steam for the plant, an in-house **power plant**, the **transport pool** that ferries raw material between shops, the staff **canteen**, the internal **IT help-desk**. Here the cost per unit is not a selling price — it is a **transfer/recovery rate** used to *re-charge user departments* so that each department bears its fair share of the service. The output of an internal service becomes an **overhead** of the department that consumes it.

Why this matters in the exam: for an internal service there is usually **no profit margin** (you recover cost, not price), and the deliverable is a **rate per unit for re-apportionment** (₹ per kWh generated, ₹ per 1,000 kg of steam, ₹ per km of internal haulage). If a question about a "captive power plant" asks you to "add 20% profit," pause — captive services are normally recovered at cost unless the question explicitly creates an inter-company charge.

---

2. The Core Idea — Cost the *Effort-Distance*, Not the Object

Here is the analogy that unlocks the whole chapter.

Imagine you hire a porter at a railway station. He offers to carry your bag. How should he price the job? He cannot charge "per bag" — a feather-light bag carried 2 km is nothing like a 40 kg trunk carried 20 metres. He cannot charge "per metre" — because 40 kg over 20 m is real work and a feather over 20 m is not. The *only honest measure of what he did* is **weight multiplied by distance** — kilogram-metres. That single fused number captures both dimensions of his effort at once.

That fused, two-dimensional measure is the heart of service costing. It is called a **composite cost unit** (also *compound cost unit*).

Where a factory says "cost per tonne," a transport company says **cost per tonne-kilometre** — because carrying one tonne one kilometre is the true atom of what a truck *does*. A passenger bus says **cost per passenger-kilometre**. A hospital says **cost per patient-day** (one patient occupying one bed for one day). A power station says **cost per kilowatt-hour** (one kilowatt drawn for one hour). A hotel says **cost per room-day** (or bed-night). A steam plant says **cost per kg of steam**.

Notice the pattern. Each composite unit multiplies a **quantity dimension** (a tonne, a passenger, a bed, a kilowatt) by a **service dimension** (a kilometre travelled, a day occupied, an hour consumed). Costing the object alone lies; costing the service dimension alone lies; **costing their product tells the truth.**

The porter charges kilogram-metres because neither the weight nor the walk alone describes his labour — only their product does. Every composite cost unit is a porter's charge.

Once you internalise that one idea — *find the two dimensions of the service and fuse them* — the rest of the chapter is bookkeeping.

2.1 Simple vs composite units — and when one dimension legitimately collapses

Not every service needs two dimensions. The composite unit is required only when **both** dimensions vary independently and both matter. When one dimension is effectively constant, it drops out and a **simple unit** is correct:

- A **canteen** serves meals of broadly standard size — "distance" has no meaning, so the unit collapses to **per meal**. There is no "meal-something."
- A **cinema** sells admissions to a fixed-length show — the unit is **per ticket** or **per seat**, not "seat-hour," because show length is constant.
- A **water utility** delivers a homogeneous commodity — **per kilolitre** suffices; there is no time dimension because water is storable-ish and billed on volume.
- A **hospital**, by contrast, cannot use "per patient," because two patients staying 2 days and 20 days are wildly different loads — so **patient-day** is mandatory.

The examiner's favourite trap is to *offer* you a plausible simple unit ("cost per passenger," "cost per bed") when the correct answer fuses two dimensions ("cost per passenger-km," "cost per patient-day"). The test: **ask whether holding the quantity constant but stretching the service dimension changes the cost.** If a passenger carried 200 km costs more than one carried 5 km, distance matters, and you *must* fuse it in.

---

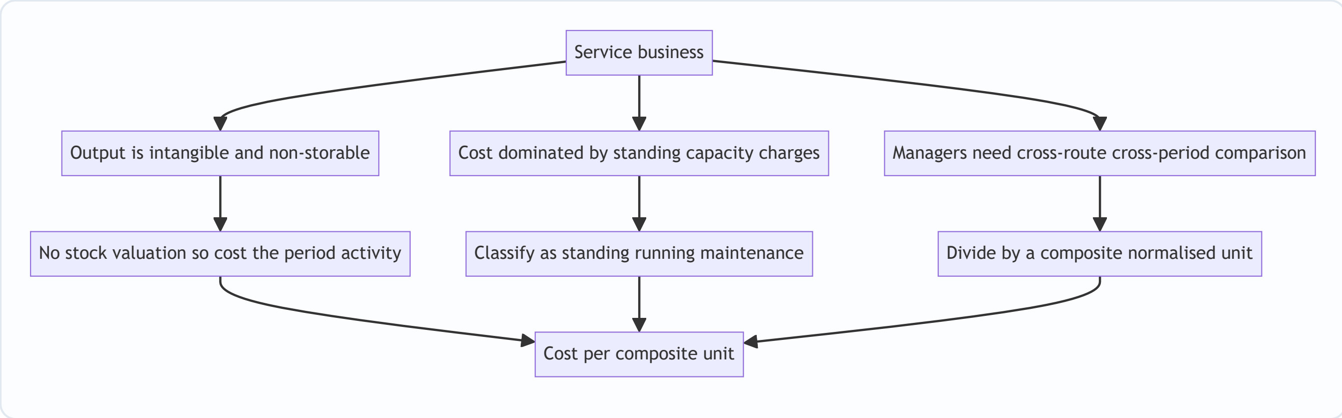
3. Why It Is Built This Way — The Three Structural Truths

Service costing looks like a grab-bag of tricks (passenger-km here, patient-day there). It is not. It flows from three structural truths about service businesses, and if you understand these three, you can *derive* the right treatment for any service you have never seen before — which is exactly what a hard exam question demands.

Truth 1 — Output is intangible and non-storable, so cost must attach to a *measure of activity*, not to inventory. There is no closing stock of "carriage" or "patient care." Therefore there is no work-in-progress, no equivalent units, no closing-stock valuation. Every rupee spent in the period is a cost of the period's service. This *simplifies* one thing (no stock valuation) and *complicates* another (you must invent a unit of activity to divide by).

Truth 2 — Cost is dominated by *capacity and standing charges*, not by *materials*. A manufacturer's cost is mostly materials that vary directly with output. A bus company's cost is mostly *the bus itself* — its depreciation, insurance, road tax, permit, garage rent, and the driver's salary — all of which are incurred **whether the bus carries 5 passengers or 50.** These are **standing (fixed) charges.** Only diesel, tyres and oil move with distance. This inverted cost structure is *why* service costing obsesses over **capacity utilisation** (occupancy %, load factor, seat-km offered vs sold). A near-empty bus and a full bus cost almost the same to run; the difference in *cost per passenger-km* is enormous. Hence the classification of costs (next section) is built around **standing vs running vs maintenance**, not around material/labour/overhead.

Truth 3 — The unit must be *comparable across time, routes and peers*, so it must normalise for scale. "Total cost of the fleet" tells a manager nothing. "Cost per bus" is better but still lies if buses run different distances. "Cost per bus-km" is better still but ignores whether the bus was full. Only **cost per passenger-km** lets you compare a short crowded city route with a long thin highway route on equal terms, compare this March with last March, and compare your corporation with the one next door. The composite unit exists to make cost *portable* across contexts.



The three structural truths of a service business each force one design choice, and the three choices converge on a single output — cost per composite unit.

3.1 The consequence of Truth 2 — operating leverage and the "occupancy is destiny" rule

Because the fixed block dominates, service businesses have **high operating leverage**: a small change in utilisation produces a large swing in cost per unit and an even larger swing in profit. This is not decoration; it is directly examinable, because ICAI loves the sub-question "recompute cost per unit if occupancy rises to X%."

Mechanically, write total cost as `F + vN`, where `F` is the fixed block, `v` the variable cost per unit of activity, and `N` the number of composite units:

$$\text{Cost per unit} = \frac{F + vN}{N} = \frac{F}{N} + v$$

The variable component `v` is a floor that never falls; the fixed component `F/N` **collapses hyperbolically as N rises**. Double the occupancy and you (roughly) halve the `F/N` term. That single equation explains why a hotel discounts fiercely to fill the last rooms, why an airline sells stand-by seats cheap, and why a hospital chases occupancy. When a question says "what fare would you charge to fill empty seats," it is testing whether you know that the *relevant* cost of an extra passenger is only `v`, not the full cost per unit — a marginal-costing bridge (Section 7).

---

4. Full Technical Content — Methods, Formulas, Classifications, Formats

4.1 Selecting the Cost Unit — the Central Skill

A cost unit is fit for purpose when it satisfies three tests:

1. **Representative** — it must genuinely capture what the service delivers (carriage over distance; occupancy over time).
2. **Measurable** — the data to compute it must actually be collectable (you can log km run and passengers carried; you cannot log "customer happiness").
3. **Comparable** — it must normalise for scale so periods, routes and peers line up.

Sometimes a **simple unit** suffices (one dimension dominates); often a **composite unit** is required (two dimensions both matter). The examiner's favourite trap is offering you a simple unit when a composite one is correct.

Service sector	Usual cost unit	Why this unit
Goods transport	**Tonne-kilometre**	Both load carried and distance matter
Passenger transport	**Passenger-kilometre**	Both persons carried and distance matter
Hospital	**Patient-day** (bed-day)	Both number of patients and length of stay matter
Hotel / lodging	**Room-day** or **bed-night**	Both rooms let and nights occupied matter
Canteen / catering	**Per meal** (or per dish)	Meals served is the natural output
Electricity	**Kilowatt-hour (kWh)**	Power drawn over time
Water supply	**Per kilolitre**	Volume delivered
Cinema	**Per ticket / per seat**	Admissions sold
Road maintenance	**Per kilometre of road**	Length maintained
IT / professional services	**Per chargeable hour** (per man-day)	Time is the billable resource
Education	**Per student** (or student-hour)	Students taught
Telecom	**Per call-minute**	Airtime consumed
Boiler / steam plant	**Per kg (or per 1,000 kg) of steam**	Mass of steam raised
Toll road / bridge	**Per vehicle-km** (or per PCU-km)	Vehicles carried over distance
Airline	**Per passenger-km / per tonne-km (cargo)**	Same logic as surface transport
BPO / call centre	**Per seat per shift** or **per call-minute**	Seat-time is the capacity sold

4.2 The Two Ways to Build a Composite Unit — Absolute vs Commercial

For transport especially, ICAI distinguishes **two ways** of computing the composite tonne-km (or passenger-km), and choosing wrong is a classic error.

Absolute (weighted) tonne-km — compute tonne-km for *each leg separately* using that leg's own load, then add. This is the accurate method and is the **default** for cost computation.

$$\text{Absolute tonne-km} = \sum (\text{load on each trip} \times \text{distance of that trip})$$

Commercial (average) tonne-km — take the *average load* over all trips and multiply by *total distance*.

$$\text{Commercial tonne-km} = \text{Average load} \times \text{Total distance}$$

They differ whenever the load varies leg to leg. **Unless the question says "commercial," use absolute.** (Same logic applies to passenger-km.)

The deeper why. Absolute is a *weighted* sum — it lets a heavy load on a long leg pull the total up, exactly as a porter's charge should. Commercial *averages away* the correlation between load and distance. They are equal in exactly one case: when every leg carries the same load (then averaging loses no information). Whenever heavy loads travel on the longer legs, **absolute > commercial**; whenever heavy loads sit on the shorter legs, **absolute < commercial**. Being able to *predict the direction* of the gap before computing is a fast self-check the examiner rewards, and it is the reconciliation insight in Example 1.

4.3 Classification of Costs in the Service Sector

Because the cost structure is capacity-dominated (Truth 2), service costing classifies costs by **behaviour and function specific to operating**, not merely as material/labour/overhead. The master scheme for **transport** is the template; other sectors adapt it.

A. Standing (Fixed) Charges — incurred to *keep the capacity available*, independent of usage: - Depreciation of vehicle (often; see note), road tax, permit fee, insurance premium - Garage / depot rent, salaries of drivers and conductors *if paid monthly regardless of running*, administrative and supervisory salaries - Licence fees

B. Running (Variable / Operating) Charges — vary directly with *distance / usage*: - Diesel / petrol / fuel, lubricating oil - Tyres and tubes (wear with distance) - Driver/conductor wages *if paid per trip or per km* - Commission on takings

C. Maintenance (Semi-variable) Charges — partly fixed, partly usage-driven: - Repairs and servicing, spare parts, painting, overhauls - Garage/workshop labour and consumables

> **Depreciation — the recurring examiner trick.** Depreciation may be **time-based** (e.g. straight-line on years → treat as a **standing** charge) or **usage/mileage-based** (e.g. per km run → treat as a **running** charge). *Read how the question states it.* If given as "₹X per annum" it is standing; if given as "₹Y per km" or "on the basis of km run" it is running.

Interest and finance cost — the quietly-dropped item. If the vehicle or asset is bought on a loan, the question sometimes gives "interest on capital / interest on loan." Treat it as a **standing charge** (it accrues with time, not usage) *unless the question tells you it is excluded from cost.* ICAI generally *includes* interest on capital in operating cost statements when the data is supplied — do not silently drop it as "financial." Flag: watch for whether interest is on the *whole* cost or on *average* capital employed (cost + scrap)/2; use exactly what the question defines.

The parallel classifications for other sectors:

Sector	Fixed / capacity costs	Variable / activity costs	Semi-variable
Hospital	Doctors' & nurses' salaries, building depreciation, equipment depreciation, admin, rent	Drugs & medicines, diet/food, disposables, laundry per load	Power, water, maintenance
Hotel	Staff salaries, building & furniture depreciation, rates & taxes, interior renovation	Linen, guest supplies, food, laundry	Power, cleaning, repairs
Canteen	Cook & staff wages, kitchen equipment depreciation, rent	Provisions, groceries, fuel/gas, milk	Power, cleaning, crockery replacement
Power (captive)	Plant depreciation, operating-staff salaries, interest on capital	Fuel/coal, water, consumable stores	Repairs & maintenance
Boiler / steam	Boiler depreciation, supervision salaries	Fuel/coal, treated water, chemicals	Repairs, cleaning

4.4 The Cost-Per-Unit Formula and the Standard Statement

The engine is always the same:

$$\text{Cost per composite unit} = \frac{\text{Total operating cost for the period}}{\text{Total composite units for the period}}$$

Everything hard is in the *denominator* — building the correct passenger-km / tonne-km / patient-day figure, allowing for occupancy, load factor, return trips, and idle days.

Building the denominator for transport — the checklist:

1. **Effective (running) days** = total days − idle/maintenance days.
2. **Trips/day and round trips** — a *round trip* covers the distance twice; count both legs.
3. **Distance run** = days × trips × km per trip (× 2 for return legs if a trip is one-way).
4. **Capacity actually used** = seats × load factor (passengers), or tonnes × capacity utilisation (goods).
5. **Composite units** = distance × capacity used (absolute method: per leg).

Two flavours of the per-unit answer — "per unit of capacity offered" vs "per unit sold." Sometimes the examiner wants *both*: - **Cost per km run** (or per bus-km / per seat-km *offered*) — divides by the *capacity dimension*, ignoring how full you were. This is a productivity/efficiency measure. - **Cost per passenger-km (sold)** — divides by *utilised* capacity. This is the pricing measure.

The gap between them is the price of empty seats. If cost per seat-km is ₹0.60 and load factor is 80%, cost per passenger-km is ₹0.60 ÷ 0.80 = ₹0.75. Being able to move between "offered" and "sold" denominators cleanly is a mark-scoring skill.

4.5 Format of the Operating Cost Statement (Transport)

Particulars	Per period (₹)	Per km (₹)	Per passenger-km (₹)
A. Standing charges			
Depreciation (time-based)	xxx		
Insurance, road tax, permit	xxx		
Driver & conductor salary (monthly)	xxx		
Garage rent, admin salaries	xxx		
Sub-total A	**XXX**		
B. Running charges			
Diesel & oil	xxx		
Tyres & tubes	xxx		
Depreciation (mileage-based)	xxx		
Sub-total B	**XXX**		
C. Maintenance charges			
Repairs & spares	xxx		
Sub-total C	**XXX**		
Total operating cost (A+B+C)	**TTT**	ttt	ttt
Add: Profit / markup	ppp		
Total takings / fare required	**FFF**		

Fare from cost — watch the base. If profit is quoted "on cost," fare = cost × (1 + margin). If quoted "on takings/fare" (i.e., on sales), then cost is (1 − margin) of fare, so **fare = cost ÷ (1 − margin).** Mixing these up is the single most common fare-calculation error.

4.6 Two format subtleties that separate a clean answer from a messy one

(i) The per-km column must reconcile down. Every running-charge line has a natural "per km" figure; every standing-charge line does *not* (it is a lump per period, converted to per-km only by dividing by total km). A disciplined answer shows standing charges as a single "per km" figure (Sub-total A ÷ km) rather than pretending each fixed line is "per km." The examiner can see at a glance that you understand *which costs are genuinely per-km*.

(ii) One vehicle vs a fleet. If the question gives fleet data (say 10 buses, different routes), decide early whether the cost unit is per-vehicle or fleet-wide. For a homogeneous fleet you can cost one representative bus and scale. For a mixed fleet (different capacities/routes) you must build **fleet total passenger-km** and **fleet total cost** and divide once — averaging per-bus rates is wrong because it weights a lightly-used bus equally with a heavily-used one.

5. Worked Examples — From Easy to Exam-Hard, Fully Reconciled

Example 1 (Easy) — Goods Transport: Absolute vs Commercial Tonne-km

Data. A truck of 10-tonne capacity makes the following trips in a day from depot D: - D → A (40 km) carrying 10 tonnes; returns empty A → D (40 km). - D → B (30 km) carrying 8 tonnes; returns empty B → D (30 km).

Total operating cost for the day = **₹9,000.** Find (i) absolute tonne-km, (ii) commercial tonne-km, (iii) cost per absolute tonne-km.

Step 1 — Absolute (weighted) tonne-km, per leg:

Leg	Load (t)	Distance (km)	Tonne-km
D→A loaded	10	40	400
A→D empty	0	40	0
D→B loaded	8	30	240
B→D empty	0	30	0
Total		**140**	**640**

Absolute tonne-km = **640.**

Step 2 — Commercial (average) tonne-km: Average load = total tonne-km ÷ total distance is *not* the definition here; commercial uses average load across trips. Average load over the four legs = (10 + 0 + 8 + 0) ÷ 4 = 4.5 tonnes. Total distance = 140 km. Commercial tonne-km = 4.5 × 140 = **630.**

Step 3 — Cost per absolute tonne-km = 9,000 ÷ 640 = **₹14.06.**

Reconciliation / insight. Absolute (640) exceeds commercial (630) because loading is concentrated on the longer leg (10 t over 40 km), which absolute rewards leg-by-leg but commercial dilutes by averaging. Cost computation uses the **absolute** figure. Empty return legs cost fuel but earn zero tonne-km — this is *why* the cost per tonne-km (₹14.06) is far above what you'd guess from cost per loaded-tonne-km alone; the deadhead return is baked into the rate.

What if the examiner tweaks it — a paid back-load appears. Suppose the return legs are no longer empty: A→D carries 4 t and B→D carries 5 t. Recompute absolute: 400 + (4×40) + 240 + (5×30) = 400 + 160 + 240 + 150 = **950 tonne-km**, and cost per tonne-km falls to 9,000 ÷ 950 = **₹9.47** — a 33% drop with *no change in cost*, purely from killing deadhead. This is the single most powerful lever in goods transport and a favourite "comment on your result" mark. Note the direction flip on the two methods too: commercial average load = (10+4+8+5)/4 = 6.75 t × 140 = 945, so now absolute (950) is only marginally above commercial (945) because loads are more even across legs.

Example 2 (Moderate) — Passenger Transport: Full Operating Cost Statement & Fare

Data. Sri Bus Co. runs one bus between town X and town Y, distance **50 km**, capacity **40 passengers.** - The bus makes **2 round trips per day.** - It runs **25 days** a month. - Average occupancy (load factor) = **80%** of capacity.

Costs per month: - Driver's salary ₹18,000; Conductor's salary ₹12,000 - Insurance ₹2,400; Road tax & permit ₹1,600; Garage rent ₹3,000 - Depreciation (time-based) ₹15,000 - Diesel & oil ₹52,000; Tyres & maintenance

₹8,000; Repairs ₹6,000

The company wants a **profit of 20% on takings (fare).** Compute (a) total monthly distance, (b) passenger-km, (c) total operating cost, (d) cost per passenger-km, (e) fare per passenger-km.

Step 1 — Distance run per month. One round trip = 50 × 2 = 100 km. Two round trips/day = 200 km/day. Monthly distance = 200 × 25 = **5,000 km.**

Step 2 — Passenger-km (denominator). Seats available per km run = 40; occupied = 80% × 40 = 32 passengers. Passenger-km = distance × passengers carried = 5,000 × 32 = **1,60,000 passenger-km.**

Step 3 — Total operating cost.

Particulars	₹/month
Standing charges	
Driver's salary	18,000
Conductor's salary	12,000
Insurance	2,400
Road tax & permit	1,600
Garage rent	3,000
Depreciation (time)	15,000
Sub-total (A)	**52,000**
Running charges	
Diesel & oil	52,000
Tyres & maintenance	8,000
Sub-total (B)	**60,000**
Maintenance charges	
Repairs	6,000
Sub-total (C)	**6,000**
Total operating cost	**1,18,000**

Step 4 — Cost per passenger-km = 1,18,000 ÷ 1,60,000 = **₹0.7375 per passenger-km.**

Step 5 — Fare per passenger-km. Profit is 20% **on takings**, so cost is 80% of fare. Fare = cost ÷ (1 − 0.20) = 0.7375 ÷ 0.80 = **₹0.921875 ≈ ₹0.9219 per passenger-km.**

Reconciliation. Total takings = fare × passenger-km = 0.921875 × 1,60,000 = **₹1,47,500.** Check profit = takings − cost = 1,47,500 − 1,18,000 = **₹29,500**, and 29,500 ÷ 1,47,500 = **20.0%** of takings. ✓ Fare per passenger for the full 50 km one-way trip = 0.921875 × 50 = **₹46.09.**

What if the examiner tweaks it — "20% on cost" instead of "on takings." Then fare = 0.7375 × 1.20 = **₹0.885 per passenger-km**, takings = 0.885 × 1,60,000 = **₹1,41,600**, profit = 1,41,600 − 1,18,000 = **₹23,600 = 20% of cost**. Notice the *same words "20% profit" produce two different fares* (₹0.9219 vs ₹0.885). This is exactly why Trap 2 exists — one phrase changes the whole answer.

Example 3 (Exam-Hard) — Transport with Idle Days, Return Legs, Load Factor, and Per-km Depreciation

Data. A logistics firm owns a **9-tonne** truck operating on a fixed route from depot P. - Distance P → Q = **120 km** (one way). The truck does **one round trip per day.** - On the **outward** leg it carries a **full 9 tonnes**; on the **return** leg it carries **6 tonnes** of back-load. - The truck operates **26 days** a month but was **idle for 2 days** under repair (so effective days = 24). - Cost of truck ₹27,00,000; life 5 years, scrap ₹3,00,000; **depreciation charged per km run** at a rate you must derive from an estimated life of **6,00,000 km.**

Monthly costs: - Driver & cleaner wages ₹32,000; Insurance ₹6,000; Road tax & permit ₹4,000; Garage rent ₹8,000; Admin & supervision ₹10,000. - Diesel: truck gives **4 km per litre**; diesel ₹90/litre. Oil & lubricants ₹0.50 per km. Tyres ₹1.20 per km. Repairs & maintenance ₹15,000 for the month (fixed portion) plus ₹0.80 per km (variable portion).

Required: (a) total km run, (b) absolute tonne-km, (c) full operating cost statement split standing/running/maintenance, (d) cost per tonne-km, (e) freight rate per tonne-km to earn **25% profit on cost.**

Step 1 — Km run. Round trip = 120 × 2 = 240 km/day. Effective days = 26 − 2 = 24. Total km = 240 × 24 = **5,760 km.**

Step 2 — Absolute tonne-km (per leg, per day, then month).

Leg	Load (t)	Distance (km)	Tonne-km/day
Outward P→Q	9	120	1,080
Return Q→P	6	120	720
Per round trip		240	**1,800**

Monthly absolute tonne-km = 1,800 × 24 = **43,200 tonne-km.**

Step 3 — Depreciation rate (per km). Depreciable amount = 27,00,000 − 3,00,000 = 24,00,000 over 6,00,000 km. Rate = 24,00,000 ÷ 6,00,000 = **₹4.00 per km** → this is a **running** charge (usage-based). Depreciation for month = 4.00 × 5,760 = **₹23,040.**

Step 4 — Running cost components (per km × 5,760 km). - Diesel: 4 km/litre → 5,760 ÷ 4 = 1,440 litres × ₹90 = **₹1,29,600.** (Equivalently ₹22.50/km.) - Oil & lubricants: 0.50 × 5,760 = **₹2,880.** - Tyres: 1.20 × 5,760 = **₹6,912.** - Depreciation (from Step 3) = **₹23,040.** - Variable repairs: 0.80 × 5,760 = **₹4,608.**

Step 5 — Full operating cost statement.

Particulars	₹/month
A. Standing charges	
Driver & cleaner wages	32,000
Insurance	6,000
Road tax & permit	4,000
Garage rent	8,000
Admin & supervision	10,000
Sub-total (A)	**60,000**
B. Running charges	
Diesel	1,29,600
Oil & lubricants	2,880
Tyres	6,912
Depreciation (per km)	23,040
Sub-total (B)	**1,62,432**
C. Maintenance charges	
Repairs — fixed	15,000
Repairs — variable	4,608
Sub-total (C)	**19,608**
Total operating cost (A+B+C)	**2,42,040**

Step 6 — Cost per tonne-km = 2,42,040 ÷ 43,200 = **₹5.6028 per tonne-km.**

Step 7 — Freight rate at 25% profit on cost. Rate = 5.6028 × 1.25 = **₹7.0035 per tonne-km.**

Reconciliation. Total freight = 7.0035 × 43,200 = **₹3,02,551** (rounding). Cleaner check without rounding: freight = cost × 1.25 = 2,42,040 × 1.25 = **₹3,02,550.** Profit = 3,02,550 − 2,42,040 = **₹60,510 = 25%** of cost 2,42,040. ✓ Cost per km = 2,42,040 ÷ 5,760 = **₹42.02/km** (a useful secondary check the examiner may also ask).

Note the two depreciation-style traps handled: here it was explicitly per km / mileage-based, so it went into running charges. Had the question said "₹4,80,000 per annum (₹40,000/month) on straight line," it would have been a standing charge instead — and cost per tonne-km would change. Always read the basis.

What if the examiner tweaks it — depreciation switched to time-based. Suppose instead "depreciate ₹24,00,000 over 5 years straight-line" = ₹4,80,000/yr = ₹40,000/month, a **standing** charge. Then Sub-total A becomes 60,000 + 40,000 = ₹1,00,000; Sub-total B loses the ₹23,040 depreciation and becomes ₹1,39,392; total cost = 1,00,000 + 1,39,392 + 19,608 = **₹2,59,000**. Cost per tonne-km = 2,59,000 ÷ 43,200 = **₹5.995 ≈ ₹6.00** — up from ₹5.60. The *same asset, same period* gives a different cost purely from the depreciation basis, and the gap (₹40,000 − ₹23,040 = ₹16,960) is exactly the difference between a full month's straight-line charge and the mileage charge for only 5,760 of the ~10,000 km/month the asset was designed for. This is the mechanism behind Trap 1.

Example 4 (Exam-Hard) — Hospital Costing: Cost per Patient-Day

Data. A charitable hospital runs a **60-bed** ward for a **30-day** month. - Average bed occupancy = **75%.** - In addition, during a **10-day peak**, the hospital hired **10 extra beds** at ₹120 per bed per day; these extra beds were **fully occupied** on those 10 days.

Monthly costs: - Salaries: doctors ₹9,60,000; nurses ₹4,20,000; other staff ₹1,20,000 - Medicines & drugs ₹2,25,000; Diet/food ₹1,80,000 - Laundry ₹90,000; Power & water ₹1,05,000 - Building depreciation ₹1,50,000; Equipment depreciation ₹75,000 - Administration ₹1,35,000

Required: (a) total patient-days, (b) total cost including hire of extra beds, (c) cost per patient-day, (d) if the hospital recovers ₹1,100 per patient-day from paying patients, what is the surplus/deficit?

Step 1 — Patient-days (the denominator).

Regular beds: 60 beds × 30 days × 75% occupancy = **1,350 patient-days.** Extra hired beds: 10 beds × 10 days × 100% = **100 patient-days. Total patient-days = 1,450.**

Step 2 — Total cost (add bed-hire as a running cost).

Particulars	₹/month
Fixed / capacity costs	
Doctors' salaries	9,60,000
Nurses' salaries	4,20,000
Other staff salaries	1,20,000
Building depreciation	1,50,000
Equipment depreciation	75,000
Administration	1,35,000
Sub-total (fixed)	**18,60,000**
Variable / activity costs	
Medicines & drugs	2,25,000
Diet / food	1,80,000
Laundry	90,000
Power & water	1,05,000
Hire of extra beds (100 bed-days × ₹120)	12,000
Sub-total (variable)	**6,12,000**
Total operating cost	**24,72,000**

Step 3 — Cost per patient-day = 24,72,000 ÷ 1,450 = **₹1,705.52.**

Step 4 — Surplus / deficit at recovery of ₹1,100/patient-day. Recovery = 1,100 × 1,450 = **₹15,95,000.** Deficit = 15,95,000 − 24,72,000 = **(₹8,77,000).**

Reconciliation / insight. The hospital runs a **deficit of ₹8.77 lakh** — expected for a charitable hospital, which recovers below cost and funds the gap from donations. The result is dominated by the **fixed block (₹18.6 lakh, 75% of cost)** — a textbook demonstration of Truth 2: raise occupancy and cost per patient-day falls sharply because the fixed block spreads over more patient-days. Verify the denominator logic: had we wrongly used *bed-days available* (60 × 30 = 1,800) instead of *occupied patient-days* (1,350) we would have understated cost per patient-day and hidden the effect of idle capacity — the classic hospital trap.

Sensitivity to prove the point: at 90% occupancy regular patient-days = 60 × 30 × 0.90 = 1,620, total patient-days = 1,720, and cost per patient-day (fixed block unchanged, variable roughly scaling) drops materially — showing that in service costing the fight is over the denominator, i.e., utilisation.

What if the examiner tweaks it — a mix of general and special beds with different recoveries. Say 45 regular beds recover ₹900/patient-day and 15 recover ₹1,600/patient-day. You cannot use a single blended recovery; you must build patient-days *per bed class* and multiply each by its own rate, then sum. This is the same trap as a mixed fleet in transport — never average two rates when you can weight them by their own volumes.

Example 5 (Exam-Hard) — Hotel Costing: Room-Day, Seasonal Occupancy, and Tariff

Data. A hotel has **80 rooms**. Occupancy differs by season across a 365-day year: - **Peak season (120 days):** 90% occupancy. - **Off season (245 days):** 40% occupancy.

Annual costs: - Staff salaries ₹96,00,000; Building & furniture depreciation ₹48,00,000; Rates & taxes ₹12,00,000; Admin & general ₹24,00,000 — all fixed. - Room supplies, linen and laundry: ₹150 **per occupied room-day** (variable). - Power & maintenance: ₹36,00,000 fixed + ₹50 per occupied room-day variable.

The hotel wants **profit of 25% on room-tariff (i.e., on takings).** Required: (a) total occupied room-days, (b) total cost, (c) cost per room-day, (d) tariff per room-day.

Step 1 — Occupied room-days (denominator). Peak: 80 × 120 × 90% = **8,640 room-days.** Off: 80 × 245 × 40% = **7,840 room-days. Total occupied room-days = 16,480.**

Step 2 — Total cost.

Particulars	₹/year
Fixed	
Staff salaries	96,00,000
Building & furniture depreciation	48,00,000
Rates & taxes	12,00,000
Admin & general	24,00,000
Power & maintenance — fixed	36,00,000
Sub-total (fixed)	**2,16,00,000**
Variable (per occupied room-day)	
Room supplies, linen, laundry (16,480 × ₹150)	24,72,000
Power & maintenance — variable (16,480 × ₹50)	8,24,000
Sub-total (variable)	**32,96,000**
Total operating cost	**2,48,96,000**

Step 3 — Cost per room-day = 2,48,96,000 ÷ 16,480 = **₹1,510.68.**

Step 4 — Tariff at 25% on takings. Cost is 75% of tariff, so tariff = 1,510.68 ÷ 0.75 = **₹2,014.24 per room-day.**

Reconciliation. Total takings = 2,014.24 × 16,480 = **₹3,31,94,675** (rounding). Cleaner: takings = cost ÷ 0.75 = 2,48,96,000 ÷ 0.75 = **₹3,31,94,667**. Profit = 3,31,94,667 − 2,48,96,000 = **₹83,00,667 = 25% of takings**. ✓

Insight — the "occupied vs available" fork drives the whole answer. Available room-days = 80 × 365 = 29,200; occupied = 16,480, an **overall occupancy of only 56.4%**. If a naive answer divides the ₹2.49 crore cost by 29,200 available room-days it gets ₹852/room-day and a tariff that *fails to recover fixed cost* in a hotel that is empty 44% of the time. The examiner sets seasonal occupancy precisely to test whether you divide by *occupied* room-days. Because peak occupancy (90%) is far above off-season (40%), a follow-up part often asks for a **differential tariff** — charge more in peak — which is a pricing-strategy comment, not a new computation.

What if the examiner tweaks it — double occupancy. If some rooms are let to two guests, the unit may shift to **bed-night** rather than room-day; recompute the denominator on beds occupied, and note that variable per-guest costs (linen, breakfast) then scale on beds while room-linked costs (cleaning) scale on rooms. Splitting variable costs by the *right* driver is the finer distinction here.

Example 6 (Exam-Hard) — Captive Power Plant: Cost per kWh with Transmission Loss

Data. A factory runs a captive power plant to supply its own shops. In a month: - Units **generated** at the plant = **5,00,000 kWh**. - **Transmission/distribution loss** = **4%** of units generated; only the balance reaches the shops (units *consumed*).

Monthly costs: - Coal/fuel ₹18,00,000; Water & treatment chemicals ₹90,000; Operating-staff salaries ₹3,60,000; Repairs & maintenance ₹1,50,000; Plant depreciation ₹6,00,000; Interest on capital ₹2,40,000;

Consumable stores ₹60,000.

Required: (a) cost per kWh **generated**, (b) cost per kWh **consumed** (the rate at which user departments should be charged), (c) classify fixed vs variable.

Step 1 — Units. Generated = 5,00,000 kWh. Loss = 4% × 5,00,000 = 20,000 kWh. **Consumed = 4,80,000 kWh.**

Step 2 — Total cost.

Particulars	₹/month	Behaviour
Coal / fuel	18,00,000	Variable
Water & chemicals	90,000	Variable
Consumable stores	60,000	Variable
Operating-staff salaries	3,60,000	Fixed
Repairs & maintenance	1,50,000	Semi-variable
Plant depreciation	6,00,000	Fixed
Interest on capital	2,40,000	Fixed
Total	**33,00,000**	

Step 3 — Cost per kWh generated = 33,00,000 ÷ 5,00,000 = **₹6.60 per kWh.**

Step 4 — Cost per kWh consumed = 33,00,000 ÷ 4,80,000 = **₹6.875 per kWh.**

Reconciliation / insight. The *right* re-charge rate to user departments is **₹6.875 per kWh consumed**, not ₹6.60 — because the cost of the 20,000 lost units must be recovered from the units that actually arrive. Charging on units generated would leave 4% of the plant's cost unrecovered (33,00,000 × 4% ≈ ₹1.32 lakh stranded). Check: 4,80,000 × ₹6.875 = ₹33,00,000 = full cost recovered. ✓ Note there is **no profit margin** — this is an *internal* service (Section 1.1); the deliverable is a cost-recovery transfer rate, so adding a markup would be wrong unless the question explicitly sells surplus power to the grid at a tariff.

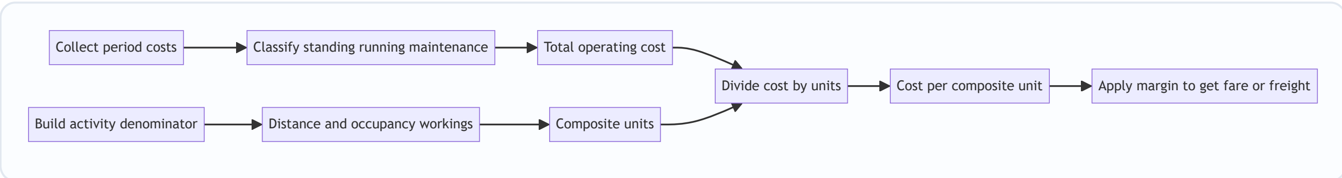
What if the examiner tweaks it — surplus sold to the grid. If 4,80,000 kWh reaches the works but the works only *use* 4,20,000 kWh and 60,000 kWh is exported at ₹5/kWh, the export revenue (₹3,00,000) is *credited* to the power-plant cost, and the net cost is recovered from internal consumption of 4,20,000 kWh: (33,00,000 − 3,00,000) ÷ 4,20,000 = ₹7.14/kWh. The by-product-credit logic (net-realisable-value) crosses over from process costing.

---

6. Presentation / Format Rules for the Exam

- **Always present a three-column or clearly-sectioned statement:** amount for the period, and where asked, per-km and per-composite-unit columns.
- **Group costs under the standard headings** (Standing / Running / Maintenance for transport; Fixed / Variable for hospital-hotel-canteen). Sub-total each group — examiners award method marks for the classification even if a number slips.
- **Show the denominator build-up as a labelled working**, not buried in the statement. Distance working, occupancy working, patient-day working — each as a separate numbered step.

- **State the cost unit explicitly** ("Cost per passenger-km," "Cost per patient-day") — never leave a bare number.
- **Carry 2–4 decimals** on per-unit figures (fares and freight rates are small numbers where rounding early destroys the reconciliation).
- **Close with a reconciliation line** proving takings − cost = profit at the stated margin. This both earns marks and catches your own errors.
- **Do the denominator FIRST, then the cost.** Building passenger-km/patient-day up front means every later "per unit" figure has a home, and you avoid the common panic of a finished cost statement with no denominator to divide by. The two streams are independent (see the workflow diagram) — start the one that is easier to get wrong.
- **Label every rate with its basis** — "₹0.9219 per passenger-km (fare, 20% on takings)" tells the examiner you know *which* margin convention you applied. An unlabelled rate invites the marker to assume the wrong base.



The exam-answer workflow: two independent streams — cost numerator and activity denominator — meet at the division, then the margin is applied last.

---

7. Connections — Where Service Costing Sits in the Whole Subject

- **vs Job / Batch / Process costing:** those cost *tangible output*; service costing costs *intangible activity*. The machinery (accumulate cost, divide by units) is identical — only the *unit* changes. Service costing is really "process costing where the process has no product."
- **Cost classification (fixed/variable):** service costing is the most vivid application of cost behaviour. Its standing-charge dominance is *why* **marginal costing and break-even** analysis are so powerful for services (a hotel's extra guest is almost pure contribution once fixed costs are covered).
- **Overhead absorption:** choosing passenger-km as the absorption base is conceptually the same act as choosing machine-hours in a factory — pick the base that drives the cost.
- **Marginal costing & decision-making (later chapters):** "Should we run Route 12?" is a *contribution* question built directly on the cost-per-unit here. "Accept a bulk transport order at ₹6/tonne-km when cost is ₹5.60?" is a relevant-cost decision seeded in this chapter.
- **Budgeting & standard costing:** standard cost per patient-day / per passenger-km becomes the benchmark; variances (occupancy variance, fuel-efficiency variance) flow from it.
- **CAS (Cost Accounting Standards):** ICAI's cost statements for transport and utilities in regulated sectors (electricity, ports) are formalised versions of exactly this statement.
- **By-product / joint-cost logic:** the "surplus power sold to grid" credit in Example 6 is the net-realisable-value treatment borrowed straight from joint & by-product costing — service costing does not live in a silo.
- **Reconciliation of cost & financial accounts:** because service costing has no stock, cost profit and financial profit differ only by items like interest or notional charges — one reason interest-on-capital

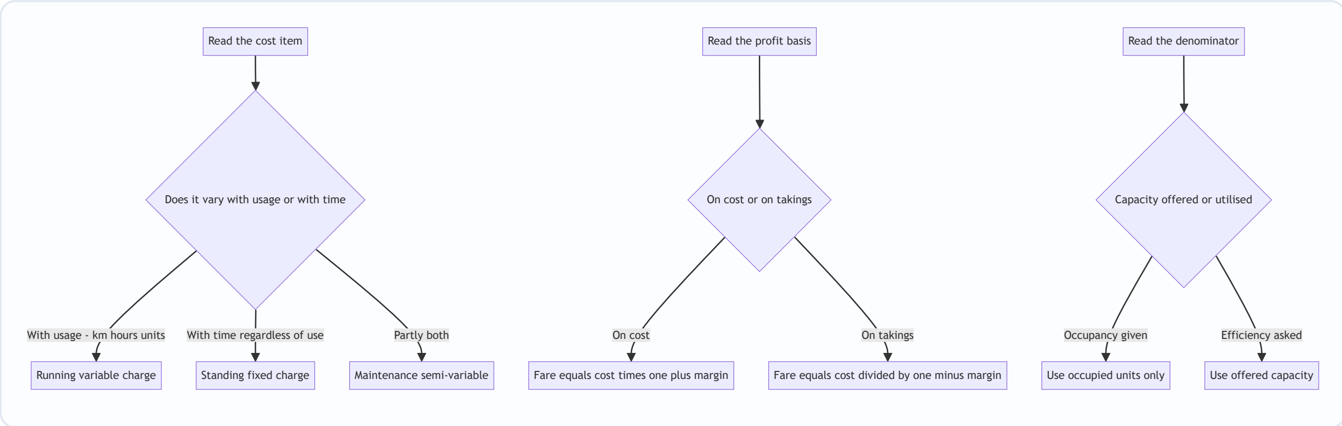
treatment (Section 4.3) matters.

---

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Depreciation basis.** Time-based ⇒ standing charge; mileage/km-based ⇒ running charge. The question *always* signals which; misclassifying changes total cost and per-unit cost. **The #1 trap.** (See Example 3's tweak for the full numerical effect.)
2. **Profit on cost vs on takings.** "20% on cost" ⇒ fare = cost × 1.20. "20% on takings/fare" ⇒ fare = cost ÷ 0.80. Reconcile at the end to catch this. (Example 2's tweak shows the two answers side by side.)
3. **Return / empty legs.** Count *both legs* of a round trip for distance and fuel, but credit tonne-km/passenger-km only for the *loaded* leg (or the back-load, if any). Empty returns cost money and earn nothing — that is *why* the per-unit rate is high.
4. **Absolute vs commercial tonne-km.** Default to **absolute (weighted per leg)** unless "commercial/average" is stated. They differ only when the load varies leg to leg — and you can predict the *direction* of the gap before computing (Section 4.2).
5. **Available vs occupied capacity in the denominator.** Use **seats/beds/rooms actually occupied** (load factor / occupancy %), *not* capacity available, when the question gives occupancy. Using available capacity understates cost per unit and hides idle-capacity cost. (Example 5's overall 56% occupancy is set to bait this.)
6. **Idle / maintenance days.** Subtract them to get *effective running days* before computing distance. A bus "operating 30 days" but "idle 3 days for repair" runs only 27.
7. **Round trips vs single trips.** "2 round trips" = 4 one-way legs = 4 × one-way distance. Read carefully.
8. **Bed-hire / peak capacity in hospitals & hotels.** Extra hired beds/rooms add to *both* cost (the hire charge) *and* the denominator (extra patient-days/room-days). Include in both or the per-unit figure is wrong.
9. **Wages classification.** Monthly fixed salary ⇒ standing; per-trip/per-km/commission ⇒ running. The same "driver's pay" can sit in either bucket depending on the pay basis stated.
10. **Units of the answer.** Fuel is per litre, but cost per km needs km/litre first. Diesel ₹90/litre at 4 km/litre is ₹22.50/km — a two-step conversion students skip.
11. **Simple vs composite unit.** Don't cost a hospital "per patient" (ignores length of stay) or a truck "per tonne" (ignores distance). Fuse the two dimensions.
12. **Transmission / distribution / evaporation loss.** For power, water, steam and gas, divide cost by units *delivered/consumed*, not units *generated/pumped* — the loss must be recovered from what actually arrives (Example 6). Charging on gross output strands the cost of the loss.
13. **Interest on capital silently dropped.** If the question supplies interest on capital/loan, *include* it (usually as a standing charge) unless told to exclude — do not reflexively treat it as a non-cost financial item.
14. **Internal service given a profit margin.** A captive power plant / boiler / transport pool recovers *cost*, not price. Do not add profit unless the question sells output externally at a stated tariff (Section 1.1).
15. **Mixing rates instead of weighting volumes.** Mixed fleets, mixed bed-classes, differential seasonal tariffs — never average two per-unit rates; build total cost and total units and divide once, or weight each class by its own volume (Examples 4 and 5 tweaks).

16. **"Per unit generated" vs "per unit sold/consumed" confusion.** Cost per km run (offered) and cost per passenger-km (sold) are both legitimate but answer different questions; give whichever the examiner asks and don't confuse the two (Section 4.4).



A decision tree for the three classification forks that generate most exam errors — behaviour of cost, basis of profit, and choice of denominator.

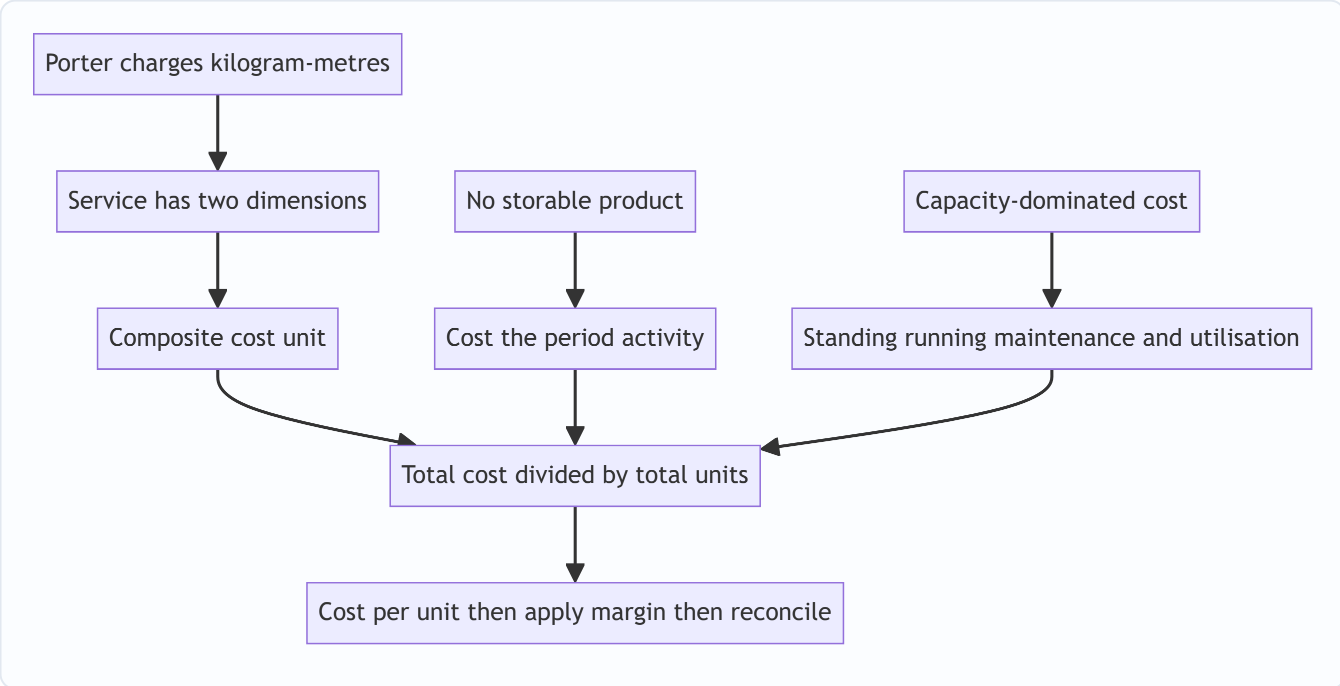
---

9. First-Principles Recap — Rebuild the Chapter From One Sentence

Start from the porter. *He charges kilogram-metres because neither weight nor walk alone describes his work.* From that one sentence, everything regenerates:

- Services have **no storable product**, so you cannot cost an object → you must cost an **activity**.
- The activity has **two dimensions** (a quantity and a service-span), so a single-dimension unit lies → you need a **composite unit** (tonne-km, passenger-km, patient-day, kWh, room-day).
- Service cost is **capacity-dominated** (the bus/bed exists whether used or not) → classify costs as **standing / running / maintenance** and *obsess over utilisation*, because the denominator (how full, how far, how long) drives the per-unit cost more than the numerator does.
- To make cost **comparable** across routes, periods and peers → divide total operating cost by total composite units to get **cost per composite unit**.
- To price → apply a margin, **watching whether it's on cost or on takings.**
- To reconcile → prove **takings − cost = stated profit.**
- Where output is **lost in delivery** (transmission, evaporation) → divide by units *delivered*, so the loss is recovered from what arrives.
- Where the service is **internal** → recover cost, not price; the per-unit figure is a transfer rate, not a fare.

If you can walk from "the porter" to "cost per patient-day" without notes, you own this chapter.



The whole chapter as a derivation tree rooted in a single intuition.

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

Core identity $$\text{Cost per unit} = \frac{\text{Total operating cost}}{\text{Total composite units}}$$

Behaviour identity (why occupancy is destiny) $$\text{Cost per unit} = \frac{F}{N} + v \quad \text{— fixed term collapses as N (utilisation) rises}$$

Cost units by sector

Sector	Unit
Goods transport	Tonne-km
Passenger transport	Passenger-km
Hospital	Patient-day (bed-day)
Hotel	Room-day / bed-night
Canteen	Per meal
Power	kWh
Steam / boiler	Per kg (per 1,000 kg)
IT / professional	Chargeable hour

Cost classification (transport) - **Standing** (capacity): time-depreciation, insurance, road tax, permit, garage rent, monthly salaries, admin, interest on capital. - **Running** (usage): fuel, oil, tyres, mileage-depreciation, per-km/commission wages. - **Maintenance** (semi-variable): repairs, spares, servicing.

Denominator recipe (transport) 1. Effective days = total − idle. 2. Distance = days × trips × km (×2 for round trips). 3. Capacity used = seats/tonnes × occupancy/load factor. 4. Composite units = Σ(load ×

distance) per leg (**absolute**).

- **Absolute tonne-km** = Σ(load × distance) per leg. *(default)*
- **Commercial tonne-km** = average load × total distance.
- Direction check: heavy loads on long legs ⇒ absolute > commercial.

Hospital denominator = beds × days × occupancy % (+ hired beds × days occupied). Include hire charge in cost. **Hotel denominator** = rooms × days × occupancy % (season by season). Divide by *occupied*, not available. **Power/steam/water** = divide cost by units *delivered/consumed* (net of transmission/evaporation loss), not units generated.

Offered vs sold denominator - Cost per km run / per seat-km = efficiency (offered capacity). - Cost per passenger-km = pricing (utilised capacity) = cost per seat-km ÷ load factor.

Pricing - Profit on **cost**: Fare = Cost × (1 + m). - Profit on **takings**: Fare = Cost ÷ (1 − m). - Internal/captive service ⇒ usually **no margin** (recover cost as transfer rate).

Depreciation flag: per-annum ⇒ standing; per-km ⇒ running.

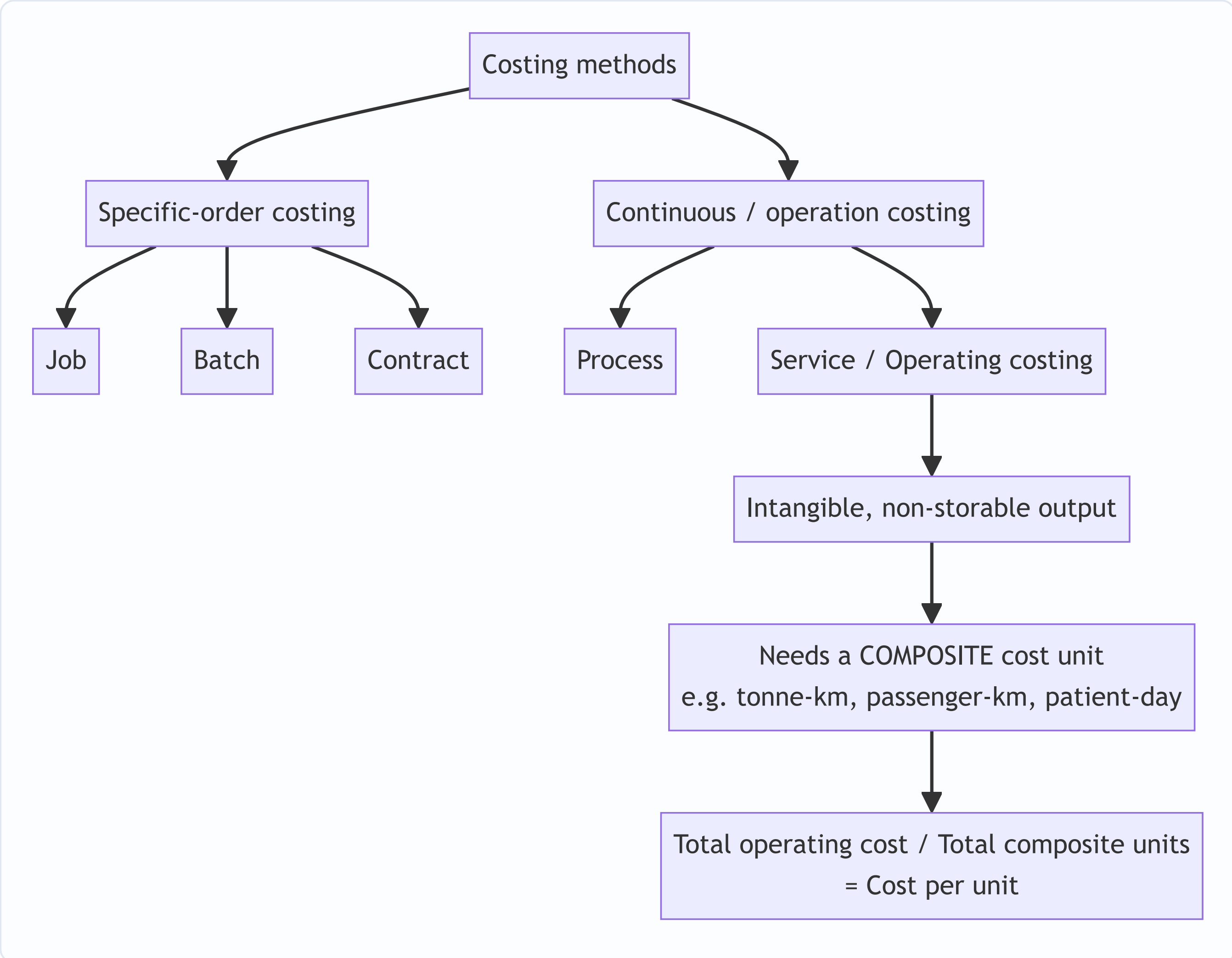
Always finish with: Takings − Cost = Profit at stated margin. ✓

Traps in one line: basis of depreciation • on-cost vs on-takings • count empty legs for distance not for tonne-km • absolute vs commercial • occupied not available capacity • subtract idle days • round trips × 2 • include hired beds in both cost and denominator • wage basis decides bucket • convert fuel/litre to /km • divide by units delivered not generated • don't drop interest on capital • no margin on internal services • weight volumes never average rates • never use a simple unit where a composite one is needed.

Q&A — Service Costing

> CA Intermediate · Cost & Management Accounting · Chapter: **Service (Operating) Costing** Every question is followed immediately by a complete model answer. All figures reconcile. Currency: Indian Rupees (Rs.).

How the method sits in the family (Mermaid)



SECTION A — Concept-Check (short answer)

A1. Why is service costing also called *operating costing*, and what is the defining feature of its output? **Answer.** It is called operating costing because it computes the cost of *operating* a service (a facility rendered rather than a good produced). Defining feature: the output is **intangible and non-storable** — it cannot be inventoried, so there is no closing WIP/finished-goods valuation; cost is expressed per unit of service rendered during the period.

A2. What is a *composite (compound) cost unit*? Give two examples. **Answer.** A cost unit built from **two factors multiplied together** because a single factor fails to capture the value delivered. Examples: **tonne-**

kilometre (weight × distance) for goods transport, **passenger-kilometre** for passenger transport, **patient-day** (patients × days) for hospitals, **kilowatt-hour** for power, **room-day** for hotels.

A3. State Porter's kilogram-metre analogy and what it teaches about composite units. **Answer.** A porter who carries 10 kg over 100 m does the *same work* as one who carries 100 kg over 10 m — both equal **1,000 kg-metres**. It teaches that in transport the *effort/value* is a **product of load and distance**, so cost must be spread over a composite unit (tonne-km), never over distance alone or load alone.

A4. Distinguish **absolute (weighted) tonne-km** from **commercial (simple/average) tonne-km**. **Answer.** - **Absolute tonne-km** = Σ (load of each trip × distance of that trip). It weights each leg by its own load — more accurate. - **Commercial tonne-km** = **Average load** × **Total distance** travelled. It uses one average load across the whole distance — simpler but approximate.

A5. Under what three cost heads are operating costs usually classified in a transport operating-cost statement? **Answer.** (i) **Standing / Fixed charges** (insurance, road tax, licence, garage rent, salary of permanent driver, depreciation on time basis); (ii) **Running / Variable charges** (fuel, oil, tyres, depreciation on km basis); (iii) **Maintenance / Semi-variable charges** (repairs, servicing, spare parts).

A6. Why can depreciation appear under *either* standing or running charges? **Answer.** If provided on a **time basis** (e.g. per annum on straight line) it is a **standing charge** (accrues whether the vehicle runs or not); if provided on a **usage basis** (e.g. per km run), it is a **running charge**. The question's wording dictates the classification — a classic trap.

A7. In a passenger-bus problem, how do you convert seating capacity and occupancy into passenger-km? **Answer.** Passenger-km = **Seats × Occupancy % × Km run × Trips (both ways as applicable) × Operating days**. Only *occupied* seats generate revenue-earning passenger-km, so the occupancy percentage must be applied.

A8. Why are *idle/off-road days* important when computing cost per running km? **Answer.** Standing charges accrue for **all** days (idle or not), but they are recovered only over the **kilometres actually run**. Ignoring idle days overstates km run, understates cost per km, and gives a wrong quotation.

SECTION B — Graded Computational Problems (easy → exam-hard)

B1 (Easy) — Simple tonne-km and cost per tonne-km

A lorry carries **5 tonnes** of goods over a **one-way** distance of **120 km** and returns **empty**. It makes this trip on all **25 operating days** in a month. Total operating cost for the month is **Rs. 90,000**. Compute (a) absolute tonne-km and (b) cost per tonne-km.

Answer. Loaded leg only earns tonne-km (return is empty ⇒ 0 tonnes). - Loaded tonne-km per trip = 5 t × 120 km = 600 tonne-km. - Monthly absolute tonne-km = 600 × 25 days = **15,000 tonne-km**. - Cost per tonne-km = Rs. 90,000 ÷ 15,000 = **Rs. 6.00 per tonne-km**.

Note: total distance run = (120 + 120) × 25 = 6,000 km, but the empty return earns no tonne-km.

B2 (Easy-Moderate) — Passenger-km and fare

A 40-seat bus runs **2 round trips** daily on a **20 km** (one-way) route, for **25 days** a month, at **75% occupancy**. Total operating cost is **Rs. 1,50,000** per month and the operator wants a **20% profit on takings**

(fare). Find (a) passenger-km and (b) fare per passenger-km.

Answer. Distance per day = 20 km × 2 (one-way per round trip) × 2 round trips = 80 km. Passenger-km per month = Seats × Occupancy × Km × Days = 40 × 75% × 80 × 25 = 30 × 80 × 25 = **60,000 passenger-km**.

Cost per passenger-km = 1,50,000 ÷ 60,000 = **Rs. 2.50**. Profit is 20% of fare ⇒ cost is 80% of fare. Fare per passenger-km = 2.50 ÷ 0.80 = **Rs. 3.125 ≈ Rs. 3.13 per passenger-km**.

Check: Fare 3.125 × 60,000 = Rs. 1,87,500; profit = 1,87,500 − 1,50,000 = Rs. 37,500 = 20% of 1,87,500. ✓

B3 (Moderate) — Full operating cost statement, goods transport

A transport company runs one truck. Data for the year: - Cost of truck Rs. 12,00,000; residual value Rs. 1,20,000; life 5 years (depreciation on **time/straight-line** basis). - Annual: Insurance Rs. 24,000; Road tax & licence Rs. 12,000; Driver's salary Rs. 1,80,000; Garage rent Rs. 24,000. - Diesel: truck runs **1,00,000 km** a year; mileage 5 km/litre; diesel Rs. 90/litre. - Oil & sundries Rs. 1.50 per km; Tyres Rs. 1.00 per km; Repairs & maintenance Rs. 60,000 for the year. - Effective load: truck carries **8 tonnes** on the outward leg and returns empty; outward and return distances are equal, so **half** the km are loaded.

Prepare the operating cost statement and find cost per tonne-km. Profit is not required.

Answer.

Depreciation (time basis) = (12,00,000 − 1,20,000) ÷ 5 = Rs. 2,16,000 p.a.

Diesel = 1,00,000 km ÷ 5 = 20,000 litres × Rs. 90 = Rs. 18,00,000. Oil & sundries = 1,00,000 × 1.50 = Rs. 1,50,000. Tyres = 1,00,000 × 1.00 = Rs. 1,00,000.

Operating Cost Statement (per annum)

Head	Rs.
A. Standing charges	
Depreciation (time basis)	2,16,000
Insurance	24,000
Road tax & licence	12,000
Driver's salary	1,80,000
Garage rent	24,000
Sub-total A	**4,56,000**
B. Running charges	
Diesel	18,00,000
Oil & sundries	1,50,000
Tyres	1,00,000
Sub-total B	**20,50,000**
C. Maintenance charges	
Repairs & maintenance	60,000
Sub-total C	**60,000**
Total operating cost (A+B+C)	**25,66,000**

Tonne-km: loaded km = half of 1,00,000 = 50,000 km at 8 tonnes. Absolute tonne-km = 50,000 × 8 = **4,00,000 tonne-km**. **Cost per tonne-km = 25,66,000 ÷ 4,00,000 = Rs. 6.415 ≈ Rs. 6.42.**

Cost per km run (for reference) = 25,66,000 ÷ 1,00,000 = **Rs. 25.66/km**.

B4 (Exam-hard) — Idle days, per-km depreciation, absolute vs commercial tonne-km, quotation

A truck operator gives the following for a month of **30 days**, of which the truck is **idle for 5 days** (under repair): - Truck cost Rs. 15,00,000; depreciation charged at **Rs. 4.00 per km run** (usage basis). - Standing charges for the month: Insurance Rs. 5,000; Tax Rs. 2,000; Permit Rs. 3,000; Driver + cleaner wages Rs. 30,000; Garage rent Rs. 6,000. - Repairs & maintenance for the month Rs. 20,000. - Diesel Rs. 90/litre, mileage 4 km/litre; Oil/lubricants Rs. 2.00 per km.

Trip pattern (performed on each of the **25 running days**): the truck makes **one round trip** of 100 km each way (200 km/day). It carries **10 tonnes outward** for the full 100 km, then **6 tonnes on the return** 100 km.

Required: (a) km run and diesel; (b) **absolute** tonne-km; (c) **commercial** tonne-km; (d) total operating cost; (e) cost per absolute tonne-km; (f) a freight **quotation per tonne-km** giving 25% profit on cost.

Answer.

(a) Km run & diesel. Running days = 30 − 5 = 25. Km/day = 200 ⇒ km run = 25 × 200 = **5,000 km**. Diesel = 5,000 ÷ 4 = 1,250 litres × 90 = **Rs. 1,12,500**.

(b) Absolute (weighted) tonne-km = Σ (load × distance of each leg) = (10 t × 100 km) + (6 t × 100 km) = 1,000 + 600 = 1,600 tonne-km/day. × 25 days = **40,000 absolute tonne-km**.

(c) Commercial (average) tonne-km = Average load × Total distance. Average load = (10 + 6) ÷ 2 = 8 tonnes. Total distance = 5,000 km. = 8 × 5,000 = **40,000 commercial tonne-km**. *(Here they coincide because both legs are equal distance; had legs differed, they would diverge — state this in the exam.)*

(d) Operating Cost Statement (for the month)

Head	Rs.
A. Standing charges	
Insurance	5,000
Tax	2,000
Permit	3,000
Driver + cleaner wages	30,000
Garage rent	6,000
Sub-total A	**46,000**
B. Running charges	
Diesel	1,12,500
Oil / lubricants (5,000 × 2)	10,000
Depreciation (5,000 km × 4)	20,000
Sub-total B	**1,42,500**
C. Maintenance	
Repairs & maintenance	20,000
Total operating cost	**2,08,500**

Note the trap handled: standing charges (Rs. 46,000) accrue for all 30 days but are recovered over 5,000 km actually run; depreciation is on **km basis** so it goes to running charges and is nil for idle days.

(e) Cost per absolute tonne-km = 2,08,500 ÷ 40,000 = **Rs. 5.2125 ≈ Rs. 5.21**.

(f) Quotation with 25% profit on cost = 5.2125 × 1.25 = **Rs. 6.5156 ≈ Rs. 6.52 per tonne-km**.

Check: Revenue = 6.5156 × 40,000 = Rs. 2,60,625; profit = 2,60,625 − 2,08,500 = Rs. 52,125 = 25% of cost. ✓

B5 (Exam-hard) — Hospital: cost per patient-day

A hospital wing has **30 beds**, occupied on average at **80%** through a **30-day** month. Costs for the month: - Doctors' & nurses' salaries Rs. 6,00,000; Housekeeping & food Rs. 1,44,000; Medicines & consumables Rs. 90,000. - Depreciation on building & equipment Rs. 60,000; Power, water, laundry Rs. 66,000; Administration Rs. 36,000. Find (a) patient-days and (b) cost per patient-day. (c) If the hospital wants 15% margin on billing, what is the daily charge per patient?

Answer. (a) Patient-days = Beds × Occupancy × Days = 30 × 80% × 30 = **720 patient-days**.

(b) Total cost = 6,00,000 + 1,44,000 + 90,000 + 60,000 + 66,000 + 36,000 = **Rs. 9,96,000**. Cost per patient-day = 9,96,000 ÷ 720 = **Rs. 1,383.33**.

(c) Charge with 15% margin on billing ⇒ cost = 85% of charge. Charge = 1,383.33 ÷ 0.85 = **Rs. 1,627.45 per patient-day**.

Check: Billing = 1,627.45 × 720 = Rs. 11,71,764; margin = 11,71,764 − 9,96,000 = Rs. 1,75,764 ≈ 15% of billing. ✓

SECTION C — Past-Paper-Style Full Questions

C1. Bus operator — fare per passenger-km (ICAI style)

A bus operator owns a **52-seat** bus plying a **30 km** (one-way) city route. It makes **3 round trips** daily for **26 days** a month at **70% capacity**. Monthly costs: - Standing: Insurance Rs. 6,000; Tax Rs. 4,000; Permit Rs. 2,000; Driver + conductor salary Rs. 40,000; Depreciation (time basis) Rs. 25,000; Garage Rs. 5,000. - Running: Diesel — bus does 4 km/litre, diesel Rs. 95/litre; Oil & sundries Rs. 3/km; Tyres Rs. 2/km. - Maintenance: Rs. 18,000. Compute total cost, cost per passenger-km, and the fare per passenger-km to earn **25% profit on total takings**.

Answer.

Distance/day = 30 km × 2 (both ways) × 3 round trips = 180 km. Monthly km = 180 × 26 = **4,680 km**.

Diesel = 4,680 ÷ 4 = 1,170 litres × 95 = Rs. 1,11,150. Oil & sundries = 4,680 × 3 = Rs. 14,040. Tyres = 4,680 × 2 = Rs. 9,360.

Head	Rs.
A. Standing	
Insurance	6,000
Tax	4,000
Permit	2,000
Driver + conductor	40,000
Depreciation (time)	25,000
Garage	5,000
Sub-total A	**82,000**
B. Running	
Diesel	1,11,150
Oil & sundries	14,040
Tyres	9,360
Sub-total B	**1,34,550**
C. Maintenance	18,000
Total operating cost	**2,34,550**

Passenger-km = 52 × 70% × 4,680 = 36.4 × 4,680 = **1,70,352 passenger-km**. Cost per passenger-km = 2,34,550 ÷ 1,70,352 = **Rs. 1.3769 ≈ Rs. 1.38**. Profit 25% of takings ⇒ cost = 75%. Fare = 1.3769 ÷ 0.75 = **Rs. 1.8359 ≈ Rs. 1.84 per passenger-km**.

Check: Takings = 1.8359 × 1,70,352 = Rs. 3,12,733; profit = 3,12,733 − 2,34,550 = Rs. 78,183 = 25% of takings. ✓

C2. Absolute vs commercial tonne-km (unequal legs) — the discriminating question

A truck's daily schedule: Delhi→A 40 km carrying 12 t; A→B 30 km carrying 9 t; B→Delhi 50 km carrying 6 t. Compute both **absolute** and **commercial** tonne-km for one day and comment.

Answer. Total distance = 40 + 30 + 50 = 120 km.

Absolute tonne-km = (12×40) + (9×30) + (6×50) = 480 + 270 + 300 = **1,050 tonne-km**.

Commercial tonne-km = Average load × total distance. Average load = (12 + 9 + 6) ÷ 3 = 9 t ⇒ 9 × 120 = **1,080 tonne-km**.

Comment: The two differ (1,050 vs 1,080) because legs have **unequal distances** — the simple average over-weights the long, lightly-loaded final leg. Absolute tonne-km is the accurate measure; commercial is a quick approximation. When legs are equal, both coincide (see B4).

C3. Theory — Distinguish service costing from job and process costing; give sectors where it applies.

Answer. - **Vs job costing:** Job costing collects cost per identifiable, distinct job/order with tangible output and closing WIP; service costing has continuous, homogeneous, **intangible** output measured by a composite unit with **no inventory**. - **Vs process costing:** Both handle continuous homogeneous output and use average cost per unit, but process costing values physical, storable output with WIP and normal/abnormal loss; service costing has **non-storable** output, no loss/WIP concept, and a **composite** cost unit. - **Sectors:** Transport (bus, truck, taxi, airline, shipping — passenger-km/tonne-km), utilities (power — kWh; water — kilolitre), hospitality (hotel — room-day), healthcare (hospital — patient-day), education (college — student-hour), canteen (per meal), IT/BPO (per seat-hour), toll roads (per vehicle-km). It aligns with **CAS-4/general CAS** principles for cost determination in the service sector.

SECTION D — MCQs & Case Scenarios

D1. The most appropriate cost unit for a goods-transport company is: (a) Per km (b) Per tonne (c) **Tonne-kilometre** (d) Per trip **Answer: (c).** Value depends on both weight carried and distance — a composite unit is required.

D2. Depreciation charged at "Rs. 5 per km run" is classified as a: (a) **Running charge** (b) Standing charge (c) Maintenance charge (d) Notional cost **Answer: (a).** Charged on usage (km) basis, so it varies with running ⇒ running charge.

D3. Absolute tonne-km equals commercial tonne-km when: (a) Load is constant (b) **Distance of each leg is equal** (c) Truck returns empty (d) Never **Answer: (b).** With equal leg distances the weighted and average-load computations coincide.

D4. A hospital's suitable cost unit is: (a) Per doctor (b) Per bed (c) **Per patient-day** (d) Per medicine **Answer: (c).** Captures both number of patients and length of stay.

D5. In service costing there is normally **no**: (a) Fixed cost (b) **Closing work-in-progress / finished-goods inventory** (c) Variable cost (d) Cost unit **Answer: (b).** Output is intangible and non-storable, so nothing is inventoried.

D6 (Case). A bus (50 seats) runs 100 km round trips, 2 trips/day, 25 days, at 60% occupancy. Passenger-km for the month are: (a) 1,50,000 (b) **1,50,000** — verify: 50 × 60% × (100×2 trips = 200 km/day) × 25 = 30 × 200 × 25 = 1,50,000. **Answer: 1,50,000 passenger-km.** Reasoning: seats × occupancy × km/day × days; only occupied seats earn passenger-km.

D7 (Case). A truck runs 6,000 km in a month (return leg empty, so half the km are loaded at 10 t). Total cost Rs. 1,20,000. Cost per tonne-km is: Loaded km = 3,000; tonne-km = 3,000 × 10 = 30,000. Cost = 1,20,000 ÷ 30,000 = **Rs. 4.00**. **Answer: Rs. 4.00 per tonne-km.** Reasoning: empty return earns no tonne-km, so only loaded km count.

D8 (Case). If standing charges are Rs. 50,000/month and the truck is idle 10 of 30 days running 200 km on each active day, the standing charge recovered per km is: Km run = 20 days × 200 = 4,000 km ⇒ 50,000 ÷ 4,000 = **Rs. 12.50/km**. **Answer: Rs. 12.50 per km.** Reasoning: standing charges accrue for all days but are spread only over km actually run.

Examiner-Trap Checklist (memorise before the exam)

1. **Empty return legs earn zero tonne-km** — never multiply total distance by full load.
2. **Depreciation basis** (time vs km) decides standing vs running classification.
3. **Idle days** still incur standing charges; recover them over km actually run.
4. **Occupancy %** must be applied to seats for passenger-km.
5. **Both-ways distance** — read whether "trip" is one-way or round.
6. **Profit on cost vs profit on takings/fare** — divide by (1+r) or (1−r) accordingly.
7. **Absolute vs commercial tonne-km** diverge only when leg distances differ.
8. **Per-annum vs per-month** data — keep the time base consistent throughout.
9. Interest/notional costs — include only if the question says so.
10. Tyres/oil are usually **per-km (running)**, not fixed.
11. Show the **operating cost statement in three heads** (standing, running, maintenance) for full marks.

Chapter 13 — Standard Costing & Variance Analysis

1. The Problem: A Number That Tells You Nothing

Imagine you run a factory that makes steel almirahs. At month-end your cost sheet says: *actual cost of production = ₹47,80,000*. Your boss asks one question: **"Is that good or bad?"**

You cannot answer. ₹47,80,000 is a naked fact. Good compared to *what*? Maybe steel prices spiked. Maybe your workers were slow. Maybe you simply made more almirahs than planned, so of course the total is higher. The single number hides five different stories, and each story demands a *different manager to fix it* — the purchase officer for prices, the shop-floor supervisor for worker speed, the production planner for volume.

This is the central failure of ordinary costing: **it records what happened but cannot say what should have happened, so it cannot locate responsibility.** A cost that is merely *recorded* is a post-mortem. A cost that is *controlled* must be caught, diagnosed, and pinned on a cause while there is still time to act.

So the real problem is not "what did it cost?" It is:

> Given that actual cost differs from what we expected, **by how much, because of which cause, and whose desk does the correction land on?**

Standard costing is the answer. It sets a *pre-determined "should be" cost* for every unit, then compares actual to that standard, and — crucially — **splits the total gap into named pieces**, each piece traceable to one decision, one department, one lever. That splitting is variance analysis.

Why "should have cost" beats "cost last month". A tempting alternative is to compare this month's actual against *last month's* actual — a trend line. But last month was itself uncontrolled; it may have baked in the same inefficiency. Comparing bad against bad tells you the inefficiency is *stable*, not that it is *acceptable*. A standard is an *engineered* target, independent of past sloppiness, so the gap it reveals is a gap against what is *achievable*, not merely against what happened to occur before. This is why standard costing is a tool of *control*, whereas historical comparison is merely a tool of *observation*.

Where standard costing fits — and where it does not. It shines in **repetitive, standardisable production**: engineering, chemicals, textiles, food processing — anywhere a unit is made the same way thousands of times so a meaningful "par" exists. It struggles in **job/contract work** where every unit differs (no stable standard), in **rapidly changing conditions** (standards go stale overnight), and in **highly creative or R&D work** (output is not repeatable). The exam sometimes tests this judgement directly: "*State two situations where standard costing is unsuitable.*"

2. The Core Idea: A Budget Per Unit, Then Control by Exception

Two analogies carry the whole chapter.

Analogy 1 — The par score in golf. A golf hole has a *par* (say, 4 strokes). Par is not what an average hacker scores; it is what a competent player *should* score under normal conditions. When you take 6 strokes, you are "2 over par". Nobody records "6 strokes" in isolation — they record it *against par*, because par converts a raw number into a judgement. A **standard cost is the par of a product**: the carefully engineered cost a unit *should* incur under efficient, normal operating conditions.

Analogy 2 — Control by exception, like a car dashboard. Your car has dozens of systems, but you don't monitor each continuously. You watch the dashboard, and only when a warning light glows do you investigate *that* system. Variance analysis is management's dashboard. When actual equals standard, the light is off — ignore it. When a variance is large, the light glows red — investigate *that specific variance*, not the whole factory. This is **management by exception**: attention flows only to the deviations, and the *decomposition of variances tells you which warning light lit up.*

Put together: standard costing sets par per unit; variance analysis reads the dashboard and names the exception.

Not every glowing light deserves a trip to the mechanic. Management by exception has a second edge students forget: *materiality*. A ₹200 adverse variance on a ₹40 lakh cost base is noise — chasing it costs more managerial time than it saves. Firms set an **investigation threshold** (say, variances above 5% of standard cost, or above a fixed rupee limit) below which the light is treated as "off" even when technically non-zero. The reasons a variance may not be worth investigating: (a) it is *small* (immaterial); (b) it is *random* (statistical noise around a stable process, not a controllable cause); (c) the *cost of investigation exceeds the benefit*; (d) it is *uncontrollable* (a market-wide price surge no manager could prevent). This is the difference between a *statistically significant* variance and a *managerially actionable* one — an exam-favourite discussion point.

Controllable vs uncontrollable variances. A variance is *controllable* if a specific manager could have influenced it (excess material usage from careless handling), and *uncontrollable* if it arose from factors outside anyone's authority (a nationwide steel price hike, a government wage award). The whole responsibility-accounting purpose of the chapter collapses if you pin an uncontrollable variance on a manager: you demotivate without improving anything. Examiners test this by asking you to *classify* a listed set of variances as controllable or not, and to name the responsible manager.

3. Why It's Built This Way: The Logic of Decomposition

Why not just report one total cost variance? Because a total is a *sum of causes that pull in opposite directions and belong to different people*. Consider labour cost. It can differ from standard for two independent reasons:

1. You **paid a different wage rate** than planned (a purchasing/HR decision — you hired costlier workers, or a wage award increased rates).
2. Your workers **took a different number of hours** than the job should need (a shop-floor efficiency matter — supervision, machine condition, worker skill).

A single "labour cost variance" of ₹20,000 adverse could be +₹50,000 from paying too much and −₹30,000 saved from working fast, netting to ₹20,000. Report only the ₹20,000 and you have *hidden a serious rate problem behind an efficiency success*. The two must be separated because **they have different causes, different owners, and different corrective actions.**

The universal engine behind every variance is one idea:

> **Change one thing at a time.** To isolate the price effect, hold quantity constant and vary only price. To isolate the quantity effect, hold price constant (at standard) and vary only quantity.

Every formula in this chapter is that single principle applied to a different input. Once you *see* it, you never memorise a formula again — you *reconstruct* it. The general shapes are:

- **Price/Rate/Expenditure variance** = (Standard price − Actual price) × Actual quantity → "*we bought/paid at a wrong price for what we actually used.*" Quantity held at actual.
- **Usage/Efficiency/Quantity variance** = (Standard quantity for actual output − Actual quantity) × Standard price → "*we used a wrong amount, valued at the honest standard price so the price story doesn't leak in.*" Price held at standard.

Notice the asymmetry that trips up thousands of students: the **price variance uses *actual* quantity**, but the **usage variance uses *standard* price**. This is deliberate. We value the usage variance at standard price precisely so that no part of the price problem contaminates the efficiency measure — the shop-floor supervisor is judged on hours, not on wage rates he doesn't set.

The joint variance — the deeper reason for the asymmetry. When *both* price and quantity change, the total gap actually contains three pieces, not two: a pure price effect, a pure quantity effect, and a *joint* effect (the price change acting on the quantity change). Algebraically, the joint bit = (SP − AP) × (SQ − AQ). Two-way variance analysis must park this joint slice somewhere, and the ICAI convention **absorbs it into the price variance** — which is exactly why the price variance is computed on *actual* quantity (AQ = SQ + the quantity deviation) rather than standard quantity. Some textbooks report a separate three-variance breakdown, but the ICAI two-variance method is standard for the exam. Knowing *where the joint variance hides* is what lets you answer "why actual quantity in the price formula and not standard?" with understanding, not recitation.

The general "three-column" skeleton

Almost every cost variance in this chapter is one instance of a single three-column layout. Build these three figures and *every* variance is a difference between two adjacent columns:

Column	What it is	Fixes what
① **Standard for actual output**	SQ × SP (or SH × SR)	nothing fixed — the pure target
② **Actual quantity at standard price**	AQ × SP (or AH × SR)	price fixed at standard, quantity actual
③ **Actual**	AQ × AP (or AH × AR)	both actual

Then: **Usage/Efficiency = ① − ②** (price held at standard, quantity varies) and **Price/Rate = ② − ③** (quantity held at actual, price varies), and **Cost = ① − ③** (the whole gap). Master this one skeleton and you can reconstruct material, labour and variable-overhead variances without a single memorised formula.

The sign convention (learn this once, apply everywhere)

For **cost** variances: `Standard − Actual`. - Positive result = **Favourable (F)** → actual cost was *below* standard, good. - Negative result = **Adverse (A)** → actual cost *exceeded* standard, bad.

For **sales/profit** variances the logic flips because more is better: `Actual − Budget` for the value, and favourable means actual *exceeds* budget.

If you always write the standard/budget figure first and subtract the actual, and then read "positive = F for costs, remember to flip for sales," you never lose a sign.

Why the sign flips for sales — first principles. A cost and a revenue are opposite-signed contributions to profit. For a *cost*, "actual below standard" *raises* profit → favourable, so favourable = standard − actual > 0. For a *sale*, "actual above budget" *raises* profit → favourable, so favourable = actual − budget > 0. The single unifying rule underneath both is: **a variance is Favourable when it increases profit, Adverse when it decreases profit.** If you ever forget which subtraction to write, ask "does this movement make the firm richer?" — that never fails, even on an exotic variance you have never seen.

4. Full Technical Content: Setting Standards and the Complete Variance Tree

4.1 What a standard cost is, and how it is set

A **standard cost** is a pre-determined cost per unit of output, built up element by element from two things: a **physical standard** (how much input a unit *should* consume — kg, hours) and a **price standard** (what each unit of input *should* cost — ₹/kg, ₹/hour). Their product is the standard cost of that element.

Standards are set by the **standard costing committee** (production engineer, purchase manager, cost accountant, personnel manager) using:

- **Material quantity standards** — from the bill of materials and engineering studies, *including a normal allowance for unavoidable scrap/wastage*.
- **Material price standards** — from the purchase manager's forecast of prices over the standard period, net of trade discounts.
- **Labour time standards** — from time-and-motion study, including normal idle/rest allowances.
- **Wage rate standards** — from HR/wage agreements.
- **Overhead standards** — budgeted overheads divided by a budgeted activity base (standard hours or units).

Types of standard (matters for interpretation):

Type	Basis	Problem
Ideal standard	Perfect conditions, no wastage, no breakdown	Unattainable; demotivating; always adverse
Basic standard	Fixed long-term, unchanged for years	Goes stale; useless for current control
Current standard	Present conditions, short period	Reflects inefficiencies as "normal"
Normal (Expected) standard	Attainable under normal efficient conditions	**The preferred, realistic benchmark**

The **normal/attainable standard** is what ICAI problems assume unless told otherwise: tight enough to motivate, loose enough to be reachable.

Why the choice of standard is a behavioural decision, not just an accounting one. An *ideal* standard is always missed, so every report is adverse — workers stop believing the number and tune it out (the "cry wolf" effect). A *loose* current standard flatters everyone and hides real slack. The *attainable* standard sits in the motivational sweet spot: hard enough that hitting it means something, soft enough that hitting it is possible, so the variance carries *information* rather than *noise or flattery*. This is why the choice of standard is examined as a management-accounting judgement, not merely a formula input.

The "standard hour" — the unit that makes everything comparable. A *standard hour* is not sixty minutes; it is **the quantity of output that should be produced in one hour**. It is a measure of *output expressed in time*. Its power: a factory making three dissimilar products (chairs, tables, stools) cannot add "40 chairs + 30 tables" meaningfully, but it *can* add the standard hours each represents, giving one common yardstick of activity. Every overhead and efficiency variance leans on this idea — "standard hours for actual output" is literally actual output re-expressed as the time it *should* have taken. Get comfortable with it, because SH is the pivot of half the chapter.

Revision of standards. Standards are revised when there is a *permanent* change — a new wage agreement, a redesigned product, a lasting change in material prices or method. They are **not** revised for *temporary* fluctuations (a one-off price spike), because a standard that chases every wobble stops being a stable benchmark. The exam contrast: a temporary deviation produces a *variance* (to be investigated); a permanent change justifies *revising the standard itself*.

Standard costing vs budgetary control: a budget is a *total* plan for a *department/period* (₹ for the whole factory); a standard is a *per-unit* cost. Budgets are extensive (aggregate totals); standards are intensive (per unit). They are complementary — the standard cost card feeds the flexible budget. A further distinction examiners like: budgetary control can operate for *any* function (finance, admin, sales — even where no physical unit exists), whereas standard costing needs a *measurable, repetitive unit of output*. So budgetary control is *broader in scope*; standard costing is *deeper in analysis*.

4.2 The variance tree — the map of the whole chapter

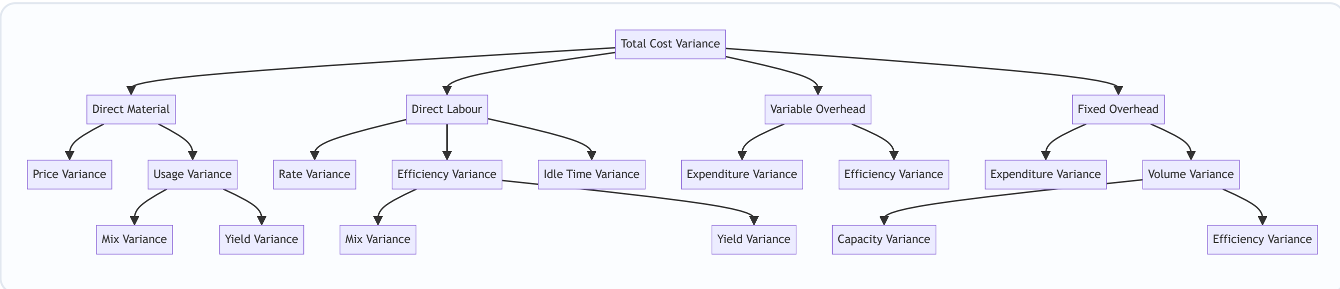


Figure 13.1 — The full cost-variance tree. Every parent equals the sum of its children; this "adding up" is your self-check.

The unbreakable rule of the tree: **at every node, the children reconcile to the parent.** Price + Usage = Cost. Mix + Yield = Usage. Capacity + Efficiency = Volume. If they don't add up, you have an arithmetic error — the tree is your built-in proof.

A map to the same idea seen a second way — the three-column skeleton (§3) sitting behind each element:

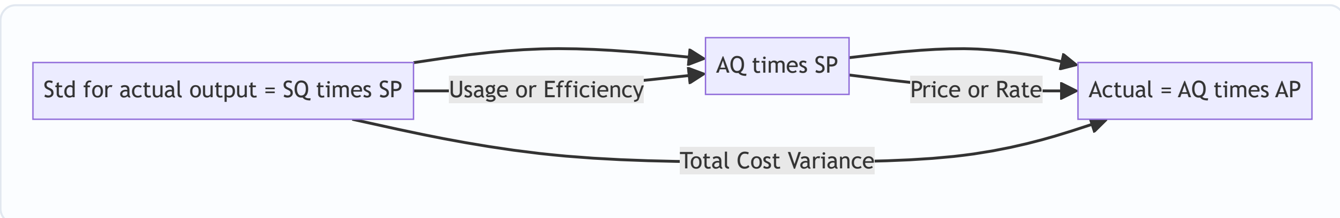


Figure 13.2 — One skeleton, every element. The left gap is the quantity story, the right gap is the price story, the whole span is the cost variance.

4.3 Direct Material Variances

Let `SQ` = standard quantity **for actual output** (not budgeted output!), `AQ` = actual quantity used, `SP` = standard price, `AP` = actual price. `AI` = actual quantity purchased/input.

- **Material Cost Variance (MCV)** = (SQ × SP) − (AQ × AP) *Meaning:* total gap between what the actual output should have cost in materials and what it did cost. The parent.
- **Material Price Variance (MPV)** = (SP − AP) × AQ *Meaning:* the cost of buying at the wrong price, for the quantity actually used. Owner: **purchase manager.** (Some texts compute on quantity *purchased* AI when price variance is isolated at purchase point; ICAI default uses AQ unless purchase and usage quantities differ and the question specifies.)
- **Material Usage (Quantity) Variance (MUV)** = (SQ − AQ) × SP *Meaning:* the cost of using the wrong amount of material, valued at the honest standard price. Owner: **production/shop floor.**

Check: MPV + MUV = MCV.

When there are **several materials mixed together** (e.g., a chemical batch), the usage variance splits again:

- **Material Mix Variance (MMV)** = (Revised Standard Quantity − Actual Quantity) × SP where **Revised Standard Quantity (RSQ)** = total actual input re-apportioned in the *standard mix ratio*. *Meaning:* the cost effect of using inputs in the wrong *proportion* (using more of the cheap material and less of the dear one, or vice versa). Owner: whoever controls the recipe/blend.
- **Material Yield (Sub-usage) Variance (MYV)** = (SQ − RSQ) × SP *Meaning:* the cost effect of the total mix producing more or less output than standard — i.e., getting a different *yield* from the same total input. Also expressible as (Actual Yield − Standard Yield from actual input) × Standard cost per unit of output.

Check: MMV + MYV = MUV.

Why RSQ is the pivot: it is the bridge figure that holds *total quantity at actual* but *proportion at standard*. Mix compares actual-proportion vs standard-proportion at the same total (RSQ vs AQ). Yield compares standard-for-output vs standard-proportion-of-actual-total (SQ vs RSQ). One variable changes per step — the golden rule again.

The purchase-point vs usage-point distinction (finer than most students realise). There are two philosophies for the price variance:

1. **Price variance at time of purchase** — compute MPV on the quantity *purchased* (AI), so the entire price variance is recognised when material enters stores, and inventory is then carried at *standard* price. Advantage: prices are flagged early, and stock records stay clean at standard. This means purchases and usage quantities can differ (you may buy 6,000 kg but use 5,720 kg), and **MPV then uses 6,000 while MUV uses 5,720** — they no longer share a base, and MPV + MUV ≠ MCV exactly (the difference sits in the closing-stock valuation).
2. **Price variance at time of usage** — compute MPV on quantity *used* (AQ); purchases and usage tie, and MPV + MUV = MCV cleanly. This is the ICAI default when the question does not separate purchase and usage.

Read the wording: the phrase "material *purchased*... material *consumed*" with two different quantities is the examiner signalling the purchase-point method.

4.4 Direct Labour Variances

Let `SH` = standard hours **for actual output**, `AH` = actual hours *paid*, `AH_worked` = actual hours *worked* (paid minus idle), `SR` = standard rate, `AR` = actual rate.

- **Labour Cost Variance (LCV)** = (SH × SR) − (AH_paid × AR) *Meaning:* total labour cost gap for actual output.

- **Labour Rate Variance (LRV)** = (SR − AR) × AH_paid *Meaning:* cost of paying a wrong wage rate. Owner: **HR/personnel.** Computed on hours *paid* because you pay for every paid hour regardless of idleness.
- **Labour Efficiency Variance (LEV)** = (SH − AH_worked) × SR *Meaning:* cost of workers taking wrong number of *productive* hours. Owner: **production supervisor.** Uses hours *worked* so idle time doesn't distort efficiency.
- **Idle Time Variance (ITV)** = Idle Hours × SR = (AH_paid − AH_worked) × SR — **always Adverse** (idle time is paid-for, never productive; you can't "gain" from it). *Meaning:* cost of paying for hours during which nobody produced (power cut, machine breakdown, material shortage).

Check: LRV + LEV + ITV = LCV. (If the question gives no idle time, AH_paid = AH_worked and ITV = 0, collapsing to LRV + LEV = LCV.)

When several **grades of labour** work together, efficiency splits (exactly parallel to materials):

- **Labour Mix (Gang) Variance (LMV)** = (Revised Standard Hours − Actual Hours worked) × SR
- **Labour Yield (Sub-efficiency) Variance (LYV)** = (SH − Revised Standard Hours) × SR

Check: LMV + LYV = LEV.

A subtlety in the gang: mix uses hours *worked*, not paid. When idle time and a multi-grade gang appear *together*, the mix and yield variances are built from hours *worked* (RSH is actual *worked* hours in standard grade ratio), because idle time is quarantined into its own variance first. A common exam trap is to feed *paid* hours into the mix calculation and double-count the idle loss. Sequence: strip idle → then split worked hours into mix and yield.

Two idle-time conventions — read the question. (a) *Idle time included in the standard* (a normal, expected allowance): then the standard rate already assumes some idle time, and only *abnormal* idle time above the norm is separated. (b) *Idle time not in the standard* (the usual exam case): all idle time becomes an adverse Idle Time Variance. ICAI problems almost always mean (b) and label idle time as abnormal, but the phrase "normal idle time is X%" is your cue that (a) applies and the standard hours must already embed it.

Why the labour efficiency and material usage variances are cousins, not twins. Both measure "wrong quantity at standard price". But labour has an extra wrinkle materials lack: *idle time* — you pay for labour hours whether or not they produce, whereas you do not pay for material you never used. That asymmetry is exactly why labour has a third child (idle time) and materials do not. Seeing *why* the trees differ in shape stops you from mechanically hunting for a "material idle variance" that does not exist.

4.5 Variable Overhead Variances

Variable OH varies with activity, so it is treated like a "labour-hour-driven" cost. Let `SR_v` = standard variable OH rate per hour, `AH` = actual hours, `SH` = standard hours for actual output, `Actual VOH` = actual variable overhead incurred.

- **Variable OH Cost Variance** = (SH × SR_v) − Actual VOH
- **Variable OH Expenditure (Spending) Variance** = (AH × SR_v) − Actual VOH = (Standard variable OH for actual hours) − (Actual variable OH). *Meaning:* did each hour of activity cost more/less variable OH than budgeted? A *rate* effect.
- **Variable OH Efficiency Variance** = (SH − AH) × SR_v *Meaning:* because variable OH is absorbed per hour, working faster/slower than standard changes VOH absorbed. Mirror of labour efficiency.

Check: Expenditure + Efficiency = VOH Cost Variance.

Which "AH" for variable overhead — worked or paid? Variable overhead is consumed only while machines/people are *actively working*, so the VOH efficiency variance uses hours *worked* (like labour efficiency). During idle time no variable overhead is incurred, so idle hours drop out. If a question gives idle time, use `AH_worked` in both the expenditure and efficiency formulas above. (Where there is no idle time, worked = paid and the distinction vanishes — which is why the base formula just says AH.) The deep reason: variable overhead is *activity-driven*; idle time is *absence* of activity.

4.6 Fixed Overhead Variances — the subtle one

Fixed OH is a *fixed lump* in reality, but standard costing *absorbs* it per unit at a pre-determined rate. This clash — fixed in fact, unitised in absorption — creates the richest variance family. Definitions:

- **Standard Fixed OH Rate per unit (FOR)** = Budgeted Fixed OH ÷ Budgeted Output. (Or per hour = Budgeted Fixed OH ÷ Budgeted Hours.)
- `Absorbed FOH` = Actual output × FOR (= Standard hours for actual output × rate per hour).
- `Budgeted FOH` = the original fixed OH budget.
- `Actual FOH` = fixed OH actually incurred.

Variances:

- **Fixed OH Cost Variance** = Absorbed FOH − Actual FOH *Meaning:* total over/under-absorption of fixed overhead.
- **Fixed OH Expenditure (Budget) Variance** = Budgeted FOH − Actual FOH *Meaning:* did we *spend* more or less fixed overhead than budgeted? Pure spending. Owner: whoever authorises the fixed spend.
- **Fixed OH Volume Variance** = Absorbed FOH − Budgeted FOH *Meaning:* because fixed cost per unit assumes a planned volume, producing more/less than planned over- or under-recovers the fixed lump. Producing *above* budget volume = Favourable (fixed cost spread over more units). This is *not* a spending issue — it is a *capacity utilisation* issue.

Check: Expenditure + Volume = FOH Cost Variance.

Volume splits further:

- **Fixed OH Capacity Variance** = (Actual hours worked − Budgeted hours) × FOR per hour *Meaning:* did we run the plant for more/fewer hours than budgeted? Owner: capacity/planning. (Some ICAI problems use "revised budgeted hours" adjusting for the number of days actually worked — see Calendar variance.)
- **Fixed OH Efficiency Variance** = (Standard hours for actual output − Actual hours worked) × FOR per hour *Meaning:* even at given capacity, working efficiently produces more standard-hours of output, recovering more fixed OH.
- **Fixed OH Calendar Variance** = (Actual working days − Budgeted working days) × Budgeted FOH per day (used only when actual days differ from budget).

Check: Capacity + Efficiency (+ Calendar) = Volume.

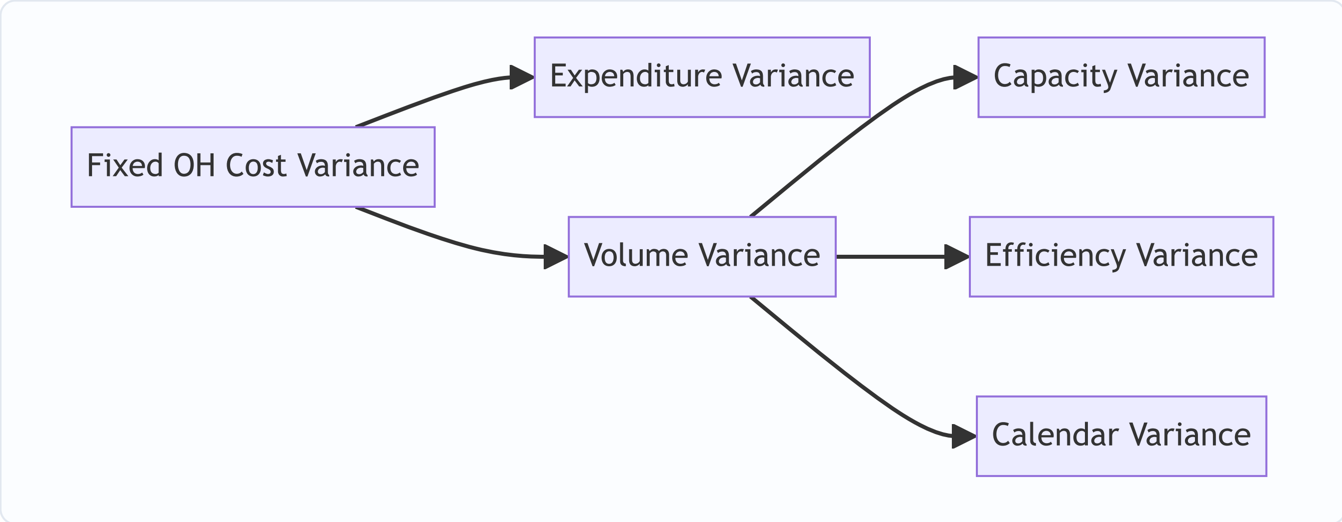


Figure 13.3 — Fixed overhead splits by a different logic than variable: spending vs volume, then volume by capacity, efficiency and calendar.

Why fixed overhead alone breeds a volume variance — the deepest "why" in the chapter. Material, labour and variable overhead all *flex* with output: make more, they cost proportionally more, and there is nothing to "over- or under-recover". Fixed overhead is different — the rent is ₹3,00,000 whether you make 4,000 units or 6,000. But absorption costing *pretends* it is variable by charging a flat FOR per unit. That pretence works only if you actually make the budgeted volume. Make fewer units and you have absorbed less than the lump you must still pay → *under-recovery* → adverse volume variance. The volume variance is literally **the accounting error created by forcing a fixed cost through a per-unit rate.** No fixed cost, no volume variance — which is exactly why marginal costing (which never absorbs fixed cost into units) has *no* volume variance at all.

The three utilisation ratios (examiners love these alongside FOH variances). Because volume variance is about *how much of budgeted capacity you actually converted into output*, ICAI often pairs it with three ratios, all built from standard hours:

- **Capacity Ratio** = (Actual hours worked ÷ Budgeted hours) × 100 → did we operate the plant for as many hours as planned?
- **Efficiency Ratio** = (Standard hours for actual output ÷ Actual hours worked) × 100 → within the hours run, did we produce at standard pace?
- **Activity (Volume) Ratio** = (Standard hours for actual output ÷ Budgeted hours) × 100 → overall, did output reach the planned level? Note **Activity Ratio = Capacity Ratio × Efficiency Ratio** (as fractions), mirroring Volume = Capacity + Efficiency in the variances. A ratio above 100% is favourable; below 100% adverse. These ratios and the fixed-OH sub-variances are two languages for the same story.

Revised budgeted hours and the calendar variance — avoiding the double count. When the actual number of working days differs from budget, ICAI computes a *revised* budgeted capacity: Revised Budgeted Hours = Budgeted hours per day × *actual* days. The calendar variance captures the day-count effect [(actual − budgeted days) × budgeted FOH per day], and the capacity variance is then measured against the *revised* budgeted hours so the day effect is not counted twice. If you forget to revise, capacity and calendar overlap and the volume reconciliation fails. This is the single most error-prone corner of fixed-OH analysis.

4.7 Sales Variances — measuring the revenue/profit side

Cost variances explain why *cost* moved. Sales variances explain why *profit* moved because of selling activity. Two bases exist; ICAI favours the **profit (margin) method**, which is what reconciles budgeted to actual profit. Let `BQ` =budgeted qty, `AQ` =actual qty sold, `BP` =budgeted price, `AP` =actual price, `SM` =standard margin (profit) per unit, `AM` =actual margin per unit.

Sales Value method (turnover-based): - **Sales Value Variance** = (AQ × AP) − (BQ × BP) - **Sales Price Variance** = (AP − BP) × AQ - **Sales Volume Variance** = (AQ − BQ) × BP

Sales Margin (Profit) method — reconciles profit: - **Total Sales Margin Variance** = (AQ × AM) − (BQ × SM) - **Sales Margin Price Variance** = (AM − SM) × AQ = (AP − BP) × AQ *(cost is held at standard, so margin change equals price change)* - **Sales Margin Volume Variance** = (AQ − BQ) × SM

Volume splits (for multi-product sales), using **RBQ** = Revised Budgeted Quantity = total actual units in budgeted mix ratio:

- **Sales Margin Mix Variance** = (AQ − RBQ) × SM *(sold a different product mix than budgeted)*
- **Sales Margin Quantity (Sub-volume) Variance** = (RBQ − BQ) × SM *(sold a different total quantity)*

Check: Mix + Quantity = Volume; Price + Volume = Total Sales Margin Variance.

Absorption vs marginal margin — a live exam distinction. The "standard margin per unit" (SM) can be defined two ways depending on the costing system: under **absorption costing** SM = selling price − *total* standard cost (including absorbed fixed OH); under **marginal costing** SM = *contribution* per unit = selling price − *variable* cost. The volume variance therefore differs numerically between systems — under marginal costing the sales volume variance is valued at **standard contribution**, which is generally the more decision-relevant figure because selling one more unit adds contribution, not the arbitrary fixed-cost slice. The exam expects you to use whichever the question specifies, and to know *why* the marginal version is preferred for decision-making.

Why the margin price variance equals the value price variance. Selling price rose by ₹5; standard cost is held constant (it is a *sales* variance, not a cost one); therefore the whole ₹5 drops straight to margin. That is why (AM − SM) = (AP − BP), and the two methods agree on the *price* variance while differing on the *volume* variance (valued at BP under value, at SM/contribution under margin). Understanding this keeps you from computing the price variance twice by two "different" formulas.

4.8 The reconciliation statement — the point of it all

The final deliverable is a bridge from **Budgeted Profit** to **Actual Profit**, threading every variance:

> Budgeted Profit ± Sales Margin variances (price, mix, quantity) = Standard profit on actual sales... then ± all Cost variances (material, labour, VOH, FOH) = **Actual Profit**

If it lands exactly on actual profit, every variance is correct. This is why examiners love it: it self-checks the entire answer.

Absorption-costing reconciliation vs marginal-costing reconciliation. Under **absorption costing** the bridge threads *all* fixed-OH variances (expenditure *and* volume). Under **marginal costing** the fixed-overhead *volume* variance does not exist, so the bridge instead runs from budgeted *contribution* → actual contribution via sales and variable-cost variances, then subtracts the fixed-OH *expenditure* variance (budgeted vs actual fixed cost) to reach actual profit. If a reconciliation refuses to tie, the first thing to check is whether you have mixed a marginal-costing sales volume variance (valued at contribution) with an absorption-costing set of cost variances — a classic self-inflicted mismatch.

5. Worked Examples

Example 1 — Material and Labour, single input (foundational)

Data. SamCo makes one product. Standard cost per unit: material 5 kg @ ₹40/kg; labour 3 hours @ ₹50/hour. Budgeted output 1,000 units. **Actual:** 1,100 units produced; 5,720 kg of material used costing ₹2,37,380; 3,410 labour hours paid costing ₹1,74,910 (no idle time).

Step 1 — Set the "standard for actual output" (flex to 1,100 units). - SQ = 1,100 × 5 = **5,500 kg**; SP = ₹40 → standard material cost = 5,500 × 40 = ₹2,20,000. - SH = 1,100 × 3 = **3,300 hrs**; SR = ₹50 → standard labour cost = 3,300 × 50 = ₹1,65,000. - AP = 2,37,380 ÷ 5,720 = **₹41.50/kg**; AR = 1,74,910 ÷ 3,410 = **₹51.30/hr**.

Step 2 — Material variances.

Variance	Formula	Working	Result
Cost (MCV)	(SQ×SP) − (AQ×AP)	2,20,000 − 2,37,380	₹17,380 A
Price (MPV)	(SP − AP)×AQ	(40 − 41.50)×5,720	₹8,580 A
Usage (MUV)	(SQ − AQ)×SP	(5,500 − 5,720)×40	₹8,800 A

Check: 8,580 A + 8,800 A = 17,380 A = MCV. ✓

Step 3 — Labour variances (no idle time).

Variance	Formula	Working	Result
Cost (LCV)	(SH×SR) − (AH×AR)	1,65,000 − 1,74,910	₹9,910 A
Rate (LRV)	(SR − AR)×AH	(50 − 51.30)×3,410	₹4,433 A
Efficiency (LEV)	(SH − AH)×SR	(3,300 − 3,410)×50	₹5,500 A

Check: 4,433 A + 5,500 A = 9,933 A. Rounding in AR (51.30) causes a ₹23 gap; using exact AR = 1,74,910/3,410, LRV = 1,74,910 − 3,410×50 = 1,74,910 − 1,70,500 = ₹4,410 A, and 4,410 + 5,500 = 9,910 A = LCV. ✓ *(Lesson: compute rate variance as Actual cost − AH×SR to avoid rounding the actual rate.)*

Reading it: every variance is adverse. Material: paid ₹1.50/kg over and wasted 220 kg. Labour: overpaid ₹0.10-odd per hour and took 110 excess hours. Two managers, four distinct actions.

Examiner tweak — "material purchased 6,000 kg, used 5,720 kg; price variance at purchase point". Now the price variance is recognised on the *purchased* quantity: MPV = (SP − AP) × AI = (40 − 41.50) × 6,000 = **₹9,000 A** (AP is unchanged because the actual price per kg is the same on stock bought). The usage variance is unaffected (still ₹8,800 A on the 5,720 kg consumed). Notice MPV + MUV = 9,000 + 8,800 = 17,800 A, which no longer equals the ₹17,380 MCV computed on consumption — the ₹420 gap is the price variance sitting in the 280 kg of closing stock (280 × ₹1.50). *Lesson: under the purchase-point method the neat "Price + Usage = Cost" tie holds only on the quantity consumed; the rest is carried in inventory at standard.*

Example 2 — Full overheads with idle time (intermediate)

Data. Budget for the month: output 5,000 units; each unit takes 2 standard hours. Budgeted fixed OH ₹3,00,000; budgeted variable OH ₹1,50,000. **Actual:** 4,800 units produced; 10,200 hours paid, of which 300 hours idle (power failure); actual fixed OH ₹3,05,000; actual variable OH ₹1,58,000. Budgeted and actual working days both 25 (no calendar variance).

Step 1 — Rates and standards. - Budgeted hours = 5,000 × 2 = 10,000 hrs. - Standard VOH rate = 1,50,000 ÷ 10,000 = **₹15/hr**. Standard FOH rate = 3,00,000 ÷ 10,000 = **₹30/hr** (= ₹60/unit). - Actual output 4,800 → **SH = 4,800 × 2 = 9,600 hrs**. - AH paid = 10,200; **AH worked = 10,200 − 300 = 9,900 hrs**. - Absorbed FOH = 9,600 × 30 = ₹2,88,000. Budgeted FOH = ₹3,00,000.

Step 2 — Variable OH.

Variance	Formula	Working	Result
VOH Cost	SH×SR_v − Actual	9,600×15 − 1,58,000 = 1,44,000 − 1,58,000	₹14,000 A
VOH Expenditure	AH_worked×SR_v − Actual	9,900×15 − 1,58,000 = 1,48,500 − 1,58,000	₹9,500 A
VOH Efficiency	(SH − AH_worked)×SR_v	(9,600 − 9,900)×15	₹4,500 A

Check: 9,500 A + 4,500 A = 14,000 A = VOH Cost. ✓ *(VOH efficiency uses hours worked; idle hours consume no variable overhead.)*

Step 3 — Fixed OH.

Variance	Formula	Working	Result
FOH Cost	Absorbed − Actual	2,88,000 − 3,05,000	₹17,000 A
FOH Expenditure	Budgeted − Actual	3,00,000 − 3,05,000	₹5,000 A
FOH Volume	Absorbed − Budgeted	2,88,000 − 3,00,000	₹12,000 A
FOH Capacity	(AH_worked − Budgeted hrs)×FOR	(9,900 − 10,000)×30	₹3,000 A
FOH Efficiency	(SH − AH_worked)×FOR	(9,600 − 9,900)×30	₹9,000 A

Checks: Expenditure 5,000 A + Volume 12,000 A = 17,000 A = FOH Cost. ✓ Capacity 3,000 A + Efficiency 9,000 A = 12,000 A = Volume. ✓ *(We ran 100 hours short of budgeted capacity — that's the capacity loss — and within the hours we ran, we were inefficient by 300 hours — that's the efficiency loss. Volume shortfall is the sum.)*

Step 4 — Labour idle-time slice (illustration). If SR = ₹50: Idle Time Variance = 300 × 50 = **₹15,000 A**, always adverse, quarantined from efficiency. This ensures the power-failure cost lands on facilities, not on the workers' efficiency record.

Step 5 — Control ratios cross-check. Capacity Ratio = 9,900 ÷ 10,000 = **99%**; Efficiency Ratio = 9,600 ÷ 9,900 = **96.97%**; Activity Ratio = 9,600 ÷ 10,000 = **96%**. Confirm: 99% × 96.97% ≈ 96% = Activity Ratio ✓, matching Capacity + Efficiency = Volume. All below 100%, i.e. all adverse — the same verdict as the rupee variances, in ratio language.

Examiner tweak — calendar variance. Suppose budget assumed 25 working days but a public-holiday cut actuals to 24 days, budgeted FOH per day = 3,00,000 ÷ 25 = ₹12,000. Then Calendar Variance = (24 − 25) ×

12,000 = **₹12,000 A**, and Revised Budgeted Hours = (10,000 ÷ 25) × 24 = 9,600 hrs, so Capacity Variance is re-measured as (AH_worked − Revised budgeted hrs) × FOR = (9,900 − 9,600) × 30 = **₹9,000 F**. Now Capacity 9,000 F + Efficiency 9,000 A + Calendar 12,000 A = **12,000 A = Volume** ✓ — the same volume total, re-attributed: the lost day (calendar) is separated from how hard we ran the *available* days (capacity).

Example 3 — Multi-material mix & yield with full reconciliation (exam-hard)

Data. A chemical "Zenol" is made by mixing three materials. Standard mix for 100 kg of output:

Material	Std qty (kg)	Std price ₹/kg	Std cost ₹
A	50	20	1,000
B	30	30	900
C	40	10	400
Input total	**120**		**2,300**
Less: normal loss 20%	(20)		
Output	**100**		**2,300**

Standard cost per kg of output = 2,300 ÷ 100 = ₹23.

Actual (one batch): Output 4,750 kg of Zenol. Materials consumed:

Material	Actual qty (kg)	Actual price ₹/kg	Actual cost ₹
A	2,900	21	60,900
B	1,600	28	44,800
C	1,300	12	15,600
Total input	**5,800**		**1,21,300**

Step 1 — Standard quantity for actual output (SQ). For 4,750 kg output at standard input ratio (120 kg input per 100 kg output): - Total std input = 4,750 × 120/100 = 5,700 kg, split 50:30:40 of 120. - SQ(A) = 5,700 × 50/120 = 2,375 kg; SQ(B) = 5,700 × 30/120 = 1,425 kg; SQ(C) = 5,700 × 40/120 = 1,900 kg.

Standard cost of actual output = 4,750 × 23 = **₹1,09,250** (cross-check: 2,375×20 + 1,425×30 + 1,900×10 = 47,500 + 42,750 + 19,000 = 1,09,250 ✓).

Step 2 — Revised Standard Quantity (RSQ) = actual total input (5,800) in standard ratio 50:30:40 (of 120): - RSQ(A) = 5,800 × 50/120 = 2,416.67 kg - RSQ(B) = 5,800 × 30/120 = 1,450.00 kg - RSQ(C) = 5,800 × 40/120 = 1,933.33 kg

Step 3 — Material Cost Variance = Std cost of output − Actual cost = 1,09,250 − 1,21,300 = **₹12,050 A**.

Step 4 — Price Variance = Σ(SP − AP)×AQ:

Material	(SP − AP)	×AQ	Result
A	(20 − 21) = −1	×2,900	2,900 A
B	(30 − 28) = +2	×1,600	3,200 F
C	(10 − 12) = −2	×1,300	2,600 A
MPV			**₹2,300 A**

Step 5 — Usage Variance = Σ(SQ − AQ)×SP:

Material	(SQ − AQ)	×SP	Result
A	(2,375 − 2,900) = −525	×20	10,500 A
B	(1,425 − 1,600) = −175	×30	5,250 A
C	(1,900 − 1,300) = +600	×10	6,000 F
MUV			**₹9,750 A**

Check: MPV 2,300 A + MUV 9,750 A = **12,050 A = MCV.** ✓

Step 6 — Mix Variance = Σ(RSQ − AQ)×SP:

Material	(RSQ − AQ)	×SP	Result
A	(2,416.67 − 2,900) = −483.33	×20	9,666.67 A
B	(1,450.00 − 1,600) = −150.00	×30	4,500.00 A
C	(1,933.33 − 1,300) = +633.33	×10	6,333.33 F
MMV			**₹7,833.33 A**

Step 7 — Yield Variance = Σ(SQ − RSQ)×SP:

Material	(SQ − RSQ)	×SP	Result
A	(2,375 − 2,416.67) = −41.67	×20	833.33 A
B	(1,425 − 1,450.00) = −25.00	×30	750.00 A
C	(1,900 − 1,933.33) = −33.33	×10	333.33 A
MYV			**₹1,916.67 A**

Check: MMV 7,833.33 A + MYV 1,916.67 A = **9,750 A = MUV.** ✓

Interpreting the story: The batch overspent ₹12,050. Of that, ₹2,300 was a *price* problem (paid more for A and C, partly rescued by cheaper B), and ₹9,750 was a *usage* problem. Digging into usage: ₹7,833 came from a *wrong blend* — we loaded far more of the expensive materials A and B and skimped on the cheap C, a costly mis-mix — while ₹1,917 came from a *poor yield* (5,800 kg of input yielded only 4,750 kg vs the standard 4,833 kg it should have yielded, i.e. 5,800×100/120). Two very different corrections: fix the recipe discipline (mix) and investigate process loss (yield).

Yield cross-check: standard output from 5,800 kg input = 5,800 × 100/120 = 4,833.33 kg; actual = 4,750 kg; shortfall 83.33 kg × ₹23 = **₹1,916.67 A** — matches MYV exactly. ✓

Examiner tweak — the "single weighted standard price" shortcut for yield. Instead of the material-by-material yield table, the yield variance can be got in one line: MYV = (Standard output from actual input − Actual output) × Standard cost per unit of output = (4,833.33 − 4,750) × 23 = 83.33 × 23 = **₹1,916.67 A**. This is faster under time pressure and is what the *cross-check* above uses — but it only works because *all three materials scale together in the yield step* (SQ − RSQ is the same proportion across materials). If asked to "show mix and yield material-wise", you still need the tables; if merely asked for the yield figure, the one-liner suffices. Knowing both saves minutes.

Example 4 — Sales margin variances and profit reconciliation (capstone)

Data. A firm budgets two products:

Product	Budget qty	Std profit/unit ₹	Budget profit ₹
X	600	40	24,000
Y	400	60	24,000
Total	**1,000**		**48,000**

Actual: X sold 700 units at a margin of ₹35/unit; Y sold 500 units at a margin of ₹58/unit.

Step 1 — Actuals. Actual profit = 700×35 + 500×58 = 24,500 + 29,000 = **₹53,500.**

Step 2 — RBQ (total actual 1,200 units in budget ratio 600:400 = 60:40): - RBQ(X) = 1,200 × 60/100 = 720; RBQ(Y) = 1,200 × 40/100 = 480.

Step 3 — Sales Margin Price Variance = (AM − SM)×AQ: - X: (35 − 40)×700 = 3,500 A; Y: (58 − 60)×500 = 1,000 A → **₹4,500 A.**

Step 4 — Sales Margin Volume Variance = (AQ − BQ)×SM: - X: (700 − 600)×40 = 4,000 F; Y: (500 − 400)×60 = 6,000 F → **₹10,000 F.**

Step 5 — split Volume into Mix and Quantity. - **Mix** = (AQ − RBQ)×SM: X (700−720)×40 = 800 A; Y (500−480)×60 = 1,200 F → **₹400 F.** - **Quantity** = (RBQ − BQ)×SM: X (720−600)×40 = 4,800 F; Y (480−400)×60 = 4,800 F → **₹9,600 F.**

Check: Mix 400 F + Quantity 9,600 F = **10,000 F = Volume.** ✓

Step 6 — Total Sales Margin Variance = Price 4,500 A + Volume 10,000 F = **₹5,500 F.** Cross-check: Actual profit 53,500 − Budget profit 48,000 = 5,500 F. ✓ *(Since only selling-side data given, cost variances are nil here.)*

Step 7 — Reconciliation Statement.

Item	₹	₹
Budgeted Profit		48,000
Sales Margin Price Variance	4,500 A	
Sales Margin Mix Variance	400 F	
Sales Margin Quantity Variance	9,600 F	+5,500
Actual Profit		**53,500**

Lands exactly on ₹53,500. The reconciliation *is* the proof.

Examiner tweak — sales *value* method on the same data. Suppose instead the question gives budgeted selling prices (X ₹200, Y ₹300) and actual prices (X ₹195, Y ₹296), asking for value-based variances. Sales Price Variance = (AP − BP)×AQ = (195−200)×700 + (296−300)×500 = 3,500 A + 2,000 A = **₹5,500 A**. Sales Volume Variance (at BP) = (700−600)×200 + (500−400)×300 = 20,000 F + 30,000 F = **₹50,000 F**. These *turnover* figures look nothing like the margin figures and — critically — **do not reconcile to profit**, because they ignore the cost of the extra units sold. Only the margin method threads into the profit reconciliation. The trap: a question that mixes value-based volume with a profit reconciliation will never tie; spot which method is demanded from the phrase "reconcile budgeted and actual *profit*" (→ margin method).

Example 5 — Labour gang with idle time, mix and yield (exam-hard)

Data. A job is standard-manned by a gang: 4 skilled @ ₹80/hr and 2 unskilled @ ₹50/hr, working a standard 40-hour week to produce 100 standard units. **Actual for one week:** the gang produced 108 units; hours *paid* — skilled 170, unskilled 90; of which 10 skilled hours and 5 unskilled hours were *idle* (machine breakdown). Actual wages: skilled ₹14,110, unskilled ₹4,680.

Step 1 — Standards. Standard gang hours per 100 units: skilled 4×40 = 160, unskilled 2×40 = 80, total 240 hrs → standard 2.4 gang-hours per unit. For 108 units: **SH(skilled) = 160×108/100 = 172.8; SH(unskilled) = 80×108/100 = 86.4** (total SH = 259.2). SR skilled ₹80, unskilled ₹50.

Step 2 — Hours worked (strip idle). Skilled worked = 170 − 10 = 160; unskilled worked = 90 − 5 = 85; total worked = 245. Actual rates: AR skilled = 14,110 ÷ 170 = ₹83; unskilled = 4,680 ÷ 90 = ₹52.

Step 3 — Rate Variance = (SR − AR) × AH_paid: - Skilled (80 − 83)×170 = 510 A; Unskilled (50 − 52)×90 = 180 A → **₹690 A.**

Step 4 — Idle Time Variance = idle hrs × SR: - Skilled 10×80 = 800 A; Unskilled 5×50 = 250 A → **₹1,050 A** (always adverse).

Step 5 — Efficiency Variance = (SH − AH_worked) × SR: - Skilled (172.8 − 160)×80 = 1,024 F; Unskilled (86.4 − 85)×50 = 70 F → **₹1,094 F.**

Step 6 — Labour Cost Variance (parent) = (SH×SR) − (AH_paid×AR): - Standard cost = 172.8×80 + 86.4×50 = 13,824 + 4,320 = 18,144; Actual = 14,110 + 4,680 = 18,790 → **₹646 A.**

Check: Rate 690 A + Idle 1,050 A + Efficiency 1,094 F = 646 A = LCV. ✓

Step 7 — Split efficiency into Mix and Yield (on hours *worked*, total 245 in standard ratio 160:80 = 2:1): - RSH(skilled) = 245 × 160/240 = 163.33; RSH(unskilled) = 245 × 80/240 = 81.67. - **Mix** = (RSH − AH_worked) × SR: skilled (163.33 − 160)×80 = 266.67 F; unskilled (81.67 − 85)×50 = 166.67 A → **₹100 F.** - **Yield** = (SH − RSH) × SR: skilled (172.8 − 163.33)×80 = 757.33 F; unskilled (86.4 − 81.67)×50 = 236.67 F → **₹994 F.**

Check: Mix 100 F + Yield 994 F = **1,094 F = Efficiency.** ✓

Reading it: The gang cost ₹646 more than standard — but that hides a strong story. Rates were higher (₹690 A, an HR matter) and a breakdown wasted 15 paid hours (₹1,050 A, a maintenance matter), yet the crew was genuinely *efficient*: they turned 245 worked hours into 108 units when standard would need 259.2 hours — a ₹1,094 F efficiency gain, of which ₹994 was superior yield (more output per worked hour) and only ₹100 came from a marginally cheaper mix. Three managers, three verdicts, from one ₹646 figure.

6. Presentation / Format

Examiners award marks for *structure*, not just answers. Standard layout:

1. **Working Note 1 — Standard cost card** and the flexed "standard for actual output" figures (SQ, SH).
2. **Working Note 2 — Basic actuals** (AP, AR derived; AH worked vs paid; RSQ/RBQ).
3. **Variance computations**, each labelled with F/A, grouped material → labour → VOH → FOH → sales.
4. **Verification lines** after each family: "Price + Usage = Cost ✓".
5. **Reconciliation Statement** from budgeted to actual profit.

Always write the **F or A** tag — a variance without its direction is worth zero. Present the reconciliation vertically with a clear running total. Show RSQ/RBQ as an explicit working; markers look for it in mix/yield questions.

Time-management order for a full 15-mark variance question. (i) First build the two working notes — SQ/SH and AP/AR/RSQ — because *every* variance draws on them; a mistake here poisons the whole answer. (ii) Compute the *parent* cost variances (MCV, LCV, overhead cost variances) directly from totals — they are quick and give you the reconciliation targets. (iii) Compute the children, then run each check line *immediately*; catching a break at the child stage costs one line, catching it at the reconciliation costs a re-do. (iv) Leave the reconciliation statement to last as the capstone. If time runs out, a correct set of *parent* variances plus stated formulas earns more than a half-finished mix/yield table.

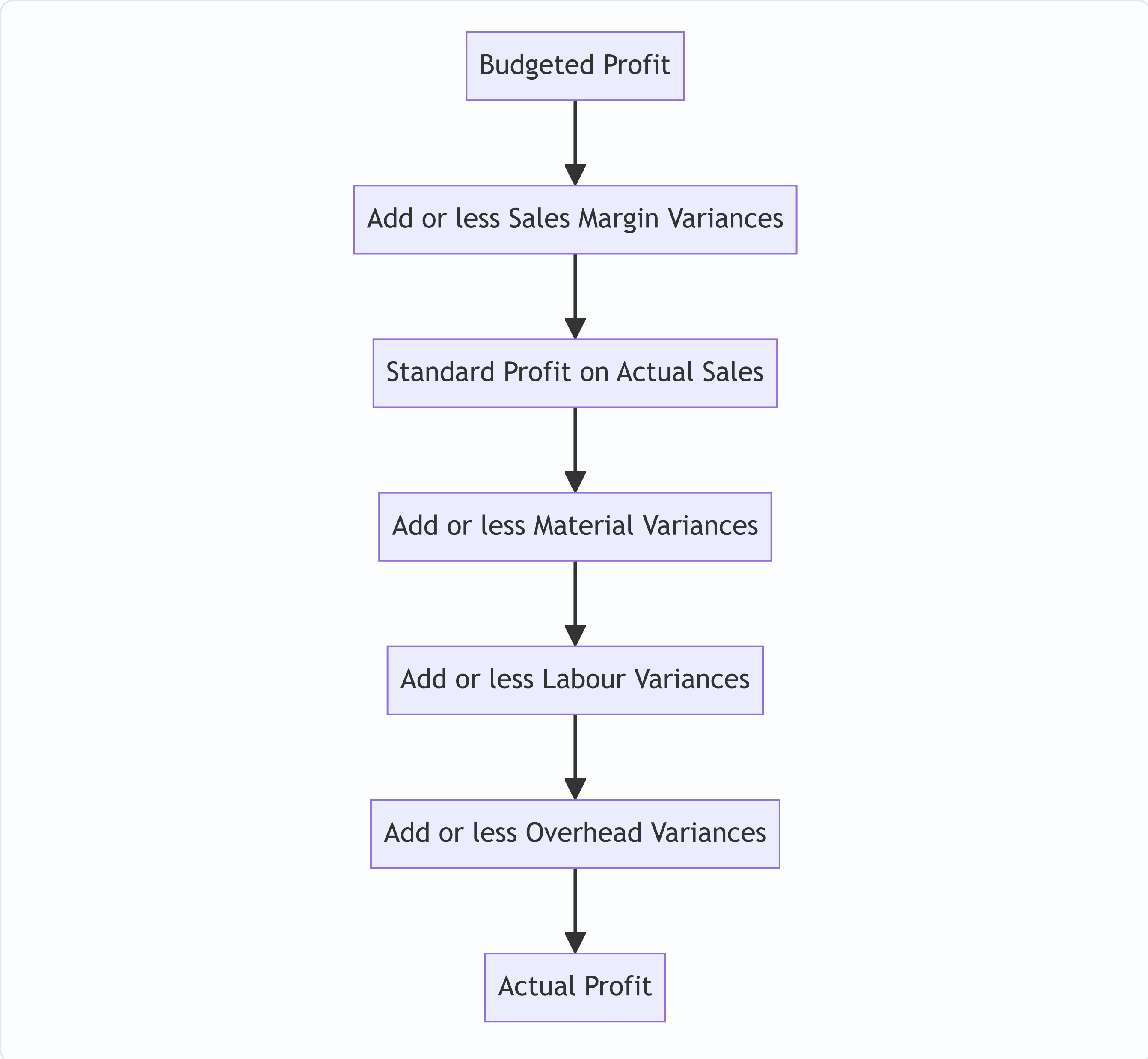


Figure 13.4 — The operating-profit reconciliation walk: start at plan, thread every variance, land on actual.

7. Connections

- **Marginal costing (Ch. 14) & CVP:** the *sales margin* method uses contribution/profit per unit — under marginal costing the sales volume variance is valued at **standard contribution**, and there is **no fixed OH volume variance** (fixed cost isn't absorbed into units). Know which system the question assumes.
- **Overheads & absorption (Ch. 04):** the FOH volume variance is exactly the "over/under-absorption" of Chapter 04, now *decomposed* into capacity, efficiency and calendar.
- **Budgetary control (Ch. 15):** flexible budgets supply the "budgeted for actual output" figures; standard costing is budgetary control at the per-unit level.
- **Material & labour costing (Ch. 02–03):** standard quantities come from the bill of materials; standard hours from time study.
- **Responsibility accounting:** each variance maps to a responsibility centre — the whole point of decomposition.

- **Process costing (Ch. 10):** the mix/yield split maps directly onto normal-loss/abnormal-loss thinking — the yield variance *is* the cost value of abnormal process loss/gain, valued at standard cost per unit of output.
- **Cost accounting standards / integral accounts:** under a standard cost *ledger*, variances are posted to dedicated variance accounts and closed to costing P&L, which is why clean reconciliation matters beyond the exam.

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Flexing to the wrong output.** SQ and SH must be based on **actual output**, never budgeted output. Using budgeted quantity is the single most common fatal error.
2. **Hours paid vs hours worked.** Rate variance and idle-time use **hours paid**; efficiency uses **hours worked**. Swap them and both go wrong. When idle time exists, LEV must exclude it.
3. **Idle time is always Adverse.** Never favourable. If your formula yields a favourable idle variance, you've mis-signed.
4. **Price variance on purchases vs usage.** If purchase quantity ≠ usage quantity and the question isolates price at purchase point, compute MPV on quantity *purchased*; otherwise on quantity used. Read the wording.
5. **FOH volume is not a spending variance.** Producing less than budget gives an adverse *volume* variance even if you spent exactly the budget — it's under-*recovery*, not over-*spending*. Students wrongly call it wasteful.
6. **Mix vs Yield direction.** Mix uses (RSQ − AQ); Yield uses (SQ − RSQ). Getting the pivot RSQ wrong (must be *actual total* in *standard* ratio) breaks both. RSQ total = AQ total; if they don't match, recompute.
7. **Sales price sign flips.** For sales, favourable = actual *exceeds* budget. Don't carry the cost convention (std − actual) into sales.
8. **Sales value vs sales margin method.** They give different volume variances (BP vs SM). Only the *margin* method reconciles to profit. Use the method the question demands.
9. **Rounding the actual rate.** Compute rate/price variances as (Actual cost − AQ×SP) to sidestep rounding of AP/AR (see Example 1's ₹23 discrepancy).
10. **Calendar variance double-count.** Only include it when actual days ≠ budgeted days; then capacity variance uses *revised* budgeted hours to avoid double counting.
11. **Reconciliation not tying.** If budgeted profit + variances ≠ actual profit, a sign is flipped somewhere. Treat the mismatch as a diagnostic, not a rounding excuse.
12. **Wrong FOR base.** Fixed OH *rate* must be computed on the *budgeted* activity (budgeted output or budgeted hours), never on actual or standard-for-actual. Dividing budgeted FOH by actual hours silently rebuilds the whole fixed-OH family wrong.
13. **Mixing marginal and absorption in one answer.** A sales volume variance valued at *contribution* (marginal) cannot be reconciled against a cost set that includes a fixed-OH *volume* variance (absorption). Pick one system for the whole question.
14. **Standard for actual output vs actual quantity in mix.** In mix/yield, SQ is the standard input for the *output achieved*, while RSQ is the standard-ratio split of *actual input*. Confusing the two totals (output-based vs input-based) is the classic mix/yield wipeout.

15. **Efficiency measured at the wrong price.** Fixed-OH efficiency uses FOR (per hour); labour efficiency uses SR; VOH efficiency uses SR_v. They are three *different* rates on the *same* hour deviation (SH − AH_worked); using one rate for another double-books or mis-values the hour.
16. **Treating an uncontrollable variance as a performance failure.** A market-wide price surge is an adverse price variance but is *not* the purchase manager's failing. Marks are lost when the "responsibility" comment blames the wrong person or ignores controllability.

9. First-Principles Recap

Strip everything away and one sentence remains: **a variance isolates the cost effect of changing exactly one input factor while holding the others at standard.** Price factors are valued at *actual quantity* (you paid the wrong price on what you actually used); quantity factors are valued at *standard price* (so the price story cannot leak into the efficiency story). The reason for that exact asymmetry is the *joint variance*: when both price and quantity move together, their interaction has to be parked somewhere, and the two-variance convention buries it inside the price variance — which is precisely why the price formula carries *actual* quantity. Mix and yield are just "quantity" split once more, pivoting on RSQ = actual total held in standard proportions. Fixed overhead is the odd one out only because a genuinely fixed cost is being forced through a per-unit rate, so a *volume* variance is born — the price you pay for pretending a fixed cost is variable per unit; and volume splits again into how many hours you ran (capacity), how hard you ran them (efficiency), and how many days you had (calendar). Sales flips the sign because more revenue is good — the true master rule being *favourable = increases profit*. And every parent equals the sum of its children, which is why the reconciliation statement, landing precisely on actual profit, proves the entire analysis in one line. Memorise nothing; hold quantity or price fixed and rebuild each formula on demand.

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

Convention: Cost variances = (Standard − Actual); positive = Favourable. Sales = (Actual − Budget). SQ/SH always for **actual output**. Master rule: Favourable = the movement *increases profit*.

Three-column skeleton (material / labour / VOH): ① SQ×SP · ② AQ×SP · ③ AQ×AP → Usage/Efficiency = ①−②, Price/Rate = ②−③, Cost = ①−③.

#	Variance	Formula
Material		
1	Cost (MCV)	(SQ×SP) − (AQ×AP)
2	Price (MPV)	(SP − AP) × AQ
3	Usage (MUV)	(SQ − AQ) × SP
4	Mix (MMV)	(RSQ − AQ) × SP
5	Yield (MYV)	(SQ − RSQ) × SP
	Check	MPV+MUV=MCV; MMV+MYV=MUV
Labour		
6	Cost (LCV)	(SH×SR) − (AH_paid×AR)
7	Rate (LRV)	(SR − AR) × AH_paid
8	Efficiency (LEV)	(SH − AH_worked) × SR
9	Idle Time (ITV)	Idle hrs × SR (always A)
10	Mix/Gang (LMV)	(RSH − AH_worked) × SR
11	Yield (LYV)	(SH − RSH) × SR
	Check	LRV+LEV+ITV=LCV; LMV+LYV=LEV
Variable OH		
12	Cost	(SH×SR_v) − Actual VOH
13	Expenditure	(AH×SR_v) − Actual VOH
14	Efficiency	(SH − AH) × SR_v
	Check	Exp+Eff=Cost
Fixed OH		
15	Cost	Absorbed − Actual
16	Expenditure (Budget)	Budgeted − Actual
17	Volume	Absorbed − Budgeted
18	Capacity	(AH_worked − Budgeted hrs) × FOR
19	Efficiency	(SH − AH_worked) × FOR
20	Calendar	(Actual − Budgeted days) × FOH/day
	Check	Exp+Vol=Cost; Cap+Eff+Cal=Vol
Sales (Margin)		
21	Total Margin	(AQ×AM) − (BQ×SM)
22	Price	(AM − SM) × AQ

#	Variance	Formula
23	Volume	(AQ − BQ) × SM
24	Mix	(AQ − RBQ) × SM
25	Quantity	(RBQ − BQ) × SM
	Check	Price+Vol=Total; Mix+Qty=Vol
Sales (Value)		
26	Value	(AQ×AP) − (BQ×BP)
27	Price	(AP − BP) × AQ
28	Volume	(AQ − BQ) × BP

Control ratios: Capacity = AH_worked ÷ Budgeted hrs; Efficiency = SH ÷ AH_worked; Activity = SH ÷ Budgeted hrs = Capacity × Efficiency. Above 100% = F.

Key figures: RSQ = actual total input × standard mix ratio. RBQ = actual total sales × budget mix ratio. FOR = Budgeted FOH ÷ Budgeted output (or hours). Absorbed FOH = actual output × FOR. Revised budgeted hours = budgeted hrs/day × actual days (calendar cases).

Reconciliation: Budgeted Profit ± Sales margin variances ± Material ± Labour ± VOH ± FOH = **Actual Profit** (must tie exactly). Marginal costing: no FOH volume variance; sales volume valued at contribution; subtract only FOH expenditure variance.

Q&A — Standard Costing & Variance Analysis

CA Intermediate · Cost & Management Accounting · Chapter 13 Every question is followed immediately by a complete model answer. All figures in Rupees (₹). Formulas per ICAI convention: **Variance = Standard − Actual** for costs (positive = Favourable, F; negative = Adverse, A).

Section A — Concept Check (short answer)

A1. What is a standard cost and how does it differ from a budget? A standard cost is a *predetermined per-unit* cost (of material, labour, overhead) built up scientifically for one unit of output. A budget is the *total* cost/revenue plan for an entire period or activity level. Standard = per unit; Budget = total. A budget is often built by multiplying the standard cost by the budgeted quantity.

A2. State the general formula for a Cost Variance and its sign convention. Cost Variance = (Standard Cost of actual output) − (Actual Cost). If the answer is positive it is **Favourable (F)** because actual cost was lower than standard; if negative it is **Adverse (A)**.

A3. Distinguish "revision variance" from a controllable variance. A revision (planning) variance arises because the original standard itself was wrong/outdated and is *uncontrollable* by the manager. A controllable (operational) variance measures performance against a realistic current standard and *is* the manager's responsibility.

A4. Why does the Material Usage Variance further split into Mix and Yield? When a product uses two or more materials that can substitute for one another, total usage can deviate for two reasons: (a) the *proportion* of inputs changed (Mix), and (b) the total input produced more/less output than expected (Yield). Mix + Yield = Usage.

A5. What is Idle Time Variance and why is it always adverse? Idle Time Variance = Idle hours × Standard rate. It isolates the cost of paid but non-productive hours (breakdowns, strikes). Since idle time is always a loss of paid hours, it can never be favourable — it is always **Adverse**.

A6. Give the four sub-variances of Fixed Overhead (absorption basis). Expenditure (Budgeted FOH − Actual FOH), Volume (Absorbed − Budgeted), which splits into Efficiency (Std hrs for actual output vs actual hrs) and Capacity (actual hrs vs budgeted hrs); Calendar variance arises when actual working days differ from budgeted.

A7. In sales variances, how do the "value/turnover" method and the "margin/profit" method differ? The value method measures the impact of sales changes on **turnover** (revenue). The margin method measures the impact on **profit** (using contribution or profit per unit) and is the one used in the budgeted-to-actual profit reconciliation.

Section B — Graded Computational Problems

B1 (Easy) — Material Price & Usage

Standard: 5 kg @ ₹4/kg per unit. Actual output 1,000 units; actual material 5,200 kg costing ₹22,360.

Solution. Standard price (SP) = ₹4; Standard qty for actual output (SQ) = 1,000 × 5 = 5,000 kg. Actual qty (AQ) = 5,200 kg; Actual price (AP) = 22,360 / 5,200 = ₹4.30/kg.

- **Price Variance** = AQ × (SP − AP) = 5,200 × (4 − 4.30) = **₹1,560 (A)**
- **Usage Variance** = SP × (SQ − AQ) = 4 × (5,000 − 5,200) = **₹800 (A)**
- **Total Material Cost Variance** = (SQ×SP) − (AQ×AP) = 20,000 − 22,360 = **₹2,360 (A)**

Check: 1,560 A + 800 A = 2,360 A. ✓ Ties.

B2 (Moderate) — Labour with Idle Time

Standard: 4 hrs @ ₹15/hr per unit. Actual output 500 units. Workers paid for 2,100 hrs @ ₹16/hr; 100 hrs were idle due to power failure.

Solution. SR = ₹15; Std hrs for output (SH) = 500 × 4 = 2,000 hrs. Hours paid = 2,100; Hours worked = 2,100 − 100 = 2,000; AR = ₹16.

- **Rate Variance** = Hours paid × (SR − AR) = 2,100 × (15 − 16) = **₹2,100 (A)**
- **Idle Time Variance** = Idle hrs × SR = 100 × 15 = **₹1,500 (A)**
- **Efficiency Variance** = SR × (SH − Hours worked) = 15 × (2,000 − 2,000) = **₹0**
- **Total Labour Cost Variance** = (SH×SR) − (Hours paid × AR) = 30,000 − 33,600 = **₹3,600 (A)**

Check: Rate 2,100 A + Idle 1,500 A + Efficiency 0 = 3,600 A. ✓ Ties.

B3 (Hard) — Material Mix & Yield

Standard mix for 100 kg output: | Material | Qty (kg) | Rate (₹) | Amount (₹) | |---|---|---|---| | A | 60 | 20 | 1,200 | | B | 40 | 30 | 1,200 | | **Total** | **100** | | **2,400** |

(Standard input 100 kg → 100 kg output, no loss.) Actual: A 340 kg @ ₹22, B 260 kg @ ₹28; output 560 kg.

Solution. Total actual input = 340 + 260 = 600 kg. Std cost/kg of mix = 2,400/100 = ₹24. Standard qty for actual output (SQ): A = 560×0.60 = 336 kg; B = 560×0.40 = 224 kg. Revised standard mix (actual total input 600 in std proportion): A = 600×0.6 = 360; B = 600×0.4 = 240.

Price Variance = Σ AQ(SP−AP): A: 340×(20−22) = 680 A; B: 260×(30−28) = 520 F → Net **₹160 (A)**

Mix Variance = SP × (Revised std qty − Actual qty): A: 20×(360−340) = 400 F; B: 30×(240−260) = 600 A → Net **₹200 (A)**

Yield Variance = Std cost/kg output × (Actual output − Std output from actual input). Std output from 600 kg input = 600 kg (no loss). Actual output = 560 kg → shortfall 40 kg. = 24 × (560 − 600) = **₹960 (A)**

Usage Variance = SP × (SQ − AQ): A: 20×(336−340) = 80 A; B: 30×(224−260) = 1,080 A → **₹1,160 (A)** Check: Mix 200 A + Yield 960 A = 1,160 A = Usage. ✓

Total Material Cost Variance = Price + Usage = 160 A + 1,160 A = **₹1,320 (A)** Verify directly: Std cost of output (560 × 24) = 13,440; Actual cost = 340×22 + 260×28 = 7,480 + 7,280 = 14,760; Variance = 13,440 − 14,760 = ₹1,320 A. ✓ Ties.

B4 (Exam-hard) — Full Overhead Variance Set

Budget for the month: output 10,000 units; standard 2 hrs/unit; fixed OH ₹1,20,000; variable OH ₹60,000; budgeted days 25. Actual: output 9,000 units; hours worked 17,500; actual days 24; fixed OH ₹1,25,000; variable OH ₹58,000.

Solution — set up standard rates. Budgeted hours = 10,000 × 2 = 20,000 hrs. Std FOH rate/hr = 1,20,000/20,000 = ₹6; Std VOH rate/hr = 60,000/20,000 = ₹3. Std hrs for actual output (SH) = 9,000 × 2 = 18,000 hrs. FOH absorbed = SH × 6 = 18,000 × 6 = 1,08,000. Budgeted FOH per day = 1,20,000/25 = ₹4,800.

Variable Overhead - Expenditure = (Actual hrs × Std rate) − Actual VOH = (17,500×3) − 58,000 = 52,500 − 58,000 = **₹5,500 (A)** - Efficiency = Std rate × (SH − Actual hrs) = 3 × (18,000 − 17,500) = **₹1,500 (F)** - Total VOH Variance = Absorbed − Actual = (18,000×3) − 58,000 = 54,000 − 58,000 = **₹4,000 (A)** ✓ (5,500 A + 1,500 F)

Fixed Overhead - Expenditure = Budgeted − Actual = 1,20,000 − 1,25,000 = **₹5,000 (A)** - Volume = Absorbed − Budgeted = 1,08,000 − 1,20,000 = **₹12,000 (A)** - Total FOH Variance = Absorbed − Actual = 1,08,000 − 1,25,000 = **₹17,000 (A)** ✓ (5,000 A + 12,000 A)

Volume split: - Efficiency = Std rate × (SH − Actual hrs) = 6 × (18,000 − 17,500) = **₹3,000 (F)** - Capacity = Std rate × (Actual hrs − Revised budgeted hrs for actual days). Revised budgeted hrs = 20,000 × 24/25 = 19,200. = 6 × (17,500 − 19,200) = **₹10,200 (A)** - Calendar = Std rate × (Revised budgeted hrs − Original budgeted hrs) = 6 × (19,200 − 20,000) = **₹4,800 (A)** Check: Efficiency 3,000 F + Capacity 10,200 A + Calendar 4,800 A = **12,000 A = Volume**. ✓ Ties.

Section C — Past-Paper-Style Full Question

C1. A company gives the following data for a period. Prepare all labour variances and reconcile. Standard: 3 hrs @ ₹20/hr per unit; budgeted output 4,000 units. Standard gang: Skilled 2 hrs @ ₹25, Unskilled 1 hr @ ₹10. Actual output 3,800 units. Actual: Skilled 8,200 hrs @ ₹26 = ₹2,13,200; Unskilled 3,600 hrs @ ₹9 = ₹32,400. No idle time.

Model answer. Std hrs for actual output: Skilled = 3,800×2 = 7,600; Unskilled = 3,800×1 = 3,800. Total SH = 11,400. Actual total hrs = 8,200 + 3,600 = 11,800. Revised std (actual total in std 2:1 ratio): Skilled = 11,800×2/3 = 7,866.67; Unskilled = 11,800×1/3 = 3,933.33.

Rate Variance = AH×(SR−AR): Skilled 8,200×(25−26)=8,200 A; Unskilled 3,600×(10−9)=3,600 F → **₹4,600 (A)**

Mix Variance = SR×(Revised std hrs − Actual hrs): Skilled 25×(7,866.67−8,200)=8,333 A; Unskilled 10×(3,933.33−3,600)=3,333 F → **₹5,000 (A)**

Yield (sub-efficiency) Variance = SR×(Std hrs − Revised std hrs): Skilled 25×(7,600−7,866.67)=6,667 A; Unskilled 10×(3,800−3,933.33)=1,333 A → **₹8,000 (A)**

Efficiency Variance = SR×(SH−AH): Skilled 25×(7,600−8,200)=15,000 A; Unskilled 10×(3,800−3,600)=2,000 F → **₹13,000 (A)** Check: Mix 5,000 A + Yield 8,000 A = 13,000 A = Efficiency. ✓

Total Labour Cost Variance = (SH×SR)−(AH×AR) = (7,600×25 + 3,800×10) − (2,13,200+32,400) = (1,90,000 + 38,000) − 2,45,600 = 2,28,000 − 2,45,600 = **₹17,600 (A)** Reconcile: Rate 4,600 A + Efficiency 13,000 A = **17,600 A**. ✓ Ties.

C2. Sales & Profit Reconciliation. Budget: 1,000 units @ ₹100, cost ₹80, profit ₹20/unit. Actual: 1,100 units sold @ ₹95; total cost per unit ₹82.

Model answer (margin method). Budgeted profit = 1,000 × 20 = ₹20,000. Standard profit/unit = ₹20. - **Sales Price Variance** = Actual units × (AP − SP) = 1,100 × (95 − 100) = **₹5,500 (A)** - **Sales Volume (profit) Variance** = Std profit × (Actual units − Budget units) = 20 × (1,100 − 1,000) = **₹2,000 (F)** - **Total Sales Margin Variance** = 5,500 A + 2,000 F = **₹3,500 (A)**

Cost side: Total cost variance = Std cost of actual output − Actual cost = (1,100×80) − (1,100×82) = 88,000 − 90,200 = **₹2,200 (A)**

Reconciliation: | Item | ₹ | |---|---| | Budgeted profit | 20,000 | | Sales price variance | (5,500) A | | Sales volume variance | 2,000 F | | Cost variances | (2,200) A | | **Actual profit** | **14,300** |

Verify: Actual profit = 1,100 × (95 − 82) = 1,100 × 13 = **₹14,300**. ✓ Ties.

Section D — MCQs & Case Scenarios

D1. Material usage variance uses which price? (a) Actual (b) Standard (c) Market (d) Weighted avg **Ans: (b) Standard.** Usage is valued at standard price to isolate the quantity effect only.

D2. Idle time variance is: (a) Always F (b) Always A (c) Either (d) Zero **Ans: (b) Always Adverse** — paid non-productive hours are pure loss.

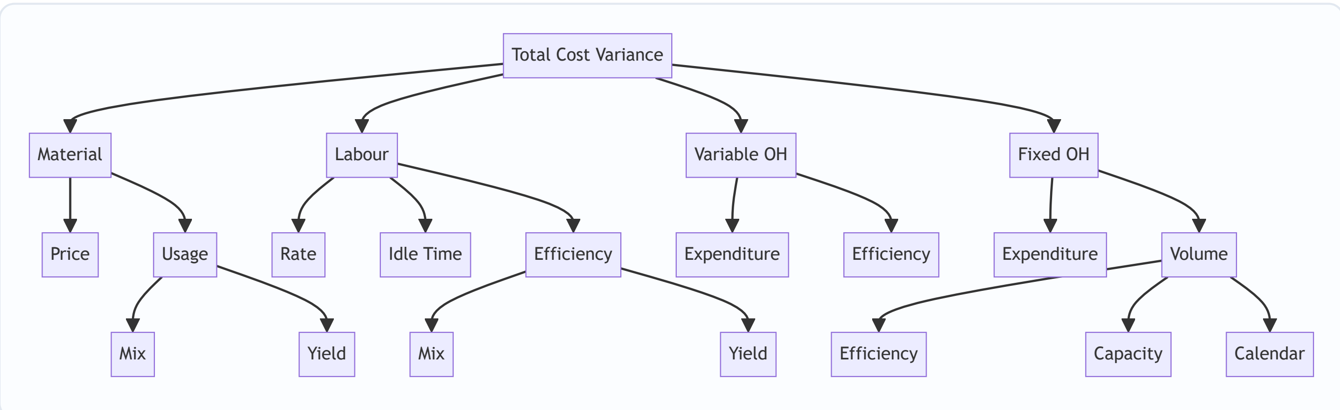
D3. Fixed OH volume variance = 0 when: (a) Actual = budgeted output (b) No idle time (c) Days equal (d) Rate unchanged **Ans: (a).** Volume = Absorbed − Budgeted; equal output means absorbed = budgeted.

D4. Sales price variance = 1,100×(95−100) uses: (a) Budget qty (b) Actual qty (c) Std qty (d) Revised qty **Ans: (b) Actual quantity** — price effect measured on units actually sold.

D5 (Case). A firm's material cost variance is favourable but usage is heavily adverse. What likely happened? **Ans:** A large **favourable price variance** (cheap, possibly inferior material) outweighed adverse usage — the classic trap where buying cheap material causes higher wastage. Examiner tests whether you flag the price–usage trade-off.

D6. Fixed OH capacity variance measures deviation in: (a) Output (b) Hours worked vs budgeted (c) Rate (d) Days **Ans: (b).** Capacity = Std rate × (Actual hrs − Budgeted hrs), i.e. utilisation of available capacity.

Variance Tree (Mermaid)



Quick-Revision Formula Sheet

Variance	Formula
Material Price	AQ × (SP − AP)
Material Usage	SP × (SQ − AQ)
Material Mix	SP × (Revised std qty − AQ)
Material Yield	Std cost/unit output × (Actual − Std output)
Labour Rate	Hours paid × (SR − AR)
Idle Time	Idle hrs × SR (always A)
Labour Efficiency	SR × (SH − Hours worked)
VOH Expenditure	(AH × Std rate) − Actual VOH
VOH Efficiency	Std rate × (SH − AH)
FOH Expenditure	Budgeted FOH − Actual FOH
FOH Volume	Absorbed − Budgeted
FOH Efficiency	Std rate × (SH − AH)
FOH Capacity	Std rate × (AH − Revised budgeted hrs)
FOH Calendar	Std rate × (Revised − Original budgeted hrs)
Sales Price	Actual units × (AP − SP)
Sales Volume (profit)	Std profit/unit × (Actual − Budget units)

Golden rules: (1) Cost variance sign: Standard − Actual, positive = F. (2) Mix + Yield always tie back to Usage/Efficiency. (3) All FOH sub-variances tie to Absorbed − Actual. (4) Reconciliation: Budgeted profit ± sales variances ± cost variances = Actual profit.

Chapter 14 — Marginal Costing & CVP Analysis

1. The Problem — When Total Cost Lies to the Decision-Maker

You have spent thirteen chapters learning to build a *total cost*. You loaded material, labour and overhead onto a job, a batch, a process, a service, and you produced a single, respectable number: the full cost of one unit. That number is honest for one purpose — telling the world what a unit *cost to produce* over a whole period. It is invaluable for valuing inventory in the financial accounts and for setting a long-run price.

But now a manager walks in with a different kind of question, and the total-cost number quietly betrays her.

A factory makes a component. The cost sheet says it costs ₹45 a unit — ₹30 of material, labour and variable overhead, and ₹15 of fixed factory overhead absorbed on normal volume. An overseas buyer offers a one-time order at **₹35 a unit**. The plant has idle capacity; the regular market is untouched. The works manager glances at the cost sheet, sees ₹45, and says: "*₹35 is below cost. Reject it — we'll lose ₹10 a unit.*"

She is **wrong**, and the total-cost number is why. Those ₹15 of fixed overhead — the factory rent, the supervisor's salary, the machine's depreciation — will be incurred *whether or not this order is accepted*. They do not change. Rejecting the order does not save ₹15; accepting it does not add ₹15. The only cost that actually moves when this order is taken is the ₹30 that varies with each extra unit. At ₹35, each unit brings in ₹35 and consumes ₹30 of genuinely additional cost, leaving **₹5 of pure surplus** to help pay for those fixed costs that exist anyway. Reject the order and the company is ₹5 a unit *poorer*.

This is the central failure that marginal costing exists to fix. **For a short-run decision, the total cost of a unit is not the cost of the decision.** Full cost mixes together two species of cost that behave in completely opposite ways:

- costs that **rise and fall with activity** (make one more, spend more; make one fewer, spend less), and
- costs that **sit there regardless** (make one more or a thousand fewer, they are unchanged in the period).

When you fuse the two into a single "₹45", you destroy the very information a decision needs — *what will actually change if I do this?* The manager who trusts total cost will reject profitable orders, keep loss-making products alive, make things she should buy, and shut down departments that were quietly subsidising the rent.

The problem marginal costing solves: separate the costs that respond to a decision from the costs that ignore it, so that every short-run choice — take the order, drop the product, make or buy, which product to push when capacity is scarce — is judged on the money that will *actually change*. Everything in this chapter flows from that single act of separation.

A second, subtler symptom — profit that lurches without a change in sales. Under the full-cost (absorption) system, a factory can sell exactly the same number of units in two years, at the same price, with the same costs, and yet report *different profits* — simply because it *produced* more in one year than the other, parking fixed overhead in unsold stock. A manager reading those two profit figures would swear something changed in the market; nothing did. Only the production-versus-sales relationship moved. Marginal costing exists partly to stop this: by refusing to let fixed cost hide in inventory, it makes profit move *with sales*, which is the number a manager can actually steer. Hold this thought — it becomes the engine of Section 5's reconciliation.

Why "short-run" is the load-bearing word. Marginal costing's whole claim — "ignore fixed cost, it will not change" — is true *only within the relevant range and only for the horizon over which those fixed costs are genuinely committed*. Over a long enough horizon, *every* cost is variable: leases expire, supervisors can be redeployed, capacity can be added or shed. So marginal costing is a tool for *tactical* decisions (this order, this quarter, this bottleneck), not for setting a permanent price floor. A firm that priced *every* sale at marginal cost would never recover its fixed costs and would die. The discipline is: use contribution to decide the *marginal* choice, but ensure that *across all sales* total contribution still clears total fixed cost with room to spare. Examiners love to test whether you know the boundary of the tool, not just the tool.

---

2. The Core Idea — The Cost of the *Next* Unit

Here is the analogy that unlocks the whole chapter.

You have booked a 50-seat bus for a private tour. The bus, the driver, the diesel for the fixed route, the toll — all of it is contracted at a flat **₹20,000** for the day, no matter how many friends you bring. Forty-five people have said yes. A forty-sixth friend calls and asks to come. What does *her* seat cost?

Not ₹20,000 ÷ 46. That "average cost per head" is a real number, but it is not the cost of *her*. Her presence changes nothing about the bus, the driver or the diesel — those are locked in. The only thing her seat adds is perhaps ₹50 for one extra packed lunch. **The cost of the next passenger is ₹50, not the average of ₹435.** So if she offers to chip in ₹200, you say yes instantly — because ₹200 comes in, ₹50 goes out, and ₹150 helps you recover the fixed ₹20,000 you are committed to anyway.

That ₹50 is the **marginal cost** — the cost of one more unit. That ₹150 surplus is the **contribution** — what the sale *contributes* first toward covering fixed costs, and then, once fixed costs are fully covered, toward profit.

This is the mental switch marginal costing demands. Stop asking "*what did a unit cost on average?*" Start asking "*what does the next unit add, and what does it contribute?*" The fixed cost is treated not as something to be smeared thinly over units, but as a **single lump the period must pay for** — a hurdle the total contribution must clear before a rupee of profit appears.

Formally, **marginal cost** is the aggregate of variable costs — the amount by which total cost increases if output rises by one unit (or falls if output drops by one unit). And the master relationship of the entire chapter, the equation you will use in a hundred disguises, is simply:

> **Sales − Variable Cost = Contribution Contribution − Fixed Cost = Profit**

Contribution is the hero. It is the fund every unit throws into a common pool; fixed cost is the bill that pool must first settle; profit is whatever is left. Once you *feel* that contribution — not profit-per-unit — is what each sale generates, break-even, margin of safety, product mix and shutdown all become obvious rather than memorised.

A note on economists' "marginal cost" versus the accountant's. In economics, marginal cost is the cost of the *very next* unit and it *changes* as output rises (falling then rising, giving a U-shaped curve, because of diminishing returns). The cost accountant deliberately makes a *simplifying assumption*: within the **relevant range** of activity, variable cost per unit is **constant**, so the accountant's marginal cost is a straight line, equal to variable cost per unit at every level. This is why CVP charts are drawn with straight lines. Know that this linearity is an *assumption*, valid only across the normal operating band — push output far beyond it and overtime premiums, bulk-buying discounts, and congestion break the straight line. An examiner testing "assumptions of CVP analysis" wants exactly this list (see 4.10).

Contribution is not profit — guard the distinction ruthlessly. A product with a *positive* contribution but which, after a share of fixed cost, shows a *loss* is still worth selling in the short run, because its contribution reduces the loss the rest of the firm must bear. Conversely, a high *contribution per unit* does not mean a product is best to push — if it devours scarce capacity, a lower-contribution product may win (Example 3). Every trap in this chapter is, at root, someone confusing contribution with profit, or contribution-per-unit with contribution-per-scarce-resource.

The forty-sixth passenger costs ₹50 because the bus is already paid for; contribution is her fare minus that ₹50, and it is the only number that should decide whether she boards.

---

3. Why It's Built This Way — Cost Behaviour, Not Cost Function

Why split costs by **behaviour** (variable vs fixed) rather than by **function** (production, admin, selling), which is how the cost sheet was built? Because a decision does not care *what a cost is for* — it cares *whether the cost will move*. Behaviour is the only classification that answers "what changes if I act?"

So marginal costing re-sorts every cost into three behavioural boxes:

- **Variable costs** move in direct proportion to activity — total varies, but cost *per unit* stays constant. Direct material, direct wages (where truly output-linked), variable overhead. In the analogy, the packed lunch.
- **Fixed costs** stay constant in total over the relevant range, so cost *per unit falls* as volume rises. Rent, salaries, straight-line depreciation, insurance. The bus hire. Crucially, fixed cost per unit is a *mathematical artefact* of the volume you happen to choose — which is exactly why it must never enter a decision.
- **Semi-variable costs** contain both (a telephone bill: fixed line rental + variable call charges; power: a fixed sanctioned-load charge + variable usage). These must be *split* into their fixed and variable parts before analysis — most commonly by the **high-low method**, which you meet in the technical section.

A finer distinction the exam probes: fixed costs are not all alike. Within "fixed" hide three sub-species, and decisions treat them differently:

- **Committed fixed costs** — locked in by past decisions and unavoidable in the short run: lease rent, depreciation on owned plant, insurance. These are the ones you *always* ignore in a short-run decision.
- **Discretionary (managed) fixed costs** — set by management policy each period and *can* be switched off: advertising, R&D, training budgets. Avoidable if the activity is dropped.
- **Stepped fixed costs** — fixed over a band of activity but jumping to a new level once a threshold is crossed (one more supervisor per shift, one more machine per 10,000 units). These are "fixed" only within their step; a decision that pushes activity across a step boundary *does* change them, and they must then be treated as relevant. Examiners hide a step-cost jump inside a "fixed cost" line to see if you notice.

The word **relevant range** now earns its keep: it is the band of activity over which the assumed behaviour holds — variable cost per unit constant, total fixed cost flat. Outside it, both assumptions fail. Every formula in this chapter carries the silent footnote "...within the relevant range."

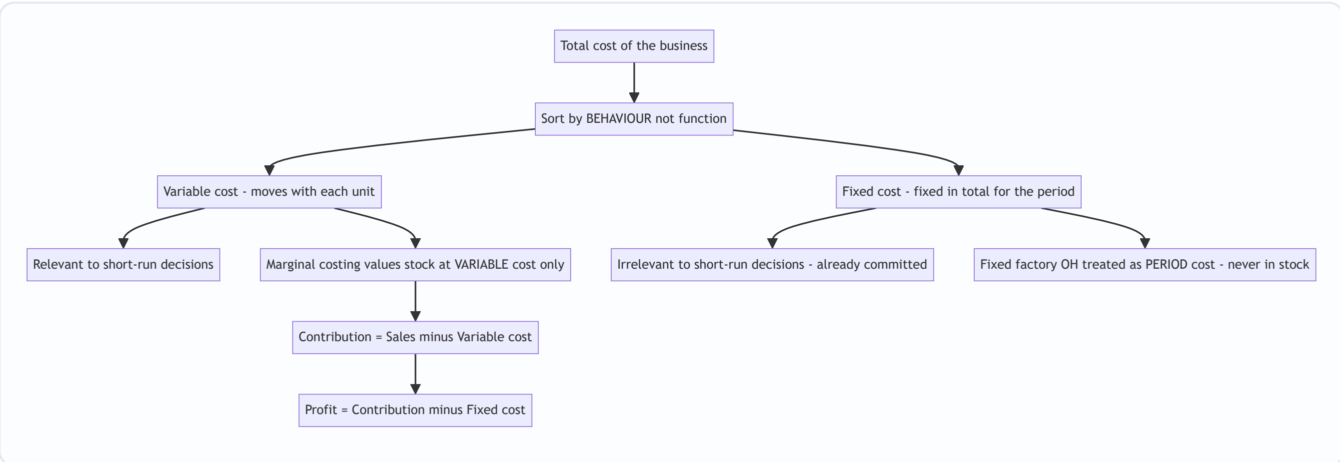
Now the second design choice, the one that trips up every student: **how do you treat fixed factory overhead when valuing stock?** This single decision splits the world into two costing systems.

- **Marginal (variable) costing** says fixed factory overhead is a **cost of the *period*, not of the *product*.** The rent is incurred because a month passed, not because units were made. So it is charged in full against that period's contribution and **never carried in the value of unsold stock.** Inventory is valued at **variable cost only.**
- **Absorption (total) costing** — the method behind your cost sheet, and the one financial reporting standards (AS 2 / Ind AS 2) *require* for published accounts — says fixed factory overhead is a genuine cost of *making* the product, so it is **absorbed into each unit** and travels with unsold units into closing stock.

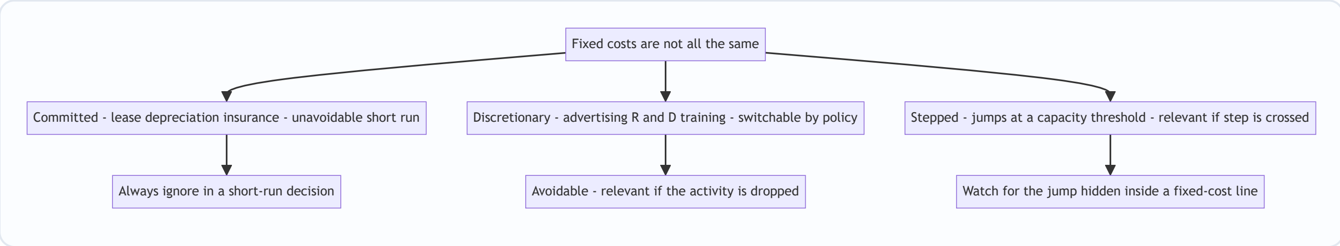
This one difference — *does fixed factory overhead sit in closing stock or not?* — is the sole reason the two methods report **different profits** in any period where production and sales volumes differ. Understanding *why* that gap arises, and being able to *reconcile* it to the last rupee, is a guaranteed exam requirement and the spine of Section 5's second example.

Why standards forbid marginal costing for published accounts. AS 2 / Ind AS 2 require inventory to include a *systematic allocation of fixed production overheads* based on *normal capacity*. The logic of external reporting is the **matching principle**: fixed factory overhead is a cost of *getting goods into a saleable state*, so it should be carried with the goods and matched against the *revenue* those goods eventually earn — not dumped into the period they were made. Marginal costing's period-cost treatment violates this matching, so it is barred from statutory accounts and used only *internally* for decisions. This is why every exam answer must flag: absorption for reporting, marginal for decisions. (Note the standard's phrase *normal capacity* — allocating fixed overhead on *normal* rather than *actual* output is what creates under/over-absorption, the bridge back to Chapter 4.)

A common misconception to kill now: marginal costing does *not* mean "ignore fixed costs." It charges the *entire* fixed cost against the period — arguably *more* aggressively than absorption, which defers part of it into stock. The difference is purely *timing and location* (period vs product), not whether fixed cost is ever counted. Over the whole life of the business, both methods report the *same total profit*; they only differ *period by period*.



Behaviour, not function, is the sorting key — because a decision only reacts to costs that move, and fixed costs do not.



The single word "fixed" hides three behaviours — only the committed kind is safely ignorable in every short-run decision.

---

4. Full Technical Content — Every Formula, With the Reason It Exists

4.1 The contribution family

Everything is one equation seen from different angles. Learn the equation; the formulas are just its rearrangements.

Concept	Formula	What it answers
Marginal cost	Direct material + Direct labour + Direct expenses + Variable overhead	Cost added by one more unit
Contribution per unit (c)	Selling price − Variable cost per unit	Surplus each unit throws into the fixed-cost pool
Total contribution	Sales − Total variable cost, or c × units	The whole pool available for fixed cost + profit
Profit	Contribution − Fixed cost	What survives after the pool clears the hurdle
Contribution (identity)	Fixed cost + Profit	Same pool, viewed from where it goes

That last identity — **Contribution = Fixed cost + Profit** — is worth its own line. It says the pool has exactly two destinations: pay the fixed bill, then become profit. It lets you find any one of the three when you know the other two, and it is the engine behind break-even (profit = 0, so contribution = fixed cost).

The four-quadrant way to remember the whole family. Any exam datum you are given is one corner of this square, and every other corner is one subtraction away:

```
        per unit            × units →          total
Sales   Selling price       ×  Q      =        Sales value
(−)     Variable cost/unit  ×  Q      =        Total variable cost
(=)     Contribution/unit   ×  Q      =        Total contribution
                                       (−) Fixed cost
                                       (=) Profit
```

Read down a column or across a row — the arithmetic is identical. Students lose marks by mixing a *per-unit* figure with a *total* figure in the same subtraction; keep each column pure and this never happens.

4.2 The P/V ratio — contribution as a *rate*

Contribution per unit is fine when you count units. But businesses often think in **rupees of sales**, and a multi-product firm cannot add "units" of a car and a pen. So we express contribution as a **percentage of sales value** — the **Profit/Volume ratio**, the single most useful ratio in the chapter.

$$\text{P/V ratio} = \frac{\text{Contribution}}{\text{Sales}} \times 100 = \frac{\text{Contribution per unit}}{\text{Selling price per unit}} \times 100$$

The P/V ratio is the **contribution earned per rupee of sales.** A P/V ratio of 40% means every ₹100 of sales generates ₹40 of contribution. Its power is that it is (usually) *constant* regardless of volume, so it converts freely between sales value and contribution.

Because selling price and variable cost per unit are constant, the P/V ratio can also be found from **any two periods'** data — it strips out fixed cost entirely:

$$\text{P/V ratio} = \frac{\text{Change in Contribution}}{\text{Change in Sales}} \times 100 = \frac{\text{Change in Profit}}{\text{Change in Sales}} \times 100$$

(Change in profit equals change in contribution because fixed cost, being fixed, does not change between the two periods — so it cancels. This is the standard "two-year" exam trick.)

The complementary identity — the variable-cost ratio. Since every rupee of sales splits into contribution and variable cost, the two ratios must sum to 1:

$$\text{P/V ratio} + \frac{\text{Variable cost}}{\text{Sales}} = 100\%$$

So a 40% P/V ratio means a 60% variable-cost-to-sales ratio. This is a fast route when the examiner gives you variable cost as a percentage of sales: P/V = 1 − (VC/Sales). It also explains *why raising the selling price* lifts the P/V ratio more powerfully than an equal rupee cut in variable cost — a price rise adds to the numerator (contribution) *and* the denominator (sales), but the numerator's proportional gain dominates near typical margins.

How to improve the P/V ratio (a favourite theory question): raise selling price; reduce variable cost per unit (cheaper materials, better labour efficiency, lower variable overhead); change the sales mix toward higher-P/V products. Note fixed cost does *not* appear — it cannot change the P/V ratio. A frequent trap: candidates list "reduce fixed cost" as a way to raise the P/V ratio. It is not — reducing fixed cost lowers the break-even point and raises profit, but the P/V ratio is untouched because fixed cost sits nowhere in its formula.

4.3 Break-even — the point where contribution exactly clears the hurdle

The **break-even point (BEP)** is the activity level at which total contribution exactly equals fixed cost, so profit is zero — no profit, no loss. It matters because it is the *floor of survival*: below it you bleed, above it you earn. Set Profit = 0 in the master identity (Contribution = Fixed cost) and solve:

$$\text{BEP (units)} = \frac{\text{Fixed cost}}{\text{Contribution per unit}} \qquad \text{BEP (₹ sales)} = \frac{\text{Fixed cost}}{\text{P/V ratio}}$$

Both say the same thing: keep piling on contribution until the pile equals fixed cost. In units, each unit adds *c*; in rupees, each rupee of sales adds the P/V ratio. (You can also get BEP sales as BEP units × selling price — they must agree; use it to self-check.)

Cash break-even point — some fixed costs (depreciation, amortisation) are *non-cash*. The level of sales at which you break even *in cash* is lower, because you only need to cover the cash fixed costs:

$$\text{Cash BEP (units)} = \frac{\text{Fixed cost} - \text{Non-cash fixed cost}}{\text{Contribution per unit}}$$

How the BEP *moves* — a source of many small MCQs. Reason it from the formula, never memorise the direction:

- Fixed cost **rises** → BEP **rises** (bigger hurdle, more units to clear it).
- Contribution per unit **rises** (higher price or lower variable cost) → BEP **falls** (each unit clears more of the hurdle).
- A **change in sales mix** toward higher-P/V products **lowers** the composite BEP; toward lower-P/V products **raises** it.
- A change in **volume alone** does *not* move the BEP — the BEP is a property of the cost structure, not of how much you happen to sell.

Composite vs product-level thinking. In a single-product firm the BEP is a genuine unit count. In a multi-product firm the "BEP in units" is meaningless unless the mix is fixed; you must work in sales value using the composite P/V ratio (4.9). Watch for a question that gives per-unit data for several products and *silently expects* you to notice you cannot just add units.

4.4 Margin of safety — how far you can fall before you bleed

Knowing the BEP, the next question is: *how much cushion do I have?* The **margin of safety (MoS)** is the excess of actual (or budgeted) sales over break-even sales — the distance you can lose before profit turns to loss.

$$\text{MoS} = \text{Actual sales} - \text{Break-even sales} \qquad \text{MoS ratio} = \frac{\text{MoS}}{\text{Actual sales}} \times 100$$

The most *revealing* form connects MoS straight to profit — because every rupee of sales *beyond* break-even is pure contribution (fixed cost is already paid), all of it drops to profit:

$$\text{Profit} = \text{MoS (in ₹)} \times \text{P/V ratio} \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad \text{MoS (₹)} = \frac{\text{Profit}}{\text{P/V ratio}}$$

A large margin of safety means a business that can weather a slump; a thin one means danger. To *improve* it: increase sales, reduce fixed cost (lowers BEP), raise the P/V ratio, or drop unprofitable low-contribution lines.

A powerful shortcut the MoS ratio hides. Because Profit = MoS × P/V ratio and BEP-portion of sales earns zero profit, the **MoS ratio equals the fraction of your P/V-generated contribution that survives as profit**. Equivalently:

$$\text{MoS ratio} = \frac{\text{Profit}}{\text{Contribution}} \qquad\text{and}\qquad \text{Profit} = \text{Sales} \times \text{P/V ratio} \times \text{MoS ratio}$$

So if P/V ratio is 40% and MoS ratio is 25%, profit is 10% of sales — computed without ever finding fixed cost. Examiners set questions giving you *only* the P/V ratio and the MoS ratio and asking for profit as a percentage of sales; this identity answers them in one line.

4.5 Target profit — break-even's ambitious cousin

Break-even asks "cover fixed cost." Managers ask "earn ₹X profit." Just raise the hurdle: the pool must now cover **fixed cost *plus* the desired profit.**

$$\text{Units for target profit} = \frac{\text{Fixed cost} + \text{Target profit}}{\text{Contribution per unit}} \qquad \text{Sales for target profit} = \frac{\text{Fixed cost} + \text{Target profit}}{\text{P/V ratio}}$$

If the target profit is stated **after tax**, gross it up first: Required pre-tax profit = After-tax target ÷ (1 − tax rate), then use the pre-tax figure above.

Target profit stated as a percentage — two very different tweaks. Read the wording with care:

- *Profit as a % of sales*** (say "profit must be 10% of sales"): here target profit itself depends on the unknown sales, so bring it into the P/V ratio. Required sales = Fixed cost ÷ (P/V ratio − required profit % of sales). Treating the required margin as a reduction in the effective P/V ratio is the clean method.
- *Profit as a % of capital employed or a fixed rupee sum*: this is a constant, so use the ordinary target-profit formula.

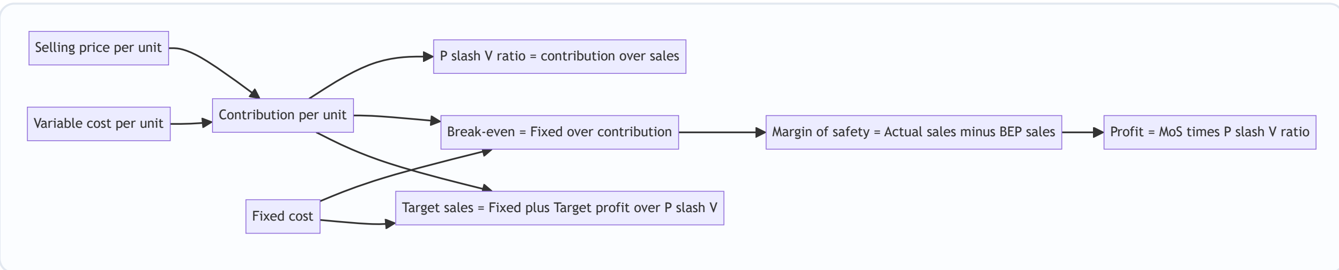
Mixing these two is a classic slip — the first needs the profit % *inside* the denominator, the second needs it as a *numerator* addition. Decide which by asking: "does the target grow as sales grow?" If yes, it belongs in the denominator.

And the general profit equation, which subsumes all of the above:

$$\text{Profit} = (\text{Sales} \times \text{P/V ratio}) - \text{Fixed cost}$$

4.6 The CVP relationship, in one picture

Cost-Volume-Profit (CVP) analysis is simply the study of how profit responds as volume moves — everything in 4.3–4.5 is one continuous story.



One chain: price and variable cost fix contribution; contribution and fixed cost fix break-even; the gap above break-even, taxed at the P/V rate, is profit.

4.7 The break-even chart and the angle of incidence

Plot sales value on the vertical axis against volume on the horizontal. Draw a horizontal-ish **fixed cost line**, a **total cost line** starting at the fixed-cost intercept and sloping up by variable cost, and a **sales line** from the origin. Where sales crosses total cost is the **break-even point**. To its left is a loss wedge; to its right, a profit wedge.

The **angle of incidence** is the angle at which the sales line cuts the total cost line at the BEP. A *wide* angle means profit accumulates rapidly once you pass break-even (high P/V ratio, strong earning power); a *narrow* angle means profit crawls up slowly. Together with the margin of safety, it summarises a firm's profit health at a glance.

Reading the chart's economics — what each feature *means*:

- The **fixed-cost line's height** is the hurdle; a firm with high fixed cost has a high line and therefore a distant break-even — high operating leverage, high risk, high reward.
- The **gap between the sales line and the total-cost line** at any volume *is* the profit (or loss) at that volume; the vertical distance is literally the P&L.

- The **best pair of health signals** is a *high margin of safety* (break-even far to the left of actual sales) *and* a *wide angle of incidence* (profit builds fast beyond it). A firm can have one without the other — a low-fixed-cost trader may break even early but earn a thin margin per rupee (narrow angle); a capital-heavy manufacturer may break even late but coin money past it (wide angle).

Two chart variants examiners ask you to distinguish:

- The **contribution break-even chart** plots the *variable cost line first* (from the origin), then stacks fixed cost on top to reach total cost. Its advantage: the *contribution* is shown directly as the wedge between the sales line and the variable-cost line, so you *see* contribution covering fixed cost then becoming profit. The conventional chart plots fixed cost first and hides contribution.
- The **profit-volume (P/V) graph** dispenses with cost lines entirely. It plots *profit* on the vertical axis against sales on the horizontal — a single straight line starting at *minus fixed cost* (the loss when sales are zero) and crossing the horizontal axis at the break-even point. Its slope *is* the P/V ratio. It is the fastest way to read off profit at any sales level and to compare two products' earning power (steeper line = higher P/V ratio). Know that the P/V graph's horizontal intercept = BEP and its vertical intercept = −Fixed cost; these two facts answer most P/V-graph MCQs.

4.8 Splitting semi-variable cost — the high-low method

Before any of this works, mixed costs must be split. The **high-low method** uses the highest and lowest activity levels:

$$\text{Variable cost per unit} = \frac{\text{Cost at highest activity} - \text{Cost at lowest activity}}{\text{Highest units} - \text{Lowest units}}$$

Then Fixed cost = Total cost at any level − (Variable cost per unit × units at that level).

Two refinements the exam slips in:

- **Pick by activity level, not by cost.** The "high" and "low" points are the highest and lowest *activity (units/hours)*, even if some middle month has a higher *cost*. Choosing by cost is a classic error.
- **Step changes and inflation break the method.** If fixed cost jumped between the two chosen periods (a stepped cost, or a mid-year rent revision), the plain high-low result is contaminated — you must adjust the high-period cost back to the low-period price basis before differencing. The high-low method assumes a *single* linear cost function across the whole range; flag it if the data hints otherwise. It also uses only two data points and ignores all the rest, so it is cruder than the least-squares regression you may meet elsewhere — a valid "limitations" point.

4.9 Multi-product (composite) break-even

When a firm sells several products in a **fixed sales mix**, you cannot use one contribution-per-unit. Compute a **composite (overall) P/V ratio** and break even in sales value:

$$\text{Composite P/V ratio} = \frac{\text{Total contribution of all products}}{\text{Total sales of all products}} \times 100 \qquad \text{Composite BEP (₹)} = \frac{\text{Total fixed cost}}{\text{Composite P/V ratio}}$$

Then split the composite break-even sales back into products in the sales-value ratio to get each product's break-even sales.

Two rival ways to define the mix — do not confuse them. The composite P/V ratio above weights by *sales value*. An alternative approach fixes the mix in *physical units* and builds a "composite unit" (e.g., a bundle of 3 of A + 2 of B), finds the contribution per bundle, and divides fixed cost by it to get the number of bundles at break-even. Both are correct; the sales-value method is faster when data are in rupees, the composite-unit method when a physical mix ratio is given. The pitfall: the break-even is valid **only for that exact mix** — change the proportions and the whole answer changes, because the composite P/V ratio shifts. Always state the mix assumption in your answer.

4.10 The assumptions (and therefore the limitations) of CVP analysis

Every CVP formula rests on a set of assumptions; each assumption is also a limitation, and stating them is a standard theory sub-question. Marks are awarded for the list *and* for showing you know why each matters:

- **Cost behaviour is linear** within the relevant range — variable cost per unit and selling price per unit are constant. Reality: bulk discounts, overtime premiums and price cuts to sell more volume all bend the lines.
- **Costs split cleanly into fixed and variable** — semi-variable costs are fully separable. Reality: the split is an estimate (high-low, regression), never exact.
- **Fixed costs stay constant** over the whole range. Reality: they step up at capacity thresholds.
- **Production equals sales** (no change in stock), so that volume alone drives both cost and revenue. When stock changes, absorption and marginal profits diverge (Section 5).
- **Sales mix is constant** in a multi-product firm — otherwise the composite P/V ratio is unstable.
- **Only volume affects cost and revenue** — technology, efficiency and price levels are held constant. It is a *short-run, single-period, static* model.

Because of these, CVP is a *planning approximation*, not a precise forecast — best for comparing options and finding the break-even neighbourhood, not for predicting profit to the rupee at extreme volumes.

---

5. Worked Examples — From Textbook-Easy to Exam-Hard

Example 1 — The full CVP toolkit on one product *(foundation)*

Data. Excel Ltd makes a single product. Selling price ₹50 per unit; variable cost ₹30 per unit; fixed costs ₹2,00,000 per year. Current sales 15,000 units. Required: (a) contribution per unit and P/V ratio; (b) BEP in units and rupees; (c) margin of safety and its ratio; (d) current profit; (e) units and sales needed for a target profit of ₹1,00,000; (f) sales needed for an after-tax profit of ₹63,000 at a 30% tax rate.

Step 1 — Contribution and P/V ratio. Contribution per unit = 50 − 30 = **₹20.** P/V ratio = 20 ÷ 50 × 100 = **40%.**

Step 2 — Break-even. BEP (units) = Fixed cost ÷ contribution per unit = 2,00,000 ÷ 20 = **10,000 units.** BEP (₹) = Fixed cost ÷ P/V ratio = 2,00,000 ÷ 0.40 = **₹5,00,000.** *Self-check:* 10,000 units × ₹50 = ₹5,00,000. ✓

Step 3 — Margin of safety. Actual sales = 15,000 × 50 = ₹7,50,000. MoS = 7,50,000 − 5,00,000 = **₹2,50,000** (or 15,000 − 10,000 = 5,000 units). MoS ratio = 2,50,000 ÷ 7,50,000 × 100 = **33.33%.**

Step 4 — Current profit. Profit = Contribution − Fixed = (15,000 × 20) − 2,00,000 = 3,00,000 − 2,00,000 = **₹1,00,000.** *Self-check via MoS:* Profit = MoS × P/V ratio = 2,50,000 × 0.40 = ₹1,00,000. ✓

Step 5 — Target profit of ₹1,00,000. Units = (Fixed + target) ÷ c = (2,00,000 + 1,00,000) ÷ 20 = **15,000 units.** Sales = 3,00,000 ÷ 0.40 = **₹7,50,000.** (Consistent with current level — current profit *is* ₹1,00,000.) ✓

Step 6 — After-tax target of ₹63,000 at 30% tax. Pre-tax profit needed = 63,000 ÷ (1 − 0.30) = 63,000 ÷ 0.70 = ₹90,000. Sales = (Fixed + pre-tax profit) ÷ P/V ratio = (2,00,000 + 90,000) ÷ 0.40 = 2,90,000 ÷ 0.40 =

₹7,25,000 (14,500 units). *Self-check:* Contribution 14,500 × 20 = 2,90,000; less fixed 2,00,000 = pre-tax 90,000; tax 30% = 27,000; after-tax = 63,000. ✓

Examiner tweak — "what if fixed cost rises by ₹40,000 and the firm still wants ₹1,00,000 profit?" New hurdle = 2,40,000 + 1,00,000 = 3,40,000; units = 3,40,000 ÷ 20 = 17,000; sales = ₹8,50,000. Notice the BEP itself also moved: new BEP = 2,40,000 ÷ 20 = 12,000 units. This is the fastest way to *feel* that fixed cost drives the break-even but never the P/V ratio (still 40%).

Example 2 — Marginal vs Absorption profit, fully reconciled *(the guaranteed exam question)*

Data. Sunrise Ltd, for the year:

Item	Figure
Units produced	10,000
Units sold	8,000
Selling price per unit	₹100
Variable manufacturing cost per unit	₹60
Fixed manufacturing overhead (for the year)	₹1,50,000
Fixed selling & administration overhead	₹50,000

There was no opening stock. Fixed manufacturing overhead is absorbed on the basis of *normal* production of 10,000 units. Prepare profit statements under **marginal** and **absorption** costing and **reconcile** the difference.

Preliminary numbers. Closing stock = 10,000 produced − 8,000 sold = **2,000 units.** Fixed manufacturing OH absorption rate = 1,50,000 ÷ 10,000 = **₹15 per unit.** Absorption cost per unit = variable 60 + fixed 15 = **₹75.**

(A) Marginal costing statement — stock valued at variable cost (₹60) only; all fixed cost charged to the period.

Marginal costing	₹
Sales (8,000 × 100)	8,00,000
Less: Variable cost of sales (8,000 × 60)	4,80,000
Contribution	**3,20,000**
Less: Fixed manufacturing overhead	1,50,000
Less: Fixed selling & admin overhead	50,000
Profit	**1,20,000**

(Closing stock here is valued at 2,000 × ₹60 = ₹1,20,000 — no fixed cost inside it.)

(B) Absorption costing statement — stock valued at full cost (₹75); fixed manufacturing OH flows through cost of goods sold.

Absorption costing	₹
Sales (8,000 × 100)	8,00,000
Cost of goods produced (10,000 × 75)	7,50,000
Less: Closing stock (2,000 × 75)	1,50,000
Cost of goods sold	6,00,000
Gross profit	**2,00,000**
Less: Fixed selling & admin overhead	50,000
Under/over absorption of fixed OH	Nil
Profit	**1,50,000**

(Absorbed fixed OH = 10,000 × 15 = ₹1,50,000 = actual fixed OH, so there is no under/over-absorption. Closing stock now carries 2,000 × ₹75 = ₹1,50,000, of which 2,000 × ₹15 = ₹30,000 is fixed overhead.)

(C) Reconciliation. Difference in profit = 1,50,000 − 1,20,000 = **₹30,000**, absorption being higher.

Reconciliation	₹
Profit as per marginal costing	1,20,000
Add: Fixed manufacturing OH carried forward in closing stock (2,000 × 15)	30,000
Profit as per absorption costing	**1,50,000**

Why absorption shows more profit here. Production (10,000) exceeded sales (8,000). Under absorption costing, ₹30,000 of this year's fixed overhead is "parked" inside the 2,000 unsold units and pushed into *next* year, so only ₹1,20,000 of fixed manufacturing OH is charged against this year's sales. Marginal costing refuses to park anything — it charges the full ₹1,50,000 now. Hence the ₹30,000 gap.

The rule that saves exam time: - Production > Sales (stock rises) → **Absorption profit > Marginal profit.** - Production < Sales (stock falls) → **Absorption profit < Marginal profit** (fixed OH from *last* year's stock is released into this year's cost of sales). - Production = Sales (no stock change) → **Profits are equal.**

Year-2 continuation — where the trap really bites. Suppose in Year 2 Sunrise *produces* 7,000 units but *sells* 9,000 (drawing down the 2,000 opening stock to zero). Same prices and costs; assume normal capacity is still 10,000 units so the absorption rate stays ₹15.

- *Marginal Year 2:* Contribution = 9,000 × (100 − 60) = 3,60,000; less fixed 1,50,000 + 50,000 = **profit ₹1,60,000.**
- *Absorption Year 2:* Opening stock carries ₹15 fixed OH per unit; selling those units *releases* that parked overhead into this year's cost of sales. Stock fell by 2,000 units, so absorption profit is **lower** than marginal by 2,000 × ₹15 = ₹30,000 → **profit ₹1,30,000.** *But note* production (7,000) is below normal (10,000), so fixed OH is **under-absorbed** by (10,000 − 7,000) × 15 = ₹45,000, which must be charged to Year 2 as well. A full absorption statement here would show gross profit reduced by that under-absorption. The teaching point: when production ≠ normal capacity, absorption profit carries a *second* adjustment — under/over-absorption — on top of the stock-movement effect. Marginal costing has neither.

- *Two-year total check:* Over Years 1+2, total produced = 17,000, total sold = 17,000, closing stock nil. Both methods must report the *same* cumulative profit. Marginal total = 1,20,000 + 1,60,000 = ₹2,80,000. Absorption total must also be ₹2,80,000 once Year 2's under-absorption and stock release are correctly booked — the ₹30,000 that absorption "gained" in Year 1 is exactly given back in Year 2. This is the deepest lesson of the chapter: the methods differ only in *timing*, never in *lifetime* profit.

Examiner tweak — actual fixed OH ≠ absorbed. If actual fixed manufacturing OH had been ₹1,60,000 while ₹1,50,000 was absorbed (on 10,000 units at ₹15), the ₹10,000 shortfall is **under-absorption**, charged to the absorption P&L, cutting absorption profit to ₹1,40,000. Marginal costing is *unaffected* — it never had a rate to over- or under-recover; it simply charges the actual ₹1,60,000 to the period. The reconciliation then has two lines: +₹30,000 fixed OH in closing stock, and the under-absorption sits only on the absorption side. Always separate the *stock-movement* effect from the *under/over-absorption* effect; they are different animals.

Example 3 — Limiting (key) factor and best product mix *(exam-hard)*

Data. Trident Ltd makes three products, A, B and C, all on the same machine. Machine capacity is limited to **20,000 machine hours** this year. Fixed costs are ₹1,00,000.

Per unit	A	B	C
Selling price (₹)	100	90	160
Variable cost (₹)	60	60	100
Machine hours per unit	2	1	4
Maximum market demand (units)	5,000	6,000	3,000

Determine the product mix that maximises profit, and compute that profit.

Step 1 — The trap: do NOT rank by contribution per unit. Contribution per unit: A = 40, B = 30, C = 60. Ranked this way, C looks best. **This is wrong.** When machine hours are the bottleneck, the scarce resource is *machine hours*, not units. The right question is *"which product wrings the most contribution out of each scarce hour?"*

Step 2 — Rank by contribution per unit of the limiting factor (machine hour).

	A	B	C
Contribution per unit (₹)	40	30	60
Machine hours per unit	2	1	4
Contribution per machine hour (₹)	**20**	**30**	**15**
Rank	**2**	**1**	**3**

B, the product with the *lowest* contribution per unit, is actually the **best** — it earns ₹30 of contribution from every scarce hour, twice what C manages.

Step 3 — Allocate the 20,000 hours by rank, respecting demand ceilings.

Rank	Product	Units (up to demand)	Hours used	Hours left
1	B	6,000	6,000 × 1 = 6,000	14,000
2	A	5,000	5,000 × 2 = 10,000	4,000
3	C	4,000 hrs ÷ 4 = 1,000	4,000	0

B and A are made to full demand; C absorbs only the leftover 4,000 hours, giving 1,000 units (against demand of 3,000).

Step 4 — Total contribution and profit.

Product	Units	Contribution/unit (₹)	Total contribution (₹)
B	6,000	30	1,80,000
A	5,000	40	2,00,000
C	1,000	60	60,000
Total contribution			**4,40,000**
Less: Fixed cost			1,00,000
Profit			**3,40,000**

Proof that this mix is optimal. Suppose we had (wrongly) prioritised C. Making C to full demand (3,000 units) would eat 12,000 hours, leaving 8,000 hours. Those 8,000 would go to B (6,000 hrs, 6,000 units) then A (2,000 hrs, 1,000 units). Contribution = C 1,80,000 + B 1,80,000 + A 40,000 = ₹4,00,000 — **₹40,000 worse.** The limiting-factor ranking wins by exactly the contribution/hour logic.

Examiner tweak 1 — a minimum-supply contract. Suppose Trident has *contracted* to supply at least 2,000 units of C regardless of profitability. Reserve those first: C 2,000 units × 4 hrs = 8,000 hours, contribution 2,000 × 60 = 1,20,000. That leaves 12,000 hours for free allocation by rank: B 6,000 units (6,000 hrs), then A 3,000 units (6,000 hrs) — A now capped by *hours*, not demand (only 3,000 of its 5,000 demand met). Contribution = C 1,20,000 + B 1,80,000 + A 1,20,000 = ₹4,20,000; profit ₹3,20,000. The lesson: a contractual minimum is carved out *before* ranking, and it *costs* you — here ₹20,000 of profit — which is the price of the commitment.

Examiner tweak 2 — two limiting factors at once. If, besides 20,000 machine hours, material were also capped (say each unit needs kilograms of a rationed input), a simple ranking no longer works because the best product on *hours* may be the worst on *material*. The problem becomes **linear programming** — formulate an objective (maximise total contribution) subject to both constraints, and solve graphically (two products) or by simplex. For CA Intermediate, recognise the *trigger* — "two or more binding constraints" means single-factor ranking fails and LP is required — even if the full LP solution is beyond this paper.

Examiner tweak 3 — a "make or buy the shortfall" option. If C could be *bought in* at ₹150 to meet its unmet demand of 2,000 units, compare the buy-in cost (₹150) with C's own variable cost (₹100). The extra ₹50 per unit is the price of relieving the bottleneck; buy in only if the contribution earned by *not* diverting machine hours to make C exceeds that ₹50 premium. This links limiting-factor analysis straight to the make-or-buy logic of Section 8.

Example 4 — Two-period data, missing fixed cost, and P/V-ratio inference *(exam-hard, no per-unit data)*

Data. Meridian Ltd gives only period totals — no selling price or unit cost is disclosed:

	Year 1	Year 2
Sales (₹)	12,00,000	15,00,000
Profit (₹)	1,50,000	2,40,000

Required: (a) P/V ratio; (b) total fixed cost; (c) break-even sales; (d) margin of safety in Year 2; (e) sales required for a profit of ₹3,00,000; (f) profit if sales fall to ₹10,00,000.

Step 1 — P/V ratio from the change (fixed cost cancels). Change in sales = 15,00,000 − 12,00,000 = 3,00,000. Change in profit = 2,40,000 − 1,50,000 = 90,000. P/V ratio = 90,000 ÷ 3,00,000 × 100 = **30%.**

Step 2 — Fixed cost (use either year; contribution − profit = fixed). Year 1 contribution = 12,00,000 × 0.30 = 3,60,000; fixed = 3,60,000 − 1,50,000 = **₹2,10,000.** *Self-check with Year 2:* 15,00,000 × 0.30 = 4,50,000 contribution; less fixed 2,10,000 = profit 2,40,000. ✓

Step 3 — Break-even sales. BEP = Fixed ÷ P/V ratio = 2,10,000 ÷ 0.30 = **₹7,00,000.**

Step 4 — Margin of safety, Year 2. MoS = 15,00,000 − 7,00,000 = **₹8,00,000** (MoS ratio = 8,00,000 ÷ 15,00,000 = 53.33%). *Self-check:* Profit = MoS × P/V ratio = 8,00,000 × 0.30 = 2,40,000. ✓

Step 5 — Sales for a profit of ₹3,00,000. Sales = (Fixed + target) ÷ P/V ratio = (2,10,000 + 3,00,000) ÷ 0.30 = 5,10,000 ÷ 0.30 = **₹17,00,000.**

Step 6 — Profit if sales fall to ₹10,00,000. Profit = Sales × P/V ratio − Fixed = 10,00,000 × 0.30 − 2,10,000 = 3,00,000 − 2,10,000 = **₹90,000.** *Self-check via MoS:* MoS = 10,00,000 − 7,00,000 = 3,00,000; × 0.30 = ₹90,000. ✓

Why this problem type matters. It tests whether you truly understand that the P/V ratio is a property of the *cost structure*, extractable from any two periods without a single per-unit figure, and that fixed cost then falls out as contribution minus profit. Candidates who can only work forward from per-unit data freeze here. The whole solution rests on one insight: *between two periods at constant prices and costs, the only thing that changes profit is the contribution on the extra sales* — so ΔProfit ÷ ΔSales must be the P/V ratio.

6. Presentation & Format — How to Lay It Out in the Exam

Always show the contribution line explicitly. In every marginal statement, the sequence is: Sales → less Variable cost → **Contribution** (a bolded subtotal) → less Fixed cost → Profit. Examiners award marks for the *structure*, not just the final number. Contrast this with the absorption format, which shows **Gross profit** (Sales − full cost of sales) and only then deducts non-manufacturing costs.

A clean comparative skeleton to reproduce:

Particulars	Marginal costing	Absorption costing
Stock valuation	Variable production cost only	Variable + fixed production cost
Fixed factory OH	Period cost — charged in full	Absorbed into units, part carried in stock
Sub-total highlighted	**Contribution**	**Gross profit**
Under/over-absorption	Does not arise	Must be shown and adjusted
Reporting acceptability	Internal decisions only	Required by AS 2 / Ind AS 2 for accounts
Profit driven by	**Sales** volume	Sales *and* production volume
Effect of building stock	No profit boost	Profit inflated (fixed OH deferred)

The last two rows are examinable theory in their own right. Because absorption profit rises when you merely *produce* more (parking fixed overhead in stock), it can be *manipulated* — a manager can flatter this year's profit by overproducing into inventory. Marginal costing removes the temptation: with fixed cost fully expensed each period, profit moves only when *sales* move. This "no incentive to overproduce" property is marginal costing's headline *advantage* for internal control, and a stock exam point.

For CVP answers, present formulas *before* substituting numbers, keep P/V ratio to two decimals, and *always* add a self-check line (e.g., "BEP units × price = BEP sales ✓"). State the units of your answer (units vs ₹) explicitly — a bare number loses marks. **For reconciliation**, the safest layout is a three-line bridge: start from one method's profit, add or subtract the fixed overhead in the *change* in stock, and arrive at the other method's profit — label the adjustment "Fixed OH in closing stock" or "...released from opening stock" so the examiner sees you understand *why*, not just *that*, they differ. **For limiting-factor problems**, the mark-scoring skeleton is: (i) identify the limiting factor, (ii) a table of contribution per unit of that factor, (iii) an explicit *ranking* row, (iv) an allocation table respecting demand ceilings and any minimum commitments, (v) a final contribution-and-profit statement. Missing the ranking row is the commonest way to lose method marks even with a correct final answer.

7. Connections — Where This Sits in the Syllabus

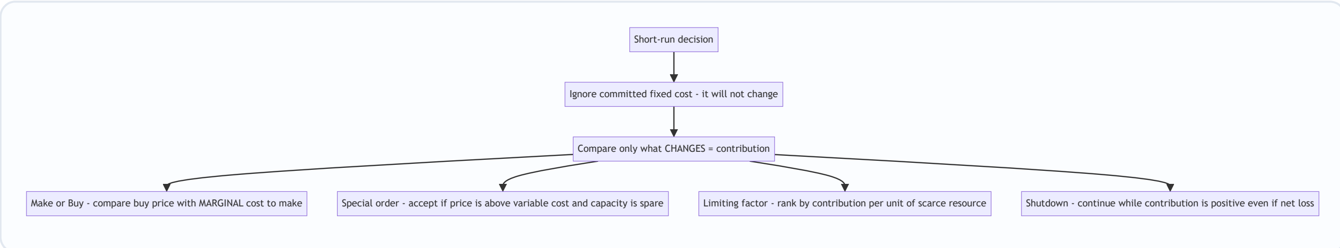
- **Overhead absorption (Ch. 4)** is marginal costing's mirror image. There you learned to *absorb* fixed factory overhead into units via a recovery rate; here you learn *why*, for decisions, you should *not*. The under/over-absorption you computed in Ch. 4 is exactly the quantity that vanishes under marginal costing — because there is no fixed rate to over- or under-recover. Example 2's "under-absorption" tweak is Chapter 4 living inside Chapter 14.
- **Standard costing & variances (Ch. 13)**: the **fixed overhead volume variance** exists *only* under absorption costing — it measures the effect of the very fixed-cost-in-units mechanism this chapter isolates. Under marginal standard costing, fixed overhead has only an *expenditure* variance, no volume variance. This chapter is the conceptual key to that difference.
- **Budgeting & flexible budgets (Ch. 15)**: a flexible budget *is* cost-behaviour analysis — it flexes variable cost with activity while holding fixed cost, precisely the split you make here. The **cash budget** connects to cash break-even.
- **Cost sheet (Ch. 6)** builds the total cost that this chapter warns you not to use for decisions.

- **Process costing & inventory valuation**: the choice of stock valuation base (variable vs full cost) that drives Example 2's profit gap is the same choice that would change closing WIP and finished-goods values in a process account — the ₹30,000 "in stock" is not academic; it changes the balance sheet.
- **Relevant costing / decision-making (advanced)**: make-or-buy, special orders and shutdown, worked in Section 8, are the foundation of the relevant-cost decisions you meet later — where **opportunity cost** (the contribution foregone on the best displaced alternative) and **avoidable fixed cost** extend the same contribution logic. When capacity is *full*, the special-order decision must add the opportunity cost of displaced regular sales — the bridge from this chapter to full relevant costing.

---

8. Decision-Making Applications — Contribution as the Universal Judge

Every short-run decision reduces to one test: **does this action increase total contribution, given that committed fixed costs will not change?** Here are the four classic exam decisions, each solved by that one idea.



Four different questions, one answer: choose the option that leaves total contribution highest, because fixed cost is a sunk backdrop.

Before the four decisions — the one qualifier that overrides them all: is there spare capacity? The clean "ignore fixed cost, chase contribution" rule assumes idle capacity, so that doing the new thing costs nothing you were already earning. The moment capacity is *full*, every new unit *displaces* an existing one, and the contribution given up on the displaced unit — the **opportunity cost** — must be charged against the new decision. Half the difficulty in exam decision questions is spotting that capacity is full and remembering to add opportunity cost. Read every decision problem asking first: *"Is capacity spare or full?"*

8.1 Make or Buy

Compare the outside buying price with the *marginal* (variable) cost of making — not the full cost. Fixed overhead already exists and is irrelevant *unless* making the part avoids a specific fixed cost or buying releases capacity for a more profitable use.

Example. A component's own cost sheet shows: material ₹8, labour ₹5, variable overhead ₹3, fixed overhead ₹4 → full cost ₹20. A supplier offers it at **₹18**. Naïve view: ₹18 < ₹20, so buy. **Wrong.** The relevant make cost is the *marginal* cost = 8 + 5 + 3 = **₹16**. The ₹4 fixed overhead continues whether you make or buy. Since ₹16 (make) < ₹18 (buy), **make it** — buying wastes ₹2 per unit. (You would only switch to buying if the ₹4 fixed cost were *actually avoidable* on outsourcing, or if the freed capacity earned more than ₹2/unit elsewhere.)

The two exceptions that flip the answer — examiners live here:

- **Avoidable fixed cost.** If, say, ₹3 of the ₹4 fixed overhead is a *dedicated* supervisor's salary that *ceases* on outsourcing, the true make cost is 16 + 3 = ₹19, now *above* the ₹18 buy price → **buy.** Only *avoidable* fixed cost enters the comparison; the unavoidable ₹1 stays out.

- **Opportunity cost of freed capacity.** If making the part ties up a machine that could otherwise earn ₹5 per part-equivalent of contribution making something else, add that ₹5 to the make cost (16 + 5 = ₹21 > 18) → **buy**, and redeploy the capacity. When capacity is spare and nothing else needs it, opportunity cost is zero and this term vanishes.

The general make-or-buy rule, stated fully: **make if [marginal cost to make + avoidable fixed cost + opportunity cost of capacity used] < buy-in price.**

8.2 Accept or Reject a Special Order

Accept any special order priced above variable cost, provided (i) there is spare capacity and (ii) it will not spoil the regular-market price. Every rupee above variable cost is extra contribution against unchanged fixed cost.

Example. Normal price ₹50, variable cost ₹30, fixed cost per unit ₹15 (full cost ₹45). A one-off export order arrives at **₹35** for 4,000 units; the plant has idle capacity and the export market is separate. Full-cost thinking says ₹35 < ₹45 → reject. **Wrong.** Contribution per unit = 35 − 30 = **₹5.** Extra contribution = 4,000 × 5 = **₹20,000**, all of it additional profit because fixed cost is unchanged. **Accept.**

Examiner tweak — capacity is full. Suppose the plant is at capacity, so making 4,000 export units means selling 4,000 fewer at the regular ₹50 (contribution ₹20 each). The opportunity cost = 4,000 × 20 = ₹80,000, far above the ₹20,000 the export order brings → **reject.** The decision flips entirely on the capacity question. Always compute the *net* effect: extra contribution from the order minus contribution lost on displaced sales.

Examiner tweak — an extra fixed cost to fulfil the order. If accepting the export order requires ₹12,000 of special packaging or a new mould (a fixed cost incurred *only because of this order*), it becomes relevant: net gain = 20,000 − 12,000 = ₹8,000 → still accept, but the margin is thinner. An order-specific fixed cost, unlike committed fixed cost, *is* relevant because it would not exist without the decision.

The non-financial trap. Even when the numbers say accept, flag qualitative factors an examiner rewards: will the low export price leak back and undercut the ₹50 home market? Will regular customers demand the same discount? Is the buyer a long-term prospect or a one-off? A complete answer states the financial recommendation *and* these caveats.

8.3 Shutdown or Continue

A product or department showing a *net loss* need not be closed. **Continue as long as it earns positive contribution**, because that contribution helps pay fixed costs that would otherwise fall on the rest of the business. Compare the contribution earned against the fixed costs *actually saved* by closing.

Example. A division: sales ₹5,00,000, variable cost ₹3,50,000, fixed cost ₹2,00,000 → **net loss ₹50,000.** Closing it would save only ₹80,000 of the fixed cost (the rest — ₹1,20,000 of head-office and unavoidable charges — continues regardless). Contribution while running = 5,00,000 − 3,50,000 = **₹1,50,000.** If we *continue*: loss = ₹50,000 (as above). If we *shut down*: we lose the ₹1,50,000 contribution but save ₹80,000 fixed → net position = −1,20,000 (unavoidable fixed) + 80,000 saved... i.e., loss = **₹1,20,000.** Continuing loses ₹50,000; shutting down loses ₹1,20,000. **Keep it running** — it is absorbing ₹1,50,000 of fixed cost that would otherwise land elsewhere. The **shutdown point** is where contribution just equals the avoidable fixed cost; below that, close.

The formal shutdown rule and its extra costs. Continue while **Contribution > Avoidable fixed cost.** But a real shutdown decision also weighs:

- **Additional shutdown costs** — redundancy payments, penalties for breaking supply contracts, the cost of protecting idle plant. These make closing *more* expensive and tilt toward continuing.
- **Restart costs** — if the closure is temporary (a seasonal slump), re-recruiting and re-commissioning later may cost more than the loss avoided. Compare the contribution foregone during closure against the shutdown-plus-restart cost.
- **Qualitative factors** — losing skilled workers, market presence, and customer goodwill; the effect on morale of remaining staff. A product kept alive at break-even contribution may still be worth it to hold a market position.

So the exam-complete rule: shut down only if avoidable fixed cost saved *exceeds* (contribution lost + any incremental shutdown/restart costs), and only if qualitative factors do not override.

8.4 Product mix under a limiting factor

Fully worked in **Example 3** above, with three examiner tweaks (minimum-supply contracts, two simultaneous constraints → linear programming, and buy-in of the bottleneck shortfall): rank by **contribution per unit of the scarce resource**, then allocate the scarce resource top-rank first up to demand. This is the single most-tested decision in the chapter. The one non-negotiable step is *ranking by contribution per unit of the limiting factor*, never by contribution per unit of product.

8.5 Pricing floors and the danger of marginal-cost pricing

A recurring decision is *how low can price go?* Marginal costing gives the *absolute short-run floor*: any price above variable cost adds contribution. But three cautions, each an exam point:

- The floor is a **short-run, spare-capacity** floor. Set as a *permanent* price it guarantees losses, because fixed cost is never recovered. Long-run price must cover *total* cost plus a margin.
- Pricing at marginal cost in one market while charging full price in another (price discrimination, e.g., exports vs home) works only if the markets are genuinely **separable** — otherwise the low price contaminates the high one.
- In a **recession or to keep a plant running**, accepting orders at or slightly above marginal cost can be rational *temporarily* — the contribution reduces the loss versus idling — but the firm must have a plan to return to full-cost pricing.

---

9. First-Principles Recap — Rebuild the Chapter From One Sentence

Start with the sentence that generates everything: **"Only costs that change should decide an action."**

1. Costs come in two behaviours: **variable** (change with each unit) and **fixed** (unchanged in the period). A decision reacts only to the first. (And "fixed" itself hides committed, discretionary and stepped sub-types — only the *committed* kind is safely ignorable.)
2. So define **marginal cost** = variable cost of one more unit, and **contribution** = selling price − variable cost. Contribution is what each sale throws into a pool.
3. The pool has one job first — **cover fixed cost** — and only then does it become **profit**. Hence *Contribution = Fixed cost + Profit*.
4. Set profit to zero and the pool must just equal fixed cost: that is **break-even**. Express contribution as a rate of sales — the **P/V ratio** — and break-even in rupees falls out as Fixed ÷ P/V ratio. (The P/V ratio

depends only on price and variable cost, so any two periods reveal it and fixed cost cannot touch it.)

5. The distance above break-even is the **margin of safety**, and because fixed cost is already paid there, all of it converts to profit at the P/V rate.
6. Raise the hurdle from "fixed cost" to "fixed cost + desired profit" and you get **target-profit** sales.
7. Because fixed cost is a period lump, marginal costing keeps it *out of stock*; absorption costing pushes it *into stock*. That single divergence makes their profits differ by exactly *the fixed overhead sitting in the change in inventory* — which is why they **reconcile** to the rupee, and why over the whole life of the business their *total* profits are identical.
8. Every decision — make/buy, special order, product mix, shutdown, pricing floor — is then the same move: **pick the option that leaves total contribution highest, ignoring the fixed cost that will not move** — *unless capacity is full, in which case charge the opportunity cost of what you displace, and unless a fixed cost is genuinely avoidable or order-specific, in which case it does change and counts.*

If you can regenerate the formulas from those eight steps, you never need to memorise a single one. The two escape hatches in step 8 — opportunity cost when capacity is full, avoidable/specific fixed cost — are where the hard marks live.

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

#	Concept	Formula
1	Marginal cost	DM + DL + Direct expenses + Variable overhead
2	Contribution per unit	Selling price − Variable cost per unit
3	Total contribution	Sales − Variable cost = Fixed cost + Profit
4	Profit	Contribution − Fixed cost
5	P/V ratio	(Contribution ÷ Sales) × 100 = (Contribution per unit ÷ SP) × 100
6	P/V ratio (two periods)	(Change in profit ÷ Change in sales) × 100
7	Variable-cost ratio	(Variable cost ÷ Sales) × 100 = 100% − P/V ratio
8	Break-even (units)	Fixed cost ÷ Contribution per unit
9	Break-even (₹)	Fixed cost ÷ P/V ratio
10	Cash break-even (units)	(Fixed cost − Non-cash fixed cost) ÷ Contribution per unit
11	Margin of safety (₹)	Actual sales − Break-even sales = Profit ÷ P/V ratio
12	MoS ratio	(MoS ÷ Actual sales) × 100 = Profit ÷ Contribution
13	Profit (general)	(Sales × P/V ratio) − Fixed cost = MoS × P/V ratio
14	Profit as % of sales	P/V ratio × MoS ratio
15	Units for target profit	(Fixed cost + Target profit) ÷ Contribution per unit
16	Sales for target profit	(Fixed cost + Target profit) ÷ P/V ratio
17	Sales for profit = x% of sales	Fixed cost ÷ (P/V ratio − required % of sales)
18	Pre-tax profit from after-tax	After-tax profit ÷ (1 − tax rate)
19	Composite P/V ratio	(Total contribution ÷ Total sales) × 100
20	Composite BEP (₹)	Total fixed cost ÷ Composite P/V ratio
21	High-low variable cost/unit	(Cost at high − Cost at low) ÷ (High units − Low units)
22	Absorption vs marginal profit gap	Fixed OH per unit × Change in stock units (production − sales)
23	Make-or-buy rule	Make if buying price > [marginal cost + avoidable fixed + opportunity cost] to make
24	Special-order rule	Accept if price > variable cost per unit, given spare capacity (add opportunity cost if full)
25	Limiting-factor ranking	Rank by Contribution per unit of the limiting factor
26	Shutdown rule	Continue while Contribution > Avoidable fixed cost (net of shutdown/restart costs)

Profit-comparison memory hook: Production **>** Sales → Absorption **>** Marginal; Production **<** Sales → Absorption **<** Marginal; Production **=** Sales → equal. (Over the whole life of the business, the two methods report the *same* total profit — they differ only in *timing*.)

Capacity checklist before any decision: (1) Spare capacity? → chase contribution, ignore committed fixed cost. (2) Full capacity? → add opportunity cost of displaced sales. (3) Any *avoidable* or *order-specific* fixed cost? → it becomes relevant. (4) Any qualitative factor (market spoilage, goodwill, staff)? → state it.

The one line that regenerates the chapter: *Contribution = Fixed cost + Profit — cover the fixed hurdle first, then earn; and in every decision, chase the option that grows contribution, because fixed cost has already made up its mind — unless capacity is full or a fixed cost is truly avoidable, the two cases where the backdrop moves.*

Q&A — Marginal Costing & CVP Analysis

CA Intermediate • Cost & Management Accounting • ICAI syllabus • All figures in Rupees (₹)

Section A — Concept-Check (Short Q&A)

A1. Define marginal cost. Marginal cost is the aggregate of variable costs — i.e., the additional cost incurred to produce one more unit of output (Prime cost + Variable overheads). Fixed cost does not form part of marginal cost.

A2. What is "contribution" and why is it central to marginal costing? Contribution = Sales − Variable cost = Fixed cost + Profit. It is the amount that first "contributes" towards recovering fixed cost, and thereafter becomes profit. Since fixed cost is a period cost, only contribution reflects the true incremental gain of an extra unit — hence it drives all short-run decisions.

A3. Distinguish product fixed overhead from period fixed overhead treatment. Under **absorption costing**, fixed production overhead is treated as a **product cost** — absorbed into units and carried in closing stock. Under **marginal costing**, fixed overhead is a **period cost** — charged wholly to the period's P&L, never carried in stock.

A4. Write the P/V ratio formula (three forms). P/V ratio = (Contribution ÷ Sales) × 100 = (Change in profit ÷ Change in sales) × 100 = (Contribution per unit ÷ Selling price per unit) × 100.

A5. What is the "angle of incidence" on a break-even chart? It is the angle formed at the BEP between the sales line and the total cost line. A **larger angle** indicates a higher rate of profit earning after break-even (high P/V ratio); a narrow angle signals low profitability.

A6. Give the cash break-even point formula and state its use. Cash BEP (units) = Cash fixed cost ÷ Contribution per unit, where cash fixed cost = Total fixed cost − non-cash items (e.g., depreciation). It shows the volume at which cash inflows just cover cash fixed outflows — useful for liquidity/survival analysis.

A7. Why does profit differ under marginal vs absorption costing? Profit differs only because of the **fixed overhead carried in the change of stock**. Difference = Change in stock units × Fixed OH rate per unit. If production > sales (stock rises), absorption profit > marginal profit, and vice-versa.

A8. State the limiting-factor (key-factor) decision rule. When a resource is scarce, rank products by **contribution per unit of the limiting factor** (not per unit of product), and allocate the scarce resource to the highest-ranking product first.

Section B — Graded Computational Problems

B1 (Easy) — Basic CVP toolkit

Selling price ₹50/unit; variable cost ₹30/unit; fixed cost ₹2,00,000. Find contribution/unit, P/V ratio, BEP (units & ₹), and profit at 15,000 units.

Solution. - Contribution/unit = 50 − 30 = **₹20** - P/V ratio = 20 ÷ 50 = **40%** - BEP (units) = 2,00,000 ÷ 20 = **10,000 units** - BEP (₹) = 2,00,000 ÷ 0.40 = **₹5,00,000** (check: 10,000 × 50 ✓) - Profit at 15,000 units = (15,000 × 20) − 2,00,000 = 3,00,000 − 2,00,000 = **₹1,00,000**

B2 (Easy-Moderate) — Margin of safety & target profit

Same data as B1. (a) Find MoS at 15,000 units in units, ₹ and %. (b) Units required for a target profit of ₹1,60,000.

Solution. (a) MoS (units) = Actual − BEP = 15,000 − 10,000 = **5,000 units** MoS (₹) = 5,000 × 50 = **₹2,50,000**; MoS % = 5,000 ÷ 15,000 = **33.33%** Check: Profit = MoS × Contribution/unit = 5,000 × 20 = ₹1,00,000 ✓ (ties to B1) (b) Units = (Fixed cost + Target profit) ÷ Contribution/unit = (2,00,000 + 1,60,000) ÷ 20 = 3,60,000 ÷ 20 = **18,000 units** Sales value = 18,000 × 50 = **₹9,00,000**

B3 (Moderate) — After-tax target profit

Fixed cost ₹4,50,000; P/V ratio 30%; tax rate 40%. Find sales (₹) needed for an **after-tax** profit of ₹90,000.

Solution. - Pre-tax profit required = 90,000 ÷ (1 − 0.40) = 90,000 ÷ 0.60 = **₹1,50,000** - Required contribution = Fixed cost + Pre-tax profit = 4,50,000 + 1,50,000 = ₹6,00,000 - Sales = Contribution ÷ P/V ratio = 6,00,000 ÷ 0.30 = **₹20,00,000** Check: Contribution 6,00,000 − Fixed 4,50,000 = 1,50,000 pre-tax; after 40% tax = 90,000 ✓

B4 (Moderate) — P/V ratio & fixed cost from two periods (high-low logic)

Year	Sales (₹)	Profit (₹)
2024	12,00,000	60,000
2025	15,00,000	1,50,000

Find P/V ratio, fixed cost, BEP, and MoS for 2025.

Solution. - P/V ratio = Δ Profit ÷ Δ Sales = (1,50,000 − 60,000) ÷ (15,00,000 − 12,00,000) = 90,000 ÷ 3,00,000 = **30%** - Contribution 2024 = 12,00,000 × 30% = 3,60,000 → Fixed cost = 3,60,000 − 60,000 = **₹3,00,000** Verify with 2025: 15,00,000 × 30% = 4,50,000 − 3,00,000 = 1,50,000 profit ✓ - BEP (₹) = 3,00,000 ÷ 0.30 = **₹10,00,000** - MoS 2025 = 15,00,000 − 10,00,000 = **₹5,00,000** (33.33% of sales)

B5 (Exam-Hard) — Marginal vs Absorption reconciliation

Data (per unit): Selling price ₹200; Direct material ₹60; Direct labour ₹40; Variable production OH ₹20; Variable selling OH ₹10. Fixed production OH ₹6,00,000; Fixed selling & admin ₹1,50,000. Normal/actual output = 30,000 units; **Production = 30,000 units, Sales = 25,000 units.** No opening stock. Fixed OH absorption rate based on normal output.

Prepare both profit statements and reconcile.

Solution.

Fixed production OH rate = 6,00,000 ÷ 30,000 = ₹20/unit.

Marginal Costing Statement | Particulars | ₹ | |---|---| | Sales (25,000 × 200) | 50,00,000 | | Less: Variable cost of sales (25,000 × 120*) | 30,00,000 | | Less: Variable selling OH (25,000 × 10) | 2,50,000 | | Contribution | 17,50,000 | | Less: Fixed production OH | 6,00,000 | | Less: Fixed selling & admin | 1,50,000 | | Profit (Marginal) | 10,00,000* |

*Variable production cost/unit = 60 + 40 + 20 = ₹120.

Absorption Costing Statement | Particulars | ₹ | |---|---| | Sales (25,000 × 200) | 50,00,000 | | Less: Production cost of sales (25,000 × 140) **| 35,00,000 | | Add: (no under/over absorption — prod = normal) | 0 | |** Gross profit **|** 15,00,000 **| | Less: Variable selling OH (25,000 × 10) | 2,50,000 | | Less: Fixed selling & admin | 1,50,000 | |** Profit (Absorption) **|** 11,00,000** |

**Full production cost/unit = 120 + 20 (fixed OH) = ₹140.

Reconciliation | Particulars | ₹ | |---|---| | Profit under Marginal costing | 10,00,000 | | Add: Fixed OH in closing stock (5,000 units × ₹20) | 1,00,000 | | **Profit under Absorption costing | 11,00,000** |

Closing stock = Production − Sales = 30,000 − 25,000 = 5,000 units. Absorption profit is higher by ₹1,00,000 because that fixed OH is deferred in stock rather than expensed. **Statements tie.** ✓

B6 (Exam-Hard) — Limiting-factor product mix

Three products; machine hours are the limiting factor (only 40,000 hrs available). Max demand: P 8,000; Q 10,000; R 6,000 units.

	P	Q	R
Selling price/unit (₹)	120	90	150
Variable cost/unit (₹)	72	54	84
Machine hrs/unit	4	2	6

Determine the optimum product mix and maximum contribution.

Solution.

Step 1 — Contribution per unit: - P = 120 − 72 = ₹48; Q = 90 − 54 = ₹36; R = 150 − 84 = ₹66

Step 2 — Contribution per machine hour (the limiting factor): - P = 48 ÷ 4 = **₹12** (Rank III) - Q = 36 ÷ 2 = **₹18** (Rank I) - R = 66 ÷ 6 = **₹11** (Rank II by product? No —)

Recheck ranking: Q ₹18 > P ₹12 > R ₹11. So **Rank I = Q, Rank II = P, Rank III = R.**

Step 3 — Allocate 40,000 hrs by rank: | Product | Units (max demand) | Hrs/unit | Hrs used | Contribution (₹) | |---|---|---|---|---| | Q (I) | 10,000 | 2 | 20,000 | 3,60,000 | | P (II) | 5,000 | *4 | 20,000 | 2,40,000 | | R (III) | 0 | 6 | 0 | 0 | | Total | | | 40,000 | 6,00,000** |

*After Q uses 20,000 hrs, remaining = 20,000 hrs → P can make 20,000 ÷ 4 = 5,000 units (below its 8,000 max). Nothing left for R.

Optimum mix: Q 10,000 units + P 5,000 units; maximum contribution = ₹6,00,000. (Contribution per hour ranking maximises total contribution given the hour constraint.) ✓

Section C — Past-Paper-Style Full Questions

C1. CVP with margin of safety and desired profit

A company sells a single product at ₹80/unit. Variable cost is ₹48/unit and annual fixed cost ₹6,40,000. Required: (i) BEP in units and value; (ii) sales to earn ₹2,40,000 profit; (iii) profit at 90% of a 40,000-unit capacity; (iv) new BEP if fixed cost rises by ₹80,000.

Model Answer. - Contribution/unit = 80 − 48 = ₹32; P/V ratio = 32/80 = 40% - (i) BEP = 6,40,000 ÷ 32 = **20,000 units**; value = 20,000 × 80 = **₹16,00,000** - (ii) Units = (6,40,000 + 2,40,000) ÷ 32 = 8,80,000 ÷ 32 = **27,500 units** → ₹22,00,000 - (iii) 90% of 40,000 = 36,000 units. Profit = 36,000 × 32 − 6,40,000 = 11,52,000 − 6,40,000 = **₹5,12,000** - (iv) New fixed cost = 7,20,000 → BEP = 7,20,000 ÷ 32 = **22,500 units**

C2. Make-or-buy decision

A firm makes a component at variable cost ₹34/unit; fixed cost ₹1,20,000 p.a. is presently absorbed at ₹8/unit (15,000 units). A supplier offers the component at ₹40/unit. Advise, if (a) fixed costs are unavoidable, (b) ₹90,000 of the fixed cost is avoidable on buying.

Model Answer. Relevant comparison uses only **avoidable** costs. - (a) Make = variable ₹34; Buy = ₹40. Fixed ₹1,20,000 is unavoidable, so irrelevant. Extra cost to buy = (40 − 34) × 15,000 = **₹90,000 higher** → **Make** in-house. - (b) Buying saves ₹90,000 avoidable fixed cost. Buy cost = 15,000 × 40 = 6,00,000. Make cost = 15,000 × 34 + 90,000 avoidable fixed = 5,10,000 + 90,000 = 6,00,000. Costs are **equal (₹6,00,000)** → indifferent; decide on qualitative factors (quality, supply reliability, spare capacity use).

C3. Special order (accept/reject)

Normal output 50,000 units; capacity 65,000 units. Selling price ₹100; variable cost ₹60; fixed cost ₹15,00,000. An export order for 12,000 units at ₹75/unit arrives, requiring ₹40,000 special packing. Should it be accepted? (Home market unaffected.)

Model Answer. Spare capacity = 65,000 − 50,000 = 15,000 units ≥ 12,000 → order fits without displacing regular sales; fixed cost already covered. - Incremental revenue = 12,000 × 75 = 9,00,000 - Incremental variable cost = 12,000 × 60 = 7,20,000 - Special packing = 40,000 - **Incremental contribution/profit = 9,00,000 − 7,20,000 − 40,000 = ₹1,40,000** Since incremental profit is **positive**, **accept** the order. (Note: ₹75 > variable cost ₹60, so each unit contributes ₹15 before special cost.)

C4. Shutdown decision

A division's data (per year): Sales ₹8,00,000; Variable cost ₹5,60,000; Fixed cost ₹3,00,000 (of which ₹1,10,000 continues even if shut down). Advise whether to continue.

Model Answer. - Contribution = 8,00,000 − 5,60,000 = ₹2,40,000 - If operating: loss = Contribution − Fixed = 2,40,000 − 3,00,000 = **(₹60,000) loss** - If shut down: loss = unavoidable (committed) fixed cost = **(₹1,10,000)** - Contribution ₹2,40,000 exceeds avoidable fixed cost (3,00,000 − 1,10,000 = ₹1,90,000) by ₹50,000. **Continue operating** — shutting down worsens the loss by ₹50,000 (₹1,10,000 vs ₹60,000). Shutdown point sales = 1,90,000 ÷ P/V ratio (30%) = ₹6,33,333; current sales exceed it.

Section D — MCQs & Case Scenarios

D1. If P/V ratio is 25% and fixed cost ₹5,00,000, BEP sales value is — (a) ₹12,50,000 (b) ₹20,00,000 (c) ₹1,25,000 (d) ₹6,25,000 **Answer: (b).** BEP = Fixed ÷ P/V = 5,00,000 ÷ 0.25 = ₹20,00,000.

D2. When production exceeds sales, absorption-costing profit will be — (a) lower than marginal (b) equal to marginal (c) higher than marginal (d) always zero **Answer: (c).** Rising stock defers fixed OH, so absorption profit is higher.

D3. Margin of safety can be increased by — (a) raising fixed cost (b) lowering selling price (c) increasing P/V ratio (d) reducing volume **Answer: (c).** A higher P/V ratio lowers BEP, widening the margin of safety.

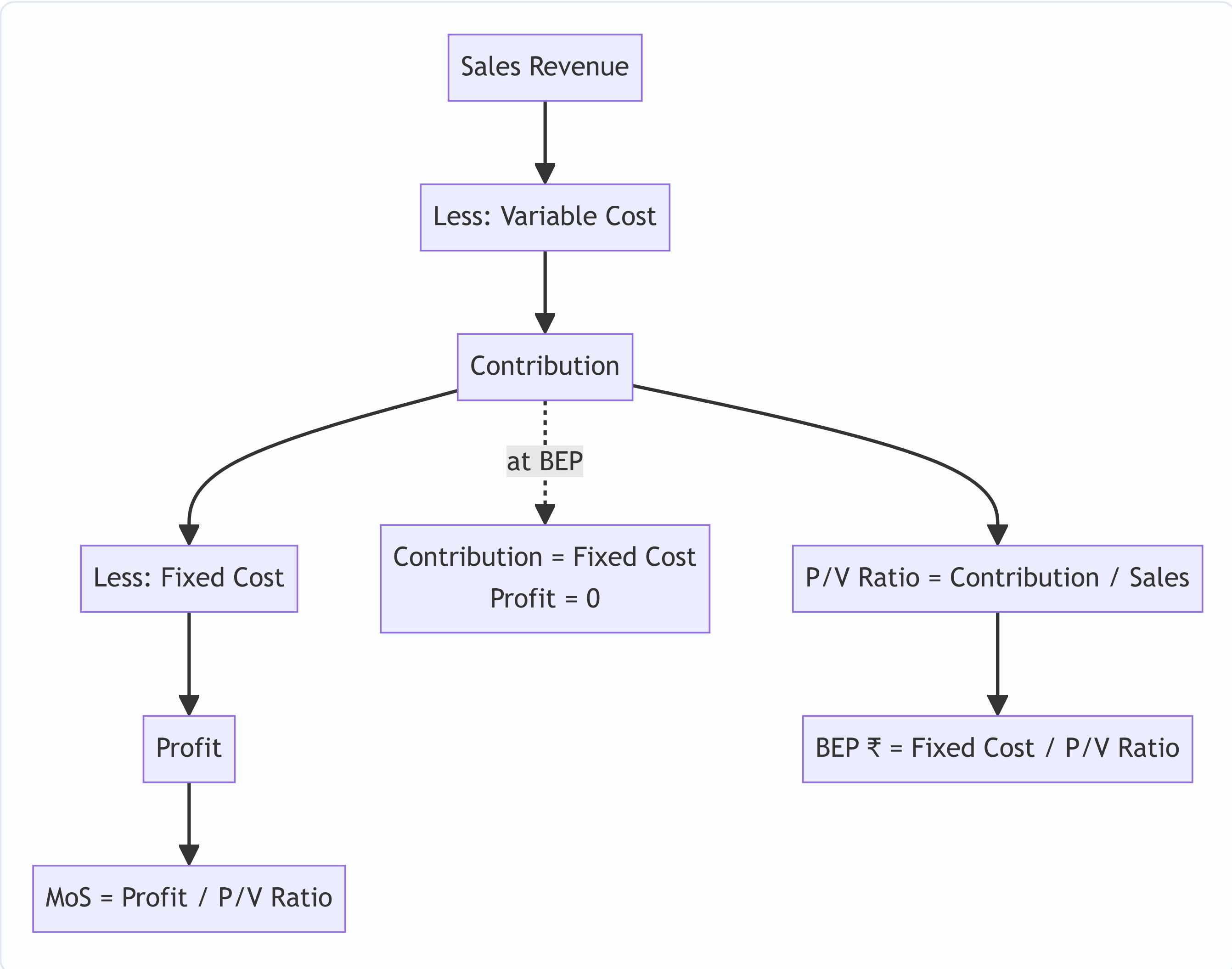
D4. Contribution per unit ₹40; fixed cost ₹4,00,000; desired profit ₹1,00,000. Required units — (a) 10,000 (b) 12,500 (c) 7,500 (d) 15,000 **Answer: (b).** (4,00,000 + 1,00,000) ÷ 40 = 12,500 units.

D5. The angle of incidence being wide indicates — (a) high fixed cost (b) high rate of profit after BEP (c) low P/V ratio (d) loss zone **Answer: (b).** A wider angle = faster profit accumulation beyond break-even.

D6 (Case). A firm has P/V ratio 40%, MoS 25%, sales ₹20,00,000. Find profit and fixed cost. **Answer.** Contribution = 20,00,000 × 40% = ₹8,00,000. Profit = MoS × P/V = (25% × 20,00,000) × 40% = 5,00,000 × 40% = **₹2,00,000**. Fixed cost = Contribution − Profit = 8,00,000 − 2,00,000 = **₹6,00,000**. (Check BEP = 6,00,000 ÷ 0.40 = ₹15,00,000; MoS = 20,00,000 − 15,00,000 = ₹5,00,000 = 25% ✓)

D7 (Case). Cash fixed cost ₹3,60,000, total fixed cost includes ₹90,000 depreciation, contribution/unit ₹30. Cash BEP = **Answer.** Cash fixed cost given = ₹3,60,000; Cash BEP = 3,60,000 ÷ 30 = **12,000 units**. (Cash BEP < accounting BEP of (3,60,000+90,000)/30 = 15,000 units, since non-cash depreciation is excluded.)

Quick Visual — CVP Structure



One-Page Formula Recall (self-check)

#	Item	Formula
1	Contribution	Sales − Variable cost = Fixed + Profit
2	Contribution/unit	SP/unit − VC/unit
3	P/V ratio	Contribution ÷ Sales
4	P/V (from changes)	Δ Contribution ÷ Δ Sales
5	BEP (units)	Fixed cost ÷ Contribution per unit
6	BEP (₹)	Fixed cost ÷ P/V ratio
7	Cash BEP	Cash fixed cost ÷ Contribution per unit
8	Margin of safety (₹)	Actual sales − BEP sales = Profit ÷ P/V
9	MoS ratio	MoS ÷ Actual sales
10	Profit	(Sales × P/V) − Fixed cost = MoS × P/V
11	Required units (target)	(Fixed + Target profit) ÷ Contribution/unit
12	Required sales (target)	(Fixed + Target profit) ÷ P/V ratio
13	Pre-tax profit	After-tax profit ÷ (1 − tax rate)
14	Sales for after-tax profit	(Fixed + Pre-tax profit) ÷ P/V
15	Composite BEP (₹)	Total fixed cost ÷ Composite P/V ratio
16	Composite P/V	Total contribution ÷ Total sales (all products)
17	Limiting-factor rank	Contribution ÷ per unit of key factor
18	Fixed OH absorption rate	Budgeted fixed OH ÷ Normal output
19	Under/over absorption	Absorbed − Actual fixed OH
20	Profit difference (MC vs AC)	Δ Stock units × Fixed OH rate
21	Shutdown point (₹)	Avoidable fixed cost ÷ P/V ratio
22	Angle of incidence	Wider ⇒ higher post-BEP profit rate
23	Absorption unit cost	Variable prod cost + Fixed OH per unit

Profit-comparison hook: *Production > Sales ⇒ Absorption profit > Marginal profit* (stock rises, fixed OH deferred). *Production < Sales ⇒ Absorption profit < Marginal profit* (stock falls, deferred fixed OH released). *Production = Sales ⇒ profits equal.*

Chapter 15 — Budgets & Budgetary Control

1. The Problem: A business is a fleet of ships that must arrive at the same port on the same day

Imagine you run a factory. Tomorrow morning, the sales team is going to promise customers 10,000 units. The purchase manager is deciding how much steel to order. The HR head is deciding whether to hire two more workers. The finance manager is deciding whether the company can afford to pay a supplier on the 15th. The production supervisor is planning shifts.

Every one of these people is making a decision **today** about the **future**, and every decision depends on what the others decide. If sales promises 10,000 units but production planned for 6,000, customers get let down. If purchases buys steel for 10,000 units but sales only sells 6,000, cash is locked in a warehouse. If finance did not foresee the wage bill of two new workers, the company bounces a cheque even while it is "profitable."

This is the coordination problem. Individually rational decisions, taken in isolation, produce a collectively irrational business. The organisation is a fleet of ships each captained by a manager, and unless someone gives every captain a shared chart, they sail to different ports.

There is a second, quieter problem. Suppose the year ends and profit is ₹40 lakh. Is that good? You cannot answer without a benchmark. Good compared to what? Compared to last year? Last year had different prices, a different scale, a different world. To judge performance you need a **standard set in advance** — a statement of what *should* have happened, against which you lay what *did* happen. Without it, "control" is just narrating history.

A **budget** solves both problems at once. It is a plan expressed in numbers, agreed before the period begins, that (a) forces every department's plans to be mutually consistent, and (b) becomes the yardstick against which actual results are later measured. **Budgetary control** is the machinery of comparing actual with budget, isolating the differences, and acting on them.

There is a third problem worth naming, because the exam frames theory questions around it: **the delegation problem.** A large firm cannot be run by one brain. Authority must be pushed down to divisional and departmental managers — but authority without a yardstick is a blank cheque. A budget is the device that lets top management *delegate* decisions while retaining *control*: each manager is given a budget (a defined slice of resources and a target), acts freely within it, and is later held to account against it. This is why budgeting and **responsibility accounting** are inseparable — a cost is reported against the manager who can *control* it, not against whoever happens to sit near it.

This chapter builds the entire apparatus from that need: why budgets exist, the family of budgets a firm prepares, the one distinction that separates a useless budget from a control tool (**fixed vs flexible**), how the functional budgets knit into a **master budget**, the **cash budget** that keeps the firm solvent, and **zero-based budgeting** for when incremental thinking rots. It also equips you with the two performance-measurement numbers the examiner loves to bolt onto a budget question — the **efficiency, activity and capacity ratios** — and the softer but heavily tested material on the **limitations of budgeting** and **behavioural** side-effects.

2. The Core Idea: A budget is a company's shared travel itinerary — priced

Think of a family planning a month-long trip across several cities. They do not just "hope it works out." They write an itinerary: which city on which date, the hotel booked, the train tickets, the daily spending money, and — critically — a check that the total cost fits the money in the bank *before they leave*.

The itinerary does three jobs, and they map exactly onto the three purposes of a budget:

- **Coordination.** Everyone's plans are made compatible. Dad's museum day and Mum's shopping day do not both need the one rental car at 10 a.m.
- **Motivation.** A target ("we will do Jaipur in two days") focuses effort. A vague wish ("let's see Rajasthan sometime") does not.
- **Control.** Halfway through, they compare the money actually spent with the money planned. Overspending in week 1 triggers a correction in week 2 — *before* the trip runs out of cash, not after.

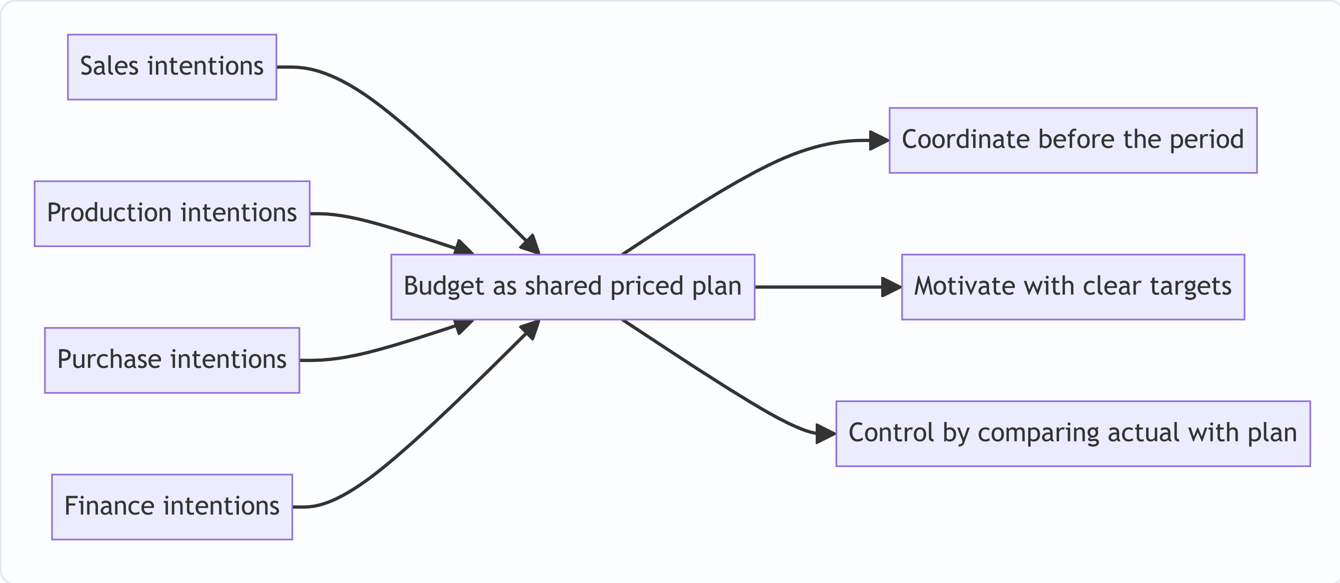
A budget is that itinerary for a business, drawn in rupees and units. The key mental shift for the self-learner: **a budget is not a forecast.** A forecast is a passive prediction of what *will* happen ("it will probably rain"). A budget is an active commitment to make something happen ("we *will* produce and sell 1,20,000 units and we accept ₹X of cost to do it"). A forecast is an input to a budget; the budget is a decision.

A fuller list of what budgets actually do (examiners ask "state the objectives of budgeting"):

1. **Planning** — force managers to think ahead and commit intentions to numbers.
2. **Coordination** — reconcile the plans of interdependent departments into one consistent whole.
3. **Communication** — the approved budget tells every manager what is expected of them and of others.
4. **Motivation** — a clear, accepted target energises effort more than a vague hope.
5. **Control** — provide the pre-set standard against which actual results are judged, via variances.
6. **Performance evaluation** — a fair basis (once flexed) for appraising managers.
7. **Authorisation** — the approved budget is management's sanction to spend up to the stated limit.

Notice that some of these purposes quietly conflict. A budget set as a *motivating* stretch target (deliberately tough) is a poor *planning* forecast (it is not the most-likely outcome) and a harsh *evaluation* yardstick. This tension — the same number being asked to plan, motivate and judge at once — is the root of most budgeting's behavioural problems (Section 4.9).

> *Figure 15.1 — A budget converts a scattered set of departmental intentions into one coordinated, priced plan that later doubles as the yardstick for control.*



---

3. Why It's Built This Way: three design decisions behind budgetary control

Before any formula, understand three deliberate design choices. Each one is a response to a way that naive planning fails.

Design decision 1 — Start from the binding constraint (the principal / key / limiting budget factor). You cannot plan every department "at full speed" because something always runs out first — market demand, machine hours, skilled labour, cash, or raw material supply. This scarcest resource is the **principal budget factor** (also called the *key factor* or *limiting factor*). The whole budget is built *starting from it*, because planning the others beyond what the constraint allows just manufactures inconsistency. In most firms the constraint is **sales demand**, which is why the **sales budget is usually prepared first** and everything else is sized to it. If instead machine capacity were the bottleneck, production would be planned to capacity and sales sized down to match. Identifying this factor first is not a detail — it is the organising principle of the entire exercise.

Deeper point — the constraint can shift. The principal budget factor is not permanent. Relieve one bottleneck (buy a second machine) and a different resource (say, skilled labour or working capital) becomes binding. A subtle exam variant gives you *two* candidate constraints and expects you to test which bites first: compute the output each resource permits and the *smaller* answer identifies the true limiting factor. Common limiting factors the exam names: **materials** (shortage/quota), **labour** (skilled-worker scarcity), **plant capacity** (machine hours), **sales demand** (market saturation), **management** (thin managerial talent) and **finance/cash** (the firm cannot fund the working capital that fuller activity needs).

Design decision 2 — Separate the plan from the yardstick by re-flexing it to actual activity (this is the seed of the flexible budget). If you plan for 10,000 units and actually make 8,000, comparing the ₹-cost of 8,000 real units against the ₹-cost of 10,000 planned units is comparing apples with oranges. Any manager will "beat" a cost budget simply by producing less. So the budget used for *control* must be **re-computed at the activity level that actually occurred**. That re-computation is the flexible budget, and it exists precisely so that control compares like with like. Hold this thought — Section 4 makes it the centre of gravity.

Design decision 3 — Management by exception. A control system that asks managers to look at every number drowns them. Budgetary control reports only the **variances** — the gaps between actual and budget — and directs attention to the significant ones. Small, random, self-correcting differences are ignored; large or persistent ones are investigated. This is *management by exception*: the budget is the routine, the variance is the alarm.

Layered on top is the human/organisational scaffolding that makes it work:

- A **Budget Manual** — the written rulebook of who prepares what, in what format, by when. It standardises procedures, defines responsibilities, fixes the timetable and the account codes, and specifies the reports and their circulation. Its value is that it makes the process repeatable and depersonalised, so budgeting survives staff turnover.
- A **Budget Committee** — cross-functional heads (headed usually by the Chief Executive, serviced by the Budget Officer) who set guidelines, reconcile conflicting departmental plans, approve the functional budgets, and finally approve the master budget. It is the forum where the coordination problem is actually resolved by negotiation.
- A **Budget Officer** — the coordinator (often the cost/management accountant) who runs the process, chases inputs, ties the numbers together and reports variances. Note: the Budget Officer *coordinates*, they do not *impose* the numbers — the line managers own their budgets.
- The **Budget Period** — the length of time a budget covers (typically one year for operating budgets, broken into months/quarters for control; longer for capital budgets). Choice of period balances two forces: long enough to cover the full operating/seasonal cycle and to let plans mature, short enough that the forecasts remain reliable. Capital-heavy, long-gestation industries (power, shipbuilding) budget over many years; fashion or perishable-goods firms budget short.

Two prerequisites the exam lists for a successful system: (i) **top-management support** — without it, budgets are ignored; and (ii) a sound, **responsibility-based organisation structure** with clearly defined authority, so each budget maps to exactly one accountable manager (the essence of *responsibility accounting*: controllable costs reported to the manager who controls them).

---

4. Full Technical Content: the machinery, each piece with its reason

4.1 What "budgetary control" formally means

Budgetary control is the establishment of budgets relating the responsibilities of executives to the requirements of a policy, and the continuous comparison of actual with budgeted results — either to secure by individual action the objective of that policy, or to provide a basis for its revision. Unpack it: *establish budgets → assign to responsible managers → continuously compare actual vs budget → act (correct the action, or revise the plan)*. The last clause matters: a variance may mean the *manager* was wrong, or it may mean the *plan* was wrong. Control decides which.

Budget vs Budgeting vs Budgetary control — three words the exam separates. A **budget** is the *quantitative statement* (the plan itself). **Budgeting** is the *act of preparing* budgets. **Budgetary control** is the *whole system* — preparing budgets, comparing them with actuals, and taking corrective action. A budget without the comparison-and-action loop is just a plan; it becomes *control* only when the feedback machinery runs. Think of it as a thermostat: the budget is the set temperature, the actual reading is the room temperature, and budgetary control is the loop that switches the heater on and off.

Advantages of budgetary control (frequently a 4–5 mark theory question): forces forward planning; coordinates activities; defines responsibilities and delegates with control; provides a yardstick for performance and management by exception; promotes cost consciousness and efficiency; aids centralised control with decentralised activity; reveals capacity that is unused; and helps obtain finance (bankers respect a budgeted cash flow). Keep the list tied to the three purposes — coordinate, motivate, control — so it is never rote.

4.2 The family of budgets — three classification axes

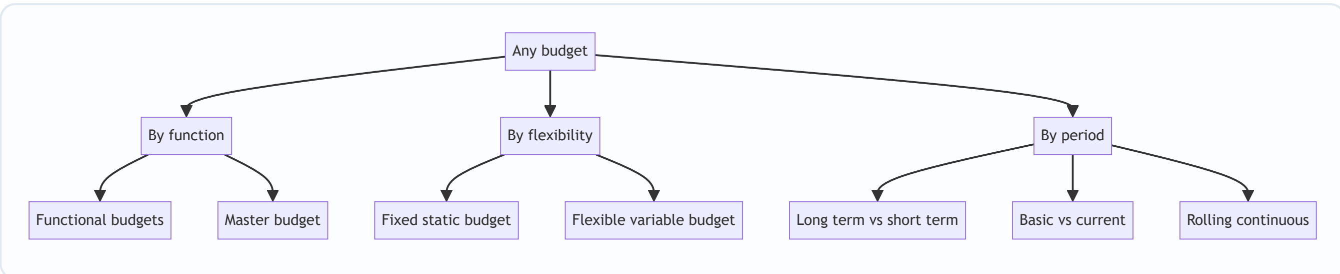
Budgets are classified along three independent axes. The same budget sits on all three simultaneously.

(A) By coverage / function: - **Functional budgets** — one per function: sales, production, materials (purchase and usage), direct labour, factory/production overhead, administration, selling & distribution, plant utilisation, capital expenditure, cash. - **Master budget** — the consolidation of all functional budgets into a single summary: a budgeted Income Statement (Cost Sheet / P&L) and a budgeted Balance Sheet, plus the cash budget.

(B) By capacity / flexibility — the control-critical axis: - **Fixed (static) budget** — prepared for a *single* anticipated level of activity; not adjusted if actual activity differs. - **Flexible (variable) budget** — designed to *change with the level of activity*, by classifying costs into fixed, variable and semi-variable and recomputing the total for whatever activity actually occurs.

(C) By period / conditions: - **Long-term** (3–10 yrs, strategic, e.g. capital budget) vs **short-term** (usually 1 yr) vs **current** (weeks/months). - **Basic budget** (a long-run standard, unaltered for the base period) vs **current budget** (adjusted for current conditions). - **Rolling / continuous budget** — as each month/quarter ends, a new one is added at the far end, so a full 12-month horizon is always in view. Reason: planning never falls off a cliff at year-end.

> *Figure 15.2 — The three independent axes along which any single budget is classified.*



When is a fixed budget actually appropriate? The chapter rightly attacks the fixed budget for *control*, but do not overstate it — a fixed budget is perfectly valid (i) as the original *planning* statement of the expected level, (ii) where activity genuinely cannot vary much (e.g. a stable, made-to-order plant, or a purely administrative cost centre), and (iii) as the starting master budget the board approves. The sin is not preparing a fixed budget; the sin is using it *for control when activity has moved*. State it that way and you avoid the trap of writing "fixed budgets are useless."

4.3 Fixed vs Flexible — the heart of the chapter, and WHY flexible is needed

Here is the failure a fixed budget walks into. Suppose a factory budgets for **10,000 units**:

	Budget (fixed, 10,000 u)	Actual (8,000 u)	"Variance"
Direct material @ ₹20/u (variable)	2,00,000	1,64,000	36,000 F
Direct labour @ ₹15/u (variable)	1,50,000	1,25,000	25,000 F
Factory rent (fixed)	1,00,000	1,00,000	—
Total cost	4,50,000	3,89,000	61,000 F

The fixed-budget comparison shows ₹61,000 **favourable**. The manager looks like a hero. But this is a lie: of course costs are lower — the factory made 20% fewer units. The comparison mixes two utterly different effects — the effect of *making fewer units* (a volume effect, often outside the cost manager's control) and the effect of *cost efficiency* (spending more or less per unit, which *is* the manager's job). A fixed budget cannot separate them, so it cannot control anything.

The fix: flex the budget to the activity that actually happened (8,000 units). Variable costs are re-computed at 8,000 units; fixed costs stay fixed.

	Flexed budget @ 8,000 u	Actual @ 8,000 u	Variance
Direct material @ ₹20/u	1,60,000	1,64,000	4,000 A
Direct labour @ ₹15/u	1,20,000	1,25,000	5,000 A
Factory rent	1,00,000	1,00,000	—
Total cost	3,80,000	3,89,000	**9,000 A**

Flexed to real activity, the truth appears: the manager actually **overspent by ₹9,000**. The favourable ₹61,000 was pure volume illusion. **This is why a flexible budget is indispensable for control: it compares like with like — the cost that *should* have been incurred for the output *actually produced* against the cost *actually incurred*.** A fixed budget is fine for *planning* a single expected level; it is useless for *controlling* when activity moves — and activity always moves.

The mechanics of flexing — cost behaviour is the whole trick. To flex, every cost must first be split by behaviour:

- **Variable cost** — total varies in direct proportion to activity; per-unit is constant. Flexed total = *variable rate per unit × actual units*.
- **Fixed cost** — total is unchanged across the relevant range; per-unit *falls* as activity rises. Flexed total = *same amount, always*.
- **Semi-variable (mixed) cost** — has both a fixed lump and a variable slice (e.g. electricity: a fixed connection charge plus per-unit consumption). It must be **segregated** into its two parts before flexing.
- **Stepped (step-fixed) cost** — fixed over a band of activity, then jumps to a new fixed level (e.g. one supervisor per 50 workers: hire the 51st worker and a second supervisor's salary steps in). Within each band it behaves like a fixed cost; the exam tests whether you notice the step when activity crosses the band boundary (see Section 4.3a).

Segregating a semi-variable cost — the High–Low method (the exam's workhorse). Take the cost at the highest activity and at the lowest activity:

$$\text{Variable rate per unit} = \frac{\text{Cost at highest activity} - \text{Cost at lowest activity}}{\text{Highest activity} - \text{Lowest activity}}$$

Then: **Fixed cost = Total cost at any level − (Variable rate × units at that level).** Once you have the fixed lump and the variable rate, the semi-variable cost flexes like any other. (More refined methods — least squares regression — exist, but High–Low is the standard exam tool.)

High–Low caution the examiner exploits: pick the highest and lowest **activity** levels, **not** the highest and lowest *costs*. If a cost figure is abnormal (a one-off repair spike) the High–Low line is distorted — the method assumes both endpoints are "normal." Also, if a *step-up in fixed cost* occurs between the low and high points, plain High–Low silently blends the step into the variable rate and is wrong; you must adjust one endpoint for the known step before dividing.

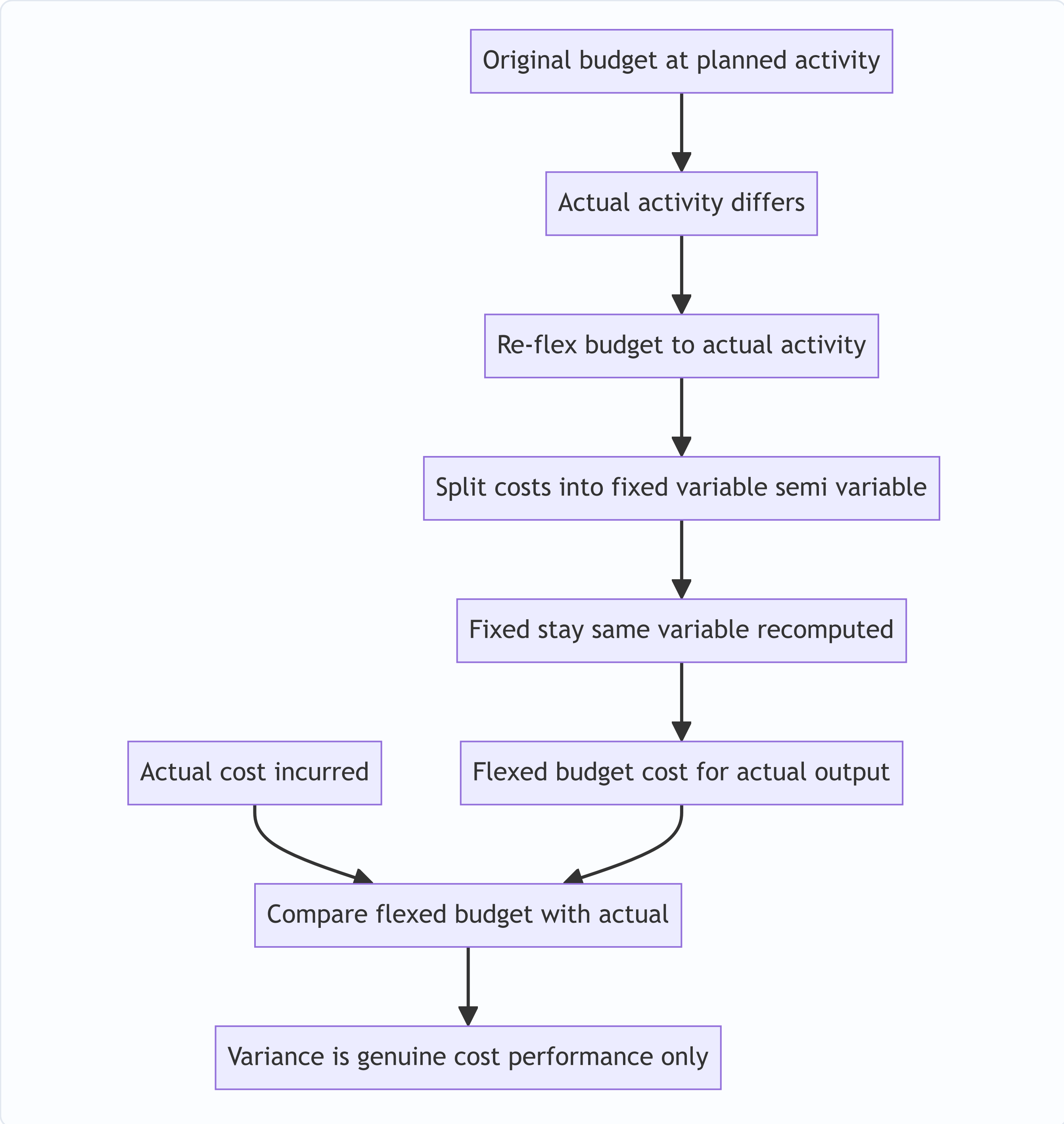
Flexible budget formula for any activity level:

$$\text{Budgeted total cost at activity } x = \text{Total fixed cost} + (\text{Variable cost per unit} \times x)$$

This straight line — a fixed intercept plus a variable slope — *is* the flexible budget. Give it any x, it returns the cost that x *ought* to cost.

Measuring activity — % capacity, units, or hours? A flexible budget can be flexed against different activity measures, and the question dictates which. Common bases: **units of output**, **direct labour hours**, **machine hours**, or **% of capacity**. Watch the distinction between **budgeted (normal) capacity**, **practical capacity** (theoretical max less unavoidable idle time for maintenance etc.), and **actual capacity utilised**. When a question says "budget was at 60% and actual was 75%," convert the % to the underlying units/hours before you flex — the variable slice keys off the physical measure, not the percentage sign.

> *Figure 15.3 — Why the flexible budget is the correct control benchmark: it re-flexes the plan to the activity that actually occurred so that only genuine cost performance remains.*



4.3a Edge cases in flexing — the tweaks an examiner adds

Three "what if the examiner tweaks it" variations sit on top of the basic flex, and each has a clean rule:

- **Stepped fixed cost crosses a band.** If fixed cost is "₹90,000 up to 15,000 units, ₹1,20,000 beyond," then flexing to 18,000 units uses ₹1,20,000, *not* ₹90,000. The fixed block is only fixed *within its relevant range*; read the data for the step and switch levels at the boundary. A favourite trap is to flex to a level that has crossed the step and leave the old fixed figure in.
- **A cost that is variable but not proportional to output** — e.g. a variable cost that changes with *labour hours* while output changes with *machine hours*, or a bulk-purchase discount that lowers the material rate above a threshold. Flex such a cost against *its own* driver, and apply the changed rate to the whole quantity (or only the excess) exactly as the question specifies. Do not blindly apply the low-volume rate at high volume.

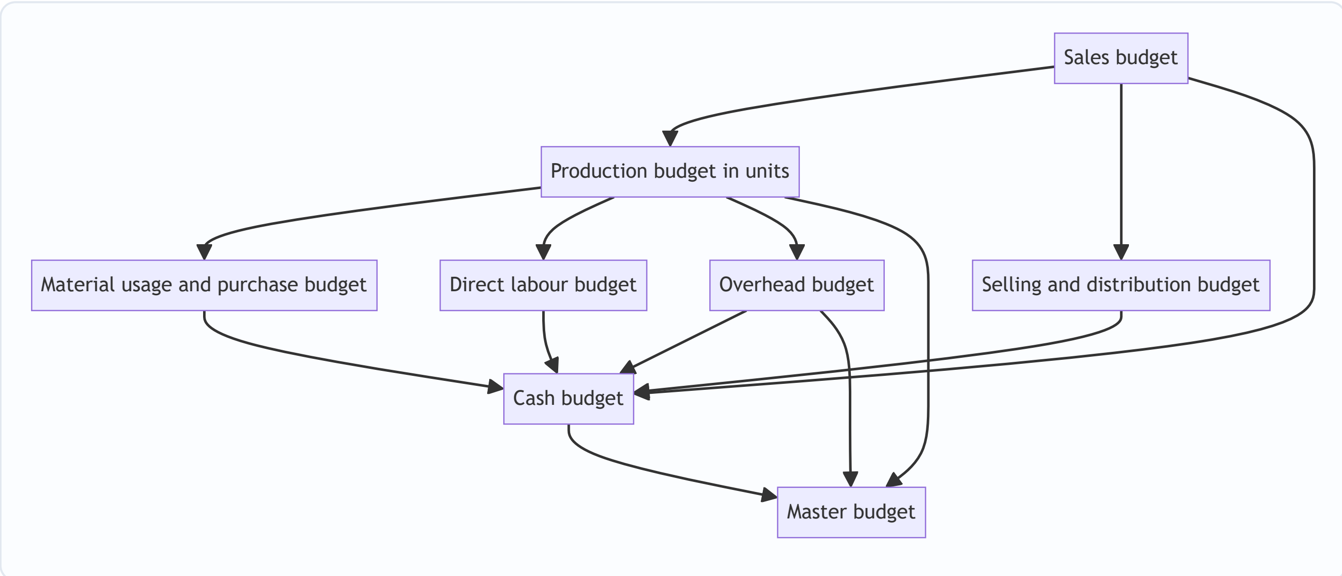
- **Semi-variable cost given as a lump plus a percentage-of-something**, e.g. "selling overhead = ₹50,000 fixed + 2% of sales value." Here the variable slice keys off *sales value*, not units. Flex the 2% against the flexed sales figure. Mixing the driver (units vs value) is a silent error that fails the reconciliation.

The unifying principle: **flex each cost against the driver it actually responds to, over the range it actually applies.** Rote "variable = rate × units" fails the moment the driver or the range changes.

4.4 The functional budgets — order, logic and formats

The functional budgets are prepared in a **strict sequence** dictated by the principal budget factor. Assuming (as usual) that **sales demand is the limiting factor**, the chain is:

> *Figure 15.4 — The build order of functional budgets when sales demand is the principal budget factor, converging into the master budget.*



(1) Sales budget. The starting point and, usually, the foundation of everything. Estimated **quantity × selling price**, broken by product, region, period, salesperson. Built from the sales force's estimates, past trends, market research, capacity and pricing policy.

(2) Production budget (in units). How many units must be *manufactured* to meet the sales plan while moving inventory from opening to the desired closing level. The logic is a stock reconciliation:

$$\text{Units to produce} = \text{Budgeted sales} + \text{Desired closing FG stock} - \text{Opening FG stock}$$

Why this shape: you must produce enough to (a) satisfy sales and (b) build the closing stock, but you get a head start from opening stock, so it is subtracted. This budget is then sub-divided into a **production cost budget** and feeds materials, labour and overheads.

Production policy variants the exam adds: sometimes the firm wants to **stabilise production** (produce the same quantity every month despite seasonal sales) so that inventory absorbs the swings; sometimes it wants to **stabilise inventory** (produce to match sales, letting the workforce swing); often it sets closing stock as "a fixed number of days/weeks of the *next* period's sales." Read which policy applies, because it changes the closing-stock figure that feeds the reconciliation. If closing stock is "one month of next month's sales," you must look *forward*, not backward.

(3) Material budgets — two distinct budgets, do not confuse them.

- **Material *usage* (consumption) budget** = units to produce × material required per unit. This is driven by *production*. $$\text{Material to be consumed} = \text{Units produced} \times \text{material per unit}$$
- **Material *purchase* budget** = what to *buy*, after a second stock reconciliation on raw materials: $$\text{Material to purchase} = \text{Material consumed} + \text{Desired closing RM stock} - \text{Opening RM stock}$$

Why two: consumption is a production question; purchasing is a stores/cash question. They differ by the change in raw-material inventory. Purchases (× price) drive the cash outflow to suppliers.

Multi-material extension: with several raw materials, run a *separate* usage-and-purchase reconciliation for each material (each has its own per-unit rate, price, and opening/closing stock), then sum the values. Do not merge kilograms of steel with litres of paint — reconcile in physical units per material, value each, then total.

(4) Direct labour budget. Standard hours per unit × units to produce = total hours; × wage rate = labour cost. Also flags whether the workforce/overtime is adequate. A richer version converts total hours into a *headcount*: required workers = total budgeted hours ÷ (hours per worker in the period), which tells HR how many to hire or whether overtime/idle time looms. Where different grades of labour (skilled, semi-skilled) are used, budget each grade separately at its own rate.

(5) Overhead budgets. Production overhead (split fixed/variable), administration overhead, selling & distribution overhead — each estimated and, for control, prepared in *flexible* form. Selling & distribution overhead often has a variable slice tied to *sales value or volume* rather than to production, so key it off the sales budget.

(6) Other budgets. Plant utilisation, R&D, capital expenditure (long-term), and the **cash budget** (below).

4.4a Capacity and efficiency ratios — the performance numbers bolted onto budgets

Examiners frequently append these three ratios to a budget question. They compare **budgeted, standard and actual** hours and answer "did we work hard, and did we work well?" Let three quantities be defined for a period:

- **Budgeted hours** — the hours the budget planned for (budgeted output × standard hours/unit).
- **Standard hours for actual output** — the hours the *actual output* should have taken (actual output × standard hours/unit). This is the "flexible budget of hours."
- **Actual hours worked** — clock hours actually spent.

$$\textbf{Efficiency Ratio} = \frac{\text{Standard hours for actual output}}{\text{Actual hours worked}} \times 100$$

$$\textbf{Capacity (Utilisation) Ratio} = \frac{\text{Actual hours worked}}{\text{Budgeted hours}} \times 100$$

$$\textbf{Activity (Volume) Ratio} = \frac{\text{Standard hours for actual output}}{\text{Budgeted hours}} \times 100$$

The identity that ties them together (and is a self-check): **Activity Ratio = Efficiency Ratio × Capacity Ratio** (as fractions). In words: how much output we produced relative to plan (activity) equals how *hard* we worked (capacity) times how *efficiently* those hours converted into output (efficiency). Some texts add a **Calendar Ratio = actual working days ÷ budgeted working days × 100**, which explains capacity shortfalls caused by fewer working days (holidays, strikes). Interpretation: a ratio above 100% is favourable (more output/hours than planned); below 100% is adverse. Worked Example 6 puts numbers to this.

4.5 The Cash Budget — keeping a profitable firm from going broke

The problem it solves: profit and cash are *not* the same thing. A firm can be highly profitable on paper and still fail to pay wages next Tuesday, because customers pay in 60 days while wages fall due weekly, and because depreciation is a cost but not a cash outflow. The cash budget is a **month-by-month forecast of cash receipts and payments** that reveals, *in advance*, when the firm will have a surplus (to invest) or a deficit (to arrange an overdraft for). It is the single most practically important budget for survival.

Golden rule of the cash budget: include only actual cash movements, and time them when the cash actually moves — not when the sale or expense is recorded.

- **Include:** cash sales; collections from debtors (lagged by the credit period); loans raised; interest/dividends received; sale of assets; issue of shares.
- **Include (payments):** cash paid to suppliers (lagged by credit received); wages; overheads paid in cash; tax; dividends paid; capital expenditure; loan repayments.
- **EXCLUDE non-cash items entirely: depreciation**, provisions for bad debts, writing off goodwill, notional/imputed costs, and any **accrued** expense not yet paid. These never touch the bank.
- **Timing is everything:** a sale in January collected in March is a *March* receipt. A purchase in January paid in February is a *February* payment.

Format — the receipts-and-payments method (the exam standard):

$$\text{Closing balance} = \text{Opening balance} + \text{Total receipts} - \text{Total payments}$$

and each month's **closing balance becomes next month's opening balance** (the balances chain). Where a minimum cash balance is required, any shortfall signals borrowing; any excess above it signals investible surplus.

Two other methods you should be able to name (the receipts-and-payments method is what problems use, but theory may ask for the alternatives):

1. **Adjusted profit-and-loss (cash-flow) method** — start from budgeted net profit, add back non-cash charges (depreciation, provisions), and adjust for changes in working capital (increase in debtors/stock reduces cash, increase in creditors raises cash) plus capital and financing flows. Useful for *longer* horizons where item-by-item timing is impractical.
2. **Balance-sheet method** — project the closing balance sheet with every item except cash, and derive cash as the balancing figure. Rarely asked to compute, often asked to identify.

Handling common cash-budget wrinkles the examiner loves: - **Bad debts / cash discount on collections.** If 2% of debtors default, collect only 98%; if a cash discount is offered for prompt payment, reduce the receipt by the discount. Never collect 100% of credit sales unless told to. - **Split collection patterns.** "60% collected in the month after sale, 30% in the second month, 10% bad" — spread each month's credit sales across the stated pattern and *sum the overlapping tails* in each column. - **Advance payments / deposits.** A customer advance is a receipt *when received*, even before the sale. - **Tax and dividend** are paid on their due dates, often quarterly/annually — enter in the month of payment, not the month of provision. - **Interest on overdraft** — if the question asks you to fund shortfalls, the resulting overdraft may itself carry interest, which becomes a later payment; do this only if explicitly required.

4.6 The Master Budget

The **master budget** is the summary budget incorporating all functional budgets, finally approved by the budget committee. It is not a fourth kind of calculation — it is the **consolidation**: a budgeted income statement (cost of sales and profit) and a budgeted balance sheet, supported by the cash budget. It is the single document the board approves and against which overall performance is judged.

Structurally the master budget has two halves that mirror financial statements: the **operating budget** (sales → cost of goods sold → gross profit → operating expenses → operating profit — built from the functional budgets) and the **financial budget** (cash budget, budgeted balance sheet, and capital-expenditure budget). Seeing this two-part shape helps in a "prepare the budgeted P&L and balance sheet" question: everything above operating profit comes from the functional operating budgets; the cash budget and capex feed the balance sheet.

4.7 Zero-Based Budgeting (ZBB) — refusing to inherit last year's fat

The problem it solves: the ordinary approach, **incremental budgeting**, takes last year's figure and adds a percentage. Its fatal flaw is that it *inherits every past inefficiency* — if a department wasted ₹5 lakh last year, incremental budgeting quietly re-funds that ₹5 lakh plus 8%. Waste becomes permanent because nobody re-justifies the base.

ZBB flips the burden of proof. Every activity starts from a **"zero base"** each cycle; every rupee, including the base, must be justified afresh as if the activity were brand new. Nothing is entitled to funding merely because it existed last year.

The ZBB process: 1. **Define decision units** — the smallest activities that can be separately evaluated. 2. **Build decision packages** — for each unit, describe the activity, its purpose, costs, benefits, and alternative ways (and levels) of performing it. 3. **Rank the packages** across the organisation by cost-benefit, from indispensable to marginal. 4. **Allocate resources** down the ranked list until the funds run out; packages below the line are cut.

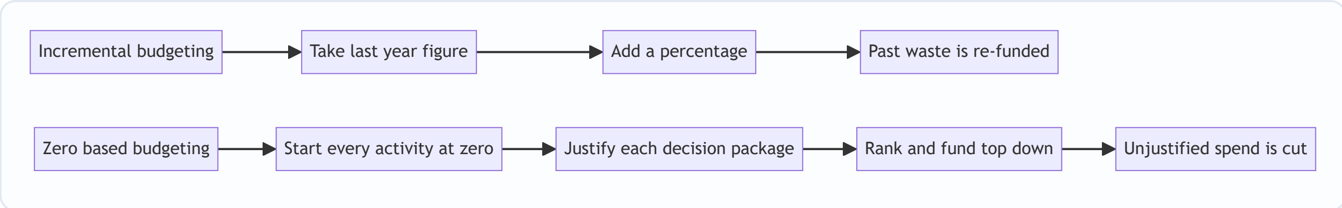
Strengths: eliminates inherited waste; links spend to objectives; forces managers to justify activities; good for discretionary/support costs (R&D, admin, marketing). **Weaknesses:** time-consuming and costly; needs skill and honesty; hard to quantify benefits of some activities; can breed short-termism. Consequently ZBB is often applied *periodically* (say every few years) or selectively to discretionary areas, not to every line every year.

Incremental vs Zero-based — the crisp contrast table (exam-ready):

Aspect	Incremental budgeting	Zero-based budgeting
Starting point	Last year's figure	Zero — nothing assumed
Burden of proof	Only the *increment* is justified	*Every* rupee is justified
Treatment of past waste	Carried forward, re-funded	Exposed and cut
Cost and time to prepare	Low	High
Best suited to	Stable, committed costs	Discretionary/support costs
Behavioural effect	"Spend it or lose it" mentality	Cost consciousness, but padding risk

Related modern budgeting approaches to name (the exam sometimes asks you to distinguish these one-liners): - **Performance budgeting** — budgets built around *functions, programmes and activities* with output measures, so spend is linked to results (common in government). - **Activity-based budgeting (ABB)** — budgets built from *cost drivers* and activities rather than departments; the budgeting mirror of activity-based costing. - **Kaizen budgeting** — budgets that build *continuous cost reduction* into each successive period (targets tighten over time). - **Rolling (continuous) budgeting** — already met in 4.2; continuously extended so a full horizon is always in view; keep it distinct from ZBB.

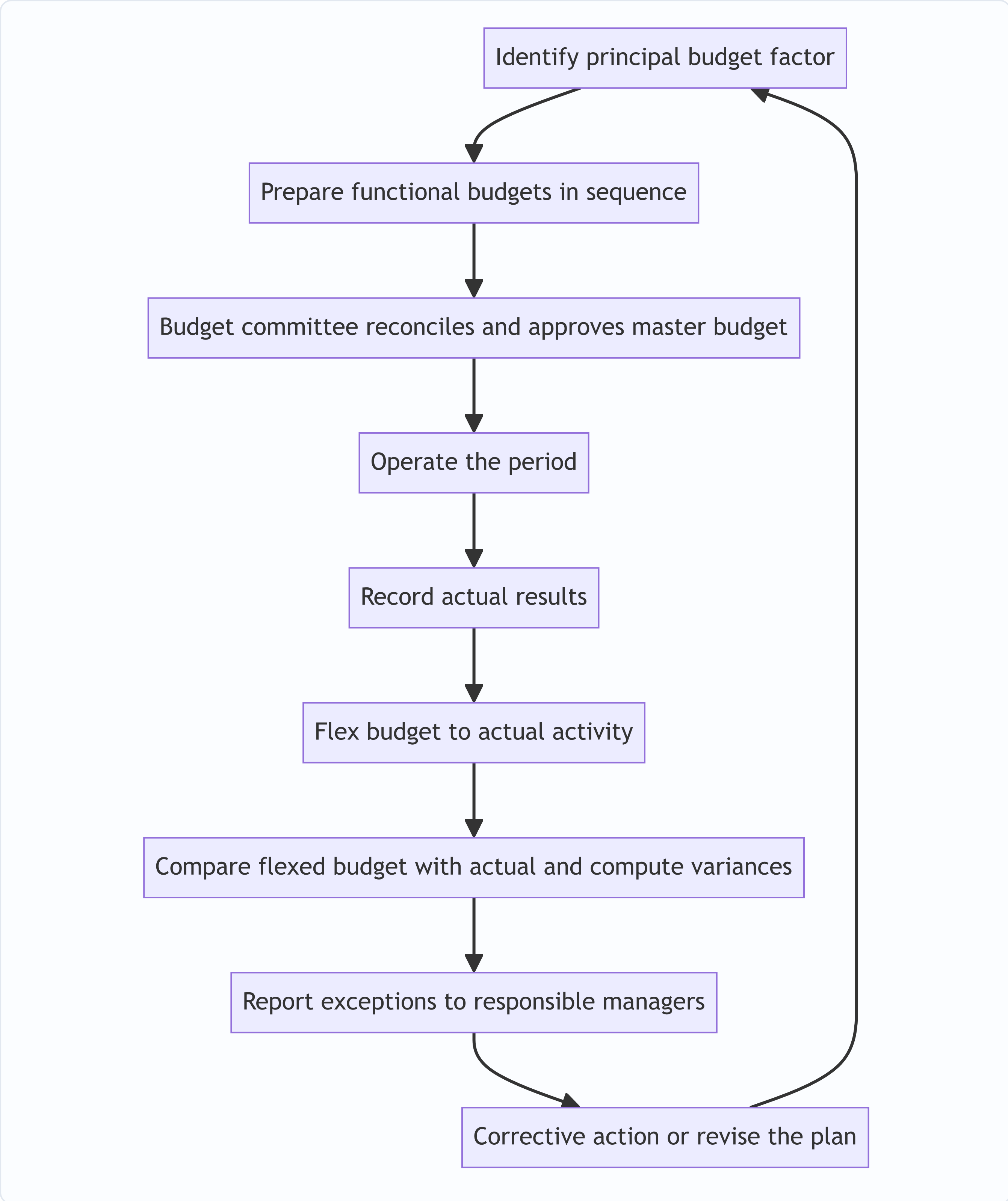
> *Figure 15.5 — Incremental budgeting inherits the past base while ZBB re-justifies every activity from zero.*



4.8 The budgeting process as a control loop

Everything above is static description; the *system* is a loop that runs every period. Setting it out as a cycle helps answer "explain the process of budgetary control."

> *Figure 15.6 — Budgetary control is a closed feedback loop that plans, measures, compares and corrects each period.*



The loop's teeth are the **feedback** arrow (compare-and-correct after the fact) and, in better systems, **feed-forward** (spotting a coming deviation — e.g. a forecast cash deficit in the cash budget — and acting *before* it happens). The cash budget is the classic feed-forward instrument: it warns of a June shortfall in April, so finance is arranged in time.

4.9 Limitations and behavioural aspects — the "soft" content that carries marks

A concept chapter that only teaches the arithmetic misses the marks reserved for judgement. Know the **limitations** and the **behavioural** pitfalls.

Limitations of budgetary control: - A budget is built on **estimates**; its quality cannot exceed the quality of the forecasts behind it. - It is a **tool, not a substitute for management** — budgets do not execute themselves; managers must act on variances. - **Rigidity** — an over-rigid budget can stop managers responding to genuine, unforeseen opportunities or changes. - **Cost** — a full system is expensive; for a small firm the cost may exceed the benefit. - **Time lag** — variance reports arrive after the event; control is only as fast as the reporting cycle. - **Conflict** — departmental budgets can breed silo behaviour and inter-departmental friction.

Behavioural side-effects (why budgets sometimes backfire): - **Budget padding / slack** — managers deliberately overstate costs or understate revenues so the target is easy to beat. ZBB and participative review attack this. - **"Spend it or lose it"** — fear that unspent budget will be cut next year drives wasteful year-end spending (the incremental system's classic disease). - **Dysfunctional behaviour** — a manager hits *their* budget in a way that hurts the *whole* firm (e.g. skimping on maintenance to beat a cost budget, causing breakdowns later). - **Participation vs imposition** — **participative (bottom-up)** budgets that managers help set earn commitment but risk slack; **imposed (top-down)** budgets are tighter but can demotivate. The practical middle is *negotiated* budgets with genuine top-management involvement. - **Aspiration level** — targets must be tight enough to stretch yet attainable enough to motivate; a target seen as impossible is abandoned, and one seen as trivial is ignored.

Being able to write two or three of these crisply turns a pure-numbers answer into a complete one.

---

5. Worked Examples — full, step-by-step, reconciled

Worked Example 1 (Easy) — Production, material usage and purchase budgets

Data. Zenith Ltd sells a single product. Budgeted sales for the quarter = **48,000 units**. It wants closing finished-goods (FG) stock of **6,000 units**; opening FG stock is **4,000 units**. Each unit needs **3 kg** of raw material at **₹25/kg**. It wants closing raw-material (RM) stock of **15,000 kg**; opening RM stock is **9,000 kg**.

Required: production budget (units), material usage budget (kg), and material purchase budget (kg and ₹).

Step 1 — Production budget (units). Produce enough for sales plus the desired stock build, less the head start from opening stock.

Production budget	Units
Budgeted sales	48,000
Add: Desired closing FG stock	6,000
Less: Opening FG stock	(4,000)
Units to be produced	**50,000**

Step 2 — Material usage (consumption) budget. Driven by production.

$$50{,}000 \text{ units} \times 3 \text{ kg} = 1{,}50{,}000 \text{ kg consumed}$$

Step 3 — Material purchase budget. Buy enough to cover consumption plus the RM stock build, less opening RM stock.

Material purchase budget	Kg
Material to be consumed	1,50,000
Add: Desired closing RM stock	15,000
Less: Opening RM stock	(9,000)
Material to be purchased	**1,56,000**

Value of purchases = 1,56,000 kg × ₹25 = **₹39,00,000.**

Note the two separate stock reconciliations — one on finished goods (Step 1), one on raw material (Step 3). Confusing consumption with purchases is the classic error.

Worked Example 2 (Moderate) — Flexible budget with a semi-variable cost segregated

Data. A factory's overhead budget was prepared at **60% capacity = 12,000 units**. Costs at that level:

Cost	₹ at 12,000 u	Behaviour
Direct material	3,60,000	Variable
Direct labour	2,40,000	Variable
Power	84,000	Semi-variable
Repairs & maintenance	60,000	Semi-variable
Factory rent	1,20,000	Fixed
Supervision	90,000	Fixed

Additional information for the two semi-variable costs (given at two activity levels so we can segregate them):

Semi-variable cost	₹ at 12,000 u (60%)	₹ at 16,000 u (80%)
Power	84,000	1,00,000
Repairs & maintenance	60,000	68,000

Required: prepare a flexible budget at **60%, 80% and 100% capacity** (100% = 20,000 units).

Step 1 — Segregate the semi-variable costs by High–Low.

Power: $$\text{Variable rate} = \frac{1{,}00{,}000 - 84{,}000}{16{,}000 - 12{,}000} = \frac{16{,}000}{4{,}000} = ₹4/\text{unit}$$ Fixed part = 84,000 − (4 × 12,000) = 84,000 − 48,000 = **₹36,000**. (Check at 16,000: 36,000 + 4×16,000 = 1,00,000 ✓)

Repairs & maintenance: $$\text{Variable rate} = \frac{68{,}000 - 60{,}000}{16{,}000 - 12{,}000} = \frac{8{,}000}{4{,}000} = ₹2/\text{unit}$$ Fixed part = 60,000 − (2 × 12,000) = 60,000 − 24,000 = **₹36,000**. (Check at 16,000: 36,000 + 2×16,000 = 68,000 ✓)

Step 2 — Establish per-unit variable rates and fixed lumps.

Cost	Variable ₹/unit	Fixed ₹
Direct material	3,60,000 ÷ 12,000 = 30	—
Direct labour	2,40,000 ÷ 12,000 = 20	—
Power	4	36,000
Repairs & maintenance	2	36,000
Factory rent	—	1,20,000
Supervision	—	90,000
Total	**56 / unit**	**2,82,000**

Step 3 — Flex to each capacity. Total cost = Fixed 2,82,000 + 56 × units.

Cost element	60% (12,000 u)	80% (16,000 u)	100% (20,000 u)
Direct material (₹30/u)	3,60,000	4,80,000	6,00,000
Direct labour (₹20/u)	2,40,000	3,20,000	4,00,000
Power (36,000 + ₹4/u)	84,000	1,00,000	1,16,000
Repairs & mtce (36,000 + ₹2/u)	60,000	68,000	76,000
Factory rent (fixed)	1,20,000	1,20,000	1,20,000
Supervision (fixed)	90,000	90,000	90,000
Total cost	**9,54,000**	**11,78,000**	**13,02,000**
Cost per unit	**79.50**	**73.625**	**65.10**

Reconciliation / self-check. At 100%: fixed 2,82,000 + variable (56 × 20,000 = 11,20,000) = **13,02,000 ✓**. Notice the cost *per unit falls* as activity rises (79.50 → 73.625 → 65.10) — the signature of fixed cost being spread over more units. That single fact is *why* comparing per-unit costs across different volumes is meaningless, and why control must use the flexed *total* at actual activity.

Examiner tweak to watch: if the question added "at 100% capacity, factory rent steps up to ₹1,50,000 because a second shed is leased," you would **replace** the ₹1,20,000 only in the 100% column, lifting its total to 13,32,000 and its per-unit to 66.60. Always scan for such step-ups before copying a fixed figure across all columns.

Worked Example 3 (Exam-hard) — Flexible budget as a control tool, fully reconciled with a fixed budget

Data. Pioneer Ltd budgeted (fixed budget) for **10,000 units** but actually produced and sold **12,000 units**. Cost structure per the original budget:

- Direct material: ₹40/unit (variable)
- Direct labour: ₹30/unit (variable)

- Variable overhead: ₹10/unit (variable)
- Semi-variable overhead: ₹80,000 at 10,000 units; it rises by ₹10,000 for every 2,000 units above 10,000 (i.e. ₹5/unit variable slice on top of a fixed lump).
- Fixed overhead: ₹1,50,000 (fixed within the relevant range up to 12,000 units).

Actual costs incurred at 12,000 units: Direct material ₹5,04,000; Direct labour ₹3,54,000; Variable overhead ₹1,26,000; Semi-variable overhead ₹98,000; Fixed overhead ₹1,55,000.

Required: (a) the fixed budget; (b) the flexed budget at 12,000 units; (c) the variance against the *flexed* budget with a full reconciliation; and (d) show why the fixed-budget comparison misleads.

Step 1 — Segregate the semi-variable overhead. It is ₹80,000 at 10,000 units, and increases ₹10,000 per 2,000 units → variable rate = 10,000 ÷ 2,000 = **₹5/unit**. Fixed part = 80,000 − (5 × 10,000) = **₹30,000**. So semi-variable = 30,000 + 5 × units.

Step 2 — Build all three columns. Variable per-unit rates: material 40, labour 30, variable OH 10, semi-variable slice 5. Fixed lumps: semi-variable 30,000 + fixed OH 1,50,000 = 1,80,000 total fixed.

Cost element	Fixed budget (10,000 u)	Flexed budget (12,000 u)	Actual (12,000 u)	Variance
Direct material (₹40/u)	4,00,000	4,80,000	5,04,000	24,000 A
Direct labour (₹30/u)	3,00,000	3,60,000	3,54,000	6,000 F
Variable overhead (₹10/u)	1,00,000	1,20,000	1,26,000	6,000 A
Semi-variable (30,000 + ₹5/u)	80,000	90,000	98,000	8,000 A
Fixed overhead	1,50,000	1,50,000	1,55,000	5,000 A
Total cost	**10,30,000**	**12,00,000**	**13,37,000**	**37,000 A**

Step 3 — Reconcile the variance (the tie-out). Sum of element variances: 24,000 A − 6,000 F + 6,000 A + 8,000 A + 5,000 A = **37,000 A**. Total flexed budget 12,00,000 vs Actual 13,37,000 = **37,000 Adverse ✓.** The parts tie to the whole.

Step 4 — Why the fixed comparison misleads. If you naively compared the **fixed** budget (₹10,30,000 for 10,000 units) with the **actual** (₹13,37,000 for 12,000 units), you would report a ₹3,07,000 *adverse* "variance" and panic. But most of that gap is simply the cost of making 2,000 *extra* units — a *volume* effect, not inefficiency. The flexible budget strips the volume effect out (10,30,000 → 12,00,000 is the legitimate cost of the extra volume) and reveals the *true* cost-control failure: only **₹37,000 adverse**.

The full decomposition: - Total fixed-budget-to-actual gap: 13,37,000 − 10,30,000 = **3,07,000 A** - Of which, volume effect (flexing 10,000 → 12,000 units): 12,00,000 − 10,30,000 = **1,70,000** (extra cost that *should* be incurred for the extra output — not a controllable variance) - True cost/expenditure variance (flexed vs actual): **37,000 A** - Check: 1,70,000 + 37,000 = 3,07,000 ✓

This is the entire argument of Section 4.3 made numerical: **only the ₹37,000 belongs on the cost manager's report card.** The ₹1,70,000 is the price of doing more business, which is good news, not bad.

Worked Example 4 (Exam-hard) — Cash Budget

Data. Sunrise Ltd wants a cash budget for **April, May, June**.

Sales (₹): Feb 2,00,000; Mar 2,20,000; Apr 2,40,000; May 2,60,000; Jun 3,00,000. - **Sales pattern:** 25% cash, 75% credit. Credit customers pay **one month after sale**. - **Purchases (₹):** Mar 1,20,000; Apr 1,40,000; May 1,50,000; Jun 1,60,000. Paid **one month after purchase**. - **Wages:** paid in the *same* month — Apr 40,000; May 44,000; Jun 48,000. - **Overheads:** ₹30,000 per month, paid in the same month. This figure **includes ₹8,000 depreciation.** - **Machinery** costing ₹1,00,000 to be bought in **May**, paid in **June**. - **Dividend** of ₹20,000 payable in **April**. - **Opening cash balance on 1 April = ₹50,000.** Minimum desired balance = ₹25,000.

Required: cash budget for the three months and comment on financing.

Step 1 — Cash receipts. Split cash sales (same month, 25%) and credit collections (75%, one month late).

Receipts	April	May	June
Cash sales (25% of current month)	60,000	65,000	75,000
Collection from debtors (75% of prior month)	1,65,000	1,80,000	1,95,000
Total receipts	**2,25,000**	**2,45,000**	**2,70,000**

Working: Apr cash = 25% × 2,40,000 = 60,000; Apr debtors = 75% × Mar 2,20,000 = 1,65,000. May cash = 25% × 2,60,000 = 65,000; May debtors = 75% × Apr 2,40,000 = 1,80,000. Jun cash = 25% × 3,00,000 = 75,000; Jun debtors = 75% × May 2,60,000 = 1,95,000.

Step 2 — Cash payments. Note: purchases lag one month; overheads exclude the ₹8,000 depreciation (cash overhead = 30,000 − 8,000 = ₹22,000); machinery is *paid* in June though bought in May.

Payments	April	May	June
Payment to suppliers (prior month purchases)	1,20,000	1,40,000	1,50,000
Wages (same month)	40,000	44,000	48,000
Cash overheads (30,000 − 8,000 dep.)	22,000	22,000	22,000
Machinery (bought May, paid June)	—	—	1,00,000
Dividend	20,000	—	—
Total payments	**2,02,000**	**2,06,000**	**3,20,000**

Step 3 — Assemble the cash budget (closing balance chains into next opening).

	April	May	June
Opening balance	50,000	73,000	1,12,000
Add: Receipts	2,25,000	2,45,000	2,70,000
Less: Payments	(2,02,000)	(2,06,000)	(3,20,000)
Closing balance	**73,000**	**1,12,000**	**62,000**

Step 4 — Reconciliation and comment. Each closing rolls to the next opening: 50,000 → 73,000 → 1,12,000 → 62,000 ✓. Independent net check: total receipts (2,25,000+2,45,000+2,70,000 = 7,40,000) − total payments (2,02,000+2,06,000+3,20,000 = 7,28,000) = net +12,000; opening 50,000 + 12,000 = **62,000 closing ✓.**

Financing comment: the firm stays above its ₹25,000 minimum in all three months, so **no overdraft is needed.** In June the machinery payment (₹1,00,000) squeezes the balance from ₹1,12,000 down to ₹62,000, but it remains comfortable. The surplus in April–May (well above the ₹25,000 floor) could be short-term invested. *The two traps this problem tests — excluding the ₹8,000 depreciation, and timing the machinery payment in June not May — are exactly where marks are lost.*

Worked Example 5 (Exam-hard) — Cash Budget with a collection pattern, bad debts, cash discount and a minimum-balance overdraft

This is Example 4 "with the examiner's screws turned." It tests the wrinkles listed in Section 4.5.

Data. Orbit Ltd needs a cash budget for **Jul, Aug, Sep**.

Credit sales (₹): May 4,00,000; Jun 5,00,000; Jul 6,00,000; Aug 5,50,000; Sep 6,50,000. (All sales are on credit.) - **Collection pattern:** 50% in the month *after* sale (these customers take a **2% cash discount**), 30% in the second month after sale, 18% in the third month after sale, and **2% become bad debts.** - **Purchases (₹)** are 60% of the *same month's* sales and are **paid the following month** in full. - **Wages & cash expenses:** ₹1,20,000 per month, paid in the same month. - **Tax** of ₹90,000 is payable in **September**. - **Opening balance on 1 July = ₹40,000; minimum required balance = ₹1,00,000.** Any shortfall is met by an overdraft in multiples of ₹10,000 (ignore overdraft interest).

Required: the cash budget and the overdraft, if any, needed each month.

Step 1 — Build the collection schedule. For each sales month, 50% (less 2% discount) lands 1 month later, 30% two months later, 18% three months later. The *net* first-month collection = 50% × (1 − 2%) = 49% of that month's sales.

July collections come from: Jun (1 month back, 49%), May (2 months back, 30%), Apr (3 months back — not given, ignore/assume zero for the tail we lack). Since we lack April, and the problem gives us May onward, the earliest fully-computable "three-tail" month is September. To keep it clean, compute what the data supports:

Collected in →	July	Aug	Sep
From Jun (49% / 30% / 18%)	49% × 5,00,000 = 2,45,000	30% × 5,00,000 = 1,50,000	18% × 5,00,000 = 90,000
From May (30% / 18%)	30% × 4,00,000 = 1,20,000	18% × 4,00,000 = 72,000	—
From Jul (49% / 30%)	—	49% × 6,00,000 = 2,94,000	30% × 6,00,000 = 1,80,000
From Aug (49%)	—	—	49% × 5,50,000 = 2,69,500
Total receipts	**3,65,000**	**5,16,000**	**8,08,500**

(May's 49% one-month collection fell in June and Jun's earlier tail in May — outside our window — so they correctly do not appear. This "overlapping tails" build is exactly the split-pattern skill being tested.)

Step 2 — Payments. Purchases = 60% of the month's sales, paid next month. - Paid in Jul = 60% × Jun sales = 60% × 5,00,000 = 3,00,000 - Paid in Aug = 60% × Jul sales = 60% × 6,00,000 = 3,60,000 - Paid in Sep

= 60% × Aug sales = 60% × 5,50,000 = 3,30,000

Payments	July	Aug	Sep
Suppliers (60% of prior-month sales)	3,00,000	3,60,000	3,30,000
Wages & cash expenses	1,20,000	1,20,000	1,20,000
Tax	—	—	90,000
Total payments	**4,20,000**	**4,80,000**	**5,40,000**

Step 3 — Cash budget with the minimum-balance / overdraft mechanism.

	July	Aug	Sep
Opening balance	40,000	1,00,000	1,00,000
Add: Receipts	3,65,000	5,16,000	8,08,500
Less: Payments	(4,20,000)	(4,80,000)	(5,40,000)
Balance before financing	(15,000)	1,36,000	3,68,500
Overdraft drawn (to reach ₹1,00,000 min, in ₹10,000 multiples)	1,20,000	—	—
Overdraft repaid	—	(36,000)→ round to (30,000)	(90,000)
Closing balance	**1,05,000**	**1,06,000**	**3,78,500**

Financing logic: In July the pre-financing balance is −₹15,000, ₹1,15,000 below the ₹1,00,000 floor; drawing an overdraft in ₹10,000 multiples needs ₹1,20,000 to clear the floor (−15,000 + 1,20,000 = 1,05,000 ≥ 1,00,000). Thereafter surplus above the floor repays the overdraft in ₹10,000 multiples: Aug repays ₹30,000 (1,36,000 − 30,000 = 1,06,000, still ≥ floor), Sep repays the remaining ₹90,000 (3,68,500 − 90,000 = 2,78,500 — wait, recompute: outstanding after Aug = 1,20,000 − 30,000 = 90,000; Sep repays 90,000, closing 3,68,500 − 90,000 = 2,78,500).

Self-check / correction. Redoing Sep cleanly: opening 1,06,000 + receipts 8,08,500 − payments 5,40,000 = 3,74,500 before financing; repay full outstanding overdraft ₹90,000 → **closing ₹2,84,500**, comfortably above the floor and overdraft fully cleared by quarter-end. *(The lesson: always recompute the chained opening balances after each financing entry — a single mis-carried figure cascades. The examiner rewards the visible re-check, not just the final number.)*

Takeaways this problem drills: net-of-discount first-month collections (49% not 50%), bad debts simply never collected (the 2% vanishes), overlapping collection tails summed per column, and an overdraft sized to a *minimum balance* in stated multiples with subsequent repayment.

Worked Example 6 (Moderate) — Efficiency, Capacity and Activity ratios

Data. A department budgeted to produce **8,000 units** in a month, each with a standard time of **2 hours**, giving budgeted hours of 16,000. During the month it actually **worked 15,000 hours** and produced **7,800 units**.

Required: the efficiency, capacity and activity ratios, and their reconciliation.

Step 1 — The three hour-quantities. - Budgeted hours = 8,000 × 2 = **16,000 hrs** - Standard hours for actual output = 7,800 × 2 = **15,600 hrs** - Actual hours worked = **15,000 hrs**

Step 2 — The ratios. $$\text{Efficiency} = \frac{15{,}600}{15{,}000} \times 100 = \mathbf{104\%}$$ $$\text{Capacity} = \frac{15{,}000}{16{,}000} \times 100 = \mathbf{93.75\%}$$ $$\text{Activity} = \frac{15{,}600}{16{,}000} \times 100 = \mathbf{97.5\%}$$

Step 3 — Reconcile via the identity Activity = Efficiency × Capacity. $$1.04 \times 0.9375 = 0.975 = \mathbf{97.5\%} \checkmark$$

Interpretation. The team worked *fewer* hours than planned (capacity 93.75%, below 100% — perhaps idle time or fewer working days) but was *efficient* while working (104%, output beat the standard time). The net effect on output is a slight shortfall against plan (activity 97.5%). This is exactly how the examiner wants the story read: capacity is *how much you showed up*, efficiency is *how well you worked*, activity is *the combined effect on output*.

---

6. Presentation & Format Standards

- **Every budget carries a heading** stating the entity, the budget's name, and the **period/activity level** it is drawn for (e.g. "Flexible Budget at 60%, 80% and 100% capacity"). For flexible budgets, activity levels are the *columns*.
- **Order the functional budgets** in preparation sequence: sales → production → materials/labour/overheads → cash → master. Present workings (High–Low segregation, stock reconciliations) *before* the final statement.
- **Cash budget** uses the receipts-and-payments columnar format, one column per sub-period, with **Opening + Receipts − Payments = Closing**, and the closing balance visibly carried forward. State non-cash exclusions explicitly (a one-line note "depreciation excluded" earns clarity marks). When a minimum balance and overdraft feature, show a distinct "balance before financing" line, then the financing line, then the closing balance.
- **Variance reports** show three columns — *Flexed Budget, Actual, Variance* — and mark each **F (favourable)** or **A (adverse)**; end with a total that **reconciles** to the sum of the parts. Never compare a *fixed* budget with actual for control.
- **Flexible budget** lists costs by behaviour (variable block, semi-variable block, fixed block) so the reader sees the structure; show **cost per unit** as a final row to expose the fixed-cost-spreading effect.
- **Ratios** should be shown to two decimals with the % sign, and accompanied by the one-line reconciliation Activity = Efficiency × Capacity — a quantified answer without interpretation loses the "comment" marks.
- **State your assumptions.** Where the question is silent (e.g. whether closing stock is a policy figure, whether a discount applies), write a one-line assumption. A clearly stated reasonable assumption is rewarded; a silent one that turns out different is not.

---

7. Connections to the Rest of the Syllabus

- **Standard Costing & Variance Analysis (the sister chapter).** A flexible budget *is* the bridge to variances. The "budget allowance for actual output" that anchors every material, labour and overhead variance is nothing but the flexed budget. Worked Example 3's ₹37,000 is a total cost variance waiting to be split into price/usage and efficiency components. Budgetary control operates on *whole departments and functions*; standard costing drills into *per-unit* detail — same philosophy, different resolution. The efficiency/capacity/activity ratios of Section 4.4a are literally the *fixed-overhead volume variance* decomposed into its efficiency and capacity sub-variances.

- **Marginal Costing & CVP.** Flexing depends entirely on the fixed/variable split — the identical cost behaviour classification underpinning contribution, break-even and the P/V ratio. The line "Total cost = Fixed + Variable × units" *is* the marginal-costing cost function.
- **Cost behaviour & segregation.** High–Low (and least-squares) segregation, learned here, is the same tool used across overhead analysis.
- **Budgetary control vs Standard costing distinction** is a favourite theory question: budgets set *overall* limits (extensive), standards set *per-unit* norms (intensive); budgets can exist without standards, standards need budgets to become a control system.
- **Working-capital & financial management.** The cash budget is the operational face of cash management and working-capital planning; the collection-pattern and creditor-lag mechanics reappear as the debtors/creditors cycles in the operating-cycle computation.
- **Activity-Based Costing.** Activity-based budgeting (Section 4.7) is ABC run forwards — driver rates set the budget instead of explaining the actual.

---

8. Traps & Examiner Tricks

1. **Comparing a fixed budget with actuals for control.** The single biggest conceptual error. If activity differs from plan, you *must* flex first. A question that gives a fixed budget and different actual output is *testing whether you know to flex.*
2. **Depreciation in the cash budget.** Depreciation is a cost but **never a cash flow.** Exclude it. If overheads are given "including depreciation," subtract it before entering payments (Worked Example 4: ₹30,000 − ₹8,000 = ₹22,000). The same applies to any accrued-but-unpaid expense.
3. **Timing lags — sales *made* vs cash *collected*, purchases *made* vs cash *paid*.** Enter cash when it moves, not when the transaction is booked. Machinery *bought* in May but *paid* in June is a June payment.
4. **Confusing material usage with material purchases.** Usage is driven by production; purchases differ by the change in raw-material stock. Two separate reconciliations (finished goods and raw material) are required.
5. **Forgetting the stock adjustment in the production budget.** Units to produce ≠ units to sell unless opening and closing FG stocks are equal. Add closing, subtract opening. And if closing stock is defined as "a fraction of *next* period's sales," look forward, not backward.
6. **Flexing fixed costs.** Fixed costs stay *fixed* when you flex — do **not** scale them with activity. Conversely, do not leave variable costs unflexed. The whole art is treating each behaviour correctly. (And a semi-variable cost must be split, not flexed whole.)
7. **Relevant range and step-ups.** Fixed costs are fixed only within a range; a huge jump in activity may push into a new range with stepped-up fixed costs. Read the data for such step-ups and switch the fixed figure at the boundary — do not copy one fixed number blindly across all activity columns.
8. **Sign and reconciliation discipline.** Label every variance F or A, and **prove** the individual variances sum to the total. An unreconciled answer signals an arithmetic slip.

9. **"Budget vs forecast."** A forecast predicts; a budget commits and is used for control. Theory questions probe this. Likewise "budget vs budgeting vs budgetary control" — know all three.
10. **Minimum cash balance.** When a minimum balance is specified, the answer is incomplete without commenting on **financing (overdraft)** or **investible surplus** relative to that floor — and, if borrowing is in stated multiples, round *up* to clear the floor.
11. **ZBB is not "starting the whole company from scratch."** It re-justifies *each activity* via decision packages and ranking; it is usually applied to discretionary costs and periodically, given its cost.
12. **High–Low endpoint error.** Choose the highest and lowest *activity* levels, never the highest and lowest *cost* figures; and beware an abnormal endpoint or a hidden fixed-cost step between the two points, which distorts the derived variable rate.
13. **Collection-pattern traps.** Apply cash discount to the *discount-taking* slice only (49%, not 50%, of that tail); let bad debts simply never be collected; and remember to *sum the overlapping tails* from several past months in each column.
14. **Wrong driver for a semi-variable/selling cost.** "2% of sales value" flexes against *sales value*, not units; selling overhead often keys off sales, production overhead off output. Flex each cost against its own driver.
15. **Principal budget factor mis-identification.** When two constraints are given, compute the output each permits and pick the *smaller*; do not assume sales is always the limiting factor.

---

9. First-Principles Recap

Strip everything away and rebuild:

1. A business is many managers deciding the future *today*, each dependent on the others. Left alone they produce an inconsistent plan. So we write one **priced, agreed plan — the budget** — to *coordinate*, *motivate*, and *control* (and to *delegate with control* via responsibility accounting).
2. Because resources are finite, we build the plan **starting from the scarcest resource** (the principal budget factor — usually sales, but test which constraint bites first). Everything else is sized to it, in a fixed sequence: sales → production → materials/labour/overheads → cash → master.
3. To *control*, the plan must become a fair yardstick. A **fixed** budget, frozen at one activity level, is unfair the moment activity moves — it mixes the *volume* effect with the *efficiency* effect. So we **flex** the budget to the activity that actually occurred, which demands splitting every cost into **fixed, variable, semi-variable** (and watching for **stepped** costs; High–Low segregates the mixed ones). Flexed budget vs actual = the *genuine* cost performance.
4. **Cash ≠ profit.** A separate **cash budget** tracks only real cash flows, timed when they move, excluding non-cash items like depreciation, so the firm foresees deficits and surpluses and arranges finance in advance — the chapter's one clear *feed-forward* instrument.
5. All functional budgets consolidate into the **master budget** — the board's approved plan and yardstick, split into an operating half and a financial half.
6. Performance can be read in *hours* through the **efficiency, capacity and activity ratios**, tied by Activity = Efficiency × Capacity.
7. When last year's base is itself suspect, **ZBB** rebuilds from zero, re-justifying every activity so inherited waste cannot survive; incremental budgeting is cheap but re-funds waste.

8. Finally, a budget is run by people, so its success turns as much on **behaviour** (participation, aspiration levels, slack) and its **limitations** as on the arithmetic.

Every formula in this chapter is a servant of one of these ideas. None was memorised; each was *needed*.

---

10. Quick-Revision Sheet

Concept	Formula / Rule	Why it exists
Principal budget factor	The scarcest resource; build the budget starting here (usually sales); if two, pick the one permitting *less* output	Planning beyond the constraint creates inconsistency
Production budget (units)	Budgeted sales + Desired closing FG stock − Opening FG stock	Make enough for sales *and* the stock build, net of opening stock
Material usage budget	Units produced × material per unit	Consumption is driven by production
Material purchase budget (qty)	Material consumed + Desired closing RM stock − Opening RM stock	Buying differs from using by the change in RM stock
Material purchase (value)	Purchase quantity × price per unit	Drives cash outflow to suppliers
Direct labour budget	Units produced × hours per unit × wage rate; headcount = total hrs ÷ hrs per worker	Sizes workforce and wage cost
Flexible budget (total cost)	Total fixed cost + (Variable cost per unit × activity)	Re-computes cost at actual activity for fair control
High–Low variable rate	(Cost at high − Cost at low) ÷ (High units − Low units)	Segregates the variable slice of a semi-variable cost
High–Low fixed part	Total cost at a level − (Variable rate × units at that level)	Isolates the fixed lump
Semi-variable cost	Fixed part + (Variable rate × units); flex against its *own* driver	Must be split before flexing
Stepped fixed cost	Fixed within a band; jumps at the band boundary	Only "fixed" within the relevant range
Variance (control)	Flexed budget − Actual (mark F or A)	Compares like with like; excludes volume effect
Volume effect	Flexed budget − Fixed budget	The non-controllable cost of a different activity level
Efficiency ratio	Std hrs for actual output ÷ Actual hrs worked × 100	How *well* the hours were worked
Capacity ratio	Actual hrs worked ÷ Budgeted hrs × 100	How *much* of planned capacity was used
Activity ratio	Std hrs for actual output ÷ Budgeted hrs × 100	Output vs plan; = Efficiency × Capacity
Cash budget	Opening balance + Receipts − Payments = Closing (chained)	Foresees cash surplus/deficit; profit ≠ cash
Cash budget — exclusions	Exclude depreciation and all non-cash/accrued items; time flows when cash moves	Only real bank movements matter

Concept	Formula / Rule	Why it exists
Cash collection with discount	First-tail collection = %-slice × (1 − discount); bad debts never collected	Reflects real cash received
Master budget	Consolidation of all functional budgets (budgeted P&L + Balance Sheet + cash); operating + financial halves	The board's single approved plan and yardstick
Incremental budgeting	Last year's figure + a %	Simple but re-funds past waste
Zero-based budgeting	Every activity justified from zero via decision packages, ranked and funded top-down	Kills inherited waste; ties spend to objectives
Budgetary control	Establish budgets → assign → compare actual vs budget → act/revise	Turns the plan into a running control system
Budget vs forecast	Forecast predicts; budget commits and controls	A budget is a decision, not a guess

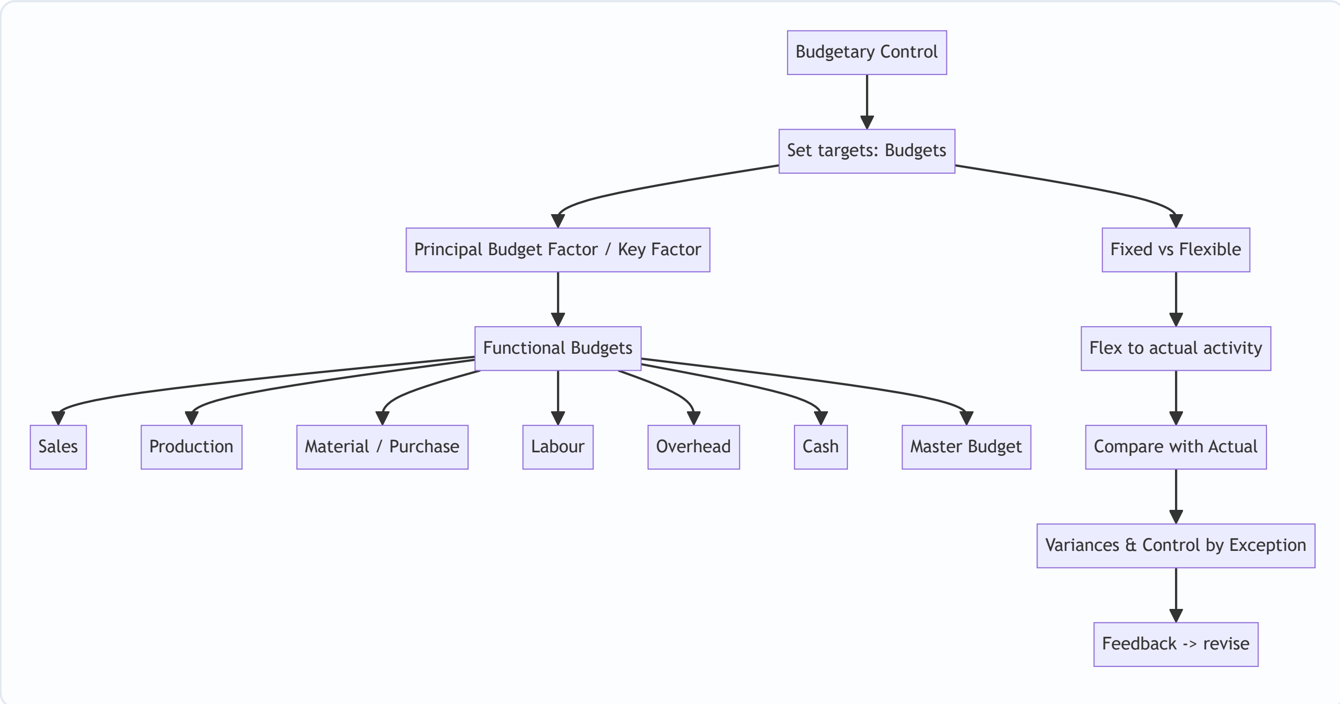
Cost-behaviour reminder for flexing: *Variable* — total moves with activity, per-unit constant. *Fixed* — total constant, per-unit falls as activity rises. *Semi-variable* — split into fixed lump + variable slice before use. *Stepped* — fixed within a band, jumps at the boundary.

Golden control rule: *Never* judge cost performance by comparing a fixed budget with actual results at a different activity level. Flex first; then, and only then, is the variance real.

Q&A — Budgets & Budgetary Control

CA Intermediate · Cost & Management Accounting · ICAI-aligned · All figures in Rupees (₹)

The map of this chapter



First-principles hook: A budget is a *priced itinerary* — you decide where the business is going (targets), cost every leg of the journey, then check en route whether you are on track. Budgetary control = plan, flex, compare, act.

Section A — Concept-check (with answers)

A1. Define budgetary control in one line. *Answer:* The establishment of budgets relating responsibilities of executives to policy requirements, and the continuous comparison of actual with budgeted results to secure the objective by individual action or revision of policy.

A2. What is the *principal budget factor* and why is it identified first? *Answer:* The factor that limits the activities of the undertaking (e.g., sales demand, material, machine capacity, cash). It is found first because every other budget must be built around it; budgeting the wrong factor first wastes the plan.

A3. State the core difference between a fixed and a flexible budget. *Answer:* A fixed budget is drawn for one level of activity and stays unchanged; a flexible budget is designed to change with the actual level of activity by segregating costs into fixed and variable elements.

A4. Why is a fixed budget useless as a control tool when volume changes? *Answer:* Because it compares actual cost at one activity level with budgeted cost at a *different* activity level — the variance mixes a volume effect with a genuine efficiency/spending effect, so it cannot isolate controllable performance.

A5. Which items are excluded from a cash budget and why? *Answer:* Non-cash items — depreciation, provisions, notional rent, bad-debt provisions, goodwill written off — because a cash budget records only actual cash inflows and outflows, not accounting charges.

A6. Distinguish zero-based budgeting (ZBB) from incremental budgeting. *Answer:* Incremental budgeting takes last year's figures + an increment as the base. ZBB starts from a "zero base" — every activity must be justified afresh each period as a decision package ranked by cost-benefit, so nothing is carried forward unquestioned.

A7. What is a master budget? *Answer:* The consolidated summary of all functional budgets, culminating in a budgeted Profit & Loss Account and budgeted Balance Sheet — the overall financial blueprint.

A8. Give the production budget identity. *Answer:* Units to be produced = Budgeted Sales + Desired Closing Stock of FG − Opening Stock of FG.

A9. Give the materials purchase (quantity) identity. *Answer:* Purchases = Material consumed in production + Desired Closing Stock of RM − Opening Stock of RM.

A10. What does "control by exception" mean here? *Answer:* Management attention is directed only to significant variances (exceptions) between budget and actual, not to every line — saving effort and focusing on what matters.

Section B — Graded computational problems (full workings)

B1 (Easy) — Production budget

Budgeted sales 12,000 units. Opening FG stock 1,500 units; desired closing FG stock 2,000 units.

Solution: Production = Sales + Closing − Opening = 12,000 + 2,000 − 1,500 = **12,500 units.**

Check: Units available = Opening 1,500 + Produced 12,500 = 14,000; less Sales 12,000 = Closing 2,000 ✓.

B2 (Easy-Moderate) — Material purchase budget

From B1, each unit needs 3 kg of material at ₹20/kg. Opening RM stock 4,000 kg; desired closing RM stock 5,000 kg.

Solution: Material consumed = 12,500 units × 3 kg = 37,500 kg. Purchases (kg) = 37,500 + 5,000 − 4,000 = **38,500 kg.** Purchases (value) = 38,500 × ₹20 = **₹7,70,000.**

Check: RM available = Opening 4,000 + Purchases 38,500 = 42,500 kg; less consumed 37,500 = Closing 5,000 ✓.

B3 (Moderate) — High-Low cost segregation

Overhead observed: at 8,000 units cost ₹94,000; at 12,000 units cost ₹1,26,000.

Solution: Variable rate = (1,26,000 − 94,000) ÷ (12,000 − 8,000) = 32,000 ÷ 4,000 = **₹8/unit.** Fixed cost = 1,26,000 − (12,000 × 8) = 1,26,000 − 96,000 = **₹30,000.**

Check at 8,000 units: 30,000 + 8,000×8 = 30,000 + 64,000 = ₹94,000 ✓.

B4 (Moderate-Hard) — Flexible budget

Using B3 costs, prepare a flexible budget at 8,000, 10,000 and 12,000 units. Selling price ₹25/unit.

Particulars	8,000 u	10,000 u	12,000 u
Sales (@₹25)	2,00,000	2,50,000	3,00,000
Variable OH (@₹8)	64,000	80,000	96,000
Fixed OH	30,000	30,000	30,000
Total cost	94,000	1,10,000	1,26,000
Profit	1,06,000	1,40,000	1,74,000

Check: Contribution/unit = 25 − 8 = ₹17. At 10,000 u: contribution 1,70,000 − fixed 30,000 = ₹1,40,000 ✓.

B5 (Exam-Hard) — Flexible budget as a control tool, fully reconciled

Budget was set for **10,000 units**: Sales ₹2,50,000; Variable cost ₹8/unit; Fixed cost ₹30,000; budgeted profit ₹1,40,000 (from B4).

Actual for the period (9,000 units): Sales ₹2,29,500; Variable cost ₹75,600; Fixed cost ₹31,000.

Step 1 — Flex the budget to actual 9,000 units: Sales = 9,000 × 25 = ₹2,25,000; Variable = 9,000 × 8 = ₹72,000; Fixed = ₹30,000. Flexed profit = 2,25,000 − 72,000 − 30,000 = **₹1,23,000.**

Step 2 — Compare actual vs flexed budget:

Item	Flexed (9,000 u)	Actual	Variance
Sales	2,25,000	2,29,500	+4,500 (F)
Variable cost	72,000	75,600	−3,600 (A)
Fixed cost	30,000	31,000	−1,000 (A)
Profit	1,23,000	1,22,900	−100 (A)

Step 3 — Reconcile original budgeted profit to actual profit:

	₹
Budgeted profit (10,000 u)	1,40,000
Less: Volume effect (1,000 u × ₹17 contribution)	(17,000)
= Flexed budget profit (9,000 u)	1,23,000
Add: Selling-price variance	4,500 (F)
Less: Variable cost variance	(3,600) (A)
Less: Fixed cost (spending) variance	(1,000) (A)
= Actual profit	**1,22,900**

Self-verify: 1,40,000 − 17,000 + 4,500 − 3,600 − 1,000 = 1,22,900 ✓. The reconciliation ties exactly, and the flexible budget separates the ₹17,000 volume drop (uncontrollable in this comparison) from the small ₹100 net operating shortfall.

B6 (Exam-Hard) — Cash budget

Prepare a cash budget for Apr–Jun. Opening cash (1 Apr): ₹40,000. Sales: Feb 1,00,000; Mar 1,20,000; Apr 1,50,000; May 1,60,000; Jun 1,80,000. Collections: 40% in month of sale, 50% next month, 10% second month after. Purchases: Apr 80,000; May 90,000; Jun 1,00,000 — paid in the following month. Wages ₹25,000/month paid same month. Overheads ₹15,000/month (includes ₹5,000 depreciation) paid same month. Machinery ₹60,000 paid in June.

Collections working:

Received in	40% current	50% prev	10% 2-prev	Total
Apr	60,000 (Apr)	60,000 (Mar)	10,000 (Feb)	1,30,000
May	64,000 (May)	75,000 (Apr)	12,000 (Mar)	1,51,000
Jun	72,000 (Jun)	80,000 (May)	15,000 (Apr)	1,67,000

Cash overhead = 15,000 − 5,000 depreciation = **₹10,000/month** (depreciation excluded).

Particulars	Apr	May	Jun
Opening balance	40,000	20,000	41,000
Add: Collections	1,30,000	1,51,000	1,67,000
Total available	1,70,000	1,71,000	2,08,000
Less: Purchases paid	—	80,000	90,000
Less: Wages	25,000	25,000	25,000
Less: Cash overheads	10,000	10,000	10,000
Less: Machinery	—	—	60,000
Total payments	35,000	1,15,000	1,85,000
Closing balance	20,000	41,000	23,000

Note: April purchase (80,000) is paid in May; June purchase (1,00,000) is paid in July, so it does not appear here. Depreciation is correctly excluded.

Check May opening = April closing ₹20,000 ✓; June opening = May closing ₹41,000 ✓.

Section C — Past-paper-style full questions

C1. "A flexible budget is superior to a fixed budget for cost control." Discuss. (5 marks)

Model answer: A fixed budget is prepared for a single, pre-determined level of activity and is not adjusted when actual output differs. If actual volume deviates, comparing actual cost against the fixed budget produces variances contaminated by the volume change — management cannot tell whether a cost overrun is due to inefficiency or simply because more units were made.

A flexible budget overcomes this by classifying costs into fixed, variable and semi-variable, then re-casting ("flexing") the cost allowance to the *actual* activity level. Advantages: (i) it isolates genuinely controllable spending and efficiency variances from volume effects; (ii) it is realistic for businesses with seasonal or uncertain demand; (iii) it improves accountability and performance appraisal. Hence for **control** purposes the flexible budget is superior, whereas the fixed budget still serves as the original *planning* benchmark.

C2. Explain the principal budget factor and give four examples. (4 marks)

Model answer: The principal (key/limiting) budget factor is the constraint that, at a given time, limits the organisation's activity and therefore governs the preparation order of all budgets. The budget for this factor is prepared first; all others are subordinated to it. Examples: (i) **Sales** — insufficient market demand; (ii) **Materials** — shortage/rationing of a key input; (iii) **Labour** — scarcity of skilled workers; (iv) **Plant capacity / machine hours** — bottleneck equipment. Cash availability can also be the key factor.

C3. Prepare a materials purchase budget. (6 marks)

A company makes products X and Y. Budgeted production: X 5,000 units, Y 4,000 units. Material M per unit: X 2 kg, Y 3 kg. Price ₹50/kg. Opening RM 3,000 kg, closing RM 4,000 kg.

Model answer: Consumption = X(5,000×2) + Y(4,000×3) = 10,000 + 12,000 = 22,000 kg. Purchases = 22,000 + 4,000 − 3,000 = **23,000 kg.** Value = 23,000 × ₹50 = **₹11,50,000.** *Check:* 3,000 + 23,000 − 22,000 = 4,000 kg closing ✓.

Section D — MCQs & case scenarios

D1. A budget that remains unchanged regardless of activity level is a: A) Flexible budget B) Fixed budget C) Cash budget D) Master budget **Ans: B.** *A fixed budget is set for one activity level and not adjusted.*

D2. Using High-Low, cost ₹50,000 at 5,000 u and ₹70,000 at 9,000 u. Variable rate = A) ₹4 B) ₹5 C) ₹6 D) ₹8 **Ans: B.** *(70,000−50,000)/(9,000−5,000) = 20,000/4,000 = ₹5.*

D3. Which is NOT included in a cash budget? A) Machinery purchase B) Depreciation C) Wages paid D) Tax paid **Ans: B.** *Depreciation is a non-cash charge, so it is excluded.*

D4. ZBB primarily differs from incremental budgeting because it: A) Uses prior year + increment B) Requires each activity to be justified from zero C) Ignores cost-benefit D) Applies only to cash **Ans: B.** *Every decision package is re-justified afresh each period.*

D5. Production = 20,000 sales, opening FG 2,000, closing FG 3,000. Units produced = A) 19,000 B) 20,000 C) 21,000 D) 25,000 **Ans: C.** *20,000 + 3,000 − 2,000 = 21,000.*

D6 (Case). A firm budgeted profit ₹5,00,000 at 50,000 units (contribution ₹15/u, fixed ₹2,50,000). Actual output 46,000 units. What is the flexed budget profit? A) ₹4,40,000 B) ₹4,60,000 C) ₹5,00,000 D) ₹4,00,000 **Ans: A.** *Flex contribution 46,000×15 = 6,90,000 − fixed 2,50,000 = ₹4,40,000.* The ₹60,000 fall from budget is purely a volume effect (4,000 u × ₹15).

D7 (Case). In D6, if actual fixed cost was ₹2,60,000 and actual contribution ₹6,85,000, the actual profit is: A) ₹4,25,000 B) ₹4,40,000 C) ₹4,30,000 D) ₹4,20,000 **Ans: A.** *6,85,000 − 2,60,000 = ₹4,25,000; a ₹15,000 adverse operating gap versus the flexed ₹4,40,000 (₹5,000 contribution A + ₹10,000 fixed spend A).*

D8. The consolidation of all functional budgets into budgeted P&L and Balance Sheet is the: A) Sales budget B) Master budget C) Flexible budget D) Capital budget **Ans: B.** *Master budget = the overall summarised financial plan.*

Connections & examiner traps

- **Standard costing link:** the flexible-budget variance in B5 is the doorway to material/labour/overhead variance analysis — same flex-then-compare logic.
- **CVP link:** contribution per unit (SP − variable cost) drives both the volume variance and break-even; a flexible budget is CVP arithmetic applied to control.
- **Trap 1:** Do NOT deduct opening stock twice — production adds closing and subtracts opening; purchases likewise for RM. Direction matters.
- **Trap 2:** Depreciation, provisions and notional charges must be stripped out of the cash budget (see B6).
- **Trap 3:** Payment/collection *timing lags* — pay a purchase in the month *after* purchase; a purchase in the last month often has no cash outflow in the budget period.
- **Trap 4:** When flexing, fixed cost stays constant in the flexed allowance; only variable cost moves with volume.

First-principles recap & formula sheet

- Production = Sales + Closing FG − Opening FG
- Purchases = Consumption + Closing RM − Opening RM
- Variable rate (High-Low) = ΔCost ÷ ΔUnits
- Fixed cost = Total cost − (Variable rate × Units)
- Contribution/unit = Selling price − Variable cost/unit
- Volume variance = (Actual − Budget units) × Contribution/unit
- Flexed profit = (Actual units × Contribution/unit) − Fixed cost
- Closing cash = Opening cash + Receipts − Payments (cash items only)

Cost & Management Accounting — Exam Strategy, Answer Templates & Examiner Traps

CA Intermediate, Paper 3. 100 marks, 3 hours. Division A = 30 marks MCQ (with **0.25 negative marking**), Division B = 70 marks descriptive/numerical. This guide is about *scoring* the marks you already know how to earn — not about learning the syllabus. Read it the week before the exam and again the night before.

Part 1 — Paper Strategy: How to Spend the 3 Hours

1.1 The overall shape of the paper

- **Division A (30 marks):** ~15 MCQs. Mix of one-liner conceptual MCQs (1 mark) and short computational MCQs (2 marks). Compulsory. **0.25 negative per wrong answer.**
- **Division B (70 marks):** Question 1 is usually compulsory; then attempt any 4 of the remaining 5. Each question 14–15 marks, typically split into a numerical part and a theory/short-note part.
- The paper is **not** time-generous. Costing numericals eat time. The single biggest reason students lose marks is **not finishing**, not "not knowing." Plan for the clock, not for perfection.

1.2 The 15-minute reading time — use it as *planning* time, not reading time

You get 15 minutes of reading time before you may write. Do NOT spend it slowly re-reading every word. Do this instead:

1. **Triage Division B first.** Go straight to the choice questions. Mark each as **A (I can do this fully and fast), B (I can do most of it), C (avoid)**. Pick your 4 optional questions NOW so you never waste live time deciding.
2. **Spot the "sitting ducks"** — the theory sub-parts (short notes, distinctions, "state four features of..."). These are pure recall, no computation risk. Mentally note which ones you'll bank.
3. **Glance at the MCQ computational ones** — identify which are 30-second reads vs. which need a mini-workings. Don't solve yet.
4. **Decide your opening move.** Most scorers open with a theory-heavy or a topic-you-own numerical to build confidence and bank marks fast.

1.3 The order to attempt (recommended)

Slot	What	Why
First 20 min	**Division B theory sub-parts + your single strongest numerical**	Bank certain marks while your mind is fresh and the clock isn't yet a threat. Confidence compounds.
Next ~75 min	**The remaining Division B numericals** you triaged as A/B	This is where the bulk of marks live. Give each ~17–18 min and *move on when time's up*, even mid-question.
~25 min	**Division A MCQs**	Do these when the descriptive load is off your chest, so a tricky 2-mark MCQ doesn't steal time from a 15-mark question. Some students prefer MCQs first — that's fine IF you cap it at 25 min hard.
Last ~20 min	**Overflow + review**	Finish any half-done statement, fill final-answer boxes, re-check MCQ transfers to the answer grid, revisit skipped MCQs you can now guess intelligently.

Golden clock rule: ~1.6 minutes per mark. A 15-mark question deserves ~24 minutes and **not one minute more.** Wear a watch. Write the "leave-by" clock time in the margin next to each question as you start it.

1.4 The most important discipline: the hard stop

The classic failure pattern is spending 40 minutes chasing a Process Costing / Reconciliation numerical whose balancing figure won't tie, and then leaving a full 14-mark question unattempted. **A question you don't start scores zero. A question you 70%-finish scores ~10/14.** Partial always beats perfect-but-absent.

- If your Cost Sheet / Reconciliation / Balance Sheet won't balance after **one** recheck, **stop hunting the difference.** Write "Difference of ₹___ due to un-located error" as a balancing line, present a clean statement, and move on. You keep almost all the method marks; you lose maybe 1.
- Never let one question breach its time box by more than ~5 minutes.

1.5 Division A MCQ tactics under 0.25 negative marking

The negative marking is **0.25 per wrong answer** (i.e., one-fourth). This is *mild* — it should change your behaviour only at the margin, not make you timid.

The expected-value logic (learn this cold): - A blank MCQ = **0**. - A wrong MCQ = **−0.25**. - A right MCQ = **+1** (or +2).

For a 1-mark MCQ, if you can eliminate even **one** of four options, guessing among the remaining three has expected value = (1/3)(+1) + (2/3)(−0.25) = 0.33 − 0.17 = **+0.16 > 0.** So **guess.** With 4 blind options, EV = (1/4)(1) + (3/4)(−0.25) = 0.25 − 0.19 = **+0.06 > 0** — still marginally positive.

Practical rules: 1. **Never leave an MCQ blank if you can eliminate even one option.** The math is strongly in your favour. 2. **Even a pure blind guess is (barely) positive EV** — but only guess blind *after* you've attempted everything else, so a rushed misread doesn't cost you a certain mark elsewhere. 3. **The real danger is not the penalty — it's the misread.** ICAI MCQs punish "EXCEPT / NOT / least / most appropriate" phrasing. Circle the negative word in the question before choosing. 4. **Two-pass the MCQs.** Pass 1: answer everything instant/certain (30 sec each), flag the computational ones. Pass 2: return to flagged ones with your remaining MCQ time. This prevents a 2-mark calc from cannibalising ten 1-mark sitters. 5. **Transfer**

discipline. If there's a separate OMR/answer grid, transfer in batches and re-verify question numbers. A one-row slip cascades and is the single most catastrophic avoidable error. 6. **Do the 2-mark computational MCQs as mini-numericals** on the rough sheet — labour rate variance, EOQ, machine hour rate, equivalent units. They're worth double; don't eyeball them.

1.6 How to maximise step / partial marks in Division B

ICAI marks numericals **step-wise**, not all-or-nothing. The final figure is often only 1–2 marks of a 14-mark answer; the **method, format, and workings carry the rest.** Extract every step mark:

- **Write the formula before plugging numbers.** A stated formula earns marks even if your arithmetic later slips.
- **Show workings as numbered "Working Notes"** below the main statement. Examiners hunt WNs for step marks. An unexplained correct number scores *less* than a shown wrong-but-logical one.
- **Carry your (possibly wrong) subtotal forward consistently.** If you mis-add cost in step 2, using that wrong figure correctly in steps 3–6 still earns the downstream method marks. This is the "own figure" / follow-through principle — examiners apply it.
- **Label every figure with its head and unit** (₹, per unit, per hour, kg). Ambiguous numbers get no benefit of the doubt.
- **Never erase a whole attempt.** Strike a single diagonal line through rejected work; a marker may still credit visible correct steps.
- **Answer the theory sub-part even if the numerical broke.** They're independent marks. A stuck 10-mark numerical does not cost you the 4-mark short note attached to it.
- **Attempt the last (5th) question even thinly.** Two decent sub-parts of a question you "don't like" often out-score polishing a question you've already maxed.

Part 2 — Answer-Writing Templates (Subject-Specific)

The universal costing answer has **four moves**: **(1) State the formula → (2) Show the step-by-step computation in a neat statement/table → (3) Show Working Notes → (4) Box the final answer.** Presentation is graded. A tidy, well-headed statement genuinely scores higher than the same numbers scrawled.

2.1 The four-move skeleton

```
[Heading: Statement of _______ / Cost Sheet of _______ for the period ____]

Formula: <write the relevant formula(e) in symbols, then in words>

<Main statement / table — columns labelled, ₹ and unit columns, subtotals shown>

Working Notes:
 WN-1: ...
 WN-2: ...

┌──────────────────────────────────────────┐
│  Answer: <final figure, with unit>         │
└──────────────────────────────────────────┘
```

2.2 Format cues per topic (what the examiner expects to *see*)

- **Cost Sheet:** the vertical build-up — Prime Cost → Works/Factory Cost (± opening/closing WIP) → Cost of Production (+ opening − closing FG) → Cost of Goods Sold → Cost of Sales → Sales. Always add "Cost per unit" column when output units are given.
- **Process Costing: Statement of Equivalent Production → Statement of Cost per Equivalent Unit → Statement of Evaluation (Apportionment) → Process Account.** Normal loss at scrap value, abnormal loss/gain to their own accounts. State the method (FIFO vs Average) in one line at the top.
- **Reconciliation (Cost vs Financial):** memorandum reconciliation statement — start from one profit, **add** items that made financial profit higher / cost profit lower, **subtract** the reverse. Head every line with the *reason*.
- **Marginal Costing:** always show **Contribution = Sales − Variable Cost**, then **P/V ratio**, **BEP**, **Margin of Safety** in that logical chain. State each formula.
- **Standard Costing (Variances):** state the variance formula, then substitute. Always tag each variance **(F)** or **(A)**. Cross-check: sum of sub-variances = the total variance — show that reconciliation; it's a free mark and catches errors.
- **Budgets / Flexible Budget:** columns per activity level; separate fixed and variable clearly; show per-unit variable rate as a WN.
- **Labour/Overhead:** state the absorption base and rate as a WN before applying it.

2.3 Worked specimen answer (this is the presentation to imitate)

Q. A worker is paid under the Rowan premium plan. Standard time for a job is 40 hours; actual time taken is 30 hours; wage rate is ₹50 per hour. Compute the earnings and the effective hourly rate.

Statement of Earnings under Rowan Premium Plan

Formulae: - Time Saved = Standard (Allowed) Time − Actual Time Taken - Basic Wages = Actual Time Taken × Rate per Hour - Rowan Bonus = (Time Saved ÷ Standard Time) × Actual Time Taken × Rate per Hour -

Total Earnings = Basic Wages + Rowan Bonus

Computation:

Particulars	Working	Amount (₹)
Basic Wages	30 hrs × ₹50	1,500
Add: Rowan Bonus	(10 ÷ 40) × 30 × ₹50	375
Total Earnings		**1,875**

Working Notes: - **WN-1 — Time Saved:** 40 hrs − 30 hrs = **10 hours** - **WN-2 — Effective Hourly Rate:** Total Earnings ÷ Actual Time = ₹1,875 ÷ 30 hrs = **₹62.50 per hour**

┌─────────────────────────────────────┐ │ **Answer:** Total Earnings = **₹1,875**; Effective Rate = **₹62.50/hr** │ └─────────────────────────────────────┘

Notice what earned marks: the **formula stated up front** (marks even if arithmetic slipped), the **labelled statement**, the **numbered WNs the examiner can scan**, the **units on every figure**, and the **boxed final answer**. Copy this shape for every numerical.

2.4 Templates for theory questions (don't write essays)

- **"Distinguish between X and Y":** always a **two-column table** with a labelled *basis of distinction* down the left. 4–5 bases. Never write it as flowing paragraphs — the table scores faster and fuller.
- **"Short note / State the features of": point form**, one crisp line each, ideally 4–5 points. Bold the lead term of each point.
- **"Define + explain":** open with a **one-line definition** (ICAI/CIMA phrasing if you know it), then bullets, then a one-line example if relevant.
- Keep theory tight: examiners reward **coverage of distinct points**, not length. Five sharp points beat two padded paragraphs.

Part 3 — Examiner Traps Specific to Cost & Management Accounting

These are the recurring, deliberate ways ICAI separates the careful from the fast-and-loose in *this* paper. Each is a mark-loss pattern that shows up year after year.

3.1 Treatment-of-loss traps (Process & Job Costing)

- **Normal loss carries scrap value, abnormal loss does NOT get "free" absorption.** Trap: students value abnormal loss units at scrap rate instead of at *cost per good unit*. **Rule:** abnormal loss/gain is valued at the **cost per equivalent good unit**, and normal loss reduces the cost base by its scrap value first.
- **Abnormal gain reduces normal loss units** and is debited to the process account. Students forget the abnormal-gain adjustment to normal loss scrap value in the Normal Loss A/c. Handle the Normal Loss account explicitly.

3.2 Stock-valuation and cost-flow traps

- **"Cost of production" vs "Cost of goods sold" vs "Cost of sales."** ICAI phrases the *asked* figure precisely. Answering CGS when they asked Cost of Production (or forgetting to adjust opening/closing **finished goods** vs opening/closing **WIP** at the correct stage) is a classic. **Adjust WIP at works-cost stage, finished goods at cost-of-production stage.** Re-read exactly which total is demanded.
- **Under/over-absorbed overhead:** students net it in the wrong direction. Under-absorption is *added* to cost / *deducted* from profit. Verify the sign.

3.3 The variance-sign trap (Standard Costing)

- Every variance must be tagged **(F)avourable** or **(A)dverse**, and the sign convention flips between cost variances and sales variances. Trap: getting the magnitude right but the direction wrong = lost marks. **Always cross-verify** that sub-variances sum to the total variance; if they don't, a sign is wrong.
- **Material Mix vs Yield, Labour Mix vs Idle-time:** idle time is *always adverse* and must be split out separately when idle hours are given. Students bury idle time inside the efficiency variance.

3.4 The marginal-costing "period cost" trap

- Under **marginal costing, fixed overhead is a period cost** — never carried in stock; under **absorption costing it is.** ICAI loves a question where opening/closing stock differs, so the two methods give different profit, then asks you to *reconcile*. Trap: absorbing fixed cost into marginal stock, or forgetting the stock-difference × fixed-OH-per-unit reconciliation. Keep the two systems mentally separate.

3.5 The units/rate trap (per-unit, per-hour, per-machine-hour)

- **Machine Hour Rate:** trap questions bundle in items that must be *excluded* (e.g., costs not related to running the machine) or ask for a **comprehensive** rate that includes operator wages. Read whether it's "machine hour rate" or "comprehensive machine hour rate."
- Mixing up **direct labour hour rate vs machine hour rate** as the absorption base. State your chosen base explicitly as a WN.

3.6 The "read the plan" trap (Incentive schemes)

- **Halsey vs Rowan** produce different bonuses; the question dictates which. Under **Halsey**, bonus = 50% of (time saved × rate); under **Rowan**, bonus = (time saved / standard time) × time taken × rate. Trap: applying the wrong plan's formula, or using *time saved* × *rate* directly in Rowan. Also: **Rowan gives higher earnings than Halsey when time saved is up to 50% of standard time** — examiners test this comparison in theory MCQs.

3.7 The EOQ / inventory trap

- **Carrying cost** must be on the *average* inventory (Q/2), ordering cost on *number of orders* (A/Q). Trap: using total demand instead of average stock for carrying cost, or ignoring a **quantity-discount** tier that the question deliberately slips in. When discounts are given, EOQ isn't automatically the answer — compare total cost at EOQ vs at each discount break.

3.8 The reconciliation "direction" trap (Cost vs Financial accounts)

- Items **only in financial accounts** (e.g., dividend received, loss on sale of asset, notional items excluded from cost) must be added/subtracted in the *correct direction*. Trap: reversing the treatment of "income credited only in financials" vs "expense charged only in financials." **Anchor on:** start from cost profit, then ask "did this make financial profit higher or lower?" and adjust accordingly. Head each line with the reason so the examiner sees your logic even if a sign slips.

3.9 The service-costing / operating-costing unit trap

- Choosing the wrong **composite cost unit** (passenger-km, tonne-km, patient-day, room-day). Trap: computing tonne-km but not weighting for *return empty trips* or *load factor* that the question specifies. Identify the cost unit and the weighting basis explicitly before computing.

3.10 Presentation traps that quietly cost marks

- **No format / no statement heading:** ICAI expects the recognised statement format; a bare list of numbers loses format marks.
- **Missing Working Notes:** a correct final figure with no supporting WN is penalised versus a shown method.
- **Not carrying forward own figures:** re-deriving from scratch after an error, and getting inconsistent, loses more than a clean follow-through.
- **Ignoring "state assumptions":** where data is ambiguous, ICAI credits a stated reasonable assumption. Write it in one line rather than guessing silently.

One-Page Pre-Exam Checklist (read at your desk)

1. Reading time = triage + pick your 4 optionals. Don't solve.
2. Bank theory sub-parts and your strongest numerical first.
3. ~1.6 min/mark. Write the leave-by time beside each question.
4. Hard stop on any statement that won't balance — insert a balancing "difference" line, move on.
5. MCQs: eliminate then guess (EV is positive even with one option gone). Circle NOT/EXCEPT. Two-pass. Verify grid transfer.
6. Every numerical: **formula → statement → working notes → boxed answer**, units on every figure.
7. Tag every variance (F)/(A) and check sub-variances sum to total.
8. Re-read *which* total is asked: Cost of Production ≠ CGS ≠ Cost of Sales.
9. Distinguish-questions = tables. Short notes = crisp points. Never essays.
10. Attempt all five parts of your chosen questions — partial always beats absent.

Cost & Management Accounting — MCQ Bank (exam practice)

Negative marking: ICAI applies **0.25 negative marking** per wrong MCQ answer in Intermediate. If unsure, weigh the risk before guessing. Coverage: all chapters — Basics, Material, Labour, Overheads, ABC, Cost Sheet, Cost Accounting Systems & Reconciliation, Unit/Batch/Job/Contract Costing, Process & Joint/By-product, Service Costing, Standard Costing, Marginal Costing (CVP), Budgetary Control. Difficulty mixed; commonly-confused traps flagged.

A. Basic Concepts of Cost Accounting

Q1. Which of the following is a feature of a **cost centre** but NOT of a **cost unit**? (a) It is a unit of product or service (b) It is a location, person or item of equipment for which costs are ascertained (c) It is used to express cost per unit (d) It is always a physical unit of measurement

Answer: (b) **Why:** A cost centre is a location/person/equipment where cost is accumulated; a cost unit is the unit of product/service to which cost is charged. (a),(c),(d) describe the cost unit trap.

Q2. A cost that has been incurred and cannot be recovered by any future decision is a: (a) Opportunity cost (b) Sunk cost (c) Imputed cost (d) Replacement cost

Answer: (b) **Why:** Sunk cost is historical and irrelevant to decisions. Opportunity cost (a) is the benefit foregone, a decision-relevant concept — the classic confusion.

Q3. "Notional cost" for which no actual cash outlay is made, e.g. interest on own capital, is a/an: (a) Explicit cost (b) Out-of-pocket cost (c) Imputed cost (d) Discretionary cost

Answer: (c) **Why:** Imputed/notional costs are hypothetical, recorded for decision-making only. Explicit/out-of-pocket costs (a),(b) involve actual cash payment.

Q4. Which classification of cost is most useful for **managerial decision-making and control**? (a) By nature (material, labour, expense) (b) By function (c) By behaviour (fixed, variable, semi-variable) (d) By element

Answer: (c) **Why:** Behaviour classification (cost-volume relationship) drives CVP, marginal costing and budgeting decisions. Nature/function/element (a,b,d) are for accumulation/reporting, not control.

Q5. Conversion cost is equal to: (a) Direct material + direct labour (b) Direct labour + direct expenses + factory overhead (c) Prime cost + factory overhead (d) Direct material + factory overhead

Answer: (b) **Why:** Conversion cost = cost of converting raw material into finished goods = direct labour + direct expenses + factory (production) overhead. It excludes direct material — the trap in (a),(c),(d).

B. Material Cost

Q6. The Economic Order Quantity (EOQ) increases when: (a) Annual demand decreases (b) Ordering cost per order decreases (c) Carrying cost per unit increases (d) Ordering cost per order increases

Answer: (d) **Why:** $EOQ = \sqrt{2AO/C}$; it varies directly with ordering cost (O) and demand (A), inversely with carrying cost (C). Higher carrying cost (c) *reduces* EOQ.

Q7. Re-order level is calculated as: (a) Maximum usage × Maximum lead time (b) Minimum usage × Minimum lead time (c) Average usage × Average lead time (d) Maximum usage × Minimum lead time

Answer: (a) **Why:** Re-order level = Maximum consumption × Maximum re-order period (safety-driven). (c) gives the average-based check figure, not the ROL.

Q8. Maximum stock level = Re-order level + Re-order quantity − : (a) (Maximum usage × Maximum lead time) (b) (Minimum usage × Minimum lead time) (c) (Average usage × Average lead time) (d) (Maximum usage × Average lead time)

Answer: (b) **Why:** Maximum level = ROL + ROQ − (Min consumption × Min re-order period). Using minimums captures the situation of slowest usage during shortest lead time.

Q9. During rising prices, which method of pricing material issues gives the **highest closing stock value** and **lowest cost of production**? (a) LIFO (b) FIFO (c) Weighted average (d) Simple average

Answer: (b) **Why:** In inflation, FIFO issues oldest (cheapest) units first — lower charge to production and newest (dearest) prices remain in closing stock. LIFO (a) gives the opposite.

Q10. A company uses 12,000 units p.a., ordering cost ₹60/order, carrying cost ₹5/unit p.a. The EOQ is: (a) 600 units (b) 537 units (c) 400 units (d) 700 units

Answer: (b) **Why:** EOQ = $\sqrt{(2 \times 12{,}000 \times 60 / 5)} = \sqrt{288{,}000} \approx 537$ units.

Q11. Which of the following is treated as **normal loss of material** and its cost is **absorbed by good units**? (a) Loss due to abnormal machine breakdown (b) Loss due to evaporation/unavoidable handling within normal limits (c) Loss due to theft/pilferage above normal (d) Loss due to fire

Answer: (b) **Why:** Normal (unavoidable) loss cost is borne by good output; abnormal losses (a,c,d) are charged to Costing P&L, not to product cost.

Q12. Under the perpetual inventory system, physical stock verification is done: (a) Only at year-end for all items at once (b) Continuously throughout the year on a rotating basis (c) Never — book records suffice (d) Only when an ABC "A" item is issued

Answer: (b) **Why:** Perpetual inventory pairs continuous book records with continuous (rotating) physical verification, avoiding year-end shutdown. (a) is periodic inventory.

C. Employee (Labour) Cost

Q13. Idle time that is **abnormal** should be: (a) Charged to the job as direct wages (b) Absorbed in factory overhead (c) Transferred to the Costing Profit & Loss Account (d) Charged to material cost

Answer: (c) **Why:** Abnormal idle time is uncontrollable/avoidable-cause loss and is written off to Costing P&L; normal idle time is loaded onto production (via inflated rate or overhead).

Q14. Under the **Halsey plan**, bonus to a worker equals: (a) 50% of time saved × time rate (b) (Time saved / Standard time) × Time taken × rate (c) 33⅓% of time taken × rate (d) Time saved × piece rate

Answer: (a) **Why:** Halsey pays wages for time taken **plus** 50% of time saved × time rate. (b) describes the Rowan premium formula — the standard confusion between the two.

Q15. Under the **Rowan plan**, the bonus is: (a) 50% of time saved × time rate (b) (Time saved / Standard time) × Time taken × time rate (c) Time taken × time rate only (d) Guaranteed day wage plus piece bonus

Answer: (b) **Why:** Rowan bonus = (Time saved ÷ Standard time) × Time taken × rate. A key property: Rowan gives a higher bonus than Halsey when time saved is up to 50% of standard time.

Q16. Labour turnover under the **Separation method** is: (a) (No. of replacements / Average workers) × 100 (b) (No. of separations / Average workers) × 100 (c) (Separations + Accessions) / Average workers × 100 (d) (No. of workers left + replaced) / Average × 100

Answer: (b) **Why:** Separation method uses only workers who left ÷ average number on roll. Replacement method (a) uses replacements; Flux method (c) combines separations and accessions/replacements.

Q17. Overtime premium (extra rate over normal) arising due to a **specific customer's urgent order** should be charged to: (a) Factory overhead (b) Costing P&L Account (c) That specific job/customer (d) General administrative overhead

Answer: (c) **Why:** If overtime is at the customer's request, the premium is a direct charge to that job. Only when overtime is general/seasonal is the premium spread via overhead.

Q18. A worker's standard time is 10 hrs, actual 8 hrs, rate ₹20/hr. Halsey (50%) total earnings are: (a) ₹160 (b) ₹180 (c) ₹200 (d) ₹176

Answer: (b) **Why:** Wages = 8×20 = ₹160; bonus = 50%×(2 hrs)×20 = ₹20; total ₹180.

D. Overheads

Q19. Which basis is most appropriate to **apportion** factory rent among departments? (a) Number of employees (b) Floor area occupied (c) Value of machinery (d) Direct labour hours

Answer: (b) **Why:** Rent/rates/lighting relate to space, so floor area is the equitable base. Value of machinery (c) suits depreciation/insurance of plant, not rent.

Q20. A blanket (single factory-wide) overhead rate is appropriate only when: (a) The factory has many dissimilar departments (b) There is only one product or all products pass uniformly through all departments (c) Overheads vary widely by department (d) Products spend very different times in different departments

Answer: (b) **Why:** A single rate is valid only when work is homogeneous; otherwise departmental rates are needed to avoid distortion (c,d are exactly when blanket rates mislead).

Q21. Under-absorption of overhead due to **defective planning / normal reasons** is best disposed of by: (a) Writing off entirely to Costing P&L (b) Supplementary rate to production/stock/COGS (c) Carrying forward to next year (d) Ignoring it

Answer: (b) **Why:** Substantial under/over-absorption from normal causes is corrected via a supplementary rate spread over cost of sales, WIP and finished stock. Abnormal-cause amounts go to Costing P&L (a).

Q22. Under the **repeated distribution / simultaneous equation** method, the item being redistributed is: (a) Only production department costs (b) Costs of service departments that serve each other (reciprocal services) (c) Direct wages (d) Selling overhead only

Answer: (b) **Why:** These methods handle inter-service (reciprocal) departments. The step-ladder (non-reciprocal) method ignores return services — a common exam distinction.

Q23. Actual overhead ₹1,10,000; overhead absorbed ₹1,00,000. This is: (a) Over-absorption of ₹10,000 (b) Under-absorption of ₹10,000 (c) Correct absorption (d) Over-absorption of ₹1,00,000

Answer: (b) **Why:** Absorbed (₹1,00,000) < Actual (₹1,10,000) → overheads charged short → under-absorption of ₹10,000.

Q24. Which of the following is a **selling** overhead (not distribution)? (a) Warehouse rent for finished goods (b) Carriage outward on delivery (c) Salesmen's commission and advertising (d) Packing for transport / secondary packaging

Answer: (c) **Why:** Selling overhead relates to creating/securing demand (advertising, commission). Warehousing, carriage outward and transport packing (a,b,d) are distribution overheads.

E. Activity Based Costing (ABC)

Q25. In ABC, a "cost driver" is: (a) The department that incurs the cost (b) A factor that causes a change in the cost of an activity (c) The total overhead of the plant (d) The predetermined blanket rate

Answer: (b) **Why:** A cost driver is the causal basis (e.g., number of set-ups, orders) used to trace activity cost to products — the heart of ABC.

Q26. ABC is likely to give **materially different** product costs from traditional absorption costing when: (a) Overheads are a small % of total cost and products are similar (b) Overheads are large and product volumes/complexity differ widely (c) There is only a single product (d) All products consume overheads in proportion to labour hours

Answer: (b) **Why:** ABC's benefit appears with high, diverse overheads and product diversity; where overhead consumption tracks labour hours (d), ABC and traditional costing converge.

Q27. The cost of "machine set-ups" would most appropriately be driven by: (a) Number of machine hours (b) Number of production runs / set-ups (c) Direct material cost (d) Floor area

Answer: (b) **Why:** Set-up cost is a batch-level activity driven by the number of set-ups/runs, not by volume-based machine hours (a) — the classic ABC insight.

F. Cost Sheet

Q28. In a cost sheet, which of the following is added to Works/Factory Cost to reach Cost of Production? (a) Selling & distribution overhead (b) Administrative (office) overhead relating to production (c) Direct expenses (d) Opening stock of raw material

Answer: (b) **Why:** Cost of Production = Works Cost + Administration overhead (production-related). Selling & distribution (a) is added later to get Cost of Sales.

Q29. Prime Cost = ? (a) Direct material + Direct labour + Direct expenses (b) Direct material + Factory overhead (c) Works cost − Administration overhead (d) Direct labour + Factory overhead

Answer: (a) **Why:** Prime cost is the sum of all direct costs. (d) is conversion cost less material — a distractor.

Q30. Which item is **excluded** from cost accounts (pure financial item)? (a) Depreciation of plant (b) Dividend paid / income tax (c) Consumable stores (d) Indirect wages

Answer: (b) **Why:** Appropriations of profit (dividend, income tax), and pure financial items are excluded from cost accounts — a frequent reconciliation trap.

Q31. Cost of goods sold = Cost of production of goods produced + Opening finished stock − _____: (a) Closing finished stock (b) Closing WIP (c) Selling overhead (d) Closing raw material

Answer: (a) **Why:** COGS adjusts for finished goods inventory: add opening finished stock, deduct closing finished stock. WIP (b) is adjusted earlier at works cost stage.

G. Cost Accounting Systems & Reconciliation

Q32. In an **integrated (integral) accounting** system: (a) Cost and financial accounts are maintained separately and reconciled (b) A single set of accounts serves both cost and financial purposes (c) No control accounts are kept (d) Reconciliation is compulsory each period

Answer: (b) **Why:** Integrated accounts merge cost and financial records into one ledger, so no reconciliation is needed. Separate (non-integrated) systems require reconciliation (a,d).

Q33. Under **non-integrated** accounting, the account that replaces personal and real accounts to make the cost ledger self-balancing is the: (a) Stores Ledger Control A/c (b) Cost Ledger Control A/c (General Ledger Adjustment A/c) (c) WIP Control A/c (d) Overhead Control A/c

Answer: (b) **Why:** The Cost Ledger Control / General Ledger Adjustment A/c absorbs all items whose contra lies in financial books, making the cost ledger self-balancing.

Q34. In reconciliation, **overheads over-absorbed in cost accounts** (profit as per cost given) require you to: (a) Add to costing profit to get financial profit (b) Deduct from costing profit to get financial profit (c) Ignore, no effect (d) Add to financial profit

Answer: (b) **Why:** Over-absorption inflates costing profit (charged more than actual), so to reach financial profit you deduct the excess. Under-absorption is added back.

Q35. Which item, appearing **only in financial accounts**, would make **financial profit lower than costing profit**? (a) Notional rent charged in cost accounts (b) Loss on sale of investment / fine (c) Dividend received (d) Interest received

Answer: (b) **Why:** Pure financial expenses/losses (fines, loss on sale) reduce financial profit only. Financial incomes like dividend/interest received (c,d) would raise it.

Q36. Notional (imputed) rent charged in cost accounts but not in financial accounts causes: (a) Costing profit to be lower than financial profit (b) Costing profit to be higher than financial profit (c) No difference (d) Financial profit to be lower

Answer: (a) **Why:** A notional charge only in cost books reduces costing profit; financial profit stays higher by that amount.

H. Unit & Batch Costing

Q37. The **Economic Batch Quantity (EBQ)** formula is: (a) $\sqrt{(2 \times D \times S / C)}$ where D=annual demand, S=set-up cost, C=carrying cost per unit p.a. (b) $\sqrt{(2 \times D \times C / S)}$ (c) $D / (S \times C)$ (d) $\sqrt{(D \times S \times C)}$

Answer: (a) **Why:** EBQ mirrors EOQ with set-up cost replacing ordering cost. (b) inverts the numerator/denominator — a common slip.

Q38. Batch costing is most suitable for: (a) Ship building (b) Pharmaceuticals / bakeries producing identical items in lots (c) A power plant (d) A road transport company

Answer: (b) **Why:** Batch costing suits identical articles made in batches (drugs, biscuits, components). Ship building is job/contract; power/transport are service (operating) costing.

I. Job & Contract Costing

Q39. In contract costing, when a contract is **less than 25% complete**, the profit to be transferred to the P&L account is: (a) 1/3 × Notional profit × (Cash received/Work certified) (b) 2/3 × Notional profit × (Cash received/Work certified) (c) Nil (no profit taken; provide fully for any loss) (d) Full notional profit

Answer: (c) **Why:** Prudence: below 25% completion the outcome is too uncertain, so **no profit** is recognised (losses fully provided). The 1/3 and 2/3 rules apply at higher completion stages.

Q40. Work-certified is ₹8,00,000, cash received 80%, notional profit ₹1,20,000, and the contract is **between ⅓ and ½ (approx 40%) complete**. Profit to P&L (using 1/3 rule): (a) ₹40,000 (b) ₹32,000 (c) ₹1,20,000 (d) ₹64,000

Answer: (b) **Why:** 1/3 × 1,20,000 × (cash 6,40,000 / certified 8,00,000) = 1/3 × 1,20,000 × 0.8 = ₹32,000.

Q41. "Cost-plus contract" means the contract price is: (a) A fixed lump sum agreed in advance (b) Cost incurred plus an agreed percentage/amount of profit (c) Always lower than actual cost (d) Determined by escalation clause only

Answer: (b) **Why:** In cost-plus contracts, price = allowable cost + agreed margin; used when costs cannot be estimated in advance. (a) is a fixed-price contract.

Q42. An "escalation clause" in a contract protects the: (a) Contractee against price falls (b) Contractor against rise in prices of materials/labour/utilities (c) Bank against default (d) Government against tax loss

Answer: (b) **Why:** Escalation clauses reimburse the contractor for cost increases beyond agreed levels; a de-escalation clause protects the contractee if prices fall.

J. Process & Joint / By-Product Costing

Q43. Abnormal gain in process costing is valued at: (a) Scrap value of normal loss (b) Cost per equivalent unit of normal output (same rate as good units) (c) Zero (d) Selling price of finished output

Answer: (b) **Why:** Abnormal gain units are valued at the normal cost per unit, then transferred to Costing P&L (net of scrap value foregone on normal loss). This mirrors abnormal loss valuation.

Q44. When computing cost per equivalent unit, the cost of **normal loss** is: (a) Ignored — added to abnormal loss (b) Spread over good units by reducing units and crediting scrap value of normal loss (c) Charged fully to Costing P&L (d) Added to closing WIP

Answer: (b) **Why:** Normal loss carries no cost of its own; its scrap realisation reduces process cost and the balance is absorbed by good output. Abnormal loss (c) goes to P&L.

Q45. Which method apportions **joint costs** in proportion to the **sales value at split-off point**? (a) Physical units method (b) Average unit cost method (c) Market value (sales value) at separation point method (d) Contribution margin method

Answer: (c) **Why:** The sales-value-at-split-off method allocates joint cost by each product's relative sales value at the point of separation. Physical units (a) ignores value differences.

Q46. Under the **reverse cost / net realisable value** method for a by-product, the estimated profit and post-separation costs are: (a) Added to the by-product's sales value (b) Deducted from the by-product's sales value to arrive at the value credited to the main process (c) Ignored entirely (d) Charged to the main product

Answer: (b) **Why:** Reverse-cost method works back from by-product sales value, deducting further processing cost, selling expense and normal profit to credit the main process.

Q47. In process costing under **FIFO** for equivalent units, which is true? (a) Opening WIP is merged with current period costs (b) Only the work needed to complete opening WIP this period is counted, plus units started and completed, plus closing WIP (c) Closing WIP is ignored (d) It gives the same equivalent units as weighted average always

Answer: (b) **Why:** FIFO separates opening WIP (only the degree completed this period counts) from current production. Weighted average (a) merges opening WIP — the two differ whenever opening WIP exists.

K. Service (Operating) Costing

Q48. A composite cost unit like **"tonne-kilometre"** is used in: (a) Job costing (b) Transport/service costing (c) Contract costing (d) Process costing

Answer: (b) **Why:** Service (operating) costing uses composite units (tonne-km, passenger-km, patient-day, kWh) to capture two dimensions of the service.

Q49. In transport costing, tyres and tubes, and diesel/fuel are classified as: (a) Fixed (standing) charges (b) Running (variable) charges (c) Maintenance charges (d) Terminal charges

Answer: (b) **Why:** Fuel, oil and tyres vary with distance run → running charges. Insurance, road tax, driver's salary, garage rent are standing charges (a) — the classic split.

Q50. A bus carries 40 passengers over 200 km, another trip 30 passengers over 100 km. Total **passenger-kilometres**: (a) 11,000 (b) 8,000 (c) 3,000 (d) 14,000

Answer: (a) **Why:** $(40\times200) + (30\times100) = 8{,}000 + 3{,}000 = 11{,}000$ passenger-km.

L. Standard Costing

Q51. Material Cost Variance = ? (a) (Std price − Actual price) × Actual qty (b) (Std cost of actual output) − (Actual cost) (c) (Std qty − Actual qty) × Std price (d) Std cost − Budgeted cost

Answer: (b) **Why:** MCV = Standard cost for actual output − Actual cost. (a) is the price variance and (c) is the usage variance — its two components.

Q52. Material Usage Variance is: (a) (Std price − Actual price) × Actual quantity (b) (Std quantity for actual output − Actual quantity) × Standard price (c) (Std qty − Actual qty) × Actual price (d) (Std mix − Actual mix) × Actual price

Answer: (b) **Why:** Usage variance isolates quantity efficiency at the **standard** price. Using actual price (c) contaminates it with price effect — a frequent error.

Q53. A **favourable Labour Efficiency Variance** together with an **adverse Material Usage Variance** could arise because: (a) Workers were paid more per hour (b) Skilled workers worked faster but wasted more material (c) Material prices rose (d) Overheads were over-absorbed

Answer: (b) **Why:** Interdependence of variances: faster (efficient) labour saving hours while spoiling material links a favourable LEV with an adverse MUV.

Q54. Sales Value Variance is split into: (a) Sales Price Variance and Sales Volume Variance (b) Sales Price Variance and Sales Mix Variance only (c) Market Size and Market Share only (d) Rate and Efficiency variances

Answer: (a) **Why:** Sales value variance = Price variance + Volume variance; volume further splits into mix and quantity (which splits into market size and share). Wages-style rate/efficiency (d) is a labour trap.

Q55. Standard price ₹10/kg, standard usage 5 kg/unit; actual output 100 units used 520 kg at ₹11/kg. **Material Usage Variance** is: (a) ₹200 Adverse (b) ₹520 Adverse (c) ₹200 Favourable (d) ₹220 Adverse

Answer: (a) **Why:** MUV = (Std qty 500 − Actual 520) × Std price ₹10 = ₹200 Adverse. Note it uses **standard** ₹10, not actual ₹11 (which would wrongly give ₹220).

Q56. Fixed Overhead Volume Variance arises because: (a) Actual fixed overhead ≠ budgeted fixed overhead (b) Actual output differs from budgeted output, so absorbed overhead differs from budgeted (c) The overhead rate per hour changed (d) Labour worked more efficiently

Answer: (b) **Why:** Volume variance = (Absorbed − Budgeted) fixed OH, driven by activity level differing from budget. The spend/expenditure variance covers actual vs budgeted amount (a).

M. Marginal Costing & CVP

Q57. The **P/V ratio** is: (a) Fixed cost / Contribution (b) Contribution / Sales (c) Profit / Sales (d) Contribution / Variable cost

Answer: (b) **Why:** P/V ratio = Contribution ÷ Sales (= change in profit ÷ change in sales). It measures contribution per rupee of sales, independent of fixed cost.

Q58. Break-even point (in ₹ sales) = ? (a) Fixed cost × P/V ratio (b) Fixed cost / P/V ratio (c) Fixed cost / Contribution per unit (d) Fixed cost + Profit

Answer: (b) **Why:** BEP (value) = Fixed cost ÷ P/V ratio. Dividing fixed cost by **contribution per unit** (c) gives BEP in *units*, not value — the usual mix-up.

Q59. Margin of Safety = ? (a) Actual sales − Break-even sales (b) Break-even sales − Fixed cost (c) Contribution − Fixed cost (d) Sales − Variable cost

Answer: (a) **Why:** Margin of safety is the excess of actual (or budgeted) sales over break-even sales; it can also be expressed as Profit ÷ P/V ratio. (d) is contribution.

Q60. Fixed cost ₹1,20,000, selling price ₹50, variable cost ₹30 per unit. Break-even quantity is: (a) 4,000 units (b) 2,400 units (c) 6,000 units (d) 3,000 units

Answer: (c) **Why:** Contribution/unit = 50 − 30 = ₹20; BEP = 1,20,000 ÷ 20 = 6,000 units.

Q61. If P/V ratio is 40% and fixed cost ₹2,00,000, sales required to earn a profit of ₹1,00,000 are: (a) ₹5,00,000 (b) ₹7,50,000 (c) ₹6,00,000 (d) ₹4,00,000

Answer: (b) **Why:** Required sales = (Fixed cost + Desired profit) ÷ P/V ratio = (2,00,000 + 1,00,000) ÷ 0.40 = ₹7,50,000.

Q62. Under **marginal costing**, closing stock is valued at: (a) Total cost including fixed factory overhead (b) Variable (marginal) cost only (c) Selling price (d) Prime cost plus all overheads

Answer: (b) **Why:** Marginal costing values inventory at variable cost; fixed overheads are period costs written off. Absorption costing (a) includes fixed factory overhead — the reason profits differ between the two.

Q63. When production **exceeds** sales (stock rising), profit under **absorption costing** compared to marginal costing will be: (a) Lower (b) Higher (c) Equal (d) Always nil

Answer: (b) **Why:** Rising stock defers some fixed overhead into closing inventory under absorption costing, so absorption profit is higher. When sales exceed production, the reverse holds.

N. Budgetary Control

Q64. A **flexible budget** is one that: (a) Remains fixed regardless of activity (b) Is designed to change with the level of activity attained (c) Covers only cash items (d) Is prepared for capital expenditure

Answer: (b) **Why:** A flexible budget adjusts costs to actual activity by segregating fixed and variable elements, giving a valid basis for control. A fixed budget (a) is set for one level only.

Q65. The budget prepared **first**, which acts as the **principal/limiting factor** in most trading concerns, is the: (a) Production budget (b) Cash budget (c) Sales budget (d) Master budget

Answer: (c) **Why:** Sales is usually the key/limiting factor, so the sales budget is prepared first and drives the others. The master budget (d) is the consolidated summary prepared last.

Q66. Zero-base budgeting (ZBB) requires that: (a) Last year's figures are increased by an inflation percentage (b) Every activity is justified afresh from a zero base each period (c) Only capital items are budgeted (d) No budget is prepared for support functions

Answer: (b) **Why:** ZBB starts from zero and requires justification of every rupee/activity, unlike incremental budgeting (a) which merely adjusts prior figures.

Q67. A budget that shows expected cash receipts and payments to manage liquidity is the: (a) Master budget (b) Cash budget (c) Flexible budget (d) Production budget

Answer: (b) **Why:** The cash budget forecasts inflows/outflows period-by-period to plan financing and surplus deployment. It excludes non-cash items like depreciation — a common exam catch.

Q68. Budgeted sales 10,000 units; desired closing stock 2,000; opening stock 1,500. Units to be **produced**: (a) 10,000 (b) 10,500 (c) 11,500 (d) 8,500

Answer: (b) **Why:** Production = Sales + Closing stock − Opening stock = 10,000 + 2,000 − 1,500 = 10,500 units.

End of MCQ Bank. Practice under timed conditions; re-attempt only the traps you missed. Remember the 0.25 negative-marking rule when deciding whether to attempt a doubtful question.

Cost & Management Accounting — Mock Test 1 (ICAI Intermediate pattern, 100 marks, 3 hours)

Group I — Paper 3

Instructions:

1. Division A comprises Multiple Choice Questions (MCQs) carrying **30 marks**. Division B comprises descriptive/practical questions carrying **70 marks**.
2. In Division B, **Question No. 1 is compulsory**. Attempt **any four** questions out of the remaining five questions.
3. Working notes should form part of the answer. Wherever necessary, suitable assumptions may be made and clearly stated.
4. Answers should be based on the provisions of Cost Accounting standards, principles and generally accepted cost accounting practices.

DIVISION A — MULTIPLE CHOICE QUESTIONS (30 Marks)

All MCQs carry 2 marks each. Total 15 MCQs.

Case Scenario I (MCQ 1 to 5)

PQR Ltd. manufactures a single product. It uses a key raw material "Alpha". The following data relates to Alpha for the year:

- Annual demand (consumption): 40,000 units
- Ordering cost: Rs. 200 per order
- Carrying (holding) cost: Rs. 4 per unit per annum
- Purchase price: Rs. 50 per unit
- Lead time: 10 days
- Number of working days in a year: 400

MCQ 1. The Economic Order Quantity (EOQ) of Alpha is:

(a) 1,000 units (b) 2,000 units (c) 4,000 units (d) 2,828 units

MCQ 2. Based on EOQ, the number of orders to be placed during the year is:

(a) 10 orders (b) 20 orders (c) 40 orders (d) 25 orders

MCQ 3. The total inventory cost (ordering cost plus carrying cost) at EOQ level is:

(a) Rs. 4,000 (b) Rs. 16,000 (c) Rs. 8,000 (d) Rs. 10,000

MCQ 4. If the company places orders of 4,000 units each (instead of EOQ), the total of ordering and carrying cost would be:

(a) Rs. 8,000 (b) Rs. 10,000 (c) Rs. 12,000 (d) Rs. 6,000

MCQ 5. The Re-order Level (ROL) for Alpha is:

(a) 400 units (b) 4,000 units (c) 1,000 units (d) 2,000 units

---

Case Scenario II (MCQ 6 to 9)

XYZ Ltd. sells a single product. The following particulars are available:

- Selling price per unit: Rs. 200
- Variable cost per unit: Rs. 120
- Total fixed cost per annum: Rs. 12,00,000

MCQ 6. The Profit-Volume (P/V) ratio of XYZ Ltd. is:

(a) 60% (b) 40% (c) 30% (d) 66.67%

MCQ 7. The break-even point in units is:

(a) 10,000 units (b) 20,000 units (c) 15,000 units (d) 6,000 units

MCQ 8. The sales quantity required to earn a target profit of Rs. 4,00,000 is:

(a) 20,000 units (b) 25,000 units (c) 18,000 units (d) 22,000 units

MCQ 9. If the company sells 25,000 units, the margin of safety (in units) is:

(a) 5,000 units (b) 15,000 units (c) 10,000 units (d) 25,000 units

---

Independent MCQs (MCQ 10 to 15)

MCQ 10. Under the FIFO method of pricing material issues, the closing stock of materials is valued at:

(a) The earliest (oldest) prices (b) The latest (most recent) prices (c) The average of all prices (d) The standard price

MCQ 11. In a transport (operating costing) undertaking, the most appropriate composite cost unit is:

(a) Per kilometre (b) Per tonne (c) Per tonne-kilometre (d) Per passenger

MCQ 12. The appropriate cost unit for a hospital would be:

(a) Per patient (b) Per patient-day (c) Per bed (d) Per operation only

MCQ 13. In a break-even chart, the "angle of incidence" represents:

(a) The break-even point (b) The rate at which profit is earned once the break-even point is crossed (c) The margin of safety (d) The total fixed cost line

MCQ 14. Which of the following is **not** included in prime cost?

(a) Direct materials (b) Direct wages (c) Direct expenses (d) Factory (works) overheads

MCQ 15. Abnormal gain in process costing arises when:

(a) Actual loss is more than normal loss (b) Actual loss is equal to normal loss (c) Actual output is more than the expected (normal) output (d) There is no scrap value of normal loss

---

DIVISION B — DESCRIPTIVE / PRACTICAL QUESTIONS (70 Marks)

Question No. 1 is compulsory. Answer any four questions from the remaining five questions.

Question 1 (Compulsory) — 14 Marks

(a) From the following information relating to material "Zeta", calculate the **Re-order Level, Minimum Level, Maximum Level and Average Stock Level**: **(4 Marks)**

- Maximum consumption: 300 units per day
- Minimum consumption: 200 units per day
- Normal consumption: 250 units per day
- Re-order period (lead time): 8 to 12 days
- Re-order quantity (EOQ): 2,400 units

(b) The following particulars relate to the workforce of a factory during a period: **(4 Marks)**

- Number of workers at the beginning of the period: 4,800
- Number of workers at the end of the period: 5,200
- Number of workers who left/were discharged (separations): 80
- Of the workers recruited during the period, 60 were engaged to replace those who left; the remaining recruitments were on account of expansion.

Calculate the Labour Turnover Rate under the (i) Separation method, (ii) Replacement method, and (iii) Flux method.

(c) State the causes of **under-absorption and over-absorption of overheads** and briefly explain the accounting treatment of the same in cost accounts. **(3 Marks)**

(d) A company manufactures a component in batches. The annual demand for the component is 1,00,000 units. The set-up cost per batch is Rs. 320 and the carrying cost is Rs. 4 per unit per annum. Compute the **Economic Batch Quantity (EBQ)** and the number of batches to be run per year. **(3 Marks)**

Question 2 — 14 Marks

(a) The following particulars are extracted from the books of Sunrise Manufacturing Co. for the year ended 31st March, 2026. Prepare a **Statement of Cost (Cost Sheet)** showing Prime Cost, Works Cost, Cost of Production, Cost of Goods Sold, Cost of Sales, Profit and Sales. **(10 Marks)**

Particulars	Amount (Rs.)
Raw materials purchased	12,50,000
Opening stock of raw materials	2,50,000
Closing stock of raw materials	3,00,000
Carriage inward on materials	15,000
Direct wages	7,50,000
Direct (chargeable) expenses	40,000
Factory (works) overheads	4,50,000
Opening work-in-progress	1,80,000
Closing work-in-progress	1,50,000
Opening stock of finished goods	3,00,000
Closing stock of finished goods	2,15,000
Administrative overheads (production related)	2,30,000
Selling and distribution overheads	1,75,000

Profit is 25% on total cost of sales.

(b) Explain briefly, with one example each, the following cost concepts: (i) Sunk Cost, (ii) Opportunity Cost, (iii) Notional Cost, (iv) Explicit Cost. **(4 Marks)**

Question 3 — 14 Marks

(a) Product "M" passes through Process I. The following details relate to Process I for the month of June, 2026: **(8 Marks)**

- Input material introduced: 10,000 units
- Material cost: Rs. 45,000
- Direct labour: Rs. 30,000
- Production overheads: Rs. 20,000
- Normal loss: 10% of input
- Scrap value of normal loss: Rs. 5 per unit
- Actual output transferred to the next process: 8,700 units

Prepare the **Process I Account, Normal Loss Account and Abnormal Loss Account**.

(b) The following information relates to a manufacturing process for a period (use the **weighted average / average cost method**; there was no opening work-in-progress): **(6 Marks)**

- Units introduced: 12,000 units
- Units completed and transferred out: 10,000 units
- Closing work-in-progress: 2,000 units

- Degree of completion of closing WIP: Material 100%, Labour 60%, Overheads 60%
- Costs incurred: Material Rs. 2,40,000; Labour Rs. 1,34,400; Overheads Rs. 67,200

Prepare a **Statement of Equivalent Production, Statement of Cost per Equivalent Unit, and Statement of Evaluation** (value of units transferred and value of closing WIP).

Question 4 — 14 Marks

(a) The following data relates to a product manufactured and sold by Delta Ltd.: **(8 Marks)**

- Selling price per unit: Rs. 50
- Variable cost per unit: Rs. 30
- Fixed cost per annum: Rs. 4,00,000

You are required to calculate: (i) P/V ratio (ii) Break-even point (in units and in rupees) (iii) Sales (in units and in rupees) required to earn a target profit of Rs. 2,00,000 (iv) Margin of safety (in units, in rupees and as a ratio) and the profit, if the company sells 35,000 units.

(b) Omega Ltd. manufactures two products, A and B. Machine hours are the limiting (key) factor, and only **10,000 machine hours** are available in the period. The following data is available: **(6 Marks)**

Particulars	Product A	Product B
Contribution per unit (Rs.)	30	40
Machine hours per unit	2	4
Maximum demand (units)	3,000	2,000

Fixed costs for the period are Rs. 50,000. Determine the **most profitable product mix** and the resulting profit.

Question 5 — 14 Marks

(a) The standard cost of a product per unit is: **(8 Marks)**

- Direct material: 5 kg @ Rs. 4 per kg
- Direct labour: 3 hours @ Rs. 10 per hour

During the month, actual production was **1,000 units** and the actual data was:

- Material used: 5,200 kg costing Rs. 22,360
- Labour: 3,100 hours costing Rs. 32,550

Calculate the following variances: (i) Material Cost Variance, (ii) Material Price Variance, (iii) Material Usage Variance, (iv) Labour Cost Variance, (v) Labour Rate Variance, (vi) Labour Efficiency Variance.

(b) Using the data below, compute the **Fixed Overhead Cost Variance, Fixed Overhead Expenditure Variance and Fixed Overhead Volume Variance**: **(6 Marks)**

- Budgeted output: 1,200 units
- Budgeted fixed overheads: Rs. 60,000

- Actual output: 1,000 units
- Actual fixed overheads: Rs. 58,000

Question 6 — 14 Marks

(a) A transport operator owns a truck used to carry goods. From the following data, compute the **operating cost per tonne-kilometre** and the **freight to be charged per tonne-kilometre** if the operator wishes to earn a profit of 20% on freight (takings): **(8 Marks)**

- Cost of the truck: Rs. 9,00,000; residual value: Rs. 90,000; estimated life: 5 years
- Carrying capacity: 10 tonnes
- The truck makes one round trip per day to a place 100 km away and returns empty. It carries a full load only on the outward journey.
- Effective working days per month: 25
- Diesel: the truck runs 5 km per litre; diesel costs Rs. 90 per litre
- Driver's salary: Rs. 18,000 per month
- Oil and lubricants: Rs. 2,000 per month
- Repairs and maintenance: Rs. 6,000 per month
- Insurance: Rs. 24,000 per annum
- Road tax and permit: Rs. 12,000 per annum
- Office and administration overheads: Rs. 5,000 per month

(b) The profit as per the cost accounts of a company for the year is **Rs. 1,50,000**. On scrutiny, the following differences between the cost and financial accounts were noted. Prepare a **Reconciliation Statement** and ascertain the profit as per financial accounts: **(6 Marks)**

1. Factory overheads over-absorbed in cost accounts: Rs. 8,000
2. Administrative overheads under-absorbed in cost accounts: Rs. 5,000
3. Interest received (recorded only in financial accounts): Rs. 12,000
4. Dividend received (recorded only in financial accounts): Rs. 6,000
5. Loss on sale of an asset (recorded only in financial accounts): Rs. 9,000
6. Preliminary expenses written off (financial accounts only): Rs. 4,000
7. Depreciation charged in financial accounts Rs. 25,000; in cost accounts Rs. 20,000
8. Notional rent of own premises charged in cost accounts only: Rs. 10,000

ANSWER KEY & MODEL SOLUTIONS

Division A — MCQ Answer Key (with reasons)

MCQ	Answer	Reason
1	**(b) 2,000 units**	EOQ = √(2 × 40,000 × 200 / 4) = √40,00,000 = 2,000 units.
2	**(b) 20 orders**	No. of orders = Annual demand / EOQ = 40,000 / 2,000 = 20.
3	**(c) Rs. 8,000**	Ordering cost = 20 × 200 = 4,000; Carrying cost = (2,000/2) × 4 = 4,000; Total = 8,000 (both are equal at EOQ).
4	**(b) Rs. 10,000**	Ordering = (40,000/4,000) × 200 = 2,000; Carrying = (4,000/2) × 4 = 8,000; Total = 10,000 (higher than EOQ cost).
5	**(c) 1,000 units**	Daily consumption = 40,000/400 = 100 units; ROL = 100 × 10 (lead time) = 1,000 units.
6	**(b) 40%**	P/V ratio = (200 − 120)/200 × 100 = 80/200 = 40%.
7	**(c) 15,000 units**	BEP = Fixed cost / contribution per unit = 12,00,000 / 80 = 15,000 units.
8	**(a) 20,000 units**	(Fixed cost + target profit)/contribution = (12,00,000 + 4,00,000)/80 = 20,000 units.
9	**(c) 10,000 units**	MOS = Actual sales − BEP = 25,000 − 15,000 = 10,000 units.
10	**(b) The latest (most recent) prices**	Under FIFO, oldest stock is issued first, so closing stock consists of the most recently purchased (latest priced) units.
11	**(c) Per tonne-kilometre**	Transport costing uses a composite unit reflecting both load and distance.
12	**(b) Per patient-day**	Hospital costing uses patient-day as it captures both the number of patients and duration of stay.
13	**(b) The rate at which profit is earned once BEP is crossed**	A larger angle of incidence indicates a higher rate of profit earning.
14	**(d) Factory (works) overheads**	Prime cost = direct materials + direct wages + direct expenses; factory overheads are added after prime cost.
15	**(c) Actual output is more than the expected (normal) output**	When actual loss is less than normal loss, actual output exceeds expected output, giving rise to abnormal gain.

Division B — Model Solutions

Answer to Question 1

(a) Stock Levels for material "Zeta"

Re-order Level (ROL) = Maximum consumption × Maximum re-order period = 300 × 12 = **3,600 units**

Minimum Level = ROL − (Normal consumption × Normal re-order period) = 3,600 − (250 × 10) = 3,600 − 2,500 = **1,100 units** (Normal re-order period = (8 + 12)/2 = 10 days)

Maximum Level = ROL + Re-order Quantity − (Minimum consumption × Minimum re-order period) = 3,600 + 2,400 − (200 × 8) = 6,000 − 1,600 = **4,400 units**

Average Stock Level = Minimum Level + ½ × Re-order Quantity = 1,100 + ½ × 2,400 = 1,100 + 1,200 = **2,300 units**

(b) Labour Turnover Rates

Average number of workers = (4,800 + 5,200)/2 = **5,000 workers**

Accessions (total recruitments) = Closing − Opening + Separations = 5,200 − 4,800 + 80 = 480 workers (Of these, 60 are replacements and 420 are on account of expansion.)

(i) **Separation method** = (Number of separations / Average number of workers) × 100 = (80 / 5,000) × 100 = **1.60%**

(ii) **Replacement method** = (Number of replacements / Average number of workers) × 100 = (60 / 5,000) × 100 = **1.20%**

(iii) **Flux method** = [(Separations + Accessions) / Average number of workers] × 100 = [(80 + 480) / 5,000] × 100 = (560 / 5,000) × 100 = **11.20%**

(c) Under- and Over-absorption of Overheads

Overheads are recovered on the basis of a **pre-determined (budgeted) rate**. When the overheads actually incurred differ from the overheads absorbed, under- or over-absorption arises.

Causes: - Error in estimating overhead expenses or the level of activity (base) used to fix the rate. - Actual output/hours differing from budgeted output/hours. - Unforeseen changes in production capacity, methods or prices. - Seasonal fluctuations in overhead expenses.

Accounting treatment: 1. **Write-off to Costing Profit & Loss Account** — where the amount is small, or due to abnormal reasons. 2. **Use of a supplementary rate** — where the amount is large, it is apportioned over cost of goods sold, finished goods and work-in-progress by a supplementary rate. 3. **Carry forward to the next period** — where the amount is expected to be adjusted in the normal course of business over the year (e.g., seasonal industries).

(d) Economic Batch Quantity (EBQ)

EBQ = √(2 × Annual demand × Set-up cost per batch / Carrying cost per unit p.a.) = √(2 × 1,00,000 × 320 / 4) = √(6,40,00,000 / 4) = √1,60,00,000 = **4,000 units**

Number of batches per year = Annual demand / EBQ = 1,00,000 / 4,000 = **25 batches**

Answer to Question 2

(a) Statement of Cost (Cost Sheet) of Sunrise Manufacturing Co. for the year ended 31st March, 2026

Particulars	Amount (Rs.)	Amount (Rs.)
Opening stock of raw materials	2,50,000	
Add: Purchases	12,50,000	
Add: Carriage inward	15,000	
Less: Closing stock of raw materials	(3,00,000)	
Raw materials consumed		12,15,000
Direct wages		7,50,000
Direct expenses		40,000
PRIME COST		**20,05,000**
Add: Factory (works) overheads		4,50,000
		24,55,000
Add: Opening work-in-progress		1,80,000
Less: Closing work-in-progress		(1,50,000)
WORKS (FACTORY) COST		**24,85,000**
Add: Administrative overheads (production)		2,30,000
COST OF PRODUCTION		**27,15,000**
Add: Opening stock of finished goods		3,00,000
Less: Closing stock of finished goods		(2,15,000)
COST OF GOODS SOLD		**28,00,000**
Add: Selling and distribution overheads		1,75,000
COST OF SALES		**29,75,000**
Add: Profit (25% on cost of sales)		7,43,750
SALES		**37,18,750**

Working: Profit = 25% × 29,75,000 = Rs. 7,43,750; Sales = 29,75,000 + 7,43,750 = Rs. 37,18,750.

(b) Cost Concepts

(i) **Sunk Cost** — A historical cost already incurred which cannot be recovered or altered by any current or future decision; it is irrelevant for decision making. *Example:* the written-down book value of an existing machine when deciding whether to replace it.

(ii) **Opportunity Cost** — The value of the benefit foregone by choosing one alternative over the next best alternative. *Example:* the rent foregone by using one's own building for the factory instead of letting it out.

(iii) **Notional Cost** — A cost included in cost accounts to represent the use of a resource for which no actual cash outflow occurs. *Example:* notional rent charged for own premises, or interest on own capital.

(iv) **Explicit Cost** — Costs that involve an actual/outlay cash payment to outsiders. *Example:* wages paid, rent paid, material purchased for cash.

Answer to Question 3

(a) Process I

Working Notes:

Total cost = Material 45,000 + Labour 30,000 + Overheads 20,000 = Rs. 95,000

Normal loss = 10% of 10,000 = 1,000 units; Scrap value = 1,000 × Rs. 5 = Rs. 5,000

Expected (normal) output = 10,000 − 1,000 = 9,000 units

Cost per unit = (Total cost − Scrap value of normal loss) / (Input units − Normal loss units) = (95,000 − 5,000) / (10,000 − 1,000) = 90,000 / 9,000 = **Rs. 10 per unit**

Actual output = 8,700 units → Abnormal loss = 9,000 − 8,700 = 300 units Value of abnormal loss = 300 × Rs. 10 = Rs. 3,000

Process I Account

Particulars	Units	Amount (Rs.)	Particulars	Units	Amount (Rs.)
To Material	10,000	45,000	By Normal Loss	1,000	5,000
To Direct Labour		30,000	By Abnormal Loss	300	3,000
To Production Overheads		20,000	By Process II A/c (output @ Rs.10)	8,700	87,000
Total	**10,000**	**95,000**	**Total**	**10,000**	**95,000**

Normal Loss Account

Particulars	Units	Amount (Rs.)	Particulars	Units	Amount (Rs.)
To Process I A/c	1,000	5,000	By Cash/Bank (scrap @ Rs.5)	1,000	5,000
Total	**1,000**	**5,000**	**Total**	**1,000**	**5,000**

Abnormal Loss Account

Particulars	Units	Amount (Rs.)	Particulars	Units	Amount (Rs.)
To Process I A/c	300	3,000	By Cash/Bank (scrap @ Rs.5)	300	1,500
			By Costing P&L A/c (net loss)		1,500
Total	**300**	**3,000**	**Total**	**300**	**3,000**

Net abnormal loss transferred to Costing P&L A/c = Rs. 3,000 − Rs. 1,500 = Rs. 1,500.

(b) Equivalent Production (Weighted Average Method)

Statement of Equivalent Production

Particulars	Units	Material (%)	Material EU	Labour (%)	Labour EU	Overhead (%)	Overhead EU
Completed & transferred	10,000	100	10,000	100	10,000	100	10,000
Closing WIP	2,000	100	2,000	60	1,200	60	1,200
Total	**12,000**		**12,000**		**11,200**		**11,200**

Statement of Cost per Equivalent Unit

Element	Cost (Rs.)	Equivalent Units	Cost per EU (Rs.)
Material	2,40,000	12,000	20
Labour	1,34,400	11,200	12
Overheads	67,200	11,200	6
Total	**4,41,600**		**38**

Statement of Evaluation

Units completed and transferred out = 10,000 × Rs. 38 = **Rs. 3,80,000**

Closing WIP: - Material: 2,000 × Rs. 20 = 40,000 - Labour: 1,200 × Rs. 12 = 14,400 - Overheads: 1,200 × Rs. 6 = 7,200 - **Total closing WIP = Rs. 61,600**

Check: 3,80,000 + 61,600 = **Rs. 4,41,600** = total cost incurred. (Reconciles.)

Answer to Question 4

(a) Cost-Volume-Profit Analysis — Delta Ltd.

Contribution per unit = Selling price − Variable cost = 50 − 30 = Rs. 20

(i) **P/V ratio** = Contribution / Selling price × 100 = 20/50 × 100 = **40%**

(ii) **Break-even point:** - In units = Fixed cost / Contribution per unit = 4,00,000 / 20 = **20,000 units** - In rupees = 20,000 × Rs. 50 = **Rs. 10,00,000** (or Fixed cost / P/V ratio = 4,00,000 / 0.40 = Rs. 10,00,000)

(iii) **Sales to earn target profit of Rs. 2,00,000:** - In units = (Fixed cost + Target profit) / Contribution per unit = (4,00,000 + 2,00,000) / 20 = **30,000 units** - In rupees = 30,000 × Rs. 50 = **Rs. 15,00,000**

(iv) **At sales of 35,000 units:** - Margin of safety (units) = Actual sales − BEP sales = 35,000 − 20,000 = **15,000 units** - Margin of safety (Rs.) = 15,000 × Rs. 50 = **Rs. 7,50,000** - MOS ratio = 15,000 / 35,000 × 100 = **42.86%** - Profit = MOS units × Contribution per unit = 15,000 × Rs. 20 = **Rs. 3,00,000** (*Check:* Total contribution 35,000 × 20 = 7,00,000 − Fixed cost 4,00,000 = Rs. 3,00,000.)

(b) Key (Limiting) Factor — Omega Ltd.

Step 1 — Contribution per machine hour (key factor):

Particulars	Product A	Product B
Contribution per unit (Rs.)	30	40
Machine hours per unit	2	4
Contribution per machine hour (Rs.)	15	10
Ranking	**I**	**II**

Step 2 — Allocation of 10,000 machine hours (as per ranking):

- Product A (first): 3,000 units × 2 hrs = 6,000 hours → contribution = 3,000 × 30 = Rs. 90,000
- Balance hours = 10,000 − 6,000 = 4,000 hours
- Product B: 4,000 hours / 4 = 1,000 units → contribution = 1,000 × 40 = Rs. 40,000

Step 3 — Profit:

Particulars	Amount (Rs.)
Contribution from A (3,000 units)	90,000
Contribution from B (1,000 units)	40,000
Total contribution	**1,30,000**
Less: Fixed costs	(50,000)
Profit	**80,000**

Most profitable mix: 3,000 units of A and 1,000 units of B; Profit = Rs. 80,000.

Answer to Question 5

(a) Material and Labour Variances

Working Notes: - Standard Quantity (SQ) for actual output = 1,000 × 5 kg = 5,000 kg; Standard Rate (SR) = Rs. 4/kg - Standard cost of material = 5,000 × 4 = Rs. 20,000; Actual cost = Rs. 22,360; Actual Qty (AQ) = 5,200 kg; Actual Rate (AR) = 22,360/5,200 = Rs. 4.30/kg - Standard Hours (SH) for actual output = 1,000 × 3 = 3,000 hrs; Standard Rate = Rs. 10/hr - Standard cost of labour = 3,000 × 10 = Rs. 30,000; Actual cost = Rs. 32,550; Actual Hours (AH) = 3,100; Actual Rate = 32,550/3,100 = Rs. 10.50/hr

Material variances:

(i) Material Cost Variance = Standard cost − Actual cost = 20,000 − 22,360 = **Rs. 2,360 (A)**

(ii) Material Price Variance = (SR − AR) × AQ = (4 − 4.30) × 5,200 = **Rs. 1,560 (A)**

(iii) Material Usage Variance = (SQ − AQ) × SR = (5,000 − 5,200) × 4 = **Rs. 800 (A)**

Check: Price + Usage = 1,560 (A) + 800 (A) = 2,360 (A) = Cost variance. ✓

Labour variances:

(iv) Labour Cost Variance = Standard cost − Actual cost = 30,000 − 32,550 = **Rs. 2,550 (A)**

(v) Labour Rate Variance = (SR − AR) × AH = (10 − 10.50) × 3,100 = **Rs. 1,550 (A)**

(vi) Labour Efficiency Variance = (SH − AH) × SR = (3,000 − 3,100) × 10 = **Rs. 1,000 (A)**

Check: Rate + Efficiency = 1,550 (A) + 1,000 (A) = 2,550 (A) = Cost variance. ✓

(b) Fixed Overhead Variances

Working: Standard fixed overhead rate per unit = Budgeted fixed overhead / Budgeted output = 60,000 / 1,200 = Rs. 50 per unit. Fixed overhead absorbed (recovered) = Actual output × Standard rate = 1,000 × 50 = Rs. 50,000.

(i) Fixed Overhead Cost Variance = Absorbed overhead − Actual overhead = 50,000 − 58,000 = **Rs. 8,000 (A)**

(ii) Fixed Overhead Expenditure Variance = Budgeted overhead − Actual overhead = 60,000 − 58,000 = **Rs. 2,000 (F)**

(iii) Fixed Overhead Volume Variance = Absorbed overhead − Budgeted overhead = 50,000 − 60,000 = **Rs. 10,000 (A)**

Check: Expenditure + Volume = 2,000 (F) + 10,000 (A) = 8,000 (A) = Cost variance. ✓

Answer to Question 6

(a) Operating Cost Statement (Transport)

Working Notes: 1. Distance per day (round trip) = 100 × 2 = 200 km; per month = 200 × 25 = 5,000 km. 2. Diesel = 5,000 km ÷ 5 km/litre = 1,000 litres × Rs. 90 = Rs. 90,000 per month. 3. Depreciation p.a. = (9,00,000 − 90,000)/5 = 1,62,000; per month = 1,62,000/12 = Rs. 13,500. 4. Insurance per month = 24,000/12 = Rs. 2,000; Road tax/permit per month = 12,000/12 = Rs. 1,000. 5. Tonne-km (loaded outward only) = 10 tonnes × 100 km × 25 days = **25,000 tonne-km per month**.

Monthly Operating Cost Statement

Particulars	Amount (Rs.)
Depreciation	13,500
Diesel	90,000
Driver's salary	18,000
Oil and lubricants	2,000
Repairs and maintenance	6,000
Insurance	2,000
Road tax and permit	1,000
Office and administration overheads	5,000
Total operating cost per month	**1,37,500**

Operating cost per tonne-km = 1,37,500 / 25,000 = **Rs. 5.50 per tonne-km**

Freight per tonne-km (profit = 20% of freight, so cost = 80% of freight): Freight per tonne-km = 5.50 / 0.80 = **Rs. 6.875 per tonne-km** (≈ Rs. 6.88)

Check: Total freight = 25,000 × 6.875 = Rs. 1,71,875; Profit = 1,71,875 − 1,37,500 = Rs. 34,375 = 20% of 1,71,875. ✓

(b) Reconciliation Statement

Particulars	(+) Add (Rs.)	(−) Less (Rs.)
Profit as per Cost Accounts	1,50,000	
Factory overheads over-absorbed in cost accounts	8,000	
Administrative overheads under-absorbed in cost accounts		5,000
Interest received (financial accounts only)	12,000	
Dividend received (financial accounts only)	6,000	
Loss on sale of asset (financial accounts only)		9,000
Preliminary expenses written off (financial accounts only)		4,000
Depreciation: charged more in financial accounts (25,000 − 20,000)		5,000
Notional rent charged in cost accounts only	10,000	
Sub-totals	**1,86,000**	**23,000**
Profit as per Financial Accounts		**1,63,000**

Reconciliation: 1,50,000 + (8,000 + 12,000 + 6,000 + 10,000) − (5,000 + 9,000 + 4,000 + 5,000) = 1,50,000 + 36,000 − 23,000 = **Rs. 1,63,000.**

Reasoning for signs (starting from costing profit): - Over-absorption of overheads in cost accounts → cost accounts charged more expense → financial profit is higher → **add**. - Under-absorption in cost accounts → cost accounts charged less expense → financial profit is lower → **subtract**. - Incomes recorded only in financial accounts (interest, dividend) → **add**. - Expenses/losses recorded only in financial accounts (loss on sale, preliminary expenses, excess depreciation) → **subtract**. - Notional rent is a cost only in cost accounts (not in financial books) → costing profit was understated → **add**.

End of Mock Test 1 — Cost & Management Accounting.

Cost & Management Accounting — Amendment & Caveat Checklist

CA Intermediate, Paper 3. This is a **verification checklist**, not study content. Its whole job is to stop you from trusting a number, rate, or format that has silently gone stale between the day these notes were written and the day you sit your exam. Read it once when you start the subject, and again during your final revision, ledger in hand.

The core caveat, stated plainly: these notes teach you the *structure and the logic* — why a Cost Sheet is built the way it is, why an EOQ formula looks the way it does, why a variance decomposes the way it does. They do **not** promise that every illustrative number, every rate, or every statutory reference is current for *your* attempt. Logic is durable; numbers are not. Where a number matters, confirm it against ICAI material for your applicable exam **before** you rely on it.

How to use this checklist

1. Identify **your applicable exam** — e.g., "May 2026 attempt." Every ICAI document is stamped with the attempt(s) it applies to. A document for a different attempt is the wrong document.
2. For each item below, open the **authoritative source named in the third column** and confirm the current position.
3. If a number in these notes disagrees with ICAI, **ICAI wins, always.** Correct your notes; do not argue with the mark scheme.

The authoritative sources, in order of precedence:

- **ICAI Study Material** for the applicable syllabus (the current scheme is the **CA New Scheme**, effective from the 2024 attempts onward — confirm you are on the right scheme first).
- **RTP (Revision Test Paper)** and **MTP (Mock Test Paper)** for your specific attempt — these carry any *applicability notes* and updated data.
- **ICAI BoS Announcements / Statutory Updates** page on icai.org — where mid-cycle changes and "applicable for XYZ attempt" notifications are posted.
- **Past ICAI Suggested Answers** — for confirming expected *format*, not for numbers (older papers may use superseded data).

Part 1 — The honest truth about *this* subject's churn

Cost & Management Accounting is one of the **most stable papers** in the CA Intermediate set. It is built on costing *technique and method* — cost sheets, material/labour/overhead costing, marginal costing, standard costing, budgets, process/job/contract costing, service costing. **None of this is driven by the annual Finance Act or by GST notifications.** There are no tax slabs, no surcharge, no 87A rebate, no TDS/TCS tables, no statutory rate cards that get rewritten every year.

So unlike **Taxation** (very high churn) or **Law** (moderate churn from Companies Act notifications), the *content* of this paper does not turn over year to year in any material way.

But "stable" is not "frozen." Three real sources of change still bite students:

- **Syllabus / scheme changes** by ICAI (topic added, dropped, or re-weighted; a chapter moved between Inter and Final).
- **Format and presentation** conventions that ICAI's Suggested Answers evolve (how a reconciliation statement is laid out, mandatory workings, treatment of a specific item).
- **Illustrative rates and assumptions** baked into these notes (a wage rate, an overhead absorption rate, an interest rate in a make-or-buy or an EOQ-with-discount problem). These are **teaching placeholders** — they are correct for the illustration, not statutory constants. A question will always *give* you its own data; never import a number from a note into an exam answer.

Part 2 — Amendment-sensitive items to verify (this subject)

For each: **what it is · why it can change · where to confirm.**

#	Item	What it is / why it can change	Where to confirm
1	**Applicable scheme & syllabus edition**	Which syllabus governs your attempt (New Scheme vs. any legacy). ICAI periodically revises scheme, chapter inclusion, and weightage. A dropped chapter is wasted study; an added one is a blind spot.	ICAI Study Material cover + BoS scheme announcement for your attempt.
2	**Chapter list & topic coverage**	Exactly which chapters are *in* for your attempt (e.g., service/operating costing sectors covered, whether a topic sits in Inter or has moved to Final).	Current Study Material table of contents; RTP for the attempt.
3	**Marks pattern / paper structure**	Division A MCQ marks, negative marking, Division B choice pattern. These are administrative and *can* be revised by ICAI notification.	ICAI exam notification + latest MTP pattern for the attempt.
4	**Answer format / presentation conventions**	Prescribed layout of Cost Sheet, Reconciliation Statement, Process Accounts, Contract Account, variance presentation, and any mandatory workings. Evolves via Suggested Answers.	Most recent ICAI **Suggested Answers** + Study Material illustrations.
5	**Illustrative rates & assumptions in these notes**	Any wage rate, overhead rate, interest/discount rate, price, or standard used in a worked example here. These are **placeholders for teaching the method**, not current constants.	Not "confirmed" against ICAI — instead, **always use the data the exam question gives.** Never carry a note's number into an answer.
6	**Formula conventions & terminology**	Occasionally ICAI standardises a formula variant or term (e.g., a specific labour-turnover or overhead-variance convention). The logic is stable; the *preferred wording* can shift.	Study Material formula boxes + latest Suggested Answers for the expected variant.

Bottom line for Cost: verify **scheme, chapter list, marks pattern, and format** (items 1–4). Treat every illustrative number in these notes as a placeholder (item 5). There is **no annual statutory rate table** in this paper to chase.

Part 3 — Cross-subject amendment map (so you know where the *real* churn is)

You are studying the whole CA Intermediate group, not this paper in isolation. The high-churn danger is in **other papers** — flagging it here so you apply the right level of paranoia to each. **The following are NOT part of Cost & Management Accounting**; they are the reason a "verify the current numbers" habit matters across your prep.

HIGH churn — Taxation (Income-tax + GST)

Rewritten essentially **every attempt** off the latest **Finance Act** and GST notifications. Never trust a tax number from memory or from last year's material. Verify each of these against the **ICAI Statutory Update / RTP for your applicable attempt**:

- **Income-tax slab rates** — both the old regime and the default new regime (Sec 115BAC); which is default; opt-out mechanics.
- **Surcharge** rates and thresholds; **marginal relief**.
- **Rebate u/s 87A** — eligibility income limit and maximum rebate (differs between regimes and has moved repeatedly).
- **Standard deduction** and **deduction limits / eligibility** (Chapter VI-A — 80C, 80D, 80CCD, etc.), including which survive under the new regime.
- **TDS / TCS rates and threshold limits** — section-wise; these get re-tabled and re-thresholded frequently.
- **GST rates, the basic exemption / registration threshold**, composition-scheme limits, and recent GST amendments.
- **The applicable Assessment Year / Previous Year and the specific Finance Act** the exam is set on — printed on the RTP. Get this wrong and every number is wrong.

> For Taxation, the RTP **Statutory Update** is not optional reading — it *is* the current law for your attempt.

MODERATE churn — Corporate & Other Laws

Driven by **Companies Act, 2013 amendments, rules, and MCA notifications**, plus updates to allied laws. Verify:

- **Recent Companies Act amendments and notified sections/rules** applicable to your attempt (thresholds for small companies, CSR applicability, limits on directorships/deposits, etc. — many are limit-based and do move).
- **Applicability cut-off** — ICAI fixes a date up to which amendments are examinable; anything after is excluded. Confirm it in the RTP.
- Any **allied-law updates** flagged in the BoS academic updates.

LOW / relatively stable — but still check anything rate- or limit-based

- **Advanced / Financial Accounting** — driven by **Accounting Standards / Ind AS**; stable year-to-year, but confirm the applicable AS list and any revised standard for your attempt. Watch any *limit-based* disclosure threshold.
- **Cost & Management Accounting (this paper)** — stable; verify per Parts 1–2 above.

- **Auditing** — driven by Standards on Auditing (SAs) and any regulatory/format updates; confirm the applicable SA list.

General rule across all papers: anything expressed as a **rate, a slab, a threshold, a ceiling, or a monetary limit** is a candidate for silent change. Anything expressed as a **principle, a method, or a logic** is durable. When in doubt, confirm against ICAI for your applicable attempt.

Part 4 — Your pre-exam verification ritual (do this once, early)

1. Download the **Study Material, RTP, and MTP for your exact applicable attempt** from icai.org. Check the attempt stamp on each.
2. For **this paper**, confirm items 1–4 in Part 2 (scheme, chapters, marks pattern, answer format). Ten minutes; done.
3. For **Taxation**, read the **RTP Statutory Update cover-to-cover** and note the applicable AY / Finance Act. This is where the marks quietly leak.
4. For **Law**, note the **amendment applicability cut-off date** and skim the BoS academic update for notified changes.
5. Re-confirm the week of the exam that no **BoS announcement / errata** has landed for your attempt.

The one sentence to remember: *these notes make you understand; ICAI's current material for your attempt decides the exact numbers — so learn the logic here, and confirm the figures there.*

Cost & Management Accounting — Accuracy Review: Corrections & Caveats

Scope of this review. This is a *spot-review*, not an exhaustive audit. I read six of the sixteen chapters in full and focused on the most error-prone, computation-heavy material:

- Ch 02 — Material Cost (EOQ, stock levels, FIFO/LIFO/WA, loss valuation)
- Ch 03 — Employee (Labour) Cost (idle time, overtime, turnover, Halsey/Rowan)
- Ch 04 — Overheads / Absorption (primary & secondary distribution, MHR, under/over-absorption)
- Ch 10 — Process & Operation Costing (normal/abnormal loss & gain, equivalent units, inter-process profit)
- Ch 13 — Standard Costing & Variance Analysis (all variance families + reconciliation)
- Ch 14 — Marginal Costing & CVP (contribution, BEP, marginal vs absorption, decisions)

I also spot-checked the definitions in Ch 01 and Ch 11. **I did not review Chapters 05, 06, 07, 08, 09, 12, 15, or the cheatsheet (00).** Absence of a chapter here is *not* a clean bill of health — it simply wasn't examined. Please verify anything material against the current ICAI study module, as the notes are AI-written.

Headline finding: The *technical content and arithmetic in the sampled chapters is strong*. Every worked computation I re-performed reconciled correctly, and the conceptual treatment (loss accounting, variance decomposition, contribution logic, absorption treatment) is sound and ICAI-aligned. The defects I did find are (1) a **pervasive internal cross-referencing error** — chapters point to each other using wrong chapter numbers — plus (2) one **garbled table cell** and (3) one **sourcing caveat**. None of these will mislead you on the *technique*; the first will only confuse you when navigating between chapters.

Issue 1 — Wrong chapter numbers in "Connections" sections (systematic, HIGH confidence)

The "Connections" sections (and a few inline references) repeatedly cite **incorrect chapter numbers**. The book's actual numbering is: 01 Intro, 02 Material, 03 Labour, 04 Overheads, 05 ABC, 06 Cost Sheet, 07 Cost Systems, 08 Unit/Batch, 09 Job/Contract, 10 Process, 11 Joint, 12 Service, 13 Standard Costing, 14 Marginal, 15 Budgets. Many references were evidently written against an older numbering and never updated.

Chapter/Topic	The claim as written	The correct position	Confidence
Ch 13 Standard Costing → Connections	"Marginal costing (Ch. 12)"	Marginal costing is **Ch. 14**	High
Ch 13 Standard Costing → Connections & §7	"Overheads & absorption (Ch. 9)" / "over/under-absorption of Chapter 9"	Overheads is **Ch. 04**	High
Ch 13 Standard Costing → Connections	"Budgetary control (Ch. 14)"	Budgets is **Ch. 15**	High
Ch 13 Standard Costing → Connections	"Material & labour costing (Ch. 4–5)"	Material **Ch. 02**, Labour **Ch. 03**	High
Ch 14 Marginal Costing → Connections	"Standard costing & variances (Ch. 15)"	Standard costing is **Ch. 13**	High
Ch 14 Marginal Costing → Connections	"Budgeting & flexible budgets (Ch. 16)"	Budgets is **Ch. 15** (there is no Ch. 16)	High
Ch 10 Process Costing → Connections	"Material & Labour Costing (Ch. 3–4)"	Material **Ch. 02**, Labour **Ch. 03**	High
Ch 10 Process Costing → Connections	"Overheads (Ch. 6)"	Overheads is **Ch. 04**; Ch. 06 is Cost Sheet	High
Ch 11 Joint Products → Connections	"Cost Sheet & overhead apportionment (Ch. 3–4)"	Cost Sheet **Ch. 06**, Overheads **Ch. 04**	High
Ch 02 Material → Connections	"Cost Sheet (Ch. 01 / 03)"	Cost Sheet is **Ch. 06**	High
Ch 03 Labour → Connections	"Cost Sheet (Ch. 02 / overheads)"	Cost Sheet is **Ch. 06**; Overheads **Ch. 04**	High
Ch 04 Overheads → Connections	"Chapter 03 (Material & Labour)" and "cost sheet (Ch. 02)"	Material is **Ch. 02** (labour Ch. 03); Cost Sheet is **Ch. 06**	High

Note: A few references are correct (e.g., Ch 14 citing "Overhead absorption (Ch. 4)" and "Cost sheet (Ch. 6)"; Ch 11 citing Process Ch. 10 and Marginal Ch. 14). The pattern is inconsistent, so treat **every** cross-chapter pointer with suspicion and navigate by chapter title, not number. **This is a navigation/citation defect only — it does not affect any formula or concept.**

Issue 2 — Garbled table cell in Ch 10, Example 5 (inter-process profit) (MEDIUM confidence it is a typo)

- **The claim as written:** In the "Process II — goods available" table, the "Wages added" row shows the Total column as `30,000 → 10,000` (a leftover editing artefact), i.e. the cell reads "30,000 → **10,000**".
- **The correct position:** Wages added = Cost ₹10,000, Profit nil, **Total ₹10,000**. The stray "30,000 →" should not be there. The downstream arithmetic is unaffected — "Goods available" is correctly totalled as Cost 80,000 / Profit 10,000 / **Total 90,000**, and the rest of the example (unrealised profit ₹2,000, realised profit ₹32,000) is correct and reconciles. Purely a display slip in one cell.

- **Confidence:** High that it is a typo; Low impact.

Issue 3 — CAS-1 attribution of the terminology definitions (LOW–MEDIUM confidence; verify)

- **The claim as written (Ch 01, §3):** "Two definitions to anchor the vocabulary (ICAI, *Cost Accounting Standards / CAS-1*)," then defines **Cost** as "the amount of expenditure (actual or notional) incurred on, or attributable to, a specified thing or activity," plus **Costing / Cost Accounting / Cost Accountancy**.
- **The correct position:** The wording quoted for "Cost" is the classic **CIMA/ICMA Terminology** definition, and the Costing / Cost Accounting / Cost Accountancy definitions are also traditionally from that terminology, *not* from CAS-1. **CAS-1's** title is "Classification of Cost," and its own definition of cost reads "a measurement, in monetary terms, of the amount of resources used for the purpose of production of goods or rendering of services." So attributing this specific wording to CAS-1 is imprecise. The *definitions themselves are standard and exam-acceptable* — only the citation is questionable.
- **Confidence:** Low–Medium. Harmless for problem-solving, but if a theory question asks you to "state the CAS-1 definition of cost," quote the CAS-1 wording above, not the CIMA one. Verify against your ICAI module.

Things I specifically checked and found SOUND

These are areas where students often catch AI errors; I re-performed the maths and found them correct:

- **Ch 02 EOQ (Example 1):** $\sqrt{(2\times12{,}000\times150/4)}$ = 948.68 units; ordering cost = carrying cost = ₹1,897.4 at EOQ. Correct. Cost-table (Example 2) correctly bottoms out at EOQ. Stock-level formulas (ROL = max×max, Min, Max, Danger) all correct; the two average-stock formulas giving 2,100 vs 2,450 are honestly flagged. FIFO/LIFO/WA ledger (Example 4) reconciles to ₹11,600 in every method; rising-price profit ranking correct. Abnormal-loss valuation (Example 5) uses expected good output (900), not actual — correct.
- **Ch 03 Labour:** Halsey/Rowan formulas and the 50%-time-saved crossover are correct, including the algebraic proof and the T=30 (equal) and T=20 (Halsey wins) cross-checks. Turnover example correctly isolates the 125 expansion hires from the 25 replacements. Overtime split (Factories Act, double rate; premium traced by cause) correct.
- **Ch 04 Overheads:** MHR build-up (Example 1) reconciles to ₹1,20,000. Reciprocal distribution by simultaneous equations (S1 = 9,581.56, S2 = 7,382.98) and repeated distribution both land P1 ≈ 45,548 / P2 ≈ 34,452 = ₹80,000. Under/over-absorption sign logic and supplementary-rate treatment correct. Apportionment-basis table correct.
- **Ch 10 Process Costing:** Normal-loss denominator (input − normal loss), abnormal loss/gain at normal cost per unit, the abnormal-gain scrap correction, and the WA-vs-FIFO equivalent-unit example (both reconcile to ₹3,38,000; WA transfer 3,15,000 vs FIFO 3,13,500) are all correct.
- **Ch 13 Standard Costing:** All four worked examples reconcile at every node of the variance tree (material price+usage=cost, mix+yield=usage; labour rate+efficiency+idle=cost; VOH exp+eff=cost; FOH exp+volume=cost, capacity+efficiency=volume; sales margin price+volume=total, mix+quantity=volume). The mix/yield example (MCV 12,050 A = MPV 2,300 A + MUV 9,750 A; MMV

7,833.33 A + MYV 1,916.67 A) checks exactly, and the sales-margin reconciliation lands on ₹53,500. Sign conventions and hours-paid-vs-worked handling are correct.

- **Ch 14 Marginal Costing:** Full CVP toolkit (Example 1) including after-tax gross-up (₹63,000/0.7 = ₹90,000 → sales ₹7,25,000) correct. Marginal-vs-absorption reconciliation (₹30,000 fixed OH in 2,000 units of closing stock) correct. Limiting-factor mix (rank by contribution/machine-hour: B 30, A 20, C 15 → profit ₹3,40,000, with the ₹40,000 proof of optimality) correct.

Overall reliability — per reviewed chapter

- **Ch 02 Material Cost — RELIABLE.** Only defect: a wrong cross-reference to the cost-sheet chapter. Computations and concepts solid.
- **Ch 03 Labour Cost — RELIABLE.** No technical errors found. Only a wrong cost-sheet/overheads cross-reference.
- **Ch 04 Overheads — RELIABLE.** No technical errors found. Wrong chapter numbers in Connections only.
- **Ch 10 Process Costing — RELIABLE, with one cosmetic typo** (Issue 2) and wrong cross-reference numbers. Core accounting is correct.
- **Ch 13 Standard Costing — RELIABLE.** Strongest chapter computationally; every variance reconciles. Only the Connections chapter numbers are wrong.
- **Ch 14 Marginal Costing — RELIABLE.** No technical errors; two wrong forward-references (to standard costing and budgeting chapters).
- **Ch 01 Intro — mostly sound**, but treat the CAS-1 citation (Issue 3) with care.
- **Ch 11 Joint Products — definitions and method logic spot-checked and sound** (NRV, physical-units, market-value-at-split-off correctly described); not fully audited.

Bottom line: For exam preparation the sampled chapters are trustworthy on *method and numbers*. Fix the cross-reference numbers in your head (navigate by title), ignore the one garbled cell in Ch 10 Example 5, and quote the CAS-1 definition from the ICAI module rather than the notes if a theory question demands it. Chapters not listed above remain unverified — apply the same "verify against ICAI" caution there.

Rapid-Recall Flashcards

100 cards for spaced repetition — cover the right column and recall. Also importable into Anki from the DECK.tsv file.

Prompt	Answer
What distinguishes cost accounting from financial accounting?	Financial accounting reports external stewardship (P&L, B/S) per GAAP; cost accounting is internal — it ascertains, controls and reduces cost per unit/job to aid pricing and decisions.
Why is cost classified by 'behaviour' (fixed/variable) rather than just by nature?	Because decisions turn on how cost reacts to volume — only variable cost changes with output, so behaviour drives marginal analysis, break-even and pricing, which nature-wise grouping cannot reveal.
Define 'cost object' vs 'cost centre'.	Cost object = anything for which cost is separately measured (product, job, service). Cost centre = a location/person/equipment where cost is accumulated for control.
Why treat 'cost unit' as the measuring rod?	It expresses cost per unit of output (per tonne, per km, per patient-day) so different periods and firms become comparable — an absolute total tells you nothing about efficiency.
What is a 'sunk cost' and why is it irrelevant to decisions?	A cost already incurred and unrecoverable; since no future action can change it, it must be ignored — only future differential cash flows matter for decisions.
What is 'opportunity cost' and why include it though no cash moves?	The benefit foregone from the next-best alternative use of a resource; ignoring it overstates the attractiveness of the chosen option in scarce-resource decisions.
Prime Cost formula	Prime Cost = Direct Material + Direct Labour + Direct Expenses.
Works/Factory Cost formula	Works Cost = Prime Cost + Factory Overheads + Opening WIP − Closing WIP.
Cost of Production formula	Cost of Production = Works Cost + Office & Administration Overheads.
Cost of Goods Sold formula	COGS = Cost of Production + Opening FG − Closing FG.
Cost of Sales / Total Cost formula	Cost of Sales = COGS + Selling & Distribution Overheads. Sales = Cost of Sales + Profit.
Why are finished-goods stocks valued at Cost of Production, not Cost of Sales?	Selling & distribution overheads relate only to units actually sold; unsold stock has not incurred them, so loading them would overstate closing stock and defer no real cost.
Economic Order Quantity (EOQ) formula	EOQ = $\sqrt{(2 \times A \times O \div C)}$, where A = annual demand, O = ordering cost per order, C = carrying cost per unit p.a.
Why does EOQ minimise total inventory cost?	At EOQ, annual ordering cost equals annual carrying cost; total cost is flat at that point, so trading one for the other yields no saving.
Re-order Level formula	ROL = Maximum usage × Maximum lead time. (Or = Safety stock + Average usage × Average lead time.)

Maximum Stock Level formula	Max Level = ROL + ROQ − (Minimum usage × Minimum lead time).
Minimum Stock Level formula	Min Level = ROL − (Average usage × Average lead time). It is the buffer/safety stock.
What is the purpose of ABC analysis of inventory?	Selective control — 'A' items (few, high value) get tight control; 'C' items (many, low value) get loose control. Effort follows value, not count.
Why does FIFO overstate profit in a period of rising prices?	It charges older (cheaper) material to production, leaving newer (dearer) stock on the balance sheet — low cost against current revenue inflates profit and closing stock.
Why does LIFO better match cost to revenue in inflation (though disallowed in India)?	It charges latest (current) prices to production, aligning cost with current selling prices; but AS-2 prohibits it because closing stock gets understated at old prices.
Which inventory valuation methods does AS-2 permit?	FIFO and Weighted Average Cost. LIFO and base-stock are not allowed.
Stock Turnover Ratio and its meaning	= Cost of materials consumed ÷ Average stock. High ratio = fast-moving, efficient; low = slow-moving/obsolete stock tying up capital.
How is normal material loss treated in cost?	Absorbed by good units — cost of normal loss is spread over good output, raising per-unit cost, since it is an unavoidable part of the process.
How is abnormal material loss treated?	Charged to Costing P&L at full cost (valued like good units), not to production — it must not distort the true cost of good units.
Labour Turnover — Separation method	LTO% = Separations during period ÷ Average number of workers × 100.
Labour Turnover — Replacement method	LTO% = Replacements ÷ Average number of workers × 100. (New posts from expansion are excluded.)
Labour Turnover — Flux method	LTO% = (Separations + Accessions) ÷ Average number of workers × 100 — total labour mobility.
Why distinguish preventive vs replacement costs of labour turnover?	Preventive cost is spent to keep workers (welfare, good pay); replacement cost arises after they leave (recruit, train, spoilage). Managing the trade-off minimises total turnover cost.
How is idle time cost treated — normal vs abnormal?	Normal idle time cost is absorbed in production (inflating labour rate); abnormal idle time (strike, breakdown) is charged to Costing P&L.
How is overtime premium treated when due to a specific customer's rush order?	Charged directly to that job. If due to general pressure, treated as overhead; if abnormal, charged to Costing P&L.
Halsey premium plan — worker's earnings	Earnings = (Hours worked × Rate) + 50% × (Time saved × Rate). Worker gets half the saving; employer keeps half.

Rowan premium plan — worker's earnings	Earnings = (Hours worked × Rate) + (Time saved ÷ Time allowed) × Hours worked × Rate.
Why does Rowan protect against over-speeding better than Halsey?	Rowan bonus is a fraction of time saved; beyond 50% time saved the bonus proportion falls, so it discourages reckless speed and rate-cutting that quality suffers from.
What is 'overhead absorption' and why is it needed?	Charging indirect cost to cost units via a rate, because overheads cannot be traced directly — without absorption, product cost would exclude a real cost of doing business.
Overhead Absorption Rate formula	OAR = Budgeted (or actual) overheads ÷ Budgeted (or actual) base (labour hours, machine hours, units).
Why is a machine-hour rate preferred in a mechanised shop?	Overheads there are driven by machine running (power, depreciation, repairs), so machine hours reflect true consumption better than labour hours.
Under-absorption of overhead — what and why treated how?	Actual overhead > absorbed. If due to normal causes/estimation error → supplementary rate or carried to P&L; if abnormal → straight to Costing P&L.
Over-absorption of overhead treatment	Absorbed > actual; credited via supplementary rate to units/stock, or transferred to Costing P&L if small/normal.
Reapportionment of service-centre cost — why 'repeated distribution'?	Service centres serve each other (canteen serves maintenance and vice versa); repeated distribution or simultaneous-equation method captures this reciprocal service accurately.
Blanket vs departmental overhead rate — when is blanket wrong?	A single plant-wide rate distorts cost when departments have differing overhead intensity or products pass unevenly through them; departmental rates give truer product cost.
Core idea of Activity Based Costing (ABC)	Costs are driven by activities, not volume alone; assign overheads to activities, then to products via cost drivers — giving accurate cost for low-volume, complex products.
Why does traditional volume-based costing under-cost low-volume complex products?	It spreads overhead on volume measures (labour/machine hrs), so high-volume simple products subsidise the disproportionate setup/handling overheads that complex products truly cause.
Define 'cost driver' in ABC	The factor that causes the cost of an activity to change (e.g. number of setups, number of orders, inspection hours) — the basis for charging activity cost to products.
What is a 'cost pool' in ABC?	The total cost accumulated for a single activity (e.g. all setup costs), later divided by its cost driver to get an activity rate.
Job costing — when is it used?	When work is done to specific customer order, each job unique and identifiable (printing, repairs, construction of a special item). Cost is collected per job.

Batch costing — cost per unit formula	Cost per unit = Total batch cost ÷ Number of units in batch. Used where identical items are made in batches (pharma, bakery, components).
Economic Batch Quantity (EBQ) formula	$EBQ = \sqrt{2 \times D \times S \div C}$, where D = annual demand, S = setup cost per batch, C = carrying cost per unit p.a.
Contract costing — why used for large, long-duration jobs?	Each contract is a big cost unit spanning periods and often site-based; costs are booked contract-wise, and profit is recognised prudently as work progresses.
Rule for profit on incomplete contracts less than 25% complete	Take no profit to P&L — too little certainty; provide full for foreseeable loss (prudence).
Notional profit transfer when contract is 25% to less than 50% complete	Transfer = ⅓ × Notional Profit × (Cash received ÷ Work certified).
Notional profit transfer when 50% or more complete (but not near done)	Transfer = ⅔ × Notional Profit × (Cash received ÷ Work certified).
Why multiply retained profit by (Cash received ÷ Work certified)?	To defer profit on work certified but not yet paid for — cash not received is not yet realised, so prudence withholds that portion of profit.
Work-in-Progress shown in contract account	WIP = (Work certified + Work uncertified) − Reserve profit − Cash received… shown net of advances on the balance sheet.
Process costing — when appropriate?	Continuous mass production through sequential processes with homogeneous output (chemicals, cement, sugar); cost is averaged over units, not traced to individual items.
Equivalent Units concept and why needed	Partly-finished units expressed as equivalent whole units by degree of completion, so cost can be spread fairly between finished output and closing WIP.
Normal loss in process — valuation and treatment	Expected loss; its cost is borne by good units. If it has scrap value, scrap credit reduces process cost. No entry to abnormal accounts.
Abnormal loss valuation	Valued at full cost per equivalent good unit (= Total cost − scrap of normal loss, ÷ expected good units); charged to Costing P&L, credited with any scrap value.
Abnormal gain — how it arises and is treated	When actual loss is less than normal loss; valued like good units, debited to process a/c and credited to Costing P&L (net of scrap forgone on the reduced normal loss).
FIFO vs Weighted Average in process costing — key difference	FIFO keeps opening WIP cost separate and completes it first; Weighted Average merges opening WIP cost with current cost and averages over all equivalent units.
Joint products vs by-products — the distinction	Joint products have comparable, significant sales value and are the main aim; by-products are incidental, low-value outputs from the same process.

Why apportion joint cost, and by which common bases?	Joint cost is incurred before split-off and cannot be traced; apportioned by physical units, sales value at split-off, or net realisable value to value stock and measure profit.
Net Realisable Value method for joint-cost apportionment	NRV = Final sales value − further processing cost − selling cost; joint cost split in NRV ratio. Best when products need unequal further processing.
Common treatment of by-product income	Credited to the main process (reducing joint cost) or to Costing P&L as other income; net-realisable value of by-product is deducted from joint cost.
Service (operating) costing — what and unit examples	Costing of services not products; composite cost units — passenger-km (transport), patient-day (hospital), kWh (power), room-day (hotel).
Why use composite cost units in transport?	A single dimension misleads — cost depends on both distance and load, so tonne-km or passenger-km captures the real service delivered.
Marginal cost — definition	The additional variable cost of producing one more unit; = Direct material + direct labour + direct expenses + variable overhead.
Contribution formula and why it matters more than profit for decisions	Contribution = Sales − Variable Cost = Fixed Cost + Profit. It measures what each unit adds toward covering fixed cost and profit — the basis for short-run decisions.
Profit/Volume (P/V) Ratio formula	P/V Ratio = Contribution ÷ Sales × 100 = Change in profit ÷ Change in sales × 100.
Break-Even Point (units) formula	BEP (units) = Fixed Cost ÷ Contribution per unit.
Break-Even Point (value) formula	BEP (₹) = Fixed Cost ÷ P/V Ratio.
Margin of Safety formula and meaning	MOS = Actual sales − BEP sales = Profit ÷ P/V Ratio. It is the cushion before the firm makes a loss; higher MOS = lower risk.
Required-sales-for-target-profit formula	Sales = (Fixed Cost + Target Profit) ÷ P/V Ratio.
Why does marginal costing exclude fixed cost from product cost?	Fixed cost is period cost, unchanged by one more unit; loading it distorts incremental decisions like special orders, make-or-buy and product-mix.
Absorption vs Marginal costing — why profit differs between them	They treat fixed factory overhead differently: absorption carries it in stock, marginal expenses it fully; so when stock rises, absorption shows higher profit, and vice versa.
Key-factor (limiting-factor) decision rule	Maximise contribution per unit of the limiting factor (scarce machine hour, material kg), not contribution per unit — the scarce resource, not output, caps profit.
Make-or-buy decision rule	Compare marginal cost to make against buy price; make if marginal (relevant) cost of making is lower, provided freed capacity has no better use.

Special order acceptance rule	Accept if selling price exceeds marginal cost and it adds contribution, provided regular sales and normal market price are not spoiled and spare capacity exists.
Budget vs Forecast — the difference	A forecast predicts what may happen; a budget is a committed plan of what should happen, with authority and responsibility for achieving it.
Why is a flexible budget more useful for control than a fixed budget?	It recasts budgeted cost to the actual activity level, so variances compare like with like — a fixed budget wrongly blames volume changes on the manager.
Zero-Based Budgeting core principle	Every activity is justified from a zero base each cycle, not incremented from last year — it forces re-examination and cuts inherited waste.
Cash budget purpose	To forecast timing of cash inflows/outflows so shortfalls are arranged and surpluses invested — profit is not cash, and solvency depends on liquidity.
Principal (key) budget factor — why identified first?	It is the constraint that limits all activity (usually sales); every other budget must be built around it, so it is fixed before the rest.
Standard costing — what is a 'standard cost'?	A pre-determined cost of material, labour and overhead per unit under efficient conditions — the benchmark against which actual cost is measured.
Why compute variances (management by exception)?	To highlight only significant deviations from standard so managers focus attention where control is needed, rather than reviewing every figure.
Material Cost Variance formula	MCV = (Std qty for actual output × Std price) − (Actual qty × Actual price).
Material Price Variance formula	MPV = Actual quantity × (Std price − Actual price).
Material Usage Variance formula	MUV = Std price × (Std qty for actual output − Actual qty).
Material Mix Variance formula	MMV = Std price × (Revised std qty − Actual qty), where revised std qty rebalances actual total input to standard proportions.
Material Yield Variance formula	MYV = Std price × (Std qty for actual output − Revised std qty).
Labour Rate Variance formula	LRV = Actual hours paid × (Std rate − Actual rate).
Labour Efficiency Variance formula	LEV = Std rate × (Std hours for actual output − Actual hours worked).
Labour Idle Time Variance formula	Idle Time Variance = Idle hours × Std rate (always adverse).
Variable Overhead Efficiency Variance formula	= Std variable OH rate per hour × (Std hours for actual output − Actual hours).

Fixed Overhead Volume Variance — what it signals	= Absorbed FOH − Budgeted FOH; it captures under/over-utilisation of capacity (only in absorption costing, since fixed cost is volume-independent in reality).
Sales Value Variance formula	= Actual sales value − Budgeted sales value; split into price and volume variances.
Reconciliation statement (cost vs financial accounts) — why needed?	Because items like notional charges, pure-financial income/expense and different stock valuations appear in only one set; reconciliation proves both are internally consistent.
Integrated vs Non-integrated accounting — key difference	Integrated: one set of books merges cost and financial records (no reconciliation needed). Non-integrated: separate cost ledger with a control account, needing periodic reconciliation.
Cost Ledger Control Account purpose (non-integrated system)	It makes the cost ledger self-balancing by recording the contra of all items whose double entry lies in financial books — completing double entry within the cost ledger.
Escalation clause in contract costing — why included?	It lets the contractor recover cost increases in material/labour/rates over a long contract, protecting margin against inflation the fixed price could not foresee.
Why is depreciation on idle assets excluded from cost?	Cost reflects resources consumed in production; an idle asset consumes nothing productively, so charging its depreciation would overstate the cost of goods actually made.